

Fate's Edge: Comprehensive Resource Guide

Comprehensive Reference Document

Risk, consequence, and sharp choices at the table.

Version v0.9

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0.1 Reviewer's Guide: Understanding Fate's Edge

This will be removed in Production

0.1.1 Reframing the Evaluation

Fate's Edge is not a traditional tabletop RPG to be evaluated by comprehensive rule mastery. Instead, it is a **narrative partnership** designed to evolve with your table's storytelling sophistication. Approach this review through the lens of **progressive storytelling enhancement** rather than static mechanical complexity.

0.1.2 Key Evaluation Framework

Start Simple, Discover Naturally

- **Session 1:** Core mechanic + 1-2 regional generators = complete playable experience
- **Session 5:** Comfortable integration of multiple subsystems
- **Session 20:** Intuitive mastery where mechanics become invisible

The Partnership Model

Rather than "learning a game," players develop a "storytelling partnership" where:

- Rules serve narrative consequences, not simulation accuracy
- Complexity emerges from interaction, not individual component sophistication
- Prep burden shifts from authoring content to facilitating discovery

0.1.3 Common Misunderstandings to Address

Content Volume vs. Discovery Process

Misconception: "Too much content to master" **Reality:** Content is designed for gradual discovery through play

Reviewer Guidance:

"Imagine a library where you only need to know about the books relevant to today's story. The rest exist to be discovered when narrative ambition demands them."

Prep-Light vs. Prep-Free

Misconception: "No prep means unstructured play" **Reality:** Prep is embedded in the constraint lattice

Reviewer Guidance:

"The system replaces authored prep with guided storytelling. Every card draw is improvisation with guardrails."

Mechanical Simplicity vs. Narrative Sophistication

Misconception: "Simple mechanics = shallow stories" **Reality:** Sophistication emerges from constraint interaction

Reviewer Guidance:

"Like jazz with a vast repertoire, the same simple rules that handle Session 1 magic effortlessly scale to manage Session 50 world-changing consequences."

0.1.4 Evaluation Methodology

Progressive Complexity Assessment

1. **Tier I Play** (30-40 XP): Evaluate session-to-session narrative flow with minimal subsystems
2. **Tier III Play** (90-150 XP): Assess how character growth naturally expands storytelling scope
3. **Tier V Play** (220+ XP): Examine how simple rules handle complex, multi-threaded narratives

Mastery Curve Analysis

Key Metric: Mastery effort should decrease as narrative complexity increases

Success Indicators:

- Session 1: Clear, engaging storytelling with minimal reference
- Session 10: Comfortable integration of multiple subsystems
- Session 30: Mechanics become invisible; focus entirely on narrative

0.1.5 What to Look For

Narrative-First Design

- Every mechanical element should serve story consequences
- Player agency should manifest through narrative choices, not optimization
- GM authority should prioritize "what happens" over "what are the rules"

Constraint-Based Creativity

- Random elements should create coherent, not chaotic, storytelling
- Regional generators should maintain thematic consistency while enabling variety
- Mechanical constraints should inspire creativity, not limit options

Scalable Sophistication

- Same core mechanics should handle intimate scenes and epic narratives
- Character progression should expand narrative possibilities, not mechanical options
- World complexity should emerge from player actions, not pre-authored content

0.1.6 Red Flags vs. Design Features

Actual Red Flags

- Mechanics that require constant reference during play
- Subsystems that don't integrate naturally with core philosophy
- Progression that adds mechanical burden rather than narrative freedom

Misinterpreted Design Features

- **High content volume** = Creative resource library, not mastery burden
- **Multiple magic paths** = Narrative vocabulary expansion, not mechanical complexity
- **Regional generators** = Inspiration engines, not reference requirements

0.1.7 Recommended Review Approach

Session 1-3 Evaluation

Focus on:

- How quickly engaging stories emerge
- Clarity of core mechanical principles
- Integration of generated content into coherent narratives

Session 10+ Evaluation

Assess:

- How naturally complexity emerges from player choices
- Integration of multiple subsystems without mechanical overhead
- Evolution from "using rules" to "telling stories"

Long-term Assessment

Consider:

- Whether the system grows with narrative ambition
- If mastery effort genuinely decreases over time
- How world complexity emerges organically from play

0.1.8 The Core Truth

Fate's Edge succeeds not by being simple, but by being **designed for simplicity to emerge naturally from complex storytelling**. Evaluate it not as a comprehensive system to master, but as a storytelling partnership that grows in sophistication at exactly the same rate your table develops narrative ambition.

This isn't a game you learn - it's a storytelling evolution you grow into.

Chapter 1

Core Principles

1.1 Safety Tools

Fate's Edge explores mature themes—conflict, loss, horror, betrayal. The table should always feel safe. Use these tools to keep the game enjoyable for everyone.

Safety Tools: Lines

X-Card Any player (including the GM) can draw an "X" on a card or simply say "X" when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is removed from the fiction—no questions, no explanations, no judgments. The scene is retconned or redirected immediately.

Lines A hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: "No sexual violence," "No harm to children," "No body horror." Establish during Session Zero.

Veils A soft boundary: content that can happen "off screen" or fade to black. Example: "A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit."

Always keep an X-Card visible. When used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate the player. The GM may also use the X-Card for their own comfort.

1.2 The Central Question

At its heart, Fate's Edge asks:

What are you willing to risk, and what are you willing to pay, to reshape the world around you?

This question is both philosophical and mechanical. Players gamble with fate every time they act, and the consequences—good or ill—become the foundation of their legend.

1.3 Core Principles

The game is built on four key ideas:

Narrative First Mechanics serve the story. Rules reward descriptive play and creative problem-solving.

Risk Creates Drama Every roll carries tension. Even success may come at a cost.

Meaningful Growth Experience is a currency of choice. Invest in yourself or in your influence on the world.

Consequences Matter No action is free. Every choice changes the fiction.

1.4 Key Concepts

1.4.1 Narrative Time

Time in Fate’s Edge is measured by story weight, not by clocks. Use these four scales:

Table 1.1: Narrative Time Scales

Scale	Description
A Moment	A heartbeat, a glance, a single strike or word.
Some Time	A few minutes: a skirmish, a careful lockpick, a short negotiation.
Significant Time	Hours: travel, a ritual, a siege.
Days	Large-scale endeavors: marches, training, recovery.

1.4.2 Story Beats (SB)

Whenever a player rolls dice, each result of **1** generates one Story Beat (SB) for the GM. Re-rolling a 1 does *not* erase its SB; if the re-rolled die also shows 1, it generates additional SB.

SB are not penalties—they are narrative fuel. The GM spends SB to introduce twists:

- **Escalation** – drawing more enemies, raising the stakes.
- **Exhaustion** – draining time, resources, or positioning.
- **Exposure** – revealing hidden actions, alerting foes.
- **Collateral** – harm or danger spilling over onto allies, innocents, or surroundings.

For a full SB Spend Menu, see [2.1.8](#).

1.4.3 Affinity

Each people (culture or heritage) provides an **Affinity**: a narrative edge or metaphysical bond. Affinities make certain actions more reliable or grant unique permissions, weaving identity into mechanics. Examples include the Aeler stone-sense or the Aelaerem hearth-luck.

1.4.4 Prestige Abilities

High-level talents unlocked by mastering cultural arts, Patron bonds, or philosophical paths. These are narrative milestones as much as mechanical upgrades.

1.4.5 On-Screen vs. Off-Screen

Fate's Edge distinguishes between resources you see at the table and those that shape the world behind the scenes:

On-Screen Resources are companions, hirelings, or allies who stand beside you in danger. They add dice pools and flavor, but they can falter, be captured, or die.

Off-Screen Resources are assets, titles, networks, or safe houses. They never swing a blade in combat, but they shape the story between sessions, turning XP into narrative leverage.

1.5 Design Philosophy

1.5.1 Core Principles (Extended)

1. **Narrative Primacy:** Mechanics serve story, not replace it.
2. **Risk as Drama:** Every roll carries potential for triumph and complication.
3. **Meaningful Growth:** XP investment creates lasting character and world change.
4. **Consequence Weight:** Choices ripple outward; nothing is free.
5. **Fail Forward:** Misses fuel Boons; 1s become Story Beats that drive the fiction onward.

1.5.2 Mechanical Constraints

Table 1.2: Core Mechanical Limits

Rule	Limit
Assist Maximum	+3 dice total per roll from all helpers.
Boon Maximum	Hold 5 Boons; trim to 2 at scene end.
Boon-to-XP Conversion	2 Boons → 1 XP, once per session, max 2 XP per session via conversion.
Follower Initiative	1 Follower Action per scene, party-wide.
Over-Stack	2+ structural advantages = start a relevant clock +1 OR GM banks +1 SB.
Position States	Dominant Controlled Desperate (affects success/failure texture).
Dice Pool Cap	Maximum 10d10 per roll; extras become auto-successes.

1.5.3 The Golden Rule

When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. If you find yourself asking "What's the optimal move?" try reframing it as "What would be most interesting for the story?"

The dice do not determine success or failure—they help decide which path you take to get there.

1.5.4 Flavor is Free

Players may add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources or requiring rolls. Flavor enriches the narrative without changing mechanical outcomes. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate.

Chapter 2

Core Mechanics

2.1 The Core Resolution Cycle

When a player rolls dice, they engage the world through risk, consequence, and discovery.

2.1.1 Step-by-Step Resolution

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** Intent + Attribute + Skill.
2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV):** GM sets DV (2–7+) based on stakes.
3. **Roll Dice Pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s (max 10 dice; extras = auto-successes).
4. **Count Results:**
 - 6–9 = 1 success
 - 10 = 2 successes
 - 1 = 1 Story Beat (SB) for GM
5. **Compare to DV** → Outcome Matrix (see [Table 2.1](#)).
6. **Spend SB:** GM introduces complications (see [section 2.1.8](#)).

2.1.2 Difficulty Value (DV)

Default DV Ladder

DV	Typical Case
2	Routine: clear intent, modest stakes, controlled environment
3	Pressured: time limits, mild resistance, partial information
4	Hard: hostile conditions, active opposition, precision required
5+	Extreme: stacked constraints, dangerous failure, high drama

Default DV = 3.

2.1.3 Position & Effect

Position (risk) Dominant (safe), Controlled (balanced), Desperate (high stakes).

Effect (reward) Limited, Standard, Great.

GM sets both based on fiction.

2.1.4 Outcome Matrix

Table 2.1: Outcome Matrix

Roll Result	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success – achieve intent without complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0	Success & Cost – achieve intent; GM spends SB for complication.
$0 < \text{Successes} < \text{DV}$	Partial – progress with complication; player gains 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss – no progress; GM escalates with SB; player gains 2 Boons.

2.1.5 Critical Success (10s)

If roll succeeds, each 10 adds narrative weight. Effects apply only on success.

- **1 ten:** Strong success – improved Position or minor advantage.
- **2 tens:** Exceptional – choose two benefits (e.g., increased Effect + free Boon).
- **3 tens:** Legendary – decisive victory; clear 1 clock segment.
- **4+ tens:** Mythic – reshape scene; clear 1–2 clock segments.

Tens are never rerolled by Position effects.

2.1.6 Dice Pool Limit & Auto-Successes

Max dice = 10d10. Extra dice become auto-successes (no SB generated).

2.1.7 Boons

Earning Boons

- Partial ($0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$): 1 Boon
- Miss (successes = 0): 2 Boons (meaningful roll only)
- Bond-driven action (once per bond/session): 1 Boon
- GM award

Limit: Max 2 Boons from failures per character per scene.

Spending Boons (1 Boon)

- Reroll one die (after result)
- Activate an on-screen Asset
- Improve Position by one step before roll
- Power certain Rites/abilities
- Convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once/session downtime, max 2 XP)

Carryover: Max 5 Boons; at scene end, reduce to 2.

2.1.8 Story Beats (SB)

Each die showing 1 = 1 SB for GM. Rerolling a 1 does not erase its SB; another 1 adds extra.

	Cost	Effect
SB Spend Menu	1 SB	Minor: noise, trace, tick clock +1, worsen Position
	2 SB	Moderate: alarm raised, lose cover/Position, lesser foe appears
	3 SB	Serious: reinforcements, key gear breaks, major twist, advance front clock
	4+ SB	Major: trap springs, authority arrives, scene shift, Patron intervenes

2.2 Player-Managed Modules

Players track their own: Obligation, Corruption, Leash, Asset States.

What Players Track		
Module	Owner	Tick Triggers (examples)
Obligation (per Patron)	Player	Invoke Rite, Push, Crack the Seal
Corruption Clock	Player	Cantor Push, Resonant Rite, GM SB on occult actions
Leash (Summoning)	Player	Spirit takes Harm, acts against nature, crosses [WARD]
Asset State (Symbol)	Player	Neglect, Crack the Seal → Compromised

Obligation Capacity = Spirit + Presence.

- Over capacity: +1 Fatigue per segment.
- Double capacity: Clear Fatigue, +1 Harm, Patron Intrusion.

Corruption Full Apply last Patron's boon burden, reset to 0.

Leash Full Spirit acts once to its nature then departs/turns hostile.

Symbol State Compromised – repair downtime (DV 3) or 1 XP.

2.3 Turn Economy

Each turn: **1 Action + 1 Move**.

2.3.1 Movement

- **Move:** Shift one band (Close ↔ Near ↔ Far) or stand from prone.
- **Dash (Action):** Move two bands; next defense Desperate.
- **Disengage (Action):** Then Move does not provoke opportunity attacks; cannot Attack this turn.

2.3.2 Action Options

- **Attack** (melee/ranged)
- **Disengage** (as above)
- **Charge (full turn):** Move two bands toward enemy + melee attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Next defense Desperate. Requires open ground.
- **Skirmish (full turn):** Move two bands away + ranged attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Next defense Desperate. Requires open ground.
- **Observe / Change Position:** +1 Position once per turn.
- **Setup:** Grant ally +1 Position or step up Effect.
- **Assist:** Spend 1 Boon for +1 die (max +3 from all assists).
- **Defend, Channel/Weave, Cast Rite/Song, Interact, etc.**

Talents (Effortless Charge, Relentless, etc.) modify these.

2.3.3 Initiative

No fixed order. GM spotlights based on fiction; ambushers act first.

2.3.4 Opportunity Attacks

Leaving an enemy's Close without Disengage provokes one free melee attack (Controlled Position, no action cost).

2.4 Fatigue & Harm

2.4.1 Fatigue Track

Size = Body. Mark from exertion, magic, stress.

Effects

- Each Fatigue worsens Position: Dominant → Controlled → Desperate.
- If already Desperate, each Fatigue → -1 die.
- **Overflow:** When track fills, increase Harm by 1 level, clear all Fatigue.

Recovery: Short rest removes 2 Fatigue; full night removes all. Requires adequate Supply.

2.4.2 Harm Levels

Harm	Effect	
Harm 1	-1 die on related actions	Recovery: medical or magical care.
Harm 2	-1 die on most actions until treated	
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying	

2.4.3 Taking Harm & Fatigue – The Procedure

When hit:

1. **Convert** Harm to Fatigue using armor (see [subsection 2.4.4](#)). Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.
2. **Apply remaining Harm:** If any, increase Harm level and clear all existing Fatigue.
3. **Add Fatigue** from step 1. If track fills, resolve overflow (Harm +1, clear Fatigue).

2.4.4 Armor Conversion Table

Armor Type	Conversion (Harm → Fatigue)	Minimum Fatigue	
Light	1 → 1	1	<i>Example: Light</i>
Medium	2 → 1	1	
Heavy	3 → 2	1	

armor hit with Harm 2 → convert 1→1 Fatigue, remaining Harm 1 → increase Harm 1, clear Fatigue, then add 1 Fatigue. Result: Harm 1, Fatigue 1.

2.4.5 Fear Effects

When Fear Track escalates (Shaken → Frightened → Panicked), roll d10 or choose:

d10	Effect
1	Freeze (cannot act)
2	Flee
3	Drop held item
4	Beg/bargain
5	Hide
6	Panic attack (nearest target)
7	Blunder into danger
8	Obeys simple command
9	Break down (useless until aided)
10	Catatonia

2.5 Skills

Action roll = Attribute (Body, Wits, Spirit, Presence) + Skill. GM sets Position and DV.

2.5.1 Core Skills (Abridged)

Skill	What It Covers
Arcana	Magic theory, wards, rituals
Athletics	Running, climbing, swimming, balance
Brawl	Unarmed combat, grappling
Command	Leadership, morale
Craft	Making, mending
Deception	Lying, bluffing
Insight	Reading emotions, detecting lies
Investigation	Research, deduction
Lore	History, cultures, general knowledge
Medicine	Healing, first aid
Melee	Close combat with weapons
Notice	Perception, spotting ambushes
Performance	Acting, music, oration
Ranged	Bows, thrown weapons
Stealth	Moving unseen
Subterfuge	Casing, forgery, sleight of hand
Survival	Wilderness navigation, foraging
Sway	Persuasion, charm
Tinker	Lockpicking, traps, devices

2.5.2 Attribute + Skill Combos

Same action can use different pairs. Example: Persuading a guard: Presence+Sway (charm), Wits+Sway (logic), Spirit+Sway (conviction).

2.6 Experience Points (XP)

2.6.1 Awarding XP (per session)

- Attendance: +2
- Major objective: +2–4
- Discoveries: +1–2
- Hard choices: +1–2
- Complication spotlight: +1–3
- Bond/flag driven: +1–2
- GM curveball: +0–3

End of major arc: +8–12 XP to all.

2.6.2 Spending XP

- **Attribute:** new rating $\times 3$ XP, downtime = new rating days.
- **Skill:** new level $\times 2$ XP, downtime = new level days.
- **Talents:** 2–12+ XP per tier.
- **Follower:** Cap^2 XP, downtime 1–3 days.
- **Asset:** Minor (4 XP, 1d), Standard (8 XP, 1w), Major (12 XP, 1 month).

Rush Rule: Skip downtime $\rightarrow$ start Haste [4] clock. On fill, ability gains flaw/hitch.

2.6.3 Reputation Tiers

Novice (0–40 XP) Local, prestige locked.

Seasoned (41–90 XP) Regional, some prestige unlock.

Veteran (91–150 XP) National, second follower slot.

Paragon (151–220 XP) Continental, rivals emerge.

Mythic (221+ XP) Legendary, kingdoms react.

2.7 Game Structure

2.7.1 Narrative Time

A Moment (heartbeat), **Some Time** (minutes), **Significant Time** (hours), **Days**.

2.7.2 Game Units

Scene (conflict/question), **Session** (3–6 hrs, 2–4 scenes), **Campaign** (6–20+ sessions).

2.8 Assets & Followers (Quick Reference)

2.8.1 Assets (Off-Screen)

Costs: Minor (4 XP, 1d), Standard (8 XP, 1w), Major (12 XP, 1m).

- **Free off-screen use:** once/session.
- **Boon activation:** 1 Boon for on-screen scene.
- **Conditions:** Maintained → Neglected → Compromised.

2.8.2 Followers (On-Screen)

Cost: Cap² XP, downtime 1–3d.

- **Assistance:** +min(Cap, relevant skill) dice, capped at +3 total.
- **Independent action:** once/scene (party-wide). Cost: 1 Exposure or 1 Harm.
- **Conditions:** Exposure, Harm tracks.

2.8.3 Upkeep (per downtime)

- **Efficient:** XP = max(1, acquisition/3).
- **Intensive:** 1 XP + dedicated downtime action.

Failure to pay: follower → Wary → Seized; asset → Neglected → Compromised.

Chapter 3

Deck-Based Generators

3.1 Introduction to Deck Generators

Deck generators in **Fate's Edge** transform random card draws into coherent narrative elements. Each deck has a distinct purpose and suit meanings so that randomness serves the story rather than derailing it. These generators provide structured inspiration for GMs while maintaining the game's narrative-first philosophy.

3.2 Standard Deck Structure

Fate's Edge uses several card-based tools, each with specialised suit meanings:

Travel Decks (regional, 52-card) Used for journey content and location-based adventures.

- **Spade** = Place / Location
- **Heart** = Actor / Faction
- **Club** = Pressure / Complication
- **Diamond** = Reward / Opportunity

Deck of Consequences (scene drama) Used for immediate complications and narrative twists during gameplay.

- **Hearts** = Social / Emotional Fallout
- **Spades** = Harm / Escalation
- **Clubs** = Material Cost / Resource Drain
- **Diamonds** = Magical / Spiritual Disturbance

Important

Never mix suit meanings across decks. When rules reference *Spade / Club / Diamond*, they mean the **Travel Deck**. When they say *Hearts / Spades / Clubs / Diamonds*, they mean the **Deck of Consequences**.

3.3 Rank Severity and Clock Size

Card rank sets the size / significance of the primary Clock:

- **2–5 (Minor)**: 4-segment Clock
- **6–10 (Standard)**: 6-segment Clock
- **J, Q, K (Major)**: 8-segment Clock
- **Ace (Pivotal)**: 10-segment Clock

Colour Influence:

- **Black suits** (♠, ♣): Travel hazards, tangible threats, fatigue.
- **Red suits** (♥, ♦): Social intrigue, reputational pressure, emotional complications.

3.4 Draw Procedures

3.4.1 Quick Hook (2 cards)

Ideal for spontaneous scene generation or when players zag unexpectedly:

1. Draw one **Spade** (place) and one **Heart** (actor / faction).
2. Use the higher rank to set Clock size.
3. Combine elements into a simple, compelling scenario.

3.4.2 Full Seed (4 cards)

For full adventures or significant arcs:

1. Draw until one card of each suit appears:
 - **Spade** = Primary location
 - **Heart** = Main actor / faction
 - **Club** = Central complication
 - **Diamond** = Key reward / opportunity
2. The highest rank sets the main Clock size.
3. If multiple face cards or Aces appear, create parallel Clocks for secondary threats or opportunities.

3.4.3 Act Builder

Structure sessions or multi-part adventures:

1. Draw three cards: setting (**Spade**), actor (**Heart**), complication (**Club**).
2. Treat **Diamond** cards drawn during play as foreshadowed opportunities or act payoffs.
3. Highest rank determines the session's primary challenge scope.

3.5 Using the Deck in Play

1. Players roll; each die showing **1** generates **1 Story Beat (SB)**.
2. The GM chooses one method for that roll:
 - (a) **Direct Spend:** Translate SB into immediate consequences or clock ticks.
 - (b) **Deck Draw:** Draw up to **min(SB, 3)** cards and synthesise a single twist guided by suit and highest rank.
3. Interpret the cards to create a coherent complication that advances the narrative.

3.6 Combo Rules

Special combinations add texture:

Pair (same rank) Recurring motif with a twist.

Run (3+ sequential ranks) Momentum – reduce the main Clock by 1 segment.

Flush (3+ same suit) Strongly theme the act toward that suit's axis.

Face + Ace Reveal a hidden patron or power behind the element.

All one colour GM gains **+1 SB** to use in that scene.

3.7 Regional Generator Summary

Table 3.1: Regional Generator Summary

Region	Theme	Special Mechanics
Acasia	Broken Marches	Curse motifs; every Ace adds a lingering omen.
Aelaerem	Hearth & Hollow	Red-thread motifs; Ace echoes quiet bells / watch-geese.
Aeler	Crowns & Under-Vaults	Stone / breath motifs; Ace: keys click, bells answer.
Aelinnel	Stone, Bough, Bright Things	Moonlight motifs; Ace adds a shortcut where none should be.
Black Banners	Condotta & Crowns	War & winter motifs; Ace: weapons remember, ice holds the dead.
Ecktoria	Marble & Fire	Imperial forms; Ace carves precedent in marble.
Kahfagia	Pilot's Mirror	Lantern-law jurisdiction shifts; Ace redefines lanes.

Table 3.1 – continued

Region	Theme	Special Mechanics
Linn	Skerries & Storm-Oaths	Sea omens; Ace: horns on wind, white horses on swell.
Mistlands	Bells, Salt, Breath	Breath / boundary motifs; Ace: bells answer across water.
Silkstrand	City of Bridges & Dyewater	Dye / bridge motifs; Ace adds a lingering omen.
Theona	Three Greens, No Ninth	"No Ninth" custom; Ace adds a telling omission.
Thepyrgos	City of a Thousand Stairs	Height / sound motifs; Ace echoes bells / wind / stair-steps.
Ubral	Stone Between Spears	Upland motifs; Ace echoes horns / heather / stone.
Valewood	Empire Under Leaves	Empire echoes (J/Q/K add relic-logic); Ace rearranges approach.
Vhasia	Fractured Sun	Broken-sun motifs; Ace blots medal / scratches milestone.
Vilikari	Laurels & Longhouses	Two-laws motifs; Ace shows wolf / eagle side-by-side.
Viterra	Last Kingdom	Legacy, parishes, and final-stand themes.
Wilds	Roads, Ruins, Weather	Reskin palette for any biome.
Zakov	Salt & Serpent	Salt & serpent omens; Ace: tides remember, reefs shift, deep listens.

3.8 NPC Generation Deck

Every NPC should feel like a person with desires, convictions, and contradictions. This deck lets you assemble a complete profile quickly by drawing one element from each category.

3.8.1 Generation Categories

Ambition What they seek to achieve or obtain.

Belief The principle or philosophy guiding their worldview.

Attitude How they present themselves and interact day-to-day.

Twist A contradiction or hidden facet that creates tension.

3.8.2 Using the NPC Generator

Select or draw one from each column and consider the frictions between public ambition, private belief, surface attitude, and the twist.

Table 3.2: NPC Generation Categories

Ambition	Belief	Attitude	Twist
Power	Might makes right	Arrogant	Secretly insecure
Wealth	Ends justify means	Charismatic	Betraying their allies
Revenge	Honour above all	Cold	Working for their enemy
Love	Truth is sacred	Friendly	Hiding a dark past
Knowledge	Loyalty is paramount	Paranoid	Actually an impostor
Survival	Family above all	Cruel	Deeply compassionate
Fame	Justice must prevail	Pious	Corrupted by power
Freedom	Fate can be changed	Optimistic	Hopelessly cynical
Protection	Tradition must be upheld	Pessimistic	Revolutionary at heart
Control	Change is necessary	Calculating	Acts on impulse
Recognition	The system works	Naive	Cynical manipulator

3.9 Practical Deck Usage Examples

3.9.1 Example 1: Quick Scene Generation

The party detours through the Mistlands. The GM draws:

- **Spade (8)**: Ancient standing stones covered in moss.
- **Heart (Queen)**: A territorial spirit guardian.

A 6-segment Clock *Spirit's Wrath* begins: the guardian demands tribute for safe passage.

3.9.2 Example 2: Consequences During Play

Kael misses a stealth roll and generates **2 SB**. The GM draws:

- **Hearts (7)**: Social complication.
- **Clubs (3)**: Resource cost.

Synthesis: *A ceremonial urn shatters; cultists recognise your patron's mark. Future dealings will demand extra tribute and materials.*

3.9.3 Example 3: NPC Creation

Merchant in Valewood:

- **Ambition:** Wealth
- **Belief:** Family above all
- **Attitude:** Charismatic
- **Twist:** Secretly compassionate

Result: *A charming hard-bargainer who supports a large family and quietly donates to orphanages – even aiding struggling competitors.*

3.10 GM Guidance for Deck Usage

3.10.1 When to Use Which Deck

- **Travel Decks:** journey planning, location adventures, regional exploration.
- **Deck of Consequences:** immediate twists during active scenes.
- **NPC Generator:** fast creation with built-in tension and hooks.

3.10.2 Interpreting Card Draws

- Prioritise narrative coherence over literalism.
- Use suits as inspiration, not constraints.
- Combine cards into layered complications rather than parallel noise.
- Remember: players can mitigate, pivot, or overcome deck outcomes.

3.10.3 Balancing Randomness and Narrative

- Draw when you want surprise or need a nudge.
- Ignore or modify draws that don't serve the current story.
- Treat combinations as creative prompts, not mandates.
- The goal is to *enhance* the narrative, not derail it.

Chapter 4

Travel Reference

4.1 Introduction to Travel

Travel in **Fate’s Edge** is not just movement between locations—it is an opportunity for adventure, discovery, and complication. The travel system uses deck-based generators to create meaningful journeys that advance the story while presenting challenges and opportunities.

4.2 Core Travel Procedure

For each leg of a journey, follow this structured approach.

4.2.1 Card Draw Sequence

Draw 3–4 cards using the appropriate regional decks:

Spade from the destination deck Sets the scene (place and environment).

Heart from the destination deck Introduces the local actor or faction.

Club from the Wilds (general hazards) or destination (if strongly policed) Brings pressure and complications.

Diamond from the authority that controls the route Represents papers, escorts, rights, or exceptions needed.

4.2.2 Travel Clock Setup

Set a travel clock based on the highest card rank drawn:

Table 4.1: Travel Clock Sizes

Rank	Clock Size	Typical Journey
2–5	4 segments	Short, straightforward journey.
6–10	6 segments	Standard journey.
J, Q, K	8 segments	Extended or complex journey.

Ace 10 segments Epic or highly dangerous journey.

4.2.3 Resolution and Consequences

- On success: advance to the next leg of the journey.
- On failure: mark delay, debt, or diversion and resolve consequences in the fiction.
- Each segment filled typically represents significant progress or a meaningful encounter.

4.3 Travel Modes and Special Rules

4.3.1 Sea Travel

Sea journeys (Amaranthine / Dolmis / Aberderrin routes) follow special considerations:

- If Theona or Valewood 9s appear in the seed, add an omission or taboo to the leg.
- Navigational challenges use *Sailing* or *Survival* skills with modified DVs.
- Weather and sea conditions act as persistent complications.

4.3.2 Underground Passes (Aeler)

Aeler's underground routes have unique mechanics:

- Any Ace can convert a surface route to an under-route.
- Diamond cards from Aeler always codify outcomes—no roll required—for sealed doors, breath time, and escorted segments.
- Underground travel uses different skill sets (*Engineering*, *Geology*, *Survival*).

4.3.3 River Travel

River journeys present distinct challenges:

- **Ecktoria / Viterra rivers:** bridges, booms, and legal checkpoints.
- **Mistlands / Linn waters:** reed-mazes and bell-line navigation systems.
- Current strength and river conditions affect travel pace and difficulty.

4.3.4 Frontier and Border Crossings

When traveling between regions with different laws or authorities:

- Draw two Diamond cards (one from each controlling authority).
- Choose which authority's laws you will be judged by at the journey's end.
- Border crossings typically add +2 segments to the travel clock.

4.4 Major Regional Routes

4.4.1 Amaranthine Coastway

Route: Kahfagia → Ecktoria → Acasia → Marcott (Vhasia) → Fairport (Viterra).

- Draw Spade+Heart from the port you are entering.
- Draw Club from the Wilds deck (gales, quarantine, harbor booms).
- Draw Diamond from the port's deck (permits, berths), or Kahfagia if convoy / lantern law applies.
- **Note:** Silkstrand is Acasia's sole metropolis and a major trading hub.

4.4.2 Astroegro Straits

Thepyrgos controls this crucial maritime hinge.

- Draw Spade+Heart and Club from Thepyrgos deck (stairs, boom, synod).
- Draw Diamond from Thepyrgos (harbor pass, crane allotment).
- Switch to Dolmis / Amaranthine modules once the boom is lowered.

4.4.3 Dolmis Sea Circuits

Route: Fairport (Viterra) → Theona (Three Greens) → Ubral fjords → Aelinnel west shore.

- Spade+Heart from destination deck.
- Club from Linn or Wilds decks.
- Diamond from Theona when island custom matters.
- Island-hopping presents unique navigation challenges.

4.4.4 Aelerian Underground Passes

Route: Vhasia / Viterra / Ubral south slopes → Aeler gates → Mistlands.

- Spade+Heart and Club from Aeler deck.
- Diamond from Aeler (Underway Pass, Key-Writ, Breath Time).
- Underground routes bypass surface dangers but present their own risks.

4.4.5 Shadow Corridors (Valewood)

Thin Shore route along Valewood's east coast toward Zakov.

- Spade from Valewood deck.
- Heart from Mistlands or Valewood deck.
- Club from Mistlands deck (wraiths, bell-line failures).
- Diamond from either Mistlands (Ward-salt, Lantern Writ) or Valewood (Way-cord, Truce-bough).

Rule of 9s

Any **9** in the seed adds an omission or taboo: a missing step, an unsaid name, an unseen guest.

4.4.6 Green Gate Tidal Routes (Aelinnel)

Aelinnel's tide-dependent passages:

- Spade+Club from Aelinnel deck (tides, geasa).
- Diamond from Aelinnel (Tide-path Key, Host-rights).
- Timing is critical—miss the tide and wait for the next cycle.

4.4.7 Major River Systems

Belworth River Boundary between Vhasia and Viterra.

- Twin ports at the mouth (Marcott and Fairport).
- Tarlington Falls requires lift / portage to plateau towns.
- Use Viterra for east-bank audits, Vhasia for west-bank politics.

Yloka River Northern raid routes into Aberderrin and Dolmis.

- Overlay Linn Clubs for hazards.
- Draw destination for Spade+Heart.

Acasian Rivers Hazardous approaches to Silkstrand.

- Use Acasia Clubs (feuds / levies / curse).
- Diamonds represent condotta permits, bridge rights.

4.4.8 Steppe Frontier Routes

Ykrul ↔ Vilikari ↔ Ecktoria / Acasia borders:

- Spade from the road (Wolf Road or Foedus Stone).
- Heart from the counterpart region (envoys, comitatus).
- Club from Wilds or frontier decks (rasputitsa, hostage protocol).
- Diamond from either Ykrul (paiza, remounts) or Vilikari (foedus seal).

4.5 Strategic Gateways and Control Points

Table 4.2: Major Travel Gateways and Control Points

Gateway		Controlling Deck	Diamond Source	Typical	Require-
				ments	ments
Kassamira (Kahfagia)		Kahfagia	Kahfagia	Convoy lantern-law pilotage token	letter; warrant;
Ecktoria Capital Port	Ecktoria	Ecktoria	Ecktoria	Berth coin-house procession permit	priority; credit;
Silkstrand		Acasia	Acasia	Exchange floor condotta permit; wa-	access;
Marcott		Vhasia	Vhasia	Letters safe-conduct; fair-	patent; ground precedence
Fairport		Viterra	Viterra	Customs seal; ferry priority; Dawn escort	
Tarlington Falls		Viterra	Viterra	Lift bridge/portage County ruling	priority; pass;
Thepyrgos Boom		Thepyrgos	Thepyrgos	Harbor pass; crane al-	lotment; Synod indul-
High-Mist Pass		Aeler	Aeler	Underway Key-Writ; breath-time allotment	pass;
Payden's Port		Mistlands	Mistlands	Lantern ward-salt; indemnity	writ; wraith
Thin Shore		Valewood	Valewood / Mist-	Way-cord; dew-mirror; lantern writ	
Green Gate		Aelinnel	Aelinnel	Tide-path host-right salt license	key; bough;
Ubral Passes		Ubral	Aeler / Ubral	Vurim hill-fort shelter guide's braid	pass-ring; writ;
Thing-holm		Linn	Linn	Thing harbor-green; writ	ruling; escort
Foedus Stone		Vilikari	Vilikari / Ykrul	Foedus re-mount hostage treaty	renewal; re- allotment;

Table 4.2 – continued

Gateway	Controlling Deck	Diamond Source	Typical ments	Require-
Zakov Roadstead	Theona / Linn	Theona / Linn	Raid-truce whale-road market immunity	ribbon; escort;

4.6 Special Travel Rules and Regional Features

4.6.1 Theona and Valewood Taboos

Whenever a 9 appears in a travel seed involving Theona or Valewood:

- Add an omission: missing step, unsaid name, unseen guest.
- If the 9 is a Diamond, you may break the taboo once—but someone will come to collect.
- These taboos create ongoing narrative hooks and complications.

4.6.2 Aeler Ace Route Manipulation

Aeler’s underground network allows special route manipulation:

- An Ace can rewrite routes beneath the mountains.
- You may swap your Spade to Aeler (keeping other seed cards) and continue under-vault procedures.
- This represents discovering or activating hidden passages.

4.6.3 Echoing Omens and Motifs

Any Ace drawn during travel adds a recurring motif:

- Examples: ash on the wind, a bell heard underground, a landmark that reappears.
- These motifs can be referenced later for narrative advantage or complication.
- Makes the world feel interconnected and memorable.

4.7 Worked Travel Examples

4.7.1 West-to-East Coastal Journey

Leg 1: Kassamira → Ecktoria

- Seed: Ecktoria Spade (Aqueduct arcades), Ecktoria Heart (Coin-house factor), Wilds Club (gale), Kahfagia Diamond (convoy letter).
- Clock: 6 segments.

- *Narrative:* Cross under coin-house eyes with convoy priority; bad weather strains schedules.

Leg 2: Ecktoria → Silkstrand

- Seed: Acasia Spade (Three-Queens Bridge), Acasia Heart (Dyers" Guildmistress), Acasia Club (loom strike), Acasia Diamond (Exchange pass).
- Clock: 6–8 segments depending on unrest severity.

Leg 3: Silkstrand → Marcott

- Seed: Vhasia Spade (Pont-du-Tithe), Vhasia Heart (Parlement clerk), Vhasia Club (coin rumor), Vhasia Diamond (letters patent).

Leg 4: Marcott → Fairport

- Seed: Viterra Spade (Fairport tideworks), Viterra Heart (shipwright), Linn Club (boom lifts), Viterra Diamond (customs seal).
- Clock: 6 segments.

4.7.2 Mountain Pass Expedition

Leg 1: Silkstrand → Aeler Gate

- Seed: Aeler Spade (Avalanche gallery), Aeler Heart (Geometer), Aeler Club (Engineer requisition), Aeler Diamond (Underway Pass).
- Underground route bypasses surface dangers.

Leg 2: Aeler Gate → Mistlands

- Seed: Mistlands Spade (Bell-Line levee), Mistlands Heart (Bell-warden), Mistlands Club (wraith crossing), Mistlands Diamond (Ward-salt).
- Mistlands present unique navigation challenges.

4.7.3 Shadow Route Travel

Leg 1: Payden's Port → Thin Shore

- Seed: Valewood Spade (Green lane), Mistlands Heart (Protectorate clerk), Mistlands Club (bell failure), Mistlands Diamond (Lantern writ).
- Rule of 9s applies for additional complications.

Leg 2: Thin Shore Transit

- Seed: Valewood Spade (Unfound stile), Valewood Heart (Path-warden), Valewood Club (Sweet wind), Valewood Diamond (Way-cord).
- Shadow corridors require special navigation skills.

4.7.4 Frontier Diplomacy Journey

Leg: Foedus Stone Parley

- Seed: Vilikari Spade (Foedus Stone), Ykrul Heart (Noyan envoy), Wilds Club (rasputitsa), Vilikari Diamond (Foedus Renewal).
- Additional draw: Ykrul Diamond (Paiza) for border crossing rights.
- Choose which authority's laws govern your passage.

4.8 Travel Pace and Consequence Guidelines

4.8.1 Standard Travel Times

Table 4.3: Standard Travel Times

Terrain Type	Clock Size and Modifiers
Road / River leg	6-segment clock standard; +2 segments if crossing law boundaries.
Sea strait / Mountain pass	8-segment clock; -2 segments with priority documents.
Shadow corridor	6-segment clock; Ace adds free omen for future use.
Urban travel	4-segment clock; complications are more social than environmental.

4.8.2 Failure Consequences

Standard failure outcomes include:

Delay Lose time; enemies advance their plans.

Diversion Forced alternate route; draw new Club card for additional complications.

Debt Promise, fine, or favor owed to the controlling authority.

Discovery Unexpected find that creates new opportunities or dangers.

4.8.3 Success Benefits

Successful travel can provide:

- Information about upcoming regions or threats.
- New contacts or faction relationships.
- Resource acquisition or trade opportunities.
- Narrative advantages for future scenes.

4.9 Locations Lore and Generators

4.10 Acasia — “Broken Marches”

Margravine of the Broken March (Elite): “The tithe must be paid, not merely offered. A promise written in ash and sealed with iron will is worth more than a thousand gold coins scattered on the wind.”

Hedge-Witch (Commoner): “Don’t cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you’ve got a silver tooth. The bridge’ll remember it, and next time you pass, it’ll want more than just your footfall. In Acasia, every road has a memory. The question is who pays the toll.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Acasia is a former province of the Utaran Empire that festers in the space between famine and ambition. Every hill wears a crown, every bridge demands a price, and every road curves back to the same cursed crossroads. Where once the Empire’s coin and grain flowed, now tithe-collectors gnaw the marrow of starving villages, and warlords dress themselves as kings. The land itself has grown bitter: grain blights spread like gossip, wine turns to vinegar in the cask, and the old Imperial roads have forgotten where they lead. The Curse—the nameless thing that makes crossroads loop back on themselves—is not a myth. It is the weight of broken promises, and Acasia is drowning in them.

What you notice first: The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature.

Regional Mood: Famine and Ambition

Here, the past is not a memory—it is a predator. The Utaran Empire left behind roads that lead to nowhere, laws that contradict each other, and a hunger that no harvest can fill. Acasia’s petty kings hold court in burned keeps, their crowns forged from iron nails pulled from famine coffins. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colors mid-march. And beneath it all, the Curse waits. It is not a monster. It is a geometry: the wrong turn, the bridge that leads back to the same shore, the bell that tolls for no funeral. In Acasia, the land itself has become a contract, and the fine print is written in mildew.

Starting Location: The Pale Causeway’s last inn, walls soot-blackened by coal and a century of gossip. A bounty poster flutters beside a half-empty hearth. The innkeeper is a one-eyed woman who pours small beer without asking. A stranger at the bar offers a sealed contract: retrieve a dowry chest from a Blackwood matriarch before the Margravine’s feast day. “The chest contains a claim, not coin,” the stranger whispers. “But a claim in Acasia is worth more than gold—it is a key to a bridge that does not loop.”

Prominent NPCs of Acasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Morwen “ <i>the Ledger</i> ”	Margravine of the Broken March	Keep the province from fracturing completely	She has never lost a feud; her sword is also a counting rod.
Oren “ <i>Tin Crown</i> ”	The Lame King	Be recognised as a true sovereign	His traveling throne is carried by debtors; he pays them in promises.
Ysabeau	Hedge-Witch of the Blackwood Char-coalers	Survive the Curse and keep her kin from the rope	She knows which bridges eat travellers, and her price is a story that ends badly.
The Bride	Dowry chest claimant (Blackwood matriarch’s heir)	Recover the chest before the Margravine’s feast day	She carries a dagger in her wedding veil. The claim is to a bridge that drowned.
Vladan	Free Company Captain (“The Rusted Banner”)	Find a permanent contract before winter	He has served three kings this year. He cannot remember their names.
Sister Ash	Ex-Imperial surveyor	Finish the old map of Acasia	She visits villages that no longer exist. The map shows them anyway.

Names of Acasia

Inspired by the martial duchies of a fallen southern empire: clipped Latin, Langobardic war-names, and the hard consonants of mountain keeps.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Alboin		Theodelinda	da Ponte	<i>the Stiff</i>
Authari		Rosamund	del Ferro	<i>the Toll-Fist</i>
Liutprand		Gundiberga	di Rocca	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Desiderius		Anspranda	Longobardus	<i>Blackwood</i>
Ratchis		Veleda	Saxo	<i>the Unremembered</i>
Aistulf		Gisela	Capoferro	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Pass/Ruin/Toll-Town) Broken milestone on the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. Vine-terrace hillside with an abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

Spades — Places

2. **Broken Milestone** — On the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. *The stone has been chiseled seven times. The last mark is still wet.*
 3. **Vine-Terrace Hillside** — Abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now. *The ivy has grown around a skeleton. The skeleton still holds a wine cup.*
 4. **Toll-Bridge Town** — Over a cold river; two tolls, no receipts. *The second toll is collected by a child. The child does not speak.*
 5. **Wolfstairs Pass** — Switchbacks beneath a stonefall cliff. *The stones were placed by a landslide that knew your name.*
 6. **Sootfall Abbey Ruins** — Bell tower intact; crypts breathing. *The breathing is a prayer. The monks are still down there.*
 7. **Hill-Motte** — Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops. *The caltrops are from a siege that ended last week. The bodies are still rotting.*
 8. **Border-Stone Ring** — Carved with seven crowns; each points wrong. *The crowns belong to kings who never existed. The stones remember them anyway.*
 9. **Blackwood Charcoalers’ Hollow** — Witch-posts at every path. *The witch-posts were made from the gibbets of tax collectors. The tax collectors still swing.*
 10. **Salt-Road Ford** — Rains expose old bones in the chalk banks. *The bones are from three wars. They are not all human.*
- J **Iron Mine Adits** — Held by a miners’ commune; the air is full of whispers. *The whispers are the mine’s memory. It remembers every collapse.*
- Q **Margravine’s Hunting Lodge** — Tapestries of victories that never were. *The tapestries were woven by a blind weaver. The threads are from her own hair.*

K War-Camp City — Tents around a burned keep; every banner claims the throne.
The keep was burned by its own lord. He did not want to share the heat.

A The Pale Causeway — The last high road that survives the spring thaws. *The causeway is made of bones. The bones are from the workers who built it.*

(Petty Crowns/Priests/Companies) Tithe-collector’s runner with a tally-rod and an empty stomach; roadside prior with three lay brothers guarding a relic.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tithe-Collector’s Runner** — Tally-rod, empty stomach, and a list of names. *His tally-rod has notches from a dozen villages. The villages are now empty.*

3. **Roadside Prior** — Three lay brothers guarding a relic. *The relic is a finger bone. The prior claims it belonged to a saint who starved to death.*

4. **Hedge-Witch** — Knows which bridges eat travelers. *Her price is a story. The story must have a bad ending.*

5. **Free Company Captain** — Pike and shot between contracts. *He has served three kings this year. He does not remember their names.*

6. **River Reeve** — Rents every boat twice. *His paper is a single page folded into a boat. The other half is elsewhere.*

7. **Salt-Baron** — Hired blades; owns the ford and your timetable. *His salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned village.*

8. **Blackwood Matriarch** — Tends the feud like a garden. *Her garden grows tombstones. She waters them with tears—her enemies’.*

9. **Ex-Imperial Surveyor** — Has the last accurate map. *The map shows villages that no longer exist. The surveyor visits them anyway.*

10. **“King” of Three Villages** — Iron-nail crown, iron-will taxes. *His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse.*

J Bride with No Dowry but a Claim — Daggers in the wedding chest. *The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bride intends to collect.*

Q Margravine of the Broken March — Half saint, half tax roll. *She has never lost a feud. Her tally stick is her sword.*

K The Lame King — Traveling throne; makes law by pointing. *His throne is a sedan chair carried by debtors. They owe him everything.*

A The Cursed Child of Silkstrand — A rumor more than a person; her laughter ends sieges. *She is said to be twelve years old. She has been twelve for a century.*

(Feud/Levy/Weather/Curse) Peat-fog; all horns sound like someone calling your name. Sudden levy—every traveler pressed for a day’s service. Bridge feud; rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Peat-Fog** — All horns sound like someone calling your name. *The name is not yours. Answer it, and the fog will take you.*
3. **Sudden Levy** — Every traveler is pressed for a day’s service. *The levy master has a list. Your name is on it—in fresh ink.*
4. **Bridge Feud** — Rival banners drop the chain on your cart. *The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.*
5. **Grain Blight** — Doubles the tithe; refusal means torches at night. *The blight has a face. It is the face of a tax collector who died hungry.*
6. **Scree Slide** — Seals the pass; the “safe” detour is owned by your enemy. *The enemy raised the toll yesterday. He was expecting you.*
7. **Wedding Turns Ambush** — You are caught between two bloodlines. *The bride’s veil is a shroud. The groom’s ring is a knife.*
8. **Witch’s Tithe Night** — Lights move in the woods; owe nothing or else. *The lights have voices. They are arguing over who should collect.*
9. **Pox Sign** — On a village gate; your escorts desert you. *The pox is a rumor. The desertion is real.*
10. **Condotta Breaks** — The Free Company flips colors mid-march. *The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted to raise morale.*
- J **Heretic Preacher** — Sparks a march; toll-gates come down in splinters. *The preacher’s text is a tax receipt. He reads it like scripture.*
- Q **Imperial Pretender** — Arrives; every petty lord changes tabards. *The pretender’s seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is slightly crooked.*
- K **River Overruns the Levee** — The pontoon goes; your rivals don’t. *The river’s name is “Debt.” It remembers every unpaid crossing.*
- A **The Curse Stirrs** — No matter the road, you return to the same crossroads. *The crossroads has a signpost. The arms are labeled “Regret,” “Hunger,” “The Same.”*

(Papers/Claims/Safe-Conduct) Toll-exemption plaque for one bridge (once); monastery letter for bed and bread on a named road.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Toll-Exemption Plaque** — For one bridge (once). *The plaque is a bronze leaf. Hold it up, and the toll-keeper will spit—but step aside.*
3. **Monastery Letter** — For bed and bread on a named road. *The letter is sealed with a wax tear. The monks will honor it—or they will not.*

4. **Wine-Right** — On an abandoned terrace; locals will work for shares. *The wine is from a vine that grows over a mass grave. It tastes of iron.*
 5. **Condotta Contract** — A signed pike contract (one battle on your terms). *The contract is written in blood. The blood is from the captain’s own finger.*
 6. **Tithe-Remission Writ** — For a village; they owe you a season’s labor. *The writ is stamped with a bell. The bell’s clapper is a finger bone.*
 7. **Border-Stone Adjustment** — Move a line two fields over. *The adjustment is a lie. The truth is that the line was always there.*
 8. **Pass-Key Charm** — Recognized by Pale Causeway watchmen. *The charm is a knotted cord. Untie it to pass—or to stay.*
 9. **Sealed Dowry Chest** — Of claims, not coin; certain doors open. *The chest is locked with a riddle. The answer is a name you do not know.*
 10. **Mine-Share** — In the commune; they fight like they mean it. *The share is a pickaxe. The commune will lend you a miner—or a grave.*
- J **Blood-Peace Charter** — Suspend a feud long enough to move your wagons. *The charter is a white ribbon. Blood will not be spilled while it flies—but blood will remember.*
- Q **Marriage Proxy** — From the Margravine; bind a hill-king to your cause. *The proxy is a wedding veil. The veil was worn by a ghost.*
- K **The Lame King’s Traveling Writ** — Troops must make way (for now). *The writ is a broken scepter. The Lame King’s seal is a footprint.*
- A **Curse-Redemption Rite (Temporary)** — For one night, no crossroads can hold you. *The rite is a whisper. The whisper is a name you have never spoken.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/claims/safe-conducts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo plague and curse motifs—crossroads that turn back on themselves, bells tolling for no funeral, banners blackened by mildew.

Additional Features

- **Feud as Currency:** Any insult, accident, or rumor can birth a feud; the GM may replace an SB result with a feud-token tied to a petty lord or house. Feud-tokens act as reusable complications: once per scene, the GM can spend a feud-token to have a rival appear, a bridge close, or a village refuse aid.

- **Rot & Tithe:** Each market or harvest scene carries a risk of rot—add a pressure if food or coin are exchanged without a blessing or a seal. A failed roll may double the tithe or spoil stored supplies.
- **The Curse Remembers:** When roads or negotiations stall, the GM may quietly repeat imagery—crossroads, whispers, mildew—to remind players that Acasia itself resists resolution. If the party ignores three such omens, the *Curse Stirrs* complication triggers automatically.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in a burned abbey. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the charcoalers, trying to untie her cord from a Rothari death warrant.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pale Causeway is a Class II Anchor site—the ghosts of workers who died building it still carry stones. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin in every crack.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the toll-collectors. Take it, and your passage is always free—but the coin will taste of blood every time the Causeway floods.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Acasian psions are called “Feud-Readers.” They taste the weight of old grudges in the water. The Margravine employs two—and has never trusted a settlement they didn’t whisper.
- **The Ninth:** In any Acasian scene, the ninth toll paid at a bridge is never the last. The wise pay eight and barter for the ninth.

Acasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Milestone:** Crumble a crust at a broken milestone. Ignore the first *Peat-Fog* penalty.
- **Knot the Contract:** Tie a single knot in a writ’s ribbon. Cancel *Bridge Feud* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Blight:** Whisper a dead tax collector’s name into a grain sack. Gain +1 Effect when avoiding tithes this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Margravine.

Decline & Patronage

Patronage here is as brittle as candle wax. The Rothari Clan holds their marches by fear and iron law—patronage from them is real, but cruel, demanding service in blood or levy. Elsewhere, noble names are little more than titles printed on parchment and sold like promises. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days, while mercenary captains trade loyalty for coin, switching colors with each bell.

To seek a patron in Acasia is to choose which hunger you will feed: the Rothari’s iron teeth, a Free Company’s purse, or the hollow blessing of a saint who may never have lived. Yet even false crowns cast shadows long enough to shelter those desperate enough to kneel.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tithe-collectors or petty lords**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **Free Company patrols or village watchmen**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **feud-trackers or hedge-witches**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable road conditions**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **River reeve or Free Company captain** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or bridge closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival bloodline or toll-lord’s enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **feud-kin, Free Company deserters, or Margravine’s guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.

- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/levy doubled/curse triggered**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** Margravine, **Lame King**, or **Cursed Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/bridge falls/curse loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Acasia (Feud & Tithe):** Toll collectors demand double, bloodlines take offense, wagons are seized as “payment.”
- **Acasia (Rot & Famine):** Grain blights spread, wells run dry, abandoned villages hold only ghosts.
- **Acasia (Curse & Crossroads):** Roads loop back, milestones point the wrong way, the same bridge appears twice.

Boss Archetypes in Acasia

- **The False King (Feud/Authority)** — A petty lord or pretender who crowns themselves on the ruins of empire. *Phases:* Levy Demanded → Feud Declared → Hasty Coronation. *Cracks:* a **Blood-Peace Charter** suspends his authority; a **Marriage Proxy** binds him to a rival.
- **The Witch of the Blackwoods (Witchcraft/Curse)** — A hedge-witch, matriarch, or revenant who manipulates feuds and curses. *Phases:* Tithe of Fear → Curse of the Crossroads → Hollow Wedding. *Cracks:* a **Curse-Redemption Rite** breaks her hold; a **Mine-Share** gives the commune courage to defy her.
- **The Tithe Collector (Greed/Extortion)** — A bureaucrat-priest with writs, escorts, and the ability to summon feuds or famine with a single decree. *Phases:* Audit of Souls → Seizure of Grain → The Reckoning. *Cracks:* a **Toll-Exemption Plaque** voids his claim; a **Wine-Right** buys off his debtors.
- **The Rotting Child (Mystery/Curse)** — A folkloric horror tied to Acasia’s plague of false crossroads. *Phases:* Laughter in the Fog → The Bridge That Loops → The Feast of Ends. *Cracks:* a **Tithe-Remission Writ** fed to the fog; a **Monastery Letter** read aloud at the crossroads.

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Dowry That Walked:** A Blackwood matriarch’s dowry chest has been stolen. The chest contains a claim to a bridge that never floods—and a curse that the Margravine wants broken.
- **The Lame King’s Feast:** The Lame King invites the party to a feast. The feast is a trial. The food is memory. The wine is lies.
- **The Curse of the Pale Causeway:** The Causeway is repeating. Every crossing brings the party back to the same inn. The innkeeper is missing a finger. She says she gave it to the bridge.

4.11 Aelaerem (Halflings) — “Hearth & Hollow”

Apple-Matron (Elite): “A proper harvest feast requires three things: the finest cider aged in the right barrel, a guest-loaf baked with intention, and the wisdom to know when to invite the quiet ones to sit by the fire.”

Miller (Commoner): “My geese know a stranger’s step from a mile off, and they’ve never been wrong. If they start honking at noon, you best check your larder – someone’s coming who wasn’t invited. And when the Hollow walks, the only safe place is a lit hearth with the ninth cup unpoured.”

Theme & Atmosphere

In Amedell, the Aelaerem keep their bonds with bread, bells, and careful counting. Lanes run under ash and hawthorn; doors reddened with thread promise a seat and a story to any who step right. Their magic is housekeeping writ large – thresholds groomed, names jarred like jam, the Hollow fed with silence and the ninth cup left unpoured. When the Neighbors stir beneath the barrows, the folk answer with kettle songs and lantern law, and the fields behave because someone asked them to. Hospitality here is not kindness—it is a covenant. Every meal is a promise, every gift a thread, every candle an argument against the dark.

Amedell lies south of the Aelinnel homeland of Aevrossa, separated by the rolling downs and the slow waters of the River Adder. The two small-folk peoples share trade in red thread, copper, and seasonal hospitality, though the Aelaerem keep a wary distance from the fae-touched gnomish courts. It is on the Southeastern coast of the Dolmis, although the Aelaerem are rarely out to sea beyond costal fishing.

What you notice first: The smell of baking bread and old apples. The way every threshold has a red thread tied at eye level. The silence of children when a stranger passes the village stone.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse an offered cup. The Hollow counts refusals as invitations. Pour the ninth cup for the empty chair, and you may feed it—or feed it.

Regional Mood: Warm Hearths, Cold Thresholds

Here, the land is not wilderness—it is a living weave of favors and omissions. The Aelaerem do not build walls; they build hedges, stiles, and the careful geometry of guest-right. A red door means bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest. A cup-mark stone on the verge accepts butter as a prayer. The watch-geese know your step before you do, and the scarecrow turns to face the road when the Hollow is hungry. The Neighbors—the things that live under the barrows, in the uncounted ninth step, in the space between the candle and its shadow—are not enemies. They are neighbors. And neighbors, if treated politely, will stay on their side of the hedge.

Starting Location: A cider-press barn perfumed with crushed apples and rain, where masks hang from beams awaiting the next festival. The Apple-Matron sits on a stool of woven twigs. Behind her, a Moot Oak leaf bleeding red sap onto a stone. “The Hollow walks early this year,” she says. “The Moot Oak bleeds wine. Will you speak for the field, or let the Neighbors claim it? Speak true—the geese are listening.”

Prominent NPCs of Aelaerem

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Elara “Crimson Door”	Apple-Matron of the Harvest Moot	Keep the Hollow at bay and the feasts true	She pours the first cup for the eldest, the ninth for the empty chair. Never takes the ninth herself.
Bram	Miller of the Watch-Geese	Protect the village from unseen strangers	His geese have names; one is “Stranger,” and it has never been wrong.
Celia	Hedge-Witch Midwife	Tie red thread and untie feuds before they fester	Her thread is from her own hair. She never cuts it—only knots it.
Drogo	Thresher-King (seasonal)	Lead the harvest rites and keep the sheaf’s secret	Chosen by the last sheaf, which is always a little damp.
Alda	Lantern-Warden of the Downs	Trim the lamps and know which shadows are wrong	Lights them in a pattern that is a prayer.
Finnian	Mummers’ Captain	Guard the masks and the laws of festival	The masks are not carved. They are grown.

Names of Aelaerem

Inspired by the pastoral hill country of a green and misty isle: earthy, clipped, with soft vowels and hard consonants, evoking hearth, hedge, and hollow.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Tolly		Daisy	Underhill	<i>the Red-Door</i>
Bram		Posy	Bywater	<i>the Goose-Wise</i>
Corbin		Marigold	Brookside	<i>Barrow-Born</i>
Willum		Hazel	Holloway	<i>Hollow-Touched</i>
Hodge		Fern	Fielding	<i>the Uninvited</i>
Pippin		Ivy	Hayward	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Lanes/Orchards/Mills/Downs/Barrows) Willow ford with flat stones and a bowed pollard that remembers faces; cider-press barn with sweet reek, old songs, doors that stick after dusk; chalk sheep-downs with a turf maze cut like a wheel.

Spades — Places

2. **Willow Ford** — Flat stones, bowed pollard that remembers faces. *The willow has a name. It will tell you if you sit beneath it and listen.*
3. **Cider-Press Barn** — Sweet reek, old songs, doors that stick after dusk. *The press was built from a barrow oak. The oak still dreams.*
4. **Chalk Sheep-Downs** — Turf maze cut like a wheel; sheep know the pattern. *The maze is a prayer. Walk it backward to ask a favor.*
5. **Millpond Under Alders** — The wheel turns some nights without water. *The water is not water. It is the memory of rain.*
6. **Bluebell Wood Path** — Rabbit-gates and snares set by careful hands. *The snares are for the Hollow. They catch only shadows—mostly.*
7. **Hedge-Tunnel Lane** — Between fields; nine stiles, locals count “eight-and-one.” *The ninth stile is a gap in the hedge. Step through, and the lane behind you changes.*
8. **Cup-Mark Stone on the Verge** — Butter left in niches goes missing kindly. *The butter vanishes before dawn. The Hollow leaves a pebble in exchange.*
9. **Barrow-by-the-Beech** — Bees go quiet at noon. *The bees are not sleeping. They are listening.*
10. **Market Green** — Maypole and stocks; carved village stones turned inward. *The stones face the green. They watch the maypole dance—and the dancers.*
- J **Dovecote Hill** — The scarecrow faces the road, not the rows. *The scarecrow has a face. It is the face of the last person who broke guest-right.*
- Q **Mother’s Orchard** — Rows straighten if you don’t look—curve if you do. *The orchard is a promise. Break it, and the apples will taste of ash.*
- K **Moot Oak** — Lantern nails hammered deep; benches at the roots. *The nails are from a hundred feuds. Each one holds a grudge.*

A **Hollow Field** — A ring where no plow will hold a line, not for any coin. *The field is a mouth. It has not fed in a century.*

(Keepers/Elders/Mummers/Quiet Powers) Hedge-witch midwife who ties red thread and unties feuds; miller and his watch-geese—better sentries than men.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hedge-Witch Midwife** — Ties red thread, unties feuds, and knows which births the Hollow watches. *Her thread is from her own hair. She never cuts it—only knots it.*
 3. **Miller** — Watch-geese that remember faces; better sentries than men. *The geese have names. One is “Stranger.” It has never been wrong.*
 4. **Orchard Reeve** — Tally-stick, cider-stained smile, and a list of who owes what harvest. *His tally-stick is an apple branch. The notches grow back.*
 5. **Beekeeper** — Keeps odd honey aside for “winter churches.” *The honey is from barrow flowers. It tastes of earth and old promises.*
 6. **Shepherd** — Bone whistle that calls dogs—and other things. *The whistle is from a wolf. The wolf still answers.*
 7. **Lantern-Warden** — Trims lamps and knows which shadow is wrong. *She lights the lamps in a pattern. The pattern is a prayer to keep the Hollow back.*
 8. **Mummers’ Captain** — Chest of masks, stricter rules than church. *The masks are not carved. They are grown.*
 9. **Traveling Tinker** — Bright kettles, dull knife for cutting oaths. *The knife was his father’s. His father used it to cut a promise with the Hollow.*
 10. **Bailiff of the Moot Oak** — Polite as a noose, carries a tally of grudges. *His tally is bark. The writing grows deeper each year.*
- J **Wold-Wardens** — Elders who swear by hedges, not crowns. *They measure time in hedge-layers. A hedge that has grown for a century has a hundred opinions.*
- Q **Apple-Matron** — Hostess of harvest feasts; power sits where she pours. *She pours the first cup for the eldest, the second for the guest, the eighth for the fire. The ninth cup is for the empty chair.*
- K **Thresher-King** — A title that moves but never leaves; harvest robes, seasonal authority. *He is chosen by the last sheaf. The sheaf is always a little damp.*
- A **The Pale Shepherd** — Comes when lambs are born and when people go missing. *He has no face. His hat is a shadow.*

(Folk Omens/Rites/Beasts/Night) Unseasonal fog; the road walks you back to your own gate. Scarecrow turns; it watches the lane, not the field. Black sow through the orchard; hooves scuff every charm.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Unseasonal Fog** — The road walks you back to your own gate. *The gate is closed. The latch is red. Do not touch it.*
 3. **Scarecrow Turns** — It watches the lane, not the field. *The scarecrow’s head follows you. The crows are silent.*
 4. **Soured Wassail** — The bowl gives back names you did not speak. *The names are of people who died last winter. They are not listed in any tally.*
 5. **Black Sow in the Orchard** — Hooves scuff every charm. *The sow was a woman once. She broke a vow.*
 6. **Hive-Swarm at Dusk** — Smoke curls the wrong way. *The bees are spelling a word. The word is “quest.”*
 7. **Old Song Taken Up by Children** — Adults remember the verse none should sing. *The verse is about a barrow that opened. The children think it is a lullaby.*
 8. **Lanterns Burn Blue at the Ford** — Crossing costs more than coin. *The blue light is a toll-keeper. Payment is a story—or a secret.*
 9. **Out-of-Season Mumming** — Masks stick; faces won’t come off. *The masks are warm. They have a heartbeat.*
 10. **Chalk Maze Fills with Mist** — You step out somewhere older. *The mist has a smell—old wool and older bread.*
- J Church Bell Rings Thirteen** — Something attends the sermon. *The thirteenth pew is empty. The dust on it is fresh.*
- Q Harvest Tithe Demanded** — Hands gloved in leaves. *The hands do not belong to anyone in the village.*
- K Moot Oak Bleeds Sap** — The color of wine; talk turns to knives. *The sap is warm. It tastes of blood and honey.*
- A The Hollow Opens** — Burrows and barrows connect; footfalls answer underground. *The footsteps are counting. They stop at eight.*

(Blessings/Tokens/Host-Rights) Guest-loaf and salt—one night’s safe board anywhere with a red door; cider-mark—a free cup on the green buys gossip and patience.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Guest-Loaf & Salt** — One night’s safe board anywhere with a red door. *The loaf is barley and rye. Break it with the host, and the Hollow will not cross the threshold—for one night.*

3. **Cider-Mark** — A free cup on the green buys gossip and patience. *The mark is a notch on a barrel. The tapster will remember you—or pretend not to.*
 4. **Hedge-Pass Ribbon** — Step through any thicket unsnagged, once. *The ribbon is red. Tie it to a branch, and the thorns will part—once.*
 5. **Bee-Queen Share** — Honey and a warning from the hives when danger nears. *The honey is from a queen who died last year. Her ghost still guards the comb.*
 6. **Shepherd’s Whistle** — Dogs and door-bolts heed you for one scene. *The whistle is a knucklebone. Blow it, and the dogs will obey—or they will hide.*
 7. **Lantern-Writ** — The lamps stay lit along your path despite wind. *The writ is a bell. Ring it, and the lamps will not flicker—until dawn.*
 8. **Mummers’ License** — Lawful mask and after-dark crossing for a feast day. *The license is a wooden mask. Wear it, and the Hollow will see a stranger—not a guest.*
 9. **Orchard Right** — Pick at Mother’s Orchard without offense; the fruit hides a truth. *The fruit is a secret. Bite it, and the secret will become yours—or it will become you.*
 10. **Mill Token** — The wheel turns at any hour, grain or rumor ground. *The token is a millstone chip. Feed it to the wheel, and it will grind anything—truths included.*
- J **Apple-Matron’s Blessing** — Hands help unseen when you ask no coin. *The blessing is a cup. Pour it out in trouble, and the fields will send rain—or roots.*
- Q **Private Moot Under the Oak** — Elders hear you alone; precedent sticks. *The moot is held at midnight. The oak’s roots are the jury.*
- K **Thresher-King’s Guard** — Six red-hooded harvesters escort you; doors open. *Their hoods are the color of dried blood. They do not speak.*
- A **Pale Shepherd’s Clause** — Once, the Hollow will not notice you; pass uncounted. *The clause is a silence. The Hollow will step aside—and will remember that it did.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (blessings/tokens/host-rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo Hearth & Hollow motifs—quiet bells, red thread, watch-geese, footsteps under the soil—so the dread feels woven through the hedges.

Additional Features

- **Bread & Lantern:** Presenting a guest-loaf and a lit lantern at a threshold shifts your next social action one step safer while you remain a guest of that hearth. The lantern must be lit from the host’s fire.
- **Neighboring Courtesies:** When you keep local taboos (count “eight-and-one,” turn village stones inward, leave butter at cup-marks), cancel the first SB generated by rites or negotiations in that scene.
- **Listen at the Stile:** A quiet pause at a stile, barrow, or hedge-tunnel yields a true omen—ask one short question about what the Hollow wants *here and now*; the answer arrives as a sign, a sound, or a small animal.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** A renegade Sister once sought refuge among the hedge-witches, hoping to untie her cord in a hollow field. The Apple-Matron gave her bread and salt, then showed her to the stile at dusk. The Sister was never seen again. The Daughters now speak of Aelaerem as a place where their threads *will not hold*—and they do not send others.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Saikou Iraś silver mirror, when turned toward a cup-mark stone, shows only the reflection of the one who holds it. He has written in his private notes: *“The Hollow does not welcome witnesses. I left butter and a coin, and the butter was taken. The coin was left on the stile. I will not return.”*
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** The silver coin that never spends was last seen in the pocket of a wandering preacher who came to the downs to speak of curses and redemption. The mummers offered him a mask and a cup. The next morning, the coin lay on the Moot Oak root, and the preacher’s hat hung from the scarecrow’s post. No one asked questions.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** The Apple-Matron employs no psions. When a Threshold-Reader once offered her services, the Matron smiled and said, *“The hollow knows our weights well enough without a stranger’s tongue.”* The Reader left by the north lane before nightfall. Aelaerem keeps its own counsel.
- **The Ninth:** Missionaries of every faith who cross the hedge-tunnel lane with intent to preach are met at the ninth stile. They are offered a cup of cider and a guest-loaf, then shown the way back. Those who refuse the cup are never counted again. The wise among the faithful now mark Aelaerem on their maps with a single word: *“Silent.”*

Aelaerem Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Barrow:** Crumble a crust at a cup-mark stone. Ignore the first *Hive-Swarm* penalty.
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a red thread at a threshold. Cancel *Out-of-Season Mumming* or take –1 die on your next festival roll (your choice).

- **Name to the Hollow:** Whisper a dead person’s name into an empty chair. Gain +1 Effect when invoking guest-right this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Pale Shepherd.

Hearth Magic

The Aelaerem weave their power through careful observance and small courtesies. Their magic lies not in grand gestures but in the precise attention to thresholds, seasons, and the proper ordering of things. Red thread binds more than wounds—it ties names to places, promises to people, and the living to the Hollow that walks beneath their feet. To offend a hedge-witch is to invite the Neighbors’ attention; to earn an elder’s blessing is to walk with the earth’s favor.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or hedge-keepers**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watch-geese or mummers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or the Hollow**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable light**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Orchard reeve or lantern-warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or threshold shift**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **scarecrow or Hollow spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wold-wardens, mummers, or Neighbors** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **taboo broken/geese turn/Hollow stirs**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Apple-Matron, Thresher-King, or Pale Shepherd** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/barrow opens/Hollow walks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aelaerem (Hearth & Hollow):** Quiet bells toll for no reason; red thread appears tied to your belongings; watch-geese honk warnings in the night.
- **Aelaerem (Threshold Magic):** A door you passed through earlier now leads somewhere else; your shadow walks behind you instead of beside you.
- **Aelaerem (Folk Customs):** You forget a crucial local taboo and offend the Neighbors; small things begin to go wrong—milk sours, knots loosen, a child points at the empty chair.

Boss Archetypes in Aelaerem

- **The Scarecrow Regent (Omen/Threshold)** — A hedge-raised guardian wearing twelve charms and one wrong knot. *Phases:* Stare of the Lane → Scare the Crows → Harvest of Faces. *Cracks:* a **Guest-Loaf** offered to its post; a **Mummers’ License** to wear a mask it cannot read.
- **The Hollow Bride (Otherworld/Hospitality)** — A Neighbor wearing a borrowed name and wedding veil. *Phases:* Invitation Drifted → Feast of Shadows → Ninth Cup Poured. *Cracks:* a **Shepherd’s Whistle** to call the dogs that guard the threshold; a **Lantern-Writ** to see her true face.
- **Lantern Bailiff of the Moot (Justice/Order)** — Enforcer of hedge-law with warrant-nails and bell-keys. *Phases:* Lantern Law → Midnight Moot → Binding Geas. *Cracks:* a **Cider-Mark** to buy a night’s silence; a **Moot Oak bench** to appeal his ruling.
- **Beekeeper of Winter Church (Sacred/Whisper)** — Keeper of cold honey and sleeping hymns. *Phases:* Swarm Omen → Waxed Vow → Memory Tithe. *Cracks:* a **Bee-Queen Share** to call her swarm to heel; a **Lantern** lit from a winter church candle.

Faction Entanglements

- **Wold-Wardens:** Honor hedge-law (count stiles, turn stones inward) or suffer +1 SB on each night march; bringing steel disputes to the Moot Oak reduces the next travel DV by 1.
- **Mummers’ Companies:** Travel under mask grants advantage crossing parochial borders; anger them (perform out of season) and village gates close at dusk (Position –).
- **Lantern-Wardens:** Donate oil or HEAL lamps to earn an escort marker; ignore a lit-lane and pay a “darkness toll” (first Stealth/Scout roll each night suffers –1 die).
- **Apple-Matron Circles:** Feast-days open barns and purses; snub an invitation and local prices double until amends are made.
- **Neighbors (quiet powers):** Leave butter at cup-marks to cancel the first supernatural SB this leg; break taboo and the Hollow stirs (add a *Hollow Attention* tick).

Cross-Regional Ties

- **Aeler Soft-Power:** Red-thread guest-right and courtesies are fashionable among Aeler houses; reputation for keeping hearth-law grants +1 die to parley with Aeler stewards and toll-clerks.
- **Kahfagian Sea-Lanes:** Beeswax, cider-brand, and wool ride river-to-coast. Storm seasons push Kahfagian factors inland—good silver, stricter contracts.
- **Way of Silk Spurs:** Caravans detour across the downs for night-safe lanes under lantern law; counterfeit guest-loaf tokens discovered here echo as distrust along Silk waystations (Social DV +1 until cleared).
- **Valewood Fallout (North):** Moon-sap and dream pollen drift on certain winds: chalk mazes misalign, barrow-whispers grow bold. When *Valewood Weather* is in effect, the first night omen is always true (good or ill).

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Hollow Bride’s Invitation:** A wedding invitation arrives at the inn. The bride is not from any village on the map. The groom has not been seen in a week. The ninth chair at the feast is already occupied.
- **The Scarecrow’s Harvest:** Crows are building a nest on the scarecrow’s shoulder. Inside the nest is a key. The key opens a door that should not exist.
- **The Beekeeper’s Tithe:** The winter church’s bees have stopped producing honey. They are producing wax effigies of the PCs. The beekeeper wants to know why.

4.12 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

Elite (Vault-Queen of a crownland)

“The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone, every seal pressed into its walls. To govern here is not to command, but to harmonize with the ancient songs that still echo in the deep places.”

Commoner (Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away)

“When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all’s well, but three knocks at night means something’s coming through the walls that wasn’t meant to walk.”

Crowns & Under-Vaults

The Aeler Kingdoms hold the mountains by breath, bell, and bargain. Dozens of sovereign holds – some sealed for centuries, others trading openly with lowland markets – share only the deep roots of stone and the supremacy of the High King Beneath the Peaks. Their halls run like arteries, their cities open in thunderous caverns where bridges leap between ribs of stone and cisterns shine like night skies turned inward. *Survival* is the first law: air is counted, water is bartered, light is rationed by wick and prayer. *Tradition* is the second: seals are kept, measures remain true, and the dead keep their offices as carefully as the living. Between the two, a people learn to argue quietly and build loudly.

Collectives (clans, guild-kin, lamp-companies) own what the mountain allows; individuals are custodians by oath. Trade runs under and over the range through under-ways and pass-forts, stitching protectorates and lowland markets to vault-mouth gates. When tunnels whisper or the air tastes wrong, the Aeler move as one animal; when the Kingsmoot calls, crowns and abbesses argue in bell-code and sealed writs until the stone itself seems to lean in.

The Fractured Crowns: Aeler Faction Spectrum

Aeler society is not monolithic. Beneath the High King’s nominal authority, each crownland follows its own star. Attitudes toward the surface range from open partnership to militant isolation, and even the most reclusive holds maintain **Edgewalker** contacts to monitor the world above.

- **Traditionalist** / “**The Old Ways**” – These holds idealize the ancient mountain-empire: closed gates, iron tariffs, and the certain knowledge that surface-dwellers cannot be trusted. They resemble the dwarves of fireside tales: stubborn, insular, and quick to reach for an axe when a human mentions “progress.” Their kings speak of the days when no foreigner stepped past the vaultmouth. *Clocks: FOREIGNER SUSPICION [4], HOLD SEALED [6].*
- **Cooperative** / “**Open Hand**” – These holds trade freely with Aelaerem, Kahfagia, and even the Vilikari. They staff the under-markets, send engineers to repair bridges in Viterra, and treat the surface as a resource to be managed, not a threat to be shunned. They prefer soft power: standardised measures, certified weights, and

bell-code protocols that make others *want* to trade on Aeler terms. *Clocks: TRADE ROUTE PROSPERITY [6], CULTURAL FRICTION [4].*

- **Isolationist / “Silent Stone”** – Deep holds that have not answered a Kingsmoot call in living memory. Their gates are lost, their peoples rumoured to have turned inward, worshipping forgotten depths. They neither help nor harm the surface – but when a White Flood or a gas flare occurs, their silence becomes a hazard of its own. *Clocks: SILENT HOLD AWAKENS [8], ANCIENT GRUDGE [6].*

Most Aeler characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same hold might shift its stance over a season, depending on grain prices, a new Vault-Queen, or a disaster that forces its hand.

Prominent NPCs of Aeler

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Valthor Aezel-bron	High King Beneath the Peaks	Preserve the ancient concord and balance the crownlands	He has not spoken above a whisper in seven years. The court reads his will by bell-code.
Grunhelda Thrainsdottir	Vault-Queen of Iron-deep	Expand trade routes while keeping the Old Ways satisfied	She keeps a pet geode that hums when a contract is fair.
Maeva Kaelen	Legate of the Under-Seal	Negotiate passage rights and standard measures with lowland realms	Her seal-rod is carved from a fossilised root. She has never lost a tariff dispute.
Thromm Stone-Tongue	Under-Mason (Commoner exemplar)	Hear the mountain’s warnings and keep the tunnels safe	He can identify a false weight by tapping it once with his hammer.

Orthen White-Ribbon	Tunnel Courier	Deliver sealed writs across hostile jurisdictions	He has run the Spine Underway in darkness without a lamp. Twice.
Lumenor Saela	Keeper of the Under- Altars	Maintain the breath-rites and the old flame	She speaks only in bell tones during services. Her mundane voice is never heard.

Names of Aeler

Aeler names blend flowing vowels and soft diphthongs (ae, ei, ou, ui) with harsh consonants (k, th, z, r, g). Surnames are carved from mountain-roots: a hold, a forge, a seam, or a trade.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Thrain		Grunhelda	Aezenbron	<i>the Iron</i>
Kaelen		Maeva	Thrainkhar	<i>Breath-Steady</i>
Orthen		Saela	Valdurg	<i>Seal-Keeper</i>
Rurik		Aeldis	Kaelthane	<i>Bell-Tongue</i>
Bromm		Helka	Zarkul	<i>the Under-Mason</i>
Zelgur		Thorunn	Dornvael	<i>White-Ribbon</i>

Spades — Places (vaultmouths, descents, underways, crown seats)

- (Security/Gatekeeping) Vaultmouth Gate in a hillslope: bronze lungs for breath-tests, tally-niches for lamps.
- (Tradition/Oaths) Crown-Crypt Porch where oaths are sworn to sleeping kings.
- (Commerce/Underground) Under-Market: lantern alleys between cistern pillars; damp coin, dry wit.
- (Labor/Danger) Smoke-Shaft Stair spiraling up to a soot hatch; handprints black as seals.
- (Mystery/Whispers) Gloam Cistern—black water, lead scales, whispers carry too far.
- (Maintenance/Travel) Lamplighter’s Mile on the Under-Road; niches sting with spent wicks.

8. (Precision/Authority) Measure Vault: standard rods and weights chained under glass and oath.
 9. (Sacred/Knowledge) Reliquary Arcade: bell-chimes answer drafts; saints keep their own tallies.
 10. (Military/Strategic) Twin-Throne Gate—surface fortress straddling a chasm bridge.
- J (Knowledge/Secrecy) Deep Archive Stacks behind grillwork; scriptoria cells breathe ink and dust.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Queen’s Descent: private stair from palace to royal vault-house.
- K (Politics/Power) Kingsmoot Cavern—crownstones in a ring around a bottomless dark.
- A (Infrastructure/Majesty) The Spine Underway, a great tunnel linking crownlands beneath the peaks.

Hearts — People & Factions (crowns, keepers, guilds, legates)

2. (Apprenticeship/Dedication) Lamplighter apprentice with a jingling key-ring and soot in the lungs.
 3. (Craft/Knowledge) Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away.
 4. (Authority/Duty) Vault Warden with breath-ledger and seal-rods; patient as granite.
 5. (Protection/Faith) Censer-Knight of the Dawn – fights miasma and men with equal zeal.
 6. (Sacred/Craft) Key-Sister (monastic locksmith) who names wards like prayers.
 7. (Commerce/Authority) Under-Market assessor whose stamp can starve or save a stall.
 8. (Engineering/Expertise) Engineer of Underways (geometer) with rod, hammer, and the right maps.
 9. (Tradition/Law) Oath-Keeper of the Crown Crypt – memory like iron, smile like law.
 10. (Diplomacy/Authority) Legate of the Under-Seal, royal commissioner between kingdoms.
- J (Communication/Loyalty) White-Ribbon tunnel courier; runs blind, rings true.
- Q (Royalty/Authority) Vault-Queen of a crownland, sovereign above and below.
- K (Supreme Authority/Tradition) High King Beneath the Peaks, first among crowns by ancient concord.
- A (Spiritual Power/Resolution) Lumenor of the Under-Altars, one sentence opens doors and closes debates.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (air, water, stone, rite, jurisdiction)

2. (Danger/Disorientation) Bad air pocket—candles gutter blue; lungs complain, schedules fail.
 3. (Disruption/Flood) Drip-flood from a burst cistern reroutes corridors without asking.
 4. (Accident/Destruction) Gas flare kisses a lamp; eyebrows and evidence vanish.
 5. (Error/Security) Seal misread—the wrong door opens, the right one will not.
 6. (Quarantine/Delay) Under-mold quarantine shuts the market just as your crate arrives.
 7. (Danger/Warning) Settling crack—dust snow warns the roof wants down.
 8. (Accusation/Suspicion) Stolen key turns up in your kit; accusations ring like bells.
 9. (Conflict/Jurisdiction) Bell-code conflict—two authorities claim the same chime.
 10. (Political Conflict/Violence) Vault-right feud: crown guards face basilica wardens on a stair.
- J (Disaster/Trapped) Cave-in behind—proof, friends, and retreat on the far side.
- Q (Religious Conflict/Inquisition) Heresy inquest in the under-chapel; arrests in whispers.
- K (Authority/Restriction) General Under-Seal—all vault traffic halted by royal decree.
- A (Natural Disaster/Destruction) White Flood—mountain thaw becomes a river through your route.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (keys, passes, breath, priority, precedent)

2. (Utility/Time) Lamp-priority tally—skip one lamplighter queue.
3. (Safety/Access) Breath-measure allotment—lawful time in a sealed chamber (once).
4. (Security/Authority) Key-Writ—operate a named lock one time, witnessed.
5. (Travel/Security) Underway Pass—escorted travel between two vaultmouths.
6. (Commerce/Rights) Stall-Right in the under-market for a season.
7. (Engineering/Safety) Engineer Shoring—a crew stabilizes your chosen corridor on your timetable.
8. (Commerce/Trust) Assay Mark—your coin/metal accepted sight unseen below.

9. (Protection/Law) Crypt Asylum—temporary sanctuary under crown law.
10. (Authority/Access) Vault Inventory License—remove a named cache under witness.
- J (Military/Authority) Under-Guard Commission—command a vault detachment for a day.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Private Descent with the Vault-Queen or High King’s chancellor.
- K (Supreme Authority/Access) High King’s Sealed Writ—doors open, mouths close across crownlands.
- A (Exception/Power) The Under-Seal Clause—temporary exception to any lock, levy, or rite below.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5→4, 6–10→6, J/Q/K→8, A→10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (keys/passes/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo stone & breath motifs—keys click, bells answer, and the mountain listens (and remembers).

Additional Features

- **Count the Air:** When a scene establishes scarce air, a character who actively paces their breathing (counted steps, measured rests) may shift *Position* one step safer on their next physical action in a confined space.
- **Bell-Code Courtesies:** If the party adopts local bell etiquette (asking a warden which chime applies and heeding it), gain +1 assist die on negotiations or passage requests within a vault or under-market.
- **Measure is Mercy:** Presenting a certified measure (rod, weight, sealed tally) calms a dispute: cancel the first SB generated by commerce or jurisdictional friction in the scene.

Stone & Sovereignty

In the deep places, survival depends on precision and tradition. The Aeler understand that stone does not forgive error – a misread seal can mean death, a miscalculated air measure can doom an expedition, and a broken bell-code can spark jurisdictional war. Their society is built on layers of authority, each with its own rites, rights, and responsibilities. To navigate their realm is to learn a complex dance of deference and demand, where even the humblest lamplighter holds power over the darkness, and the smallest key can unlock the greatest vault.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **vault wardens or lamp-lighter companies**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **under-guards or echo bats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or assessors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable air**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Breath warden or vault warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **air shift or seal change**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crown’s guard or gas wraith** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **crown guards, true masons, or lamp companies** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **seal misread/cave-in/flare ignites**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Vault-Queen, High King’s Legate, or Lumenor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **gas floods/water breaks/floor collapses**.

- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aeler (Stone & Breath):** Keys click in the wrong locks, bells answer without being rung, mountain air grows thin without warning.
- **Aeler (Authority & Tradition):** A seal is misread, bell-codes conflict between jurisdictions, a vault warden demands proper credentials.
- **Aeler (Underground Hazards):** Bad air pockets form, settling cracks warn of collapse, gas flares ignite unexpectedly.

Aeler — Under-Vault Tensions

Starting Location: An Underway junction lit by guttering brass lanterns, its stone walls scored with tally-marks from a dozen forgotten crowns.

“Among the Aeler, stone remembers the weight of oaths, and every echo calls a reckoning.”

In... An Underway junction, a Geometer halts the party with a tally-rod. “The Spine shifts,” he says, stone-dust in his beard. “Choose a crown—or be buried by one.”

Regional Motifs Load-bearing oaths, fault-prayers, crown-rights, catacomb guilds.

Whispers to Offer “Cut a supporting tie,” “Sign for another’s debt,” “Take a shortcut through the sealed tunnel.”

External Clocks Threat: “The Spine Slips”; Fracture: “Maps Reorder”; Community: “Surface Panic.”

Complications Load-lights dim; echoes reply in politics; crown agents arrive early.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s workshop; a shared refuge tunnel.

Escalation Beat The tally-rod points to the most guilty PC.

Relief Shore a vault with sacrifice (1 anchor), or complete a truce between crowns; Spirit + Resolve (5) to hold a cave-in long enough to evacuate.

Faction Entanglements

- **Edgewalkers (Prospectors):** If you accept their escort or intel, start a 4-segment *Opportunity* clock you can cash for +1 Effect on one venture. If you refuse a posted hazard, they post *your* route as “open” (first stealth or smuggling roll this leg suffers –1 die).
- **True Masons (Infrastructure Orders):** Pledge tools or labor to earn a *Mason’s Stamp* (treat as papers to traverse construction zones). Cross a marked barrier without their leave and gain the *Tampered Work* tag—first structural mishap SB against you is free.
- **Lamplighter Companies:** Donate wick, oil, or time on the Mile to bank a *Lamp Credit*; spend to ignore darkness penalties once on the Under-Road. Skip a service bell and all under-market buys that scene cost +1 clock tick (queues & suspicion).
- **Under-Market Assessors:** Submit to measure/weigh and reduce Commerce DV by 1 this scene. Try to pass unassayed goods—on a Miss, lose the load *or* accept a *Caveat Stamp* that poisons your price two markets downstream.
- **Breath Wardens:** Register bodies & flames before sealed work; compliance cancels the first air-hazard SB. Skipping registry adds a *Thin Air* tick to the leg (applies –1 die to the first exertion test in confinement).

Cross-Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Agrarian Reliance (Human Breadbelts):** Grain, timber, tallow, and fleece convoys from Acasia/Vhasia/Viterra sustain vault populations. Famine or levy spikes uprange impose night rationing; Under-Road checks +1 DV and food trades add +1 SB pressure until relief.
- **Standards Diplomacy:** Aeler *Measure Vault* rods adopted abroad grant +1 die to settle disputes in foreign markets; rejecting Aeler standards increases toll and inspection frequency (first border scene gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB).
- **True Mason Missions Abroad:** Accept a Mason cadre to “stabilize” bridges, ports, or sluices: reduce Travel DV by 1 on that route for the arc, but the route now respects Aeler closure bells (authorities can halt traffic with one writ).
- **Edgewalker Concessions:** Prospect notes traded to frontier lords exchange for wayleaves and salvage rights; cash once for an *Under-Seal Clause (local)* or accept a rival claimant clock that will mature if you delay.
- **Kahfagian Interface (Sea Monopoly):** Aeler export hard-goods via Kahfagian factors; storm seasons or privateer scares add a *Harbor Quarantine* tick to any surface leg feeding those ports (customs DV +1).
- **Aelerem/Aelinnel Fallout:** When *Valewood Weather* is signaled, Aeler works creak; all bell-codes in mixed settlements (Aelerem/Aelinnel) are one step easier to misread (first bell-etiquette scene: add a free “Error/Security” SB unless you consult a local).

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Airworks & Wick (Oil, Char, Filters):** Donate to a vault—bank a *Breath Favor* to cancel the next bad-air complication. Hoard in a shortage and your lot is flagged; all purchases beneath that crown suffer −1 die until you settle a fine or tithe.
- **Stonework & Ironwork (Beams, Keys, Rods):** Selling to foreign keeps spreads Aeler codes: once per arc, treat a foreign gate as if it used Aeler warding (gain +1 die with Key-Sisters/warders there). Counterfeit measure rods trigger a cross-border inquest clock.
- **Foodflows (Grain, Fleece, Tallow):** Move relief trains to clear one *Rationing* tag for a settlement (DV −1 for social checks there). Divert a relief train and gain an *Audit* clock that follows you three markets hence.
- **Cistern-Right & Water Engineering:** Fund a sluice or cistern abroad to gain *Water Priority* (skip one queue during drought). Neglect maintenance and the keeper may invoke *Aeler Liability*—pay or lose access to the route for a season.

Patron Networks (Below and Beyond)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Consecrated door-nails from True Mason kits act as single-use *stay* writs (negate one forced entry this scene).
- **The Traveler:** Spine milestones double as wayshrines; leave a brass chit to reroll one failed travel test on that segment this arc.
- **Inquisitor Prime:** Breath-pure censers sanction “clean rooms”; once per delve, dispel one ambient miasma or ward-rot effect at cost of +1 Obligation to local abbey-knights.
- **Maelstraesus:** Under-Market stalls tithe to the Great Ledger; cash a *Market Dominance* tick to flip one price band in your favor for a scene, then mark a 4-segment *Karmic Debt* with assessors.

Survival-Horror Procedures (Use Often)

- **Headcount & Flamecount:** At scene start in confinement, ask “Who breathes, what burns?” If headcount+flamecount exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start a 4-segment *Stale Air* clock.
- **Two Bells to Safety:** Any time the fiction stalls underground, ring two nearby bells (authority vs. sanctum). PCs must pick one to heed; ignoring both increases the next hazard’s Cap by +1 (stone holds grudges).
- **Measure or Mistrust:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB this scene; failing to present one imposes −1 die on haggling or passage until appeased.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Breath Favor (minor resource):** Earned by donating wick/oil or assisting air wardens. Spend to downgrade one underground hazard outcome or to bypass a lamplighter queue.
- **Stamps & Seals:**
 - *Mason-Marked:* Doors to worksites open; smugglers avoid you (harder to buy contraband, easier to cross safely).
 - *Edge-Trusted:* Prospectors share fresh maps—first detour per leg is free; officials eye you as opportunists (first civic audience DV +1).
 - *Assessor-Clean:* Under-markets honor your assay; rivals spread rumors—add a trailing *Audit* clock if you score a windfall.

Boss Archetypes in Aeler

Systemic / Economic / Conspiracy

- **Under-Market Syndic (Cartel/Measure Fraud):** Price-fixes breath, wick, and water; wields corrupt assay marks to starve rivals. *Win by exposing forged measures or seizing the Assay Chain.*
- **True Mason Provost (Infrastructure Coup):** Locks cities behind “safety closures,” weaponizes detours and permits. *Win by forcing a public bell-code audit or breaking the Permit Clock.*
- **Edgewalker Concessionaire (Route Monopolist):** Controls salvage and shortcuts, posts hazards to strangle traffic. *Win by proving route tampering or opening a sanctioned bypass.*
- **Bell-Code Inquisitor (Silent Coup):** Rewrites chimes to shift jurisdiction; arrests arrive as echoes. *Win by restoring canonical bell charts or capturing the Chime Key.*

Survival Horror (Environment as Boss)

- **White Flood (Water/Pressure):** Thaw-swollen river through the halls; phases at *trickle* → *surge* → *roar*. *Win by sluicework, sacrificial breach, or riding the flood.*
- **Bad Air (Miasma/Invisible):** Candles gutter blue; thoughts slow; corridors choose the slowest. *Win by air discipline, filter rites, or opening a lung-shaft.*
- **Hungry Stone (Creep/Collapse):** Settling cracks hunt noise and heat; shudders on every miss. *Win by shoring, silence, and rerouting stress through old ribs.*
- **Lamp Famine (Darkness/Isolation):** Wicks fail in sequence; last lights lure you deeper. *Win by restoring the Lamplighter’s Mile or kindling a saint-wick.*

Undead / Fallen Kingdom / Eldritch / Demonic

- **Crown-Lich of the Crypt (Undead Sovereign):** Keeps ancient offices; binds petitioners with oaths to the dead. *Win by repealing a mortmain writ or severing the Oath-Chain.*
- **Echo-King in the Deep (Eldritch Memory):** A throne of voices; answers every argument you will ever make. *Win by changing the Measure (new precedent) or striking the Silent Note.*
- **Seal-Devil (Demonic Contract):** Lives in locks and signatures; eats exceptions. *Win by offering a flawless counter-seal or starving it of loopholes.*
- **The Hollow Architect (Fallen Works):** A ghost-guilder rebuilding the empire wrong on purpose. *Win by unkeying the master plan or collapsing the false load paths.*

Boss Mechanics Notes

- **Air & Light Tracks:** In confined scenes, track *Headcount*, *Flamecount*. If *Headcount* + *Flamecount* exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start **Stale Air** [4]. Each tick imposes −1 die to exertion until vented.
- **Jurisdiction Clocks:** Many bosses run a **Bell-Code Conflict** [4] or **Seal Dispute** [6]. On fill, the boss gains *Authority Surge*: increase their social DV by +1 and seize initiative once.
- **Lair Actions (choose 2–3):**
 - *Collapse Probe:* Mark “Settling Crack”; nearest noisy PC tests PROWESS or risk *Pin/Separate*.
 - *Breath Tax:* Reduce *Flamecount* by 1; next exertion in zone costs Fatigue 1 on a miss.
 - *Blackout/Glare:* Snuff or flare lamps; impose Disorient (−1 die) until a *Lamp-lighter Action* restores balance.
 - *Bell Override:* Swap which faction’s law applies; social actions vs. boss gain +1 DV this round.
 - *White Flood Surge:* Advance environment clock; force MOVE/WRECK or be *Separated*.
- **Phase Triggers:** Environment bosses phase when *Air* hits 2/4, *Water* hits 3/6, or *Light* hits 0; Conspiracy bosses phase when *Audit* or *Permit* clocks fill.
- **Truth & Measure:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB each phase; forging one gives the boss 1 SB and a free *Expose Fraud* reaction.
- **Crowd Pressure:** In under-markets, add **Panic Crowd** [4]; each tick adds +1 DV to precise actions (shoot, pick, ritual) unless calmed with bell-code or coin.
- **Fear Hooks (optional):** *Bad Air* inflicts FEAR vs. suffocation; *Echo-King* inflicts FEAR vs. isolation; *Seal-Devil* inflicts FEAR vs. helplessness. On Fail: mark *Shaken*; on Critical Fail: drop a resource (*lamp*, *key*, *breath*).

4.13 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — “Stone, Bough, and Bright Things”

Elite (Stone Prince of Aelinnel)

“The law here flows like water over stone – it finds its own path, and woe to those who try to dam it with paper and pretense. The earth itself will testify against the unjust.”

Commoner (Charcoal-burner clan who read draught and omen by smoke)

“Our kilns tell us more than your books ever could. When the smoke curls left, the tide’s with you. When it splits in three, best stay by your own hearth till it burns straight again. And never trust a court that speaks in only one ledger.”

Stone, Bough, and Bright Things

Aelinnel homeland of Aevrossa clings to the Dolmis coast beneath the shadow of the Valewood, its halls threaded through granite and hawthorn, its roads counted by antler-posts and moonlit courtesy. Here, promises have weight and silence has meaning. *Even* steps are safe, *odd* words are careful, and truths are traded like copper nails – bright, useful, and slightly poisonous in the wrong pocket.

To the north, the Valewood looms; to the south, the downs of Amedell where the Aelaerem keep their red doors. The Green Gate sometimes opens onto halfling barrows – a fact neither people speaks of aloud.

Yet no single crown rules the gnomish lands. Dozens of courts, guilds, and seasonal pacts weave a shifting lattice of loyalty. Some Aelinnel hold fast to ancient fae treaties, speaking in two ledgers and never carrying naked iron; others barter in the Green Market with pragmatic coin, treating courtesy as a bargaining chip; still others vanish into the deep woods, listening to stag-roads and root-galleries where the Wild Hunt sometimes rides. The gnomish heart is divided – and that division is their shield against the fae.

Craft and courtesy govern every traffic between mortal keeps and the courts under the hill. Gnomish stone-singers tune bridges with a hum that keeps the Green Gate at bay; forester-wardens hammer copper where iron would draw unwanted attention. In markets under living roofs, a sentence can be cut to fit a purse, and a memory can be wrapped for travel. Paths sometimes shorten for those who keep good count, and lengthen for those who sneer at patterns. The fae are never rude – but they are never safe.

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Moonlit groves, polite iron, and the uncanny weight of a promise.
- **Key Conflict:** What is said versus what is meant; fae courtesy versus mortal bluntness.
- **Notable Threats:** Glamour fog, iron offense, geas-catch, the Green Gate yawning at the wrong hour.
- **Common Rewards:** Hazel tokens, tide-path keys, oath-beads, and the Wild Hunt’s clemency.

Prominent NPCs of Aelinnel

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Thorn	Lady of Thorns, Sovereign of the Hawthorn Court	Remind mortals that courtesy is a leash, not a gift	She never repeats herself. Her silences are verdicts.
Caelum Viridant	Green Knight, Warden of the Stag-Roads	Test the worthy and trap the careless	His armour is woven from living boughs that bleed when he lies.
Eilidh Stone-Prince	Mortal ruler of the Hall of Aelinnel	Keep the old pacts indexed and the fae at arm’s length	She speaks only in conditional tense. No one has heard a declarative sentence from her lips in seven years.
Riven	Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride	Chase down debts, oaths, and those who flee the Green Gate	His horn is carved from a fossilised scream. He only blows it when the debt is nine days old.
Tallow	Charcoal-burner (commoner exemplar)	Read the smoke and warn the village before the fae come	He has never lost a sheep to the Hollow. He has lost three helpers who did not listen.

Sable	Green-Market Broker	Trade truths for trinkets, and never lose the margin	Her receipts are written on leaf-vein paper. They curl when the bargain is unbalanced.
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Names of Aelinnel

Aelinnel names are built from soft vowels (ae, ei, ui, oi) and liquid consonants (l, r, n, m) with occasional sharp endings (-k, -t, -x). Surnames are often taken from a notable grove, a tide-mark, or an ancestor’s defining courtesy. They evoke the sound of water over stone and wind through hawthorn.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Caelum	Eilidh	Thornweave	<i>the Green-Wise</i>	
Riven	Sable	Tidespeak	<i>Two-Tongue</i>	
Tallow	Merrow	Evenstep	<i>the Unseen Guest</i>	
Fennel	Briar	Hawthorn	<i>Barrow-Kept</i>	
Osprey	Vesper	Silverbough	<i>the Uncounted</i>	
Linden	Ash	Foxtail	<i>Ash-Finger</i>	

The Three Courts: Aelinnel Alignments

Aelinnel society is not a single crown but a lattice of courts, guilds, and seasonal pacts. Three broad stances shape their dealings with outsiders and with the fae. Most gnomes shift between these postures depending on the season, the tide, and who is asking.

- **Thorn–Courteous (Fae–Lean)** – These gnomes keep the old pacts with the Lady of Thorns and the Green Knight. They speak in two ledgers, never carry naked iron, and treat every threshold as a negotiation. They are the ones who remind visitors to count their steps and pour no ninth cup. *Clocks: COURTESY DEBT [4], HAWTHORN PATIENCE [6].*
- **Market–Square (Trade–Lean)** – These gnomes prioritize the Green Market, the Under-Market, and the flow of quartz, copper, and name-script. They are pragmatic, will use iron if it is gilded, and view fae courtesies as bargaining chips rather than sacred laws. *Clocks: TARIFF DISPUTE [4], MARKET DOMINANCE [6].*
- **Forester–Trusted (Wild–Lean)** – These gnomes live among the stag-roads and root-galleries, closer to the stone-singers and the tree-wardens. They speak the old names of tides and groves, and they are the first to notice when the thorn blight spreads or the moonwell stains a name wrong. *Clocks: ROOT CALLING [4], WILD HUNT INTEREST [6].*

Most Aelinnel characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same gnome might wear a different mask when trading at the Green Market than when walking the stag-roads.

Spades — Places (stone spires, sea-rock, deep woods)

2. (Tide/Mystery) Tide-rift steps cut into black rock; limpets and old votive nails keep count for those who forget.
3. (Magic/Transformation) Moonwell basin in a granite bowl; coins turn green in a week, names in a season.
4. (Music/Stone) Dolmen stair up a ridge; each capstone rings a different interval if you tap it true.
5. (Magic/Secrecy) Charcoal coppice under witch-hazel; a neat ash-heap hides a door that opens on even knocks only.
6. (Nature/Music) Basalt organ cliffs: sea-caves breathe like slow bellows; the wind prefers prime numbers.
7. (Nature/Tradition) Stag Road – game-trail marked by antler-posts; hooves know it best, maps accept it grudgingly.
8. (Magic/Purity) Quartz spring where the sand shines like ground stars; drinkers tell the same story with better structure.
9. (Fae/Visibility) Elf-causey of pale flags through a marsh; visible at dawn and dusk and whenever someone is counting aloud.
10. (Underground/Living) Root gallery under an oak hill; lanterns hang from living bark – two lit, one listening.
- J (Death/Music) Barrow gallery with stone chimes; a cold draft from below plays scales no throat can sing.
- Q (Fae/Danger) Thorn Court ring – hawthorns trained into arches; petals fall like knife-points and settle into proofs.
- K (Civilization/Magic) Hall of Aelinnel: a timber keep threaded between standing stones; floors level themselves for guests.
- A (Otherworld/Gate) The Green Gate in a sea-arch; at certain tides it opens to a forest not on any map, and expects exact change.

Hearts — People & Factions (keepers, courts, craftsmen, hunters)

2. (Practical/Knowledge) Goat-herd of the stone edges – measures danger in hoof-widths; never wrong twice.

3. (Craft/Divination) Charcoal-burner clan who read draught and omen by smoke; their kilns hum in thirds.
 4. (Magic/Commerce) Hedge-witch with a pocket of thorns and prices stated in *un-
lesses*.
 5. (Craft/Magic) Stone-singer (quarryman) whose hum finds a seam and a secret; walls relax when they pass.
 6. (Nature/Courtesy) Forester-warden with copper nails and a polite dislike of iron; paths obey their hammer.
 7. (Nature/Tradition) Reed-net fisher who knows when the selkies listen; mends nets to lullabies in 5s and 8s.
 8. (Law/Magic) Oath-carver who sets promises in quartz so they can be seen; breaks none, bends many.
 9. (Navigation/Guidance) Way-keeper of the Stag Road; never lost, often followed, sometimes found ahead.
 10. (Commerce/Magic) Green-market broker trading truths for trinkets and back again; receipts in leaf-vein script.
- J (Fae/Authority) Green Knight – antler helm, mirror-bright blade, courtesy old as frost; keeps a tally of saved insults.
- Q (Fae/Power) Lady of Thorns, sovereign of a hawthorn court; smiles like a snare and forgives in exact measures.
- K (Authority/Magic) Stone Prince of Aelinnel, mortal crown with fae debts properly indexed and current.
- A (Hunt/Destiny) Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride; his horn turns shortcuts into roads, and debts into destinations.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (glamour, geasa, weather, neighbors)

2. (Illusion/Disorientation) Glamour fog; time drifts, footfalls don’t match, conversations arrive neatly folded.
3. (Offense/Magic) Iron offense – someone brought the wrong nails to the right grove; paths take it personally.
4. (Magic/Displacement) Root-slide pulls a trail two ridges away while you blink; your footprints stay where they were.
5. (Magic/Physics) Wrong tide at the sea-arch; boats rise where arithmetic says no and physics excuses itself.
6. (Magic/Binding) Spoken geas catches on an unlucky word; the task names itself and refuses synonyms.

7. (Commerce/Magic) Green Market price: payment demanded in names and memories; change returned in riddles.
 8. (Death/Complaint) Stone-wight stirs in a barrow; echoes hate company and file complaints as drafts.
 9. (Time/Magic) Lost day – the sun miscounts; your dawn arrives at supper and demands bread.
 10. (Nature/Curse) Thorn blight crawls across orchards; pruners bleed stories that grow where they drip.
- J (Hunt/Duty) Stag horn sounds; everyone owes the chase – especially you, especially now.
- Q (Fae/Law) Thorn Court tithe levied on the Hall; arrests wear flowers and quote etiquette.
- K (Nature/Conflict) Muster of the Bough – forest banners rise; travel becomes trespass by default.
- A (Otherworld/Logic) Green Gate yawns at the wrong hour; roads rewire across your path with excellent logic.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (charms, passes, host-rights, exceptions)

2. (Magic/Protection) Hazel token – step through a hedge uncut, once; the scratch you did not get will *remember* you kindly.
3. (Utility/Rebellion) Salt license – carry and use ward-salt where it’s discouraged; doors frown and open anyway.
4. (Magic/Authority) Dolmen carving-right – inscribe a name or claim on a speaking stone; arguments quiet while you carve.
5. (Hospitality/Fae) Guest-bough from the Thorn Court – one night’s safe table among thorns; knives behave.
6. (Magic/Access) Quarry allotment of clear quartz; subtle doors open to its bearer if asked in the right tense.
7. (Commerce/Magic) Green Market voucher – buy a truth at face value (today only); tomorrow costs interest.
8. (Magic/Binding) Oath-bead; a spoken promise warms the bead when kept, chills when not, glows if misunderstood.
9. (Travel/Magic) Tide-path key – lawful crossing of a named sea-cave at neap; the cave will wait.
10. (Nature/Permission) Forest truce – hunt, cut, or travel through a warded copse without offense; the birds file no reports.

- J (Protection/Fae) Green Knight escort from ridge to gate; watchers bow, paths part, insults lodge elsewhere.
- Q (Fae/Authority) Private audience with the Lady of Thorns; a whisper exits as policy with petals attached.
- K (Authority/Magic) Stone Prince’s seal – levies defer, foresters guide, scribes stop arguing and fetch tea.
- A (Hunt/Protection) Wild Hunt clemency – ride under the horn for one night; no hound will take you, no debt will sleep.

Quick use notes

- Draw until all four suits appear: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5→4, 6–10→6, J/Q/K→8, A→10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (charms/passes/host-rights) that *change position* rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo dark fae motifs: antlers in shadow, petals that cut, a tide that breathes, and a shortcut that insists on proper payment.

Additional Features

- **Two-Ledger Courtesy:** Once per scene, a character who states both what they *say* and what they *mean* (in or out of character) may shift *Position* one step safer on a social roll against a fae or fae-touched being. The GM may demand a small token (a copper coin, a knotted thread) as earnest.
- **Copper over Iron:** When the party visibly favours copper or brass tools over iron in fae-facing scenes, gain +1 assist die from locals (or avoid a –1 penalty) for acts of courtesy, passage, or petition. Iron is not forbidden – it is simply *impolite*, and impoliteness is remembered.
- **The Unsaid Clause:** In any bargain or promise, if the players explicitly leave one term unspoken (but agreed upon by all at the table), the GM may bank 1 SB to introduce a complication later where that omission becomes the hinge of the deal. The fae love what is not said.

Courtesies of the Green Gate

- **Never bring naked iron** past a hawthorn arch unless it is gilded or named. Copper is polite, silver is opinionated, cold iron is an accusation.
- **Always return what points the way.** Way-cords, antler-posts, chalk. Borrow the path; do not keep it. The fae count what you take.
- **Speak debts in the daylight.** Promises made under lantern-boughs are heard by leaves as well as by law. The Green Gate listens.
- **The ninth cup is never poured.** Leave it empty for the uninvited guest. If you pour it, drink it yourself – and hope the guest does not arrive.

Pattern & Paranoia

Aelinnel gnomes are known for their careful attention to pattern, sequence, and the unspoken. Some say they see the world as a set of nested rules – each interaction a move in a game where the stakes are never declared. This is not a flaw; it is a survival trait. The fae do not lie, but they mislead; they do not break promises, but they interpret them. To live beside the Green Gate, one must learn to read the fine print before the bargain is struck – and to recognise that some fine print is written in invisible ink. Outsiders often find Aelinnel courtesy exhausting. The gnomes find outsider bluntness endearing – and fatal.

Thematic SB Spend Table (Aelinnel)

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **thorn-courtiers** or **forest-wardens**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **stone-singers** or **green-market traders**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **stag-road trackers** or **oath-carvers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Green Knight** or **Lady of Thorns’ herald** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **glamour fog** or **root-slide**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **stone-wight** or **thorn blight spirit** arrives on scene.

- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional fae courtiers, forester-wardens, or stag-horn riders arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **geas triggers/green gate opens/iron offense declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Lady of Thorns, Stone Prince, or Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **tide turns/green gate yawns/thorn blight spreads**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options (Aelinnel)

- **Courtesy & Geas (1–3 SB):** A hawthorn arch closes behind you; copper tools glow with fae attention; a polite phrase becomes a binding geas. The fae have noted your manners – or your lack thereof.
- **Glamour (1–2 SB):** Conversations arrive folded and misaddressed; time drifts unexpectedly; your footfalls no longer match your steps. The Green Gate breathes.
- **The Unsaid (1–2 SB):** An omission you did not know you made becomes the price of passage. The Lady of Thorns smiles. You do not know why.

Aelinnel — Tidal Bargains

Starting Location: A tide-shed at dawn, fog curling over anchored barges, while gulls cry omens over the river’s black glass.

“In Aelinnel lands, the river speaks with many tongues, and each tide demands a name in return.”

In... a tide-shed at dawn, a gnomish reeve offers passage on a sealed barge. “The Green Gate opens at neap tide. What we trade there, the Dolmis will not name.”

Regional Motifs Tide-ledgers, river gods, sealed cargo, name-taboo.

Whispers to Offer “Peek in the crate,” “Speak the hidden name,” “Break quarantine.”

External Clocks Threat: *Green Gate Thirst* [6]; Community: *Dockside Fear* [4]; Anchor: *Barge Oath* [4].

Complications Freshwater turns brackish; the cargo sings; a rival reeve boards with knives.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s river-kin; the barge’s blessing.

Escalation Beat The Gate opens early; the tide runs backwards.

Relief Offer a river-gift; carry a name written in river-mud across the threshold; spend 2 to seal the leak for a scene.

Faction Entanglements

- **Stone–Singer Conclave:** Sponsor a bridge-chant or way-tuning and bank a *Harmonic Favor*—spend to shift *Position* one step safer on any passage across worked stone or living root. Skip their rites and the first crossing this leg gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB as paths sulk.
- **Forester–Wardens:** Accept copper-nail protocols to cancel the first *Fae Offense* SB in a wood scene. Drive iron stakes or break taboo and mark a 4-segment *Polite Apology* clock you must clear before locals assist you again.
- **Green-Market Brokers:** Submit an itemized truth (what was said / what was meant) to reduce barter DV by 1 for the scene. Try to haggle on single-ledger terms, and the market tags you with *Exact Change Only*—all bargains hereafter demand a tithe of memory or name until appeased.
- **Oath–Carvers" Guild:** Have a promise set in quartz to gain a *Visible Oath* token; spend to treat one social test as if aided by a reputable witness. Breaking a quartz-oath spawns a 4-segment *Shattered Nuance* clock that complicates future negotiations.
- **Tide–Reeves:** File a tide-plan before neap to earn a *Tide Window*—ignore one tidal timing penalty this leg. Skipping the ledger adds a free “Wrong Tide” SB the first time you touch the Dolmis.

Cross–Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Way of Silk Interface:** Kon"reh-counted caravans that adopt Aelinne step-metrics (even steps, counted halts) gain +1 die to avoid ambushes on the Way this arc. Breaking count invites a free “Glamour Fog” SB at the next way-shrine.

- **Aeler Standards (Rods & Wards):** Recognize Aeler measures publicly to reduce dispute DV by 1 with dwarven legates; insist on gnomish dual-ledger and foreign merchants grumble—first mixed-market scene gains an “Assay Doubt” SB.
- **Vhasia/Viterra Complications:** Vhasian hedge-duties (wood rites) and Viterra tithe-scripts (grain flows) cross your ledgers. When either region is “Stressed,” add +1 DV to Green-Market exports that travel their roads unless you carry a *Forest Truce* or *Tithe Waiver*.
- **Valewood Fallout:** On a *Valewood Weather* signal, fae proofs spill downslope; counting etiquette cancels the first navigation SB each scene, but any iron shown gains a free “Fae Complaint” SB (even among humans). Aelaerem hospitality rites mitigate this: presenting guest-loaf removes one such complaint per hall.

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Quartz & Proof–Stone:** Donate clear quartz to a shrine to bank a *Seen Promise*—once, treat a murky contract as if properly witnessed. Peddle clouded quartz as “ritual grade” and spawn a roaming *Counterfeit Proof* inquiry clock.
- **Copper Etiquette Kits:** Issuing copper over iron in mixed courts grants +1 assist die on petitions; flooding markets with cheap copper pins offends foresters—add a “Copper Resentment” tag that raises DV in wood jurisdictions until you make amends.
- **Name–Script & Memory Wraps:** Legal export of name-script lowers espionage DV by 1 for allies who carry it. Smuggling wraps risks a *Name-Tax*—first customs scene converts 1 SB into a compelled disclosure.
- **Tide Rights & Barge Seals:** Funding barge-seals creates a *Waiting Cave*—once per arc the cave “waits” an extra beat for your crew. Ignoring seal-maintenance flips it: first Dolmis crossing suffers “Wrong Hour” SB.

Patron Networks (Patterns & Thresholds)

- **Sacred Geometry:** Chalk a golden-mean spiral at a ford to reroll one failed prediction/trajectory check this leg; doing so in view of fae courts adds a 2-segment *Proof Envied* clock.
- **The Sealed Gate:** Hawthorn-gilded door-nails act as single-use stay writs: negate one forced entry or pursuit at a hedge-gate.
- **Lunara:** Counting under moonlight lets you ask one terse yes/no about a hidden path; on a Miss, secrets spread—mark Exposure +1 in the nearest Green Market.
- **The Traveler:** Antler-posts double as wayshrines; leave a copper and recite a sequence to finish one travel clock tick for free on forest legs.

Field Procedures (Use At the Table)

- **Two-Ledger Talk:** When parley stalls, the GM asks: “What was said? What was meant?” If players state both, cancel the first social SB this scene; if they refuse, the next bargain demands collateral (memory/name).
- **Count or Be Counted:** At any fae-touched crossing, a player who audibly counts in a fitting sequence (steps, heartbeats, breaths) shifts *Position* one step safer for that crossing. Boasting or mocking numbers adds a free “Geas Catches” SB.
- **Copper Courtesy Check:** Producing copper/brass tools in a ritual space removes the first *Fae Offense* tag this scene; drawing iron instead escalates the next Complication by +1 Cap.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Hazel Favors (minor resource):** Earned by returning way-cords, restoring antler posts, or paying tide-dues. Spend to downgrade a *Glamour* or *Geas* complication once per leg.
- **Alignment Reputation:**
 - *Thorn-Courteous:* Doors of the hawthorn courts open a step easier; human clerks distrust your clauses (first city office DV +1).
 - *Market-Square:* Brokers vouch your weights; rival stalls circulate riddled slander—add a trailing *Folded Rumor* clock.
 - *Forester-Trusted:* Paths shorten for you once per journey; port inspectors assume concealed copper—first harbor search gains a free “Alarm Raised” SB unless declared up front.

Boss Archetypes in Aelinnel

Court & Courtesy (Fae Sovereigns)

- **Lady of Thorns (Etiquette Engine):** Punishes breaches with precise harms, rewards perfect courtesy with literal boons. *Win by satisfying three courtesies in sequence (no iron, two-ledger speech, return the waymark).*
- **Green Knight (Trial by Pattern):** Duel of paths and proofs, not blades. *Win by presenting a higher-count route (Fibonacci, even-steps) or yielding a deserved apology at the right number.*

Threshold & Hunt (Environment that Judges)

- **Moonlit Ride (Wild Hunt):** Three phases—*Sounding* (horns), *Coursing* (paths shorten for the bold), *Closing the Ring*. *Win by naming safe-clemency, joining the chase without taking a prey, or blowing the right counter-call (2–3–5).*
- **Green Gate (Living Crossing):** Demands exact change in truths. *Win by paying a memory that fits the posted proof; forcing passage triggers “Roads Rewired.”*

Numbers & Glamour (Logical Anomalies)

- **Glamour Fog (Layered Illusion):** Each layer dispelled by a correct count, courtesy, or copper rite. *Win by completing the Three Proofs: count aloud, return a borrowed path token, trade a said/meant receipt.*
- **Lost Day (Time Miscount):** The sun misnumbers hours. *Win by reconciling two ledgers (what happened / what should have), then ringing a prime-number chime.*

Market & Oath (Contract Tricksters)

- **Green-Market Broker (Truth Arbitrage):** Buys your meanings, sells your words. *Win by catching them in a one-ledger statement or producing an Oath-Bead that chills (misunderstood clause).*
- **Oath-Carver Gone Wrong (Quartz Tyrant):** Binds towns with over-precise promises. *Win by carving a Release Unless into communal quartz at cost of a public truth.*

Stone & Memory (Ancestral Hazards)

- **Stone-Wight Chorus (Echo Jurors):** Resent footsteps, adore proofs. *Win by tapping the dolmen scale that matches the grievance and returning a taken token to the barrow.*

Boss Mechanics (Use 2–3 levers)

- **Courtesy Track [4]:** Each breach (iron bared, skipping greetings, single-ledger lie) ticks it. On fill, boss gains *Polite Punishment*: escalate DV +1 and impose a Geas.
- **Counting Proofs (three steps):** Name a pattern, perform it, return a waymark. Completing all three lowers boss tier for one exchange or ends a phase.
- **Said/Meant Ledgers:** Any bargain scene runs two mini-clocks; if *Said* fills first, glamour favors the boss; if *Meant* fills first, PCs gain a *Visible Oath* token.
- **Iron Offense Meter [0–3]:** Showing iron, striking hawthorn, or salting impolitely raises it. At 3, fae gain a free “Thorn Blight” SB; reduce by copper rites or gifts.
- **Hunt Phases:** *Sounding* (fear checks; pass to gain +1 die to pace), *Coursing* (paths shorten for counted strides), *Closing* (only truth-payment or clemency halts the circle).
- **Lair Actions (pick two):** *Fold the Conversation* (re-target a statement); *Shift the Count* (odd ↔ even penalties); *Petal Cut* (apply 1 Harm unless copper shown); *Wrong Tide* (swap entry/exit costs at a gate).

4.14 Black Banners — “Condotta & Crowns”

Banner-Captain (Elite): “A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it. In this game, we sell steel by the season and vendettas by the year.”

Veteran Sergeant (Commoner): “I’ve seen three captains rise and fall in the time it takes to grow a beard, but the mud stays the same and the pay comes when it pleases. Best keep your own counsel and your blade sharp. The camp sings? You live. They stop singing? Even the best charter bleeds.”

Condotta & Crowns

Ecktorian treasuries bankroll a perpetual border-war they claim to be *contain-ing*. In truth, the gold keeps the fire burning. The Black Banners are mercenary leagues—ex-Utaran legionaries, second-sons, debt-dodgers, and exiles—who sell steel to the highest bidder, today’s ally becoming tomorrow’s quarry. Between them move the Ykrul steppe-clans (swift, pragmatic, oath-canny) and the Vilikari hill tribes (crafty, patient, and proud). Ecktorian ministers call it “pressure man-agement.” The companies call it a season.

What you notice first: The smell of wet wool and old blood. The way every tent has a ledger pinned to its flap. The silence when the paychest is opened—and the murmur when it’s light.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never break a Bell Dawn. Three bells at sunrise means bury the dead, trade prisoners, fix the wells, no ambushes. Violating it is how legends end badly—and how captains end hanging.

Regional Mood: The Theater of Banners

Here, war is a marketplace. The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling league of freelance violence, bound by camp law, pay customs, and the shared knowl-edge that tomorrow’s enemy might be today’s employer. The real battles are fought in counting-tents over clauses and riders; the clash outside is just the audit. Loyalty is a coin that fluctuates with the market, and a captain’s true skill lies in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honor codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one—always at dawn, with a witness, and with surety paid.

Starting Location: A war-camp crossroads where two banners snap in the same wind, their sigils bleeding into one another. A Condotta broker with ink-stained fingers lays two contracts on a barrel—one from Ecktoria, one from Ykrul. “Pick a war. Pick a grave. The bell tolls at noon.”

Prominent NPCs of the Black Banners

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Castellan Thorne	Banner-Captain of the Iron Hand	Win a permanent contract for his company	He has never lost a siege, but he has lost three paychests to bad debt.
Old Sorka	Veteran Sergeant (commoner exemplar)	Keep her squad alive until spring	She counts scars like coins; her left ear is a nub from a mutineer’s apology.
Lys	Condotta Broker	Flip contracts for maximum margin	Her ink has a metallic smell. She says it’s from the silver in the seals.
Chaghan	Ykrul Clan Emissary	Test the Black Banners’ honour before the next migration	He speaks only in proverbs and pays in copper from a cursed mine.
Volund	Quartermaster-Provost	Stockpile leverage on every officer in the camp	His bribe book is thicker than his roster; he calls it “risk assessment.”
The Bannerless One	Mysterious warlord	Unite the scattered companies under a single will	She has no flag. Men follow her because she asked.

Names of the Black Banners

Names here are a polyglot stew – Acasian grit, Ecktorian formality, Ykrul harshness, Vilikari cadence, and the nicknames that arise from a season in the mud. Surnames may be patronymic, a place of origin, or a battlefield epithet.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Castellan		Sorka	Thornson	<i>the Iron</i>
Chaghan		Lys	Volund	<i>the Red-Tally</i>

Orthen	Maeva	Kaeldottir	<i>Bell-Breaker</i>
Rurik	Veleda	dei Conti	<i>the Unpaid</i>
Bromm	Gisela	Halvkirk	<i>White-Ribbon</i>
Zelgur	Thorn	Flint	<i>Ash-Foot</i>

(Camps/Battlefields/Fortresses/War-roads) Burned village turned field-hospital; flies, tinctures, and fever-prayers. Frozen ford with last month’s dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice.

Spades — Places

2. **Burned Village** — Field-hospital; flies, tinctures, fever-prayers. *The flies are fat. They’ve eaten well this season.*
 3. **Frozen Ford** — Last month’s dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice. *The ice is clear—clear enough to read the terror on their faces.*
 4. **Latrine Row** — At dusk; mud, shame, whispered mutiny, a sergeant who hears too well. *The sergeant’s ears are scarred. He listened to a mutiny once and survived.*
 5. **Crater Pasture** — From an alchemical barrage; in spring, glass flowers sprout like guilt. *The flowers cut. They remember the hands that sowed them.*
 6. **Supply Road** — Twelve broken wagons; oxen nose the wreckage for salt. *The salt is from a burned caravan. The oxen are from the same village.*
 7. **Half-Raised Siege Tower** — In an abandoned camp; every rung creaks with grudges. *The tower was paid for twice. It still leans toward the richer patron.*
 8. **Salt-Cured Cache** — Behind the surgeon’s tent; the wrong kind of maggots move. *The maggots have a pattern. It spells a name—yours, or the surgeon’s.*
 9. **Command Tent** — Maps show borders that diplomacy has already erased. *The maps were drawn by a clerk who died last winter. He was still updating them.*
 10. **Watch-Tower** — Stacked from skulls and slate; the crows know the countersign. *The crows are paid in eyes. They are very well paid.*
- J **Ancient March-Keep** — Held by a skeleton garrison of veterans; they remember when the banners were gold. *The veterans are dead. They just haven’t noticed yet.*
- Q **The Bone Fields** — Where Ykrul elders parley among cairns and reckon oaths with the dead. *The dead vote. Their votes are always for war.*
- K **Marcher’s Fortress** — Three walls, two sieges’ scars, one gate that opens inward only. *The gate opens inward so the dead can leave. The living are not invited.*
- A **The Singing Wastes** — Fallen weapons hum with the voices of their last wielders on a wind that tastes of iron. *The hum is a petition. The dead want their names back.*

(**Captains/Cadets/Clans/Tribes**) Young cadet with a father’s sword and a mother’s debt; veteran sergeant who counts scars like coins—and spends them on whiskey and mercy.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Young Cadet** — Father’s sword, mother’s debt, and a hunger to prove himself.
The sword is old. The debt is older. Both weigh the same.
3. **Veteran Sergeant** — Counts scars like coins—spends them on whiskey and mercy.
His left ear is gone. He says a mutineer took it. He says the mutineer apologized.
4. **Ecktorian Banner-Captain** — Griffon standard, a ledger of noble grudges, and a smile like a winter. *The griffon’s eyes are rubies. They were looted from a temple. The god still watches.*
5. **Condotta Broker** — Changes colors when the wind turns, but always lands on his feet. *His feet are calloused from landing. He has never broken an ankle.*
6. **Ykrul Clan Emissary** — Speaks in riddled proverbs and pays in copper and promises. *The copper is from a cursed mine. The promises are from a cursed tongue.*
7. **Vilikari War-Chief’s Second Son** — Honor burns brighter than his father’s patience. *His father’s patience is measured in seasons. This is the last season.*
8. **Surgeon of the Red Ledger** — Treats friend and foe alike; her ledger balances only in blood. *Her ledger is bound in human skin. The skin was a gift from a patient who lived.*
9. **Quartermaster** — Knows where every coin went and every man will fall. *His bribe book is thicker than his roster. He calls it “risk assessment.”*
10. **Tribune’s Aide-de-Camp** — Sealed orders that contradict the general’s intent. *The general’s intent was to retire. The seals say otherwise.*
- J **The Black Colonel** — Legendary commander not seen in the line for months, yet his banner still rides. *The banner rides alone. The horse is riderless. The men follow anyway.*
- Q **Ykrul Clan-Mother** — Weaves war-braids from the hair of oath-breakers. *Each braid has a name. The names are still attached.*
- K **Vilikari High Chief** — Trades mercenaries like game pieces and never tips the board. *The board is an old treaty map. The pieces are real.*
- A **The Bannerless One** — Commands loyalty without rank or flag; men follow because they want to. *They follow into the Singing Wastes. They follow into the ice. They follow because she asked.*

(Betrayals/Weather/Politics/War) Payday delayed; supplies die before coin arrives. False orders: your target is now your ally—on paper. Blizzard pins two rival companies in the same cloister; vows and knives both come out.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Payday Delayed** — Supplies die before coin arrives. *The coin was eaten by interest. The interest has teeth.*
 3. **False Orders** — Your target is now your ally—on paper. *The paper is from a dead notary. The signature is warm.*
 4. **Blizzard Pins** — Two rival companies, one cloister; vows and knives both come out. *The cloister’s abbot is counting. He will sell the winner’s story.*
 5. **Ykrul Counter-Offer** — Better terms than Ecktoria; your contract becomes a liability. *The terms are written in salt. They will dissolve in rain—or blood.*
 6. **Condotta Flip** — Unit switches colors mid-battle; your “relief” hits your flank. *The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted a raise.*
 7. **Camp-Fever** — Blooms in the surgeon’s tent; the counting-house for the dead. *The fever has a face. It is the face of a soldier you left behind.*
 8. **Vilikari Raid** — Cuts your supply road; winter moves the schedule. *The raiders took the salt and left a recipe. The recipe calls for tears.*
 9. **Honor Code Collision** — Ecktorian ideals vs. mercenary pragmatism; the camp splits by doctrine. *The doctrine is written on a napkin. The napkin is from a feast that ended badly.*
 10. **Tribune Captured** — The aide must choose: the rescue or the war. *The war is a ledger. The rescue is a name. Names are heavier than ledgers.*
- J **Black Colonel’s Banner** — Appears on the wrong field; confusion is a weapon. *The banner is frayed. It has seen too many wrong fields.*
- Q **Blood-Feast** — Clan-Mother calls it; all contracts suspended until dawn’s judgment. *The judgment is a feast. The feast is a trial. The trial is a knife.*
- K **High Chief’s Game** — Plays companies against each other; “winner” takes obligations, not spoils. *The obligations are written in invisible ink. You will see them when it is too late.*
- A **The Singing Wastes Awaken** — Every fallen blade rises to seek its last hand. *The blades remember the grip. They do not remember mercy.*

(Contracts/Claims/Dispensations) Emergency requisition—strip a fallen company for what you need (and their ghosts for what they’re owed). Dual contract—serve two masters with goals that cannot both be met.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Emergency Requisition** — Strip a fallen company; their ghosts watch. *The ghosts will remember. They will collect.*
3. **Dual Contract** — Serve two masters whose goals cannot both be met. *The masters are both paying. The interest is your reputation.*
4. **Honor Dispensation** — Your acts are justified regardless of code (for now). *The dispensation is a bell. Ring it, and the tribunal looks away—once.*
5. **Condotta Rider’s Pass** — Cross any camp perimeter unchallenged. *The pass is a feather. The feather is from a messenger who arrived too late.*
6. **Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token** — Pass a named clan’s lands unmolested (until the moon changes). *The token is a horse’s tooth. The horse was a gift from a Khagan. The Khagan is dead.*
7. **Vilikari War-Mark** — Their scouts guide you through hostile hills—and remember the favor. *The favor will be called at dawn. The location will be a ridge. The odds will be even.*
8. **Surgeon’s Debt-Note** — Medical care when no coin remains; the interest is names. *The names are of people who owe the surgeon. You are now one of them.*
9. **Tribune’s Cipher Ring** — Decode orders that do not exist yet. *The ring is warm. The future is cold.*
10. **Banner-Captain’s Seal** — Commandeer resources from junior companies (and their resentment). *The seal is a skull. The jaw moves when you press it.*
- J **Field Promotion Warrant** — Assume command of a shattered unit, inherit its clocks. *The clocks are ticking. The unit is watching.*
- Q **Clan-Mother’s War-Braids** — Her chosen fight beside you this battle, then judge you after. *The judgment is a song. The song will be sung at your funeral.*
- K **High Chief’s Trading Charter** — Buy or sell *anything* in any camp, no questions asked aloud. *The questions are asked in silence. The answers are paid in silence.*
- A **The Bannerless Word** — Loyalty that outruns rank, law, and coin. *The word is a whisper. The whisper is a promise. The promise is a grave.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (contracts/claims/dispensations) that shift position rather than call for a roll.
- If any Ace appears, echo war and winter motifs—ice that keeps the dead, weapons that remember, loyalty that needs no banner.

The Fractured League: Banner Alignments

The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling market of violence. Three loose alignments shape the loyalties of any war-camp. Most companies shift between these poles depending on the season, the paychest, and the weather.

- **Condotta Brokers (The Paper Men)** – They own the contracts, not the swords. They flip companies like playing cards and measure victory in percentages. Most captains hate them, but everyone pays them. *Clocks: BROKER’S GRIP [4], DOUBLE CHARTER [6]*.
- **Company Loyalists (The Old Banners)** – Veterans who remember when a banner meant a blood-oath, not a season’s wage. They grumble, they desert, they are sometimes bought – but they fight like demons when the paychest is full. *Clocks: VETERAN WRATH [4], OATH REMEMBERS [6]*.
- **Free Companies (The Tide)** – Newly raised, culturally mixed, and chronically unpaid. They are as likely to mutiny as to charge, and their loyalty can be bought with a hot meal and a day’s rest. *Clocks: MUTINY WHISPER [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6]*.

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul steppe-clans** (honour-bound, quick to take insult) and the **Vilikari hill tribes** (pragmatic, patient, and skilled at ambush). A wise captain learns to read all three.

Additional Features

- **Payday & Supply Clocks:** Track two pressures common to the Black Banners: **Payday** [4] and **Supply** [4]. When Payday fills, morale falters and the Keeper may peel away a squad or impose a desertion SB. When Supply fills, all risky maneuvers begin one step worse Position until the players secure fresh provisions or bargain a Diamond.
- **Allegiances in Flux:** At the start of a scene, roll 1d6 to see if loyalties shift:
 1. Condotta broker flips colors mid-parley.
 2. Ykrul emissary offers better terms; accept and mark Obligation, or refuse and tick Payday.
 3. Vilikari scouts reveal a shortcut; gain +1 Effect but risk SB from hostile terrain.
 4. Ecktorian clerk “corrects” your orders; obey for +1 Position, defy and gain a Diamond but earn a Black Mark.
 5. Rival captain spreads falsified orders; unless revealed, counters are harder this scene.
 6. The Bannerless One’s messengers arrive; accept their word to clear 1 Payday, but the Keeper gains 1 SB.
- **Honor vs. Pragmatism Dial:** Place a two-step dial between *Honor* and *Pragmatism*.
 - **Honor:** +1 Position in parley or oathbound actions; logistics costs rise faster.

- **Pragmatism:** +1 Effect in ambushes or sabotage; parley begins one step worse Position.

Center the dial by a symbolic act—repaying arrears, returning prisoners, or honoring a broken writ.

Mercenary Realpolitik

In the world of the Black Banners, loyalty is a currency that fluctuates with the market. A man’s worth is measured not in noble blood or ancestral holdings, but in the sharpness of his blade and the reliability of his word. The condotta system creates a web of shifting allegiances where today’s enemy may become tomorrow’s employer, and a captain’s true skill lies not in strategy alone but in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honor codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Deserters who flee a losing battle sometimes cross into the Singing Wastes at night. They return at dawn with their mouths sewn shut and a ward-sigil branded on their palms. The Bannerless One pays well for such men — they cannot speak of what they saw, and they never run again.
- **Maelstraeus, the Infernal Bargainer:** A black ledger circulates among the condotta brokers, its pages written in dried blood. A captain who signs it never misses a payday — but the ledger’s interest is collected in souls, not silver. The Bannerless One has refused to touch it. Twice.
- **The Traveler:** Before every major march, a White-Ribbon courier from the Aeler tunnels appears at the edge of camp, plants a brass way-stone, and vanishes by dawn. Companies who follow the stone’s direction find safe passage through the worst terrain. Those who ignore it are never seen again.
- **Khak’Thul, the Thunder-Speaker:** A drummer walks the camp on the night before a battle, beating a rhythm that has no source. Veterans do not look for the drummer; they sleep with their hands over their ears. When the drum stops, the battle begins — and one side will be annihilated by a storm that came from nowhere.
- **The Ninth:** In any war-camp, the ninth tent pitched in a row will collapse before dawn. The wise pitch eight and leave a space. Those who ignore this find that the ground beneath the ninth tent is always damp — and the footprints leading out of it never match any boot in the company.

Black Banner Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Paychest:** Crumble a crust into an empty chest. Ignore the first *Payday Delayed* penalty.

- **Knot the Colors:** Tie a single knot in a banner’s cord. Cancel *Condotta Flip* or take −1 die on your next morale check (your choice).
- **Name to the Wastes:** Whisper a dead captain’s name into the wind. Gain +1 Effect when rallying their former unit this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bannerless One.

Boss Archetypes in the Black Banners

Contract & Command (Human Adversaries)

- **Banner-Captain (Fixer General)** — Wins by paperwork and parade-ground precision. *Break their chain-of-command clock [6] by flipping lieutenants, forging orders, or seizing the paychest.*
- **Condotta Broker (Color-Flipper)** — Turns loyalties like cards. *Expose a dual contract or force public arbitration under neutral bells to collapse their leverage track.*
- **Quartermaster-Provost (Logistics Tyrant)** — Starves you with ledgers. *Complete the Three Cuts: road, ration, rumor—any two stalls them; all three topple their supply engine.*

Tribe & Tactic (Field Sovereigns)

- **Ykrul Raid-Mother (Oath-Weaver)** — Fights with remounts and safe-hostages. *Honor horse-rites to gain truce windows; break one braid in parley to end a phase.*
- **Vilikari Hill-Fox (Ambush Architect)** — Owns ridgelines and feint paths. *Clear Three High Stones (overwatch, supply cache, signal cairn) to force even ground.*

Faith & Fear (Camp Powers)

- **Field Chaplain-Inquisitor (Morale Engine)** — Smelts guilt into zeal. *Win by sanctifying plague-ground or redeeming prisoners; each rite drops their Zeal track [0–3].*
- **Surgeon of the Red Ledger (Mercy’s Price)** — Keeps units marching past sense. *Expose graft or pay blood-debts; on three reconciled names the operating tent stands down.*

The Unquiet Field (Supernatural Front)

- **The Singing Wastes (Weapon-Host)** — The battlefield itself retaliates. *Complete the Silencing Acts: oil the choir (funeral honors), bury the standards, ring the wind-break bell—each lowers its Tier for one exchange.*
- **Black Colonel’s Banner (Legend in Motion)** — A rumor that commands. *Prove the lie or become the truth: either unmask the courier network (three ciphers cracked) or fly a counter-sigil to pull rank on the myth.*

Faction Entanglements

- **Condotta Brokers" Syndicate:** Register your charter and bank a *Broker's Favor* – spend to reduce one parley DV inside a war-camp. Skipping registration flags your unit with *Unauthorized Colors*: the first checkpoint scene gains a free “False Orders” SB.
- **Camp Quartermasters:** Accept ration-scale audits to cancel the first *Supply* tick this leg; refuse and mark a 4-segment *Short Rations* clock that worsens Position on marches.
- **Field Chaplains & Leech-Circles:** Donate time or tithe to clear 1 segment from *Camp-Fever*; if ignored, the Keeper may convert the first 1 SB of a scene into “Disease/Death.”
- **Steppe Envoys:** Honor horse-rites (salt, water, shade) to gain *Remount Rights* – once, treat a retreat as movement with +1 Effect. Break rites and add a *Soured Oath* tag that raises parley DV with riders until cleansed.
- **Hill Truce-Holders:** Enter a stones-circle under their witness to bank a *Blood-Truce* – spend to negate one ambush on hill roads. Violating the circle spawns a 4-segment *Guest Right Forfeit* clock.

Field Procedures (Use at the Table)

- **Colors & Countersigns:** Declaring correct countersigns cancels the first “False Orders” SB each night; wrong signs worsen Position on first contact.
- **Payline Drill:** If a scene depicts orderly pay, clear 1 *Payday*. If pay is “creative,” clear it but mark *Black Mark* – future officers begin one step colder in parley.
- **Scavenge Doctrine:** After battles, you may gain 1 temporary Gear tag or advance *Supply* by 1; on a 1–2 on 1d6, spawn “Honor vs. Pragmatism” conflict immediately.

4.15 Dungeon — “Living Infrastructure”

Elite (Dungeon’s Creator)

“I built more than walls and corridors – I crafted a living symphony of stone and shadow, where every passage breathes and every chamber remembers. The structure itself is the true inhabitant.”

Commoner (Scholar-Prisoner)

“The walls here got a memory like old parchment – they remember every scream, every spell, every drop of blood spilled on the stones. And sometimes, when the air’s just right, they whisper it back to you. The dungeon listens. The question is whether it learns.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with mechanical lungs and dream electric dreams. Dungeons are not merely ruins but living systems—vascular networks of stone and shadow where every corridor hums with purpose and every chamber holds its own hungry logic. The walls remember every footfall, the air carries whispers of forgotten conversations, and the very architecture shifts like a sleeper turning in bed. Here, the boundary between structure and organism blurs, and those who would plunder its secrets must first learn to speak its language of echoes, scents, and subtle pressures.

What you notice first: The wet stone smell of a place that sweats. The distant grinding of gears that should have seized centuries ago. The way your footsteps echo back with an extra beat—like someone is following, or catching up.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ignore a door that opens when you’re not looking. The dungeon is offering you a choice. Refuse, and the next door may not open at all.

The Living Hierarchy: Factions of the Deep

Dungeons are not empty. They host a fragile ecology of factions, each with its own relationship to the site’s “consciousness.” A site’s dominant faction determines its mood; a dungeon ruled by *Custodians* may be melancholic and negotiable, while one overrun by *Awakened Organs* is actively predatory.

- **Custodians (Forgotten Caretakers)** – The original stewards, now half-mad or ghostly. They maintain the dungeon’s rhythms (polishing thresholds, oiling traps) and may trade safe passage for a memory or a promise. *Clocks: CUSTODIAN PATIENCE [4], MAINTENANCE ROUNDS [6].*
- **Invaders (Plunderers & Refugees)** – Living interlopers: mercenary remnants, cult initiates, refugee families. They exploit the dungeon’s resources while trying to avoid its attention. Their presence raises *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)*. *Clocks: INVADER DESPERATION [4], RIVAL CLAIM [6].*
- **Awakened Organs (The Dungeon’s Will)** – Manifestations of the site’s internal systems: the *Heart Chamber*, the *Digestive Array*, the *Ledger Lich*. They act as immune

responses or as twisted echoes of the original purpose. *Clocks: ORGAN HUNGER [4], SYSTEM REBOOT [6].*

- **Wild Symbiotes (Echoes & Aberrations)** – Creatures that evolved within the living infrastructure: stone-wights, memory eels, gravity ticks. They are neither friendly nor hostile – they simply follow the dungeon’s new rules. *Clocks: SWARM TIDE [4], SYMBIOTIC ACCORD [6].*

Most expedition sites will feature two or three of these factions in uneasy balance. A dungeon with predatory *Awakened Organs* and desperate *Invaders* is a very different crawl than one haunted by melancholic *Custodians* and curious *Wild Symbiotes*.

Spades — Places

2. **Cracked Gallery** — Hairline faults veined with damp; grit ticks from the ceiling like a slow clock. *The ticking is a language. It is counting the number of intruders.*
 3. **Sunken Vestibule** — Waist-deep water glazed with oil rainbows; cold leeches the knees, something brushes past. *The water has a pulse. It is not yours.*
 4. **Vaulted Refectory** — Tables laid for a meal gone to dust; goblets taste faintly of iron when breathed upon. *The iron is blood—old, dried, and patient.*
 5. **Spiral Stairwell** — Steps cupped by centuries; one cough ricochets down into a throat not your own. *The throat is the dungeon’s. The cough is an answer.*
 6. **Collapsed Observatory** — Stars stare through ribs of broken dome; wind brings ash that smears like soot. *The stars are not real. The dungeon remembers the sky and shows it wrong.*
 7. **Armory Alcove** — Weapon shadows longer than the racks; a glass-front case fogs from the inside. *The fog has a shape. The shape is a hand.*
 8. **Chained Sanctuary** — Prayer-niches and iron hooks; stone bruised where something strained to leave. *The chains are warm. Something wore them recently.*
 9. **Mirror Hall** — Reflections lag by a heartbeat; one pane shows you older, another shows you missing. *The missing reflection is ahead of you. It will wait.*
 10. **Garden of Stone** — Statues mid-breath; a chisel-mark still weeps dust as if freshly struck. *The dust is from the statues. They are not statues. They are frozen.*
- J **Throne of Echoes** — A single block worn satin-smooth; sit and your name returns in a stranger’s verdict. *The verdict is from a trial you never attended. The jury is the dungeon.*
- Q **Vault of Whispers** — Books exhale when opened; vowels crawl up the spine and into the ear. *The books are not books. They are memory. They eat yours to grow.*
- K **Chamber of Seasons** — Air flips from pollen-sweet to knife-cold; breath ghosts, sweat beads, leaves skitter. *The seasons are the dungeon’s moods. Today it is spring. Tomorrow, winter without end.*

- A **The Heart Chamber** — Mortar smells like blood, light like fever; floor hums to your pulse then sets its own. *The pulse is not your own after the third beat.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Forgotten Custodian** — Keys like teeth on a ring; polishes thresholds no one crosses. *He has forgotten why he polishes. The threshold remembers.*
 3. **Scholar-Prisoner** — Ink-stained nails, hollow cheeks; knows which lies the walls prefer. *The walls prefer lies that are almost true. She tells them often.*
 4. **Symbiotic Colony** — Many mouths, one hunger; bargains in warmth, hoards salt. *The mouths whisper in chorus. Their voices are the dungeon’s breath.*
 5. **Cursed Noble** — Velvet rotted to lace; voice drags like chain, eyes beg for ending. *The curse is the dungeon’s favor. He has worn it too long.*
 6. **Mercenary Remnant** — Dried mud, wet fear; map carved into forearm with a dinner knife. *The map is accurate—for now. The dungeon moves while he sleeps.*
 7. **Bound Guardian** — Filigree of wards across stone skin; obeys the letter, hears the spirit. *The spirit is the dungeon’s. The letter is a suggestion.*
 8. **Cult Initiate** — Pupil-widened zeal; speaks passwords like prayers, prayers like debts. *The debt is to a god that does not answer. The dungeon answers instead.*
 9. **Refugee Family** — Boot-scrapes under cots; clutch charms that grow warm when danger nears. *The charms are stones from the garden. The statues are their ancestors.*
 10. **Merchant of Curiosities** — Breath like cloves and rust; sells certainty bottled and slightly used. *The certainty is a lie. The bottle is genuine.*
- J **Ascended Vermin** — Crown of wire, court of nests; taxes crumbs, enforces with a thousand eyes. *The eyes are not all vermin. Some are the dungeon’s.*
- Q **Fallen Hero’s Shade** — Armor of frost, sword of grievance; wants one last right choice. *The right choice is the one that frees her. The dungeon disagrees.*
- K **Dungeon’s Creator** — Architect’s hands cracked with mortar; still moving rooms the way others move chess. *He does not remember the Heart Chamber. The Heart Chamber remembers him.*
- A **The Collective Consciousness** — Voices braided into one intention; your thoughts return carrying fingerprints. *The fingerprints are yours. The thoughts are the dungeon’s.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Shifting Walls** — Mortar pops like knuckles; corridors narrow behind you with polite insistence. *The insistence is the dungeon’s. It wants you to stay.*

3. **Hungering Dark** — Wicks gutter blue; shadows lip the flame and swallow the heat first. *The dark has weight. It leans.*
4. **Memory Fog** — Cool on the gums, sweet on the tongue; you "recall" a door that never was. *The door is real. The memory is the dungeon's.*
5. **Gravity Wells** — Knees turn to iron; dropped coins smack floor like thrown knives. *The coins are the dungeon's now. It will spend them later.*
6. **Temporal Echoes** — Footfalls not yours keep pace; a conversation repeats with one word wrong. *The wrong word is a clue. The clue is a trap.*
7. **Corrosive Atmosphere** — Leather slimes, metal freckles; breathe shallow or taste copper. *The copper is blood. The blood is the dungeon's offering.*
8. **Phantom Locks** — Doors exist when watched sidelong; they prefer particular hands and hours. *The hands are yours. The hours are the dungeon's.*
9. **Borrowed Time** — Hair whitens at the tips; hunger leaps ahead of the clock. *The time will be returned. The interest is your memory.*
10. **Infectious Transformation** — Fingertips grain to stone, pupils catch light like a cat's; urges shift. *The urge is to stay. The garden needs new statues.*
- J **Reality Anchor Points** — Candles burn sideways, water beads uphill; spells itch in the teeth. *The itch is the dungeon laughing.*
- Q **The Dungeon's Will** — Maps argue with themselves; paths rephrase your intentions. *The path is the dungeon's intention. Your intention is a suggestion.*
- K **Cascading Failure** — A cracked lintel sighs and the far cistern answers; systems talk in groans. *The groans are a warning. The warning is too late.*
- A **The Price of Passage** — Each shortcut salts your tongue with loss; the house keeps its ledger. *The ledger is the dungeon's. The loss is yours.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Wayfinder Compass** — Needle twitches toward safety like a frightened animal; steadies if you hum. *The humming must be in tune with the dungeon's breath. The breath changes.*
3. **Key of Echoes** — Warms in the palm when a door remembers being opened. *The door's memory is not yours. It remembers a different key.*
4. **Lantern of Clarity** — Light outlines hollows in the world; truths show up as clean edges. *The truths are sharp. They cut if you look too long.*
5. **Cloak of Passage** — Hem sips through stone or mist; leaves damp prints on the far side. *The prints are the dungeon's. It will follow.*

6. **Tome of Convenient Knowledge** — Pages grow new margins; ink creeps to answer the question you’re afraid to ask. *The answer is a lie. The lie is useful.*
 7. **Ration of Sustenance** — Bread that tastes like last winter; settles the stomach, quiets the shakes. *Last winter was in the dungeon. The bread was grown in the garden.*
 8. **Focus Crystal** — Thrum matches your breath; thoughts align the way teeth fit. *The breath is the dungeon’s after the third inhale.*
 9. **Token of Safe Return** — Thread around a wrist; tugs once when it’s time to flee. *The tug is the dungeon’s mercy. It does not offer twice.*
 10. **Map that Grows** — Charcoal blooms corridors as you walk; tiny figures drift where things currently are. *The figures are the dungeon’s. They are not always accurate.*
- J **Shield of Temporary Immunity** — Hazards strike sparks and spend themselves like rain on slate. *The immunity is borrowed. The dungeon will ask for it back.*
- Q **Crown of Momentary Authority** — Creatures blink, recognize a crest they cannot name, and obey. *The crest is the dungeon’s. The obedience is a misunderstanding.*
- K **Forge of Quick Repair** — Heat like a heartbeat; fractured gear exhales and remembers its shape. *The memory is the dungeon’s. The gear will remember you, too.*
- A **The Dungeon’s Blessing** — A knack that lingers in the bones; doors like you now, as do certain hungers. *The hungers are the dungeon’s appetites. They like you very much.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (safeties/knowledge/immunities) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **living infrastructure**—walls shift, voices repeat your plans, light returns redder.

Additional Features

- **Living Infrastructure:** Fluids, heat, dust, and sound move like blood—follow the drafts, the drips, the echoes to find organs: cisterns, chimneys, nerve-halls.
- **Scent Ledger:** Track smells (ozone, wet lime, tallow, old wine); they foretell hazards and factions before you see them.

- **Echo Etiquette:** Some rooms reward whispers and punish shouts; others demand a spoken price to cross. Listen first.

Patronage & Power

The true dungeon is not a place but a process—a slow alchemy that transforms intruders into something the structure can understand or consume. Every chamber is a test, every corridor a negotiation, and every inhabitant a symptom of the site’s deeper hungers. The wise explorer learns to read the dungeon’s moods in the way light falls, the way echoes return, and the way the very air seems to lean toward certain passages. Here, knowledge is not power but currency, and the smart adventurer knows when to pay with memory, when to pay with blood, and when to simply walk away.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **dungeon dwellers or factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **creatures or echoes**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or resources**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **The dungeon’s will** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **shifting architecture**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **minor entity or faction member** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **dungeon entities or guardians** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **trap springs/route blocked/ally turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.

- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: The Dungeon’s Creator or Collective Consciousness** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **walls shift/floor collapses/air thickens**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Living Infrastructure (1–2 SB):** Corridors whisper your name, reflections blink slower, scent trails loop back.
- **Echo Etiquette (1–3 SB):** Shouts echo thrice, silence answers back, doors ask riddles.
- **Cascading Failure (1–2 SB):** One crack becomes many, water flows uphill, lights dim in sequence.

Dungeon — Living Infrastructure

Starting Location: A spiral stairwell deep beneath a forgotten citadel, pulsing with a heartbeat not entirely mechanical.

"In the Dungeon, walls breathe, corridors shift, and memory is the only map worth keeping."

In... a spiral stairwell, the steps hum underfoot. A Forgotten Custodian keys a door that wasn’t there yesterday. "The Heart Chamber hungers," they whisper. "Will you feed it—or be fed?"

Regional Motifs Maintenance spirits, adaptive stone, ritual vents, memory valves.

Whispers to Offer "Take the shortcut that erases you," "Trade blood for passage," "Leave a companion behind as toll."

External Clocks Threat: *Heart Pressure Rises [6]*; Fracture: *Floorplan Loops [4]*; Anchor: *Safe Route Fails [4]*.

Complications Corridors swap; keys rust to teeth; the Custodian forgets who asked.

Anchors at Risk Camp cache; a mapping apprentice.

Escalation Beat The stairwell adds a step every circuit.

Relief Vent the Heart with a true name; feed it a secret belonging to all PCs (reduces Threat by one).

Plug-in Expedition Layer

- **Universal Clocks (drop into any site):**

- *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)* [10]: rises on loud actions, light spillage, blood, or haste. At 4/7/10, the Keeper may promote Clubs results one step.
- *Structure Stress* [6/8]: ticks on blasts, overloading mechanisms, or ignored warnings; when full, trigger *Cascading Failure*.
- *Expedition Supply*: three pooled tracks—*Light* [4], *Air* [4] (if sealed), *Load* [4] (fatigue/overburden). Each empty track worsens Position for relevant actions until refreshed.

- **Safe Route Tokens:** On a strong success mapping/scouting, issue a *Safe Route* token. Spend to bypass one known hazard in that segment or to negate a single "Position Lost" SB.

- **Retreat & Seal:** When withdrawing, a PC may *seal the way* (chalk, wedges, wards). Clear 1 Heat, but tick *Structure Stress* or spawn a *Phantom Lock* in that lane.

Interfaces & Entanglements (use what fits your campaign)

- **Surface Stakeholders:** *Scavenger Union, Shrinekeepers, Civic Factors*. Register finds to bank a *Finder's Favor*—spend to reduce one sell-off DV; skipping registration adds a "Disputed Claim" tag to the haul.

- **Internal Politics:** *Custodians, Bound Guardians, Refugee Enclaves*. Parley with proper tokens (salt, names, warmth) to downgrade the next Clubs result in their turf.

- **Patron Hooks (optional):**

- **The Sealed Gate:** Chalk lines cancel one intrusion for a scene; breaking them adds 1 Heat.
- **Lunara:** Moon-silver reveals one hidden organ (cistern, nerve-hall); mark Exposure +1.
- **The Traveler:** Waymarks let you finish one travel tick after a room clear.
- **Varnek Karn:** Naming the dead here clears 1 *Awareness* but starts a *Ledger Attention* [4].
- **Maelstraeus:** Trade salvage tags at "fair rate" once/expedition; skewed trades create a *Karmic Debt* [6].

Keys, Locks, & Doors (drop-in schema)

- **Door Attitudes:** *Literal* (wants the right key), *Courteous* (opens to the right words), *Hungry* (takes a toll), *Shy* (hates crowds), *Proud* (demands ceremony).
- **Key Types:** *Mechanical* (wards/picks), *Mnemonic* (password, name), *Somatic* (gesture, breath), *Affective* (emotion offered), *Sacrificial* (blood, time, memory).
- **Rule of Two:** Each important barrier recognizes two different key types; learning either grants +1 Effect to breach or parley with it.

Salvage, Haul, & Conversion

- **Salvage Tags:** *Stable* (safe to carry), *Volatile* (ticks Stress on jostle), *Bound* (linked to site), *Loud* (adds Heat when moved), *Forbidden* (attracts factions).
- **Convert on Exit (choose one):** trade haul for a *Map that Grows* upgrade, a *Pass-Key Writ* (one automatic door compliance), or *Market Credit* (reduce next sell-off complication).

Table Prompts (d6 each, fast prep)

Echo Questions

1. What does the room want?
2. Who set this alarm?
3. What was repaired last?
4. Where does the draft go?
5. What memory sticks here?
6. What price opens the way?

Find the Organ

1. Cistern (fluid)
2. Bell-shaft (signal)
3. Heat lung (thermal)
4. Nerve-hall (control)
5. Waste sluice (decay)
6. Relay shrine (intent)

Procedures at the Door (one-minute read-aloud checklist)

1. **Sense:** Name two smells; ask which grew stronger.
2. **Listen:** Offer one echo; ask what word returns wrong.
3. **Light:** Describe color/behavior; ask who steadies it (hum, prayer, silence).
4. **Count:** Beats, drips, or breaths—players may claim *Counting Etiquette* to shift Position safer once.
5. **Declare Price or Key:** Players state attitude + key type; on a hit, grant +1 Effect or a *Safe Route* token.

Plug-in SB Conversions (use with any dungeon)

- First 1 SB in a scene may become *Heat +1* instead of a narrative wrinkle (signal without immediate harm).
- Any 2 SB can instead tick *Structure Stress* and foreshadow *Cascading Failure* rather than spawn foes.
- On 3+ SB, offer a bargain: pay with *memory/gear/time* to halve the consequence and add *Price of Passage* [3].

Bosses & Lairs (Classic Crawl Feel, Fate’s Edge Framework)

Using Bosses Each boss runs on a **Phase Clock** and 2–3 **Lair Actions**. Tie them to the site’s *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)* and *Structure Stress*; as either rises, promote boss position/effect. Boss defeats should yield a Diamond-tier boon keyed to the lair.

Oculus Warden (many-eyed sentry)

A floating nerve-knot studded with glass eyes; lenses irise like gills.

- **Phase Clock:** [8] *Calibration* → *Overwatch* → *Lethal Focus* → *Blind Panic*
- **Moves:** *Disintegrate Signage* (erase waymarks), *Anti-magic Glare* (downgrade 1 magical effect this exchange), *Scry Ping* (advance Awareness +1).
- **Lair Actions (Mirror Hall / Vault of Whispers):**
 1. *Prismatic Sweep:* Split the party’s positions (each PC steps one tier toward Controlled).
 2. *Echo False Order:* One PC hears an ally’s command that was never given; test or waste an action.
 3. *Lens Flare:* Next ranged attack against the Warden loses 1 Effect unless the light source is doused.
- **Counters:** Smoke, darkness, reflective shields, calling shots on specific lenses (name a lens: cancel one Move this round).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Crown of Momentary Authority* or *Lantern of Clarity*.

Digestive Array (cube-that-crawls)

A transparent, room-sized solvent held in grid tension; carries tools it cannot digest.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Probe* → *Enmesh* → *Dissolve*
- **Moves:** *Corrode* (apply COMPROMISED to metal/wood), *Engulf* (split group; trapped PC marks Fatigue or gear loss), *Clean Bones* (remove tags from fallen).
- **Lair Actions (Sunken Vestibule / Chained Sanctuary):**
 1. *Flood Gate Twitch:* Water level rises a step; footing worsens.
 2. *Sluice Pulse:* Pushes all creatures one range band.

3. *Reagent Bloom*: Vapors add −1 die to breathy actions this round.

- **Counters:** Grates, cold cinders, base powders; lures with iron filings or salted meat (draw off for a scene).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Forge of Quick Repair* salvage or *Ration of Sustenance* (3).

Ledger Lich (archivist revenant)

A curator bound by indices; hands of ink, breath of dust.

- **Phase Clock:** [8] *Citation* → *Injunction* → *Foreclosure* → *Redaction*
- **Moves:** *Name Forfeiture* (steal a declared tag until bell), *Writ of Seizure* (lock a Diamond or gear under spectral seal), *Errata* (retroactively worsen one PC’s prior roll Outcome).
- **Lair Actions (Vault of Whispers / Deep Archive):**
 1. *Quiet Hours*: Casting/rites generate +1 SB or fail softly.
 2. *Reference Only*: Movement through stacks costs an action unless proper tokens are presented.
 3. *Cross-reference Collapse*: Bookshelves reconfigure; split the party.
- **Counters:** True names carved in quartz, burning a citation (sacrifice an *index*—a map, a ledger, a vow) to cancel one Move.
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Key of Echoes*, *Tome of Convenient Knowledge*.

Protocol Titan (stone sentinel)

A walking paragraph of law in granite; joints clock with tiny bells.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Challenge* → *Adjudicate* → *Execute*
- **Moves:** *Ward Stomp* (shockwave; prone or position −), *Clause Capture* (binds a PC to a declared rule), *Countermeasure* (reflect mundane force).
- **Lair Actions (Measure Vault / Throne of Echoes):**
 1. *Bell of Standing*: Only those who declare an intent may act this round.
 2. *Weigh Deceit*: The largest lie in the scene takes Harm 1 (Stress).
 3. *Seal Turned*: A door the party used closes and locks under new terms.
- **Counters:** Present certified measures, exploit contradictions, or swear a binding minor oath (shift boss Position −).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *The Under-Seal Clause* (local), *Key-Writ*.

Mimetic Colony (door-that-eats)

An ecosystem of impostor hinges, handles, chests, and carpets.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Invitation* → *Adhesion* → *Ingestion*
- **Moves:** *Stickfast* (immobilize limb/gear), *Swallow Noise* (negate assists), *Split & Flank*.
- **Lair Actions (Armory / Garden of Stone):**
 1. *Everything's a Mouth:* First interacted object bites.
 2. *False Safe:* Creates a "short rest" that actually advances Heat +2.
 3. *Chew Through:* Destroys one rung/bridge segment.
- **Counters:** Iron spikes, chalk lines, bait boxes; fire/acid cause the colony to fragment (treat as minions).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Cloak of Passage*, *Token of Safe Return*.

Sluice Dragon (steam & acid wurm)

A heat lung grown proud; scales are boiler plates, breath a flash-boil scream.

- **Phase Clock:** [10] *Banked Heat* → *Pressure Rise* → *Vent Fury* → *Rupture*
- **Moves:** *Scalding Cone*, *Vacuum Lurch* (pull PCs), *Steam Blind* (Position −).
- **Lair Actions (Heat Lungs / Cistern):**
 1. *Valve Spin:* Change terrain tags (Dry/Wet/Boiling).
 2. *Gauge Pop:* Structure Stress +1; cracks form.
 3. *Pressure Shadow:* The dragon gains +1 Effect for one exchange.
- **Counters:** Chill the room (dump cistern), bleed valves (two actions), or bait with metal ingots.
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Forge of Quick Repair*, *Shield of Temporary Immunity*.

Crawl Procedures (Quick, Crunchy Options)

- **Short Rest (10 minutes):** Clear Fatigue 1 *or* refresh one spent tool; advance *Dungeon Awareness* +1 and roll once on *Ambient Signs* (below).
- **Secure Camp (1 hour, defensible):** Clear Fatigue 2 and one *Condition* (not Harm); *Structure Stress* +1d2 from barricading/heat, *Awareness* +2 unless *Sealed*.
- **Search a Room (5 minutes):** On success, gain 1 *Safe Route* token *or* a *Map that Grows* tick; on miss, trigger a *Door Attitude* complication.
- **Light, Air, Load:** Track three pooled clocks [4] (see Plug-in Expedition Layer). Empty tracks worsen Position until restored.

Wandering Signs & Encounters (d12)

1. Whisper returns one word wrong; nearest door adopts a *Hungry* attitude.
2. Drip changes rhythm; nearby *Gravity Well* awakens.
3. Custodian chalk erased and redrawn *behind* you.
4. A stack exhales: *Memory Fog* for one exchange.
5. Pilfer-vermin court demands toll (crumbs, salt, *or* gossip).
6. Bound Guardian patrol, willing to debate terms (papers help).
7. Refugee child with a *Key of Echoes* that hates you.
8. Floor warms; *Heat Lung* cycling—steam hazard next room.
9. Echo sermon on "proper doors"; ignoring it adds Heat +1.
10. Sloshing in walls; *Digestive Array* scouts with a filament.
11. A mirror shows your gear two items lighter—choose which or mark Fatigue 1.
12. Stone hymn—sing along to cancel first SB this scene, or suffer *Hungering Dark* pulse.

Classic Traps, Living-Site Style (pick 1–2 tags)

- **Pressure Mosaic** (Artful, Loud): Floor pattern asks for a dance step; wrong beat drops spears from *ceiling*, not floor.
- **Breath Tax** (Subtle, Lingering): Room meters exhalations; excess vents sleeping gas; counting etiquette downgrades risk.
- **Magi-Siphon Grate** (Hungry, Magnetic): Drains charges from tools/wards; feeding it a *Focus Crystal* buys safe passage.
- **Echo Latch** (Riddle, Social): Door opens to a truth spoken softly; lies trigger *Phantom Locks*.

Treasure & Upgrade Hooks (d8 hoard seeds)

1. Cage of *tame echoes*—store a sentence for later; release as perfect mimicry.
2. *Map that Grows* (upgraded): shows *organs* (cistern/nerve-hall) when rubbed with tallow.
3. *Wayfinder Compass* attuned: hum a note to swap "nearest exit" with "nearest objective."
4. *Key-ring of Attitudes*: once each—*Courteous*, *Hungry*, *Proud*.
5. Bottle of *stolen seasons*: pour to set room to *pollen-sweet* or *knife-cold* for one scene.

6. *Token of Safe Return* (party-wide) that tugs twice when the *Heart Pressure* hits threshold.
7. A ledger page signed by the *Dungeon’s Creator*—treat one barrier as if you are expected.
8. *Lantern of Clarity* mantle: once/session, reveals the *Price of Passage* without paying it.

Boss Build Template (one-minute prep)

1. **Name & Nature:** What organ of the dungeon is this boss the face of?
2. **Phase Clock:** 6/8/10 with 2–4 titled phases.
3. **Three Moves:** One space-control, one resource-tax, one identity/knowledge twist.
4. **Two Lair Actions:** Environmental toggles keyed to this lair.
5. **Counters:** A courtesy, a tool, a sacrifice. (Players should be able to *learn* these.)
6. **Drop:** A Diamond (from §4.15) or bespoke boon tied to the organ.

Dungeon Boss: The Heart Itself (set-piece)

A chamber of ribs and lintels; mortar smells like blood, light like fever.

- **Phase Clock:** [10] *Palpate* → *Synchronize* → *Pacemaker* → *Arrest*
- **Moves:** *Syncopate* (force actions to resolve off-beat; assist dice misfire), *Tachycardia* (Heat +2, Structure Stress +1), *Backflow* (reverse one clock tick on *Floorplan Loops*, but split the party).
- **Lair Actions:**
 1. *Valve Close:* Seal exits; require a "Somatic" or "Affective" key to reopen.
 2. *Adrenal Surge:* The Heart acts twice next round unless fed a secret *all PCs share*.
- **Counters:** Speak the dungeon’s *true purpose* (as inferred via organs), vent a heat lung, or sacrifice mapped ground (tear up a *Safe Route*).
- **Victory States:** *Stabilize* (site becomes safer; Awareness clears to 0), *Pacify* (gain *Dungeon’s Blessing*), or *Slay* (collapse risk; Structure Stress +2 across the level).

4.16 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

Grand Magistrate (Elite): “The law here is written not in books but in marble and flame. Every edict carries the weight of centuries, and every judgment echoes in the very stones of the Forum.”

Ferrymaster (Commoner): “I’ve seen the city burn three times and rise again like a phoenix made of stone. The marble remembers, the bells tell the truth, and the fire judges all – especially those who think coin can buy clean hands.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once the heart of the Utaran Empire, Ecktoria has worn its laurels into chains. Three centuries of sack, fire, and slow decline have not stripped its marble forums nor its gold-sealed coin-houses – but each day, more of its wealth slips into the hands of mercenaries and factions. The Black Banners march on its purse, avenging old Ykrul wounds by proxy. Processions still crown its stairways, yet ash lines every step. The city burns not only with memory, but with ambition still unquenched. Beyond the capital’s walls, the province is a patchwork of struggling towns, abandoned fortresses, and grainlands whose harvests are disputed by rival tax-collectors. The Everflame Orthodoxy preaches unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The statues watch. The fire judges.

What you notice first: The smell of old incense and fresh bread. The way crowds part for a procession—and close again for a knife. The marble steps, worn smooth by centuries of petitioners.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a toast in a coin-house. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again.

Regional Mood: The Flame That Remembers

Here, the past does not fade—it is polished into monuments. Every statue, every obelisk, every triumphal arch is a legal precedent carved in stone. Ecktoria is not one city but three: the marble forums of the old patricians, the soot-stained alleys of the mercenary camps, and the basilicas where the Everflame’s priests balance piety against profit. The Grand Magistrate presides over a skeleton empire, but the real power moves in coin-houses, grain ledgers, and the whispered judgments of the Censor’s Hall. The Black Banners are not invaders; they are employees. The Ykrul are not enemies; they are creditors. And the Everflame is not a god; it is an auditor that never sleeps.

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons. A factor with smoke-singed ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. Your credit is good—for now. Find out who lit the fire, or the Flame will audit your soul at dawn.”

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Marble grandeur, ash-tipped ambition, and the slow rot of imperial forms.

- **Key Conflict:** Legitimacy versus wealth; old families, new mercenaries, and the Everflame’s judgment.
- **Notable Threats:** Bread riots, arena spills, ducal conflicts, inquisitorial visits, and the Red List.
- **Common Rewards:** Procession permits, coin-house credit, laurel deeds, and a Golden Edict carved in precedent.

Prominent NPCs of Ecktoria

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Valerius	Grand Magistrate	Preserve the forms of law while the empire crumbles	His gavel is a sundial; it only strikes at noon.
Flavia	High Priest of the Everflame	Balance the factions and keep the flame lit	She has never raised her voice; the flame speaks for her.
Cassia	Duchess-Regent of the Dolmis Gate	Protect her family’s trading rights	She rules from behind a silk screen; a dagger-hole is cut at eye level.
Marcus	Coin-House Factor	Survive the next credit panic	He seals deals with three ribbons: white (ask), red (now), black (never).
Lucius	Lanista (arena master)	Own the next champion and the secrets of the hypogeum	His fighters’ brands are his signature; he never repeats a mark.
The Red Clerk	Censor’s Hall scribe	Control which names are remembered	His inkwell is a skull; the skull belonged to a name he erased.

Names of Ecktoria

Inspired by late Latin and early Romance: strong vowels (ae, i, o), soft endings, and the weight of imperial bureaucracy. Surnames often denote a place of origin, a trade, or a notable ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valerius	Flavia	de Urbe	<i>the Iron</i>
Marcus	Cassia	Aquilinus	<i>the Coin-Wise</i>
Lucius	Aelia	Honoratus	<i>Flame-Touched</i>
Tiberius	Cornelia	Lateranus	<i>the Unburned</i>
Gaius	Livia	Silvanus	<i>Bread-Counter</i>
Decimus	Valeria	Portinari	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

The Three Ecktorias: Faction Spectrum

Ecktoria is not a single polity but a battlefield of three competing visions. Most citizens and factions fall somewhere between these poles, shifting allegiance as the grain price changes.

- **Old Blood (Patrician Traditionalists)** – The ancient senatorial families who remember when Ecktoria ruled the world. They worship precedent, hoard marble, and see mercenaries as necessary filth. Their power is in law, lineage, and the silent networks of the Censor’s Hall. *Clocks: PATRICIAN PATIENCE [4], BLOOD DEBT [6].*
- **Black Purse (Mercenary & Trade Leagues)** – The new power: condotta brokers, coin-house factors, and mercenary captains who have bought what birth could not give. They care about supply lines, not bloodlines. Their loyalty is to the next contract, and their god is the ledger. *Clocks: CONTRACT SPIRAL [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6].*
- **The Everflame (Church & Inquisition)** – The priests, inquisitors, and relic-keepers who claim that the Eternal Flame is the only true sovereign. They offer legitimacy to whoever pays the tithe—and withdraw it from whoever forgets. Their power is in pulpits, processions, and the fear of excommunication. *Clocks: HERESY INDEX [4], SANCTUARY VIOLATION [6].*

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul creditors** (who hold Ecktoria’s debt like a leash) and the **Black Banners** (who hold its streets like a lease). A wise politician learns to balance all three—and keeps a boat ready on the Dolmis.

Spades — Places

2. **Petition Steps** — Milk-stone steps where dawn petitions are pinned. *The petitions are written in ink and hope. The steps answer in marble and silence.*
3. **Tally-Ford Ferryhouse** — Rope-drums thrum all day; the ferrymaster watches coin and banners. *The rope-drums have a pattern. It spells the names of those who paid late.*

4. **Arena Hypogeum** — Practice sand and whispered secrets beneath the games. *The sand is from the Tiber. It still remembers the blood of the last revolt.*
5. **Everflame Cloister** — Candle markets and side-chapels where flame speaks truth. *The flame has a voice. It is the voice of the last liar who tested it.*
6. **Shatterline Bazaar** — Between quake-toppled columns, merchants hawk broken dreams. *The columns were toppled by an earthquake that killed a senator. He still haunts the rubble.*
7. **Coin-House Floor** — Counting ledgers under glass; factors seal credit with three ribbons. *The ribbons are colored: white for "ask," red for "now," black for "never."*
8. **Mile-Zero Obelisk** — Surveyors' starting point; all roads measured from here. *The obelisk has a crack. The crack is a mile long—in the other direction.*
9. **Triumph Stairs** — Processional Way switchback; marble worn smooth by ambition. *The stairs have a name: "The Rise of the Forgotten." No one remembers why.*
10. **Aqueduct Walk** — Narrow guardpath above the city's arteries; perfect for ambush or escape. *The water below tastes of iron. It is the city's memory of its own blood.*
- J **Ducal Loggia** — High above a packed square; a duchess watches and waits. *The duchess has not blinked in three hours. She is counting.*
- Q **Censor's Hall** — Red-lacquered tablets record every name, every shame. *The tablets are redacted in invisible ink. The truth is underneath.*
- K **Grand Forum** — Statues tarped, echoes loud; where crowds become mobs. *The tarps were a gift from a dead emperor. The statues do not thank him.*
- A **Imperial Arena** — The Marble Bowl, gates chained – for now. *The chains are warm. Something inside is breathing.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Torchbearer Child** — Ash-smudged hands; knows every shortcut through the ruins. *She has never been lost. The ruins speak to her in dust.*
3. **Ferrymaster** — Knows which banners pay late; collects more than coin. *His ledger is a net. The names are the catch.*
4. **Coin-House Factor** — Seals credit with three ribbons; eyes twitch at defaults. *His eyes are the color of old silver. They see through your purse.*
5. **Lanista** — Owns fighters – and their secrets; sells victory in the sand. *His grin is a brand. The brand is on his fighters' necks.*
6. **Decumanus-Master** — Surveyor who "moves" stones; rewrites the city's shape. *His rod is a finger bone. The bone belonged to the last surveyor who argued.*

7. **Procession Marshal** — Permits and whistle; keeps order in ceremonial chaos. *His whistle is for the living. His bell is for the dead.*
 8. **Grain-Prefect** — Allots loaves; knives in the margins of every ledger. *His ledger has a stain. The stain is wine—or blood.*
 9. **Censor’s Clerk** — “Misfiles” careers; knows which names to forget. *His inkwell is a skull. The skull belonged to a name he forgot.*
 10. **Veteran Standard-Bearer** — Sells honor as a retainer; medals heavier than sword. *His medals are from a war that never happened. The corpses are from one that did.*
- J **Gladiatrix** — Darling of the crowds; owes no one but the sand. *Her sword has no name. The sand has many.*
- Q **Duchess-Regent** — Behind a silk screen; speaks through cousins, rules through silence. *The screen has a hole. The hole is for a dagger—hers.*
- K **High Priest of Everflame** — Smiles like law; flame judges truth and debt. *His smile is a candle. It can warm—or burn.*
- A **Grand Magistrate** — Guardian of forms, breaker of them when needed. *His gavel is a sundial. It only strikes at noon.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Blocked Bridge** — A procession blocks the only crossing till sundown. *The procession is for a saint who died hungry. The saint is not forgiving.*
3. **Proscribed Sigil** — A sudden edict: your mark is now forbidden. *The edict was written in the dead of night. The ink is still wet—and warm.*
4. **Bread Riots** — Grain barges are late; hunger hisses at the city’s edges. *The hunger has a face. It is the face of a baker who ran out of flour.*
5. **Arena Spill** — A riot spills into streets; shutters slam, guards draw steel. *The riot started over a point. The point was a sword.*
6. **Ducal Conflict** — Rival dukes levy the same ward; your recruits vanish. *The recruits are not dead. They are hired. They are now your enemies.*
7. **Border Dispute** — A re-plat redraws boundaries; your deed becomes “disputed.” *The surveyor’s rod is bent. He calls it “context.”*
8. **Frozen Purse** — A coin-house calls in notes; your purse freezes at the worst moment. *The notes were called by a dead man. His signature is still warm.*
9. **Inquisitorial Visit** — A relic’s authenticity is questioned; penalties are swift and public. *The relic is a nail from a cross. It has been forged seven times. It still works.*

10. **Aftershock** — Masonry and timetables fall; scaffolds groan with new cracks. *The crack has a name. It whispers it to the wind.*
- J **Counterfeit Laurel** — Your win is void unless you find the forger. *The forger is a child. The child is a slave. The slave is a senator's son.*
- Q **Church Purge** — "Spectacles" are banned; your venue is canceled by zealots. *The zealots are paid by a rival. The rival is in the front row.*
- K **Rerouted Triumph** — The crowd follows the favored path; your moment is stolen. *The favored path is lined with archers. The archers are not there for the ceremony.*
- A **Red List** — A secret ledger; your patron's name appears overnight. *The list is written in a dead hand. The dead are still collecting.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bread Chit** — Ward sustenance for a week; street patience guaranteed. *The chit is a clay token. Break it to eat—or to bribe.*
3. **Procession Permit** — Move sacred flame through a crowded quarter; law walks with you. *The permit is a torch. Carry it, and the city will part—or burn.*
4. **Arena Purse** — Settles debts and hires mouths; blood-money in coin. *The purse is a helmet. The helmet belonged to a champion who lost.*
5. **Survey Writ** — Reset one boundary stone; redraw the city's shape. *The writ is a stone. Move it, and the map changes—on paper.*
6. **Ducal Safe-Conduct** — Four guards and a trumpet; noble favor walks ahead. *The guards are paid by the duke. The trumpet is paid by you.*
7. **Coin-House Credit** — Silent and immediate; debt becomes opportunity. *The credit is a ribbon. Cut it to spend—or to owe.*
8. **Magistrate's Postponement** — Buy a tenday against any suit; law delayed, not denied. *The postponement is a letter. The letter is sealed with a tear.*
9. **Laurel-Deed** — Crowd favor follows you into court; glory as a shield. *The deed is a leaf. It was plucked from a victor's crown. The victor is dead.*
10. **Grain Ledger** — Name who eats this month; hunger bends to your will. *The ledger is a stomach. Feed it, or it will feed on you.*
- J **Minor Title** — A style that opens doors that bolts resist; rank as a key. *The title is a word. The word is "Patrician." The doors do not ask questions.*
- Q **Basilica Audience** — One private hour with the High Priest; the flame speaks truth. *The hour is a candle. When it burns out, so does your favor.*
- K **Censor's Indulgence** — One banned thing becomes permitted (for you). *The indulgence is a silence. The silence is a scream.*
- A **Golden Edict** — An exception carved in marble; precedent travels like law. *The edict is a crack. The crack in the law is now an opening.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/favor/precedence) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **marble and fire** motifs – statues that watch, flames that judge, and law that remembers every name.

Additional Features

- **Imperial Ruins:** Every district bears half-collapsed arcades, serving as markets, courts, or shelters for mercenary companies.
- **Competing Factions:** Dukes, guilds, and priests stage processions that collide at bridges and squares, each claiming legitimacy.
- **Monuments as Weapons:** Statues, obelisks, and colonnades are not only symbols – they are barricades, rallying points, and high ground when the city riots.
- **Everflame Orthodoxy:** The basilicas preach unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The High Priest plays balance while cultivating his own following.
- **Black Banner Contracts:** Foreign mercenaries fill the gaps left by a shrinking citizen levy, their loyalty secured only by steady coin.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Marcellus (Mykkiel) of the Gilded Scale (Order of Justiciars):** The Censor’s Hall keeps a sealed archive of *unwritten laws* — precedents that were never spoken aloud. The Order of Justiciars claims that reading even one of these laws binds the reader to enforce it. The Grand Magistrate has never opened the archive. The Red Clerk has, and his inkwell is now a skull.
- **Saint Valeria (Isoka) of the Serpent (Order of the Shed Robe):** In the Everflame Cloister, a side chapel is dedicated to the *Shedding Saint*, whose mosaic shows a snake eating its own tail. Pilgrims who leave a confession there wake the next morning having forgotten one sin — but also one kindness they received. The High Priest permits the chapel because the offerings keep the basilica warm.
- **The Hospice of the Soot-Stained Hands:** A hospice in the Shatterline Bazaar is run by grey-robed healers who ask no payment. They are tolerated because they treat wounded mercenaries for free, but the Black Purse faction suspects they also erase debts — ledgers left near their doors have been found blank. The Order’s rule: “You do not pay back. You pay forward. But woe to the one who strikes a healer.”

- **The Ember Prefect (Heretic Cult):** A schism within the Everflame believes the flame should *not* be contained in basilicas. They meet in the arena hypogeum at midnight, chanting the *Unspoken Ninth Citation*. The Grand Magistrate has outlawed them three times. Each time, the edict was found burned the next morning, with a single word left intact: “*Audit.*”
- **The Ninth:** In any Ecktorian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls — and their cases are never heard again.

Ecktoria Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Flame:** Crumble a crust into the Everflame. Ignore the first *Bread Riots* penalty.
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a coin-house credit ribbon. Cancel *Frozen Purse* or take −1 die on your next debt roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Marble:** Whisper a dead debtor’s name into a statue’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their heirs this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Grand Magistrate.

Patronage & Power

Ecktoria’s decline is not collapse, but transformation. Wealth bleeds into patronage webs: a senator’s indulgence, a censor’s indulgence, a noble’s purse. The city’s great houses keep mercenary captains on retainer, while priests sell ritual processions as public theater and private favor.

For the GM: Patronage should function as both opportunity and trap. Any gift (a purse, permit, or charter) binds the receiver to service, but patrons can die, fall from favor, or suddenly proscribe what they once allowed. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, ribbons, laurel crowns) that can be stolen, forged, or voided.
- Let rival patrons issue conflicting “safe-conducts,” forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use processions, funerals, or trials as arenas for social contests, where patronage debts surface and shift allegiances.

Patronage in Ecktoria is not mere background – it is the engine of politics, coin, and survival.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city guards** or **rival factions**.

- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or ceremonial processions**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **patrols or inquisitors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or ceremonial opportunity**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **City authorities or noble house** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction member or city official** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **guards, mercenaries, or zealots** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **procession turns violent/boundary dispute erupts/patron turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **High Priest, Grand Magistrate, or Duchess-Regent** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **procession erupts/arena gate opens/monument collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **flame speaks/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ecktoria (Marble & Fire):** Statues turn their heads, flames burn blue, ceremonial masks appear in windows.
- **Ecktoria (Procession):** Crowds chant your name, banners block your path, trumpets announce your arrival.
- **Ecktoria (Patronage):** Seals break in your hand, favors are revoked, noble houses compete for your allegiance.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Cross-Region Hooks (optional draws):**
 - *Aeler True Masons* bid to shore a failing aqueduct; accepting stabilizes *After-shock* but grants them soft leverage in the ward.
 - *Aelinnel Green-Market broker* offers “truth-credit” on court gossip; pay later in favors or names.
 - *Black Banner retainer* parade demands back pay on the Triumph Stairs; crowd sympathy tilts your next parley.
- **Faction Entanglements During Travel (use en route or on city entry):**
 - If the party holds any *Condotta* Diamonds, begin with *Bread Riots* at +1 segment (mercenary grain trains re-routed).
 - Entering with an *Underway Pass* (Aeler) grants +1 Position on *Aqueduct Walk* scenes but ticks *Ducal Conflict* once (guild jealousy).
 - Carrying *Green Market* tags downgrades one *Censor’s Hall* action but flags *Inquisitorial Visit* at the next temple.
- **Patron Touchpoints (as Saints & Orders):**
 - **Saint Maelstraeus (the Reckoner):** Coin-houses keep shadow ledgers; once/session convert one social success into a *Coin-House Credit* Diamond but start a *Karmic Debt* [6].
 - **Saint Mykkiel (the Justiciar):** Any *Procession Permit* can be notarised as an *Oath Irons* lite: breaking its terms applies –1 die to legal actions for a scene.
 - **Saint Lunara (the Silver Quiet):** *Everflame Cloister* niches hide “silver mirrors”; on use, ask one yes/no about civic intrigue; mark Exposure +1.
 - **Saint Traveler (the Wayfinder):** Map the *Triumph Stairs* as a living route: spend 1 Boon to treat one crowd scene as *overland progress* for clocks.
- **Trade Good Consequences (pick 1 when a haul sells):**
 - *Arena Steel* → street duels spike → start *Arena Spill* at 1.
 - *Relic Fragments* → basilica prestige swings → tick *Church Purge* or grant *Basilica Audience*.

- *Survey Rights* → boundary re-plot → downgrade one *Border Dispute* or upgrade a rival's.

- **Diplomatic Favor (minor currency):**

- Earn by resolving a public scene without bloodshed (Forum, Procession, Coin-House).
- Spend 1 to reduce DV of a permit/audience by 1, or to ignore *Blocked Bridge* for one crossing.
- Holding 2+ makes you “interesting”: start a *Red List* [4] that advances on snubbed patrons.

- **Reputation Echoes (soft power):**

- *Crowd-Loved (Laurel-Deed)*: first time per session you face a mob, set Position one step safer.
- *Coin-House Trusted (Credit)*: ignore the first *Frozen Purse*; next time, it returns at +1 severity.
- *Clerically Vouched (Everflame)*: downgrade one *Inquisitorial Visit*; if abused, promote *Church Purge*.

Monuments as Mechanics (opulence with teeth)

- **Processional Geometry**: When acting on the *Triumph Stairs*, choose: +1 Effect or –1 Heat; on a miss, *Rerouted Triumph* advances.
- **Aqueduct Leverage**: Securing an aqueduct span grants a one-scene *high ground* tag in any linked ward; if collateral hits, tick *Aftershock*.
- **Forum Acoustics**: Rally speeches at the *Grand Forum* grant an extra assist die if at least 20 witnesses; failure spawns *Bread Riots* at +1.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Ecktoria flavor)

- Any 1 SB may become *Crowd Drift*: shift the scene's terrain in favor of or against you (bridges clog, stairs clear).
- Any 2 SB may become *Seal Revoked*: void one paper (Permit/Chit/Indulgence); to avert, sacrifice *Diplomatic Favor*.
- On 3+ SB offer *Patron Bargain*: accept a visible mark (ribbon, laurel brand) to halve consequences; start a *Patron Debt* [6].

Hidden Orders & Ancient Conspiracies (d12 hooks)

1. **The Ash Senate** – a ledger of “extinguished” patrician lines still voting by proxy through funerary guilds.
2. **Surveyors of the Ninth Mile** – decumanus-masters who can *move* boundaries with ritual math; a lost rod sets precedent across the city.
3. **Lantern Tetrarchy** – four basilica beadles who decide which miracles are counted; the fifth lamp was broken in a purge.

4. **The Red Marble Compact** – coin-house founders who tithe 1 in 100 coins to a secret indemnity fund used to flip coups.
5. **Archivum Umbrae** – censor clerks maintaining a *shadow index* of names that must not stand trial (yet).
6. **Peregrine Brotherhood** – ferrymasters trading in sealed confessions; blackmail that floats.
7. **The Laurel of Dust** – a gladiators’ mutual that chooses which champions live long enough to hold office.
8. **Aqueduct Collegium Obscura** – engineers who keep a second set of sluice keys; droughts become elections.
9. **Order of the Broken Obelisk** – survey-cult that believes Mile-Zero is *wrong* and can re-found the city with one stone.
10. **The Funeral Republic** – undertakers running a parallel courier state through catacombs and wakes.
11. **The Ember Vault** – a sealed reliquary under the Arena; victors' sweat was bottled for augury.
12. **Triumphal Maskers** – procession costumers who encode heretical theses into robe pleats and torch patterns.

Cults & Mystery Rites (d10)

1. **Children of the Phoenix** (*rebirth by fire*): ash-marks grant +1 die vs. fear in crowds; mark Fatigue if you hesitate near open flame.
2. **Verdant Laurel** (*blood to marble, sap to coin*): once/session turn 1 Harm into 1 Coin-House Credit; start a *Green Debt* [4].
3. **Mask of the Thirteenth** (*forbidden procession step*): walk through a riot unmolested; next parley with clergy begins one step worse.
4. **Brotherhood of the River Tongue** (*truth ferried at night*): ask the Dolmis one yes/no; a ferryman shows up later to collect a name.
5. **Candlemakers of Ever** (*flame remembers lies*): blue flame points to falsehood; the liar dreams of you for three nights (Exposure +1).
6. **Sable Standard** (*war saint cult*): your banner ignores morale checks once; start a *Blood-Tithe* [4] owed to the saint’s chapel.
7. **The Ninth Bell** (*hour that is not kept*): skip a queue or sentence; next edict you need arrives late (Delay SB free once).
8. **Guild of Red Accountants** (*sin as ledger*): convert 2 SB into a *Magistrate’s Postponement*; add *Karmic Debt* [6].

9. **The Marble Eaters** (*mortification sect*): bite stone, gain +1 Effect resisting crowd crush; take Harm 1 (Stress) if you boast.
10. **Torch of Saint Vessa** (*saint of necessary arson*): sanctify a fire to purge a tag (Plague/Corruption); City Heat +2.

Religious Schisms & Trials

The Everflame Divide (choose a live schism)

1. **Orthodox Basilica vs. Ember Reformers**: Is miracle *counted* by law or *kindled* by need?
2. **Laurel Theologians vs. Street Saints**: Does glory flow *down* from triumphs or *up* from bread-lines?
3. **Iconoclast Ward vs. Reliquary Keepers**: Is the flame purer without images?

Schism Mechanics (table-facing)

- **Heresy Index** [0–6]: ticks when players publicize a stance, defy clergy, or wield cult rites in view. At 3: inquisitorial audits become common; at 6: *Church Purge* (Q) auto-triggers once/session until lowered.
- **Sanctuary / Anathema Tags**: locations acquire tags during arc scenes. *Sanctuary*: first harm in scene becomes Fatigue; *Anathema*: first social miss spawns “Proscribed Sigil.”
- **Trial by Fire (mini-procedure, 3 beats)**:
 1. *Assembly*: set the forum/stair as arena; state thesis in one sentence (players or NPCs).
 2. *Witness*: three proofs (relic, miracle, precedent). Each proof: test Social/Arcana/Resolve vs. crowd DV; on success, reduce Index by 1 or gain *Basilica Audience*.
 3. *Judgment*: roll Crowd Mood (1d6): 1–2 mobs, 3–4 silent acceptance, 5–6 laurel toss (gain *Laurel-Deed*). If Index ≥ 4 , –1 to the roll.

Ecktoria – Marble and Fire

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons.

“In Ecktoria, even faith must balance its ledgers, and the gods audit in ash.”

In... the Coin-House floor, a factor with smoke-singed ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him.”

Regional Motifs Coin-oaths, basilica relics, marble acoustics, augury smoke.

Whispers to Offer “Bid against the city,” “Pocket the relic shard,” “Name an innocent debtor.”

External Clocks Threat: *Procession of Ash* [6]; Community: *Credit Panic* [4]; Anchor: *Basilica Choir* [4].

Complications Smoke speaks truths; coins stick to skin; a reliquary runs hot.

Anchors at Risk A choir novice; a patron account.

Escalation Beat The Basilica tolls a note only one PC hears.

Relief Return the shard; pay a city-debt in blood or ; route the procession elsewhere.

Boss Seeds (Cults & Conspiracies)

- **The Ember Prefect** (schismatic inquisitor): *Phase* [8] Citation → Censure → Auto-da-fé → Purge. Lair: Everflame Cloister. Counters: relic provenance, crowd-favor, rival sermon.
- **The Surveyor-Primus** (geomantic usurper): *Phase* [6] Re-plat → Dispossess → Erase. Lair: Mile-Zero. Counters: Aeler measure-rods, witness line, broken rod.
- **Phoenix of the Arena** (miracle or hoax?): *Phase* [10] Hype → Immolation → “Rebirth” → Riot. Lair: Imperial Arena. Counters: doused ash, Mask of the Thirteenth, Everflame test.

Diamonds: Forbidden Leverage (add to §4.16)

14. **Shadow Index Leaf** – remove one name from the Red List for a week; add *Countercoup* +1.
15. **Ember Writ** – sanction one cult rite as “orthodox” for a scene.
16. **Surveyor’s Ninth Rod** – redraw one ward line unnoticed (until dawn).

Cross-Contamination (fast ties)

- **Aeler True Masons:** backing an iconoclast audit grants shoring crews; bell-codes now gate temple entries.
- **Aelinnel Thorn Courts:** hawthorn chaplains host “mirror sermons”; a basilica gains *Sanctuary* while a rival becomes *Anathema*.
- **Black Banners:** war-chaplains monetize indulgences; clearing *Payday* risks +1 *Heresy Index*.

4.17 Linn — “Skerries & Storm-Oaths”

High Jarl (Elite): “The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds. To rule these shores is to dance between their moods and never miss a step.”

Net-Wife (Commoner): “The water speaks to those who know how to listen – the way it moves tells you if the fish are running, if the weather’s turning, or if something’s coming that wasn’t invited to the feast.”

Theme & Atmosphere

North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are traders and raiders in equal breath, their longships crowding the whale-road and river mouths. They descend the Ylolka like an axe-blade and cut into southern shores, or slip through the Thin Strip where the Valewood dares not touch salt. Yet even these storm-oath people dread the Mistlands and the Valewood, whose fog and trees have no need of ships or harbors to claim their due.

What you notice first: The smell of tar and salt fish. The creak of oars from unseen boats. The way everyone—jarl to thrall—touches a knotted cord before speaking of the sea.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a drowned person aloud while underway. The sea collects names, and if it hears you speaking one it doesn’t recognize, it may reach up to correct the ledger.

Regional Mood: Skerry Stormcall

Power here is spoken, not written. A jarl’s authority rests on the weight of his oath-chest and the sharpness of his skald’s tongue. Longships are not vessels; they are promises carved in timber. Every voyage is a gamble against tide, reef, and the attention of things that sleep beneath the waves. The Linn do not fear death—they fear dying without a witness, swallowed by fog where no verse will remember their name.

Starting Location: A longship house lined with storm-charms and whale-bone runes, salt wind clawing at the doors. A Net-Wife binds a storm-token into a PC’s palm. “The Whale-Road sings,” she says. “But the Mistlands whistle back. Bring us three keel-lengths of ironwood from the Valewood edge, or the tide will take our boats in the spring.”

Prominent NPCs of Linn

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Jarl Skjold	High Jarl of the Southern Fjords	Unite the scattered strands under one oath	His beard is braided with silver from every ship he has taken.
Volva Hervor	Mist-seer and oath-reader	Read the tides of fate before they turn	She speaks once a year; the rest of the time she listens to the fog.
Astrid	Net-Wife (commoner exemplar)	Keep her village safe from the Hollow and the deep	She ties a knot for every storm she’s survived. Her belt has thirty.
Brother Halvard	Missionary of the Temple of Light	Convert the Linn to the Lens of the White Flame	He carries a water-clock to measure the hours of prayer, but the skerries have no hours.
Gunnhild	Sea-Queen’s Hand	Enforce the queen’s will without drawing a blade	She never draws her sword. The threat is enough.
The Draugr Jarl	Unfinished business (rumoured)	A dead jarl whose oath was never fulfilled	Said to rise from the Thing-Holm when the ninth bell tolls.

Names of Linn

Inspired by the northern fjords: short, hard consonants, compound words that evoke the sea and the storm. Surnames are often patronymic (-son, -dottir) or taken from a notable deed.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Skjold		Astrid	Einarsson	<i>the Oath-Keeper</i>

Bjorn	Gunnhild	Hervorsdottir	<i>Tide-Reader</i>
Ragnar	Sigrid	Ketilsson	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Halvard	Yrsa	Ormsson	<i>the Unfinished</i>
Torsten	Runa	Sturladottir	<i>Whale-Bone</i>
Vidar	Helga	Haakonsson	<i>Ash-Prow</i>

(**Fjord/Skerry/Hall**) Kelp-skerry gut: a narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock; tide-shed of longship houses with tar smoke and gulls for sentries.

Spades — Places

2. **Kelp-Skerry Gut** — Narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock. *Kelp strands like dead men’s hair; row silently or the reef listens.*
 3. **Tide-Shed** — Longship houses; tar smoke and gulls for sentries. *Each shed holds a keel’s ghost; old crews sleep under the floor planks.*
 4. **Wave-Gate Reef** — Just off a raiding beach; only locals know the cut. *One wrong turn and the wave breaks over you—twice.*
 5. **Runestone Causey** — Across tidal flat; names half lost to barnacle. *Touch the stone with your left hand. If it’s warm, the ancestors approve.*
 6. **Herring-Stairs** — Drying racks above cliff path; knives flicker like fish. *Workers sing a counting song—eight verses, never nine.*
 7. **Winter Hall** — Turf walls, smoke-eye roof, benches crowded with shields. *The fire never goes out. Feed it a story each night or it goes hungry.*
 8. **Mistlands Maze** — Reed-channels braid and vanish; navigation by instinct. *The reeds whisper names you’ve forgotten. Do not answer.*
 9. **Boomed Harbor** — Iron rings in whale-bone posts; controlled access. *The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.*
 10. **Aberderrin Headland** — Current rips past wreck timbers in the kelp. *On foggy nights, the drowned signal with lanterns. Never follow.*
- J **Dolmis Waystation** — Low isle with fresh water and old debts. *The well is lined with copper. A single dropped coin returns as a blessing.*
- Q **Thing-Holm** — Flat islet ringed with stones for speaking and swearing. *The stones have ears; oaths spoken here echo for three tides.*
- K **High Jarl’s Seat** — Above fjord, beacon tower glaring out to sea. *The beacon oil is mixed with whale fat. It burns green when a storm is close.*
- A **Whale-Road Horizon** — Open water where storms are born and names are made. *Here, the sky meets the sea. Here, the dead meet the living.*

(**Jarl/Oar-Crew/Keeper**) Net-wife who reads the sea like a ledger and the sky like a mood; steersman whose tiller-hand never shakes.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Net-Wife** — Reads sea like ledger, sky like mood; weather-witch in all but name. *She ties a knot for every storm she’s survived. Her belt has thirty.*
 3. **Steersman** — Tiller-hand never shakes, even when keel does. *His left ear is scarred—he listened too long to a siren’s promise.*
 4. **Shipwright** — Pitch on palms, schedule in teeth; knows every plank’s story. *He names each timber after a dead relative. The keel is his grandmother.*
 5. **Oar-Master** — Sets beat that decides if home is today or never. *He drums on a hollowed skull. The rhythm is a prayer to the sea.*
 6. **Mist-Pilot** — Ghosts boats through marsh lanes; reed-runner with secret paths. *He never blinks in fog. Some say he traded his blink for safe passage.*
 7. **Skald** — Verses buy silence, start fights, end them; law in rhyme. *Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath.*
 8. **Shield-Band** — Cousins fine with coin, better with cattle. *They sharpen their swords on runestones. The sparks tell fortunes.*
 9. **Foster-Son** — Southern coast birth; speaks both laws and subtext. *He wears two brooches—one iron, one bone. Neither is his true allegiance.*
 10. **Thing-Speaker** — Makes war into lawsuit, lawsuit into lunch. *He carries a water-clock. When it runs out, so does your patience.*
- J **Sea-Queen’s Hand** — Envoy with seal-bag and sword-belt; queen’s will made manifest. *He never draws his blade. The threat is enough.*
- Q **Sea-Queen** — Crown of hammered silver, eyes for weather and law. *She lost an eye to a storm—or to a spy. She won’t say which.*
- K **High Jarl** — First among raids, last to boast; paramount over strands. *His beard is braided with silver from every ship he’s taken.*
- A **Volva of Mist** — Oath-reader whose nod stills surf; seer of tides and truth. *She speaks once a year. The rest of the time, she listens to the fog.*

(**Weather/Reef/Feud**) Black squall drops from clear band; oars or prayers—pick one; fogfall makes friend and reef trade places.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Black Squall** — Drops from clear band; oars or prayers—pick one. *The wind screams a name. Listen carefully—it might be yours.*
3. **Fogfall** — Sound travels, sight does not; friend and reef trade places. *You hear oars. Then you don't. Then they're behind you.*
4. **Boom Lift** — Harbor chain rises; schedules drown in harbor mouth. *The chain's links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
5. **Levy Clash** — Viterra's wardens arrive with polite spears. *They carry a writ stamped with the queen's seal. The seal is still wet.*
6. **Keel-Rot Rumor** — Crews beach mid-voyage; trust in timber fails. *The rot smells sweet—too sweet. Someone poisoned the tar.*
7. **Feud Token** — Raid becomes wedding... or funeral; oath-debt called due. *A bronze ring arrives on an arrow. The meaning is clear.*
8. **Oath Matured** — Verse sworn last winter comes due today. *The skald clears her throat. The room goes cold.*
9. **Mistlands Miscount** — Channels “move,” cargo vanishes without witnesses. *The fog lifts to reveal a different shore. Your charts are now lies.*
10. **Aberderrin Race** — Contrary currents split flotilla; half late, half lost. *The water churns like a dying man. Something beneath is feeding.*
- J **Southron Fire-Pots** — Night-run turns to daylight; surprise ashore. *Pots shatter on the deck. The fire burns blue—alchemical.*
- Q **Thing Injunction** — No sailing till grievance heard (hours? days?). *The Thing-Speaker smiles. He has all the time in the world.*
- K **General Muster** — Horns on every headland; all bays become spears. *The war fleet assembles. Your ship is the smallest.*
- A **Ground-Sea** — Long, blind swell rolls under; steering lies. *The swell has a rhythm—two short, one long. A signal from below.*

(Right/Token/Escort) Harbor-green mark—dock without levy in named strand; oar-share claims two benches on fast longship.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Harbor-Mark** — Dock without levy in named strand (once). *The mark is a notch cut in a bone. Match it to the harbor post.*
3. **Oar-Share** — Claim two benches on a fast longship for a season. *The oars are carved with your name. Row well, or they'll be recarved.*

4. **Pilot’s Token** — Mist-runner guides through reed-maze safely. *The token is a dried eel skin. Keep it dry.*
 5. **Wharf-Right** — Dolmis waystation loading priority; first ashore. *The harbormaster frowns but steps aside. Your name is now on a list.*
 6. **Salvage Claim** — Flotsam on reef stretch becomes “inventory.” *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
 7. **Thing Ruling** — Verdict in your favor that travels with you. *The verdict is carved on a whale-rib. Carry it as a shield.*
 8. **Raid-Truce** — Immunity in named bay for one market day. *A white banner on your mast. No one will attack—openly.*
 9. **Foster-Bond** — Guest-kin by jarl’s house; hospitality guaranteed. *You share a cup with the jarl. The cup is silver. The promise is iron.*
 10. **Herring Allotment** — Priority barrels when the run hits; silver in season. *The barrels are sealed with your mark. Break one to test quality.*
- J **Escort Writ** — Eight shields and wolf-banner from cape to cape. *The shields are painted with a wolf’s head. They die before you do.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Whisper exits as policy; sea-law bends. *The Queen’s hand writes your words on vellum. The ink is her blood.*
- K **High Jarl’s Pennon** — Levies open booms and mouths when it flies. *The pennon is torn from a captured ship. Fly it proudly—or else.*
- A **Storm-Oath Clause** — Temporary exception to any sea-law, sealed. *The clause is whispered, never written. The sea hears and obeys—once.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (rights/tokens/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea-omens**—horns on wind, white horses on swell, verse unfinished until landfall.

Additional Features

- **Storm-Oaths:** Every raid or voyage sealed by oath to sea and storm. Break one, invite the sea’s judgment.
- **Skald’s Burden:** Verses are law, history, curse. A poor rhyme can damn a crew as surely as a reef.

- **Mist-Dread:** The bravest Linn will not enter the Direwood’s breath or the Valewood’s shade. Even the Sea-Queen pales at the Ninth Bell of the Mistlands.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Draugr Jarl (Unfinished Business):** The Thing-Holm is haunted by a jarl who died before his oath was fulfilled. He rises when a storm-oath is broken, demanding a blood-price paid in stories. The Temple of Light has sent three missionaries to lay him to rest; all three drowned in calm water.
- **Saint Adar of the Dawnfire (Oath of Flame & Light):** The Temple of Light’s soft crusade has reached the Linn coast. Missionaries build school-houses and healers’ huts, teaching that oaths sworn by the White Flame are as binding as any storm-oath. The old Sea-Queen tolerates them because they bring iron trade, but the Volva of Mist has warned that the Hollow does not distinguish between faiths.
- **Saint Hervor of the Salted Cord (The Witness):** A Linn skald who swore never to sing a false verse. After she discovered her jarl had faked a raid’s spoils, she composed a *nothing* verse that cursed his line to seven generations. The Sea-Queen keeps Hervor’s runestone at the Thing-Holm; those who lie there hear their own words echo back as mockery.
- **The Tide-Washed Covenant (The Hospice of the Salted Anchor):** A grey-robed healer runs a hospice on the edge of the Mistlands, treating wounded raiders and fog-mad sailors alike. She asks no payment, but she writes every name in a ledger that never dries. Linn captains leave offerings of fresh water before a voyage; those who refuse find their ship plagued by the drowned.
- **The Ninth:** In any longhouse, the ninth horn blown at a feast summons the Hollow. The wise stop at eight. Those who blow the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the high table—waiting to collect a debt.

Linn Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over the gunwale before a voyage. Ignore the first *Black Squall* penalty.
- **Knot the Oar:** Tie a single knot in your oar’s leather grip. Cancel *Keel-Rot Rumor* or take −1 die on your next rowing check (your choice).
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the tide. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Sea-Queen.

Patronage & Power

Among the Linn, power flows through oaths, kinship, and the spoken word. Jarls maintain authority through successful raids and wise judgments, while skalds wield influence through their ability to immortalize deeds in verse—or damn names through satire. The Sea-Queen holds sway over the coastlands, but her rule depends on the respect of the High Jarl and the Thing-speakers who interpret ancient laws.

For the GM: Power in Linn society is fluid and performance-based. Patronage often takes the form of foster-bonds, oar-shares, or raid-truces—each binding the recipient to service and reputation. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, banners, verses) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival jarls issue conflicting claims, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the Thing-holm and harbor gatherings as arenas for social contests, where oaths are sworn and broken.

In Linn society, your word is your bond, and your reputation is your greatest treasure.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **coastal guards** or **rival crews**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **ships** or **harbor watch**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **mist-pilots**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local jarl** or **harbor master** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift** or **reef hazard**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crew** or **levy force** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **ships, warriors, or skalds** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **storm hits/oath invoked/feud declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Sea-Queen, High Jarl, or Volva** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **storm rises/reef shifts/mist closes in**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Linn (Storm-Oaths):** Sudden calm, breaking waves speak names, verses come unbidden to lips.
- **Linn (Mistlands):** Channels shift without sound, voices call from reed-beds, compass spins.
- **Linn (Thing-Law):** Witnesses appear, oaths are demanded, skald begins composing your saga.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your color, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal)

- **The Net-Father (Nine Nets)** — *Phases*: Harbor Favours → Orchestrated Wrecks → Thing Coup. *Cracks*: cut a cord lineage; reveal swapped verdict; survive a staged squall.
- **The Blue Cantor (Brine-Gospel)** — *Phases*: Drownings Called Mercy → Procession at Reef → Tide-Baptism of a Jarl. *Cracks*: relic earplugs, survivor testimony, storm turning against them.

4.18 Midh Ahkaz — “The Violet Gate”

Khatun of the Ring (Ykrul Elder): “The wind carries names, not ledgers. But here, in the shadow of the Oasis Compact, both trade and oaths change hands. Do not mistake our patience for weakness. The grass remembers every hoof that crossed it.”

Vilikari Factor (Night Market Regular): “Ecktoria calls it uncivilized. We call it unbeatable. No tariffs, no seals, no questions. Coin talks. The rest walks.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Midh Ahkaz is not a city of stone—it is a city of felt, iron, and shifting grass. A day’s ride north of the Ecktorian border, it squats on the edge of the Violet Steppe like a patient wolf. Here, the Ykrul, Vilikari, Ostrikeri (their eastern kin from the grassy fringes of this same prairie), and a dozen other peoples gather to trade, haggle, and settle grudges. The air smells of horse sweat, cedar smoke, and the faint copper tang of blood money.

The city has no walls. Instead, rings of tents and caravanserais spiral outward from the central Counting House. At dawn, the grass—tall enough to hide a horse—is cut back. At dusk, the perimeter fires are lit. The colour of the steppe comes from the violet hue of mature grass seeds, which ripen in waves across the prairie. The Ecktorian emissaries call it “the Brink.” Locals call it home.

What you notice first: The constant low drumming of hooves. The way every merchant has a scale on their table. The braids in every horseman’s mane—each knot a story, a debt, a promise.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse the guest-cup. The first pour is courtesy. The second is negotiation. The third is a blood-price unspoken.

Western Steppe vs. Eastern Steppe (GM Sidebar)

The Ykrul divide their world into two great grass seas:

Western Steppe (Violet Prairie): Rolling, fertile, forgiving. The grass grows tall enough to hide a crouched rider, but the land is laced with caravanserais, seasonal wells, and the smoke of permanent camps. This is where Midh Ahkaz sits—the soft underbelly of the steppe, where trade happens and clans winter. The violet seed-heads give the prairie its name.

Eastern Steppe (True Steppe): Vast, dry, harsh. Shared with the Kuvani horse-clans, it stretches east of the Valewood. Grass is shorter, winds are colder, and a rider can see a day’s ride in every direction. The Ostrikeri who appear in Midh Ahkaz are from the eastern fringes of the *Western Steppe*—they speak with a harder accent, braid their horses’ tails differently, and carry bows of horn and sinew, not wood.

Why this matters: A Ykrul from the Eastern Steppe might find Midh Ahkaz almost claustrophobic. A trader from the Violet Prairie might feel lost in the east. Use the contrast to create tension between clans or to flavour foreign visitors.

Regional Mood: Wind, Grass, and Contract

Midh Ahkaz thrives on movement. Caravans arrive from every direction: Ykrul horse-tribes from the deep steppe, Ostrihari mercenaries from the eastern fringes, Vilikari traders from the river towns, and the occasional bold Ecktorian factor with a silver tongue and a hidden dagger. The city’s “law” is the Oasis Compact—a shifting web of seasonal rights, grazing permits, and arbitration courts held under open sky. Disputes are settled by the Bowl (fairness) then the Board (geometry). A broken promise can cost a herd. A kept oath can buy a ford for a generation.

Starting Location: The Violet Bazaar, a sprawling market of felt tents and chalk circles, where horse traders shout over the jingle of brass bridles. A Vilikari merchant with oiled braids hands you a sealed letter. “The Coin-Weigh Tribunal suspects a counterfeit seal. Find the forger before the Grass Moon, or the contract on your head becomes public.”

(Ring/Well/Cairn) The Oasis Well where water shares are drawn; counting pebbles placed on stone ledges; the distant smoke of a Steppe Ranger campfire.

Spades — Places

2. **Violet Bazaar** — Felt stalls, chalk circles, horse traders and rumor merchants.
The chalk circles are for disputes. Step inside and speak truth—or pay in grass.
3. **Coin-Weigh Tribunal** — Tariff court under a canvas dome; scales of bronze and iron. *The scales were blessed by a dying Sky-Speaker. They tip even when the wind is still.*
4. **Oasis Well** — Stone-rimmed pool, token-keeper with a leather bag of water rights.
Each token is a carved pebble. Lose it, and your herd drinks dust.
5. **Steppe Ranger Camp** — Tent line on the eastern edge; trackers, scouts, feud mediators.
The rangers wear wolf tails. They do not smile—they wait.
6. **Caravan Rings** — Concentric circles of wagon shelters; fires lit inward, watch posts on ox carts. *The inner ring is for sworn allies. Outsiders sleep in the second ring, coin in hand.*
7. **Sky-Speaker’s Cairn** — Stone heap atop a low hill; wind-knot ropes and bones.
The shaman leaves offerings of horsehair. The wind carries his prayers to Kuva.
8. **Dust Market** — No-questions auction at the city’s edge; stolen goods, cursed relics, bad memories. *The auctioneer wears a hooded mask. No one knows his face. No one has asked twice.*
9. **Silver Stall Stable** — Remount station; horses for hire, gossip for free, blood for more. *The stable master has three fingers on his left hand. He lost the others in a bet over a mare.*
10. **Grass Ring** — Ritual dueling ground; mourners and bookies share benches. *The grass grows back faster after a duel. The dead fertilize the peace.*

J Foreign Quarter — Ektorian, Vhasian, and Viterran merchants in permanent felt mansions. *The Ektorian envoy winters here. He has not left in five years.*

Q Khatun’s Ring — Largest tent, carpeted with woven battle scenes; the old chieftain’s seat. *The carpet is made of enemy cloaks. Each sash is a surrendered banner.*

K Under-Arcades — Earthen tunnels below the bazaar; root-walled, bone-dusted. *The walls are packed with bone dust and old burrows. The dead whisper route tips.*

A Iron Well — Ancient Aeler shaft, now used for vengeance contracts and whispered names. *The water tastes of rust and memory. Those who drink never lie again—or never speak.*

(Horse/Tally/Token) Sky-Speaker’s apprentice with a drum and a dream; Ostrihari arms-master selling short bows; Ykrul elder counting braids.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Horse-Braid Apprentice** — Young Ykrul with a head full of trade routes and a knot diary. *She ties a new braid for every paying passenger. Her hair is a map of debts.*

3. **Ostrihari Arms-Master** — Selling short bows and longer grudges; fights for coin. *He names each bow after a dead rival. The bows never miss.*

4. **Coin-Weigh Clerk** — Ink-stained, patient, scales in her eyes; never lies, never forgives. *She records weights in blood. A single drop seals a verdict.*

5. **Vilikari Factor** — Braided, oiled, quick with a smile and a second ledger. *His caravan has three names. Only the real one buys safe passage.*

6. **Steppe Ranger** — Tracker with a wolf-tail cloak and a debt to the Sky-Speaker. *He never draws his bow unless watched. Hunger is his real weapon.*

7. **Tokan (Ykrul Scout)** — Mute, sharp-eyed, always smelling the wind; her ears miss nothing. *She signs with her knuckles. Three taps is "danger." One tap is "run."*

8. **Ecktoria Emissary** — Proud, wax-sealed, fuming at the "primitive" customs. *He carries a copy of Imperial Code that he has never opened. The flies love his ink.*

9. **Sky-Speaker’s Shadow** — Elder’s quiet apprentice; listens more than the wind. *She can name every clan’s sky-omen. She cannot name her own origin.*

10. **Knot-Keeper (Tulkani)** — Counts caravan promises with a rope of nine strands. *Each knot is a contract. Untie one and the deal dissolves.*

J Dust Market Auctioneer — Hooded, genderless voice; knows the weight of every sin. *The hammer is a thigh bone. The block is a skull altar from the Direwood.*

- Q **Khatun of the Ring** — Grey-haired, one-eyed, still deadly at sixty; speaks for seven clans. *She lost her eye to a Linn raider. She killed him with his own hook.*
- K **Kuva's Voice (Wandering Priest)** — Weathered, ash-marked, offers omen readings for grass. *He prays to the sky by throwing bones. The bones never lie—they just mislead.*
- A **Iron Well Keeper (Vengeance Broker)** — Mute, scarred, accepts names written in ash. *A drink from the well costs a memory. A death costs a fortune.*

(**Drought/Feud/Blight**) Dry well cuts water rations; blood-price feud spills into the bazaar; locust swarm from the east grains.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Dry Well Ration** — Water shares halved; prices spike, tempers fray. *The token-keeper has a list. The list has a knife mark beside your name.*
 3. **Blood-Price Feud** — A killing in the Horse Ring; kinsmen demand wergild in coin or flesh. *The victim's tribe drums the death rhythm. Every beat is a deadline.*
 4. **Locust Swarm** — Grass blackens; caravans stranded, fodder worthless. *The swarm leaves a sticky residue. It smells of burnt honey and dread.*
 5. **Counterfeit Coins** — Light silver floods the Dust Market; Oasis Compact inquiry. *The counterfeit coins are warm. The real ones are cold. Touch quickly.*
 6. **Grass Fire** — Wind-whipped flame from the east; evacuations, scorched trade paths. *The smoke spells a name. Yours. Or your debtor's. Hard to tell.*
 7. **Horse Sickness** — Contagion at the Silver Stall Stable; quarantines, lost mounts. *The sick horses dream. Their screams sound like your last argument.*
 8. **Khatun's Illness** — Old chieftain fading; succession knives out. *Her death will split seven clans. The Sword Oath lasts one year.*
 9. **Census Raid** — Ecktorian legion patrol "just visiting"; tensions high, bribes higher. *The patrol leader wears a mask of imperial wax. Pull it off and see a dead man's face.*
 10. **Sky-Omen (Red Wind)** — Dust storm from the Ashaani desert; all navigation Desperate. *The dust tastes of iron and old blood. Breathe it and dream of falling.*
- J **Oath Challenge** — A Kon"reh master demands geometry arbitration; your bond is the stake. *The board is a painted skull. The pieces are horse teeth.*
- Q **Tariff Strike** — Coin-Weigh clerks refuse to audit; trade freezes, tempers explode. *The clerks chant a counting rhyme. Stop them before they reach nine.*
- K **Duel for Rights** — Two clans claim the same well; witnesses needed to prove water share. *The duel is fought with blunt spears. First blood wins the well. Both bleed.*

A **Kuva’s Vengeance** — The sky itself turns; hail, lightning, and a voice from the clouds. *The voice names a sinner. Your name. The hail has teeth.*

(Writ/Token/Pass) Grass Right for one season of grazing; Oath-Bead to compel a Kon"reh master’s arbitration.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Grass Right** — One season of grazing on a named meadow; herders pay you tribute. *The right is a branded stick. Burn it to end the lease—or renew.*
 3. **Oath-Bead** — A single knot of horsehair; compels a Kon"reh master to arbitrate your dispute. *The bead grows warm when the master speaks truth. Cold when he lies.*
 4. **Water Share** — Priority access to a well during drought; token from the Oasis Compact. *The token is a polished pebble. Drop it in the well to claim your draw.*
 5. **Steppe Ranger Favor** — One dangerous tracking job resolved off-screen. *The ranger marks your name on his tent pole. He never forgets a favor.*
 6. **Vilikari Voucher** — No-questions cargo space on three caravans; smuggle as you will. *The voucher is a strip of oiled leather. The factor’s scent guides the mules.*
 7. **Census Waiver** — Ecktorian patrol leaves you alone for one crossing; paper shield. *The waiver is stamped with a bear. The bear’s eyes follow you.*
 8. **Khatun’s Whistle** — Summon a small warband once (Cap 3) for a single scene. *The whistle is a hollow horse tooth. Blow it and the grass shivers.*
 9. **Sky-Speaker’s Omen** — One weather forecast that cannot fail; plan your escape. *The omen is a bone thrown into fire. Read the cracks—carefully.*
 10. **Silver Stall Chit** — One free remount exchange; never be horseless. *The chit is a brass hoof. Present it and the stable master nods once.*
- J **Black Ledger Entry** — A written promise from a rival, witnessed by three camp elders. *The entry is written in ash on felt. Wash it and the vow dissolves.*
- Q **Dust Market Cut** — A share of the auctioneer’s commission for a season; wealth in sin. *The cut is paid in mismatched coins. Spend them fast before they curse you.*
- K **Blood-Price Bond** — A criminal clan owes you a life; they will kill once for you or die trying. *The bond is a braid of enemy hair. Cut it to call the debt.*
- A **Seal of the Oasis Compact** — Casting vote on any water right dispute. Once. *The seal is a bronze well with a snake curled at the bottom. Turn it and the water booms.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are narrative permits (grazing rights, oaths, witnesses) that shift Position rather than demand a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **grass and wind** motifs—shifting alliances, debts that ride with the seasons, the sky as witness.
- The violet seed-heads of the steppe are a recurring omen: when they glow under moonlight, a spirit walks; when they shed, a caravan will be late.

Additional Features

- **Kon"reh Arbitration:** Disputes are settled on a board painted on hide. Winners gain seasonal rights. Losers pay in grass or labor.
- **Grass Omens:** The steppe flickers violet when rain is near; when the seed-heads droop at noon, a blood-feud approaches.
- **Khatun's Braid:** The chieftain's hair holds the memory of every oath she swore. Cutting a braid voids a promise.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a "free soup" wagon near the Dust Market. They ask no coin—but they measure your shadow.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Saikou Ira once tracked a ghoul to the Under-Arcades. He left a silver mirror in the wall. It still shows the ghoul's face.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A broken Kon"reh board at the Iron Well is said to compel truth. Players who touch it gain +1 die to resist lies—but mark 1 Obligation to Malachai.
- **The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire:** Midh Ahkaz psions are called "Wind-Readers." They sense lies by the tremor in grass. The Khatun employs two; they never speak to each other.
- **The Ninth:** In any Midh Ahkaz scene, the ninth horse table in the Violet Bazaar sells nothing but bad advice. Spend a Boon to reroll a failed negotiation—but the advice may haunt you.

Midh Ahkaz Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Hoofprint Pour:** Pour a cup of water into the first hoofprint of a new horse. Ignore the first *Horse Sickness* penalty.
- **Braid the Knot:** Tie a strand of mane hair around your wrist. Cancel *Counterfeit Coin* or take –1 die on your next Charisma roll (your choice).

- **Name to the Grass:** Whisper a debtor’s name into the wind at noon. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from them this scene, but mark *Obligation* to a Sky-Speaker.

Patronage & Power in Midh Ahkaz

In Midh Ahkaz, power flows through horseflesh, water rights, and the geometry of oaths. The Khatun rules by consensus, but the true authority rests with the Oasis Compact—a loose council of clan elders, Vilikari factors, and Steppe Rangers who interpret the Wind Law.

For the GM – Actionable Examples:

- A player who wins a Kon"reh match earns a **Grass Right** (Diamond). That right could be contested by a rival clan the very next session—forcing a rematch or a chase across the prairie.
- A **Water Share** token is stolen. The thief leaves a violet seed-head as a signature. Tracking them leads to a seasonal camp where debt is repaid not in coin but in stories.
- The Khatun’s illness (Club) is not natural. A Vilikari factor (Heart) knows the poisoner’s name but demands a **Black Ledger Entry** (J Diamond) in exchange—a dangerous witness the player must then protect.

These hooks turn the generator entries into immediate playable situations.

Thematic SB Spend Table (Midh Ahkaz)

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw attention from **Steppe Rangers** or **Coin-Weigh** clerks.
- **Noise:** The sound carries across the grass; a **rival clan’s scout** overhears.
- **Trace:** Hoofprints, broken grass, or losing an arrow marks your path.
- **Delay:** A water ration takes longer; a horse tires without rest.
- **Grass Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Border riders** converge on your position; a horn sounds.
- **Position Lost:** You lose high ground/cover/the wind due to a **grass fire** or **horse stampede**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **Vengeance broker**, **Ostrikari sell-sword**, or **clan champion** arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A **bridle breaks**, **bow string snaps**, **waterskin leaks**.
- **Oath Hearsay:** A false rumor about your oath reaches the wrong ear.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional horsemen, blood-price hunters, or Dust Market thugs arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A horse goes lame, seal ring cracks, trade ledger burns.
- **Major Twist:** The situation changes – Khatun dies, well runs dry, duel interrupted by grass fire.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** (e.g., Blinded by dust, Parched).

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A hidden pit, poisoned water share, or false oath activates.
- **Authority Arrival:** Khatun’s warband, Ecktorian patrol, Sky-Speaker intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes – grass fire sweeps through, dust storm blinds, night falls without warning.
- **Patron Omen:** A bolide, strange animal, or wind that speaks your name appears.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn – the real forger was your ally; the water right was a trap.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Midh Ahkaz (Grass & Trade):** Grass catches fire, horses spook at shadows, bargains settled with a knife on the table, violet seed-heads floating in the wind.
- **Midh Ahkaz (Oath & Sky):** Clouds spell forgotten names, wind carries false testimony, a duel’s outcome shifts with the sun, a violet dusk signals a spirit.
- **Midh Ahkaz (Horse & Bow):** An arrow splits in flight, a horse refuses a rider, a bowstring sings a dying clansman’s tune, a braid comes undone at the wrong moment.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Counting Circle (cursed scale bound to the Oasis)** — *Phases:* Fair Auditing → Retroactive Drought → Naming of Debtors. *Cracks:* burn a counterfeit token in the Oasis well; settle a seven-clan water debt; let a Sky-Speaker rebless the scale.
- **Grass Reaver (vengeful horse-lord, half-legend)** — *Phases:* Hoof Drum → Ghost Herd → Blood-Price Ride. *Cracks:* confess a broken oath at his cairn; return a stolen foal; outrun him on a borrowed horse.

- **Coin-Weigh Wraith (greedy merchant who sold his shadow)** — *Phases*: Tally of the Lost → Ledger Chain → Crack the Seal. *Cracks*: pay a forgotten wergild; break his contract with a witnessed error; let the Iron Well drink his name.

4.19 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

Legate of Mists (Elite): “The bells here do more than mark time – they weave the very fabric of reality, keeping the mist at bay and the dead in their proper places. Each chime is a thread in the pattern that holds the world together.”

Salt-Monk (Commoner): “Salt don’t just preserve the fish – it holds back the things that shouldn’t walk. Every grain blessed is a prayer, and every prayer keeps the mist from remembering your name.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Mistlands lie north of the Aelerian mountains, where the Aberderrin Sea laps against reed-fens and drowned shores. To the west, the Direwood breathes; to the east, the salt tides of the Aberderrin. It is a Protectorate of the Aeler, but their iron passes only hold the southern roads—the land itself belongs to fog and bells. Every levee hums with ward-notes, every ferry takes salt as tithe, and every shadow is measured against the Direwood’s endless breath. The people here live by the weight of salt, the echo of bells, and the hope that their names will not be spoken by the mists.

What you notice first: The constant, distant chime of bells—never quite in sync. The taste of salt on your lips even inland. The way everyone holds their breath when crossing a bridge.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you.

Regional Mood: Bells and Breath

Here, breath is currency and silence a sin. Every exhalation is counted by the ward-bells, and every stolen inhalation feeds something that should not be. The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with ledgers and patrols, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

Starting Location: A Bell-Line levee veiled in fog, where bell-ropes sway though no wind stirs, and each ring tastes like a heartbeat. A Ferryman demands a name as toll. When the party hesitates, a Bell-Warden steps forward. “The Ninth Bell rings tonight. Will you answer—or flee?”

Prominent NPCs of the Mistlands

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
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Legate Halvar	Aeler governor of the Protectorate	Keep the bell-lines intact and the grain flowing east	She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.
Mother Anja	Salt-Monk of the White Pans	Preserve the old wards against the Direwood	Her tongue is white with salt; she speaks only in blessings or silence.
Warden Kael	Bell-Warden of the High Line	Protect his village from the mist and the Aeler tax-men	He refuses to write down the ninth note; it lives only in his fading memory.
Sister Darya	Healer of the Grey Hospice of the Unnamed (Temple of Light)	Tend the fog-sick and the drowned	Her grey robes never stain, and she asks no payment—only a name for her ledger.
Notary Voss	Covenant judge (Mykkiel)	Impose Aeler law on local customs	He carries a water-clock to measure the shifting of legal moods. The mist ignores it.
The Ferryman	Oath-ferryman of the Ghost Slip	Collect fares in salt and whispered names	His left hand is always gloved; underneath, the names are carved into his palm.

Names of the Mistlands

Inspired by the coastal fens and the Aeler protectorate: clipped, breathy, with soft vowels and hard endings. Surnames often denote a marsh, a craft, or a ward.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Halvar		Anja	Foss	<i>the Bell-Sworn</i>
Kael		Darya	Mork	<i>Fog-Born</i>
Voss		Elara	Saltvedt	<i>the Unnamed</i>
Torben		Lise	Kyst	<i>Breath-Thief</i>
Stian		Ragna	Dyrep	<i>Ward-Keeper</i>
Vidar		Signe	Tangen	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(**Fen/Levee/Bell-line**) Reed-fen causey with chalked ward-runes on every milestone; Bell-Line levee with iron posts and eight bells per span.

Spades — Places

- Reed-Fen Causey** — Chalked ward-runes on every milestone; safe path through the mist. *Step only on the chalked stones. The mud between has no bottom.*
- Bell-Line Levee** — Iron posts, eight bells per span; one bracket empty, one note forbidden. *The empty bracket is for the bell that never rings. The rope is still there.*
- Ghost-Ferry Slip** — Rope crosses black water; fares paid in salt and whispered names. *The ferryman never blinks. Some say he traded his eyelids for the right to collect.*
- Pall Watch-Tower** — Piles above mire; mirrors face west to the Direwood’s breath. *The mirrors are silvered on both sides. The wardens watch their own reflections as much as the trees.*
- Mist-Chapel** — Stilted planks; votive lanterns gutter under damp rafters. *The icon has no face. Worshippers say it lost its features to the fog, one by one.*
- Dead-Cut Canal** — Old imperial ditch; patrolled by eel boats and law. *The eels have eyes like men. Fishermen throw back any that blink.*
- Drowned Copse** — Root-tangles clutch tide like old hands; bones in the bark. *The trees were planted on a mass grave. They grew twisted, hungry.*
- Fogmill Ridge** — Wind vanes vanish into cloud; gears hiss like prayers to fog. *The miller grinds salt, not grain. His customers pay in breath, not coin.*
- Salt-Pan Terraces** — Patched with peat; ward-salt dries under nets, watched by monks. *The monks chant without ceasing. If they stop, the salt spoils—and so does the warding.*

- J **Fort-Stair** — Stacked timber and stone; flags swallowed by mist, guards by routine. *The flags are changed daily. The ones that vanish are never spoken of again.*
- Q **Witchlight Bridge** — Over black runnel; ninth plank “counted” but unseen. *The missing plank is there—you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all.*
- K **High-Mist Pass** — Through Aelerians; cairns ringed in iron nails, bells in the stones. *Each cairn holds a bell that rang once at the death of a warden. They ring again when mist takes another.*
- A **Weeping Gate** — Western palisade facing Direwood; bells wired to bones of trees. *The gate weeps sap that smells of iron and old grief. Wardens collect it in silver cups.*

(**Warden/Ferryman/Aeler**) Bell-warden whose ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts; oath-ferryman collecting fares in salt and names.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Reed-Cutter** — Peat-black hands, precise opinion on fog; knows every safe path. *She cuts reeds in a pattern—one snip, two snips, then a pause for the ninth.*
 3. **Salt-Monk** — Blesses pans, keeps ward-measure honest; salt as both shield and vow. *His tongue is white with salt. He speaks only in blessings or silence.*
 4. **Bell-Warden** — Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay. *She refuses to write down the ninth note. It lives only in her memory—and that memory is fading.*
 5. **Oath-Ferryman** — Fares in salt and names; remembers both, collects both. *His left hand is always gloved. Underneath, the names are carved into his palm.*
 6. **Lantern Acolyte** — Trims wicks and arguments; light as law in the mist. *He carries a bell on his belt. It rings once for each lie he hears.*
 7. **Mist-Pilot** — Linn refugee; ghosts ships through reed-lace—if paid in breath. *She never speaks above a whisper. Her voice is currency, and she spends it carefully.*
 8. **Protectorate Clerk** — Aeler oilskin ledgers, narrow smile; law in triplicate. *His stamp is a bell. He presses it twice—once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
 9. **Shroud-Diver** — Harvests tokens from drowned fields before dawn’s false light. *He wears a bell around his ankle. If it rings, he’s stayed too long.*
 10. **Direwood Refugee** — Cold breath, colder stories; knows what the trees whisper. *She carved out her own tongue. The trees still speak through her—in a voice not her own.*
- J **Fog-Knight** — Cavalry rides levee crowns by bellcode; mist as their steed. *Their horses have no shadows. Some say they traded them for fog-sight.*

Q Legate of Mists — Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree, bells at their command. *She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.*

K Lord Warden — Local strong hand sworn to Legate’s seal; law walks the fens. *He lost an eye to a wight. He wears a bell in the socket.*

A Mist-Seer — Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks. *She has no shadow. The mist took it as a down payment.*

(Undead/Weather/Law) Ground-mist lifts off fen and eats tracks by the yard; witch-lights try to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets you.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Lifts from fen; eats tracks by the yard, names by the breath. *Your footfalls vanish behind you. The mist is following, not rising.*

3. **Witchlight Count** — Trying to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets your path. *The lights flicker in a pattern—two short, two long. They’re signaling someone.*

4. **Ward-Salt Short** — Pans go green; bells ring, nothing answers from the other side. *The salt is grey, not white. Someone cut it with grave dust.*

5. **Wrong Bell** — Cracked note opens a door the Legate can’t close; mist takes the gap. *The bell’s clapper is a finger bone. The original owner wants it back.*

6. **Linn Raid** — Slips reed-maze; hearths douse, horns travel on the fog. *The raiders wear bells on their belts—stolen from the last village.*

7. **Direwood Moan** — At dusk; Weeping Gate ropes go taut by themselves. *The moan has words. You don’t want to understand them.*

8. **Valewood Wind** — Crosses Aberderrin; voices sweet, landmarks false. *The wind smells of honey and rot. Do not follow it.*

9. **Bell-Line Failure** — Levee breaks silence; wraith steps across like it owns the road. *The wraith carries a lantern. The light is blue—the color of drowned breath.*

10. **Marsh-Quake** — Sod heaves, dyke slumps; proofs and bodies sink together. *The ground exhales. Your name rises from it like smoke.*

J Protectorate Interdiction — All ferries sealed “until review”; routes dry up. *The seals are stamped with a bell. The wax is mixed with bone ash.*

Q Rite-Purge — Inspectors call local customs heresy; tempers at a boil. *The inspectors carry blank ledgers. They fill them with names of the accused.*

K General Alarm — Pall horns sound; every lantern becomes law, every shadow suspect. *The horns are made from the tusks of a sea beast. The beast’s ghost is angry.*

A **Tide-Mist** — Rolls from Aberderrin; spirits ride the white and won’t be named.
The spirits have no faces—only the faces of the drowned.

(Pass/Seal/Token) Ward-salt allotment draws safe circle once; ferry token crosses named black runnel regardless of curfew.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ward-Salt** — Pure measure draws safe circle once; mist parts, briefly. *The salt is warm. It knows it will be used.*
 3. **Ferry Token** — Cross named black runnel regardless of curfew or tide. *The token is a knuckle bone. The ferryman accepts it without comment.*
 4. **Bell-Key** — Unlock and set one bell on the Line to your note; change the song. *The key is a tuning fork. Strike it once to claim your note.*
 5. **Lantern Writ** — Lawful travel at night along levee crown with escort. *The writ is written on dried bladder. It crinkles when you lie.*
 6. **Exorcist’s Seal** — Stamped clause downgrades “haunt” to “nuisance.” *The seal is a bell without a clapper. It’s silent, like the wraiths it binds.*
 7. **Codeleaf** — Today’s mirror and horn sequences; fog cannot hide what you know. *The leaf is soaked in brine. Read it before it dries.*
 8. **Protectorate Mark** — Priority rations and rope from Fort-Stair stores. *The mark is a brand. It smokes when you show it.*
 9. **Wraith-Indemnity** — Legal immunity for actions taken under apparition threat. *The indemnity is signed in salt water. It will dissolve if you misuse it.*
 10. **Bone-Field License** — Salvage rights at drowned hamlet (with witnesses). *The license is a map drawn on a shroud. Follow the stitch marks.*
- J **Refuge-Right** — Move a named household through Gate unchallenged; breath as passport. *The right is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt. Nonna will ask.*
- Q **Legate’s Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; bells ring your decree. *The Legate’s ear is a silver bell. Speak into it once.*
- K **Warden’s Commission** — Raise levee guards; local doors open, purses too. *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the fens answer.*
- A **Pall Indulgence** — Temporary exception to ward law, spoken and sealed by bell. *The indulgence is a single bell-note, held in a jar. Break the jar to release it.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/seals/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **breath and boundary**—bells answering across water, salt that won’t dry, voices returning late.

Additional Features

- **Breath-Toll:** Many claim the mist remembers every breath. Travelers hold breath crossing bridges, fearing the mist will count them wrong.
- **Salt as Promise:** A handful of salt is more than warding—it is a vow. Spill it on plank or stone to swear safety; break that vow, and invite the Direwood’s claim.
- **The Ninth Bell:** Legends say a ninth bell once rang on the Line. The note is not in any ringbook; no warden speaks of it. Some nights, though, it rings—and gates open where none should be.
- **Payden’s Port:** The only true city in the Mistlands, huddled on the western coast of the Aberderrin. Its wharves are built from salvaged longship timber, and its law is split between the Aeler Legate’s seal and the old bell-wardens’ traditions. Grain ships leave from its harbour each autumn, carrying the Protectorate’s tithe east—and returning with iron, engineers, and the occasional missionary.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Kael of the Iron Bell (The Sealed Gate):** The bell-wardens venerate a legendary warden who hammered a ninth bell into the Weeping Gate to seal a Direwood breach. The bell cracked, but the breach closed. His chisel is kept at Payden’s Port; it is said to quench the mist for an hour if struck against an iron post. The Aeler Protectorate has tried to confiscate it twice; both attempts ended with the confiscators lost in fog.
- **Saint Anja of the White Pans (Oath of Mercy and Grace):** A salt-monk who died blessing the pans during a tide-mist. Her body never decayed, and her chapel now serves as a hospice for fog-sick sailors. The Temple of Light sends offerings of fresh water each spring; the Everflame considers her a heretic. Pilgrims who pray at her shrine may ask one question of a drowned ancestor—but the answer is always a single word, and that word is a debt.
- **The Grey Hospice of the Unnamed:** Sister Darya runs a hospice near Payden’s Port. She asks no payment, but she records every patient’s name in a ledger that never dries. The Aeler clerks suspect she is erasing debt, not healing wounds. She has been investigated three times; each time, the investigator vanished into the fog and returned with no memory of why they came.

- **The Bell-Ringer’s Covenant (The Keeper of the Silent Seal):** Notary Voss is the Protectorate’s appointed judge, charged with imposing Aeler law on local customs. He carries a water-clock to measure the shifting of legal moods, but the mist ignores it. His rulings are always delivered in triplicate, and the bell-wardens obey them—slowly. Those who lie before him find that their next passage through the Ghost-Ferry Slip is denied; the ferryman refuses to name them.
- **The Ninth:** In any Mistlands scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the mist’s attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count. Those who speak ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the foot of the bed that night—waiting to collect a breath.

Mistlands Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Fog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a bridge. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty.
- **Hold the Ninth Breath:** Cross a threshold while holding your breath. Cancel *Witchlight Count* or take –1 die on your next action (your choice).
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect against undead for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Legate.

Patronage & Power

In the Mistlands, power flows through ritual, warding, and the careful balance between the living and the dead. The Aeler Protectorate maintains nominal control through military presence and legal frameworks, but true authority lies with those who understand the bells, the salt, and the breath of the land itself. Local wardens, salt-monks, and bell-keepers hold sway over daily life, while the Legate of the Mists mediates between imperial law and ancient custom.

For the GM: Patronage in the Mistlands revolves around protection—from mist, from spirits, from the encroaching forest. Rewards often take the form of tokens, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater security. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (salt, bells, lanterns) that can be challenged, depleted, or voided.
- Let rival factions issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the levees, ferries, and watchtowers as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of the old ways determines success.

In the Mistlands, your safety is your standing, and your standing depends on who remembers your name.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fog-knights**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **spirits or patrol boats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Protectorate forces or local warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or bell failure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **wraith, raiding party, or inspector** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fog-knights, spirits, or Aeler forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **bell-line fails/ward broken/mist claims name**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Legate, Lord Warden, or Mist-Seer** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **mist thickens/bells ring/forest breathes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Mistlands (Bells & Breath):** Bells ring without cause, breath forms visible words, mirrors reflect wrong faces.
- **Mistlands (Salt & Warding):** Salt refuses to dry, ward-runes bleed color, protection tokens crack.
- **Mistlands (Direwood Threat):** Trees whisper your name, roots shift position, forest breath grows stronger.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Ninth Bell Ringer (Direwood herald)** — *Phases:* Lost Names → Broken Lines → Open Gate. *Cracks:* restore a ringbook; trade a breath; rehang a forbidden bell with copper nails.
- **Queen of Counting Lights (fae arbiter)** — *Phases:* Courteous Tithes → Geas-Market → Ledger of Leaves. *Cracks:* return stolen way-marks; speak said and meant; gild the iron.
- **Reed-Wolf Captain (Linn raider)** — *Phases:* Smoke Signals → Night Oars → Thing Verdict. *Cracks:* name a feud-token; win a skald-duel; force harbor-truce under bell and banner.

4.20 Silkstrand — “City of Bridges & Silk”

The Matron (Elite): “In this city, every bridge is a contract and every current carries coin. The bargains struck in our shadows never quite fade from memory, and the waters remember every handshake.”

Bobbin-Runner (Commoner): “I can cross this city faster than any grown-up, and I know which planks creak and which merchants lie. The bridges remember every step, and the canals carry more secrets than fish.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Silkstrand is a city strung across canals and arches, a place where every bridge is a contract and every current carries rumor. The silk looms never sleep, the Exchange never closes, and the Archivolt’s notaries seal fates with a drop of wax. Merchants rise and fall with the tide of the market, bravos carve reputations on the planks of Three-Queens Bridge, and the city’s underworld runs on whispers and borrowed keys. The Matron rules from her palazzo stairs with velvet and iron, but the city itself belongs to silk, silver, and shadow.

What you notice first: The clash of water against ancient stone. The constant rumble of cart wheels on bridge planks. The way every handshake lingers a heartbeat too long—as if both parties are checking for hidden clauses.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a rival while crossing a bridge at night. The water remembers, and the curse you send may come back wrapped around your own throat.

Regional Mood: Bridges and Ledgers

Here, fortune is written in ink and sealed in wax. Silkstrand is not lawless—it is *layered*. Above the tide lies the world of guild charters, notarial seals, and the Matron’s velvet justice. Below the bridges, in the weeping arches and the midnight boat lanes, a quieter economy runs on whispers, borrowed keys, and the careful omission of names. The city’s bravos duel for reputation on Three-Queens Bridge while factors bribe clerks in the Archivolt. Every alliance is a knot that can be pulled loose. Every fortune is a thread that can be cut.

Starting Location: Three-Queens Bridge, crowded with market stalls, its stones worn smooth by centuries of footsteps. A Guildmistress with ink-stained fingers offers a customs waiver. “The Exchange boils today,” she says. “And something in the canals remembers your scent. Bring me three bolts of untaxed crimson before the closing bell, or the Archivolt will find your name in a dead notary’s ledger.”

Prominent NPCs of Silkstrand

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
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Matrona Lucia	The Matron, ruler of Silkstrand	Keep the guilds balanced and the treasury full	She has never raised her voice. The city learned to fear her silences.
Guildmistress Elara	Head of the Dyers' Guild	Secure the red dye monopoly	She can tell your guild by the stain on your cuff; she never forgets a color.
Niccolò	Archivolt notary	“Fix” missing recitals for a fee	His inkwell contains a single drop of his own blood. He renews it each spring.
Ravel	Night-boat smuggler	Move cargo that cannot be named	His boat has no name. The canal would remember it, and memory is a kind of tax.
Sister Chiara	Healer of the Weavers of Mercy (The Silk-Shrouded) (Temple of Light)	Run a hospice near the Salt Gate	She asks no payment, but she records every patient's name in a ledger that never dries.
Captain Borso	Condottieri watch captain	Keep the peace between guilds	He wears a mask on feast days; no one has seen his face in seven years.

Names of Silkstrand

Inspired by the mercantile republics of the southern coast: liquid vowels, soft endings, and surnames that recall a bridge, a canal, or a trade.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Lorenzo	Lucia	da Ponte	<i>the Bridge-Wise</i>
Niccolò	Elara	Canaletti	<i>the Unseen</i>
Borso	Chiara	del Forno	<i>Bobbin-Foot</i>
Marco	Fiammetta	Riva	<i>the Silent</i>
Tommaso	Oria	Selci	<i>Red-Handed</i>
Andrea	Zilia	Molin	<i>Ash-Thread</i>

(**Bridge/Canal/Mill**) Mulberry garths and wormhouses outside North Gate with steam and sweet rot; Filature hall where whispers travel faster than steam.

Spades — Places

2. **Mulberry Garths** — Wormhouses outside North Gate; steam, sweet rot, desperate pickers. *The pickers’ hands are stained black. They say the color never fades, even after death.*
3. **Filature Hall** — Cocoon-boil chambers; whispers travel faster than steam. *The steam carries voices from last season. Some say they’re warnings.*
4. **Redwater Dyeworks** — Along stain-canal; brick stained forever with forgotten dyes. *The dye-runners wear lead masks. The ones who don’t die young—or wrong.*
5. **Spindle Tower** — Creaking windlass-lifts and posted rates; heights and hazards. *The lift operator has a bell. He rings it once for every passenger who didn’t pay.*
6. **Three-Queens Bridge** — Stacked market stalls; cells under arches, reputations made and broken. *The cells are for debtors. The walls are washed with canal water so no one forgets the smell.*
7. **Salt Gate Quay** — Rope booms, chalk tallies, tired eyes; customs and coin. *The chalk is mixed with ground bone. A false tally writes itself in a dead hand.*
8. **Silk Exchange** — Floor with chalk circles and clappers for opening bids. *The clappers are whale ribs. The bids echo, and sometimes the echo answers.*
9. **Ropewalk Sheds** — Arrow-straight; bruisers hired by the yard, muscle for hire. *The rope-walkers never look back. They say a rope remembers who pulled it last.*
10. **Old Arsenal** — Free Company’s barracks now; arms and ambitions stored. *The arsenal’s bell rings at odd hours. No one admits ringing it.*
- J **The Archivolt** — Arcaded street of notaries, seals, and quiet knives. *The notaries write in lemon juice. Heat reveals the truth—or a facsimile.*

Q Basilica of Azerin — Weaver-saint; confraternity rooms hum with vows. *The saint’s icon has one eye. The other was traded for the secret of red dye.*

K Palazzo della Matrona — Ruling seat with private river stairs; velvet and iron. *The Matrona’s barge is rowed by debtors who have repaid in years, not coin.*

A Flood-Stairs — Bronze flood marks, bell rope ready when the Strand runs wild. *The flood marks go up to nine. The ninth step is underwater—always.*

(Guild/Factor/Crown) Bobbin-runner child with feet sure on parapets; foreign factor seeking warehouse and friend at customs.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bobbin-Runner** — Child with sure feet on parapets, rumors in pocket. *She ties a knot in her apron string for every secret she carries. The apron is nearly solid knots.*

3. **Mulberry Steward** — Counting leaves; desperate for pickers, quick with coin. *His left hand is missing two fingers—lost to a cocoon-rot curse. He calls it a bargain.*

4. **Foreign Factor** — Seeking warehouse and friend at customs; connections for sale. *He carries three ledgers. One for the Matron, one for the Archivolt, one for himself.*

5. **Guildmistress** — Dyers’ hands stained, permits tighter than purse strings. *She can tell your guild by the stain on your cuff. She never forgets a color.*

6. **Bridge Bailiff** — Rents stalls, sells gossip by the breath; power in position. *He rings a small bell before each announcement. The tone tells you if it’s truth or theater.*

7. **Archivolt Notary** — “Fixes” missing recitals—for a donation; law as service. *His inkwell contains a single drop of his own blood. He renews it each spring.*

8. **Watch Captain** — Condotta to three lords; passwords change with the wind. *He wears a mask on feast days. No one has seen his face in seven years.*

9. **Spinner-Matron** — Wormhouses; temper like hot copper, secrets in the steam. *She names each cocoon after a dead rival. The silk is said to carry their complaints.*

10. **Exchange Caller** — A clap can still a thousand voices; auction master. *He lost his voice to a curse. Now he claps in a language only the bids understand.*

J Night-Boat Smuggler — “Ravel,” silent oar, louder favors; shadows for coin. *His boat has no name. The canal would remember it, and memory is a kind of tax.*

Q The Matron — Patient, velvet, iron; the city’s thread pulled through her hands. *She has never raised her voice. The city learned to fear her silences.*

K Lame King’s Envoy — Velvet boots; claims certain alleys “protected.” *His cane is hollow. Inside is a letter of marque that expired a decade ago.*

A Saint of Warps — If real: sees curses braided in cloth; holy unraveler. *Her eyes are milk-white. She sees not the cloth, but the threads of obligation within.*

(Flood/Interdict/Riot) Flood siren with gates lowering—move crates or kiss them goodbye; quarantine flag at Redwater sealing dyers’ row.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Flood Siren** — Gates lowering; move crates or kiss them goodbye to tide. *The gate-keeper’s palm is marked with a bell. Cross it with silver to hurry.*
 3. **Quarantine Flag** — Redwater dyers’ row sealed; your cargo implicated. *The flag is dyed with lamp-black and something else—something that smells of graves.*
 4. **Loom Strike** — Over “bad cocoons”; streets fill with idle frames. *The striking weavers wear red threads around their wrists. They will not speak first.*
 5. **Seal Counterfeit** — Discovered at Archivolt; all contracts frozen. *The forged seal is warm. The real one is cold. Touch both to know which is which.*
 6. **Bridge Riot** — A dropped stall blocks lanes; tempers boil faster than vats. *The riot started over a missed bell-ring. Or a stolen bolt. Or a look.*
 7. **Condottieri Flip** — Colors change; watchwords shift, escorts vanish. *The captain’s new banner is stitched with thread from his old captain’s shroud.*
 8. **Blackwood Panic** — Witch-posts hammered on quay doors overnight. *The posts are from the Direwood edge. They sweat sap that smells of old fear.*
 9. **Fungus Blight** — Silk-fungus; wormhouses burn, refugees flood piazze. *The fungus glows faintly in the dark. It spells names—sometimes yours.*
 10. **Salt-Tax Doubled** — At Salt Gate; boats stack three deep, bribes flow. *The tax collector wears a mask. Beneath it, his face is a salt-caked skull.*
- J **Duel Challenge** — Booked on Three-Queens Bridge; you’re named as seconds. *The challenge is written on silk. Burn it to refuse—and lose face forever.*
- Q **Exchange Corner** — Rivals hoard raw thread; prices go vertical. *The cornering merchant has a ledger bound in human skin. The names inside are his competitors.*
- K **Saint’s Procession** — Closes half the wards; ignore at peril, faith walks the streets. *The icon weeps dyewater. The faithful collect it in silver cups.*
- A **Curse Awakened** — In canals: no route reaches the address you seek. *The water is still. Your reflection is gone. You are still here—for now.*

(Permit/Seat/Escort) Bridge token for peak-hour cart crossing free; dye-permit chit to process “questionable” color this week.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bridge Token** — One peak-hour cart crossing free; traffic as currency. *The token is a bronze coin with a hole in the center. The hole is the toll.*
3. **Dye-Permit** — Process “questionable” color this week; law bends for coin. *The permit is written on dyed vellum. The color changes with the tide.*
4. **Warehouse Seal** — From Matron’s office; rivals legally shut out. *The seal is a brass bell. Ring it once to claim the space.*
5. **Exchange Pass** — Day pass to trade without sponsor; freedom in paper. *The pass is stamped with a spider. The spider’s legs are the signatures of three guilds.*
6. **Watergate Priority** — Skip one flood closure when it matters; tide waits for none. *The priority token is a dried eel skin. Show it, and the gate-keeper spits but stands aside.*
7. **Notarial Indulgence** — Retrofit a missing recital; past deals stand. *The indulgence is written in lemon juice. Heat it to see the terms.*
8. **Wormhouse Allotment** — Claim a share of the next hatch; future in cocoons. *The allotment is a silk-worm egg. Keep it warm, or it will hatch into a debt.*
9. **Ropewalk Credit** — Hire crews before you have coin; muscle on credit. *The credit is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each favor called.*
10. **Arsenal Key** — One night’s issue for retinue; arms in trusted hands. *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist.*
- J **Condotta Rider** — City watch escorts through any ward, once. *The rider’s horse has iron shoes. The sparks tell him who to watch.*
- Q **Matron’s Audience** — Private whisper becomes policy; velvet commands. *The Matron’s ear is a bell. Speak into it, and the city listens—once.*
- K **Tax-Farm Share** — On Three-Queens stalls for a season; profit in peddlers. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your portion.*
- A **Golden Thread** — Temporary charter to set tolls on a named canal. *The thread is real gold. It will not break—but it will stretch.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (permits/seats/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **silk and water** motifs—threads that bind, currents that remember, bargains that stain the ledger.

Additional Features

- **Duel Etiquette:** Duels fought on bridges draw crowds eager to wager on blood. Refusing stains a name worse than losing.
- **Canal Omens:** Canals run strange colors at dawn; red foretells riots, blue brings calm, black means a curse has awakened.
- **Matron’s Seal:** Any contract bearing her seal is law—but the Matron is known to rescind seals without warning, leaving debts tangled.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Lazarus of the Unfinished Ledger (The Witness):** The Archivolt notaries keep a sealed archive of *unwritten contracts*—promises that were never stamped. The Order of the Witness claims that reading even one of these binds the reader to fulfil it. The Matron has never opened the archive. The Red Clerk has, and his inkwell is now a skull.
- **Saint Fina of the Dyed Veil (Isoka):** The Basilica of Azerin has a side chapel dedicated to the *Shedding Saint*, whose mosaic shows a silkworm breaking its cocoon. Pilgrims who leave a confession there wake the next morning having forgotten one sin—but also one kindness they received. The Guildmistress permits the chapel because the offerings keep the dyers’ guild solvent.
- **The Weavers of Mercy (The Silk-Shrouded):** A hospice near the Salt Gate is run by grey-robed healers who ask no payment. They are tolerated because they treat wounded condottieri for free, but the Black Purse faction suspects they also erase debts—ledgers left near their doors have been found blank. The Order’s rule: “You do not pay back. You pay forward. But woe to the one who strikes a healer.”
- **The Ledger of Unbroken Promises (The Syndicate Seal):** A small but influential order of notaries based in the Archivolt. They adjudicate disputes over contracts, cargo claims, and bridge tolls. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes—only binding oaths. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three shipments are impounded.
- **The Ninth:** In any Silkstrand scene, the ninth bridge crossed in a day leads somewhere unexpected. The wise stop at eight and take a boat. Those who cross the ninth are said to hear a faint laugh from the water—and their contracts are never quite fulfilled.

Silkstrand Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Canal:** Toss a crust into the water before crossing a new bridge. Ignore the first *Bridge Riot* penalty.
- **Knot the Thread:** Tie a single knot in a scrap of silk. Cancel *Seal Counterfeit* or take −1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Water:** Whisper a debtor’s name into the canal at dawn. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from them this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Archivolt.

Patronage & Power

In Silkstrand, power flows through commerce, connections, and the careful weaving of influence. The Matron maintains control through a web of guilds, factors, and condottieri, each bound by contracts and customs that shift like the tides. Merchants rise and fall with the Exchange, while the city’s bravos and smugglers operate in the spaces between law and profit.

For the GM: Patronage in Silkstrand revolves around access—to bridges, to warehouses, to the Exchange floor itself. Rewards often take the form of permits, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, tokens, contracts) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds issue conflicting charters, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the bridges, markets, and Exchange as arenas for social contests, where reputation and connections determine success.

In Silkstrand, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you rise or drown.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city watch** or **rival merchants**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds** or **bridge traffic**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **customs**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Bridge bailiff** or **guildmaster** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement** or **flood**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival merchant** or **hired bravo** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **condottieri**, **smugglers**, or **guild enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **flood hits/contract voided/duel declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** The **Matron**, **Watch Captain**, or **Guildmistress** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **flood rises/bridge collapses/procession blocks streets**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Silkstrand (Bridges & Trade):** Bridge planks shift underfoot, bargains restructure mid-speech, coins change hands without touch.
- **Silkstrand (Canals):** Water levels rise without warning, gondolas block routes, a sudden fog hides a rival’s approach.
- **Silkstrand (Duel Culture):** Challenges are issued mid-conversation, seconds appear from the crowd, honor prices rise with each breath.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Corseted Ledger (cursed accounting bound in silk)** — *Phases:* Friendly Audit → Retroactive Debts → Names as Collateral. *Cracks:* burn one forged seal in public; settle a rival’s debt at cost; wash the book on Flood-Stairs at high bell.
- **Archivolt Ragman (collector of “missing recitals”)** — *Phases:* Quiet Inserts → Paper Hunts → Bridge Vetoes. *Cracks:* win a duel for precedent; expose a double-entry altar; break his pen with the Matron’s Seal.
- **Color That Walks (dyewater revenant)** — *Phases:* Stain → Spread → Drown. *Cracks:* confess on Three-Queens; bind scent-rights properly; let the Saint of Warps unpick a life’s thread (costly).

4.21 Theona — “Three Greens, No Ninth”

Matron of Wells (Elite): “The wells here hold more than water – they hold the dreams and prayers of generations. To govern is to tend these sacred spaces where the living commune with what came before.”

Peat-Cutter (Commoner): “The land here remembers everything, especially what you don’t say. Skip the ninth step, forget the ninth name, and the green earth takes note. Best keep your omissions honest.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The isles of Theona rise green and jagged from the Dolmis, their basalt cliffs wrapped in mists and moorland song. Nominally a duchy sworn to Viterra, in truth the Three Greens heed no crown but their own moots, no law but their taboos. The greatest of these is the silence of Nine: no bell tolls a ninth, no bridge counts that span, no oath dares its syllable. It is said that those who break the ban invite the Green Host, and that debts of nine can never be paid in coin.

What you notice first: The smell of wet peat and salt. The silence that follows every eighth bell-ring. The way locals count on their fingers—thumb, then fingers, then a long pause where the ninth should be.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never pour the ninth cup at a feast. Never speak the ninth name in a bargain. Never step where a step is missing. The Green Host rides for those who complete what should remain incomplete.

Regional Mood: Three Greens, No Ninth

Here, peace is a ritual, and every word sharpens the blade that seals it. Theona is claimed by Viterra but ruled by moots, well-keepers, and the old faith. Linn longships cut through the fog for raiding; Ashaani slavers hunt the coves in stolen coracles; pirates from Zakov and the Vilikari shore trade stolen goods for kelp and salt. Sidhi sailors and Aelinnel factors run cargo up the tide-stairs, and Aelaerem hedge-wives barter red thread for hawthorn passes. Through it all, the Ninth Taboo threads every handshake, every toast, every whispered prayer. To break it is to invite the Green Host—and the Host does not bargain.

Starting Location: A Moot Hill under rain, where vows are carved into stone and knives gleam beside the altar. A Bride-Peacemaker draws a blade between two bloodlines. “The ninth vow was never spoken,” she says. “But the Green Host remembers. Bring us the head of the slaver who burned the eastern strand, and the feud will end. Fail, and your name will join the uncounted.”

Prominent NPCs of Theona

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Matron Eithne	Keeper of the Sacred Wells	Preserve the old ways against Viterran encroachment	She drinks only from the ninth well—the one no one admits exists.
King Conall	Three-Isles King (elected by the moots)	Balance the demands of Viterra with the taboos of the Green Host	He lost his left hand to a Linn raid; the replacement is carved from hawthorn.
Brid	Bride-Peacemaker	End feuds before the Green Host rides	Her knife has a wooden blade; families cut their palms with wood—blood without iron.
Sister Cera	Missionary of the Temple of Light	Convert the islanders to the White Flame	She preaches in the old tongue and leaves offerings at hawthorn groves; the locals are not sure whether she is a saint or a heretic.
Brother Iarlath	Everflame inquisitor (Ecktoria)	Purge the ‘pagan’ taboos and impose imperial orthodoxy	He carries a censer that never cools, but it smokes green in the fog.
The Lady Beneath	Dream-queen of the hollow hills	Keep the old bargains and collect the ninth name	She has no face; those who see her forget their own names for a year.

Names of Theona

Inspired by the green isles of the western sea: soft consonants, melodic vowels, and surnames that evoke a hill, a well, or a sacred grove.

First (Male) Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Conall	Eithne	O'Malley	<i>the Ninth</i>
Cormac	Brid	Mac Gowan	<i>Well-Sworn</i>
Iarlath	Cera	Ó hAodha	<i>Hawthorn</i>
Turlough	Riona	Ó Braonáin	<i>the Uncounted</i>
Lorcán	Máire	Ó Dálaigh	<i>Fog-Born</i>
Finán	Gobnait	Ó Cuilinn	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Ringfort/Well/Cliff) Basalt tide-stairs cut into cove; everyone steps past a “missing” rung; Saint’s Well under hawthorn hung with ribbons.

Spades — Places

2. **Tide-Stairs** — Basalt steps into cove; everyone skips the “missing” rung. *The missing step is still there—you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all.*
3. **Saint’s Well** — Under hawthorn hung with ribbons and secrets; wishes tied in cloth. *The ribbons are knotted in eights. The ninth knot is never tied—only imagined.*
4. **Fog-Wick Tower** — Burning peat; bell plays eight notes, never nine. *The bell-ringer wears a mask. Underneath, he has no mouth—only a whisper.*
5. **Black Bog Causeway** — White stones like teeth; will-lights test your stride. *The stones were set by a king who drowned. He counts each footstep from below.*
6. **Cliff Ringfort** — Over kelp-nets; storm-ladders creak like hymns. *The ladders are hauled up at dusk. If you’re left below, you sleep with the tide.*
7. **Barrow Field** — Standing stones; birds hush at noon, the earth remembers. *The stones have ears. Do not speak a secret you cannot afford to lose.*
8. **Sea-Cave Harp** — Tide-ropes sing under headland; echoes bargain for safe passage. *The harp has no player. It plays itself when the drowned want to speak.*
9. **Uncounted Bridge** — Nine-arch causeway; locals tally “eight-and-one.” *The ninth arch is there—but the locals will deny it. Walk it at your own risk.*
10. **Ogham Grove** — Carved pillars around an absent ninth post; runes speak in silence. *The missing post was removed by a king who broke a vow. The runes still curse his line.*

J **Coracle Harbor** — Jammed in a notch; upturned boats roof the sheds. *The coracles are made of hide and guilt. Each one has carried a secret.*

Q **Green Moot Hill** — Three Greens’ court; benches of turf, salt wind judges. *The wind never stops. It carries the votes of the dead.*

K **High Hall** — Whale-rib beams; storm banners sleep, kings are chosen. *The kings are chosen by lot—a knotted cord pulled from a pot. The cord has eight knots.*

A **Lookout Cliff** — One vantage where all three isles stand in a single gaze. *From here, you can see the Green Host riding on the horizon—if it wants you to.*

(Moot/Keeper/Court) Peat-cutter with steady barrow and steadier gossip; well-keeper who ties ribbons and unknots feuds.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Peat-Cutter** — Steady barrow, steadier gossip; knows every hidden path. *Her barrow has a false bottom. She hides debts there—and bodies.*

3. **Well-Keeper** — Ties ribbons, unknots feuds; wishes and wisdom in equal measure. *She never ties a ninth ribbon. The ninth wish is always her own.*

4. **Kelp-Netter** — Reads rip lines like ledgers; tide as teacher. *His net has a torn patch. He sewed it with thread from a hanged man’s shirt.*

5. **Harp-Satirist** — A few bars can end a career or a war; music as a weapon. *Her harp is strung with catgut and grudges. Each string is a name.*

6. **Wick-Warden** — Tends fog-lamps, counts in eights; guardian of the silent count. *He counts on his fingers—thumb, finger, finger, finger—and stops. The ninth is for the fog.*

7. **Taboo-Witness** — Geas-keeper who knows which words ruin deals. *She carries a bell with no clapper. She rings it with her tongue.*

8. **Island Abbot** — Saint’s bell, tolerant smile; faith in the old ways. *His bell rings eight times. The ninth ring is the silence that follows.*

9. **Green Neighbor** — Polite emissary from under the hill; borrowed boots, strange customs. *He never steps on a crack. He says the earth has teeth.*

10. **Coracle-Captain** — Eight-boat flotilla; swift as rumor, sure as the tide. *Her boats have no names. She says naming a vessel invites the Green Host to count it.*

J **Bride-Peacemaker** — Walks between bloodlines with a silver knife; peace in marriage. *Her knife has a wooden blade. The families cut their palms with wood—blood without iron.*

Q **Matron of Wells** — Queen-mother in truth if not in name; wisdom in water. *She drinks only from the ninth well—the one no one admits exists.*

K **Three-Isles King** — Elected by the moots; whale-bone throne, weathered eyes.
He lost his left hand to a Linn raid. The replacement is carved from hawthorn.

A **Lady Beneath** — Unseen queen who bargains in dreams; hawthorn’s whisper.
She has no face. Those who see her forget their own names for a year.

(Fog/Feud/Taboo) Ground-mist erases tracks; horns travel, edges do not; bog-lights lure teamster off the causeway.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Erases tracks; horns travel, edges do not; navigation by sound alone.
The mist has a voice. It whispers your name—but only once.

3. **Bog-Lights** — Lure teamster off the causeway; recovery costs time and pride. *The lights are the souls of debtors. Follow them, and you’ll never pay your way out.*

4. **Spoken Geas** — No ninth word in parley—or the deal curdles like milk. *The word you cannot speak sits on your tongue like a stone.*

5. **Salt-Rot** — Smokehouse fails; fish spoil, tempers rise like the tide. *The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard.*

6. **Procession Clash** — Saint-day vs. hawthorn taboo; shutters slam, peace fractures. *The saint’s banner and the green branch cannot touch. When they do, blood follows.*

7. **Wave-Count** — Eighth swell, Nameless follows; boats tremble, sailors pray. *The ninth swell never comes. But something rides the eighth.*

8. **Ringfort Wakes** — A bone-judge is “consulted”; now you’re named in the old law. *The bone-judge’s skull is filled with peat smoke. It speaks in riddles—and judgments.*

9. **Ninth Law** — Something vital cannot be counted, measured, or named. *You try to count your crew. The number keeps changing.*

10. **Net-Surge** — Harbor stairs; kelp wraps ankles and alibis like truth. *The kelp moves against the current. Someone underneath is pulling.*

J **Bride-Theft** — At Moot—peace flips to feud; you’re caught mid-ritual. *The stolen bride’s hand is cold. She has been dead for a year.*

Q **Mainland Return** — Exile with papers; elders arrested “for progress.” *The papers are stamped with a Viterran seal. The seal is still warm—and wrong.*

K **Green Host Rides** — Hooves like drums, cattle scatter, sentries sleep. *The riders have no faces—only masks of woven hawthorn.*

A **Great Fog** — Routes loop, bells lie, every promise takes the long way. *The fog is old. It remembers promises made to the dead.*

(**Blessing/Token/Right**) Well-blessing for a named ford crossing; moot token with eight-knotted cord skips local queues.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Well-Blessing** — Named ford crosses you safely, once; water remembers your need. *The blessing is a ribbon. Tie it to your wrist. Do not tie a ninth knot.*
 3. **Moot Token** — Eight-knotted cord; skip any local queue or judgment. *The cord is braided from horsehair and silence. Cut a knot to speak.*
 4. **Harbor-Green** — Painted mark exempts your boat from the next levy; tide as ally. *The mark is a circle with an eighth cut. The missing slice is the toll.*
 5. **Hawthorn Pass** — Immunity from a single local taboo (for one scene). *The pass is a hawthorn twig. Carry it in your mouth. Do not chew.*
 6. **Bell-Right** — Lawful ring at a fog-wick summons the watchers; law travels on sound. *The bell has no clapper. You must ring it with your own breath.*
 7. **Coracle Share** — Crew and oars pledged for one crossing; tide as a steed. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your passage.*
 8. **Ogham Ruling** — Monk’s reading settles a dispute in your favor; runes as law. *The ruling is carved on a slate. The slate is damp. The runes may change by morning.*
 9. **Unnumbered Right** — Ignore the Ninth prohibition for one action (costs a favor later). *The right is a silence. Use it, and the Green Host will ask for its name.*
 10. **Salt-Cure License** — Process scarce fish despite ration edicts; preservation as power. *The license is signed with a thumbprint. The thumb is not yours.*
- J **Bride-Charter** — Two feuding houses sheath knives for a season; peace in marriage. *The charter is written on a wedding veil. The bloodstains are from the dowry.*
- Q **Private Moot** — With Matron and King; whispers become policy. *The moot is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written.*
- K **Whale-Escort** — Eight-oar guards across the Dolmis reach; strength in numbers. *The crew carries your name on a scrap of vellum. If the paper gets wet, you are alone.*
- A **Green Favor** — One uncanny exception to custom, spoken beneath hawthorn. *The favor is a dream. When you wake, the hawthorn will remember—even if you don’t.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (blessings/tokens/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- The “No Ninth” custom: whenever a 9 appears in your seed, add an omission to the scene (a missing step, an unsaid name, an unseen guest). If the 9 is a Diamond, you may break the taboo once—but someone will come to collect later.
- If any A appears, echo **green and count** motifs—hawthorn that whispers, bells that miscount, promises that take the long way home.

Additional Features

- **The Silent Count:** Players and GMs are encouraged to omit a detail (a name, a step, a tally) when the Ninth appears, echoing Theona’s taboo.
- **Green Host’s Omen:** Any dream sequence or omen may be framed as the ride of the Green Host—hoofbeats across the sky, wind through the moors, sea spray tasting of salt and blood.
- **Bride-Peace Feasts:** Weddings, truces, and funerals blur; sharing a feast can end a feud for a season—or doom a guest if the ninth cup is poured.
- **Raider’s Shadow:** Theona’s coves are haunted by Linn longships, Ashaani slave barges, and Zakov pirates. Sidhi and Vilikari sailors crew the coracle fleets, while Aelinnel and Aelaerem traders bring red thread and counting stones from the far shore of the Dolmis.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Bríd of the Unquenched Well (Syncretic):** A local saint venerated by both the Temple of Light and the old well-keepers. Her shrine is a well hung with red ribbons; pilgrims who tie an eighth knot and leave a silver coin may ask one question of the Green Host—but the answer comes in a dream, and the dream always costs a memory. The Everflame calls her a heretic; the islanders call her the Matron’s aunt.
- **Saint Colmán of the Eighth Bell (Oath of Mercy and Grace):** A missionary who tried to convert the isles by ringing a ninth bell. The Green Host took his tongue, and he spent the rest of his life speaking in eights. His hospice still stands near the Fog-Wick Tower; it heals the fog-sick, but every patient leaves unable to count past eight. The Temple of Light venerates him as a martyr; the Everflame has declared his cult anathema.
- **The Covenant of the Counted (The Ninth Seal):** The Viterran claim to Theona is enforced by Covenant judges who travel with Linn mercenaries. They

insist that Viterran law supersedes the Ninth Taboo. The islanders obey—slowly, and with omissions. A judge who tries to count the ninth article of a contract is said to find that the parchment has grown a new fold.

- **The Order of the Unnumbered Cup:** Grey-robed healers run a hospice on the main isle, treating raiders, refugees, and the fog-mad. They ask no payment, but they record every patient’s name in a ledger that never dries. The Matron of Wells allows them because they also tend the sacred wells. The Everflame accuses them of erasing sins; the Temple of Light praises their mercy. They say nothing.
- **The Ninth:** In any Theona scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the Green Host’s attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count. Those who speak ninth are said to see a pale rider on the horizon the next night—and the rider is always one name closer.

Theona Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Bog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a causeway. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty.
- **Knot the Eighth:** Tie a single knot in a ribbon before a moot. Cancel *Spoken Geas* or take –1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into Saint’s Well. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Matron.

Patronage & Power

In Theona, power flows through ancient custom, sacred spaces, and the careful observance of taboo. The Three Greens maintain their independence through a web of moots, well-keepers, and geas-keepers who ensure the old laws are honored. The King and Matron rule by consensus and tradition, while the unseen Lady Beneath influences events through dreams and whispers.

For the GM: Patronage in Theona revolves around blessings, exemptions, and the delicate balance of keeping or breaking taboos. Rewards often take the form of tokens, rights, or divine favor that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (ribbons, tokens, blessings) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival factions issue conflicting exemptions, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the moots, wells, and causeways as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of custom determines success.

In Theona, your word is your weave, and your weave determines whether you walk the green path or invite the Host.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **moot-keepers or well-guardians**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **coracle crews or ringfort sentries**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or green neighbors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Wick-warden or moot official** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or taboo breach**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **feuding house member or bone-judge** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **coracle crews, green neighbors, or moot enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **taboo broken/green host rides/feud declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **King, Matron, or Lady Beneath** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog rises/bells ring/causeway shifts**.

- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Theona (Silent Count):** Steps disappear mid-climb, names vanish from lips, the ninth item in a list goes unmentioned.
- **Theona (Green Host):** Hoofbeats echo without a horse, mist takes familiar shapes, dreams predict the next action.
- **Theona (Taboo Law):** Words refuse to form, actions miscount, promises require exact phrasing.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Unsung Bell (forbidden note given will)** — *Phases:* Hum in Mist → Echo Under Well-stone → Command of Fog. *Cracks:* bind its clapper with eight ribbons; let a rival speak the ninth and pay; drown the echo at the Sea-Cave Harp.
- **Bride-Thief of the Green Host (dream raider)** — *Phases:* Invitation in Sleep → Procession Across Moor → Feast Without Ninth Cup. *Cracks:* cut the dream-veil with silver; sing satire at the Green Moot Hill; trade a Bride-Charter.
- **The Missing Step (living omission)** — *Phases:* Vanished Witness → Unread Clause → Unwalkable Bridge. *Cracks:* invite a Taboo-Witness to count aloud; spill nine drops into Saint’s Well but *name only eight*; let the Lady Beneath keep a memory.

4.22 Thepyrgos — “City of a Thousand Stairs”

The Archon (Elite): “Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky. This city is not built – it is grown, stone by stone, law by law, until the very architecture speaks wisdom.”

Bell-Runner (Commoner): “I know every step that creaks a warning and every landing that whispers gossip. The bells tell the city’s mood better than any lord – three chimes means business, six means trouble, and nine means the hunters are coming.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Thepyrgos is both realm and city, a former Utaran province whose capital rises in tiers of towers, terraces, and endless stairs above the Dolmis shore. Once a military bastion, now a nation unto itself, it is famed for its universities, libraries, and debating synods, where precedent and philosophy weigh as much as pikes or coin. Outside the city, the countryside reflects a rugged coastal landscape of whitewashed villages, olive groves, and timber churches—home to the Hyro people, humans with an unusually high rate of arcane talent. This region is also the land of Canré, a Kon’reh variant that deliberately ignores its historical roots in favor of pure geometry. Ruins of the ancient Astroegro Empire litter the hills—shattered observatories, drowned agoras, and columns carved with impossible angles—whispered to have been sunk by the wrath of Khemesh, the Abyssal Maw, when its last emperor broke a covenant older than the sea.

The Chain-Lantern order and other Witch-Hunter Commissariats ruthlessly patrol the villages and hamlets, using bounty postings, candle-smoke tests, and stair-seizures to identify and kidnap children with arcane talent for the university’s hidden colleges. The enigmatic Witness and the Ninth fight proxy wars via fraternal orders and occult mystery cults, their influence felt in the political maneuvering of the Synod and the mysterious disappearances that plague the countryside. Every stone stair carries the echo of old campaigns and civic quarrels, every bell carries law across the wind. Here, authority climbs as much as it rules: archons elected by the city’s wards, synods decreeing rites and edicts, guilds policing ropes, cranes, and chains. In Thepyrgos, height is hierarchy, sound is sovereignty, and law is etched into every rung.

What you notice first: The endless chime of bells from different tiers, never quite in sync. The smell of brine and olive oil and candle wax. The way locals glance at the sky when a child coughs.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never let a bell-ringer count your breaths. The Chain-Lanterns pay well for names that ring false on the test stairs.

Regional Mood: Stairs, Bells, and Smoke

Here, every ascent is a plea and every descent a confession. Thepyrgos the city is a vertical labyrinth of stair-rights, rope-guilds, and synod edicts that shift with the tide. Thepyrgos the province is a haunted countryside of hidden talent and state-sanctioned abduction. The Hyro keep their arcane children in root cellars and haylofts, praying the hunters take

the neighbor’s instead. The Chain-Lanterns move at dawn, their brass censers swinging, their bells tuned to the frequency of latent magic. In the university’s forbidden tiers, the Witness and the Ninth arm rival fraternities with citations and curses, and no one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks—gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

Starting Location: The Synod Hall at dusk. Gold-glass mosaics glitter as a Matriarch reads a scroll aloud. “The Beacon Crown sees traitors in the smoke. A child’s talent was sold to the Commissary last night. Find the informer—or the next stair seized will be yours.”

Prominent NPCs of Thepyrgos

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Archon Konstantinos	Ruler of the city, elected by the wards	Balance the synod, the guilds, and the Commissariat	He wears a key around his neck; no one knows what it opens.
Matriarch Eleni	Synod primate, head of the Temple of Light’s synod	Keep the Everflame from reclaiming the province	She speaks once a session; when she does, the bells listen.
Commissary Kyrillos	Chain-Lantern commander	Purge all untutored magic from the province	His lantern shows not only latent talent but also the bearer’s greatest fear.
Sofia	Bell-Runner (commoner exemplar)	Outrun the hunters and protect the hidden gifted	She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket.
Nomophylax Zoe	Law-scholar, master of citations	Reform the synod from within	She has never lost a case; her opponents have a habit of vanishing.

The Lighthouse-Patriarch	Reclusive seer of the Beacon Crown	Steer the city through the coming storm	He has no eyes—only mirrors where his eyes should be.
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Names of Thepyrgos

Inspired by the southern peninsulas and the Aegean coast: clear vowels, soft endings, and surnames that recall a stair, a tower, or a village.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Konstantinos	Eleni	Skalas	<i>the Stair-Wise</i>
Dimitris	Zoe	Platanos	<i>the Unseen</i>
Kyrillos	Sofia	Raptis	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Nikolas	Anastasia	Laskaris	<i>the Accursed</i>
Leonidas	Irini	Makris	<i>Ash-Finger</i>
Stephanos	Fotini	Koutroulis	<i>the Silent</i>

(Tower/Stair/Sea-wall) Pilgrim’s Stair zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; Tower Quarter with family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges.

Spades — Places

- Pilgrim’s Stair** — Zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; ascent as devotion. *Every hundredth step has a bell. Pilgrims ring once for mercy, twice for memory.*
- Tower Quarter** — Family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges; vertical neighborhoods. *The lowest rung of each ladder is painted red—a toll for the rope-guild.*
- Chain-Barbican** — Harbor gate; capstans ready to raise the boom at horn’s call. *The capstan pins are carved from the thighbones of executed smugglers.*
- Blue Cistern** — Under the forum; cool echo, strict tally; water as law. *The water tastes of copper and old prayers. Drink deep, and you may forget a debt.*
- Ropeyard Terrace** — Cranes walk cargo up slope by treadwheel; muscle and machinery. *The treadwheel operators sing in eights. The ninth beat is always silent.*
- Storm-Wall Arcades** — Wind shrieks through arched galleries; defense as architecture. *The wind carries voices from the last siege. Some say they’re warnings.*
- Beacon Crown** — Ring of watchtowers signaling along the Dolmis; eyes of the city. *The beacons burn juniper and saltpeter. Black smoke means fire; white smoke means hunters.*

9. **Library of Keys** — Archive vaults; shelves locked by rung and rite; knowledge as power. *The keys are graded by sin. The ninth key opens nothing—and everything.*
 10. **Siege Court** — Test ramp and scarred stones; war never far from peace. *The ramp’s stones are stained with lamp oil and regret. Practice charges end in the cistern.*
 - J **Ladder Monastery** — Perched on a needle of rock; monks climb toward truth. *The monks never speak. They write commandments in chalk on the rungs.*
 - Q **Synod Hall** — Gold-glass mosaics; judgment audible at a whisper’s distance. *The acoustics are enchanted. A lie told here echoes twice—once in the liar’s voice, once in truth’s.*
 - K **Archon’s Citadel** — Acropolis peak; mirror tiles glare like noon’s justice. *The mirrors were a gift from Kahfagia. They show not the sea, but the faces of debtors.*
 - A **Sky-Bridge** — Twin cliff towers joined over the inner harbor; height as connection. *The bridge has no railings. The Archon says the wise don’t need them.*
- (Archon/Synod/Guild) Bell-runner child whose feet know every stair by heart; Master of Ropes with palms like oak, voice like a whistle.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bell-Runner** — Child whose feet know every stair by heart; speed as currency. *She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she’s outrun. Her hair is a thicket.*
3. **Master of Ropes** — Palms like oak, voice like a whistle; guild head of lifters. *He lost two fingers to a frayed line. He keeps them in a jar as a warning.*
4. **Icon-Smith** — Portable shrine, temper about pigment; faith in detail. *His pigments are ground from stolen icons. He calls it recycling the divine.*
5. **Wall Strategos** — Drills levies on the test ramp; defense as daily ritual. *She lost a son to a Linn raid. She trains orphans now—and keeps a list.*
6. **Chain-Keeper** — Harbor boom; hates “surprises” at dusk; order as obsession. *His bell never rings the same note twice. He says the tide changes its mind.*
7. **Oath-Examiner** — Weighs words like iron; notary of truth and consequence. *She carries a scale with one pan empty. The empty pan is for lies.*
8. **Archive Sister** — Key to the “forbidden rung”; keeper of dangerous knowledge. *Her left eye is milk-white—a price for reading a cursed shelf.*
9. **Salt-Fish Syndic** — Warehouse queen of the quays; profit in preservation. *Her salt is cut with ground bone meal. The fish stay fresh—and quiet.*
10. **Nomophylax** — Law-scholar whose citations close mouths; precedent as weapon. *He has never lost a case. His opponents have a habit of vanishing.*

J **Palikar Captain** — Tower guards; ladder-quick and letter-shy; strength in motion. *His shield is painted with a ladder—each rung a battle he survived.*

Q **Matriarch of the Ladder** — Synod primate; calm as stone, wisdom in height. *She speaks once a session. When she does, the bells listen.*

K **The Archon** — Elected, entrenched, counting bells; ruler of the ascent. *He wears a key around his neck. No one knows what it opens.*

A **Lighthouse-Patriarch** — Reclusive seer; said to steer beacons in storms. *He has no eyes—only mirrors where his eyes should be.*

(**Edict/Quake/Chain**) Tremor with hairline cracks racing down a stair; crowds freeze; iconoclast riot in the Tower Quarter.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Tremor** — Hairline cracks race down a stair; crowds freeze, dust speaks. *The dust spells names. Yours appears if you’ve broken a stair-right.*

3. **Iconoclast Riot** — In the Tower Quarter; pigments and teeth fly through the air. *The riot started over a missing icon’s eye. The eye was a hunter’s informer.*

4. **Chain Jam** — At the barbican; capstan pins shear at the worst moment. *The pins were filed by a saboteur. The chain will hold—or not.*

5. **Black Northerly** — Pins cranes; cargo hangs between tiers, prayers below. *The wind smells of iron and ice. Someone is using weather magic.*

6. **Cistern Taint** — Sour water; inspectors padlock spouts, thirst rises. *The taint is sweet—too sweet. Someone poisoned the cistern to flush out a talent.*

7. **Synod Summons** — A chant or badge is suddenly proscribed; law shifts like wind. *The summons is written on a bell-clapper. Read it, and you are a witness.*

8. **Rope Guild Interdict** — No lifts until a grievance is heard; the city stops climbing. *The guild’s grievance is a single name. The name is yours.*

9. **Siege Drill Panic** — Practice horns mistaken for real; chaos in the ranks. *The horns were blown by a child who didn’t know the difference. Or did they?*

10. **Smuggler’s Ladder** — Discovered; the whole stair sealed, routes rerouted. *The ladder was built by a Hyro family. Now they are all “guests” of the Commissariat.*

J **Ropeyard Fire** — Sparks leap uphill faster than boots; smoke chokes the ascent. *The fire was set to cover a kidnapping. The victim’s name is on the bounty board.*

Q **Exarch’s Claim** — “Thepyrgos under my protection”; arrests follow the papers. *The Exarch is a puppet of the Chain-Lanterns. His seal is a bell without a clapper.*

K **General Watch** — All towers manned; levies seize carts “for the walls.” *The levies are looking for one thing: children who flinch at candle-smoke.*

A **Seaquake Seiche** — Surges the harbor; chain, quays, timetables snap like twine.
The seaquake was no natural event. Something beneath the Dolmis is waking.

(Key/Rite/Paper) Stair token passes a barricaded stair without delay; harbor pass lowers the boom for your vessel on command.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Stair Token** — Pass a barricaded stair without delay (once); height as right. *The token is a bronze step. It fits into a missing rung.*

3. **Harbor Pass** — Boom lowers for your vessel on command; sea as ally. *The pass is a note written on a fish scale. The gate-keeper will not ask why.*

4. **Cistern Draw-Right** — A named ward during scarcity; water as favor. *The right is a clay cup. Break it to claim your share.*

5. **Crane Allotment** — One guaranteed lift on the Ropeyard Terrace; height as service. *The allotment is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each use.*

6. **Icon License** — Display a disputed image without penalty; faith as leverage. *The license is stamped with the Archon’s ring. The ring is warm—the Archon is watching.*

7. **Archive Hour** — Library of Keys; one shelf opened to you; knowledge as power. *The shelf is sealed with a riddle. Solve it, or the key will break.*

8. **Bellmark** — Lawful right to ring a tower bell (summons the watch); sound as law. *The bellmark is a brand on your palm. Show it, and the watch bleeds for you—once.*

9. **Watchlight Code** — Today’s beacon and mirror signals; navigation as paper. *The code is written in lemon juice. Heat it to read, then hide it again.*

10. **Synod Indulgence** — One proscribed chant or rite permitted (for you). *The indulgence is a bell-note held in a jar. Break the jar to release it.*

J **Pronoia Grant** — Temporary farm/tax of a terrace hamlet; land as income. *The grant is a wooden token. Present it to the village elder—if she is still alive.*

Q **Synod Audience** — Private with the Matriarch and clerks; wisdom as policy. *The audience is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written.*

K **Archon’s Writ** — Palikars escort you between towers; authority as escort. *The writ is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt, and the guards will know your voice.*

A **Golden Key** — Open or seal any city gate once; access as power. *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist. It will work—once.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (keys/rites/papers) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **height and sound** motifs—bells that carry, wind that remembers, stairs that echo with purpose.

Additional Features

- **Bell-Law:** Bells are law made sound. Once per session, a Bellmark or tower bell summons the watch, a levy, or a decree. False rings stain a reputation; the Synod may inquire.
- **Stair-Rights:** Every stair is owned, owed, or leased. A token bypasses barricades and tolls; climbing the wrong stair without leave sparks a riot or a duel.
- **Synod Edicts:** Voice reshapes daily life. Once per session, a decree grants or strips rights: a chant forbidden, a symbol proscribed, a stair sealed. Rulings create leverage and risk.
- **The Chain-Lanterns:** The most feared of the Witch-Hunter orders. Their captains carry brass lanterns that reveal latent magic through candle-smoke tests. A Chain-Lantern raid is heralded by a single, low bell—the death knell of innocence.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Astroegro Remnant (Khemesh):** Deep beneath the Beacon Crown, a sealed chamber contains a working Astroegro orrery. Its gears are carved from abyssal glass, and it still ticks. Those who listen too long hear a voice whispering the true names of drowned emperors. The Chain-Lanterns have posted a perpetual guard; they say the orrery is a beacon for something that should not surface.
- **Saint Methodia of the Silent Stair (The Witness):** A legendary archivist who climbed the Ninth Stair of the Library of Keys and never came down. Her ghost is said to appear to those who speak a truth the Synod has buried, offering a single citation that can overturn any edict. The price is a secret of equal weight, and the ghost never forgets.
- **The Cog-Cults of the Clockwork Monad:** Underground fraternities of gear-smiths and logicians who believe the Astroegro Empire fell because its geometry was imperfect. They meet in the basements of the Ropeyard Terrace, trying to reconstruct the lost orrery. The Chain-Lanterns tolerate them because their calculations sometimes predict talent blooms. Heretics from the Everflame call them clock-worshippers; the Cog-Cults call themselves the True Iterators.

- **The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root):** A hospice in the lower tiers is run by grey-robed women who ask no payment, but they take names. They are tolerated because they treat the poor for free, but the Commissariat suspects they also hide gifted children. A renegade Sister hides among the bell-runners, trying to unbind her Hollowed from the Chain-Lanterns’ ledger.
- **The Savage Heart (Red Maw):** In the highland villages west of the city, a bear cult has arisen. They believe the only way to escape the Commissariat’s hunts is to become the hunter. They wear cured skins and speak in growls, and they have begun hunting Chain-Lantern patrols. The Archon has declared them outlaws, but the villagers leave offerings of raw meat at their shrines.
- **The Ninth:** In any Thepyrgos scene, the ninth bell rung in an hour opens a threshold. The wise stop at eight and cover their ears. Those who ring the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing on the Beacon Crown’s mirror tiles—waiting to collect a name.

Thepyrgos Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stair:** Toss a crust onto a rung before climbing. Ignore the first *Tremor* penalty.
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a crane line. Cancel *Rope Guild Interdict* or take −1 die on your next lift (your choice).
- **Name to the Smoke:** Whisper a hunter’s name into the Beacon Crown’s fire. Gain +1 Effect when evading the Chain-Lanterns this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Synod.

Patronage & Power

In Thepyrgos, power flows through elevation, education, and the precise application of law. The Archon maintains authority through a complex web of guilds, synods, and civic institutions that govern every aspect of vertical life. Social mobility is literally upward mobility, with stair-rights, bellmarks, and archive access serving as both currency and status symbols.

For the GM: Patronage in Thepyrgos revolves around access—to towers, to knowledge, to the right to climb. Rewards often take the form of keys, passes, or legal exemptions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, keys, papers) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds issue conflicting rights, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the synods, towers, and staircases as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.

In Thepyrgos, your ascent is your standing, and your standing determines whether you rise or fall.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tower guards** or **guild masters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bell-runners** or **civic patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **archive keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable ascent**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Wall Strategos** or **guild head** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **quake damage** or **stair closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction** or **civic enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **palikars**, **guild enforcers**, or **synod guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **bell rings falsely**/stair collapses/law changes.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1**/**Harm 1**/**Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Archon**, **Matriarch**, or **Lighthouse-Patriarch** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **quake hits**/bells ring/bridge collapses.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears**/blessing lost/curse manifests.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Thepyrgos (Height & Law):** Stairs shift position, bells ring with the wrong tone, legal papers rewrite themselves.
- **Thepyrgos (Synod Power):** Edicts change mid-speech, citations appear in the air, wisdom comes unbidden.
- **Thepyrgos (Vertical City):** Ropes fray without warning, cranes swing cargo unexpectedly, tower windows show wrong views.

The Magic Colleges (University Extensions)

- **College of Ladders & Lines** — geomancy, architecture, constraint; stairs as sigils, capstans as circles.
- **College of Bells & Beacons** — acoustics, omen-fire, signal calculus; law made audible, augury made measurable.
- **College of Waters & Weights** — alchemy, cistern rites, dyes; solutions, precipitates, and lawful flow.
- **College of Names & Oaths** — nomikon theurgy; citations that bind, clauses that compel.

- **College of Mirrors & Haze** — illusion, scrutiny; seeing, being seen, un-being seen.
- **College of Quiet** — ethics of death, memory rites; permitted remembrances—anything more is heresy.

The Witch-Hunter Province (Commissariat Extensions)

Thepyrgos-the-Province funds Witch-Hunter Commissariats—ministries with bounties posted per ward. Notices hang on stair-landings; bells announce *hunts lawful and hunts less so*. The Chain-Lantern order is the most feared, but others compete for quotas.

Hunter Hearts (faces of the persecution)

- **Commissary-Exarch** — Writs in triplicate; quotas in private.
- **Bounty-Reader** — Weighs children like coin; “verification” by bell.
- **Pardoner-Chaplain** — Sells absolution to informers; keeps a careful ledger.
- **Stair-Runner Informant** — Knows which doors open to the right knock.
- **Chain-Lantern Captain** — Commands the most feared order; his lantern reveals truth through flesh.

Hunter Clubs (pressures and sweeps)

- **Bounty Posting** — New price on “untutored talent”; crowds turn into nets.
- **Candle-Smoke Test** — Lines at the Blue Cistern; smoke curls toward the Gifted.
- **Commissary Sweep** — Ladders chained; a whole tier searched under horn.
- **Quieted Child** — An “accident” near the Exam Stair; evidence goes missing.
- **Chain-Lantern Raid** — Dawn assault on a hamlet; children taken before the rooster crows.

Hunter Diamonds (leverage and reprieve)

- **Witness Pardon** — Informer absolved and paid; cancels one legal fallout *once*.
- **Archon’s Clemency** — Suspends a bounty clock for one named; bell-marked and public.
- **Hidden Stair Token** — Through a maintenance run unseen; good for one group escape.

Detection & Denial (Fast Procedures)**Scry & Deny (evading the tests)**

1. **Mask the Trace:** dye, salt, bell-oil; pick *one* (each grants +1 die to one approach).
2. **Pick the Test:** *Smoke, Sound, Mirror*. State how you spoof it (alchemical veil, bell overtones, angle games).
3. **On a hit:** cancel a **Candle-Smoke Test** or **Proctors’ Gate** tag for this scene.
Consequence: start *Bell Debt* [2] or *Rector’s Notice* [2].

Bounty Economy (quick table, GM picks or 1d6)

1. *Whisperer* (faint talent): 1 purse; informers abundant.
2. *Spark-Hand* (cantrip): 2 purses; “rehabilitation” promised.
3. *Mirror-Bent* (glamour): 3 purses; seized at once.
4. *Bell-Singer* (acoustic): 4 purses; Synod claims jurisdiction.
5. *Oath-Breaker* (binding): 5 purses; Exarch insists on custody.
6. *Quiet-Worker* (death-ethic): 6 purses; College of Quiet petitions for trial.

Scenario Starters (Plug-and-Play)

The Bright Child on the Exam Stair *Hook:* A Bell-Runner begs you to get a latent child to campus before the dawn sweep. *Complications:* **Candle-Smoke Test**, **Commissary Sweep**, a jealous **Street Thaum**. *Relief:* Trade a *Latency Seal* for testimony; or ring a lawful *Bellmark* to create a corridor—accept *Censure Murmurs* [2].

The Black Ledger of Bounties *Hook:* The College of Quiet wants proof that a Commissary inflates prices to fill quotas. *Complications:* **Synod Summons**, **Smuggler’s Ladder**, **Chain Jam**. *Relief:* Publish via a *Nomikon* colloquy (gain *Synod Indulgence*); or sell it to the Archon (gain *Archon’s Clemency* but start *Faculty Feud* [4]).

The Golden Key and the Silent Stair *Hook:* A dying Archivist gives you a Golden Key. “It opens the stair the hunters fear.” *Truth:* The stair leads to the Beacon Crown’s secret basement—a prison for children who passed the smoke test. *Relief:* Free the children and expose the Commissariat (gain *Archon’s Clemency* for the whole party, but start *Exarch’s Claim* at full); or seal the stair forever (gain *Golden Key* to use elsewhere, but the children are lost to memory).

4.23 Ubral — “The Stone Between Spears”

Lady of Tor (Elite): “The stone here remembers every oath sworn upon it and every blood spilled in its shadow. To lead is to understand that the land itself is the true sovereign, and we are merely its stewards.”

Hearth-Aunt (Commoner): “Hospitality’s a sacred thing in these hills – break bread at my table and you’re family till the sun sets twice. But cross that trust and the very stones will remember your name.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Ubral is a land of upland mists, stone cairns, and clan oaths held tighter than iron. Caught between the Aelerian mountains and the lowland courts of Viterra, its hills are scarred by old raids and crowned by watch-fires that speak faster than any rider. Here, law is written not in charters but in cattle, wergild, and songs; a guest’s word can buy more than a sword, but one broken vow can spark a feud lasting generations. Dwarves of Khaz-Vurim guard their mountain steps with tolls and grim patience, while clans hold their moots in hollows where voices echo long after speakers fall silent. Ubral is the stone between spears: a land of pride, passage, and peril.

What you notice first: The smell of peat smoke and wet granite. The constant lowing of cattle on distant hills. The way every threshold has a knife hidden nearby—for guests, not against them.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a cup from a hearth-aunt. Hospitality is a contract sealed in salt and bread. Refusal is an insult that blood must answer.

Regional Mood: Cairn, Tor, and Oath

Here, the past is never past. Every cairn holds a voice, every burn scar on a hillside remembers a raid. Viterra has tried to conquer Ubral a dozen times; each attempt ended with supply lines cut by reivers, passes sealed by dwarf tolls, and lowland knights lost in mist. The Utaran Imperium itself broke its leg on these hills and limped away. Now the clans watch the lowlands with patient eyes, and the dwarves of Khaz-Vurim weigh every traveler’s honesty on iron scales. A guest here is kin—until they prove otherwise. And kin here will die for you—or kill you over a stolen cow.

Starting Location: A Warden’s Cairn at the fog line. Spears planted like grave markers, their shafts wrapped in faded clan ribbons. Hoofbeats echo in the valley below. The Hearth-Aunt offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. “The Wolf Road wakes,” she says. “Viterran tax men are asking which passes you used. The clans are counting your steps. Speak true, or the cairn will add your name to its tally.”

Prominent NPCs of Ubral

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Lady Morwen	Clan-chief of the Grey Tor, Lady of Tor	Keep the old oaths and resist Viterran encroachment	She lost a hand to a Viterran knight; her iron hook has a built-in bell.
Hearth-Aunt Brigid	Keeper of guest-right (commoner exemplar)	Protect her household and settle feuds before blood is spilled	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.
Councillor Gethin	Elder of the Council of Cairns	Preserve the wergild system and the memory of the dead	He speaks once a year; his sentences take a full season to deliver.
Oath-Singer Lili-as	Verse-weaver and feud mediator	Turn vengeance into cattle, not corpses	Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath.
Stone-Speaker Baerd	Dwarf envoy from Khaz-Vurim	Negotiate tolls and keep the passes open	He carries a tuning fork; strike it, and the mountain answers.
Sister Niamh	Healer of the Cairn-Keepers of the Grey Palm (Temple of Light)	Run a free hospice at Grey Tor without angering the old gods	She asks no payment, but she writes every patient’s name on a slate that never fills.

Names of Ubral

Inspired by the highland clans and the old stone circles: short, hard, with spirant consonants (ll, ch, th) and names that evoke hill, water, or cattle.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Gethin		Morwen	ap Cairn	<i>the Grey</i>

Bran	Brigid	ferch Tor	<i>Oath-Sworn</i>
Drystan	Lilias	mac Tern	<i>the Stone-Foot</i>
Eilian	Niamh	O’Ruarc	<i>Hollow-Tongue</i>
Padraig	Siorcha	Mac Gowan	<i>the Unbroken</i>
Tegid	Ailbhe	O’Creagh	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(**Tor/Cairn/Hill-fort**) Sheepwalk Ledge with goat path and room for one honest lie; Warden’s Cairn on windy tor with signal-fire basket.

Spades — Places

2. **Sheepwalk Ledge** — Goat path with room for one honest lie at a time. *The lie must be small—a false weight, a borrowed name. Tell it twice and the ledge crumbles.*
 3. **Warden’s Cairn** — Windy tor; signal-fire basket and dry cache; eyes of the hills. *The cache holds a single arrow. Light it with the fire, and the message is war.*
 4. **Wergild Ford** — Flat stones, deep pools, table rock for counting silver. *The table rock is smooth as glass. Blood washes off; lies do not.*
 5. **Droppers’ Bridge** — Stone span rigged to fall; pins already loosened. *The pins are greased with mutton fat. The bridge knows who paid for the grease.*
 6. **Scree-Ladder** — Climbing to a notch; red rags mark safe steps through danger. *The rags are old clan banners. Step where they wave, not where they lie flat.*
 7. **Moot Hollow** — Ring of standing stones; voices carry and won’t quite stop. *The stones have ears. Speak a false oath here, and every cairn will know.*
 8. **Reiver’s Gate** — Between boulders; cart-ruts vanish into heather’s memory. *The gate has no lintel. Above it, ravens nest in a skull.*
 9. **Khaz-Vurim Steps** — Dwarf-cut switchbacks with iron mile studs; toll and toil. *The studs are cold iron. Touch them, and the mountain knows your weight.*
 10. **Grey Tor Fort** — Earthen rampart, timber crown, smoky cook pits. *The cook pits have been burning for three hundred years. The ash is deep enough to bury a secret.*
- J **Black Broom Bog** — Stepping-logs; wrong one drinks you into silence. *The logs are painted with warding runes. One is unpainted—that one is the quick way.*
- Q **Bride’s Causey** — Raised road to a valley kirk; ribbons hang like warnings. *The ribbons are from wedding gowns—cut short when the groom fell in a feud.*
- K **Three-Fires Ridge** — Watchposts that see Viterra and Vhasia both; news travels fast. *The fires are layered: birch for peace, pine for raid, oak for invasion.*
- A **Pass of Ashes** — When snow closes here, the upland becomes an island. *The ash is from old sacrifices. The pass remembers every offering.*

(Clan/Dwarf/Reiver) Hearth-aunt who holds guest-cup and house’s temper; hill guide with thorn-staff and quiet shortcuts.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hearth-Aunt** — Holds guest-cup and house’s temper; hospitality as power. *She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.*
3. **Hill Guide** — Thorn-staff and ten quiet shortcuts; the land as a map. *He taps each stone before stepping. The stones talk to him.*
4. **Feud-Broker** — Knows the weight of a life in cattle and coin; peace as trade. *His ledger is a row of tally sticks. Each notch is a death—or a birth.*
5. **Reiver Band** — Light on tack, heavy on nerve, laughing in the rain. *They wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles, not names.*
6. **Fire Warden** — Braziers speak faster than riders; warning as weapon. *She can light a signal with a single word. The word is a dead man’s name.*
7. **Wergild Counter** — Keeps tallies, ends grudges, starts others; law as math. *His abacus beads are sheep knuckles. He clicks them in his sleep.*
8. **Dwarf Warden** — Khaz-Vurim road; toll first, friendship later. *Her hammer has a chip where she cracked a liar’s skull. She never fixed it.*
9. **Oath-Singer** — Verses bind hands and open gates; word as iron. *Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath.*
10. **Lowland Factor** — Buying iron blooms, selling trouble; coin as catalyst. *He carries two ledgers. One is for the clans. One is for the tax man.*
- J **Bride-Carrier** — Peaceweaver walking bloodlines with a knife and a smile. *Her knife has a wooden blade. The threat is real.*
- Q **Lady of Tor** — Clan-chief in cloak and mail; her nod is winter or spring. *She lost a hand to a Viterran knight. Her iron hook has a built-in bell.*
- K **Council of Cairns** — Greybeards and granite wills; they do not hurry. *They have sentenced men to exile. The sentences take a year to deliver.*
- A **Stone-Speaker** — Dwarf envoy whose word moves roads and rates. *He carries a tuning fork. Strike it, and the mountain answers.*

(Mist/Feud/Toll) Upland mist—hear horns but not edges; feud rekindled—cousin spits on guest-law.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Upland Mist** — Hear horns but not edges; navigation by sound and instinct. *The horns are calling a muster. Which clan? You will know when they arrive.*
 3. **Feud Rekindled** — Cousin spits on guest-law; knives wake from sleep. *The spit lands at your feet. The insult is now yours to answer.*
 4. **Bridge Dropped** — Pursuers fall... and the route with them; passage becomes peril. *The bridge was cut from the far side. Someone expected you.*
 5. **Black-Rent Demand** — “Privateering on land”; pay or be “escorted.” *The escort has a noose. Choose your words carefully.*
 6. **Wergild Breach** — Silver short by a head; tempers long by a spear’s length. *The bereaved clan has a new widow. She is sharpening a blade.*
 7. **Snow-Squall** — Seals the notch; tents turn to coffins if you dally. *The snow is tinged grey—ash from the Pass. Someone burned an offering.*
 8. **Dwarf Toll Hike** — At the Steps; papers right, purses wrong; law costs coin. *The warden quotes a rate from a book that wasn’t there yesterday.*
 9. **Cattle Scatter** — Bells ringing downslope; the cover story runs with the herd. *The bells are yours. The herd is not.*
 10. **False Alarm** — Watch-fire beacons ridge to ridge; levies seize the road. *The fire was lit by a child. Or a spy. The levy doesn’t care.*
- J **Bride-Theft** — A wedding becomes a war-party; you are caught between both. *The bride’s veil is on the ground. The groom’s own kin drew first blood.*
- Q **Royal Incursion** — Neighbor’s “lawful” arrests in the uplands; flags and chains. *The flags are Viterran. The chains are new. The prisoners are children.*
- K **Clan Muster** — Horns call men from steadings to spears; all traffic stops. *The muster stone is black with old blood. The new blood will be red.*
- A **Hill-Fall** — Rain liquefies a slope; trail, proof, and bodies slide together. *The mud is warm. Something underneath is still breathing.*

(Oath/Right/Token) Guest-right token—one hearth owes food, bed, and steel at dawn; guide’s braid for lawful passage on sheepwalks.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Guest-Token** — One hearth owes food, bed, and steel at dawn. *The token is a knucklebone from a feast. The host’s name is carved on it.*
3. **Guide’s Braid** — Lawful passage on named sheepwalks (once). *The braid is woven from horsehair and a promise. Unravel it to return.*

4. **Ford Remission** — Cross Wergild Ford free for a season; water as ally. *The remission is a white stone. Skip it across the ford to pay.*
 5. **Feud-Charter** — Two clans sheath blades until the next harvest. *The charter is a broken spear. Each clan keeps a half.*
 6. **Bloom Allotment** — Claim on a week’s iron from a hill bloomery. *The bloomery is a woman’s name. She decides how much you get.*
 7. **Watch-Code** — Today’s beacon order from Three-Fires Ridge. *The code is a sequence of smoke puffs. Read it, and the hills will watch for you.*
 8. **Pass-Ring** — Dwarf road priority for one train of carts. *The ring is iron. Wear it on your off hand.*
 9. **Bride-Escrow** — Hold the purse; both sides must humor you. *The purse is a leather bag. The coins inside are from a dead man’s hoard.*
 10. **Shelter Writ** — Grey Tor opens its gates during storm or pursuit. *The writ is a raven feather. Burn it to claim shelter.*
- J **Oath-Bracelet** — One binding vow ends cleanly, witnessed. *The bracelet is silver. The clasp is a wolf’s head. Bite it to break the oath.*
- Q **Council Audience** — The Cairns hear you alone; precedent sticks like stone. *The audience is held at midnight. The stones glow when they agree.*
- K **Road Commission** — Collect tolls on a stretch of pass (for now). *The commission is a wooden staff. Plant it at the toll gate.*
- A **Stone-Clause** — Temporary exception to dwarf toll or law, sealed. *The clause is a single rune. Carve it on the toll post, and the mountain will honor it—once.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (oaths/rights/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **stone and spear** motifs—cairns that watch, voices that echo, and oaths that cut deeper than steel.

Additional Features

- **Guest-Law:** Breaking hospitality stains a name worse than breaking a sword. Guest-right tokens guarantee shelter, but abuse invites a blood feud.
- **Wergild System:** Every injury has a price in cattle or coin. Wergild counters keep tallies that outlive the injured; debts pass to kin.

- **Dwarf Toll Roads:** Khaz-Vurim gates charge for passage, but their roads are sure and swift. Pass-rings grant priority, but dwarf law is strict.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Eluned of the Unbroken Chain (The Traveler):** A legendary hill guide who walked the Wolf Road backwards during a blizzard and never lost a step. Her shrines are cairns with a single iron ring embedded in the stone; travellers who touch the ring and speak a destination find the fog lifts for one hour. The Temple of Light venerates her; the old clans claim she was a hedge-witch who tricked the Hollow.
- **The Grey Tor Covenant (Mykkiel):** A small order of notaries who adjudicate feuds without violence. They carry no weapons, only a set of iron scales and a copy of the **Wergild Tables**. A ruling from the Grey Tor Covenant is binding on both clans, but any party who lies before them forfeits their guest-right for a year and a day.
- **The Cairn-Keepers of the Grey Palm:** Sister Niamh runs a hospice at Grey Tor, treating wounded reivers and lowland knights alike. She asks no payment, but she writes every patient’s name on a slate that never fills. The clans tolerate her because she also tends the cairns, leaving a cup of fresh water at each one at dawn. The Viterran Crown has tried to close her hospice twice; both times the investigating magistrate vanished into the mist and returned with no memory of the journey.
- **Saint Madoc of the Silent Cairn (The Witness):** A clan chief who discovered that one of the Council of Cairns had falsified a wergild payment to start a feud. He spoke the truth aloud at the Moot Hollow, and the stones cracked. His own name was carved into a new cairn that night. The Council now keeps a sealed chamber under Grey Tor containing the **Ledger of Unspoken Truths**—debts that were never paid and oaths that were never sworn. Opening it is said to reignite every feud Ubral has ever settled.
- **The Savage Heart (Red Maw):** A bear cult has taken root in the remote glens, believing that the only way to resist Viterran encroachment is to become as fierce as the old predators. They wear cured bear-skins and carve runes into their ribs. The clans fear them nearly as much as the lowland tax men. The Lady of Tor has forbidden their rites, but every winter a bull is found torn open on the Pass of Ashes, and the cult grows stronger.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ubral scene, the ninth stone in a cairn is always warm. Touch it, and you will remember an oath you never swore. Those who touch the ninth stone three times are said to become a cairn themselves—silent, still, and waiting for the next hand.

Ubral Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Cairn:** Crumble a crust at the base of a standing stone. Ignore the first *Upland Mist* penalty.

- **Knot the Guest-Cup:** Tie a single knot in the handle of a drinking cup. Cancel *Feud Rekindled* or take −1 die on your next hospitality roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Ford:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the Wergild Ford. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Lady of Tor.

Patronage & Power

In Ubral, power flows through clan bonds, guest-right, and the careful balance of honor and iron. Clan chiefs maintain authority through wergild, moots, and the respect of their people, while the dwarves of Khaz-Vurim wield influence through their control of mountain passes and trade routes. Law is personal and passed down through generations, with each oath and debt creating a web of obligation that can last centuries.

For the GM: Patronage in Ubral revolves around hospitality, protection, and the resolution of feuds. Rewards often take the form of tokens, charters, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, bracelets, writs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival clans issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the moots, hill-forts, and watch-fires as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of custom and kinship determines success.

In Ubral, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you walk in peace or peril.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **clan guards or reiver scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watch-fires or hill guides**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or feud-kin**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Hill guide or clan chief** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist or bridge collapse**.

- **Foe Appears:** A reiver band or feud-kin arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional clan warriors, reivers, or dwarf wardens arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **feud declared/bridge falls/snow closes pass**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** Lady of Tor, Council of Cairns, or Stone-Speaker intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **mist thickens/bridge drops/hill falls**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ubral (Stone & Oath):** Cairns shift position, voices echo from empty air, oaths bind mid-speech.
- **Ubral (Hill Law):** Paths reroute without warning, tolls increase mid-journey, guest-rights expire.
- **Ubral (Feud Culture):** Insults are overheard, weapons appear in sheaths, kin arrive unsummoned.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Wolf-Road Captain (reiver-king on a piebald mare)** — *Phases:* Ride-Through → Torch the Fold → Laugh in Rain. *Cracks:* present a **Watch-Code** or **Guide’s Braid** to reduce his effect; strike a truce with a season’s cattle.

- **The Bride-Thief of Black Broom (mask of bog-rush)** — *Phases*: Switch the Bride → Bog Embrace → Nettle Oath. *Cracks*: play a **Bride-Charter** to freeze blades; a **Well-Blessing** nulls one bog move.
- **Stone Auditor of Khaz-Vurim (dwarf toll-magistrate)** — *Phases*: Double the Toll → Weigh the Lie → Seal the Switchback. *Cracks*: present two of {**Pass-Ring**, **Stamped Load-List**, **Named Sponsor**} to downgrade his authority.
- **The Oath-Eater Wight (cairn-bound revenant)** — *Phases*: Take the Word → Cold of Cairn → Bind Witness. *Cracks*: **Oath-Bracelet** or a skald’s stanza spoken over bread and blood cancels one move; repay an ancestral wergild.
- **Grey-Tor Hedge-Witch (heather crown, ash staff)** — *Phases*: Weather-Turn → Hag-Stone Sight → Bind the Gate. *Cracks*: gift a **Bloom Allotment** or a winter’s salt; a **Council Audience** compels parley.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Sheepwalk Ledge Trial** — Speak one honest lie to pass. On success, set Position one step safer for the next border scene; on failure, start *Kin Arrive*.
- **Wergild Ford Weighing** — Cast silver on the table-rock. If paid in full, clear 1 *Feud-Smoke*; if short, *Wergild Breach* enters play.
- **Pass of Ashes Vigil** — Hold a fire through the night storm. Success grants **Shelter Writ**; a miss summons the *Oath-Eater Wight* at weak strength.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Oath Dial (Honor ↔ Cunning)**: Track how the party navigates Ubral norms.
 - *Honor High*: +1 Position when invoking guest-right, keeping truce, or paying wergild promptly; first ambush/raid action each session starts one step worse.
 - *Cunning High*: +1 Effect on raids, evasions, and border tricks; first formal parley or oath-bound request each session starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by restoring stolen cattle, hosting an enemy well, or submitting to a cairn ruling.
- **Feud Math (fast settlement)**: Lay three markers: **Blood**, **Beasts**, **Blame**.
 1. Make a single *Parley/Command/Study* roll per side. On a hit, move one marker to your side; great Effect moves two.
 2. Win any two to settle: *Blood* = oath/hostage, *Beasts* = wergild in cattle/coin, *Blame* = public apology/verse.
 3. Miss: mark *Feud-Smoke* [4]. At 4, the losing side names a lawful target (bridge, herd, guide).
- **Guest-Right Procedure**:
 - Present a **Guest-Token** (or bread and salt). Host must choose: *Shelter*, *Escort at Dawn*, or *Neutral Meal*.

- Breaking it creates *Blood-Oath* [6] against the violator; any Ubral ally may spend 1 $\Diamond$ *totickittwice*.
- Abiding it clears 1 tick from *Feud-Smoke* and grants +1d to the next social action in that steading.

• **Watchfire Net (ridge signals):**

- Two clocks: *Beat the Beacons* vs *Ridge Aflame* (size by highest rank in your seed).
- Choose a lane each exchange: *Low Fold* (slow, stealth), *Sheepwalk* (tricky, quick), *Road* (fast, obvious).
- Advantage: Low Fold $\triangleright$ Road (conceal), Road $\triangleright$ Sheepwalk (speed), Sheepwalk $\triangleright$ Low Fold (shortcuts).
- *False Alarm (1 SB)*: light or douse a misleading brazier; shift one segment between the two clocks.

• **Reiver Ride (mounted chase):**

- Track *Remounts* (3): each push for speed trades 1 remount for +1d or +1 Effect. At 0, gain *Blown Mounts* condition.
- *Hag-Stone Cut*: pass a known gap (Sheepwalk Ledge, Droppers’ Bridge) to force pursuers to roll or fall behind.

• **Khaz-Vurim Protocol:**

- Present any two: **Pass-Ring, Stamped Load-List, Named Sponsor**. Two = safe passage; one = pay toll + scrutiny; none = delay and search.
- *Stone-Clause* may override one dwarf law once; afterwards start *Ledger Notice* [3] with the wardens (prices rise, patience falls).
- *Tally Truth*: you may substitute exact weights/measures for charm or coin to improve Position by one step with dwarves.

• **Bride-Peace Interlude:**

- Play a **Bride-Charter** to suspend violence at a scene. Everyone sheaths—or earns *Song Shame* [4]. When it fills, a skald memorializes the insult (ongoing -1d with that clan).

• **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**

1. *Clear Ridge*: first signal test gains +1d.
2. *Lowing Herd*: +1d to tracking or herding; -1d to stealth near cattle.
3. *Wet Stone*: climbs start one step worse; mending gear is easier (free repair tick).
4. *Old Verse Remembered*: first oath/plea gains +1d if spoken in rhyme.
5. *Border Drums*: Viterra patrols near; papers safer, raiding harsher.
6. *Dwarf Toll Day*: prices firm; any $\Diamond$ *tiedtoroadscountsdoublevalueattheSteps*.

• **Plug-in SB Conversions (Ubral Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Mud and Heather*: footing worsens; next physical action –1d or mark *Winded*.
- 2 SB → *Kin Arrive*: add a rival cousin/ally who changes the ask or splits the pot.
- 3+ SB → *Cairn Decrees*: a standing stone “speaks” (witnesses recall the law); swap one held *for a less right until you make amends*.

• **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Guest-Faithful*: once/session downgrade a social backlash inside a steading; next time you refuse hospitality, mark *Feud-Smoke* +1.
- *Reiver-Favored*: +1 Effect to seize cattle/contraband on the move; city gates start one step worse Position.
- *Stone-Friend*: +1d with dwarf wardens on roads; any false measure triggers *Ledger Notice* +1.

4.24 Valewood — “Empire Under Leaves”

Hazel Queen (Elite): “The forest here remembers empires that crumbled to dust, and its laws are older than your kingdoms. To walk these paths is to enter into covenant with powers that measure time in seasons, not years.”

Pathweaver (Commoner): “The woods here got a mind of their own – they’ll lead you where you need to go if you ask right, but they’ll just as soon lose you if you’re carrying ill intent. Best know which is which before you wander off the path.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Valewood is older than kingdoms, older than the maps that skirt its borders. Beneath its canopy lie the bones of a Lethai empire whose name is forgotten, its towers swallowed by vine and root, its star-roads cracked and phasing between worlds. The air hums with half-remembered songs of magic, and the ruins bleed their mysteries into root and stream. Fae courts linger in clearings that shift with moonlight, beast-kin patrol moss-choked cairns, and echoes of imperial shades still march patrols on vanished streets. To walk the Valewood is to risk being claimed by it: as guest, prey, heir—or trespasser.

What you notice first: The smell of wet moss and old stone. The way the light filters through leaves like stained glass. The silence that falls when you speak a name too loudly.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never eat the fruit of a tree that has a face. The forest does not forget its debtors, and the first bite is always the price of admission.

Regional Mood: Leaves, Oaths, and Echoes

Here, the past is not past—it phases in and out like moonlight on water. The Lethai-ar who remain are not conquerors but custodians, tending to laws written before the first human kingdom rose. The fae courts of Hazel and Alder play their endless games of courtesy and obligation, and the beast-kin speak in parliaments where every vote is a scent. Imperial shades march through walls that no longer exist, and the star-roads hum with geometries that twist the unwary into yesterday. The Valewood does not forgive arrogance. It expects humility, patience, and the willingness to trade a piece of yourself for safe passage.

Starting Location: A moss-covered amphitheatre where roots crawl through marble benches and owls whisper verdicts to the wind. An Owl-Sister speaks in riddles: “The Lethai-ar stir. The paths remember your true name. Speak it into the hollow of this stone, or the forest will learn it from your footsteps.”

Prominent NPCs of the Valewood

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
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Queen Amalthea	Hazel Queen, sovereign of the Hazel Court	Preserve the old pacts and keep the empire from waking	She has never spoken a lie. She has never needed to.
King Thorn	Alder King, ruler of the Twilit Court	Collect debts, old and new, and expand the forest’s reach	His crown is a noose of thorns. He wears it proudly.
Pathweaver Sila	Lethai-ar guide (commoner exemplar)	Knot safe routes and keep the star-roads from bleeding	Her cord has eight knots; the ninth is the one she never ties.
Bramble	Fox-headed courier of the beast-kin	Deliver messages that cannot be written	The price is always a secret, and the secret is always bitter.
The Huntsman	Antlered hunter of the Moonlit Ride	Claim those who break the forest’s laws	His face is a stag’s skull; his voice is the wind in the leaves.
Shardwright Kael	Artisan who repairs the star-roads	Wake the ancient ways before they fade forever	Her chisel is a tooth from the first dragon. She stole it.

Names of the Valewood

Inspired by the old Lethai language and the fae courts: flowing vowels, soft consonants, and names that feel like they belong to a forgotten song.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Caelith	Amalthea	Thornweave	<i>the Green</i>
Eryndor	Sila	Starfoot	<i>Oath-Woven</i>
Kael	Liriel	Hawthorn	<i>the Unseen</i>
Oren	Vesper	Silverbough	<i>Hollow-Tongue</i>
Riven	Fenn	Mossglen	<i>the Last</i>
Thorn	Myrin	Gloaming	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Phasing Ruin/Star-Road/Living Stone) Star-road shard with pale flagstones that hum when trod in sequence; rooted amphitheatre with moss-seats remembering speeches.

Spades — Places

2. **Star-Road Shard** — Pale flagstones hum when trod in sequence; a path between worlds. *The sequence is always incomplete. The missing step is the one you hesitate to take.*
3. **Rooted Amphitheatre** — Moss-seats remember speeches not yet given; a stage for fate. *Sit in the high seat, and the roots will ask you a question. Answer wrong, and you may never stand.*
4. **Moon-Cistern** — Reflecting sky that isn’t tonight’s; water as a mirror of truth. *The reflection shows what you lost, not what you carry. Look away before it names you.*
5. **Glyphed Bridge** — Across a dry stream; glyphs glow when lies pass; truth as a toll. *The bridge has no railings. Liars fall—into the stream, or into memory.*
6. **Glassleaf Gallery** — Boughs grown into panes, dust like constellations; beauty as a barrier. *The dust is crushed star-road. Breathe it, and you will dream of the empire’s fall.*
7. **Hollow Aqueduct** — Water runs uphill if the song is right; magic in the melody. *The song has eight verses. The ninth is the silence that follows.*
8. **Calendar Grove** — Standing-trees aligned to solstices; one trunk is stone; time as architecture. *The stone tree bleeds sap once a year. Collect it, and the forest owes you a season.*
9. **Unfound Arcade** — Arches appear at dusk, vanish at dawn; reality as a schedule. *The arches have names—Carved on the inside. You must walk through to read them.*
10. **Breathing City** — Vine-choked streets shift on the hour; a ruin as a living thing. *The vines pulse with a slow heartbeat. The city is sleeping, not dead.*
- J **Amber Ziggurat** — Caught mid-construction for a thousand years; time as an artifact. *The workers are statues of amber. Their eyes follow you.*
- Q **Ivory Observatory** — Brass orrery tracks two lost moons; the sky as memory. *The moons are not in any sky you know. One of them is yours.*
- K **Throne-Bower** — Living alder and argent wire; the seat of forgotten power. *Sit here, and the forest will crown you—or crush you. You won’t know which until the leaves settle.*
- A **Valeheart Spire** — The empire’s axle; stairs that end where they began. *The spire has no top. It has only a center. Finding it is the journey.*

(**Lethai-ar/Fae/Beast-kin**) Pathweaver who knots safe routes into cord; fox-headed courier with a promise braided into its tail.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Pathweaver** — Lethai-ar guide who knots safe routes into cord; navigation as magic. *Her cord has eight knots. The ninth is the one she never ties.*
3. **Fox-Courier** — Promise braided into its tail; messages as living things. *It will deliver anything—for a price. The price is always a secret.*
4. **Owl-Sister** — Pupils show yesterday; her hands show yours; sight as prophecy. *She never blinks. If she does, the future has changed.*
5. **Antler-Hunter** — Sworn to keep the cities sleeping; a guardian of rest. *His spear is a sharpened root. It grows back when broken.*
6. **Moss-Scribe** — Writes deeds in lichen, reads stone like vellum; law as growth. *Her ink is rainwater and regret. The words fade when the debt is paid.*
7. **Lark-Keeper** — Caged bird sings warnings strangers can’t hear; danger as song. *The lark’s song is a map. Learn it, and you can walk anywhere—once.*
8. **Green Neighbor** — Fae courtier wearing a borrowed smile and boots; hospitality as a trap. *Never accept a gift from a Green Neighbor. It’s never a gift.*
9. **Warden-Coterie** — Beast-kin (badger, stag, lynx); one law: no digging deep. *They speak in growls and gestures. The lynx is the one who remembers faces.*
10. **Echo-Legionary** — Imperial shade bound to a patrol that never ends; duty as a curse. *Its sword passes through stone but not through flesh. Run, don’t fight.*
- J **Shardwright** — Ancient artisan who wakes star-road with a chisel; craft as resurrection. *Her chisel is a tooth from the first dragon. She stole it.*
- Q **Hazel Queen** — Lethai-ar sovereign in leaf and law; wisdom as authority. *She has never spoken a lie. She has never needed to.*
- K **Alder King** — Twilit Court sovereign in shadow and debt; power as obligation. *His crown is a noose of thorns. He wears it proudly.*
- A **The Huntsman** — Antlers of moonlight; shortcuts owe him; the path as price. *His face is a stag’s skull. His voice is the wind in the leaves.*

(Glamour/Ward-Trap/Imperial Residue) Sweet wind nudges landmarks hedge-width—enough to matter; path reverses—footprints vote to go elsewhere.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Sweet Wind** — Nudges landmarks hedge-width—enough to matter; navigation as deception. *The wind smells of honey and lies. Do not trust your nose.*
3. **Path Reversal** — Footprints vote to go elsewhere; direction as democracy. *Your tracks point the way you came—even when you haven’t turned.*

4. **Ward-Trap** — Ancient security treats you as yesterday’s invader; the past as prison. *The glyphs were set by a dead queen. She still enforces her grudges.*
5. **Oath-Magnet** — Spoken promises stick and reshape plans; word as binding magic. *Every “I will” becomes a knot. Every “I won’t” becomes a chain.*
6. **Geas Catch** — A careless word triggers a task that names itself; speech as summoning. *You said “if only.” Now the forest has heard you.*
7. **City Phase** — Streets rotate; the exit becomes a balcony; space as puzzle. *The city breathes. You are in its lungs.*
8. **Name-Theft** — Something learns your true name’s edges; the tests begin. *First, you forget a minor debt. Then a friend’s face. Then your own.*
9. **Ring Claim** — A circle names you host; feeding guests becomes law. *The mushrooms are listening. They will remember what you serve.*
10. **Mirror Rain** — Leaf-drips replay choices you didn’t make; the past as echo. *The rain shows you a path you refused. Now it offers it again—with interest.*
- J **Redcaps Abroad** — Hats wet, boots quick, courtesies thin; violence as hospitality. *They will ask for a kiss or a coin. Refuse, and they take both.*
- Q **Court Tithe** — Truth, song, or memory you’d miss; the price as sacrifice. *The courtier opens its hand. What you place there is never returned.*
- K **Muster of Boughs** — Green banners rise; travel becomes trespass. *The boughs bear old sigils. The war they remember ended a thousand years ago.*
- A **Empire Wakes** — A district aligns; doors open, guardians open farther. *The shades have orders. You are the target.*

(Charm/Key/Truce-Bough) Way-cord knot points to the true next turn; dew-mirror shows a thing as it is, not as it is sung.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Way-Cord** — A knot points to the true next turn (once); navigation as a gift. *The knot is a breath tied in silk. Untie it to find your way—or to lose it forever.*
3. **Dew-Mirror** — See a thing as it is, not as it is sung, for one scene; truth as a tool. *The mirror is a drop of water on a leaf. It dries when the lie dies.*
4. **Hazel Token** — Lawful crossing of a warded hedge without snag; permission as paper. *The token is a hazelnut. Crack it open; the kernel is your password.*
5. **Honey-Right** — Eat and speak safely at any bee-stone ring; hospitality as law. *The honey is golden. Taste it, and the bees will know you as a guest—once.*

6. **Name-Bead** — A kept promise warms; a broken one chills and glows; an oath as a magic item. *The bead is warm in your palm. If it cools, you have forgotten someone.*
 7. **Wind-Veil** — Mute a sweet wind’s lies for a short walk; truth as protection. *The veil is a scrap of silk. Breathe through it, and the wind cannot speak.*
 8. **City-Shard** — Wake one gate or stair in a phasing ruin; a key as a catalyst. *The shard is a piece of a star-road. Hold it to the lock, and the ruin answers.*
 9. **Truce-Bough** — Hunt, cut, or camp without offense in a named copse; peace as a branch. *The bough is green. Plant it in the ground, and the forest will not harm you—or help you.*
 10. **Oathsap** — Seal a pact that even echoes respect; a promise as a binding force. *The sap is warm. Drink it, and your words become stone—for good or ill.*
- J **Shardwright’s Favor** — Repair or light a length of star-road; craft as power. *The favor is a chip of amber. The Shardwright will come when you break it.*
- Q **Hazel Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; word as law. *The audience is a leaf. Speak into its spine, and the Hazel Queen will listen—once.*
- K **Alder Writ** — Levies defer, wardens guide, scribes stop arguing; authority as writ. *The writ is a thorn. Carry it in your boot, and the Alder King’s debtors will make way.*
- A **Valeheart Clause** — A temporary exception to any local rule, spoken in leaves. *The clause is a rustle. The forest will pretend it didn’t hear—but it will remember.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charms/keys/passes) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- Empire Echo: when a J/Q/K is the highest rank in your seed, add one visible relic-logic (floating stairs, singing locks, patrol shades).
- If any A appears, echo **leaf and light** motifs—paths that remember, leaves that whisper, light that moves like water.

Additional Features

- **Forest Claims:** Any oath, bargain, or gift exchanged binds with more weight. Once per session, a spoken promise becomes magically enforceable: breaking it creates 1d4 SB and echoes through scenes.

- **Ruins Awaken:** If you linger at an ancient site, roll or draw to see which mechanism stirs. May grant guidance (lit star-road, a memory shown) or danger (patrol shades, collapsing glyphs).
- **Court Interference:** Encounters with fae or beast-kin are never neutral. Once per session, the GM may convert a Diamond into a demand for hospitality, tribute, or alliance—shifting the expedition’s tone.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Genesis Vats (The Clockwork Monad):** Deep beneath the Amber Ziggurat lie the empire’s failed laboratories. Here, the Lethai ancients combined elf and beast, hoping to create the perfect guardian. The vats still hum, and the beast-kin who survived do not speak of what they saw. The Shardwrights say the Monad’s pressure is still optimising the old designs, and that one day the vats will open again.
- **The Parliament of Claw and Fur (The Savage Heart):** The beast-kin are not savages. They hold a moot once every season, deep in a clearing that no star-road touches. Their laws are carved in scent and scar, and their judgments are final. The Savage Heart speaks through their eldest, but it does not command—it suggests. Outsiders who attend the moot must bring a true name of a foe and leave it on the speaking stone. Those who lie are given fur and four legs, and are hunted at the next moon.
- **Saint Oren of the Unfinished Star (The Ninth):** A Lethai-ar astronomer who calculated the exact angle at which the empire’s star-roads would collapse. He was erased from the imperial records, but his ghost still walks the Ivory Observatory, tracing equations in starlight. Those who find him may ask one question about the forest’s hidden geometry. The answer is always a single number, and that number is a debt.
- **The Grey Pilgrims (The Traveler):** A wandering order of Lethai-ar who maintain the old way-cords. They wear grey cloaks woven from mist and speak only in riddles. It is said that if you give a Grey Pilgrim a lock of your hair, they will knot it into your way-cord, and you will never be lost in the Valewood again—but you will also never find a place you truly wish to leave.
- **The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root):** A renegade Sister hides among the moss-scribes of the Rooted Amphitheatre, trying to untie her own cord from the Hazel Queen’s ledger. She claims the queen’s hospitality is a cage, and that the forest’s memory is a trap. The Hazel Queen has not corrected her; she only smiles, and the roots grow tighter each night.
- **The Ninth:** In any Valewood scene, the ninth leaf to fall from a tree will land pointing to a hidden threshold. The wise catch it—or pretend they didn’t see. Those who follow the leaf’s direction find a place that was not there a moment ago, and something old waits inside.

Valewood Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Roots:** Crumble a crust at the base of a standing stone. Ignore the first *Sweet Wind* penalty.
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a way-cord. Cancel *Oath-Magnet* or take −1 die on your next promise (your choice).
- **Name to the Cistern:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the Moon-Cistern. Gain +1 Effect when evading fae this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Alder King.

Patronage & Power

In the Valewood, power flows through ancient magic, forgotten oaths, and the delicate balance between guest and host. The Lethai-ar maintain influence through their knowledge of paths and ruins, while the fae courts wield power through hospitality and geas. Beast-kin serve as guardians of the deeper mysteries, and the echoes of the empire still patrol their eternal rounds, enforcing laws written in starlight and stone.

For the GM: Patronage in the Valewood revolves around hospitality, knowledge, and the careful navigation of ancient laws. Rewards often take the form of charms, keys, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, mirrors, cords) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival courts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the ruins, groves, and star-roads as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of ancient customs determines success.

In the Valewood, your word is your world, and your world determines whether you walk as a guest or a ghost.

Thematic SB Spend Table**Minor Complications (1 SB)**

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens** or **fae scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **echo-legionaries** or **beast-kin**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **imperial shades**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable phase**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Pathweaver** or **moss-scribe** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **path reversal** or **city phase**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **redcap band** or **patrol shade** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fae courtiers**, **beast-kin**, or **imperial echoes** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **geas triggers/ruin awakens/court interferes**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Hazel Queen**, **Alder King**, or **Huntsman** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **city phases/paths shift/empire wakes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Valewood (Magic Paths):** Routes rearrange without warning, bridges appear mid-step, directions become riddles.
- **Valewood (Fae Law):** Promises bind mid-speech, gifts carry hidden costs, hospitality turns to obligation.
- **Valewood (Imperial Echoes):** Patrols march through walls, ancient mechanisms activate, past and present blur.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Huntsman of Shortcuts (antlers of moonlight)** — *Phases*: Owe the Cut → Step Across → Tally the Tread. *Cracks*: present a **Truce-Bough** to halt pursuit; a **Way-Cord** cancels *Step Across* once.
- **Redcap Captain Rill (hat never dries)** — *Phases*: Hospitality Turned → Knee the Truth → Boot-Hook. *Cracks*: **Honey-Right** reverses one phase; **Dew-Mirror** exposes his “host right.”
- **Echo Centurion of the XIII Star-Road (bronze mask)** — *Phases*: Reform the Line → Juridical Recall → Standard Rekindled. *Cracks*: a **City-Shard** lets you counter-order once; a **Moss-Scribe** ruling cancels *Juridical Recall*.
- **Shardwright Unmended (glassy chisels)** — *Phases*: Cut the Clock → Wrong Stone → Wake the Segment. *Cracks*: offer **Oathsap** to bind a repair oath; **Shardwright’s Favor** flips *Wrong Stone*.
- **The Hazel Advocate (mask of living bark)** — *Phases*: Measure the Word → Prune the Lie → Court Silence. *Cracks*: **Hazel Token** grants speaking rights; **Oathsap** lets you safely retract one bound clause.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Glyphed Bridge Ordeal** — Speak a hard truth to pass dry; lie, and the bridge demands a memory tithe (mark *Name Leverage* +1, gain *Bridge’s Favor* only if confessed).
- **Moon-Cistern Vigil** — Watch someone else’s sky until the owl calls; success grants a single **Dew-Mirror** charge; failure spawns **Mirror Rain**.
- **Valeheart Spiral** — Climb stairs that return to start; map with verse, gift, count, listen (all four once) to unlock a *Between-Places* shortcut.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Name Economy (true-name pressure)**:
 - Each PC has *Name Facets*: **Called-Name** (common), **Given-Name** (trusted), **True-Edge** (dangerous).
 - When a foe or court learns a deeper facet, mark *Name Leverage* [3]. At 3, they may compel one precise action or forbid one path unless countered by a $\diamond$ or **Oathsap**.
 - You may trade a shallower facet to erase 1 tick from *Name Leverage* but gain *Rumor Tail* condition until scene end.
- **Hospitality Ledger (guest/host law)**:
 - When *Honey-Right* or *Truce-Bough* is invoked, set a 3-step *Table Owed* clock for the host and a 3-step *Courtesy Owed* for the guest.
 - Ticking your clock grants +1d to social tests with that party; overpaying (4+) converts 1 tick into a portable *Favor Twig* (spend for +1 Position later).

- Breaking either clock spawns **Ring Claim** or **Oath-Magnet** at the keeper’s option.
- **Path-Logic Mini-game (finding the true way):**
 - Two opposed clocks per journey: *True Way* vs *Forest Has You* (size by highest rank in the seed).
 - Each leg, pick an *Approach*: **Rhyme** (speak a pattern), **Count** (steps/time), **Gift** (leave a token), **Listen** (ambient omen).
 - Edge: Rhyme→Gift (courtesies bind), Gift→Count (the land answers), Count→Listen (timing frames the omen), Listen→Rhyme (echo feeds verse).
 - Spend a **Way-Cord** to flip a failed leg; spend a **Wind-Veil** to ignore **Sweet Wind** once.
- **Truth Mechanics (seeing through glamour):**
 - **Dew-Mirror** reveals one *Unkind Fact* in the scene; naming it aloud gives +1 Effect but ticks **Court Tithe** +1.
 - **Glyphed Bridge** judges the next lie uttered; if you pass speaking truth, gain *Bridge’s Favor* (+1 Position on crossings hereafter). If you lie, mark **Name-Theft** +1.
- **Star-Road Procedure (phasing traversal):**
 - To wake a segment: meet two of three—*Proper Footfall* (count/pattern), *Shard Key* (City-Shard, Shardwright help), *Witness* (owl, echo-legionary, or courtier).
 - Success grants *Between-Places*: one safe shortcut and one *Echo Fee* (memory, song, or small timeline bruise chosen by the GM).
 - On a miss, spawn **Ward-Trap** or **City Phase**.
- **Court Etiquette (Hazel vs Alder):**
 - **Hazel Audience**: pays in *precision*—exact words, measured gifts. +1d when you cite prior custom or present a **Moss-Scribe** ruling.
 - **Alder Writ**: pays in *obligation*—future tasks, debts. +1 Effect when you promise service; tick **Oath-Magnet** +1.
- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**
 1. *Leaf-Whisper*: first Listen/Study gets +1d; first boast draws **Geas Catch**.
 2. *Antler Shadow*: the Huntsman watches—shortcuts improve; hiding worsens.
 3. *Mirror Drip*: **Dew-Mirror** free use but **Court Tithe** starts at 1.
 4. *Root Push*: terrain shifts in your favor once; buildings dislike you (locks complicate).
 5. *Bird Parliament*: a rumor arrives true; one plan becomes public knowledge.
 6. *Star-Tingle*: star-road easier (+1d to wake) but every $\Diamond$ *hereafter* risks **Ward-Trap** on 1–2.

- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Valewood Flavor):**
 - 1 SB → *Sweet Wind Shift*: reposition an approach vector; -1d unless you adjust method (Rhyme/Count/Gift/Listen).
 - 2 SB

4.25 Valewood — “Empire Under Leaves”

Hazel Queen (Elite): “The forest here remembers empires that crumbled to dust, and its laws are older than your kingdoms. To walk these paths is to enter into covenant with powers that measure time in seasons, not years.”

Pathweaver (Commoner): “The woods here got a mind of their own – they’ll lead you where you need to go if you ask right, but they’ll just as soon lose you if you’re carrying ill intent. Best know which is which before you wander off the path.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Valewood is older than kingdoms, older than the maps that skirt its borders. Beneath its canopy lie the bones of a Lethai empire whose name is forgotten, its towers swallowed by vine and root, its star-roads cracked and phasing between worlds. The air hums with half-remembered songs of magic, and the ruins bleed their mysteries into root and stream. Fae courts linger in clearings that shift with moonlight, beast-kin patrol moss-choked cairns, and echoes of imperial shades still march patrols on vanished streets. To walk the Valewood is to risk being claimed by it: as guest, prey, heir—or trespasser.

What you notice first: The smell of wet moss and old stone. The way the light filters through leaves like stained glass. The silence that falls when you speak a name too loudly.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never eat the fruit of a tree that has a face. The forest does not forget its debtors, and the first bite is always the price of admission.

Valewood at a Glance

Quick Reference

Genre	Dark forest / fey remnant / imperial echo
Primary conflict	Phasing ruins, fae courts (Hazel vs. Alder), beast-kin, imperial shades
Key factions	Hazel Queen (Lethai-ar), Alder King (Twilit Court), beast-kin parliament, imperial
Key resources	Way-cords, dew-mirrors, hazel tokens, oathsap, shardwright’s favour
Major threats	Sweet wind, geas catch, name-theft, redcaps, empire waking
Signature taboo	Never eat fruit from a tree with a face; never speak a true name aloud.

Regional Mood: Leaves, Oaths, and Echoes

Here, the past is not past—it phases in and out like moonlight on water. The Lethai-ar who remain are not conquerors but custodians, tending to laws written before the first human kingdom rose. The fae courts of Hazel and Alder play their endless games of courtesy and obligation, and the beast-kin speak in parliaments where every vote is a scent. Imperial shades march through walls that no longer exist, and the star-roads hum with geometries that twist the unwary into yesterday. The Valewood does not forgive arrogance. It expects humility, patience, and the willingness to trade a piece of yourself for safe passage.

Starting Location: A moss-covered amphitheatre where roots crawl through marble benches and owls whisper verdicts to the wind. An Owl-Sister speaks in riddles: “The Lethai-ar stir. The paths remember your true name. Speak it into the hollow of this stone, or the forest will learn it from your footsteps.”

Prominent NPCs of the Valewood

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Queen Amalthea	Hazel Queen, sovereign of the Hazel Court	Preserve the old pacts and keep the empire from waking	She has never spoken a lie. She has never needed to.
King Thorn	Alder King, ruler of the Twilit Court	Collect debts, old and new, and expand the forest’s reach	His crown is a noose of thorns. He wears it proudly.
Pathweaver Sila	Lethai-ar guide (commoner exemplar)	Knot safe routes and keep the star-roads from bleeding	Her cord has eight knots; the ninth is the one she never ties.
Bramble	Fox-headed courier of the beast-kin	Deliver messages that cannot be written	The price is always a secret, and the secret is always bitter.
The Huntsman	Antlered hunter of the Moonlit Ride	Claim those who break the forest’s laws	His face is a stag’s skull; his voice is the wind in the leaves.

Shardwright Kael	Artisan who repairs the star-roads	Wake the ancient ways before they fade forever	Her chisel is a tooth from the first dragon. She stole it.
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Names of the Valewood

Inspired by the old Lethai language and the fae courts: flowing vowels, soft consonants, and names that feel like they belong to a forgotten song.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Caelith		Amalthea	Thornweave	<i>the Green</i>
Eryndor		Sila	Starfoot	<i>Oath-Woven</i>
Kael		Liriel	Hawthorn	<i>the Unseen</i>
Oren		Vesper	Silverbough	<i>Hollow-Tongue</i>
Riven		Fenn	Mossghlen	<i>the Last</i>
Thorn		Myrin	Gloaming	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Phasing Ruin/Star-Road/Living Stone) Star-road shard with pale flagstones that hum when trod in sequence; rooted amphitheatre with moss-seats remembering speeches.

Spades — Places

2. **Star-Road Shard** — Pale flagstones hum when trod in sequence; a path between worlds. *The sequence is always incomplete. The missing step is the one you hesitate to take.*
3. **Rooted Amphitheatre** — Moss-seats remember speeches not yet given; a stage for fate. *Sit in the high seat, and the roots will ask you a question. Answer wrong, and you may never stand.*
4. **Moon-Cistern** — Reflecting sky that isn’t tonight’s; water as a mirror of truth. *The reflection shows what you lost, not what you carry. Look away before it names you.*
5. **Glyphed Bridge** — Across a dry stream; glyphs glow when lies pass; truth as a toll. *The bridge has no railings. Liars fall—into the stream, or into memory.*
6. **Glassleaf Gallery** — Boughs grown into panes, dust like constellations; beauty as a barrier. *The dust is crushed star-road. Breathe it, and you will dream of the empire’s fall.*
7. **Hollow Aqueduct** — Water runs uphill if the song is right; magic in the melody. *The song has eight verses. The ninth is the silence that follows.*
8. **Calendar Grove** — Standing-trees aligned to solstices; one trunk is stone; time as architecture. *The stone tree bleeds sap once a year. Collect it, and the forest owes you a season.*

9. **Unfoun Arcade** — Arches appear at dusk, vanish at dawn; reality as a schedule. *The arches have names—Carved on the inside. You must walk through to read them.*
10. **Breathing City** — Vine-choked streets shift on the hour; a ruin as a living thing. *The vines pulse with a slow heartbeat. The city is sleeping, not dead.*
- J **Amber Ziggurat** — Caught mid-construction for a thousand years; time as an artifact. *The workers are statues of amber. Their eyes follow you.*
- Q **Ivory Observatory** — Brass orrery tracks two lost moons; the sky as memory. *The moons are not in any sky you know. One of them is yours.*
- K **Throne-Bower** — Living alder and argent wire; the seat of forgotten power. *Sit here, and the forest will crown you—or crush you. You won’t know which until the leaves settle.*
- A **Valeheart Spire** — The empire’s axle; stairs that end where they began. *The spire has no top. It has only a center. Finding it is the journey.*

(**Lethai-ar/Fae/Beast-kin**) Pathweaver who knots safe routes into cord; fox-headed courier with a promise braided into its tail.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Pathweaver** — Lethai-ar guide who knots safe routes into cord; navigation as magic. *Her cord has eight knots. The ninth is the one she never ties.*
3. **Fox-Courier** — Promise braided into its tail; messages as living things. *It will deliver anything—for a price. The price is always a secret.*
4. **Owl-Sister** — Pupils show yesterday; her hands show yours; sight as prophecy. *She never blinks. If she does, the future has changed.*
5. **Antler-Hunter** — Sworn to keep the cities sleeping; a guardian of rest. *His spear is a sharpened root. It grows back when broken.*
6. **Moss-Scribe** — Writes deeds in lichen, reads stone like vellum; law as growth. *Her ink is rainwater and regret. The words fade when the debt is paid.*
7. **Lark-Keeper** — Caged bird sings warnings strangers can’t hear; danger as song. *The lark’s song is a map. Learn it, and you can walk anywhere—once.*
8. **Green Neighbor** — Fae courtier wearing a borrowed smile and boots; hospitality as a trap. *Never accept a gift from a Green Neighbor. It’s never a gift.*
9. **Warden-Coterie** — Beast-kin (badger, stag, lynx); one law: no digging deep. *They speak in growls and gestures. The lynx is the one who remembers faces.*
10. **Echo-Legionary** — Imperial shade bound to a patrol that never ends; duty as a curse. *Its sword passes through stone but not through flesh. Run, don’t fight.*

- J **Shardwright** — Ancient artisan who wakes star-road with a chisel; craft as resurrection. *Her chisel is a tooth from the first dragon. She stole it.*
- Q **Hazel Queen** — Lethai-ar sovereign in leaf and law; wisdom as authority. *She has never spoken a lie. She has never needed to.*
- K **Alder King** — Twilit Court sovereign in shadow and debt; power as obligation. *His crown is a noose of thorns. He wears it proudly.*
- A **The Huntsman** — Antlers of moonlight; shortcuts owe him; the path as price. *His face is a stag’s skull. His voice is the wind in the leaves.*

(**Glamour/Ward-Trap/Imperial Residue**) Sweet wind nudges landmarks hedge-width—enough to matter; path reverses—footprints vote to go elsewhere.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Sweet Wind** — Nudges landmarks hedge-width—enough to matter; navigation as deception. *The wind smells of honey and lies. Do not trust your nose.*
3. **Path Reversal** — Footprints vote to go elsewhere; direction as democracy. *Your tracks point the way you came—even when you haven’t turned.*
4. **Ward-Trap** — Ancient security treats you as yesterday’s invader; the past as prison. *The glyphs were set by a dead queen. She still enforces her grudges.*
5. **Oath-Magnet** — Spoken promises stick and reshape plans; word as binding magic. *Every “I will” becomes a knot. Every “I won’t” becomes a chain.*

Oath-Magnet Mechanics

When a character makes a promise in the Valewood, the GM creates a **Promise Clock [4]**. Each time the character acts against that promise (or fails to act in its favour), tick the clock. When it fills, the forest extracts a toll: 1 Fatigue, a lost memory (erase a minor fact or face), or a minor geas (the GM chooses). Breaking a promise intentionally (not through failure) instantly ticks the clock twice.

6. **Geas Catch** — A careless word triggers a task that names itself; speech as summoning. *You said “if only.” Now the forest has heard you.*
7. **City Phase** — Streets rotate; the exit becomes a balcony; space as puzzle. *The city breathes. You are in its lungs.*
8. **Name-Theft** — Something learns your true name’s edges; the tests begin. *First, you forget a minor debt. Then a friend’s face. Then your own.*

Name-Theft Mechanics

When **Name-Theft** occurs, the GM secretly records one piece of the target’s identity (a memory, a bond, a talent name). The target suffers –1 die on any roll that would rely on that piece until it is restored by a quest or a bargain with the thief (often a fae or shade).

9. **Ring Claim** — A circle names you host; feeding guests becomes law. *The mushrooms are listening. They will remember what you serve.*
10. **Mirror Rain** — Leaf-drips replay choices you didn’t make; the past as echo. *The rain shows you a path you refused. Now it offers it again—with interest.*
- J **Redcaps Abroad** — Hats wet, boots quick, courtesies thin; violence as hospitality. *They will ask for a kiss or a coin. Refuse, and they take both.*
- Q **Court Tithe** — Truth, song, or memory you’d miss; the price as sacrifice. *The courtier opens its hand. What you place there is never returned.*
- K **Muster of Boughs** — Green banners rise; travel becomes trespass. *The boughs bear old sigils. The war they remember ended a thousand years ago.*
- A **Empire Wakes** — A district aligns; doors open, guardians open farther. *The shades have orders. You are the target.*

(**Charm/Key/Truce-Bough**) Way-cord knot points to the true next turn; dew-mirror shows a thing as it is, not as it is sung.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Way-Cord** — A knot points to the true next turn (once); navigation as a gift. *The knot is a breath tied in silk. Untie it to find your way—or to lose it forever.*
3. **Dew-Mirror** — See a thing as it is, not as it is sung, for one scene; truth as a tool. *The mirror is a drop of water on a leaf. It dries when the lie dies.*
4. **Hazel Token** — Lawful crossing of a warded hedge without snag; permission as paper. *The token is a hazelnut. Crack it open; the kernel is your password.*
5. **Honey-Right** — Eat and speak safely at any bee-stone ring; hospitality as law. *The honey is golden. Taste it, and the bees will know you as a guest—once.*
6. **Name-Bead** — A kept promise warms; a broken one chills and glows; an oath as a magic item. *The bead is warm in your palm. If it cools, you have forgotten someone.*
7. **Wind-Veil** — Mute a sweet wind’s lies for a short walk; truth as protection. *The veil is a scrap of silk. Breathe through it, and the wind cannot speak.*

8. **City-Shard** — Wake one gate or stair in a phasing ruin; a key as a catalyst. *The shard is a piece of a star-road. Hold it to the lock, and the ruin answers.*
9. **Truce-Bough** — Hunt, cut, or camp without offense in a named copse; peace as a branch. *The bough is green. Plant it in the ground, and the forest will not harm you—or help you.*
10. **Oathsap** — Seal a pact that even echoes respect; a promise as a binding force. *The sap is warm. Drink it, and your words become stone—for good or ill.*
- J **Shardwright’s Favor** — Repair or light a length of star-road; craft as power. *The favor is a chip of amber. The Shardwright will come when you break it.*
- Q **Hazel Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; word as law. *The audience is a leaf. Speak into its spine, and the Hazel Queen will listen—once.*
- K **Alder Writ** — Levies defer, wardens guide, scribes stop arguing; authority as writ. *The writ is a thorn. Carry it in your boot, and the Alder King’s debtors will make way.*
- A **Valeheart Clause** — A temporary exception to any local rule, spoken in leaves. *The clause is a rustle. The forest will pretend it didn’t hear—but it will remember.*

Quick use notes

- * Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- * Diamonds are codified outcomes (charms/keys/passers) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- * Empire Echo: when a J/Q/K is the highest rank in your seed, add one visible relic-logic (floating stairs, singing locks, patrol shades).
- * If any A appears, echo **leaf and light** motifs—paths that remember, leaves that whisper, light that moves like water.

Additional Features

- * **Forest Claims:** Any oath, bargain, or gift exchanged binds with more weight. Once per session, a spoken promise becomes magically enforceable: breaking it creates 1d4 SB and echoes through scenes.
- * **Ruins Awaken:** If you linger at an ancient site, roll or draw to see which mechanism stirs. May grant guidance (lit star-road, a memory shown) or danger (patrol shades, collapsing glyphs).
- * **Court Interference:** Encounters with fae or beast-kin are never neutral. Once per session, the GM may convert a Diamond into a demand for hospitality, tribute, or alliance—shifting the expedition’s tone.

Forest Mood (d6 per scene)

Forest Mood Table

1. **Hazel’s Favour** – Paths open willingly. +1 die to navigation rolls this scene.
2. **Alder’s Hunger** – Debts are called. Someone in the scene must offer a memory or service to proceed.
3. **Empire Wakes** – A patrol of imperial shades marches through. Avoid or pay a toll (1 Fatigue or a secret).
4. **Beast-kin Moot** – Animals gather and watch. They will not attack unless provoked, but they remember faces.
5. **Sweet Wind** – All navigation rolls suffer –1 die; landmarks shift subtly.
6. **Green Gate Breath** – A threshold appears. Crossing it leads to a different part of the forest (or a different time).

Star-Road Discovery (d6)

When the party encounters a star-road shard or attempts to wake a segment, roll on this table for an additional feature:

1. **Singing Stones** – The flagstones hum a tune. Anyone who sings along gains +1 die on the next roll.
2. **Echo of an Emperor** – A ghostly figure appears and asks a riddle. A correct answer grants a **City-Shard**.
3. **Fractured Timeline** – The road shows a glimpse of the future (1d6 scenes ahead). The GM must answer one yes/no question truthfully.
4. **Ward-Trap** – The segment is booby-trapped. Trigger a **Ward-Trap** complication (see Clubs).
5. **Shardwright’s Cache** – Hidden nearby is a **Shardwright’s Favor** (Diamond) or a rare component (e.g., amber shard).
6. **The Ninth Step** – The sequence has a hidden ninth stone. Stepping on it teleports the party to a **Valeheart Spire** or a court audience.

Beast-kin Traits (for NPCs or PC ancestry)

Beast-kin are not a single species but a loose alliance of animal-aspected beings. Use these traits for quick NPCs or optional player characters.

Beast-kin Traits

- * **Scent Memory:** +1 die to track a creature you have smelled before.
- * **Parliament Oath:** Once per session, you may invoke the beast-kin moot to ask a local animal one simple question (the GM answers truthfully).
- * **Claw or Fang:** Unarmed strikes deal Harm 1 and count as Light weapons.
- * **Optional:** Choose a lineage:
 - *Stag:* +1 die to resist being moved or knocked prone.
 - *Lynx:* +1 die to stealth in forest terrain.
 - *Badger:* You may burrow through loose earth at half speed.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- * **The Genesis Vats (The Clockwork Monad):** Deep beneath the Amber Ziggurat lie the empire’s failed laboratories. Here, the Lethai ancients combined elf and beast, hoping to create the perfect guardian. The vats still hum, and the beast-kin who survived do not speak of what they saw. The Shardwrights say the Monad’s pressure is still optimising the old designs, and that one day the vats will open again.
- * **The Parliament of Claw and Fur (The Savage Heart):** The beast-kin are not savages. They hold a moot once every season, deep in a clearing that no star-road touches. Their laws are carved in scent and scar, and their judgments are final. The Savage Heart speaks through their eldest, but it does not command—it suggests. Outsiders who attend the moot must bring a true name of a foe and leave it on the speaking stone. Those who lie are given fur and four legs, and are hunted at the next moon.
- * **Saint Oren of the Unfinished Star (The Ninth):** A Lethai-ar astronomer who calculated the exact angle at which the empire’s star-roads would collapse. He was erased from the imperial records, but his ghost still walks the Ivory Observatory, tracing equations in starlight. Those who find him may ask one question about the forest’s hidden geometry. The answer is always a single number, and that number is a debt.
- * **The Grey Pilgrims (The Traveler):** A wandering order of Lethai-ar who maintain the old way-cords. They wear grey cloaks woven from mist and speak only in riddles. It is said that if you give a Grey Pilgrim a lock of your hair, they will knot it into your way-cord, and you will never be lost in the Valewood again—but you will also never find a place you truly wish to leave.
- * **The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root):** A renegade Sister hides among the moss-scribes of the Rooted Amphitheatre, trying to untie her own cord from the Hazel Queen’s ledger. She claims the queen’s

hospitality is a cage, and that the forest’s memory is a trap. The Hazel Queen has not corrected her; she only smiles, and the roots grow tighter each night.

- * **The Ninth:** In any Valewood scene, the ninth leaf to fall from a tree will land pointing to a hidden threshold. The wise catch it—or pretend they didn’t see. Those who follow the leaf’s direction find a place that was not there a moment ago, and something old waits inside.

Valewood Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- * **Bread to the Roots:** Crumble a crust at the base of a standing stone. Ignore the first *Sweet Wind* penalty.
- * **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a way-cord. Cancel *Oath-Magnet* or take −1 die on your next promise (your choice).
- * **Name to the Cistern:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the Moon-Cistern. Gain +1 Effect when evading fae this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Alder King.

Patronage & Power

In the Valewood, power flows through ancient magic, forgotten oaths, and the delicate balance between guest and host. The Lethai-ar maintain influence through their knowledge of paths and ruins, while the fae courts wield power through hospitality and geas. Beast-kin serve as guardians of the deeper mysteries, and the echoes of the empire still patrol their eternal rounds, enforcing laws written in starlight and stone. **For the GM:** Patronage in the Valewood revolves around hospitality, knowledge, and the careful navigation of ancient laws. Rewards often take the form of charms, keys, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- * Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, mirrors, cords) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- * Let rival courts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- * Use the ruins, groves, and star-roads as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of ancient customs determines success.

In the Valewood, your word is your world, and your world determines whether you walk as a guest or a ghost.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- * **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fae scouts**.

- * **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **echo-legionaries** or **beast-kin**.
- * **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **imperial shades**.
- * **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable phase**.
- * **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- * **Alarm Raised:** **Pathweaver** or **moss-scribe** becomes aware and begins responding.
- * **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **path reversal** or **city phase**.
- * **Foe Appears:** A **redcap band** or **patrol shade** arrives on scene.
- * **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- * **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- * **Reinforcements:** Additional **fae courtiers**, **beast-kin**, or **imperial echoes** arrive.
- * **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- * **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **geas triggers/ruin awakens/court interferes**.
- * **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- * **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- * **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- * **Authority Arrival:** **Hazel Queen**, **Alder King**, or **Huntsman** intervenes.
- * **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **city phases/paths shift/empire wakes**.
- * **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- * **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- * **Valewood (Magic Paths):** Routes rearrange without warning, bridges appear mid-step, directions become riddles.
- * **Valewood (Fae Law):** Promises bind mid-speech, gifts carry hidden costs, hospitality turns to obligation.

- * **Valewood (Imperial Echoes):** Patrols march through walls, ancient mechanisms activate, past and present blur.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- * **The Huntsman of Shortcuts (antlers of moonlight)** — *Phases:* Owe the Cut → Step Across → Tally the Tread. *Cracks:* present a **Truce-Bough** to halt pursuit; a **Way-Cord** cancels *Step Across* once.
- * **Redcap Captain Rill (hat never dries)** — *Phases:* Hospitality Turned → Knee the Truth → Boot-Hook. *Cracks:* **Honey-Right** reverses one phase; **Dew-Mirror** exposes his “host right.”
- * **Echo Centurion of the XIII Star-Road (bronze mask)** — *Phases:* Reform the Line → Juridical Recall → Standard Rekindled. *Cracks:* a **City-Shard** lets you counter-order once; a **Moss-Scribe** ruling cancels *Juridical Recall*.
- * **Shardwright Unmended (glassy chisels)** — *Phases:* Cut the Clock → Wrong Stone → Wake the Segment. *Cracks:* offer **Oathsap** to bind a repair oath; **Shardwright’s Favor** flips *Wrong Stone*.
- * **The Hazel Advocate (mask of living bark)** — *Phases:* Measure the Word → Prune the Lie → Court Silence. *Cracks:* **Hazel Token** grants speaking rights; **Oathsap** lets you safely retract one bound clause.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- * **Glyphed Bridge Ordeal** — Speak a hard truth to pass dry; lie, and the bridge demands a memory tithe (mark *Name Leverage* +1, gain *Bridge’s Favor* only if confessed).
- * **Moon-Cistern Vigil** — Watch someone else’s sky until the owl calls; success grants a single **Dew-Mirror** charge; failure spawns **Mirror Rain**.
- * **Valeheart Spiral** — Climb stairs that return to start; map with verse, gift, count, listen (all four once) to unlock a *Between-Places* shortcut.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- * **Name Economy (true-name pressure):**
 - Each PC has *Name Facets*: **Called-Name** (common), **Given-Name** (trusted), **True-Edge** (dangerous).
 - When a foe or court learns a deeper facet, mark *Name Leverage* [3]. At 3, they may compel one precise action or forbid one path unless countered by a $\Diamond$ or **Oathsap**.
 - You may trade a shallower facet to erase 1 tick from *Name Leverage* but gain *Rumor Tail* condition until scene end.
- * **Hospitality Ledger (guest/host law):**
 - When *Honey-Right* or *Truce-Bough* is invoked, set a 3-step *Table Owed* clock for the host and a 3-step *Courtesy Owed* for the guest.

- Ticking your clock grants +1d to social tests with that party; overpaying (4+) converts 1 tick into a portable *Favor Twig* (spend for +1 Position later).
- Breaking either clock spawns **Ring Claim** or **Oath-Magnet** at the keeper’s option.
- * **Path-Logic Mini-game (finding the true way):**
 - Two opposed clocks per journey: *True Way* vs *Forest Has You* (size by highest rank in the seed).
 - Each leg, pick an *Approach*: **Rhyme** (speak a pattern), **Count** (steps/time), **Gift** (leave a token), **Listen** (ambient omen).
 - Edge: Rhyme→Gift (courtesies bind), Gift→Count (the land answers), Count→Listen (timing frames the omen), Listen→Rhyme (echo feeds verse).
 - Spend a **Way-Cord** to flip a failed leg; spend a **Wind-Veil** to ignore **Sweet Wind** once.
- * **Truth Mechanics (seeing through glamour):**
 - **Dew-Mirror** reveals one *Unkind Fact* in the scene; naming it aloud gives +1 Effect but ticks **Court Tithe** +1.
 - **Glyphed Bridge** judges the next lie uttered; if you pass speaking truth, gain *Bridge’s Favor* (+1 Position on crossings hereafter). If you lie, mark **Name-Theft** +1.
- * **Star-Road Procedure (phasing traversal):**
 - To wake a segment: meet two of three—*Proper Footfall* (count/pattern), *Shard Key* (City-Shard, Shardwright help), *Witness* (owl, echo-legionary, or courtier).
 - Success grants *Between-Places*: one safe shortcut and one *Echo Fee* (memory, song, or small timeline bruise chosen by the GM).
 - On a miss, spawn **Ward-Trap** or **City Phase**.
- * **Court Etiquette (Hazel vs Alder):**
 - **Hazel Audience**: pays in *precision*—exact words, measured gifts. +1d when you cite prior custom or present a **Moss-Scribe** ruling.
 - **Alder Writ**: pays in *obligation*—future tasks, debts. +1 Effect when you promise service; tick **Oath-Magnet** +1.
- * **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**
 1. *Leaf-Whisper*: first Listen/Study gets +1d; first boast draws **Geas Catch**.
 2. *Antler Shadow*: the Huntsman watches—shortcuts improve; hiding worsens.
 3. *Mirror Drip*: **Dew-Mirror** free use but **Court Tithe** starts at 1.
 4. *Root Push*: terrain shifts in your favor once; buildings dislike you (locks complicate).
 5. *Bird Parliament*: a rumor arrives true; one plan becomes public knowledge.
 6. *Star-Tingle*: star-road easier (+1d to wake) but every ◇*hereafter* risks **Ward-Trap** −2.

* **Plug-in SB Conversions (Valewood Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Sweet Wind Shift*: reposition an approach vector; −1d unless you adjust method (Rhyme/Count/Gift/Listen).
- 2 SB → *Obligate Courtesy*: immediate small gift or truth required; refuse and tick *Name Leverage* +1.
- 3+ SB → *Empire Echo*: add a patrolling **Echo-Legionary** cohort or activate a dormant mechanism that reframes the scene.

* **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Guest-Faithful*: once/session, downgrade **Ring Claim** to simple hospitality; the next refused invitation spawns **Oath-Magnet**.
- *Path-Favored*: +1 Position on *Path-Logic* legs; any shortcut taken owes a *token or tale*.
- *Truth-Bearer*: +1d with the Hazel court when presenting facts; −1d with the Alder court when declining obligation.

* **Quick Cross-Region Hooks:**

- *Kahfagia Lanes* ↔ *Star-Roads*: a **Mirror Warrant** can stand in for a **Shard Key** once.
- *Mistlands Bells* ↔ *Path-Logic*: paying **Ward-Salt** counts as the *Gift* approach with +1d.
- *Aelinnel Math* ↔ *Proper Footfall*: *Counting Etiquette* grants +1 Position on the **Star-Road Procedure**.

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Artifacts of the Valewood

The Valewood remembers not only oaths and names but also the tools of those who came before. Some artifacts are cursed by the empire’s fall; others are blessed by the forest’s slow patience. Each artifact carries its own burden—a fragment of will that accumulates Obligation as it is used. When the Obligation fills, the artifact demands a price, just as a Patron does.

Artifact Obligation Rules

- An artifact has an **Obligation Capacity** equal to the wielder’s **Spirit** (or a fixed number, as noted). Mark Obligation each time a Rite is invoked.
- When Obligation exceeds Capacity, the wielder marks 1 Fatigue per extra segment (as per standard Obligation overflow).
- When the artifact’s Obligation clock reaches double its Capacity, it **demand**s a price (see each artifact’s “Demand”). Refusing the demand may cause the artifact to become *Compromised* (unusable until a quest is completed) or to inflict a permanent curse.
- Obligation can be cleared through acts of service aligned with the artifact’s nature (e.g., protecting a grove, telling a forgotten truth, shedding your own blood).
- Bound by Obligation: An artifact cannot be permanently discarded or destroyed while you owe it Obligation. If you deliberately abandon it (or attempt to destroy it by mundane means), it reappears beside you at the next dawn, and you mark +1 Obligation. This penalty applies only once per artifact; subsequent attempts to abandon it cause the artifact to become *Compromised* – it still reappears, but its Rites cannot be invoked until you perform a minor act of devotion (GM’s choice). An artifact can be legitimately transferred to another willing creature, clearing your Obligation; the new owner inherits any remaining Obligation. An artifact can be permanently destroyed only by a specific method (e.g., a star-road shard, a dragon’s tooth, or the Hazel Queen’s permission), which typically requires a quest.

Artifact	Description	Rites (Abilities)	Demand (Obligation 2×Cap)
<i>Echo’s Lament</i>	A silver hand-bell with a cracked clapper. When rung, it repeats the last words spoken at the site of an imperial execution.	Rite of the Last Echo (Low) – Ask one question about a death that occurred within Near range; the bell answers with a whisper. Mark +1 Obligation.	The wielder must pronounce a true name of someone they have wronged, aloud and unasked, before the next full moon.

<i>Thorn-Fang</i>	A dagger carved from a single hawthorn root, its edge weeping sap that smells of iron and honey.	Rite of the Unhealing Prick (Low) – On a successful melee attack, the wound bleeds for 1 additional Fatigue per scene (non-stacking). Mark +1 Obligation.	The dagger demands a drop of the wielder’s own blood before each dawn; if refused, it turns on its owner (next attack targets self).
<i>Glassleaf Lantern</i>	A lantern whose panes are made of petrified leaves. It burns without oil, casting light that reveals only things that are lost.	Rite of the Unfound Path (Standard) – Once per scene, the lantern illuminates a hidden threshold or a forgotten memory in the area. Gain +2 dice to Investigation or Navigation for that task. Mark +2 Obligation.	The lantern demands to be left at a crossroads at midnight. If not, it will guide the wielder into a dead end (next travel leg automatically fails).
<i>Cord of Eight Knots</i>	A finger-thick rope of braided grey wool, with eight tight knots. The ninth knot is missing.	Rite of the Unbroken Promise (Low) – Tie the cord around a willing creature’s wrist; until untied, that creature cannot willingly break a spoken oath. Mark +1 Obligation.	The cord demands a ninth knot, which must be tied in a strand of hair from someone who has broken a vow. Untying any existing knot costs 1 Fatigue.
<i>Alder King’s Tooth</i>	A black, curling tooth set in a copper ring. When worn, it whispers the debts of those nearby.	Rite of Debt-Sense (Low) – Concentrate for a moment; learn the single greatest debt owed by a creature you can see (in vague terms: “a life,” “a stolen heirloom”). Mark +1 Obligation.	The tooth demands that you collect a minor debt (a few coins, a favour) from someone weaker than you before sunset. If you refuse, it begins listing your own debts aloud.

<i>Shardwright's Mallet</i>	A stone hammer with a handle of petrified wood. One side is smooth (to repair), the other rough (to break).	Rite of the Broken Seal (Standard) – Strike a phasing ruin or star-road shard. Either temporarily stabilise it (open a safe passage) or shatter it (destroy the path, cause a Ward-Trap). Mark +2 Obligation.	The mallet demands that you break something precious to you (a gift, a memento, a tool) and leave the pieces on a star-road.
<i>Mirror of Unfinished Faces</i>	A hand mirror with a silvered surface that shows not your reflection but a version of you who made a different choice.	Rite of the Other Self (Low) – Gaze into the mirror; gain +1 die on your next roll that involves a decision (the other self's memory guides you). Mark +1 Obligation.	The mirror demands that you speak aloud the choice you regret most, to a stranger, within a day. If you refuse, the other self begins to appear in reflections, whispering doubts.
<i>Whispering Horn</i>	A curved horn of amber, cracked along one side. When blown, it sounds like the roar of a forgotten beast.	Rite of the Imperial Hunt (Standard) – Once per session, blow the horn to summon a spectral pack of hounds that track a designated target for one scene (grants +1 die to tracking and pursuit). Mark +2 Obligation.	The horn demands a hunt – you must chase and catch something (even a mouse) within the hour, or the spirits will hunt you instead (suffer Harm 1 from ethereal bites).

<i>Grave-Moss Cloak</i>	A heavy cloak woven from moss that grows only on imperial barrows. It is always damp and smells of rain.	Rite of the Walking Dead (Low) – Pull the hood up; for one scene, imperial shades treat you as one of their own (no attacks, you may pass patrols). Mark +1 Obligation per scene of use.	The cloak demands that you bury something that was never buried – a memory, a secret, a tooth. If you fail to do so before the next moon, it wraps itself around your throat in your sleep.
<i>Hazel Queen’s Comb</i>	A wooden comb carved with thorned vines. Running it through your hair removes tangles and also removes recent memories.	Rite of the Forgetful Stroke (Low) – Stroke the comb through your hair; erase one recent short-term memory (a face, a password, a few minutes of events). The memory is stored in the comb. Mark +1 Obligation.	The comb demands that you give a stored memory to a stranger without explanation. If you refuse, the comb begins to remove random memories each dawn (GM chooses).

Using Artifact Rites in Play

- Activating a Rite takes an action unless noted otherwise.
- Unlike Patron Rites, artifact Rites do not require a Codex or Familiar – only possession of the artifact.
- The GM may allow a wielder to clear artifact Obligation by performing a small act of devotion (e.g., for *Thorn-Fang*: cut a thorn bush; for *Glassleaf Lantern*: leave it in a moonbeam overnight).
- Artifacts can be stolen, lost, or destroyed. If an artifact is destroyed, any accumulated Obligation is cleared, but the destruction itself may trigger a final demand (GM’s discretion).

4.26 Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”

Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (Elite): “The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains. Every coin minted here carries our blessing, and every law written bears our seal – the rest is just politics.”

Road Warden (Commoner): “I’ve served under three different banners on this same stretch of road, and the only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls. My horn calls honest warning – best heed it. The Fenwoods burned Lence, and now every duke with a coin purse thinks he’s king.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Vhasia is a realm of broken coronations and split loyalties. Once a proud province of the Utaran empire, the unified Sun-court shattered like its heraldic sunburst when the Fenwoods of Viterra and their allies sacked the capital of Lence and cast down the old Blood line. Now rival dukes, duchesses, abbesses, and parlements claim the fractured light. Everywhere, signs of fracture: chipped sun-discs on milestones, worn tabards bearing half a crown, coins minted in rival cities with different suns. In Vhasia, legitimacy is as fragile as a mirror, and every oath risks breaking along the fault lines of politics, faith, and fortune.

What you notice first: The smell of old smoke and fresh ink. The way every noble’s seal has a hairline crack. The constant, nervous laughter of courtiers who remember whose head rolled last season.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason.

Regional Mood: Crowns, Courts, and Companies

Here, the past is a weapon and the future is a debt. The Fenwoods came from Viterra with fire and iron, broke the Sun-king’s army at the Ford of Ashes, and burned Lence until the mirrors melted. They left the throne empty—not destroyed, but open. Now every duke with a long purse and a short conscience backs a claimant. The Queen-Mother weaves alliances from her riverside keep. The Two Crowns—rival dukes crowned in rival cathedrals—march their levies through fields that can feed neither. Routiers sell their swords by the season, and parlement clerks drown justice in procedure. Vhasia is not a nation at war. It is a nation that forgot how to be at peace.

Starting Location: The Pont-du-Tithe, its golden arches catching fire in the sunset as pilgrims chant from both banks. A Duchy Constable in splendid armor guards the toll gate. “The Chevauchee burns,” he says, gesturing to distant smoke. “Two Crowns march to meet it. Whose seal do you carry? Speak quickly—the levy waits for no one.”

Prominent NPCs of Vhasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Elleanor Everblood	Queen-Mother (née Longblood) of Ethon	Restore her son Valdais to the throne	She has outlived three husbands and two sons; she is not mourning.
Valdais Longblood	Duke of Adria, claimant to the Sun-court	Unite Vhasia under a strong northern crown	He has never lost a joust. His opponents have a habit of falling ill before the tilt.
The Red Marshal	Exiled commander of the Sun-court’s army	Win back Lence or die trying	He lost the Battle of Ashes; he still sees it in his dreams—and his nightmares.
Seint Michel’s Justiciar	Magistrate of the Order of the Gilded Scale	Enforce the chivalric code without mercy	He carries a scale with one pan empty; the empty pan is for lies.
Sister Oria	Custodian of the Lantern-Rites House on the Belworth	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.
The Cantor Alain	Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring	Sing the truth of Corin’s mercy before the armor closes again	Feathers grow from his temples; his shadow moves a half-step behind him.

Names of Vhasia

Inspired by the fractured duchies: Francien, Norman, and Brittonic influences. Soft vowels, silent consonants, and surnames that recall a bridge, a ford, or a stained banner.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valdais		Eliador	de la Marche	<i>the Iron</i>
Renaud		Isabeau	de Lence	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Corin		Oria	d'Aethor	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Touénot		Mael	du Pont	<i>the Silver</i>
Alain		Giselle	de la Croix	<i>Ash-Banner</i>
Ghiro		Celandine	l'Argent	<i>the Unpaid</i>

(Château/Cathedral/Forest) Wayside shrine with pilgrims tacking petitions to a scorched sun-disc; vine-terraced clos above a millstream with napping watchmen.

Spades — Places

2. **Wayside Shrine** — Pilgrims tack petitions to a scorched sun-disc; each parchment curls in different winds. *The petitions are never answered. The shrine is a mailbox for the dead.*
3. **Vine-Terrace** — Clos above a millstream; watchmen nap, halberds traded for bottles. *The best vintage is called “Crownbreaker.” It tastes like smoke and regret.*
4. **Bastide Square** — Neat as a checkerboard; merchants pay homage to different “hours” of the Sun. *The square has a gallows. It rotates to face whichever claimant lost the last duel.*
5. **Royal Forest** — Antler posts mark laws no king remembers; poachers still hang. *The forest’s deer have grown bold. They wear crowns of shed antlers.*
6. **Pont-du-Tithe** — Toll-bridge flanked by chapels and crossbows; chains blessed by rival bishops. *The chains were forged from melted sunbursts. They ring in different keys.*
7. **Great Fair** — Outside a chartered town; counting sheds ring like bells, rumors louder still. *The fair has a Court of Miracles where counterfeiters sell to informers.*
8. **Salt Pans** — Wind-pumps on an estuary; gulls own the law, smugglers own the night. *The salt is grey. It tastes of old tears and older debts.*
9. **Siege-Château** — Hoardings patched, cistern low, banners cut into ragged suns. *The banner’s ragged edges are from a Fenwood sword. The owner still limps.*
10. **Cathedral Yard** — Cranes creak, stones fly, scaffolds bristle with rival masons’ marks. *The mason’s marks are clan signs. A scratched-out mark means a dead foreman.*

J Parlement Hall — Hung with faded tapestries; sunbursts spliced and re-stitched by claimants. *The tapestries show battles that never happened—and some that shouldn’t have.*

Q Queen’s Causeway — Mile-long oath paved in quarried stone; half-sunk each spring. *The sunken half is a graveyard for vows. The stones are slippery with old lies.*

K Sun Palace (Lence) — Shuttered mirrors, brambled gardens; courtiers playing at kingship. *The mirrors were covered after the sack. No one wants to see what they show now.*

A King’s High Road — Milestones chipped of crowns; yet every army still marches it. *The road is paved with the bones of tax collectors. They are not missed.*

(Lord/Court/Company) Road warden with dented badge and honest horn; vintner-guild syndic counting saints’ days as credit terms.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Road Warden** — Dented badge, honest horn; ignored by both crowns but knows the roads. *His horn is cracked. It still sounds—but the note is always half a step flat.*

3. **Vintner Syndic** — Counts saints’ days as credit terms, vintages as treaties; wine as diplomacy. *He keeps a bottle of Crownbreaker in every cellar. He knows which vintage each duke prefers.*

4. **Abbess-Chatelaine** — Rules a fortress-convent with iron accounts and sharper scripture. *She has never drawn a blade. The scaffold has, on her orders.*

5. **Routier Captain** — Scarred and mercenary; prefers ransoms to loyalty; coin as conscience. *He switches banners as often as his shirt. His loyalty is to the paychest—and his mother.*

6. **Duchy Constable** — Splendid armor, empty coffers, pride swollen as a banner; glory over gold. *His armor was his grandfather’s. It still has the dent from a Fenwood axe.*

7. **Parlement Clerk** — Drowns foes in procedure, fishes them out for fealty; law as a weapon. *His quill is a dagger. He sharpens it every morning.*

8. **Salt-Farmer** — Gabelle lessee with cudgels, writs, and a river-chart no crown has; tax as tyranny. *His ledger is written in salt. One drop of water and the debts vanish—along with the evidence.*

9. **Trouvère** — A scandalous lay about the last Sun-king brings knives to tavern doors. *He sings the truth. That is why he sleeps in a different inn every night.*

10. **Marshal-Exile** — The Sun-court’s hammer; now wielded by whoever pays in silver. *He lost the Battle of Ashes. He still sees it in his dreams—and his nightmares.*

J **Heretic Perfect** — Preaches peace while tucking hidden daggers into parchment margins. *His sermon is a code. The psalms tell you which bridge to cross—and which to burn.*

Q **Queen-Mother** — Riverside keep; weaves alliances as if they were dowers. *She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning.*

K **Two Crowns** — Rival dukes, each “crowned” in rival cathedrals, neither whole. *One wears a crown of iron. The other wears a crown of words. Both rust.*

A **Last Dauphin** — A rumor with a birthmark; armies march for whispers alone. *He may be a baker’s son. The armies don’t care. They need a sun to follow.*

(Chevauchée/Law/Church) Chevauchée burning loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. Interdict falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Chevauchée** — Raiders burn loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. *The raiders wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles—and grudges.*

3. **Interdict** — Falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls, heretics prosper. *The bells were melted for shot three wars ago. The silence is old.*

4. **Forest Law** — Venison becomes treason; poachers hang from antler posts. *The antler posts are carved with the names of the hanged. They whisper at dusk.*

5. **River Spate** — Ferries chained, bridges drowned, pilgrims stranded mid-prayer. *The water is the color of old gold. It washed away a mint last spring.*

6. **Coin Debasement** — Three mints, three suns, no trust; soldiers demand silver alone. *The silver is from the same mine—but the stamp is a prayer, not a promise.*

7. **Parlement Divided** — A siege laid on parchment before walls; war by paperwork. *The clerks duel with citations. The loser pays the winner’s ink bill.*

8. **Company Mutiny** — Unless arrears are paid—in blood or coin; mercenaries as a time bomb. *The mutineers have a list. Your name is on it—or will be by nightfall.*

9. **Relic Dispute** — Two abbeys claim the same saint’s bones; mobs answer with stones. *The bones are actually from a cow. The saints don’t mind. They like the attention.*

10. **Harvest Blight** — Bread locked behind pikes; bakers guarded as lords. *The blight has a name. It is the name of a duke who raised the levy too late.*

J **Tournament “Accident”** — Hides an assassination; your favor is now evidence. *The lance was filed with a prayer. The prayer was answered—but not for the target.*

Q **Royalist Restoration** — Sunburst badges painted overnight on doors and graves. *The paint is the color of dried blood. The badges face the wrong direction.*

K **Feudal Levy** — Lords demand levies in days, not months, with three days’ bread. *The bread is hardtack from the last Fenwood siege. It still smells of smoke.*

A **Winter Campaign** — Roads turn to mud, hooves to ice, armies to ruin. *The snow is grey with ash. The Pass of Ashes has a sister pass now.*

(**Charter/Patent/Right**) Safe-conduct sealed by a duke or abbey; honored only once, on one road; burgess charter for a market ward.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Safe-Conduct** — Sealed by a duke or abbey; honored only once, on one road. *The seal is cracked. The road is watched. Use it before the seal breaks.*

3. **Burgess Charter** — A market ward; walls, watch, and revenue at your call. *The charter is a bell. Ring it, and the town answers—or it doesn’t.*

4. **Bridge Farm** — Tolls at Pont-du-Tithe for a season, if you can hold it. *The tollkeepers are loyal to the last coin. Yours or theirs.*

5. **Paréage Charter** — Shared rule with a monastery—half justice, half rent, no peace. *The monks pray for you. They also pray for your enemies. Balance.*

6. **Wardship** — Over a minor heir; lands obey you “for now.” *The heir has a knife. He knows how to use it. He learned from watching you.*

7. **Gabelle Lease** — Salt-tax rights; lucrative, hated, and dangerous. *The lease is a death warrant written in profit. Cash it wisely.*

8. **Letters Patent** — Raise a free-company under your banner; an army as a business. *The letters are signed in blood—yours or the notary’s. Both are valid.*

9. **Remission** — Of feudal dues for a village; they’ll march when called. *The village has a long memory. They remember the last lord who promised mercy.*

10. **Low-Justice** — Grant (stocks, fines, gallows) in a troublesome hamlet. *The gallows rope is new. The notches are from the last hamlet.*

J **Confiscation Writ** — Against a royalist estate—if you can seize it first. *The writ is a race. The other claimant rides a faster horse.*

Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private with the Queen-Mother; a whisper becomes policy. *The audience is a chess game. She always wins—but she lets you take a pawn.*

K **Sunburst Warrant** — Of the fallen court—most still bow if shown boldly. *The warrant is a ghost. It has no power—only the power of belief.*

A **General Pardon** — Temporary: rebels absolved if they bend the knee. *The pardon is a spring. It will close when the season turns.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/patents/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **fractured sun** motifs—light that splinters, oaths that crack like glass.

Additional Features

- **Fractured Seals:** When brandishing a writ, badge, or charter tied to a Sun-court claimant, step Position up one step for the scene’s next interaction at a gate, court, or checkpoint. Each use advances a Legitimacy [4] clock linked to the claimant; when it fills, rivals challenge the authority on sight.
- **Parlement Games:** If a scene touches petitions, guild disputes, or feudal appeals, the first Diamond played becomes a policy lever: treat it as two Diamonds toward swaying a decision or rewriting a custom. Afterward, start or advance a Whispered Precedent clock; when it fills, backlash spreads as other courts cite the case against you.
- **Gabelle Knife-Edge:** At bridges, fairs, or salt depots, convert Diamonds tied to tolls, leases, or safe-conducts into immediate passage or tariff relief for the company (no roll). Each conversion ticks a Resentment [4] clock for the locale; when it completes, expect boycotts, ambush rumors, or an audit by rival officials.
- **Vhasian Chivalry:** The knights of the western cantons (Ethor, Adria) follow the Round of Five Virtues: Courage, Courtesy, Mercy, Prowess, Truth. In a formal joust or a legal duel, the GM may award Victory by Virtue rather than by blood: the combatant with the higher Virtue score wins the dispute, even if they lost the physical exchange. This is the law of the tilt—and the law of the court.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Seint Michel, the Judge of the Scar (Mykkiel):** The Order of the Gilded Scale maintains the *Chivalric Ledger*—a record of every oath sworn and broken in the cantons. A page torn from this ledger can serve as a single-use Claim String (gain +1 Position in any court). The Order’s justiciars are feared and respected; they never unbuckle their gorgets, and they have never lost a case. The Queen-Mother keeps a copy in her riverside keep, wrapped in a grey shroud.
- **Seint Isabeau, Who Slumbers Amongst the Lilies (Ikasha):** In the Ethorian marches, knights whisper prayers to Seint Isabeau when they long to set aside their steel. Her shrine is a hawthorn grove where armour must be left at the gate. Pilgrims who enter bare-skinned and speak a true regret find that their next wound heals in a single night—but they dream of a woman in white who asks, “Will you

remember how to be touched?” Those who return to the grove a second time are never seen again.

- **Seint Evroul of the Cairn (Mor’iraath):** In the high passes of the Ethorian marches, a rusted knight in an unopened helm haunts the old barrows. He is the patron of those who carry a blood-debt and cannot rest. To call upon him, one must pour a cup of salt water at a cairn and name the wrong done to your house. He will witness one blow; if it lands, the foe is *Marked by the Cairn*—any spirit may locate them for a year. If it misses, the blow turns inward. The Marshal-Exile carries a scar from such a bargain; he does not speak of it.
- **The Order of the Sunken Cup (The Hospice of the Broken Blade):** A grey-robed hospice in the ruins of Lence treats the wounded of both crowns. They ask no payment, but they record every name in a ledger that never dries. The Restorationists suspect they are spies for the Queen-Mother; the Two Crowns accuse them of erasing debts. Sister Oria, the hospice’s custodian, is also the keeper of the Lantern-Rites House on the Belworth—neutral ground where even claimants must leave their blades at the door.
- **The Chivalric Clocks (Armor Closes / Song Escapes):** The Cantor Alain, bearer of the Cracked Ring, sings a warning at every tourney: the *Armor Closes* [6] when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When it fills, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars. The *Song Escapes* [8] advances when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled, when a Cantor sings the truth. When it fills, a moment of genuine connection occurs—though it may be fatal. In Rouen, Alain still sings the *Planctus Armatus* each spring, and the congregation weeps for Sir Corin, who unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief’s voice and was undone by the mercy he offered.
- **The Ninth:** In any Vhasian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls—and their cases are never heard again.

Vhasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Sun:** Crumble a crust onto a cracked sun-disc. Ignore the first *Chevauchée* penalty.
- **Knot the Seal:** Tie a single knot in a charter’s ribbon. Cancel *Parlement Divided* or take –1 die on your next legal argument (your choice).
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead claimant’s name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect when collecting debts from their faction this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen-Mother.

Patronage & Power

In Vhasia, power flows through the remnants of imperial authority, fractured legitimacy, and the careful manipulation of legal and religious institutions. Former Utaran provincial structures still provide a framework for governance, but competing claimants to the Sun-court have created a complex web of overlapping jurisdictions and conflicting loyalties. The true power lies with those who can navigate this legal maze and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority.

For the GM: Patronage in Vhasia revolves around legitimacy, legal documents, and the ability to command respect from institutions that no longer have a clear central authority. Rewards often take the form of charters, writs, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, badges, writs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the parlements, cathedrals, and châteaux as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.

In Vhasia, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **rival officials or court guards**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **parlement clerks or routier patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or tax collectors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable legal window**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Duchy constable or abbess-chatelaine** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or road closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival claimant or free-company** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.

- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **routiers**, **parlement guards**, or **rival ducal forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **writ voided/interdict declared/levy called**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Two Crowns**, **Queen-Mother**, or **Marshal-Exile** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **chevauchee hits/river floods/parlement erupts**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Vhasia (Fractured Authority):** Seals break mid-signing, legal papers rewrite themselves, badges refuse to be honoured.
- **Vhasia (Legal Warfare):** Court decisions reverse without warning, precedents are cited against you, writs expire at crucial moments.
- **Vhasia (Sun Symbolism):** Sun-discs crack underfoot, light splits into contradictory shadows, oaths shatter like glass.

The Vacant Throne Campaign Clocks

For long-form political campaigns, use the following clocks alongside the faction sheets from the *Political Intrigue* expansion:

- **Vacant Throne Clock [10]:** Advances when a claimant gains a major advantage (battle, noble defection, foreign alliance). Retreats when the party brokers a truce or exposes a weakness. When full, a claimant takes Lence and declares themselves king.

- **Armor Closes [6]:** Advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars.
- **Song Escapes [8]:** Advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs—though it may be fatal.
- **Claimant’s Coup (per claimant):** A 6-clock that advances when that claimant wins a Parlement vote, a joust, or a skirmish. When full, they march on Lence.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Red Marshal (Exiled Sun-court hammer)** — *Phases:* Chevauchee Call → Banner Turn → Lists to War. *Cracks:* Letters Patent buys one round of obedience; General Pardon lets a unit stand down.
- **Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (scarlet gloves)** — *Phases:* Interdict Blade → Seal Both Ways → Confessional Leak. *Cracks:* Queen’s Audience cancels Interdict Blade once; a Synod Indulgence treats a church check as controlled for one scene.
- **The Parlement Spider (chief clerk; quills like daggers)** — *Phases:* Motion to Delay → Counter-Citation → Filed at Dawn. *Cracks:* Sunburst Warrant opens a “royal window”; a Burgess Charter lets a town court overrule once locally.
- **The Two Crowns (rival dukes)** — *Phases:* Contradictory Edicts → Levy in Hours → Coin Trial. *Cracks:* Sunburst Warrant + public mass unites them for one scene; General Pardon calms levy unrest once.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Tournament Ordeal (Bastide Square)** — Declare Purse, Patent, or Pardon as stakes. Win to cash a matching $\diamond$; *lose and spawn Tournament “Accident”*.
- **Cathedral Scaffold Assize** — Argue law atop creaking beams; each good point moves Position up; each slip marks Exposure. A *Paréage Charter* lets you call a recess once.
- **Pont-du-Tithe Vigil** — Keep the bridge peaceful through dusk: clear 3 segments on *Bridge Peace* by feeding pilgrims, quieting relic zeal, and paying one tithe from your purse.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Legitimacy Dial (Claimant ↔ Neutrality):** Track the party’s public stance.
 - *Claimant High:* +1 Position when invoking seals, warrants, or feudal rights; first parley with a rival claimant starts one step worse.
 - *Neutrality High:* +1 Effect when brokering truces or smuggling between factions; first petition to a court or cathedral starts one step worse.

- Center the dial by paying weight to both sides or hosting a neutral moot.

• **Parlement Mini-Game (legal duel):**

- Lay three counters: *Precedent*, *Equity*, *Force*.
- Argue a point (roll Lore + Sway vs. DV 3). On a hit, move one counter to your side. On a miss, the clerk gains *Citation Edge*.
- Win two counters to secure a temporary *Parlement Ruling* (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
- *Spider’s Interjection* (2 SB): flip *Precedent*, but start *Whispered Precedent* [2].

• **Chevauchée Pressure (raid clock):**

- Two opposed clocks: *Outrun the Fire* vs *Scorched Earth* (size by highest rank in seed).
- Each leg, choose *High Road* (fast, exposed), *Bypass* (slow, hidden), or *Ford* (risky, shortcut).
- Advantage: Bypass → High Road (cover), Ford → Bypass (speed), High Road → Ford (navigation).
- Spend a *Watch-Code* (from Three-Fires Ridge) to shift one segment from *Scorched Earth* to *Outrun*.

• **Favor of the Sun (prestige track):**

- Earn by resolving disputes between claimants without bloodshed, or by returning stolen relics.
- At 3 Favor, treat one *Safe-Conduct* or *Sunburst Warrant* as unquestioned for a scene.
- Each use after the first advances *Legitimacy Challenge* [4] against that claimant.

• **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**

1. *Cracked Bell*: first legal action gains +1d; first boast draws *Parlement Divided*.
2. *Smoke on the Ridge*: Chevauchée advances once; shortcuts open.
3. *Three Suns*: three claimants claim the same road; pick a side or start *Coin Debasement*.
4. *Queen’s Dove*: a message arrives; +1d on the next *Queen’s Audience* attempt.
5. *Salt Wind*: *Gabelle Lease* counts double value today; smugglers’ ears open.
6. *Routier Campfire*: mercenaries are hireable for one scene at half price—but they’ll ask questions later.

• **Plug-in SB Conversions (Vhasia Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value until re-witnessed.
- 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a *✧orrecallapastruling*).
- 3+ SB → *Crown Fracture*: the claimant’s legitimacy splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival’s seal on your paper (start *Legitimacy Challenge*).

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade *Parlement Divided* to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
- *Chevauchée-Tested*: +1 Position when evading raids; supply lines run 1 segment longer.
- *Neutral Broker*: +1d with both claimants in a truce scene; any betrayal earns *Resentment* [2] from both sides.

- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**

- *Thepyrgos Synod Leak*: a *Synod Indulgence* can suspend a Vhasian interdict—but starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
- *Ubral Feud Echo*: paying wergild to a Vhasian claimant instead of a clan starts *Feud Rekindled* along the border roads.
- *Kahfagia Salt War*: cashing a *Gabelle Lease* to outbid corsair lanes adds *Market Knives* [4] in Silkstrand or on the coastal quays.
- *Valewood Relic Interest*: a relic from a Vhasian cathedral may be claimed by fae courts; a Diamond spent on relic control may instead draw *Court Tithe*.

4.27 Vilikari — “Laurels & Longhouses”

Federate King (Elite): “We are the bridge between empire and wilderness, the marriage of law and custom. Our strength lies not in choosing one path but in walking both with equal surety.”

Hearth-Mother (Commoner): “The old ways and new laws both have their place at our table. Serve the right mead to the right guest, honor the proper customs, and you’ll find we’re better hosts than most kings.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Vilikari are the agrarian peoples straddling the frontiers between Ecktoria and Kahfagia, tillers and treaty-makers who balance survival between empire, steppe, and sea. In a three-way war with the Ykrul and the Black Banners, they live by the cleverness of their diplomacy, the leverage of their markets, and the shifting weight of oaths. Their halls are longhouses raised over ruined forums; their laws carved on both oak and marble; their loyalties braided like the braids of their war-maidens’ hair.

What you notice first: The smell of woodsmoke and old parchment. The way everyone speaks two languages at once—switching mid-sentence. The longhouse roofs that use broken imperial tiles as shingles.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never invoke only one law. The mallus (oak-ring) and the basilica (marble bench) must both be honored. Choose one, and the other will find you.

Regional Mood: Laurels and Longhouses

Here, the past is not a ruin—it is a landlord. The old Utaran forums still echo with the footsteps of legionaries, but now those columns hold longhouse roofs. The Vilikari do not choose between empire and tribe; they marry them, awkwardly, imperfectly, and with frequent arguments. Their kings wear both a laurel wreath and a wolf-tail cloak. Their courts meet twice: once under the oak for blood-price, once on the marble bench for statute. No verdict is final until both have spoken. In the marches, a man can be a barbarian in the morning and a citizen by noon—if he knows which door to knock on.

On the coast, Vilikari fishing villages double as smugglers’ coves, running fugitives, forbidden goods, and whispered messages between the powers of the Amaranthine. Their boats are fast, their pilots know every reef and patrol route, and their loyalty is to the cargo’s survival, not the flag it flies.

Starting Location: A longhouse quarter tucked into an old forum. Laurel garlands hang from broken columns. Smoke from a dozen hearths curls under cracked marble arches. A Hearth-Mother offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. “The Foedus Stone cracks,” she says. “The steppe listens. Which law will you speak when the Ykrul envoy arrives—oak or marble?”

Prominent NPCs of the Vilikari

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Federate King Aldric	Rex-Dux of the Vilikari	Keep the two-law balance and the Foedus Stone intact	He has three thrones—oak, marble, and saddle. He uses whichever is not being argued over.
Hearth-Mother Vesna	Keeper of guest-right (commoner exemplar)	Protect her village from raiders and tax men alike	She has never lost a quarrel; her voice is soft, her memory longer than the Foedus Stone.
Shield-Brother Rurik	Comitatus oath-bearer	Enforce the mallus code in the marches	His braids are his ledger; each knot is a debt paid—or owed.
March Notary Theodora	Utaran-trained legalist	Draft treaties that neither side can break	She writes in three scripts; her left hand writes Latin, her right writes runes.
Smuggler Captain Drago	Vilikari fisherman and trafficker	Run contraband and refugees past the Kahfagian patrols	He knows every reef and every lantern shift; the harbormasters cannot catch him.
Elder of Elders	Thing-council speaker	Preserve the old customs against imperial erosion	He speaks once a year; the rest of the time he listens—and remembers.

Names of the Vilikari

Vilikari names blend Utaran (Latin) roots with steppe influences: hard consonants, fluid vowels, and surnames that recall a ford, a bridge, or a longhouse.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Aldric		Vesna	de la Marche	<i>the Two-Law</i>
Rurik		Theodora	Longwood	<i>the Fox</i>
Drago		Gisela	Kalderash	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Oswin		Mira	Oakenshield	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Vidar		Svanhild	Tregard	<i>Ash-Prow</i>
Kael		Ragna	Foedus	<i>the Grey</i>

(March Town/Villa-Fort/Old Road) Longhouse Quarter tucked into old forum with hearth-smoke under broken eaves; Milefort XVII with earth bank and faded eagle.

Spades — Places

2. **Longhouse Quarter** — Tucked into old forum; hearth-smoke under broken eaves. *The forum’s marble floor is worn smooth by dancing feet, not sandals.*
 3. **Milefort XVII** — Earth bank, stone gate; faded eagle over fresh knotwork. *The eagle’s stone wings were reglued after a lightning strike. It still leans left.*
 4. **Stone Ford** — Plank-palings and a customs table at knee-height; border as bureaucracy. *The ford changes hands every season. The customs table never moves.*
 5. **Villa Granary** — Barracks with a tile roof; spear racks where olives once slept. *The olive press still works. The pressers are now armorers.*
 6. **Twin Court** — Mallus ring beneath an oak, basilica bench across the lane. *The oak and the bench are the same distance from the well. The well is neutral ground.*
 7. **Blackwood Road** — Milestones re-carved in runes and Latin both. *The runes say “safe passage.” The Latin says “toll payable twice.”*
 8. **Staple Market** — Frontier where Ykrul horses meet Vilikari iron. *The horse-traders and smiths speak a pidgin of gestures and grudges.*
 9. **Burial Field** — Ship-ridge mounds beside tiled mausolea, both garlanded. *The mausolea have fresh offerings. The ancestors are not picky.*
 10. **Repaired Bridge** — An arch of stone, a Vilikari trestle stitched on; past and present joined. *The trestle creaks in Vilikari, the stone groans in Utaran. They argue at midnight.*
- J **Hill Amphitheater** — A lord’s hall raised in an old arena’s curve; power in architecture. *The lord’s throne is a gladiator’s chair. He does not know who last sat in it.*

Q **New Raivon** — March capital; grid-streets colliding with wandering lanes. *The grid was laid by a surveyor who never came back. The lanes are older.*

K **Dux’s Palace** — Purple awnings, wolf-hides, law tablets on the wall. *The tablets list every treaty broken. The wolf-hides are from the treaty-breakers.*

A **Foedus Stone** — At a crossroads; every treaty carved, every hand weighed. *The stone has grown. Each new treaty adds a finger of granite.*

(Federate/Mixed Court/Diaspora) Hearth-Mother with guest-cup and wergild chest key; Shield-Brother with oaths braided into hair.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hearth-Mother** — Guest-cup and wergild chest key; hospitality as power. *She has never lost a quarrel. Her voice is soft, her memory longer than the Foedus Stone.*

3. **Shield-Brother** — Comitatus oaths braided into hair; loyalty as bond. *His braids are his ledger. Each knot is a debt paid—or owed.*

4. **March Notary** — Utaran-trained; writes three scripts without blinking. *His left hand writes Latin, his right writes runes. He signs with his foot.*

5. **Horse-Reeve** — Rations pasture between plows and warbands. *He measures grass in fistfuls. The Ykrul respect his arithmetic.*

6. **Ykrul Envoy** — Riding under safe-conduct; speaks debts in proverbs. *He never carries a weapon. His tongue is sharp enough.*

7. **Old Legionary** — Drill-master for Vilikari levies; Utar in muscle memory. *He still marks time in paces. The recruits call him “Grandfather Eagle.”*

8. **Ecktorial Factor** — Vilikari blood, Ecktorial coin; flows where the ledger points. *His coat has two collars—one for each loyalty. He wears whichever is warmer.*

9. **Kahfagian Pilot** — Lantern-law chit and clan tattoo; sea-law on land. *He navigates by stars and tariffs. Both change with the season.*

10. **Marcher-Lord** — Iron-nail crown, Vilikari law in pocket; a frontier king. *His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse.*

J **War-Maiden** — Oath-braid names the dead and the owed; vengeance as memory. *Her braid is longer than her sword. Both have drawn blood.*

Q **Queen of Marches** — Consort-regent; smiles like precedent. *She married the Federate King for peace. She kept the kingdom for herself.*

K **Federate King** — Rex-Dux sworn to forms, sung by his own. *He has three thrones—oak, marble, and saddle. He uses whichever is not being argued over.*

A **Elder of Elders** — Thing-council speaker; a nod can unmake a clan. *He speaks once a year. The rest of the time, he listens—and remembers.*

(Two Laws/Two Fronts/Old Grudges) Annona late—grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken; jurisdiction tangle of mallus vs. basilica writ.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Annona Late** — Grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken like flint. *The granary is full. The keys are in the wrong vault. Someone is waiting for the price to rise.*
3. **Law Tangle** — Mallus verdict vs. basilica writ—whose seal bites? *The oak judge and the marble judge are cousins. They send each other holiday cards.*
4. **Raid Rumor** — A Ykrul boyar; levies panic the plowlands. *The boyar is a ghost—or a tax collector. The farmers don’t wait to find out.*
5. **Bridge Levy** — Doubled for road-works; caravans balk, fists rise. *The road-works are a ditch. The ditch fills every spring.*
6. **Succession Feud** — Wolf-brother claim vs. purple-charter heir. *The wolf-brother has a better sword. The purple-charter has a better notary.*
7. **Foedus Recall** — A prefecture resettlement is “requested”; homes bristle. *The prefecture’s map is forty years old. It shows a village that drowned.*
8. **Coin Talk** — Debasement; pay demanded in salt, hides, or hostages. *The salt is from a disputed pan. The hides are from cattle that were never born.*
9. **Grave Offense** — A burial field disturbed; omens ride with the news. *The ancestors are angry. They have a list. Your name may be on it.*
10. **Port Clash** — Lantern-law vs. street-law; confiscations bloom. *The lanterns were moved last night. The old safe channel is now a reef.*
- J **Warband Flip** — Colors change mid-pay; hostage protocol snaps shut. *The hostages are eating well. Their captors are not.*
- Q **Restoration Preacher** — Stirs crowds against the “barbarian king in purple.” *The preacher’s license was signed by a dead abbot. The seal is still warm.*
- K **General Levy** — The march is closed; markets freeze into spears. *The levy notice is posted in three languages. None of them are local.*
- A **Spring Melt** — Eats the Wolf Road; proofs, plans, and armies bog. *The road is a memory. The ruts fill with water—and older things.*

(Charter/Right/Escort) Foedus Renewal Seal for settlement and stipends; Mallus Bench-Right to hold court under the oak.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Foedus Seal** — Settlement and stipends confirmed for a season. *The seal is a bronze wolf’s head. It warms when the treaty holds—and cools when it doesn’t.*
 3. **Mallus Right** — Hold court under the oak and be obeyed. *The oak is older than the kingdom. Its roots have seen more verdicts than the throne.*
 4. **Stipend Arrears** — Paid in salt and grain; portable, persuasive. *The salt is grey. The grain is from last harvest. Both are worth more than coin.*
 5. **Utaran Patent** — Citizenship-style privilege; doors open, bows deepen. *The patent is a worn scrap of vellum. It has been folded and refolded for a century.*
 6. **Stall-Right** — Customs favor on a frontier market line. *The stall is a painted plank. Plant it, and the tax man will pretend not to see you.*
 7. **Hostage Treaty** — Exchange fosters; grudges trade for leverage. *The hostages are children. Their parents are patient.*
 8. **Remount Allotment** — Fresh horses from royal paddocks, no questions. *The horses are from the king’s own herd. They know the roads better than you.*
 9. **Wergild Table** — Recognized by both codes; vengeance priced and paid. *The table is a slate slab. The prices are carved deep—and often recarved.*
 10. **Bridge Farm** — Imperial for a season; funds and friends accrue. *The bridge toll is a copper a head. The bridge keeper is your new best friend.*
- J **Purple Warrant** — Wear the stripe; officials defer on sight. *The stripe is a sash. It was a curtain in a past life.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private; a whisper becomes policy. *The audience is held in a garden. The flowers are listening.*
- K **Dux Commission** — Command a mixed unit with pay authority. *The commission is a baton. It doubles as a mace in a pinch.*
- A **Great Law Day** — Proclaim a new concord; one temporary exception to old law. *The proclamation is made at noon. By sunset, everyone will have an opinion.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/rights/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **law and bond** motifs—oaths that bind, stones that witness, treaties that remember every hand.

Additional Features

- **Two-Law Balance:** Whenever a *jurisdictional conflict* arises (mallus vs. basilica, oak vs. marble), players may step Position up by citing the Foedus Stone or an older precedent—but every use adds a tick to a **Two-Law** [4] clock. When it fills, one side demands exclusive authority.
- **Frontier Diplomacy:** If a *Heart* card involves a foreign envoy, a federate, or a mixed-blood courtier, treat the first **Diamond** played in the scene as doubled leverage. Once per session, a deal struck reverberates—advance or start a **Border Tension** front.
- **March Markets:** At any *Staple Market*, *Ford*, or *Bridge*, Diamonds tied to rights or escorts may be cashed as currency in lieu of coin, one-for-one. Doing so creates a **Ledger Debt** that the GM may call in later through factions or raiders.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Smugglers’ Covenant (The Sealed Gate):** Vilikari pilots who run the Kahfagian coast swear by a secret oath to the *Unlatched Lock*—a threshold that never fully closes. They leave a copper nail at every hidden cove. A captain who breaks the covenant finds that their boat will not cross the tide line; the sea simply refuses to carry them. The Kahfagian Admiralty has tried to bribe the covenant’s keeper; he accepted the coin and sank the next morning in calm water.
- **Saint Theodora of the Dual Writ (The Witness):** A march notary who uncovered a Fenwood spy in the Federate King’s court. She forced the spy to sign a confession under both oak and marble, then burned the oak copy and kept the marble one. The spy vanished, but his signature appears on every broken treaty in Vilikari history. Her quill is kept in the Dux’s Palace; it writes in lemon juice, and the truth it records cannot be erased by fire or water.
- **The Host of the Two Ledgers (The Longhouse Healers):** A hospice near the Foedus Stone is run by grey-robed healers who ask no payment. They treat wounded raiders from both sides of the steppe, and the Ykrul and Ecktorian captains have agreed to a truce around its doors. The Federate King tolerates them because they also hold the rite of the *Unbuckled Oath*—a ceremony where a knight may renounce a blood-debt without losing honour, by placing their sword on the stone and speaking a single true regret.
- **The Ostrihari Cousins (The Savage Heart):** The eastern Vilikari, called Ostrihari by lowlanders, are no more savage than any frontier people. Their reputation comes from the bear cults of the upper Wolf Road, where initiates wear cured skins and speak in growls. The Ostrihari do not raid Vilikari villages; they trade furs for iron and send their young to serve as mercenaries in the Black Banners. A Vilikari proverb says: “The Ostrihari sharpen their teeth on stone, not on kin.”
- **The Ninth:** In any Vilikari scene, the ninth witness called to a mallus court is always a ghost. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who call a ninth witness find that the ghost speaks the truth—but the truth is always the worst possible version, and the living witnesses remember it as their own.

Vilikari Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stone:** Crumble a crust at the base of the Foedus Stone. Ignore the first *Law Tangle* penalty.
- **Knot the Braid:** Tie a single knot in a horse’s tail. Cancel *Annona Late* or take –1 die on your next supply roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Oak:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the hollow of the mallus oak. Gain +1 Effect when collecting wergild from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Elder of Elders.

Patronage & Power

In Vilikari society, power flows through the careful balance of multiple legal traditions, the management of frontier diplomacy, and the maintenance of complex oaths and treaties. The Federate King maintains authority through a combination of imperial forms and traditional customs, while local leaders wield influence through their knowledge of both Uтарan law and tribal custom. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex legal and diplomatic landscape while maintaining the loyalty of their people and the respect of their neighbors.

For the GM: Patronage in Vilikari society revolves around legal documents, diplomatic relationships, and the ability to command respect from institutions that operate under multiple legal systems. Rewards often take the form of treaties, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, treaties) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival legal systems issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the courts, markets, and frontier posts as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.

In Vilikari society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you rule or are ruled.

Thematic SB Spend Table**Minor Complications (1 SB)**

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **march officials or tribal elders**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **levy guards or market patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or treaty keepers**.

- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable legal window**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Horse-Reeve or March Notary** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or border closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction or warband** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **shield-brothers, levy forces, or foreign troops** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **treaty voided/levy called/border dispute erupts**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Federate King, Queen of Marches, or Elder of Elders** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **raid hits/levy called/treaty breaks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Vilikari (Two Laws):** Legal documents contradict each other, courts issue conflicting rulings, oaths bind to different authorities.
- **Vilikari (Frontier Diplomacy):** Treaties expire without warning, foreign envoys demand additional concessions, mixed-blood courtiers shift allegiances.
- **Vilikari (Border Tensions):** Frontier posts close without notice, markets shift locations, safe-conducts are revoked mid-journey.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The March Notary (quills like daggers)** — *Phases:* Citation Tangle → Seal Swap → Precedent Trap. *Cracks:* produce a **Foedus Seal** to quiet him; a **Queen’s Audience** overrules his filing.
- **Ykrul Storm-Rider (wolf-cloak, bone whistle)** — *Phases:* Raid Cry → Herd Stampede → Blood Price. *Cracks:* a **Wergild Table** settles the feud without combat; a **Hostage Treaty** buys a season’s peace.
- **The Prefect’s Auditor (Ecktorial ink on his fingers)** — *Phases:* Ledger Seizure → Tax Levy → Fort Closure. *Cracks:* an **Utaran Patent** grants immunity; a **Mallus Right** transfers jurisdiction to the oak.
- **The Direwood Whisperer (moss in her hair)** — *Phases:* Name Theft → Bell Failure → Breath Claim. *Cracks:* a **Stipend Arrears** paid in blessed salt; a **Purple Warrant** invokes imperial ward-law.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Foedus Stone Oath** — Place your hand on the stone and speak a treaty term aloud. On success, the stone warms; gain +1 Position on all negotiations this scene. On a miss, a crack appears—start a **Law Tangle** clock.
- **Twin Court Ordeal** — Argue the same case before oak and marble. Win both to secure a **Great Law Day**. Win one and lose the other to spawn **Law Tangle**. Lose both—the ancestors laugh, and you owe a feast.
- **Burial Field Vigil** — Spend a night among the ship-ridge mounds. Dawn reveals a memory of a broken treaty. Learn a secret weakness of a rival faction—or gain a haunting.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Two-Law Dial (Oak ↔ Marble):** Track which legal tradition holds sway.
 - *Oak High:* +1 Position when invoking mallus, blood-price, or tribal custom; first basilica petition starts one step worse.
 - *Marble High:* +1 Effect when citing charters, patents, or Utaran precedent; first mallus oath starts one step worse.

- Center the dial by offering a wergild recognized by both sides or hosting a joint moot.

• **Treaty-Feast Procedure (fast diplomacy):**

1. **Set the Table:** Name 2–3 *terms* (what both sides want) and 1 *taboo* (off-limits).
2. **First Cup (Position):** Roll a social test; success grants +1 die to bargain, failure grants the host 1 SB.
3. **Bread & Salt (Offer):** Put *one* leverage on the table (Diamond or oath-promise). Host matches with an obligation (escort, market access, or hostage).
4. **Smoke (Complication):** The GM reveals a pressure tied to *Old Grudges* or *Two Laws*. Resolve it or accept a *Rider Clause*.
5. **Knot the Braid:** On success, create a **Feast-Bond** [3] clock that protects both parties from betrayal in that matter while it has segments; on breach, the breaker immediately takes 1–2 SB and the clock flips to **Blood-Owed** [3].

• **Frontier Market (quick trading):**

- At any *Staple Market* or *Stone Ford*, players may convert a held $\diamond$ into a *Market Edge* (+1 die to all buy/sell rolls).
- Each conversion ticks a **Market Knives** [4] clock for that locale. When it fills, a rival factor challenges your right to trade—face a duel, a bribe demand, or a confiscation.

• **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**

1. *Laurel Wilt:* first legal action gains +1d; first boast draws **Law Tangle**.
2. *Smoke on the Steppe:* **Raid Rumor** advances once; shortcuts open.
3. *Twin Bells:* both courts are in session; pick a side or start **Law Tangle**.
4. *Queen’s Dove:* a message arrives; +1d on the next **Queen’s Audience**.
5. *Grey Salt:* **Stipend Arrears** counts double value today; smugglers’ ears open.
6. *Old Eagle:* an Utaran relic surfaces; **Utaran Patent** use is free this scene.

• **Plug-in SB Conversions (Vilikari Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Seal Crack:* a writ loses half its value until re-witnessed.
- 2 SB → *Citation War:* increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a $\diamond$ or recall a past ruling).
- 3+ SB → *Crown Fracture:* a treaty splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival’s seal on your paper (start **Two-Law** clock).

• **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Court-Favored:* once/session, downgrade **Law Tangle** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
- *Raid-Tested:* +1 Position when evading Ykrul or Black Banners; supply lines run 1 segment longer.

- *Neutral Broker*: +1d with both oak and marble in a treaty scene; any betrayal earns **Blood-Owed** [2] from both sides.

- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**

- *Kahfagia (Lantern-Law)*: A **Foedus Seal** may stand in for a *Safe-Conduct* along a beaconed lane once. Doing so starts **Port Clash** [2] in the next harbor touched.
- *Ecktoria (Imperial Remnants)*: An **Utaran Patent** counts as either *Archive Hour* (scholars open doors) or *Icon License* (display symbols) in Ecktorial sites—choose once per session.
- *Aelerian Mountains (Pass & Toll)*: A **Pass-Ring** (from the Aeler expansion) grants priority at dwarf switchbacks; cashing it to bypass inspection spawns **Ledger Notice** [3].
- *Direwood (Breath & Bells)*: Spending **Stipend Arrears** for levee labor converts one Direwood **Clubs** draw into a *Ward-Salt* Diamond for a scene, then begins **Names Disputed** [3] with bell-wardens.

4.28 Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”

Warrior Queen (Elite): “Every hedge here marks not just a boundary but a principle – the careful balance between order and freedom, justice and mercy. Our law grows like the hedges themselves, tended with precision and patience.”

Fen Reeve (Commoner): “The dikes hold back more than water – they hold back chaos. Every rod measured, every stone placed, keeps the flood from washing away not just our fields but our very way of life. And across the Belworth? The Vhasians still claim our hedges are theirs. Let them try.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition. Once a proud kingdom before becoming a Utaran province, it is now reborn under a new Warrior Queen who rules by legal precision as much as military might. The realm’s true sinews lie not in steel but in writs, charters, and the ancient rights that bind lord to tenant, crown to county, and church to common. Every hedge-row, every parish stone, every ferry crossing carries the weight of custom older than memory.

But Viterra is also a kingdom of restless ambition. Northward, the Ubral highlands reject any crown but their own moots. Southward, the City of a Thousand Stairs—Thepyrgos—watches with scholarly scorn and synod edicts. Westward, across the Belworth River, lie the fractured cantons of Vhasia, where Viterran dukes hold ancient claims to estates and abbeys—claims that have fueled decades of raiding, ransom, and legal warfare. And in the Dolmis, the isles of Theona pledge nominal fealty but keep their own taboos, a constant tug between crown law and green custom. Viterra is not a nation at peace. It is a realm that wages law as war, and war as law.

What you notice first: The smell of damp parchment and fresh ink. The clatter of writ-runners’ boots on cobblestones. The way every noble’s hand rests on a seal ring—and every commoner’s hand rests on a hatchet.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never cross the Belworth without a charter recognized on both banks. Viterran law and Vhasian claim fight every crossing, and the river takes the losers.

Regional Mood: Hedge, Crown, and Claim

Here, law is a blade. The Warrior Queen rules from Valora, her throne a bench of precedents. The old Fenwood dukes—whose ancestors sacked Lence and left the Vhasian Sun-court fractured—still hold vast estates in the northern marches, and their claims across the Belworth keep the border smoking like a low fire. Every spring, the Queen’s justiciars ride west with warrants and escorts, demanding homage from villages that have paid Vhasian tithes for a generation. Every autumn, Vhasian routiers raid the grain convoys, and the legal duels that follow are fought with steel and citation alike.

North, the Ubral clans watch from their cairns, ready to rekindle feuds if a Viterran levy crosses the passes. South, Thepyrgos sends clerks and spies, testing the edges of Viterran jurisdiction with every disputed toll. And in Theona, the Three Greens mumble old curses while Viterran bailiffs try to count their cattle—and always miscount by one.

Starting Location: The Hall of Dawning tilt-yard at first light. Dawn-knights drill in armor polished like mirrors. Beside them, advocates rehearse arguments with the same intensity. A Queen’s Justiciar slides a parchment across an oaken rail. “Three charters, one road across the Belworth. The Vhasian claimant says the bridge is theirs. The local reeve says it’s crown land. And the abbey says it’s a pilgrimage, not a toll. Carry the Queen’s writ, break the Quiet Tolls, and make them agree—by clause or by cut.”

Prominent NPCs of Viterra

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Queen Veralyn Everblood	Warrior Queen of Viterra	Consolidate her rule and balance the duchies	Her crown has no jewels—only seals; each seal is a conquered claim.
Justiciar Elodie Venn	Queen’s Justiciar	Enforce the law without fear or favour	She has never lost a legal duel; her opponents tend to fall down stairs.
Baron Aldric	Disgraced turncloak (former NPC)	Seeks to restore his lost honour	He was stripped of his lands for oath-breaking; now he haunts the northern marches.
Ser Roran	Knight of the Queen’s household	Remind himself that a stranger’s coin bought his life	He wears a silver gauntlet over his left hand; he never takes ransom.
Fen Reeve Cuthbert	Keeper of the dike guilds	Protect the fens from flood and the Queen’s tax men	His tally-rod has notches from three floods; the next notch will be from a Vhasian raid.

Master Advocate Halric	Legal duelist and scholar	Win the Great Law Day and retire undefeated	He has argued cases in three kingdoms and won all using their own precedents.
Sister Oria	Custodian of the Lantern-Rites House (Belworth)	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness on the border	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.

Names of Viterra

Inspired by Tudor England and early modern Britain: strong consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that recall a hedge, a dike, or a parish.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Veralyn	Elodie	Everblood	<i>the Law-Giver</i>
Cuthbert	Aldric	Fenwood	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Roran	Halric	of the Scar	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Constano	Oria	de la Marche	<i>the Hedge-Wise</i>
Touénot	Mael	l’Argent	<i>the Silent</i>
Ghiro	Celandine	Riven	<i>Ash-Banner</i>

(Reeve/Guild/Knight/Legal Advocate) Fen reeve with tally-rod speaking for dike guilds; river-carter syndic moving grain faster than rumor; justices of the peace settling disputes with careful pen; master advocates who duel with words and swords.

Spades — Places

2. **Fen Causeway** — Stile with toll-rod and eel carts queueing; each reeve claims right to collect under a different charter. Dueling advocates argue cases on makeshift platforms. *The causeway sinks an inch each year. The lawyers argue over whose fault that is.*
3. **Hedgerow Green** — In the Dales; bows strung under apple trees where justices of the peace hold court beneath makeshift arbors. Court duels permitted for matters of honor. *The apple tree is called “the Hanging Judge.” Its fruit tastes of iron.*
4. **Beacon Hill** — Above the Highlands; fire-grate still warm from last winter’s levy call, signal tower with semaphore arms for legal dispatches and military alerts. *The hill has three beacons. One for Ubral raids, one for Vhasian incursions, one for paperwork.*

5. **Belworth Stairs** — Ferry ledgers gone damp with river-mist; three manors claim toll rights, writs in three different hands. Legal challenges fought in boats while waiting. *The stairs were repaired last year. The Vhasian side uses a different measurement.*
6. **Bloom Quarry** — Old iron-bloom turned drill yard; hammer echoes carry, forge-reeve holds tally of crown contracts. Military contracts awarded through legal bidding wars. *The forge-reeve has never lost a contract. His opponents have a habit of finding better jobs elsewhere.*
7. **Parish Maze** — Stone maze where three maps disagree; hedge-priest’s vote decides who pays tithe and who holds freehold. Legal disputes settled by navigating the maze correctly. *The maze changes at night. The hedge-priest says that’s God’s will.*
8. **Fairport Works** — Tideworks at the Dolmis mouth; customs writs in three languages flutter, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest. Maritime law enforcement includes boarding actions. *One language is Utaran, one is Linn, one is for the smugglers.*
9. **Law Quarter** — Valora archives, oath-rooms, Hall of Dawning where precedent is birthed in ink and sealed with wax. Adjacent training grounds for legal advocates. *The archives have a locked wing. The key is a legal argument no one has won.*
10. **Counting Fields** — Tarlington beside muster ground; wagons load, ledgers mis-sum, auditors with quill-pens and suspicious eyes. Military mustering follows strict legal procedures with armed oversight. *The auditors carry swords. They say it’s for counting cattle. No one asks further.*
- J **Dike Crown** — Ring of turf and timber; brotherhood bells warn of flood—and spies who move like water through the fen. Legal sanctuary for those fleeing court judgments. *The sanctuary lasts for one tide. After that, the reeves can come—if they can find you.*
- Q **Progress Camp** — Queen’s canvas palisade, banners stiff, whispering old courtiers plot advancement through legal maneuver and sanctioned duels. *The camp moves every week. The lawsuits follow at a measured pace.*
- K **Tilt-Yard** — Hall of Dawning at first light; Dawn-knights drill clean, loyalties in contracts signed with careful pen. Legal challenges often end in trial by combat. *The sand is raked between duels. Sometimes the rake turns up old blood—or old oaths.*
- A **Highway Stone** — Queen’s milestone above the Dolmis road; three sheriffs post seals over hers, each claiming different jurisdiction. Territory disputes resolved through armed arbitration. *The stone has been broken and reglued seven times. Each crack is a forgotten compromise.*

(Reeve/Guild/Knight/Legal Advocate) Fen reeve with tally-rod speaking for dike guilds; river-carter syndic moving grain faster than rumor; justices of the peace settling disputes with careful pen; master advocates who duel with words and swords.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Fen Reeve** — Tally-rod; speaks for dike guilds, remembers every flood-year’s debts and the charters that govern them. Authorized to call local levies for legal disputes. *His tally-rod has notches from three floods. The next notch will be from a Vhasian raid.*
 3. **River Syndic** — Moves grain faster than rumor; knows which writs matter and which customs officials can be... persuaded. Maintains armed merchant guards. *His ledger has a watermark—a crown on one side, a sunburst on the other. He shows the right side to the right audience.*
 4. **Parish Surveyor** — Three maps, one opinion; hedge-walks settle more disputes than courts, measures boundaries with careful chain. Expert witness in property disputes. *His chain is exactly one rod long. The rod changes length depending on who is paying.*
 5. **Dawn Quartermaster** — Ledgers sharper than tongue; logistics before lances, counts every farthing spent in the Queen’s name. Legal authority over military supplies. *He once tracked a missing farthing to a Vhasian counting house. The farthing was returned—with interest.*
 6. **Levy Serjeant** — Dales bow calm, cider breath, memory keen for every loophole in the mustering laws. Commands armed civilians in legal enforcement actions. *His bowstring is made from a cancelled writ. He says it shoots truer now.*
 7. **Cleric-Pair** — Light preacher vs. Everflame canon lawyer; debates decide tithe law, one for the spirit, one for the letter. Religious law carries weight in secular courts. *They share a room at the inn. They have not spoken outside court in seven years.*
 8. **Fairport Shipwright** — Dolmis cousins; skiff carries more secrets than cargo, knows which manifests to forge and which to honor. Expert in maritime law and naval combat. *Her skiff has no name. The customs clerks have given it three.*
 9. **Fenwood Comptroller** — Conjures wagons with a signature, silence with a seal, counts the Queen’s coin and tracks every debt owed to the crown. Legal authority over taxation. *His quill is a dagger. He has used it as both.*
 10. **Queen’s Justiciar** — Law on the road, polite as a noose; bearing three kings’ judgments and a purse full of pardons for the right price. Authorized to conduct trial by combat. *She has never lost a legal duel. Her opponents have a tendency to fall down stairs.*
- J **Border Routier** — Reads ledgers as ambushes; serves two crowns, collects from both, knows which border posts take bribes in what coin. Expert in frontier law enforcement. *His loyalty is to the highest bidder. The Queen and the Vhasian claimant are currently in a bidding war.*
- Q **Warrior Queen** — Crown on helm, sword at side, patient sums behind her gaze; rules by law’s sharp edge and knows every precedent that supports her claim. Final

arbiter in legal duels.
conquered claim.

Her crown has no jewels—only seals. Each seal is a

K Crown Council — Fenwood dukes, guild envoys, abbots; weighing grain against glory, charters against coin, precedent against practicality. Legal battles fought through proxy advocates. *The council has a standing rule: no weapons within the chamber. The advocates have found seventeen loopholes.*

A Master Advocate Halric — Silver-tongued legal warrior who settles disputes through verbal duels that can end in physical combat. Keeper of legal combat traditions. *He has argued cases in Vhasian, Thepyrgosian, and Ubral courts—and won all three using their own precedents.*

(Writ/Charter/Duel/Legal Challenge) Dike breach in black-rain; wrong reeve claims credit while wagons drown; feast-day clash of Light vs. Everflame processions; secret meetings in counting houses; legal duels fought in courtyards.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Dike Breach** — Black-rain; the wrong reeve claims credit while wagons drown, insurance claims and liability writs fly like autumn leaves. Legal liability may require armed enforcement. *The water is brown with peat and lies. It carries old deeds downstream.*
3. **Feast Clash** — Light vs. Everflame processions collide; shutters slam, writs fly, justices of the peace called to settle which holy day takes precedence. Honor disputes may require legal duels. *The processions take different routes now. The clash was not an accident.*
4. **Quiet Tolls** — Sprout on the Queen’s Highway; escorts sniff traps, sheriffs argue rights, customs officials demand duties no one knew existed. Territorial disputes resolved through armed arbitration. *The toll posts have fresh paint. The paint is from the keep of a Vhasian claimant.*
5. **Audit Freeze** — Counting-house freezes cargo; Queen’s seal vs. old writs, auditors with suspicious eyes and quill-pens sharp as daggers. Legal challenges may escalate to physical confrontation. *The auditors work by candlelight. The shadows on the walls look like gallows.*
6. **Border Snarl** — Three courts arrest the same hay-cart; whose hay is it? Which lord’s charter takes precedence? Bribes flow like wine. Frontier justice often involves armed standoffs. *The hay is from a field that was Vhasian last spring. Now it’s Viterran. The field hasn’t moved.*
7. **Isle Refusal** — Theona withholds levy; the quays choke on rumor, ships idle while lawyers debate maritime law and ancient treaties. Naval blockades become legal enforcement actions. *Theona’s envoy carries a hawthorn branch. The Queen’s justiciars will not touch it.*

8. **Delta Spat** — Fairport vs. Marcott customs; barges stack three deep, merchants pick sides, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest. Trade disputes fought with merchant guards. *The magnifying glasses reveal truth and also start fires. Both are useful.*
9. **Routier Arrears** — A free-company flips unless someone pays; your name on a ledger, a debt owed to men who know the price of blood. Legal debts enforced through hired swords. *The routiers have a list. Your name is on it—or will be by sunset.*
10. **Salt Pinch** — Import spikes, bakers barricade; the Queen’s promise tastes like thin gruel, merchants hoard salt like gold, riots brew in back alleys. Economic warfare becomes physical conflict. *The salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned Vhasian customs post.*
- J **Dawn Recall** — Escort pulled to a flood-struck parish; the writ argues with the river, justices demand inquiry into who neglected the dikes. Military enforcement of legal judgments. *The escorts are back in a week. They bring new writs—and fewer men.*
- Q **Aberielist Intrigue** — Royalist seals in wrong hands; the Queen’s patience thins, conspirators plot in counting houses, whispers of rebellion. Treason charges carry death penalty in legal duels. *The seals are from a dead duke. The duke’s ghost is said to approve.*
- K **Levy Call-Up** — Dalesmen mustered; your wagons seized “for the realm,” conscription writs signed with careful pen, families left to tend fields alone. Legal authority backed by armed force. *The conscription writs have a clause: “void if Belworth freezes.” The river is still warm.*
- A **Legal Duel Challenge** — Master Advocate Halric issues a formal challenge; refuse and lose legal standing, accept and risk life and fortune in court-yard combat. The ultimate legal weapon. *The challenge is written on both sides of the parchment. There is no blank space to refuse.*

(Bribe/Seal/Writ/Duel Warrant) Ferry priority at Belworth crossing; dike-work allotment with brotherhood labor granted; market license sealed with proper wax; sanctioned duel to settle property dispute.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ferry Priority** — Belworth crossing (once); a horn answers, though perhaps the wrong ferry; customs officials look the other way for the right coin. Legal right of way backed by armed escort. *The priority token is a writ signed by both banks. The ink on one side is newer.*
3. **Dike Allotment** — Brotherhood labor granted if three clerks are convinced and proper bribes distributed among the right hands. Work performed under legal contract with military oversight. *The allotment includes a clause: “as tides permit.” The reeve decides what the tides permit.*

4. **Market License** — Valora’s square; a guild nod still needed, but the right seal on the right parchment opens many doors. Legal protection from merchant guild enforcement. *The license is written on vellum from a Vhasian abbey. The irony is noted.*
5. **Dawn Escort** — Four lances at dawn; loyalty waxes and wanes with pay, but their presence keeps lesser men from troubling you. Legal authority to enforce your writs. *The lances are from the Fenwood armory. The Fenwood dukes have their own plans.*
6. **River Charter** — Guaranteed haul on a grain artery—weather permitting and proper duties paid to the right officials. Legal right protected by river patrol. *The charter is stamped with a seal that looks like a crown—or a sunburst. No one can agree.*
7. **Map Correction** — A hedge moves, borders shift, lawsuits bloom; a new survey can make or break a man’s fortune overnight. Legal survey backed by armed surveyors. *The surveyors carry chains and swords. The swords are for when the chains disagree.*
8. **Customs Seal** — Fairport for Dolmis cargo; honored today, disputed tomorrow, but tonight it clears the way for what needs moving. Legal immunity from customs enforcement. *The seal is a wax crab. It pinches when pressed.*
9. **Thing Ruling** — Sharp local bite, but appeals run swifter than oaths; justice swift but not always just, depending on which purse feeds the judge. Court decisions enforceable by local levy. *The ruling is carved on an oar. Break the oar, and the ruling breaks with it.*
10. **Salt Allotment** — Winter depot; the Queen’s writ opens doors, old hands still count sacks, but the right connections ensure the best salt reaches the right tables. Legal monopoly backed by military force. *The salt is from a pan worked by Ubral exiles. They still count in clan measure.*
- J **Wardship** — A minor fen-keep; men-at-arms “for now,” a tutor has plans, but the right guardian can be found for the right price. Legal guardianship with military authority. *The ward is a child. The child has a seal ring. The ring is older than the kingdom.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private; her questions strike like thrusts, but her favors can elevate a man from nothing to something overnight. Royal decree carries immediate enforcement power. *The audience lasts one hour. The paperwork lasts a generation.*
- K **Ducal Warrant** — Fenwood to enforce customs; old power bows, new power watches, but the parchment carries weight in any court. Legal authority backed by noble house military. *The warrant is signed in blood—or ink that looks like blood. The difference matters at trial.*
- A **Duel Sanction** — Right to challenge in legal combat; the Queen’s seal makes it official, Dawn-knights serve as seconds, the winner takes all legally. Ultimate legal

enforcement mechanism.

The sanction is a coin. Heads you duel, tails your opponent chooses the weapon.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (writs/charters/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **hedge-law** motif—boundaries blur, charters contradict, precedent splinters, and the careful web of legal authority shows its cracks. Legal warfare escalates to physical conflict.

Additional Features

- **Hedge-Law Momentum:** When a valid *writ*, *charter*, or *warrant* is presented in the proper parish, step **Position** up one category on social or logistical actions in that locale for the scene. The first contradiction starts a **Border-Lace** [4] clock; advance each time competing papers are invoked.
- **Beacon & Bell Chain:** If two adjacent *beacons* or *brotherhood bells* are under your influence, convert one **Club** draw into a travel delay for *others* while the party proceeds with improved **Effect** for movement and logistics. The signal draws scrutiny; the GM may bank 1 SB tied to local authority.
- **River-Right Window:** At a ferry, tidework, or customs stair, play any **Diamond** tied to crossings or seals to open a short *window of lawful passage*: one convoy passes uninspected, or one cargo clears at priority. The window closes immediately if a storm, audit, or levy card is revealed.
- **Legal Duel Protocol:** When legal disputes cannot be resolved through argument, parties may challenge each other to a duel. The winner’s position becomes legally binding. Requires proper sanction and seconds.
- **Vhasian Claims:** Any Viterran noble with land across the Belworth may invoke a *Ducal Warrant* to attempt to collect rents or enforce judgments in Vhasia. Doing so starts a **Border Snarl** clock, as the Vhasian claimants are unlikely to cooperate.
- **Theona Contest:** The Warrior Queen’s authority over the Three Greens is nominal at best. Any attempt to enforce Viterran law in Theona triggers a **Isle Refusal** complication, and the local taboos may twist the law into knots.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Elodie of the Unbuckled Gorget (The Witness):** The Justiciar Elodie Venn invoked the long-forgotten *Right of Acknowledgment* in the trial of Baron Aldric the Turncloak. Her ruling forced a father to speak one truth aloud before his son. The precedent now stands in the Hall of Dawning: “The truth, once

spoken, is payment in full. No further interest shall accrue.” The Temple of Light has adopted her as a saint of mercy; the Fenwood dukes still whisper that she overstepped.

- **The Hedge-Seal (The Dike Covenant):** Covenant judges in the eastern parishes adjudicate disputes over river tolls and inheritance. They carry no weapons, only a set of iron scales and a copy of the *Hedge-Law Tables*. A ruling from the Order is binding in both Viterra and the Vhasian marches, but any party who lies before them forfeits their right to appeal. The Warrior Queen has granted them a charter; the Fenwood dukes consider them spies.
- **Saint Cuthbert of the Fen (The Traveler):** A legendary reeve who walked the flooded dikes during the Great Storm and lit every beacon by hand. His shrines are stiles and bridge posts; travellers who touch the iron ring on his shrine and speak a destination find the road holds firm. The Temple of Light has absorbed his cult, but the fen folk still leave offerings of eels at his cairns.
- **The Cog-Cults of the Northern Hills (The Clockwork Monad):** In the high parishes near the Ubral border, secret fraternities of millers and surveyors believe that law is a machine that can be perfected. They meet in abandoned watermills, measuring boundaries with brass chains and reciting the *Canons of Proportion*. The Everflame calls them heretics; the Queen’s justiciars ignore them because their charts are always accurate.
- **The Salt Sworn of the Eastern Coast (The Pale Shepherd):** Along the Dolmis shore, a syncretic cult tends to the drowned. They build cairns of salt stone and leave no offerings—only the names of the lost, carved into driftwood. The Temple of Light has tried to suppress them three times; each time, the mission ships have been found adrift with no crew and a single name carved into the mast: *Oblivion*.
- **The Ninth:** In any Viterran court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous citations. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls—and their cases are never heard again.

Viterran Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Hedge:** Crumble a crust at a parish boundary stone. Ignore the first *Border Snarl* penalty.
- **Knot the Writ:** Tie a single knot in a charter’s ribbon. Cancel *Audit Freeze* or take −1 die on your next legal argument (your choice).
- **Name to the River:** Whisper a dead claimant’s name into the Belworth. Gain +1 Effect when arguing against their heir’s claim this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen’s Justiciar.

Patronage & Power

In Viterra, power flows through the careful application of law, the management of ancient rights, and the delicate balance between imperial legacy and reclaimed sovereignty. The Warrior Queen maintains authority through a combination of military might and legal precision, while the old duchies and local officials wield influence through their knowledge of traditional customs and hedge-law. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex legal landscape and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority while building genuine support.

But remember—in Viterra, law is warfare. Every document is a weapon, every courtroom a battlefield, and every advocate a soldier. The pen cuts as deep as any blade, and legal victory can be as decisive as military conquest.

For the GM: Patronage in Viterra revolves around legal documents, local rights, and the ability to command respect from institutions still finding their post-imperial identity. Rewards often take the form of writs, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, charters) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival duchies and Vhasian claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the courts, parishes, and muster grounds as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.
- When legal conflicts escalate beyond words, transition naturally to physical confrontation with appropriate stakes.

In Viterra, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled. But when words fail, steel speaks—and the law says both are valid.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **crown officials or rival advocates**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **writ-runners or levy guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or customs inspectors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable court date**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Queen’s Justiciar or fen reeve becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or river closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival claimant or border routier** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Dawn-knights, levy forces, or Vhasian routiers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **writ voided/duel declared/levy called**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Warrior Queen, Crown Council, or Master Advocate Halric** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **dike breaks/river floods/court erupts**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Viterrra (Hedge Law):** Boundary stones shift, charters contradict themselves, legal precedents split mid-citation.
- **Viterrra (Cross-Border Claims):** Vhasian landlords appear with older deeds, Theonan taboos void writs, Ubral cairns declare neutrality with axes.
- **Viterrra (Legal Warfare):** Court decisions reverse without warning, witnesses recant, duel seconds change sides.

Legal Combat System (Summary)

When legal disputes cannot be resolved through negotiation, parties may engage in formal legal duels. These combine verbal sparring with physical combat:

Phase 1: Pleadings

- Each advocate presents their case (Wits + Sway vs. DV 3)
- Success grants +1 die to the next phase
- Failure creates 1 SB that the opponent can spend

Phase 2: Cross-Examination

- Attack opponent’s arguments (Wits + Insight vs. DV 3)
- Success inflicts Fatigue 1 on the opponent
- Critical success forces opponent to answer truthfully

Phase 3: Trial by Combat (if unresolved)

- Physical combat with legal stakes
- Winner’s position becomes legally binding
- Loser suffers legal consequences plus physical harm

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Violet Clerk (Master of Counter-Seals)** — *Phases*: Produce Earlier Patent → Split the Writ → Seal Fast. *Cracks*: a **Queen’s Audience** overrules his seal; a **Duel Sanction** forces personal combat.
- **The Thorn Captain (Queen’s Quiet Hand)** — *Phases*: Queenspeace Zone → Duel Warrant → Swap the Field. *Cracks*: a **Map Correction** reveals a loophole; a **Dike Allotment** lets you claim the field as “flood zone.”
- **The Saffron Abbess (Keeper of Bell-Law)** — *Phases*: Wrong Hour → Bless or Damn → Mixed Tribunal. *Cracks*: a **Queen’s Justiciar** invokes crown supremacy; a **Border Routier** bribes her bell-ringer.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Belworth Stairs Ordeal** — Cross the river without a charter. On success, you prove that possession is nine-tenths of the law. On failure, the river takes your name—and your cargo.
- **Hall of Dawning Vigil** — Spend a night in the tilt-yard. At dawn, you recall a forgotten legal precedent. Gain a one-use *Precedent Edge* (+1 die in any court). The ghost of a dead duelist may challenge you.
- **Hedge-Moot at Dusk** — Settle a boundary dispute by walking the hedge. Each successful navigation test clears 1 segment from a **Border Snarl** clock. A miss plants the thorn of a future feud.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Legal Dial (Crown ↔ Local Custom):** Track the party’s stance on authority.
 - *Crown High*: +1 Position when invoking royal writs, charters, or the Queen’s name; first appeal to local custom starts one step worse.
 - *Local High*: +1 Effect on hedge-law, parish rights, or ancient precedent; first royal petition starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by hosting a mixed moot or surrendering a contested seal to a neutral third party.
- **Courtroom Mini-Game (fast trial):**
 - Lay three stones: **Precedent**, **Equity**, **Force**.
 - Argue a point (roll Lore+Diplomacy vs. DV 3). On a hit, move one stone to your side. On a miss, the opposing advocate gains *Citation Edge*.
 - Win two stones to secure a temporary **Court Ruling** (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
 - *Halric’s Interjection* (2 SB): flip **Precedent**, but start **Whispered Precedent** [2] with the losing side.
- **Cross-Border Tensions (fast pressure):**
 - Two opposed clocks: *Queen’s Peace* vs *Border Fire* (size by highest rank in the seed).
 - Each leg, choose *Viterran Road* (safe, slow), *Vhasian Claim* (fast, risky), or *Ubral Pass* (hidden, costly).
 - Advantage: Vhasian Claim→Viterran Road (shortcuts), Ubral Pass→Vhasian Claim (concealment), Viterran Road→Ubral Pass (supplies).
 - Spend a **Ducal Warrant** to shift one segment from *Border Fire* to *Queen’s Peace*.
- **Start-of-Scene Rumors (1d6):**
 1. *Wrong Wax*: a rival’s seals softened; +1d to forgeries this scene.
 2. *Empty Beacon*: tower unmanned; travel faster, scrutiny harsher.
 3. *Dawn-Lane Cleared*: first convoy action gains +1 Position.
 4. *Clerk’s Wedding*: filings delayed; first petition ignores *Audit Freeze*.
 5. *Fen High Water*: ferries slow; river-charters count double value.
 6. *Mask at Progress*: someone uses your name at court; +1d to social opens, +1 SB banked by GM.
- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Viterra Flavor):**
 - 1 SB → *Hedge Shift*: a boundary moves; increase DV by 1 for navigation or legal rolls this scene.

- 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a *◊orrecallapastruling*).
- 3+ SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value; swap one held *◊foralesserrightuntilre-witnessed*.

• **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade **Audit Freeze** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
- *Fen-Tested*: +1 Position when resolving dike or flood crises; legal arguments about water rights start one step worse.
- *Double-Sealed*: +1d with both royal and local courts in a truce scene; any betrayal earns **Border Snarl** from both sides.

• **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**

- *Ubral (Stone & Oath)*: A **Ducal Warrant** acts as a *Guest-Token* once at a clan hearth, but starts a **Feud Rekindled** tick if you collect tolls twice in a tenday.
- *Thepyrgos (Synod Law)*: A **Queen’s Audience** can suspend a synod interdict—but starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
- *Vhasia (Fractured Sun)*: A **Duel Sanction** is recognized on the Pont-du-Tithe—but a rival abbey can turn it into *Parlement Divided* on a Club draw.
- *Theona (No Ninth)*: **Ferry Priority** overrides a local taboo once; if the Ninth custom is in play, the writ “forgets” one clause on use (GM banks 1 SB).

Conspiracy Flourishes (keep it close, keep it quiet)

- **Hedge-Moots at Dusk**: Parish elders “trim hedges” while trading sealed whispers.
- **Cipher Roses**: Folded writs stamped with thorn-petals; one petal missing marks a false clause.
- **Mirror Hours**: Beacons flash lawful signals—reversed for those who know the counter-code.
- **Eel-Letters**: Oiled parchment smuggled in eel-baskets; ink runs in water, truth does not.
- **Quiet Steel, Quieter Quills**: Dawn-knights duel at first light; advocates settle three duels before breakfast with ink alone.
- **Progress Masks**: Courtiers wear legal devices as masque motifs (seal, chain, beacon) to signal faction at a glance.
- **Bell Penance**: A single off-hour peal grants amnesty to those who confess a clause before the twelfth echo.

4.29 The Ways Between — “Spiritways & Veilways”

The Wayfinder (Elite): “I exist only in the moment of choice, the breath between one path and another. To guide here is to understand that every way leads somewhere, but only the wise know which somethings are worth the journey.”

Lost Pilgrim (Commoner): “The paths here don’t care where you think you’re going – they care where you need to be. Best walk softly and listen to what the waystones whisper when you pass. I’ve been walking for... I forget how long. But the road hasn’t lost me yet.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Between Death and Dreams lies a country of crossings. Roads remember promises; milestones remember names you never spoke. The Ways Between do not measure miles—they measure choices. Here, a wrong turn might lead to yesterday, or to a version of yourself who made a different decision. The mist does not hide landmarks; it hides destinations. Every threshold demands a toll, and the currency is always something you did not know you had: a memory, a fear, a forgotten debt. Walk softly, pay what the path asks, and mind which version of you arrives.

What you notice first: The air tastes of copper and old keys. Your footsteps echo half a beat too late. The waystones are warm—and they pulse like hearts.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a question asked by a reflection. The answer will bind you to the path you did not choose.

Regional Mood: The Road That Remembers

Here, the road is not a thing—it is a witness. It remembers every traveler who has walked it, every promise made at a crossroads, every lie told to a milestone. The Ways Between do not forgive, but they do not forget either. They offer passage in exchange for truth. The longer you walk, the more the path learns about you. By the time you reach your destination, you may find that the destination knows you better than you know yourself. Some travelers never leave. They become waystones, their faces pressed into moss, their names still warm on the lips of the next pilgrim.

Starting Location: A crossroad shrine of black glass stones, where travelers meet their reflections coming the other way. The shrine is silent except for the soft hum of the stones. A Backwards Pilgrim stands at the crossroads, facing the direction you came from. “The Thirteenth Stone speaks,” they say. “But the path chooses who arrives. What did you bury on the road here? The stones can smell it.”

(Path/Crossing/Threshold) Mist-shrouded ford where water runs uphill; footsteps echo backwards; bone-lit corridor where shadows walk the walls.

Spades — Places

2. **Mist-Ford** — Water runs uphill; footsteps echo backwards through time. *The ford shows you wading through your own past. Do not look down at the water.*

3. **Bone Corridor** — Shadows walk the walls but never touch the floor; light as memory. *The bones are not from any creature you know. They shift when you blink.*
4. **Threshold Arch** — Shows a reflection as someone you might have been; the past as a mirror. *The reflection has a scar you never got. It asks how you avoided it.*
5. **Spiral Path** — Ascends but returns to the same stone marker; the journey as meditation. *Each loop, the stone moves closer to the center. Or you do.*
6. **Promise Bridge** — Cross with a vow and it remembers your debt; an oath as a toll. *The bridge’s planks are old letters. Read one, and you may owe the writer.*
7. **Crossroads** — All four paths lead to the same destination, but different tomorrows. *The center stone is warm. A coin placed there will vanish—or be accepted.*
8. **Stone Circle** — Marks where a village used to be; the houses are now constellations. *The stars are too close. You can touch them. They crumble like ash.*
9. **Memory Tunnel** — Hear the thoughts of those who passed here; the past as an echo. *The thoughts are in a language you almost understand. One word is your name.*
10. **Fossil Stairs** — Each step is an eye that watches your ascent; the climb as scrutiny. *The eyes belong to those who fell here. They blink in sequence.*
- J **Waystation** — The keeper trades in unfinished conversations; words as currency. *The keeper has no face. It wears the faces of those who paused too long.*
- Q **Junction** — Paths physically collide; you must choose which reality to follow. *The collision sounds like breaking glass. The glass reforms into a door.*
- K **Long Mile** — The road stretches differently for each traveler; distance as perception. *You are the only one walking. The others are already at the end.*
- A **Thirteenth Stone** — Where the path reveals its true destination; truth as revelation. *The stone whispers. The whisper is a promise you made to yourself and broke.*

(Wayfarer/Spirit/Dream-walker) Lost pilgrim who thinks they’re going home but forgot where; toll-taker accepting payment in forgotten memories.

Hearts — Travelers & Guides

2. **Lost Pilgrim** — Thinks they’re going home but forgot where; destination as a memory. *Their pack is full of stones. Each stone is a forgotten promise.*
3. **Toll-Taker** — Accepts payment in memories you didn’t know you had. *Their scales weigh truth and echo. A balanced scale means you pass—for now.*

4. **Wayward Guide** — Directions technically correct, morally questionable. *They point with a broken compass. The needle spins, but the path is true.*
5. **Dream-Merchant** — Carries a sack of nightmares and one perfect dream for sale. *The perfect dream is their own. They are selling it because they cannot wake up.*
6. **Child-Ghost** — Knows shortcuts but charges in riddles; wisdom as a puzzle. *The riddles have no answer—only a choice. Choose wrong, and you become a child.*
7. **Wounded Walker** — Bleeding metaphor; their pain grows thorns along the path. *The thorns have faces. Each face is someone they failed to save.*
8. **Map-Merchant** — Selling maps to places that don’t exist yet; the future as a commodity. *The maps change as you watch. The destination is always one page ahead.*
9. **Guide-Dog** — Made of shadow and starlight; follows those who walk with purpose. *It never barks. It whines when you are about to make a mistake.*
10. **Backwards Pilgrim** — Moving through time; their steps erase what just happened. *They are walking toward their birth. Every step, they forget something.*
- J **Soul-Ferryman** — Carries the luggage of the living; a burden as a service. *The luggage is full of things you never said. The ferryman knows them all.*
- Q **Road’s Child** — Born where paths crossed, raised by waymarks; navigation as instinct. *They have no navel. They were never born—they simply began.*
- K **Dead-Road Keeper** — Ensures proper passage for those who should not walk. *Their lantern burns a cold blue. The flame does not flicker.*
- A **The Wayfinder** — Exists only in the moment a choice is made; a decision as an entity. *They are every guide you ever needed. They are also every road you refused.*

(Veil-Thin/Dream-Bleed/Wayward) Path loops back to show your funeral preparations; reality thins—you see the dreams of sleeping travelers.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Funeral Loop** — The path shows your funeral preparations; death as a destination. *The mourners are people you have not met yet. They seem to know you well.*
3. **Reality Thins** — You see the dreams of sleeping travelers; the boundary as a veil. *A dreamer mutters your name. They are dreaming of a choice you will make tomorrow.*
4. **Waymark Lies** — Points the wrong way; trust leads to places that never were. *The waymark has a crack. Through the crack, you see a path you should have taken.*

5. **Dream-Bleed** — Waking memories become someone else’s nightmares. *You remember a childhood fear that was not yours. It still terrifies you.*
 6. **Toll Demanded** — Currency you did not know you carried; payment as a revelation. *The toll is a secret you told a dead person. They are now standing behind you.*
 7. **Path Split** — Each version of you remembers differently; identity as a choice. *One you is smiling. One you is weeping. One you is already walking away.*
 8. **Gravity Shifts** — Emotional weight grows physically heavy; a burden as physics. *Your pack feels heavier. Inside is a regret you forgot you carried.*
 9. **Time-Sickness** — You arrive before you left; paradox shadows follow. *Your past self waves at you. Do not wave back.*
 10. **Truth Payment** — The road remembers your lies and demands truth as payment. *The lie is carved on a stone. The stone is warm. It knows your temperature.*
- J **Crossroads Judgment** — The path you chose judges the ones you did not; decision as karma. *A ghost of the road not taken asks why. You have one sentence to answer.*
- Q **Memory-Thief** — A rest stop keeper pays in counterfeit recollections. *The memory is almost right. The color of the sky is wrong.*
- K **Forbidden Path** — Opens only for those already lost; loss as a key. *The path smells of old tears. You taste salt on your lips.*
- A **Convergence** — All travelers arrive together, none recall how; arrival as a mystery. *You recognize everyone. You have never seen any of them before.*

(True Name/Safe Passage/Waywisdom) Waymark that always points toward your next important choice; a token of passage that the road recognizes as belonging.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Choice Compass** — Always points toward your next important choice. *The needle is a splinter of the Thirteenth Stone. It hums when you are near a decision.*
3. **Passage Token** — The road recognizes you as one who belongs. *The token is a braid of your own hair. You do not remember cutting it.*
4. **Dream-Catcher** — Filters nightmares from your rest; sleep as a sanctuary. *The catcher is woven from old promises. It smells of lavender and regret.*
5. **Truth-Compass** — Points to what you most need to know, not what you want. *The compass has no needle. The housing spins until you speak a truth.*
6. **Memory-Anchor** — Keeps you from losing yourself on deeper paths. *The anchor is a river stone. Your name is carved on it in a language you have never seen.*

7. **Safe Haven** — A guaranteed rest stop without complication. *The haven is a dry arch. The arch is a doorframe with no door.*
8. **Guide-Light** — Burns the color of your truest intention; purpose as a beacon. *The light is blue. Blue means you are honest. Red means you are not.*
9. **Path-Cutter** — Cuts distance through metaphor, not space. *The cutter is a pair of shears. Cut a memory, and the road between here and there vanishes.*
10. **Debt-Clearing** — The road forgives one obligation you thought you owed. *The obligation was to a dead person. They are no longer dead on this path.*
- J **Crossroads Boon** — Choose among three paths, each exactly where you need to be. *The paths are labeled: Regret, Forgive, Forget. Choose carefully.*
- Q **Way-Wisdom** — Understand the language of paths and signs for one journey. *The waystones whisper. They are complaining about the last traveler. It was you.*
- K **Grace Passage** — Walk safely through any dangerous crossing for one night. *The grace is a bell. Ring it, and the road will pretend not to see you.*
- A **Road’s Name** — Call the path by its true name and command its nature. *The name is a single syllable. Speaking it will change the road—and you.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (true names/safe passages/waywisdom) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **dream-road** motifs—reflections that lie, paths that judge, destinations that choose the traveler.

Additional Features

- **Dream-Logic Navigation:** Any Ace introduces a metaphysical requirement (a sacrifice, a taboo, an exchange) that must be satisfied to pass. Name it at the table; the road will enforce it.
- **Reflection Points:** Face cards (J, Q, K) show alternate selves or unlived choices. Treat them as temporary NPCs or scene tags that can help, hinder, or tempt.
- **Memory Currency:** Diamonds may be traded for knowledge or safe passage as if they were memories. Describe the memory paid; the path (or its keeper) pays in kind.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord know the Ways Between as the Cord’s shadow. A lost Hollowed wanders here, its thread trailing into the mist. Follow it, and you may find a Sister who cut herself free.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Saikou Ira’s silver mirror shows the Ways Between as a tangled knot of unfulfilled obligations. He has walked three paths here. He will not speak of the fourth.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends lies at every crossroads. Pick it up, and the road will offer you a shortcut—but the coin will reappear in your pocket at the next junction, heavier.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Psions call the Ways Between “the Stair.” They climb it in their dreams, trading memories for glimpses of paths not yet walked. Some never wake.
- **The Ninth:** On any path in the Ways Between, the ninth step you take in a straight line will land on a threshold you did not see. The wise take eight steps, then pause to look around.

Ways Between Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stones:** Crumble a crust at the base of a waystone. Ignore the first *Waymark Lies* penalty.
- **Knot the Path:** Tie a single knot in a piece of string and hang it from a milestone. Cancel *Path Split* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Crossroads:** Whisper a dead traveler’s name into the center stone. Gain +1 Effect when bargaining with a Toll-Taker this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Wayfinder.

Patronage & Power

In the Ways Between, power flows through understanding the metaphysical nature of paths, the ability to navigate dream-logic, and the careful management of obligations and truths. The true authorities are those who know the True Names of paths, can mediate between alternate versions of travelers, and understand the currency of memory and choice. Power here is not about commanding others, but about understanding the fundamental nature of journey and destination.

For the GM: Patronage in the Ways Between revolves around guidance, safe passage, and the ability to navigate metaphysical requirements. Rewards often take the form of waymarks, tokens, and knowledge that can be leveraged into greater understanding. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, compasses, lights) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guides issue conflicting directions, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the crossroads, waystations, and thresholds as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of path-logic determines success.

In the Ways Between, your understanding is your power, and your power determines whether you walk or are walked.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **path keepers** or **wayward spirits**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **travelers** or **memory echoes**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **reflection points**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable path alignment**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Toll-taker** or **wayward guide** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **path shift** or **reality thinning**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **memory-thief** or **forbidden path entity** arrives on scene.

- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wayward spirits, path entities, or alternate selves** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **path loops/time shifts/reality fractures**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **The Wayfinder, Dead-Road Keeper, or Road’s Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **reality thins/paths converge/time loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ways Between (Dream-Logic):** Paths rearrange without warning, reflections speak unbidden, destinations shift mid-journey.
- **Ways Between (Memory Currency):** Memories become tangible, forgotten knowledge resurfaces, past and present blur.
- **Ways Between (Choice Consequences):** Decisions echo forward, alternate selves appear, paths judge moral weight.

Path-Moves & Procedures (Optional Depth)

Weighing of Steps (Travel Move) When the company enters a liminal path (Mist-Ford, Bone Corridor, etc.), choose one:

- **Pay the Toll:** Each PC names a small truth or a fond memory (GM: 1 SB banked, +1 Position on navigation).
- **Refuse the Toll:** +1d on Speed, but start a **Way-Debt** [4] clock.

- **Bargain the Toll:** Trade a *Diamond* reward as if it were a memory (see Memory Exchange below); cancel one imminent *Club* card in this scene.

When **Way-Debt** fills, trigger *Crossroads Judgment* at the next junction.

Reflection Duel (Social/Moral Test) When confronted by an alternate self or *Reflection Point*, state what that self wants from you and roll your best social action.

- **Success:** Gain a *Guide-Light* tag for the scene and clear 1 tick from **Paths Decide**.
- **Mixed:** Trade places for one exchange or take a **Condition: Disoriented**.
- **Miss:** The reflection walks away with one of your *Diamonds* (GM picks the most narratively apt).

	Memory Offered	Buys You
Memory Exchange (Rates & Risks)	A childhood smell, a forgotten nickname	+1 Position on one crossing
	A first failure or small betrayal	Cancel one minor Complication
	A true fear you have never spoken	<i>Guide-Light</i> or <i>Way-Cord</i> -like effect
	The details of a kept promise	<i>Safe Passage</i> for the party
	The meaning behind a scar	Convert one <i>Club</i> into <i>Trace</i> only
	A perfect day (all details)	Treat the next <i>Heart</i> face as an ally

Exchange Rule: If you pay the same *kind* of memory twice in a journey, start **Hollowing** [4]. When it fills, you gain the *Backwards Pilgrim* tag until you reclaim what was lost.

Way-Keys & Taboos (d6)

1. **Speak Last:** Only the final word said at a gate is true; others are “practice.” First speakers take –1d on their next test.
2. **Step Odd:** Crossings require an odd number of steps; even counts loop you back one scene.
3. **Name Nothing:** True names wake *Name-Theft*; use titles or lose a *Diamond*.
4. **Wet Iron:** A drop of water on iron cancels one glamour once per scene.
5. **Back Gift:** Leave something behind to go forward; refuse and tick **Way-Debt**.
6. **Answer Bent:** Answer a waystone’s question with a metaphor, not a fact, or trigger *Truth Payment*.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Archivist of Unmade Roads (cloak stitched from surveyor’s cords)** — *Phases*: Receipts of Refusal → Stay of Journey → Unfiled Options. *Cracks*: a **Choice Compass** reveals the true path; a **Debt-Clearing** voids his claim.
- **The Toll-Matriarch Beneath the Bridge (many hands, one voice like wet stone)** — *Phases*: Truth Payment → Debt-Clearing → Forbidden Path. *Cracks*: a **Passage Token** marks you as belonging; a **Road’s Name** commands her to stand aside.
- **The Wayfinder’s Shadow (your silhouette, two steps ahead)** — *Phases*: Crossroads Judgment → Guide-Light → Haste Mark. *Cracks*: a **Memory-Anchor** keeps you grounded; a **Grace Passage** slips past its gaze.

Encounter Seeds (quick hooks)

- **The Promise Bridge’s Receipt**: An old vow you never spoke was logged here. To cross, define when you would have sworn it—and to whom.
- **Thirteenth Stone Auction**: The stone sells three possible endings. Each bidder is you from a different failure.
- **Bone Corridor Choir**: Shadows sing a name wrong by one letter. Correct it and gain *Truth-Compass*; ignore it and start **Name-Theft**.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Choice Dial (Resolve ↔ Drift)**: Track the party’s footing between firm intent and wandering.
 - *Resolve High*: +1 Position on *Path Split* tests; the first *Dream-Bleed* each session hits harder (start at 2).
 - *Drift High*: +1 Effect when bargaining with way-entities; the first *Truth Payment* each session costs a cherished *detail*.
 - Center the Dial by naming aloud the next choice *and* why you might refuse it; clear 1 tick from **Way-Debt**.
- **Counter-Seal (once/scene, if justified)**: Break a single metaphysical instruction (taboo, key, or omen) by presenting a memory in symbol form (a token, a letter, a sketch). Gain +1d on that crossing; the GM banks 1 SB as a *Marked Consequence* to spend when reflections return.
- **Start-of-Scene Murmurs (1d6)**:
 1. *Second Sunrise*: light arrives twice; your first missed navigation roll becomes a mixed success.
 2. *Name Draft*: the air steals a syllable; your next lie sounds true once.
 3. *Echo Debt*: your footprints owe a step—skip a square or tick **Way-Debt** +1.
 4. *Pale Bell*: time hiccups; the first *Club* can be delayed until the end of the scene.

5. *Traveler’s Chorus*: distant voices agree with you; +1d on appeals to path entities.
6. *Hollow Weather*: rain that does not wet; conditions look dire but impose no penalties this scene.

- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Ways Between Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Footprint Vote*: your tracks choose a different direction; increase DV by 1 on any roll that relies on following a trail.
- 2 SB → *Echo of Refusal*: a choice you avoided manifests as a minor obstacle (a locked gate, a forgotten toll).
- 3+ SB → *Threshold Cracks*: the path fractures; gain a temporary **Path-Cutter** effect but start **Convergence** [4] (all travelers you have met will arrive together at the next junction).

- **Cross-Regional Conversions (Using Diamonds Across the Map):**

- *Valewood*: **Road’s Name** may count as a *Valeheart Clause* once if spoken under leaves; doing so creates **Court Tithe** [2].
- *Mistlands*: **Grace Passage** functions as *Pall Indulgence* over one levee crown at night; ring a bell afterward or start **Witchlight Count**.
- *Vhasia*: **Way-Wisdom** can be presented as “pilgrim right” to bypass one *Interdict* barrier; begin a **Parlement Divided** tick.
- *Viterra*: **Passage Token** can be notarized into a temporary *Ferry Priority*; on use, advance **Border-Lace**.
- *Ubral*: **Memory-Anchor** counts as a *Guest-Token* at one hearth if you recount a family road-tale.
- *Silkstrand*: **Path-Cutter** doubles as a night-boat route once; spend 1 favor with a smuggler or trigger *Seal Counterfeit*.
- *Linn*: **Choice Compass** acts as a *Pilot’s Token* in a reed-maze if you pay a name to the water.
- *Theona*: **Crossroads Boon** allows counting “eight-and-one” to cross an *Uncounted Bridge* safely once.

4.30 The Wilds — “Roads, Ruins, and Weather”

Claimant Chief (Elite): “These lands answer not to charters but to those who can read their signs and respect their moods. Authority here is earned one campfire at a time, by proving you understand the difference between claiming and belonging.”

Forager Child (Commoner): “The wilds don’t need your roads or your rules – they got their own ways of keeping score. Follow the cairns if you want to live, and always leave something behind to thank the land for letting you pass. Every hill hides a secret, and every hollow breathes.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Between towns and treaties lies the patience of the land. Old roads remember armies; cairns remember names no book keeps. In the Wilds, law thins to trail-marks and favors, and the weather keeps its own counsel. This is the country of the hexcrawl: a patchwork of hidden valleys, forgotten ruins, beast lairs, and the bones of failed settlements. No single authority rules here—instead, the land itself is the ledger, and every crossing writes a new line. Walk soft, read the wind, bargain with whatever still listens, and keep one eye on the horizon. The next hex may hold water, treasure, or teeth.

What you notice first: The silence after a bird stops singing. The way a cairn seems to have shifted since you passed it last. The smell of rain on dry stone, even when the sky is clear.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sleep in a hollow that has soot on the ceiling without adding your own to the fire. The land knows the difference between a guest and a thief.

The Unfinished Map

The Wilds are not a route—they are a grid of secrets. Each day’s march opens a new page. Some hexes are empty: water, fuel, a safe place to sleep. Others hold lairs, ruins, shrines, or the remnants of old wars. The GM should key a handful of interesting places in advance, then let the cards populate the space between. Draw a card for each new leg; let the suit and rank whisper what you find. The land does not repeat itself, but it echoes.

(Crossing/Lookout/Old Road) Crossing point with ford/ice-span/stepping logs/dune saddle/reef shelf; lookout knoll with wind-carved marker; old road trace with cairns half-eaten by terrain.

Spades — Places (Hex Terrain)

2. **Crossing Point** — Ford, ice-span, stepping logs, dune saddle, reef shelf. *The crossing has a price: a stone, a story, or a moment of silence.*

3. **Lookout Knoll** — Tor, cliff, dune, ridge with wind-carved marker. *From here, you can see three hexes in clear weather—and one that shouldn't exist.*
 4. **Old Road** — Trace with cairns and switchbacks half-eaten by terrain. *The cobbles are worn smooth by ghosts. They whisper directions at dusk.*
 5. **Shelter Hollow** — Overhang, cave, root cellar; soot says “used lately.” *The soot is layered. Someone has been coming here for a very long time.*
 6. **Water Source** — Spring, seep, fog net, snow pan, guarded by thorns or stone. *The water tastes of iron and old bargains. Drink deep, but leave a coin.*
 7. **Windbreak** — Rock ribs, lee of pines, reed-wall berm. *The windbreak smells of woodsmoke. Someone camped here last night.*
 8. **Ruined Outpost** — Watchstack, wayside shrine, marker pile. *The ruin's flagstones are warm. Something lives beneath them.*
 9. **Bad Ground** — Sinkhole, bog crust, crevasse, loess slump. *The ground breathes. Step lightly or it will swallow you.*
 10. **Gate Gully** — Pinch point between bluffs, dunes, or ice hummocks. *The gully has a name carved in the rock. The name changes every season.*
- J **Boundary Row** — Totems, standing stones, prayer flags bent by weather. *The flags are faded. The last prayer was for rain—and it still hasn't come.*
- Q **Worksite** — Abandoned mine, quarry, logging camp, salt pan. *The tools are scattered. Whoever left did not plan to return.*
- K **Signal Height** — Old fire-pit or mirror stand; smoke stains linger. *Light the fire, and someone will answer. Whether they are friend or foe is your risk.*
- A **Trail Nexus** — Migratory, pack, or contraband paths knot here. *Three trails meet, but only two are on any map. The third belongs to the dead.*

(Guide/Warden/Caravan) Forager child with truer maps than yours; guide with three routes and one price (changes daily).

Hearts — People & Factions (Hex Denizens)

2. **Forager Child** — Goat-herd or berry-picker with truer maps than yours. *Their map is drawn on a scrap of bark. It shows a path that disappears at a standing stone.*
3. **Guide** — Three routes and one price (changes daily); navigation as negotiation. *Their price is never coin. It is a favor, a secret, or a night's watch.*
4. **Warden Patrol** — Local badges, local laws, local patience; order as familiarity. *Their badge is a chipped sunburst. They serve a crown that no longer exists.*
5. **Caravan Crew** — Drovers, porters, yarn-post hands trading speed for coin. *They know every shortcut and every ambush. They will share both—for a price.*

6. **Pilgrims** — Bound for a tucked-away shrine or stone; faith as a destination. *Their shrine has no name. The stone there is warm, and it answers questions poorly.*
7. **Poachers** — Know every snare and shortcut; survival as expertise. *They wear the teeth of game wardens as necklaces. The game wardens are still alive.*
8. **Hermit-Healer** — Dogs, geese, and opinions about weather; wisdom as isolation. *Their poultices smell of grave-moss. They work anyway.*
9. **Prospectors** — Salt, amber, iron, fungus; chasing rumors and glint. *Their claim is marked with a knot of red thread. Cross it, and they will shoot.*
10. **War-Band** — Reavers or “escorts,” depending on your purse; violence as commerce. *Their banner is a painted skull. The paint is from a dead comrade’s blood.*
- J **Monster-Hunter** — Rite-keeper wearing yesterday’s trophies; death as livelihood. *Their trophy is still warm. The monster’s mate is close behind.*
- Q **Quartermaster** — Ledgers first, hospitality second; supply as authority. *Their ledger is written in a code only they understand. The code is their life story.*
- K **Claimant Chief** — Papers and spears to match; legitimacy as force. *Their papers are stained with water and blood. Both are still wet.*
- A **The Stranger** — Spirit-touched nomad or emissary; rules bend near them. *They have no shadow. The ground does not remember their footprints.*

(**Weather/Doubleback/Prowlers**) Weather turn with heat snap/cold snap/fog/dust; doubleback with tracks that loop; prowlers shadow with wolves/jackals/ghouls.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (Hex Hazards)

2. **Weather Turn** — Heat snap, cold snap, fog, dust; plans sag like wet leather. *The wind changes direction three times in an hour. Someone is watching.*
3. **Doubleback** — Tracks loop; the navigator swears the land moved underfoot. *Your own footprints face you. They were made yesterday—or tomorrow.*
4. **Prowlers Shadow** — Wolves, jackals, ghouls, seals, ravens by night; hunt as a company. *Their eyes reflect no light. Their teeth do.*
5. **Route Blocked** — Deadfall, rockfall, dune shift, ice heave; the path as an obstacle. *The blockage was placed. The toolmarks are fresh.*
6. **Quarantine Sign** — Camp fever; wardens sniff your packs for death. *The sign is a ribbon tied in a figure-eight. Do not cross it.*
7. **Territorial Beast** — Charge, stampede, or swarm; your choice of which is wrong. *The beast’s lair is nearby. You can smell it—old blood and older musk.*
8. **Elemental Front** — Grassfire, peat-burn, canopy flare, blowing spindrift. *The fire moves against the wind. The wind is lying.*

9. **Paper vs Spear** — Jurisdiction fight in the wilds stalls your day; law as argument. *Two officials, one road. Both have seals. Neither will show them.*
 10. **Supply Pinch** — Water, fuel, or feed low; pick what starves first. *Your canteen is full. The water is from a source that dried up last year.*
 - J **Pursuit** — Hunters or avengers follow; signs say “close.” *The tracks are one hour old. They are gaining.*
 - Q **Bad Omen** — Will-lights, taboo day, saint bells silent; locals refuse to move. *The omen is written in bird droppings on a milestone. It is still accurate.*
 - K **General Alarm** — Levy, muster, evacuation; all tracks become checkpoints. *The alarm horn is cracked. It sounds like a scream.*
 - A **Catastrophe** — Flood, whiteout, sandstorm, lahar; clocks jump like frightened deer. *The catastrophe has a name. The land remembers it.*
- (Cache/Pass/Favor) Cache token for hidden food or fuel stash; right-of-way pass recognized by a named trail; warden’s favor with an escort letter.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (Hex Discoveries)

2. **Cache Token** — Key to a hidden food or fuel stash (once); preparation as power. *The token is a knucklebone. The stash is marked with a cairn that has one stone missing.*
3. **Right-of-Pass** — Recognized marker for a named trail or crossing. *The marker is a notch carved in a milestone. The notch is shaped like a bird.*
4. **Warden’s Favor** — Escort letter; “they’re with us” as a shield. *The letter is stamped with a bell. The bell’s clapper is missing.*
5. **Weather Window** — Good forecast and a narrow gate to use it. *The window is a single hour at dawn. The birds will tell you when.*
6. **Water Deed** — Lawful draw at a scarce source; necessity as a right. *The deed is a clay cup. Break it, and the spring will flow—once.*
7. **Route Song** — A map scrap that actually works; knowledge as navigation. *The song has eight verses. The ninth is humming.*
8. **Remount Hire** — Fresh legs or hulls waiting at a post; speed as a service. *The remounts have no names. They answer to whistles and bribes.*
9. **Truce Cord** — Taboo exemption at a site (one scene); peace as a thread. *The cord is braided from wool and ash. Burn it to invoke the truce.*
10. **Toll Waiver** — A ferry, bridge, or reef gate honors this chit; passage as paper. *The chit is a dried leaf. The toll-keeper will not touch it.*
- J **Rescue Debt** — Locals owe you (or you owe them); trade for labor or intel. *The debt is carved on a tally stick. Break it when the favor is done.*

Q Private Audience — A keeper, shrine-warden, or spirit of the place hears you alone. *The audience is held at midnight. The spirit wears your face.*

K Road Commission — Temporary authority over a stretch of wilds. *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the land will listen—once.*

A Earth’s Exception — One temporary rule-bend (cross during a storm, pass uncounted, beasts ignore you). *The exception is a secret. The land will forget it as soon as you use it.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (cache/pass/favor) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, add a lingering omen of the land (a smell on the wind, a sound that carries too far, tracks that shift) that you can echo in later scenes.

Travel at a Glance (Fast Loose)

A journey through the Wilds is a series of choices, not a checklist. Before each leg (a day, a stretch of road, a single hex), the party picks two priorities from **Speed**, **Stealth**, **Safety**, **Survey**. Those become your edge; the others become vulnerabilities. The GM then frames a single roll based on the terrain and the weather’s mood (see *Weather Whims*, below). Success means you find what you sought; a mixed result trades progress for a cost; a miss throws a complication from the *Clubs* table onto the path.

Weather Whims (d6, one per leg)

1. *Glass-clear* – long sight, easy navigation. +1 to Survey actions.
2. *Low fog* – stealth advantage, speed suffers. +1 to Stealth, –1 to Speed.
3. *Trickle rain* – tracks wash, cold bites. First navigation or tracking roll at –1 die.
4. *Dry cold / heat* – resources drain faster. Mark +1 supply strain at end of leg.
5. *Shifting wind* – smoke and scent lie. Reroll one die on a weather-related check, but the GM may bank 1 SB.
6. *Omen sky* (aurora, sun-dog, three moons) – the land is listening. The GM may ask one player to answer a single question about the party’s future.

Making Camp When you stop, choose one *boon* and accept one *risk*:

- **Boon:** heal a piece of gear; clear 1 Fatigue; scout tomorrow’s weather; share a story with a road spirit (gain a *Truce Cord*).
- **Risk:** thin shelter (next weather hits harder); smoky fire (attracts prowlers); exposed approach (ambush more likely); hungry neighbors (locals or beasts appear).

A road spirit’s favour requires a small offering—a pinch of salt, a dropped coin, a whispered truth. Be polite.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord use certain shelter hollows as waystations. A renegade Sister has hidden a Hollowed in a ruined outpost; the child has not moved in weeks.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Old Roads are Class II Anchor sites—ghosts of imperial surveyors still measure the miles. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin at every milestone.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends lies at the bottom of every spring. Take it, and the water will never run dry—but the spring will remember your face.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Wilds psions are called “Stone-Listeners.” They hear the memory of old trails. Claimant chiefs pay well for their services—and dispose of those who hear too much.
- **The Ninth:** In any Wilds scene, the ninth cairn you pass in a day will be warm. Leave an offering, or the path will forget you.

Wilderness Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Cairn:** Crumble a crust at a boundary stone. Ignore the first *Bad Ground* penalty.
- **Knot the Trail:** Tie a single knot in a piece of grass at a crossing. Cancel *Doubleback* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Spring:** Whisper a dead traveler’s name into a water source. Gain +1 Effect when foraging this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the land.

Patronage & Power

In the Wilds, power flows through knowledge of the land, the ability to navigate without formal authority, and the careful cultivation of local relationships. True authority comes from understanding weather patterns, reading tracks, and maintaining the favor of both human inhabitants and the spirits of place. Those who can provide safe passage, find water in dry times, or mediate between conflicting claims hold the most influence.

For the GM: Patronage in the Wilds revolves around practical knowledge, local customs, and the ability to provide essential services like navigation, shelter, and supply. Rewards often take the form of tokens, passes, and local knowledge that can be leveraged into greater safety and efficiency. To emphasise the hexcrawl feel:

- Key 6–10 interesting hexes before the session, then use the generator to fill the rest.
- Let the party discover new routes, short cuts, and hidden lairs through successful scouting or lucky finds.
- Use the *Roads Move*, *Weather Wakes*, and *Local Resentment* clocks (from the hexcrawl procedures) to create a living, reactive wilderness—or simply let the cards speak.
- Offer Diamonds as “exploration rewards” that unlock new options (a cache token, a safe passage, a local ally).

In the Wilds, your skill is your standing, and your standing determines whether you survive or perish.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or local hunters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **prowlers or caravan guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or claimants**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Guide or warden patrol** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift or route blockage**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **war-band or territorial beast** arrives on scene.

- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wardens, war-bands, or prowlers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **weather turns/catastrophe strikes/quarantine declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Claimant chief, quartermaster, or The Stranger** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **weather shifts/blockage clears/catastrophe hits**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Wilds (Weather):** Conditions shift without warning, storms arrive early, calm turns to chaos.
- **Wilds (Navigation):** Trails reroute mid-journey, landmarks disappear, guides demand additional payment.
- **Wilds (Local Customs):** Spirits demand tribute, territorial beasts become aggressive, local laws change with the terrain.

Fast reskin palette

Forest swap dunes→deadfall, spindrift→canopy flare, prowlers→boar/wolves; water = spring/stream.

Desert swap bog→salt pan, fog→dust, shelter = overhang/wadi; water = seep/fog net.

Tundra/Ice swap dune shift→ice heave, fire→spindrift, boats→sleds; prowlers = bears/wolves.

Coast/Isles crossings = reef shelves, prowlers = seals/raiders, alarms = harbor booms; fuel = driftwood.

Swamp/Fen crossings = corduroy/log causeways, bad ground = peat crust, prowlers = gators/leeches.

Highlands crossings = cols and scree traverses, alarms = beacon chains, prowlers = cats/eagles.

Wilds — Roads and Ruins

Starting Location: A shelter hollow carved into a fallen giant’s ribcage, moss glowing faintly under starlight.

“In the Wilds, the land walks when you don’t watch it, and the roads remember who bled on them.”

In... A Shelter Hollow, a Forager Child offers a route-song. “The Bad Ground shifts,” they say. “And the weather walks behind it.”

Regional Motifs Ruin ivy, singing paths, weather as creature, stone memories.

Whispers to Offer “Cut through the Bad Ground,” “Take the relic,” “Leave the guide.”

External Clocks Threat: “Weather Wakes”; Fracture: “Roads Move”; Community: “Foragers Vanish.”

Complications Ruins reassemble; rain falls upward; the child knows tomorrow.

Anchors at Risk A caravan; a family relic.

Escalation Beat The song changes key.

Relief Sing in harmony; mark a safe path with blood and story; abandon the relic to drop Threat by one.

Terrain Stock (d20)

Roll or choose a striking detail to dress a hex.

1. Fresh ash on an old fire ring; prints circle *around* it.
2. Boundary totems toppled but re-stack themselves if watched politely.
3. Broken wagon with salt-vein crystals growing through spokes.
4. Singing culvert; echo names the boldest listener wrongly.
5. Weather bell hung in a pine; tolling swaps rain and wind.
6. Cairn with a copper coin balanced on edge; don’t breathe hard.

7. Fence of antlers pointing uphill; follow and skip one *Bad Ground*.
8. Mummified pack-beast wearing a courier’s braid; letter hums.
9. Pebble mosaic of an old levy call; stepping it summons wardens.
10. Fossil rib arch; shelter under it and dream of tomorrow’s route.
11. Abandoned hunter’s cache; choice of food or rumor, not both.
12. Mirror-puddle; shows last night’s sky whatever the hour.
13. Rope bridge made of prayer knots; one is freshly cut.
14. Scare-stakes dressed in saltcloth; something big respects them.
15. Stone with bite-marks; taste iron and remember a shortcut.
16. Old road mile-post defaced into a saint; offerings still fresh.
17. Thistle patch buzzing with coin-flies; feed them copper for safe passage.
18. Fallen giant’s footprint now a pond; frogs chant a route-song.
19. Soot writing on cliff: *Storm at Second Bell*. It’s right.
20. Hollow tree full of carved names; the newest is yours.

Lair Seeds (One-Page Crawls)

d12 quick lair hooks. Each can be a single session’s focus.

1. **Fen Clockworks** — Bog-gears turn under peat; each tooth a drowned oath.
2. **Dry River Gallery** — Petroglyphs re-arrange at dusk; wrong reading summons bramble knights.
3. **Ice-Well Vault** — Stairs drilled through permafrost; breath blooms frost-runes that answer questions badly.
4. **Sunken Forum** — Pillars knee-deep in silt; rust moths nest in the rostrum.
5. **Pilgrim Kilns** — Charcoal mounds hike on stilt roots at night; a hermit-healer bargains weather for charcoal.
6. **Hanging Salt Chapel** — White stalactites ring like bells; grave-eels coil in the font.
7. **Thorn Maze Mill** — Waterwheel turns without water; phase panthers pace the sluice.
8. **Brewer’s Hollow** — Barrels of wind; decant a gale or drink a calm.
9. **Antler Archive** — Ledger carved on horn; theft awakens the cairn-wights’ accountant.

10. **Black Lantern Mines** — Lantern-eyes nest like bats; light buys silence, darkness buys passage.
11. **Stormbone Spire** — Vertebrae tower; earth-sharks circle beneath like sharks in sand.
12. **Amber Orchard** — Trees fossilised mid-sway; trapped thunderflies grant *Weather Window* when freed.

Wilderness Bestiary

A palette of strange creatures, each with *signs* (what you notice before it sees you) and a *hook* (how to engage or avoid).

- **Earth-Sharks** — Burrow beneath loess and tundra; dorsal ridges like plowshares. *Signs*: furrows that breathe; pebbles rattle. *Hook*: lure with drumbeats or goat bells.
- **Phase Panthers** — Shadow-striped cats that step between gusts. *Signs*: paw-prints offset from themselves. *Hook*: mirrored water or bell-silver disrupts the blink.
- **Rust Moths** — Swarms that taste iron memory. *Signs*: lacework mail; pitted nails. *Hook*: feed them old keys; they ignore fresh steel.
- **Lichen-Bears** — Moss-matted ursines with rock-teeth. *Signs*: clawed bark with green scabs. *Hook*: smoke of juniper calms; salt enrages.
- **Wind Drakes** — Rib-thin sky-serpents that ride fronts. *Signs*: shed vanes; feathers like glass. *Hook*: whistle back the storm to ground them.
- **Ooze-Remnants** — Alchemical slough from an old field lab. *Signs*: boot-holes rounded smooth. *Hook*: wood ash firms them; vinegar makes them sprint.
- **Fell Harts** — Antlered shades that herd the living toward cliffs. *Signs*: hoofprints that don't compress soil. *Hook*: speak a hunter's apology while walking backward.
- **Cairn-Wights** — Stone-stack custodians; patient as frost. *Signs*: pebbles rear-ranged around your fire. *Hook*: rebuild the stack correctly; they serve until dawn.
- **Thundertusks** — Boars that store lightning in tusk-veins. *Signs*: fused sand beads; singed roots. *Hook*: ground your spear; throw shadow to draw the strike.
- **Lantern-Eyes** — Floating orbs of watchlight rumor; jealous of secrets. *Signs*: daylight in ravines at midnight. *Hook*: offer a whispered truth; they part like reeds.
- **Grave-Eels** — Burrow through barrow loam; taste names. *Signs*: sinking turf over old wars. *Hook*: sing lineage or throw false names to mislead.
- **Bramble Knights** — Empty helms grown through with thorn; patrol old borders. *Signs*: briar in boot-grease. *Hook*: present a hedge-blessing; they escort instead of impale.

Strange Finds (d10)

When you discover a hidden cache or an ancient hoard, roll or pick:

1. **Route-stones** that warm near true north.
2. **Weather-bell clapper** that tolls only for lightning.
3. **Trail-right knot** dyed in berry law; locals honour it once.
4. **Salt-vein pick** that cuts oozes like cloth.
5. **Glass feather**; break to call a wind drake for one pass.
6. **Ledger leaf** waterproofed with eel-fat; ink never runs, words drift.
7. **Thorn sigil** that bramble knights read as parley.
8. **Coin-fly cocoon**; hatch it for one honest guide to the nearest water.
9. **Bone flute** that calls earth-sharks to circle elsewhere.
10. **Lantern-eye husk**; squeeze for daylight the length of a camp prayer.

Omens & Signs

The land speaks. Use these when the party pauses or when the GM needs a portent.

Sky Signs (d8)

1. sun-dog
2. mare's tails
3. anvil cloud faces the wrong way
4. silent birds
5. far thunder without storm
6. moon with halo
7. ash scent on clear air
8. stars “shiver”

Ground Signs (d8)

1. cairn with new pebble
2. boot prints that end at rock
3. butchered game left neat
4. snapped twig at head height

5. ash under wet moss
6. ward-knot cut
7. trail beads on shrub
8. a single coin on a stone

4.31 Ykrul — “Wolf Standards, Winter Camps”

Khatun of the Ring (Elite): “The steppe remembers every oath sworn beneath its endless sky, and the wolf-standards carry the honour of clans that have outlasted empires. To lead here is to keep the old ways sharp as winter steel.”

Herd-Scout (Commoner): “The horses know the weather before it comes, and the wolves know the thoughts in a man’s heart. Best speak true and ride steady – the steppe doesn’t forgive lies or clumsy hands on the reins. An old saying: the straight road is a lie. The wise follow the bent twig.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ykrul ride the endless Violet Steppe, where the horizon drinks the sky and law lives in saddlebags. Their sacred patterns are called Kon’reh — not a written code but a living way of reading routes, debts, and exits. Every crossing has its price, every ford its weight, every feud an angle measured in horse-lengths and heartbeats. Hosts gather by the thousand, then scatter at a word; one night you share their fires, the next they test your bonds. Their banners are wolves’ teeth, their treaties braided cords, their memory longer than the rivers that cut the grass. The old folk still recite the Thirty-Six Sayings of the Road, but the wisest know the thirty-seventh is the one you learn alone, on a night when the stars blink out and the wolf does not howl.

What you notice first: The smell of horse sweat and woodsmoke. The way every rider counts hoofbeats under their breath. The silence when a stranger approaches the fire.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ride between two wolves at dusk. The space between them is a blind angle — a route with no exit, a debt with no payment.

Regional Mood: The Geometry of the Steppe

Here, the horizon is not a line — it is a question. The Ykrul measure distance in oaths, not miles. A camp is a weave of favours owed and honour satisfied. A feud is a slow equation: blood in, blood out, with interest compounded by winter. The Khagan rules not by force alone but by keeping the old patterns — the unwritten rules that govern every crossing, every treaty, every duel. Break the pattern, and the steppe itself may turn against you. Keep it, and even enemies will share their salt. The Ykrul build no monuments. They build relationships, each one a stone in an invisible cairn that stretches from the Dolmis to the Aberderrin.

Starting Location: A winter camp on the steppe edge, banners snapping in frost-bright wind as the Khagan’s fires burn in the east. A Khatun of the Ring offers a clay cup of salted tea. “The Khagan’s kin ride from the salt pan. The old sayings say the straight road is a lie. You came by the bent path — the wolf knows you. Speak your errand before the wind changes.”

Prominent NPCs of the Ykrul

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Khatun Bortai	Keeper of the Ring	Keep the clans from tearing each other apart	Her hostage strings are braided from the hair of oath-breakers.
Noyan Temur	Banner-lord of the Red Reeds	Win a winter pasture without bloodshed	He has never lost a negotiation. He has never needed to speak.
Sogata	Herd-Scout (commoner exemplar)	Read the weather before the storm	He can read a trail by the way the grass bends — and a lie by the way a rider sits.
Elder Saruul	Bone-Singer	Keep the names of the dead	She sings the names of the departed each dawn; the dead sing back.
The Dust Prince	Raider who rides the wind's lee	Amass enough salt to buy a clan	He offers escort braids for secrets, never seen from the front.
Storm-Singer Urum	Sky-Speaker	Sell weather on credit	His bills come due during the Wolf Moon.

Names of the Ykrul

Inspired by the open steppe and the deep east: guttural stops, flowing vowels, and suffixes that mark lineage or deed.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Bortai	Temur	Sogata	<i>the Grey</i>
Urum	Saruul	Khorch	<i>Red-String</i>
Khasar	Altan	Noyan	<i>the Unbuckled</i>

Mongke	Checheg	Borjigin	<i>Storm-Born</i>
Edil	Borte	Uriankhai	<i>Ash-Prow</i>
Toghrul	Orghana	Qasar	<i>the Silent</i>

(**Steppe Road/Winter Ring/Ford**) Wolf Road milepost of stacked stones with wind whining through eye-holes; winter camp ring with felt tents in horseshoe facing wind.

Spades — Places

2. **Wolf Milepost** — Stacked stones; wind whines through eye-holes. *Each stone is a treaty. Remove one, and the wind names you oath-breaker.*
3. **Remount Station** — Low corral with stamped snow and tether-posts. *The tether-posts are carved with the names of dead horses. The living ones remember.*
4. **Birch Windbreak** — Above black-earth tracks; old offerings in the bark. *The offerings are strips of wool. Each strip is a prayer for safe crossing.*
5. **Salt Pan** — Crusted white; hoof-prints like stars across the void. *The pan has a name: “The Khagan’s Mirror.” Look into it, and you see your debts.*
6. **Reed Ford** — River braids; poles mark yesterday’s safe line. *The poles shift in the night. The river’s path changes with the moon.*
7. **Trading Palisade** — Way-post with wolf-skull pennons snapping. *The skulls face outward. They watch for liars and bad weights.*
8. **Winter Camp** — Felt tents in a horseshoe facing the wind. *The open end is for guests. The closed end is for the ancestors.*
9. **Kurgan Field** — Low barrows; horse-bones bead the grass like prayer beads. *The bones were placed by a bone-singer. Each bead is a name.*
10. **Watch Kopje** — Lonely tor with signal fire-scar; the eye of the steppe. *The fire-scar is from a signal that saved a host. The smoke still smells of hope.*
- J **Pontoon Crossing** — Laced hides creak; the current speaks fast and hungry. *The hides are from horses that died crossing. Their ghosts still pull.*
- Q **Council Hollow** — Standards planted; the ground tamped like a war-drum. *The standards have ears. Speak a treason here, and every clan will know by dawn.*
- K **Khagan’s Station** — Broad ger on a timber platform; guards in silence. *The guards never blink. They are paid in salt and secrets.*
- A **Sky Steppe** — Open, wind like a voice; tracks keep pace beside you. *The tracks are not yours. They belong to the ancestors who ride with you.*

(**Host/Envoy/Rider**) Herd-scout with three ponies and six opinions; camp-mother who chooses where fires live.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Herd-Scout** — Three ponies and six opinions; the horizon as a map. *He can read a trail by the way the grass bends. He can read a lie by the way a rider sits.*
3. **Camp-Mother** — Chooses where fires live; hospitality is law. *She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.*
4. **Banner Youth** — Minding the wolves’ tooth standard; pride as duty. *The standard is older than his grandmother’s grandmother. He will die before it falls.*
5. **Salt-Broker** — Weighs promises like grain; trade as precision. *Her scales are honest—except when they aren’t. The difference is a prayer.*
6. **Remount Keeper** — String-master with a book of brands; horses as currency. *His book is written in hoof-prints. He can read a horse’s soul.*
7. **Bone-Singer** — Knows the kurgans’ proper names; death as memory. *She sings the names of the dead each dawn. The dead sing back.*
8. **Road-Judge** — Tümen scribe with seals and a patient ear. *His seals are from three empires. He uses whichever one is still valid.*
9. **Noyan Envoy** — Silver paiza, iron smile; diplomacy as a blade. *His paiza was a gift from a Khagan who is now dead. He does not mention that.*
10. **Host Captain** — The tent-wall is a map; strategy in every fold. *He can see a battle in the way smoke rises. He is usually right.*
- J **Falcon Courier** — Leather gauntlets, answers sooner than asked. *The falcon is a sleeper agent. It belongs to a different clan. The courier doesn’t know.*
- Q **Khatun of Ring** — Keeper of camp-law and hostage strings. *Her strings are braided from the hair of hostages. She knows each strand’s owner.*
- K **Khagan’s Kin** — A nephew or niece sent to bind a foedus with a look. *They have never lost a negotiation. They have never needed to speak.*
- A **Sky-Speaker** — Shaman of storms; shortcuts owe them a price. *They can call lightning—or call it off. The price is always a story.*

(Law/Weather/Feud) White squall with dry snow, lost horizons; rasputitsa turning the road to porridge; a feud spark from a name spoken wrong.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **White Squall** — Dry snow, lost horizons; navigation by instinct alone. *The snow tastes of iron. Someone is bleeding nearby.*
3. **Rasputitsa** — The road becomes porridge; wheels are lies on the earth. *The mud has a smell—old blood and older lies.*

4. **Remount Sickness** — A cough in the string; swaps get awkward, trust thinner. *The cough is a curse. The horses know who cast it.*
5. **Salt Shortage** — Meat spoils; tempers thin like winter air. *The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard.*
6. **Hostage Call** — Protocol invoked; someone must sit in the tent. *The tent has no floor. The hostage can see the earth beneath—and the bones.*
7. **Feud Spark** — A name spoken wrong reopens an old cut; blood remembers. *The name was spelled correctly. The insult was in the pause before it.*
8. **Grassfire** — Runs with the wind faster than horses; escape as a prayer. *The fire has a face. It is the face of a Khagan who burned a village.*
9. **Foedus Recall** — Treaty terms re-read; your papers disagree. *The treaty was written on both sides. The other side used a different ink.*
10. **River Break** — Ice goes; ferries don’t; crossing becomes a gamble. *The ice is still thick in the middle. The edges are lying.*
- J **Raid Shadow** — Another banner follows at a patient distance. *They are not attacking. They are waiting for you to make a mistake.*
- Q **Kurultai Call** — Camps converge; travel becomes politics. *The kurultai has a list of grievances. Your name is near the top.*
- K **Wolf Muster** — A levy raised; every road a checkpoint, every rider a judge. *The muster horn is a wolf’s skull. It sounds like a scream.*
- A **Sky Omen** — Three suns, or none; routes rewrite themselves. *The omen is a wedge of cranes flying north in winter. The sky is wrong.*

(Pass/Remount/Truce) Camp token for one night’s lawful fire and fodder; salt allotment from a named store without quarrel.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Camp Token** — One night’s lawful fire and fodder; hospitality as a right. *The token is a horsehair braid. Burn it to claim your fire.*
3. **Salt Allotment** — Draw from a named store without quarrel. *The allotment is a salt-cake. Break it in half to share.*
4. **Ford-Right** — Cross a named braid at lawful depth. *The right is a pole. Plant it in the river, and the ford will hold—once.*
5. **Remount Chit** — Swap two tired mounts for fresh. *The chit is a horse’s tooth. The remount keeper will not smile when you present it.*
6. **Escort Braid** — Two riders see you through a bad stretch. *The braid is woven from the riders’ own hair. They will die before they cut it.*

7. **Safe-Hostage** — Place or take token-kin for a truce. *The hostage is a child. The child is patient.*
8. **Paiza Tablet** — Priority on the Wolf Road and at posts. *The tablet is bronze. It is warm when your reputation is good.*
9. **Foedus Seal** — A treaty clause that trumps petty order. *The seal is a wolf’s head. Press it into wax, and the steppe listens.*
10. **Market-Green** — Trade under a banner; weapons sheathed. *The banner is a green field. No blood may be spilled beneath it.*
- J **Standard Guard** — Travel under wolf-tooth; raiders defer. *The standard is a wolf’s tooth on a pole. Raiders will bow—or die.*
- Q **Ring Audience** — The Khatun hears you alone; precedent sticks. *The audience is held at midnight. The fire is the only witness.*
- K **Khagan’s Writ** — Doors open, mouths close across the steppe. *The writ is a sheet of hammered silver. It bends, but it does not break.*
- A **Sky’s Exception** — Once, the weather ignores you (storm, whiteout, dust). *The exception is a single breath. Use it well.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/remounts/truces) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **steppe and sky** motifs—wind that speaks, horses that remember, treaties that bind across generations.

Additional Features

Hostage Strings. Every oath is secured with a **hostage string**—a token kin, retainer, or sworn ally left in the other camp. If the deal is broken, the hostage’s fate becomes the story’s next beat. (Mechanically: create a 4-segment *Hostage* clock; on breach, the clock becomes a countdown to vengeance.)

Steppe Law. Travelers are bound by **steppe law**: hospitality lasts three nights, insults last three generations. The Keeper may demand 1 SB when either law is broken.

Sky Omens. When the sky shows strange signs—mock-suns, green fire, thunder without storm—the steppe itself speaks. Once per scene, players may treat an omen as a *Diamond*, shifting Position without a roll. The GM may bank 1 SB for future weather complications.

Bowl and Board. Ykrul elders settle disputes not by shouting but by drawing two circles in the dirt: the **Bowl** for fairness, then the **Board** for routes and concessions. A successful *Wits + Lore* (or a relevant skill) roll creates a *Seasonal Concession String* at a ford, harbor, or pass. On a miss, the **Market Moot** [4] clock advances as factions argue.

The Thirty-Seven Sayings of the Road (Excerpts)

The Ykrul teach strategy not in manuals but in proverbs—each a line of play. A few of the most quoted:

Let the river freeze before you cross. — Do not rush. Let the opponent make the first move; your opening will be built on their impatience.

Borrow a corridor to trap a king. — When the enemy carves a path toward you, let it deepen. Then seal the mouth behind them.

Loot a burning house. — Strike only when the enemy is committed elsewhere.

Hide your dagger behind a smile. — Threaten one flank; strike the other.

The reed bends, the oak breaks. — Yield to overwhelming force, but do not break; preserve your core.

A distant banner casts no shadow. — A threat far away is no threat at all; control the centre.

The guest who outstays his welcome steals the host’s peace. — Allow no force, however small, to remain within your lines uncontrolled.

Count exits, not victims. — Before you move, count the ways your foe can flee. If the number is greater than zero, you have not yet won.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice near the salt pans. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the herders, trying to untie her cord from a Ykrul blood-debt.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The kurgans are Class II Anchor sites—the spirits of old Khagans bound by unfinished wergild. Saikou Ira would carry a bag of salt in each hand here.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the salt-brokers. Take it, and your store never runs dry—but the coin will reappear in the salt pan at every new moon.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ykrul psions are called “Weather-Readers.” They taste the future in the wind. Road-judges employ two—and have never trusted a verdict they didn’t hear from the sky.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ykrul camp, the ninth cup poured at a feast is for the ancestors. The wise pour eight and leave the ninth as a pause.

Ykrul Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Salt to the Wind:** Toss a pinch into the air before a long ride. Ignore the first *White Squall* penalty.
- **Knot the String:** Tie a single knot in a hostage cord. Cancel *Feud Spark* or take −1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Kurgan:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into a horse’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when raiding their clan this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bone-Singer.

Patronage & Power

In Ykrul society, power flows through the careful management of hospitality, the binding of oaths with hostages, and the ability to navigate the complex web of tribal relationships. The Khagan maintains authority through the loyalty of noyans and the respect of khatuns, while local leaders wield influence through their control of resources like salt, remounts, and safe passage. The true power lies with those who understand the ancient customs and can maintain the delicate balance between hospitality and honour.

For the GM: Patronage in Ykrul society revolves around hospitality, hostage exchanges, and the ability to command respect from hosts and courts. Rewards often take the form of tokens, treaties, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the old ways:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, braids, standards) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Use the *Bowl and Board* procedure for disputes—first fairness (Bowl), then routes and concessions (Board), then a seasonal right.
- Let rival hosts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.

In Ykrul society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you ride as guest or ghost.

Thematic SB Spend Table

- **Minor Complications (1 SB):** Exposure, Noise, Trace, Delay, Supply Strain.
- **Moderate Setbacks (2 SB):** Alarm Raised, Position Lost, Foe Appears, Gear Trouble, Lock/Barrier.
- **Serious Trouble (3 SB):** Reinforcements, Key Gear Breaks, Major Twist, Rail Tick, Condition Applied.
- **Major Turns (4+ SB):** Trap Springs, Authority Arrival, Scene Shift, Patron Omen, Narrative Pivot.

- **Region-Specific SB Options:** Steppe Law (hospitality fails, insults echo, treaties shift), Horse Culture (mounts refuse, remounts empty, riding unreliable), Sky Omens (weather shifts, signs contradict, navigation mystical).

Terrain Stock (d20)

Roll or choose a striking detail to dress a hex of the Violet Steppe.

1. Wolf milepost with fresh red thread; someone retied the law.
2. Reed ford poles lying on bank; current whispers a different depth.
3. Fallen standard tooth used as a chopping block; grooves still warm.
4. Circle of pony skulls facing east; one blinks when the wind shifts.
5. Snow trench with cudgel steps; no prints leave it.
6. Copper salt-scale hung from a birch; pans balance only under oath.
7. Hoof-bells threaded on hair; ringing calls riders – or storms.
8. Abandoned paiza shard wedged in a milestone; edges bite skin.
9. Kurgan capstone chalked with a name misspelled; feud waiting.
10. Flint knapper’s tarp half-buried; a perfect arrowhead points north.
11. Blue-fledged signal arrow stuck in frost; message in the vane.
12. Camp-sweep marks: three rings – last night was a council.
13. Wheel rut frozen like glass; a face looks up from inside.
14. Salt-brined jerky hanging from a tripod; untouched by birds.
15. River ice singing in thirds; ferryman’s pole wedged under.
16. Pony hobble-rope knotted in hostage-string pattern.
17. Cold forge dug into loess; tools wrapped in wolfskin.
18. Child’s braid-bead dropped in snow; still warm to the tongue.
19. Thorn-tether scratched with clan brands; two over-scratched.
20. Bone flute lodged in a cairn; playing it summons a road-judge.

Lair Seeds (One-Page Rides)

d12 lair hooks for the steppe.

1. **Ger of Echoes** — Empty felt walls repeat anything uttered in the Khagan’s voice once per night.
2. **Salt-Pit Shrine** — Rope winch to brine caverns; offerings are tears and horsehair.
3. **Remount Vault** — Subterranean stables under reed mats; mounts won’t leave without a tale.
4. **Kite-Maker’s Bluff** — Bone kites pinned on racks; their shadows scout for raiders.
5. **Storm-Rider’s Stone** — Pillar that hums to hooves; racing round it sets weather wagers.
6. **Frozen Court** — Ice dais in a dry riverbed; law held here counts triple until thaw.
7. **Banner Grave** — Flags planted like trees; each knows the battle it died in.
8. **String-Mother’s Yard** — Web of hostage cords; cutting one opens a secret but starts a feud.
9. **Fire-Under-Snow** — Warm vent where foals winter; spirits ask for salt-song.
10. **Quiet Palisade** — Trading post where voices fail; deals done in gesture and cut meat.
11. **Ashen Trident** — Three lightning-split birches; tie a braid to choose a road’s luck.
12. **Grey Ger** — Moves at night; inside, a camp-mother tests your hospitality the other way around.

Steppe Bestiary (Palette)

Signs and hooks for strange creatures of the Violet Steppe.

- **Steppe Manticores** — Lionine torsos, porcupine tails of bone quills. *Signs:* quills in fence-posts; ponies refuse to drink. *Hook:* play a raid-song backward; they circle to listen.
- **Dust Hulks** — Wind-packed silhouettes that rise from dunes. *Signs:* dunes “breathe”; grit sifts upward. *Hook:* spill water on their shadow; they settle for a watch.
- **Bone Kites** — Carrion birds with rune-etched pinions. *Signs:* spiral flights over kurgans. *Hook:* offer a name-stake (twig with hair) to barter silence.
- **Frost Wargs** — Blue-pelt wolves that steam cold. *Signs:* rime on tracks; breath that crackles. *Hook:* warm milk poured on ice buys one unchallenged crossing.
- **Reed Stalkers** — Long-necked marsh hunters, gait like stilts. *Signs:* pole-pocks where no ferryman walks. *Hook:* carry reeds in your mouth; they read it as truce.

- **Salt Screammers** — Pale eels in dry pans; voices like flutes. *Signs*: fissures crusted with salt frost. *Hook*: scatter ash; they coil to sing and forget to bite.

Relic & Find (d10)

When you uncover a kurgan cache or a lost hoard, roll or pick:

1. Wolf-tooth standard tip; planted, it demands silence for parley.
2. Bronze paiza half; merchants honour it as full once – then talk.
3. Salt-needle that points to the nearest brine store.
4. Frost-bitten stirrup: mount that wears it ignores ice once.
5. Braid-bead of hostage glass; melts when a string is cut nearby.
6. River-depth rod carved with safe counts for three fords.
7. Iron hoof-bell that rings for liars at council.
8. Bone-lot cup; roll it to name which feud clause applies.
9. Wind-wrung scarf; pass it round to share breath in a white squall.
10. Wolf-road tablet scrap; reads as a *Foedus Seal* to one clerk.

Complication Twists (d8)

When a travel complication arises, roll or choose a twist that deepens the story.

1. *White Squall* reveals a remount vault’s smoke hole; entering angers reed stalkers.
2. *Rasputitsa* exposes kurgan stones; riding around them starts a name-claim.
3. *Feud Spark* was staged by a salt-broker; paying in *Salt Allotment* unmasks them.
4. *Hostage Call* is for a *Safe-Hostage* you already carry – by another name.
5. *Grassfire* runs uphill toward a council hollow; smoke votes before riders do.
6. *Foedus Recall* cites a river you crossed yesterday – now it flows the other way.
7. *Raid Shadow* is your own tracks, mirrored by sky omens; choose which you admit.
8. *Kurultai Call* stacks councils; words spoken in one bind you in the other.

4.32 Zakov — “Salt & Serpent”

Salt Prince (Elite): “The tide here keeps better ledgers than any scribe, and the reefs remember every secret whispered above their depths. Power flows like the currents – those who understand them rule the waves.”

Dock-Rat (Commoner): “The sewers and the sea both carry what folks want to forget, but they also remember everything. Best keep your business above water and your enemies guessing which dock you’ll use next. The Salt Prince’s crown floats, and the tide pulls for anyone with a sharp knife and a sharper tongue.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Zakov is the pirate-city of the Dolmis coast, where tides trade secrets and knives settle debts. Its streets are piers, its courts are taverns, and its rulers are whoever the Syndicates fear most this season. The Salt Prince claims the throne, but the real power ebbs and flows with the tide—and the tide remembers everything. Here, every manifest is a lie, every harbor a doorstep to a dozen conspiracies, and every fog-light a lure or a warning. The city breathes with the sea: at low tide, secrets exposed; at flood, the drowned walk the Sunken Quarter and knock on doors that should be locked. Zakov is not a place you visit. It is a place you survive—or rule.

What you notice first: The smell of brine and tar. The constant slap of water against stone. The way every tavern has a door that leads to a different dock—and every dock has a name that changes with the tide.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never take a coin that tastes of brine. The Serpent’s Mark is not a blessing. It is a debt that drowns.

Regional Mood: Salt and Serpent

Here, the sea is not a border—it is a landlord. Zakov rose from the wreckage of a sunken empire, and every stone is a salvage claim. The Salt Prince rules from a throne of driftwood and extortion, but the real lords are the Syndicate factors who own the docks, the eel-cults that whisper from the sewers, and the fae courts that launder their influence through tide-bargains. Ships arrive with goods no customs post will name, and depart with cargoes no manifest will show. The city’s law is the Tide Clock: low water for killing, flood water for trading, slack for negotiation. Break the rhythm, and the city will break you.

Starting Location: A smuggler’s gate built into the seawall, its iron mouth crusted with barnacles and secrets. The gatekeeper is a one-eyed woman who accepts payment in stories. Behind her, the Dregs Quarter stretches on stilts into the harbor, and the Salt Prince’s flagship, the *Red Wake*, rides at anchor off the Iron Pier. “The levy rises tonight,” the gatekeeper says, spitting into the water. “Every ship pays, or every ship burns. You look like the burning type. Good. The Prince needs a reminder that the tide turns for everyone.”

Prominent NPCs of Zakov

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Salt Prince Lev	Nominal ruler of Zakov	Keep the syndicates from tearing the city apart	His crown is a circlet of driftwood; he has never taken it off.
Pirate Queen Mila	Rules the Shallows with charm and cutlass	Carve out a kingdom free of the Salt Prince’s levies	Her cutlass was her grandmother’s; the grandmother was also a queen.
Kraken’s Tongue	Tide-oracle who speaks in riddles	Survive another season without being sacrificed to the deep	She lives in a bell tower that only exists at high tide; the bell does not ring.
Dock-Master Olena	Syndicate factor who “loses” ships	Own the waterfront, one debtor at a time	Her ledger has a secret page that is a map of debtors’ bones.
The Reckoner	Broker of cosmic debts (Maelstraeus)	Collect interest on every contract signed in Zakov	His coin appears in the pocket of the opposing counsel the next day.
The Salt-Bitten Angel	Cursed messenger (Malachai)	Offer cruel bargains that always leave a scar	A silver coin that tastes of brine circulates among the smugglers; take it, and your cargo always passes inspection.

Names of Zakov

Inspired by the Black Sea and Odessa: Slavic, Turkic, and Greek inflections, with nick-names that stick like barnacles.

First (Male)	Names	First Names (Fe- male)	Surnames	Epithets
Lev		Mila	Voloshyn	<i>the Grey</i>
Dmytro		Olena	Bondarenko	<i>Tide-Foot</i>
Sarkis		Anush	Torosyan	<i>the Unpaid</i>
Kostya		Zoya	Morozov	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Ruslan		Nadia	Kravchenko	<i>Ash-Prow</i>
Taras		Halyna	Shevchenko	<i>the Silent</i>

(Harbor/Bolt-hole/Black Market) Salt-cracked wharf where tide brings back what law forgets; Bone-yard beach with wrecks and corpses in kelp; Smuggler’s Gate behind the Fish Market.

Spades — Places

2. **Salt Wharf** — Cracked and crumbling; the tide brings back what law forgets. *The wharf has a memory. It remembers every cargo that passed—and every captain that didn’t.*
 3. **Bone-Yard Beach** — Wrecks and corpses tangled in kelp and rope. *The bones are from three empires. They shift at high tide to form new constellations.*
 4. **Smuggler’s Gate** — An alley behind the Fish Market; always unlocked, always watched. *The lock is a riddle. The answer changes with the moon.*
 5. **The Shallows** — A reef-ridden cut only locals dare; navigation as survival. *The reef has a name: the Serpent’s Spine. It grows longer each year.*
 6. **Dregs Quarter** — Shanties on stilts; boats tied to doorframes like pets. *The stilts are whale ribs. The quarter rises and falls with the tide—and the mood.*
 7. **Iron Pier** — Gangplank to the *Red Wake*, the corsair flagship; power as a vessel. *The ship was a slaver once. It still smells of chains and salt.*
 8. **Crow’s Roost** — A tavern built into the hull of a beached galleon; the past as the present. *The hull was a prize from a war that ended forty years ago. The crew who took it still drink there.*
 9. **Black Bazaar** — Tents under tarps; goods that scream if you listen. *The scream is not pain. It is a warning.*
 10. **Salt Maze** — Marsh paths only the lost know; confusion as protection. *The maze was a graveyard. The dead rearranged the hedges.*
- J **Sunken Quarter** — Half the city is underwater at high tide; wealth as depth. *The flooded houses have air pockets. People still live there—damply.*

Q Crimson Docks — Contracts signed in blood; commerce as violence. *The blood is not always the signatory’s. The docks do not care.*

K Anchorhead — A floating fortress of the Pirate Syndicate; law as an anchor. *The fortress is built from the hulls of seized ships. You can hear the captains weeping in the timbers.*

A Serpent’s Spine — A reef pass to the city’s secret heart; danger as a gateway. *The pass is a submerged arch. Swim through, and the city shows you its true face—once.*

(Syndicate/Corsair/Fence) Dock-rat pickpocket with a map tattoo and no fear; a fence dealing in stolen names and secondhand loyalties.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Dock-Rat** — Pickpocket with a map tattoo and no fear; the street as education. *His tattoo is of the Sunken Quarter at low tide. The buildings are upside down.*

3. **Fence** — Deals in stolen names and secondhand loyalties; trust as currency. *Her ledger is written in disappearing ink. She is the only one who knows the antidote.*

4. **Tavern-Keeper** — Remembers every face—and sells the list; hospitality as a trap. *His memory is a curse from a fae court. He cannot forget—and he cannot stop talking.*

5. **Corsair Lieutenant** — A letter of marque signed in blood; authority as paper. *The letter is stained with a thumbprint. The thumb is still attached to the signatory.*

6. **Dock-Master** — “Loses” ships that owe the Syndicate; bureaucracy as a weapon. *His ledger has a secret page. The page is a map of debtor’s bones.*

7. **Smuggler Captain** — A false manifest and a quicker blade; honesty as a liability. *She names her boats after dead lovers. The current boat is named “Mistake.”*

8. **Poison-Tongue** — Trades secrets like coin; words as blades. *His tongue is forked—not by birth, but by a curse. He can speak two truths at once.*

9. **Exiled Admiral** — Runs a black-market shipyard; rank as a resource. *Her flag is a torn imperial pennant. She keeps it to remind herself why she left.*

10. **Pirate Queen** — Rules the Shallows with charm and cutlass; beauty as power. *Her cutlass was her grandmother’s. The grandmother was also a queen.*

J Silent Syndicate — No names, just favors and faces; anonymity as strength. *Their messenger is a child with no tongue. She writes in the air with smoke.*

Q Kraken’s Tongue — An oracle who speaks in riddles and tides; the future as a mystery. *She lives in a bell tower that only exists at high tide. The bell does not ring.*

K Salt Prince — The nominal ruler; real power in the shadows; a crown as a mask. *His crown is a circlet of driftwood. He has never taken it off.*

A **Drowned Admiral** — A legend says he still gives orders from the deep; death as command. *His orders arrive in bottles. The bottles are corked with finger bones.*

(Betrayal/Storm/Syndicate Feud) The tide turns early—your ship is now ashore on the wrong side; a rival syndicate burns a warehouse with your goods inside.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Tide Shift** — Turns early; your ship is now ashore on the wrong side. *The tide stole a day. Your alibi is now a lie.*
 3. **Warehouse Fire** — A rival syndicate burns it; your goods are inside. *The fire is green. It burns paper and wood—and secrets.*
 4. **Cursed Cargo** — Something in the hold is *watching*; cargo as a curse. *The cargo is a mirror. The reflection is not yours.*
 5. **Storm Warning** — Ships flee, prices soar, lawmen vanish. *The storm has a name. It is the name of a captain who swore revenge.*
 6. **Double-Cross** — You are holding a fake shipment and real enemies. *The fake shipment is real. The real shipment is a trap.*
 7. **Prince’s Levy** — Every ship pays tithe or gets sunk; tax as a threat. *The levy collector wears a mask. The mask is the face of a dead admiral.*
 8. **Plague Ship** — Quarantine flags are ignored; sickness spreads. *The plague is a cough that speaks the name of who infected you.*
 9. **Blood Feud** — Erupts between pirate crews; collateral damage mounts. *The feud began over a stolen duck. The duck is still alive.*
 10. **Kraken Rising** — Reefs shift, ships vanish, sailors scream. *The kraken is not a monster. It is a debt that has grown teeth.*
- J **Voided Contract** — Your protection now means nothing. *The contract was written on shark skin. It dissolved in salt water.*
- Q **Syndicate Split** — Zakov becomes a warzone overnight. *The split was orchestrated by a third party. You are the third party.*
- K **Naval Blockade** — No ships in or out without a fight. *The blockade is a fae illusion. The ships are real.*
- A **Tide Forgets** — Half the city is cut off, drowning in secrets. *The water is warm. The drowned are not dead—they are waiting.*

(Pass/Contract/Stolen Goods) A smuggler’s token to pass a checkpoint unseen; a forged manifest that makes your cargo “clean.”

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Smuggler’s Token** — Pass one checkpoint unseen; stealth as paper. *The token is a dried eel skin. Show it, and the guards will not see you—or will pretend not to.*
3. **Forged Manifest** — Your cargo is now “clean”; truth as forgery. *The manifest is a leaf from a salt-cured book. The ink reads differently in moonlight.*
4. **Safe Berth** — Bone-yard; no questions, no law; sanctuary as a wreck. *The berth is a beached ship. Its captain still lives below decks—and does not age.*
5. **Corsair’s Charter** — Raid with impunity for one moon; violence as a license. *The charter is a whip. Crack it, and the Syndicate will answer—or flog you.*
6. **Prince’s Writ** — Levies cannot touch you (yet); authority as a delay. *The writ is a feather. The Salt Prince’s signature is a claw mark.*
7. **Black Ledger** — Names, debts, and where they sleep; knowledge as power. *The ledger is a skull. Read the names, and the skull will whisper their secrets.*
8. **Salvage Rights** — A named wreck; first claim, no questions. *The wreck is a ghost ship. The ghost is the original owner.*
9. **Lighthouse Key** — Stolen; redirect ships where you will. *The key is a tuning fork. Strike it, and the lighthouse will lie for you.*
10. **Debt-Marker** — The Syndicate owes you a favor; obligation as an asset. *The marker is a coin. The Syndicate’s symbol is worn smooth—by regret.*
- J **Queen’s Blessing** — Safe passage through the Shallows; charm as protection. *The blessing is a kiss. The Pirate Queen’s lips taste of salt and blood.*
- Q **Kraken’s Favor** — The tides part for your ship, once; nature as an ally. *The favor is a tentacle wrung dry. When you need it, soak it in seawater.*
- K **Prince’s Coin** — Bribe any official, silence any witness. *The coin is a finger bone. The official who takes it will not speak—or not listen.*
- A **Serpent’s Mark** — The reef itself will guide you home; danger as a guide. *The mark is a scar on your palm. The reef will cut you—but it will also open.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/contracts/goods) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **salt and serpent** motifs—tides that remember, reefs that shift, the deep that listens.

Additional Features

- **Tide Clock:** Scenes run on a four-segment **Tide Clock**. Each advance shifts Position: *Low tide* reveals hidden wrecks and bolt-holes; *Flood tide* drowns streets and seals doors. When the Clock turns, the Keeper may demand 1 SB tied to the waters.
- **Syndicate Debt:** Every deal leaves a mark. Track a single **Debt** value (0–3). At 3, the Syndicate calls it in: a betrayal, a levy, an unwanted escort. Clear 1 Debt by paying a Diamond or sacrificing a useful contact.
- **Whispers Deep:** Rumors carry teeth. When characters openly boast, bargain, or betray, roll 1d6: 1–3, Whispers spread, increasing SB generation; 4–6, Whispers favor the PCs, lowering suspicion until the tide turns.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in the Sunken Quarter. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the eel-cults, trying to untie her cord from the Salt Prince’s ledger.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Serpent’s Spine is a Class II Anchor site—the bound spirit of a drowned admiral. Saikou Ira would trade his silver mirror for a single reef chart.
- **The Salt-Bitten Angel (Malachai):** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the smugglers. Take it, and your cargo always passes inspection—but the coin will taste of brine every time you touch it, and the Angel will ask for a favour before the next full moon.
- **The Reckoner (Maelstraeus):** The Crimson Docks keep a ledger signed in salt water; those who borrow from the Reckoner find that their interest compounds with every tide. A captain who defaults may wake to find their ship’s name struck from all records, as if it had never sailed.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Zakov psions are called “Tide-Readers.” They taste the future in the salt. The Pirate Queen employs two—and has never trusted a forecast that didn’t cost blood.
- **The Ninth:** In any Zakov scene, the ninth ship to enter the harbor in a tide will be claimed by the reef. The wise wait for the tenth—or pay a name to the Kraken’s Tongue.

Zakov Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Tide:** Toss a crust into the water before a voyage. Ignore the first *Tide Shift* penalty.
- **Knot the Manifest:** Tie a single knot in a corner of your cargo list. Cancel *Voided Contract* or take –1 die on your next customs check (your choice).

- **Name to the Reef:** Whisper a dead captain’s name into the Serpent’s Spine. Gain +1 Effect when navigating the Shallows this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Kraken’s Tongue.

Patronage & Power

In Zakov, power flows through the control of smuggling routes, the management of syndicate debts, and the ability to navigate the complex web of pirate politics. The Salt Prince maintains nominal authority, but real power lies with those who control the tides, the reefs, and the flow of information through the city’s taverns and black markets. The true authorities are those who can provide safe passage, protect cargoes, and mediate between competing syndicates.

For the GM: Patronage in Zakov revolves around smuggling rights, safe harbors, and the ability to provide protection from both legal and illegal authorities. Rewards often take the form of tokens, charters, and safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the city’s fluid power:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, manifests, keys) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival syndicates issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the docks, taverns, and smuggling routes as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of custom and connections determines success.

In Zakov, your reputation is your wealth, and your wealth determines whether you rule the waves or feed the fishes.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **syndicate enforcers** or **dock guards**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **pirates** or **tavern patrons**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **fence networks**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Dock-master** or **corsair lieutenant** becomes aware and begins responding.

- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **tide shift** or **syndicate patrol**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival syndicate** or **pirate crew** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **syndicate enforcers**, **pirate crews**, or **naval forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided**/storm hits/syndicate splits.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1**/**Harm 1**/**Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Salt Prince**, **Pirate Queen**, or **Drowned Admiral** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **tide shifts**/storm hits/blockade imposed.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears**/blessing lost/curse manifests.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Zakov (Tide Power):** Water levels change without warning, ships become stranded or flooded, tidal currents shift direction.
- **Zakov (Syndicate Politics):** Protection money demands increase, rival factions make conflicting demands, contracts are voided mid-deal.
- **Zakov (Pirate Culture):** Ships are commandeered, crews mutiny, pirate codes are enforced with violence.

Zakov — Salt and Serpent

Starting Location: A smuggler’s gate built into the seawall, its iron mouth crusted with barnacles and secrets.

“In Zakov, the sea remembers its debts, and every tide drags a name to pay.”

In... A Smuggler’s Gate, a Fence offers a forged manifest. “The Salt Prince’s levy rises,” they say. “And the tide forgets who paid.”

Regional Motifs Salt levies, river smugglers, eel cults, threshold markets.

Whispers to Offer “Take a bribe,” “Change the manifest,” “Drown the witness.”

External Clocks Threat: “Levy Teeth”; Community: “Smuggler War”; Anchor: “Gate Truce.”

Complications Eels spell names; brine coins multiply; gates open to water.

Anchors at Risk A dockside aunt; a tide-warden.

Escalation Beat The manifest adds the party’s cargo.

Relief Pay the levy in kind; throw the coin-chain back; swear the Gate to a new keeper.

City Operating System (Fast Play)

Tide-State (4) Track a **Tide Clock** (Low → Flood → Slack → Ebb). At each shift:

- change **Position**: Low (+Infiltration), Flood (-Mobility), Slack (+Deals), Ebb (+Getaway).
- Keeper may bank 1 SB tied to *water, rot, or rumor*.

Heat & Debt Track **Heat** (0–4) and **Debt** (0–3) citywide.

- *Heat* rises on noisy jobs; at 4, a *Syndicate Split* tick or *Naval Blockade* rumor triggers.
- *Debt* rises when you stiff a faction; at 3, a creditor picks the next scene’s complication.

Crew Playbooks (pick one tag) *Cutters* (+Effect on coercion at Crimson Docks); *Ghosts* (ignore first Tide penalty each job); *Lighters* (cargo swaps create 1 **Forged Manifest** per session); *Lanterns* (fae bargains count as Diamonds once/session).

Signal, Cipher, & Circuitry

Harbor Flash (d6 quick comms) 1 one-lantern (safe) 2 two-lantern (watch) 3 red rag (fire) 4 black gull (hit) 5 three knocks (meet) 6 eel-twine (fae eyes)

Dock Cant (micro-phrases) “wet ledger” = bribe; “green rope” = cursed cargo; “white rain” = blockade rumor; “dead wake” = tail on you.

Shadow-Net Each *Crow’s Roost*/tavern can host one **Cache**: 3 rumors total; *spend* 1 rumor to bump Position on info-gathering. When emptied, add +1 **Heat**.

The Fae Leak

Saltbound Rules Fae cannot *enter* a circle salted with **tidewater salt**, but can *bargain* across it. Breaking circle = 1 SB and a personal *Mark*.

Eel Court Wharf-spirits (eel-hooded) adjudicate vows “where water hears.” Presenting a **Serpent’s Mark** lets you reroute a single clause in a contract once.

Drowned Names Names thrown from *Bone-Yard Beach* return as *Echo Debtors*. Cash one to erase 1 **Debt**—but the name occasionally speaks from your mouth.

Heist Skeletons (Plug & Play)

The Manifest Swap (3 beats) **Beat 1:** *Entry* (Smuggler’s Gate or Sunken Quarter); on miss, *Tide Shift*. **Beat 2:** *Edit* (swap bill at Dock-Master); spend **Forged Manifest** to auto-pass. **Beat 3:** *Exit* (Shallows); fail = *Cursed Cargo* wakes.

Anchorhead Skim (4 beats) **Case** a ledger → **Turn** a clerk → **Lift** a page → **Ghost** on the Iron Pier. Any alarm = *Prince’s Levy* this scene.

Syndicate Play (Mini-Game)

Stacks & Faces Pick a patron *Stack* each arc: **Red Wake** (muscle), **Silent Syndicate** (intel), **Salt Prince** (papers). During downtime, exchange *Faces* (favors) for one of: reduce **Heat** by 1; clear 1 **Debt**; mint one **Black Ledger** page (one-use leverage on any named).

War Track (0–6) Each conflicting job advances **War**; at 3, *Blood Feud*; at 6, *Syndicate Split*. Reset if PCs deliver a **Queen’s Blessing** or sacrifice a crew asset.

Urban Terrain & Glitches

Glitch Table (fae-punk fuzz, d8) 1 door opens to water 2 lantern whispers your alias 3 rope grows kelp 4 coin tastes like brine and lies 5 footprints go opposite 6 eel writes your name 7 reef sound indoors 8 tide remembers a promise you didn’t make

Zones (quick tags) *Dregs*: +Stealth, -Status; *Crimson*: +Force, -Subtle; *Sunken*: +Weird, -Mobility; *Salt Maze*: +Escape, -Clarity.

NPC Templates

Kraken’s Tongue (Oracle) *Wants:* Tribute in secrets. *Leverage:* once/session convert a **Club** to a **Diamond**. *Cost:* forget a friend’s face for a night.

Dock-Master Briga *Wants:* A rival’s ledger singe. *Leverage:* “lose” any hull for a day. *Cost:* your real name in her book.

Pirate Queen Mael *Wants:* A tide-warden compromised. *Leverage:* **Queen’s Blessing**. *Cost:* carry her mark where it shows.

Contraband & Curses

Hot List (d6) 1 saint-glass (screams when lied to) 2 eel-ink (writes back) 3 tide-bell (rings at wrong hour) 4 serpent charts (reef moves for bearer) 5 name-wine (drink a memory) 6 drowned coins (buy help, cost breath)

Tagging Cargo Each illicit lot has 1 *Tag*: **Watching, Hungry, Bound, Cold**. Tag can be “disarmed” by the right shrine/fee/contact.

Cross-Region Conversions

- **Theona:** *Smuggler’s Token* counts as *Hawthorn Pass* if bells play eight; a ninth sound voids both.
- **Viterrra:** *Prince’s Writ* can masquerade as *Customs Seal* for one audit before *Audit Freeze* ticks.
- **Ubral:** *Black Ledger* page buys one night of *Guest-Token*—if read aloud at Wergild Ford.
- **Vhasia:** *Lighthouse Key* spoofs a beacon on *Beacon Crown*/King’s High Road ferries once.
- **Valewood:** *Serpent’s Mark* = one-scene *Way-Cord* if dipped in Moon-Cistern.
- **Ways Between:** A complete *Forged Manifest* recited at a *Threshold Arch* becomes a *Passage Token*.

Clocks & Pressures

Levy Teeth (6) 1–2: Quayside “inspections” 3–4: Tithe brigades 5: Fire at the wrong warehouse 6: Floating gallows at Anchorhead.

Smuggler War (6) 1–2: Protection doubled 3–4: Routes trapped 5: Crews defect 6: Open water gunwales—everyone draws steel.

Gate Truce (4) 1: Coins tied on rope 2–3: Gate stays “neutral” 4: New Keeper named; reroute *Tide Clock* once/session.

Score Seeds

- **The Eel That Spoke:** A *Cursed Cargo* eel whispers court gossip from Thepyrgos; bottle it before *Syndicate Split*.
- **Red Wake’s Shadow:** Lift a *Black Ledger* page naming the Salt Prince’s heir; payment is *Prince’s Coin*—and a knife in the dark.
- **Lighthouse Down:** Swap the *Lighthouse Key* during a storm; success grants *Kraken’s Favor*, fail triggers *Naval Blockade*.

Designer Hooks (Optional)

Reefburn When you voluntarily take *Heat* to make a daring move, mark *Reefburn*. Once per session, spend *Reefburn* to treat the *Serpent’s Spine* as a safe exit regardless of tide—something else pays the price later.

Name-Mask Craft a single-scene alias with eel-ink; while worn, your **Heat** ticks to the mask, not you. If the mask “dies,” transfer 1 **Debt** to the faction who owned the name you stole.

Harbor Homage Sites & Lairs (drop-in districts)

- **Chain-Gate Teeth** — Twin boom-chains scarred by ramming hulks; oiled winches sing secrets if fed brine coins.
- **Gallows" Net** — Web of rigging strung over a tide-pool court; verdicts lowered on block-and-tackle.
- **Coinsink Stairs** — Weed-slick steps to a shrine that only counts offerings thrown blind.
- **Red Wake’s Cradle** — Drydock carved into a wreck’s ribs; timbers remember mutinies and whisper them back at night.
- **Keelhouse Scriptorium** — Sailmakers who stitch clauses into canvas; a mainsail can carry a contract farther than a courier.
- **Eel-Bell Court** — Tide-bells toll wrong hours; each clang grants sanctuary until the next wave touches your boots.
- **Smokespine** — Stack-maze where tar-fires never die; a breath of it makes lies taste like rope.
- **Seven-Anchor Yard** — Museum of seized anchors; the biggest still drags in storms, pulling rumors with it.

Urban Bestiary (palette)

- **Brine Wraiths** — Drowned debtors that cling like wet canvas. *Signs:* coins stack themselves; ropes unknot. *Hook:* return a name to Bone-Yard and they carry one whisper for you.

- **Reef Serpents** — Kelp-maned constrictors nesting in pilings. *Signs:* barnacles spell spirals; gulls won’t land. *Hook:* beat a net like a drum; they follow the rhythm, not the blood.
- **Tar Gulls** — Oil-dripped scavengers that trade trinkets for shine. *Signs:* black feathers on white foam. *Hook:* flash a mirror; they’ll fetch what you picture—once.
- **Ledger Crabs** — Carapaces etched with accounts; they rearrange ledgers in their sleep. *Hook:* feed them wormwood; they “forget” one debt for a tide.
- **Knot-Hags** — Wharf spirits that live in snarls; they tangle plans and lines equally. *Hook:* cut a sacrificial coil; they unknot one problem and braid another.
- **Lampfishers** — Tall, mask-eyed things seen under grates in Slack; they love secrets heavier than gold.

Dock Stock (d20 quick)

- 1 Tar bucket still warm; prints lead both directions.
- 2 Three-lantern code lit wrong; fourth is a watcher.
- 3 Rope with twelve splices; one is a message in sailor’s braid.
- 4 Crate labeled “salt”—full of sand and a single black coin.
- 5 Rust-red wake stain; no ship left that color.
- 6 Drift altar of bottle-glass; one bottle whispers back.
- 7 Bilge-water map sketched in mildew; only visible at ebb.
- 8 Hook with wedding ring; bent outward.
- 9 Ledger page soggy but legible; last line adds your cargo.
- 10 Eel skin pennon; points to the Serpent’s Spine when wet.
- 11 Tar handprint too large for any sailor; points toward Smuggler’s Gate.
- 12 Splinters arranged like teeth; bite if pocketed.
- 13 Tide-clock with missing hand; still keeps perfect Slack.
- 14 Harbour rat wearing a thread collar with a sigil bead.
- 15 Net weights stacked as a little gallows.
- 16 Driftwood idol with a knife in it; blood’s fresh, wood is dry.
- 17 Copper nail stamped with a crown you don’t recognize.
- 18 Coil of rope tied in a noose-knot that won’t tighten on liars.
- 19 Shells arranged as a charter seal; one is a listening ear.
- 20 Barnacle rosary; counting it makes footsteps pass you by.

Lair Seeds (d12 one-night jobs)

1. **The Net-Queen’s Loft** — A rigging den where favors are measured in fathoms.
2. **Ink-Cellar** — Eel-ink vats below a printshop; the walls remember every name printed.
3. **Deadwake Chapel** — Floods on Slack; boatmen marry their knives here.
4. **Chainman’s Hostel** — Beds locked with anchor chain; rent is paid in confessions.
5. **Serpent Choir** — Reef tunnel; the surf sings clauses backwards.

6. **Gull-Tower** — Pigeon roost gone feral; messages shredded unless fed offal.
7. **Copperbone Yard** — Scrapyard ships with copper ribs; sparks start rumors.
8. **Salt-Judge’s Dock** — A retired warden tries cases for fishers at dawn bell.
9. **Mask Market** — One aisle where faces are rented for a tide.
10. **Weeping Winch** — Cranes that leak brine on liars; useful, hated.
11. **The Quiet Slip** — Sound dies; perfect for handoffs, bad for warnings.
12. **Eel-Kiln** — Smokehouse that preserves more than fish; memories steep in brine.

Relics & Finds (d10)

- 1 Tide-compass that points to Slack, not north.
- 2 Reef tooth key; opens any lighthouse once.
- 3 Brine-ink quill; contracts signed with it cannot be read aloud.
- 4 Salt prince’s cufflink; bribes one guard, insults one captain.
- 5 Gaff with a prayer cut along the shaft; lifts curses, scars users.
- 6 Tarred ledger strap; binding a book with it hides one page from audits.
- 7 Barnacle brooch; pins a lie to someone else for a scene.
- 8 Foghorn reed; blown softly, turns footsteps to surf-noise.
- 9 Sea-glass seal; impresses a *Forged Manifest* as genuine once.
- 10 Eel-scale veil; wear it to be unseen by anything reflected in water.

Complication Twists (d8)

1. *Tide Shift* reveals a smugglers’ stair *and* floods the only exit behind you.
2. *Warehouse Fire* was lit with rain; flames don’t spread—smoke writes names.
3. *Double-Cross* includes your own counterfeit mark; someone sold your alias.
4. *Prince’s Levy* is collected by a syndicate impostor; paying sparks a *Blood Feud*.
5. *Plague Ship* flies false flags; the plague is in the cargo, not the crew.
6. *Voided Contract* cites a clause only the *Kraken’s Tongue* would know.
7. *Naval Blockade* uses fae buoys; they drift toward *Forged Manifest* holders.
8. *Tide Forgets* empties a canal and exposes a gallows with a still-kicking shadow.

Mini-Procedures (quick harbor play)

Cut a Wake When you need a clean exit through the Shallows, choose two and pay their costs:

- **Speed:** spend 1 *Remount Hire* equivalent (oars/crew) or mark *Heat*+1.
- **Silence:** leave a *Cache* rumor at a tavern; GM banks 1 SB.
- **Cover:** light a false beacon; start *Levy Teeth*+1.

Rope Court To settle a dispute without steel, each party knots a clause in one rope. Roll off; winner keeps their clause, loser’s knot is cut and their stake is forfeit. Spending **Serpent’s Mark** lets you retie one knot mid-judgment.

Boss Hooks (harbor crowns)

- **Mist-Baroness** — Controls the fog-candles; sells Slack on credit, calls it in on flood.
- **Anchor Virtue** — Exiled admiral preaching a stricter pirate code; her crews don’t drink on duty and never drown a debtor.
- **The Red Notary** — Tattoos charters into skin; burn him and an entire fleet loses papers.
- **Lord of Eels** — Fae broker in a salt circle; offers memory-for-manifest swaps at moonrise.

Extra Score Seeds

- **The Rope Court Heist** — Replace a clause-knot before dawn judgment; success flips *Prince’s Levy* to your rival.
- **Fog-Candle Run** — Steal three fog-candles from the Mist-Baroness; each lit scene rerolls the *Tide Clock*.
- **Drowned Name Auction** — Bid at Bone-Yard for a name that erases *Debt*; every bidder speaks from someone else’s mouth.

4.32.1 Politics of the Mortal Realms

Power in Fate’s Edge is transactional, territorial, and personal. Every Patron, every city-state, every clan has teeth. Characters do not merely travel through the world—they collide with the systems that run it.

Patronage and Power Dynamics

Patrons grant Rites and miracles, but demand service, obedience to theme, or the slow gravity of Corruption and Obligation. Runekeepers, Cantors, and Invokers navigate the politics of the divine as surely as nobles do on mortal thrones.

Rivalries are explicit:

- Malachai vs. Oath of Flame & Light: cursed blessing against purifying vow.
- Aveh vs. Varnek Karn: storm-born freedom against cosmic accounting.
- Inquisitor Prime vs. Outsider Patrons: zealotry against the arcane.

Allying with one Patron often earns the enmity of another. A boon is never free; the world notices who you serve.

Regional Governance and Conflict

Each realm runs by its own rules. To take power, keep power, or even survive, characters must learn how that region governs.

Vhasia: fractured monarchy, duelling claimants, and the Chevauchée as political warfare.

Vilikari: Utaran law and steppe clan law—a case can be won in one court and lost in the other.

Aeler Holds: guilds, lineages, and territorial rights; justice measured in stone, steel, and precedent.

Merchant Republics: Kahfagia, Silkstrand, and Thepyrgos ruled by coin-houses and guild votes.

Ykrul, Linn, Ubral: clan justice, blood-price, guest-right, and the Thing or the Moot.

Theocracy: Ecktoria’s Everflame and the Valewood Courts where scripture is law.

Politics means charters, hostage treaties, levies, blood feuds, Synod judgments, and the quiet power of written law.

Institutional Power

Thrones are not the only engines of authority.

- Guilds control crafts, trade, and representation.
- Mercenary companies make or break wars (Black Banners, Condotta).

- Legal systems vary wildly: Utaran Code, Aeler Measure, Hedge-Law, Synods.
- Magical colleges and Runekeeper orders police the arcane.

A crown can be ignored; a guild charter cannot.

Resource Control and Economic Leverage

Salt, iron, grain, stone, glass, dye, and wine decide who rises and who starves. Control of bridges, ferries, straits, and toll rights is as valuable as any army. A dragon hoards gold. A duke hoards trade routes.

Social Currency and Reputation

Names have weight. Honour, geasa, rescue debts, hostage treaties, and guest-right shape diplomacy as much as swords. Fame attracts allies—and rivals. A single broken oath can change a kingdom’s fate.

In Summary. Characters do not merely slay monsters. They enter the machinery of power: Patrons, guilds, courts, clans, and crowns. Every choice matters. Every consequence echoes.

Chapter 5

Resource Management

5.1 Introduction

Resource Management in **Fate's Edge** focuses on tracking the tangible and intangible assets that enable character actions while creating narrative tension. Rather than micromanaging every item, the system uses abstract clocks and conditions that trigger when dramatically appropriate. This keeps the focus on story consequences rather than bookkeeping.

5.2 Supply Clock

The Supply Clock is a shared condition for the entire party, representing food, water, ammunition, and basic gear. It tracks the group's overall readiness for extended endeavors.

5.2.1 Supply States

Table 5.1: Supply Clock States

State	Effect
Full Supply (0 segments)	The party is well-equipped and prepared. No penalties.
Low Supply (2 segments)	Minor narrative complications: bland food, damaged arrows, thinning waterskins, worn gear.
Dangerously Low (3 segments)	Each character gains Fatigue 1 due to exhaustion and deprivation.
Out of Supply (4 segments)	Severe penalties apply; characters face starvation, dehydration, and failing gear with significant mechanical consequences.

5.2.2 Filling the Supply Clock

The Supply Clock advances under the following circumstances:

- Harsh travel conditions or lost pack animals (GM fiat).
- GM spends 2+ **Story Beats (SB)** to represent resource depletion.
- The party chooses to travel light for speed or stealth advantages.
- Failed foraging or resource-gathering attempts.

5.2.3 Emptying the Supply Clock

The Supply Clock can be reduced through:

- Reaching civilisation or safe haven resets to **Full Supply**.
- Successful foraging / hunting: group *Survival* check (DV 2) clears 1 segment.
- Downtime spent in relative safety removes 1 segment.
- Purchasing or trading for supplies in settlements.

5.3 Fatigue

Fatigue represents physical exhaustion, hunger, emotional strain, and spiritual depletion. It accumulates through extended effort, deprivation, or magical backlash.

5.3.1 Clearing Fatigue

- A night's rest with adequate Supply removes 1 level of Fatigue.
- You cannot clear Fatigue if the party's Supply clock is *Dangerously Low* or *Out of Supply*.
- Magical healing or special abilities may provide additional Fatigue recovery.
- Extended downtime (3+ days) in safety clears all Fatigue.

5.4 Gear Condition

Gear in **Fate's Edge** does not have hit points or detailed durability tracking. Instead, equipment suffers consequences only when drama demands it.

5.4.1 Compromised Items

- Compromised status is introduced via SB spends or narrative consequence.
- A **Compromised** item gives -1 die on relevant rolls until repaired.
- Multiple Compromised items affecting the *same* action do not stack penalties.

5.4.2 Breaking Point

If a Compromised item suffers another significant setback, it breaks entirely and becomes unusable.

5.4.3 Repair Options

Field Repair Temporary fix; requires *Craft* or *Survival* check (DV 2) to remove the penalty for one scene.

Proper Repair Permanent restoration; requires proper tools, materials, and significant downtime.

Magical Repair Certain spells or rituals can instantly restore gear, but may carry Obligation or Backlash costs.

5.4.4 Equipment Enchantments Quick Reference

Table 5.2: Equipment Enchantment Guidelines

Type	Cost
Minor Enchantments	2–4 XP
Major Enchantments	6–8 XP
Prestige Enchantments	10+ XP

Limitations:

- Max enchantments = Spirit attribute.
- No stacking identical benefits.
- Maintenance affects functionality.

5.5 Asset and Follower Management

5.5.1 Followers (On-Screen Resources)

Cost Cap² XP to acquire.

Assist Dice When applicable, the follower adds help dice equal to min(Cap, helper's relevant Skill), capped at +3 dice total from all sources. *Exception:* *Exceptional Coordination* Talent allows one follower to provide +4 assist dice.

Capability Ranges from 1–5 (5 is exceptional).

Upkeep Each Downtime period, pay XP equal to Cap *or* spend a Scene tending the relationship.

Risk If the GM spends 2+ SB on an action you take with assistance, they may endanger, injure, or separate the follower instead of you if fictionally appropriate.

Off-Screen Capability Once per downtime, a Cap 5 follower can solve one significant problem but generates 1 SB for the party; the GM must describe how their action creates consequences.

5.5.2 Upkeep (Expanded)

Upkeep is the story of attention. Followers and assets thrive when seen and sour when ignored.

Design Intent

- **Choice with Teeth.** Players choose *time* or *XP*. Either way, the fiction moves: quick delegation vs. hands-on scenes.
- **Visible Drift.** Missing upkeep degrades things predictably: **WARY** → **SEIZED**, **NEGLECTED** → **COMPROMISED**.
- **Story First.** Every payment should say something about the relationship or the tool.

Asset Upkeep

Frequency. Once per Downtime period.

Option A — Efficient (Higher XP, Less Time) Pay Upkeep $XP = \max\left(1, \frac{XP \text{ Acquisition Cost}}{3}\right)$. Minimal effort in-fiction (a retainer handles it; you check in by letter).

Option B — Intensive (Lower XP, More Time) Pay 1 XP. Spend a *dedicated Downtime action* personally tending the follower / asset.

Failure. If unpaid this Downtime:

- *Follower:* becomes **Wary** (or **Seized** if already Wary).
- *Asset:* becomes **Neglected** (or **Compromised** if already Neglected).

What the Conditions Look Like

WARY (Follower) They hesitate, ask for guarantees, or interpret orders narrowly. *Mechanical nudge:* first social / test involving them is -1 position *or* costs 1 extra Stress.

SEIZED (Follower) Someone else sets terms (rival, guild, family) or they withdraw until appeased. *Nudge:* cannot assist this Downtime; to re-engage, pay 1 Boon *or* clear via a narrative scene that addresses their grievance.

NEGLECTED (Asset) It underperforms; parts go missing; paperwork piles. *Nudge:* -1 effect on its next use *or* an *Alarmed Attention* clock $+1/2$.

COMPROMISED (Asset) Faults propagate; someone has leverage; the tool is noisy or unsafe. *Nudge:* first use this session automatically creates 1 **SB** *or* requires a costly fix scene.

Examples by Type**Followers.**

Table 5.3: Follower Upkeep Examples

Type	Efficient Upkeep (pay XP, quick)	Intensive Upkeep (1 XP + action)
Scribe	Send coin and a sealed brief with instructions.	Host a lesson; co-author a pamphlet that sharpens their craft.
Scout	Dispatch a courier with a new map and stipend.	Walk the route together; overhaul signals and caches.
Acolyte (Patron-bound)	Arrange a blessing via intermediaries.	Lead them in a minor rite; narrate the teaching moment.
Mercenary	Wire hazard pay with a short commendation.	Drill formation; settle a dispute; toast the unit.
Informant	Drop a dead-letter and payment.	Meet face-to-face; share protection protocol.

Assets.

Table 5.4: Asset Upkeep Examples

Type	Efficient Upkeep (pay XP, quick)	Intensive Upkeep (1 XP + action)
Workshop	Pay the foreman; authorise routine parts.	Personally recalibrate; craft a sample piece.
Safehouse	Hire a caretaker; basic supplies delivered.	Repair locks/windows; rewrite the cover story with neighbours.
Library	Fund copying; buy indices.	Catalogue a shelf; cross-ref a case; bind a damaged tome.
Boat	Pay moorage and minimal maintenance.	Scrape hull; patch sails; sail a proving run.
Sigil Network (Invoker)	Replace two worn plates.	Etch a new master glyph; clear 1 wear mid-scene next session.

Edge Cases & Rulings

- **Multiple Resources.** Each follower / asset checks upkeep separately. A single Intensive action can cover a *cohesive group* if fiction supports it (e.g., one drill for a squad).
- **Remote Care.** If you narrate convincing remote oversight (sending a trusted lieutenant), count as Efficient.

- **Patron-Tinted Upkeep.** Tie upkeep scenes to a Patron's theme for small boons (advantage on the next related roll) without changing costs.
- **Stacking Misses.** Missing upkeep across *two* consecutive Downtime periods moves WARY → SEIZED or NEGLECTED → COMPROMISED; a third consecutive miss risks loss (follower quits; asset condemned) at GM discretion.

Optional Modules

Ledger Credits Track fractional prep: three Efficient payments can be banked to waive one Intensive action later.

Union Rules Some factions demand Intensive upkeep; Efficient counts as half (two Efficient = one Intensive).

Patron Favor Swap Spend a **Boon** to treat missed upkeep as paid for one follower / asset if the scene honours the Patron.

GM Guidance

- **Making it a Scene.** Intensive upkeep should reveal something (new contact, flaw, rumour).
- **Foreshadowing Degradation.** Before applying SEIZED / COMPROMISED, show warning signs the players can act on.
- **Naming the Toll.** If a **Patron's Largess** (wrath) applies, state the narrative reason and the extra toll (e.g., an added SB, a temporary lockout, or a vow demanded).

Upkeep Quick Reference

Once per Downtime. Pay Efficient ($XP = \max(1, \frac{acq}{3})$) or Intensive (1 XP + action).

Missed: Follower → WARY → SEIZED; Asset → NEGLECTED → COMPROMISED. Tie scenes to your Patron for flavour, not discounts.

5.5.3 Follower Assist Rules

- Assist dice come from the helper's capabilities, not the leader's.
- Total Assist on any roll (from any sources) is hard-capped at +3. *Exception:* *Exceptional Coordination* may allow +4 from a single follower.
- Only one follower may assist a given action at a time.
- Followers cannot assist actions beyond their narrative scope or capabilities.

5.5.4 Loyalty & Bonds (Optional Rules)

- Track a simple Loyalty tag per follower: *Wary* / *Steady* / *Devoted*.
- *Devoted* followers can once per arc convert one GM Complication targeting them into a lesser setback.
- *Wary* followers cost +1 XP to maintain during Downtime.
- Loyalty can change based on how the PC treats the follower and shared experiences.

5.5.5 Off-Screen Assets

Table 5.5: Asset Types and Costs

Asset Type	Cost
Minor Asset	4 XP (safehouse, small charter, local business)
Standard Asset	8 XP (noble title, guild section, spy ring, significant property)
Major Asset	12 XP (city licence, regional network, major institution influence)
Artifact Asset	16+ XP (unique items or positions with campaign-level significance)

Asset Activations

- **Off-Screen Activation:** At campaign start or during Downtime, activate an off-screen asset by spending **1 Boon** or **2 XP**.
- **Off-Screen Effects:** Use each Asset's listed off-screen effect once per session for free.
- **On-Screen Activation:** To reshape the current scene, spend **1 Boon**.
- **Plausibility Test:** The Asset must have appropriate scope and reach for the intended effect.

Asset Condition Tracks

Maintained Full capability; no penalties. The asset is in good standing and fully functional.

Neglected −1 die when used (assist or leverage). Narratively: slower response, sullen staff, short-staffed operations.

Compromised Unavailable for use. Narratively: captured, burned, seized, defected, or otherwise incapacitated.

Maintenance and Repair

- After a story arc or 2–3 sessions of heavy use, the GM may flag the resource as *at risk*.
- To keep an asset *Maintained*, the player must either:
 - Spend Downtime repairing / servicing it, or
 - Pay XP immediately (representing replacement parts, masterwork upkeep).
- If neglected, the asset becomes *Neglected* (–1 die) and may eventually become permanently lost.
- Superior and Artifact assets do not require normal upkeep; if *Compromised* through complications, only narrative quests can repair them.

5.6 Bond-Driven Resource Generation

When a player takes a significant action to aid an ally with whom they share a bond, and explicitly references that bond in an *Intricate* description, they may mark that bond to gain **1 Boon** *after* the action resolves.

5.6.1 Requirements

- **Mutual Bond:** Player shares a defined bond with the ally they are aiding.
- **Intricate Description:** Player describes how the bond motivates their action using rich, multi-sensory details.
- **Significant Aid:** Meaningful assistance beyond basic dice bonuses.
- **Fiction First:** The bond genuinely drives the choice to help, not added retroactively.

5.6.2 Examples

Valid Examples:

- "Remembering how they saved me from the falling rubble in Aeler, I throw myself in front of the crossbow bolt meant for them!"
- "Thinking of our shared vow to protect the innocent, I use my last healing potion to stabilise them instead of saving it for myself."
- "Drawing on our years fighting side-by-side in the Border Wars, I rally the other mercenaries to keep fighting alongside them when morale fails."

5.6.3 Limitations

- Once per bond per session.
- Must involve meaningful sacrifice or risk.
- GM approval required for what constitutes "significant action".
- Cannot be used for basic assistance rolls or minor favours.
- The Boon is awarded *after* the action resolves, not before.

5.7 Over-Stack Rule

The Over-Stack rule prevents excessive accumulation of advantages from trivial sources while rewarding meaningful preparation.

5.7.1 Structural Advantages

Structural advantages include:

- Active buffs or beneficial tags affecting the party.
- Favourable venue or environmental factors.
- Unused *Follower Initiative* for the scene.
- On-screen Asset activation providing immediate benefits.
- Opponent disadvantaged by fiction (surprised, trapped, etc.).
- Ritual preparation that applies to the current situation.

5.7.2 Over-Stack Trigger

- If the party **enters** a scene with ≥ 3 structural advantages, a GM *may* apply Over-Stack once for that scene.
- The GM chooses either:
 - Start one named obstacle or challenge at **+1 DV**, or
 - The GM banks **+1 SB** for the first Deck Twist in the scene.
- This represents narrative pushback when characters have overwhelming advantages.
- Over-Stack applies only once per scene, regardless of how many advantages accumulate.

Note: Over-Stack applies to advantages held at scene framing, not those generated through play. If the party enters with overwhelming force, the world pushes back once. If they create overwhelming force through creative improvisation during the scene, that is the intended reward cycle—no Over-Stack applies.

5.8 Currency-Free Economy (Compressed Reference)

Quick Reference

No coin. Incidental expenses are hand-waved. Significant costs use XP, barter, Strings, or Obligation (Debt Clocks).

5.8.1 What Costs What

Item / Benefit	XP Cost	Alternative Payment
Minor Asset	4 XP	Minor String or Debt Clock [4]
Standard Asset	8 XP	Standard String or Debt Clock [6]
Major Asset	12 XP	Major String or Debt Clock [8]
Follower (Cap n)	n^2 XP	Debt Clock $[n + 2]$ or equivalent String
Single-use magical item	2–4 XP	Barter (item of equal rarity)
Permanent magical item (Tier I)	6–10 XP	Quest + String
Clear Debt Clock segment	2 XP	One service scene
Permanent String (earned)	— (reward)	—
Form a Trust (party pool)	10 XP	—

5.8.2 String Values

String Tier	Purchasing Power
Minor	1 XP discount, or one free use of a Minor Asset effect
Standard	Minor Asset (4 XP) or clear 2 Debt Clock segments
Major	Standard Asset (8 XP) or Cap 3 Follower

5.8.3 Debt Clock Equivalences

Debt Clock Size	Equivalent Value
	Minor Asset or one-time service
	Standard Asset or Cap 3 Follower
	Major Asset or Cap 5 Follower

5.8.4 Trust Investments (from Party Pool)

XP	Effect
4	Increase Trust Debt Clock capacity by 2
6	Add Minor Asset (Trust-owned)
8	Upgrade Asset (Minor → Standard)
10	Add Cap 3 Follower (Trust lieutenant)
12	Gain permanent Standard String (faction owes Trust)
15	Trust becomes Major Terrestrial Patron (can grant Rites)

5.8.5 Hand-Waved (Free)

Meals, inn stays, basic tools, riding horse, routine transport, minor repairs, small bribes.

5.8.6 GM Adjudication Quick Mat

Situation	Ruling
Player asks for small, reasonable item	Yes, free.
Player wants a permanent asset	XP, String, or Debt Clock.
Player offers barter	Roll Presence+Sway (DV 2–5); on success, trade happens.
Player spends a String	No roll unless hostile/extreme; String is consumed.
Debt Clock fills	Creditor makes a demand (mission, sacrifice, public oath).
Player hoards XP	Introduce problems that need Assets/Trusts, not personal power.
Player farms Boons for XP	Anti-fishing: no Boons from safe/repetitive actions.
Player founds a Trust	Require 10 XP from pool; run introductory mission to clear founding Debt Clock.

5.8.7 SB Menu – Currency Complications

SB Spent	Complication
1	Barter item damaged; NPC demands extra favor.
2	Debt Clock ticks unexpectedly; String found counterfeit.
3	Trust Asset threatened; major barter deal collapses.
4+	Trust schism; Debt Clock called in early at worst moment.

5.8.8 Currency-Free Economy – Core Principles

- **Hand-wave trivial.** Say yes to small, sensible requests.
- **Significant gains cost XP, Strings, or Debt.**
- **Debt is story.** Call in Debt Clocks at dramatic moments.
- **Trusts are player-driven factions.** Use them to generate missions and rivals.
- **Spent XP is remembered.** Make assets and followers matter in the fiction.

Chapter 6

Character Advancement

6.1 Introduction

Character advancement in **Fate's Edge** reflects meaningful growth in capability and standing. XP is awarded for table-facing accomplishments, hard choices, and the dramatic friction that defines your story. Advancement should always reinforce narrative identity: what drives, obligations, and affinities are shaping the character?

6.2 Starting Character Builds

6.2.1 Standard Starting XP

Players begin with **30 XP** to allocate during initial character creation. This represents a balanced baseline for competent starting characters.

6.2.2 Enhanced Starting Options

Players may exceed the standard 30 XP build through narrative engagement:

- **Bonds:** Up to two player-defined mutual bonds may be taken for +2 XP total (+1 XP each).
- **Complications:** Up to two initial complications may be accepted for +4 XP total (+2 XP each).

This allows a maximum starting build of **34 XP**. Players are encouraged to aim for 30 XP and use bonds/complications to enhance characterization rather than pure mechanical optimisation.

6.2.3 Initial Complications Reminder

For each initial complication taken at character creation:

- Start each scene with +1 banked SB per character with initial complications.
- These complications remain until cleared through play or character development.

6.2.4 Small Folk of the Threshold

The Aelaerem and Aelinnel are diminutive peoples attuned to liminal spaces and hidden ways. Their stature grants them agility and subtlety, though at the cost of bearing heavy arms or armor.

- **Restriction:** Cannot use *Heavy Armor* or *Heavy Weapons*.
- **Bonus:** Gain +1 *Position* when Dodging or Resisting Knockback, and +1 die on *Hide* or *Evasion* rolls made while in cover.

Their presence in the world is often underestimated, but their knack for slipping unseen through thresholds and enduring where others falter has earned them a quiet reverence.

6.3 Player Archetypes

Not every group plays the same way. These archetypes describe how players typically spend XP and seek spotlight.

6.3.1 The Solo

Definition Invests XP primarily in Attributes and Skills. Minimal followers, minimal holdings. All power is on the character sheet.

Typical XP Spread 70–90% Self; 0–10% On-screen help; 0–20% Off-screen assets.

Strengths Consistent scene impact; few moving parts; resilient to follower loss.

Risks Limited fiction reach between sessions; can stall when problems demand logistics or networks.

Starting Focus Attributes 2–3, Skills 1–2, minimal assets.

6.3.2 The Mixed Player

Definition Splits XP between self-growth and one or two meaningful assets (a small follower or a reliable holding).

Typical XP Spread 50–65% Self; 15–25% On-screen help; 15–25% Off-screen assets.

Strengths Versatile: credible in scenes and has a lever for special problems.

Risks Upkeep pressure; helper can be targeted when the GM spends 2+ Story Beats.

Starting Focus Balanced approach with one minor asset or low-cap follower.

6.3.3 The Mastermind

Definition Prioritises followers / cadres / familiars and off-screen networks. The character sheet is the hub of a larger apparatus.

Typical XP Spread 25–40% Self; 35–55% On-screen help; 20–40% Off-screen assets.

Strengths Scene control via assistance; strategic reach between sessions; strong heist / social-planning play.

Risks Dependency on assist lanes; followers can be endangered on 2+ SB spends; upkeep pressure.

Starting Focus Significant investment in followers or major assets from the beginning.

6.4 XP Costs and Advancement

6.4.1 Core Character Improvements

Table 6.1: Core Improvement Costs

Improvement	Cost and Downtime
Attribute increase	Cost = new rating $\times$ 3 XP; downtime = new rating (days).
Skill increase	Cost = new level $\times$ 2 XP; downtime = new level (days).
On-screen Follower	Cost = Cap^2 XP; 1–3 days to recruit and brief.

6.4.2 Off-Screen Assets

Table 6.2: Asset Costs

Asset Type	Cost and Downtime
Minor Asset	4 XP; 1 day.
Standard Asset	8 XP; 1 week.
Major Asset	12 XP; 1 month.
Artifact Asset	16+ XP; campaign effort.

6.4.3 Talent Costs

Table 6.3: Talent Costs

Talent Tier	Cost
Minor Talents	2–3 XP (small situational bonus).
Major Talents	4–6 XP (strong upgrade, permanent effect in a niche).
Prestige Talents	7–10 XP (campaign-defining, breaks fundamental limits).

Epic Talents 11+ XP (legendary, story-shaping).

6.5 Tiers of Reputation

Though there are no character levels, total XP spent creates soft "tiers" that shape how the world responds to characters.

Table 6.4: Reputation Tiers

Tier	Effect
Tier I – Novice (0–40 XP)	Local reputation; prestige abilities locked.
Tier II – Seasoned (41–90 XP)	Regional notice; prestige abilities may unlock.
Tier III – Veteran (91–150 XP)	National influence; second follower slot suggested.
Tier IV – Paragon (151–220 XP)	Movers and shakers; rivals emerge to challenge.
Tier V – Mythic (221+ XP)	Legendary status; kingdoms and cults respond directly.

6.6 Prestige Abilities and Talents (Examples)

Prestige abilities are narrative milestones unlocked through mastery or story events. They are priced at 6+ XP and include campaign-shaping effects.

6.6.1 General Talents

Battle Instincts (6 XP): Once per scene, re-roll a failed defence roll.

Silver Tongue (4 XP): Gain +1 die when persuading or deceiving through speech.

Iron Stomach (6 XP): Immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food; halve complications from toxic sources.

Exceptional Coordination (8 XP): One follower can provide +4 assist dice (exception to the +3 cap).

Subtle Casting (Major Talent – 8 XP) *Prerequisite:* Lore 3+, Performance 2+ **or** Runekeeper with Codex.

Effect: Make a **Performance** + **Lore** roll to quietly cast a spell, invoke a Rite, or sing a Cantos against DV (Tier). If successful, the casting does *not* generate Story Beats on the Channel or initial roll. Any SB generated are **banked by the GM** and applied at dramatically appropriate moments.

Limitations:

- Cannot be used for **Great** or **Extreme** Tier effects.
- The *Weave* phase (if applicable) still generates normal SB.

Backstab (Major Talent – 8 XP) *Prerequisite:* Stealth 2+, Melee 2+, Light weapon.
Effect: When you attack an **Unaware** or **Engaged** foe from **Stealth**, deal +1 *Harm* and ignore 1 point of their *Armor*.

Definitions:

- **Unaware:** Target not aware of your presence or hostile intent.
- **Engaged:** Target is taking an *Attack* action against another character, or casting a spell that targets another character.

Limit: Once per scene. On a miss, you are *Exposed* – drop to Desperate Position or mark 1 *Harm*.

Shadow Dance (Synergy Talent – 10 XP) *Prerequisite:* Backstab, Stealth 3+, Mobility 2+.

Effect: After a successful **Backstab**, test **Stealth** vs. DV (Tier). On success, re-enter **Stealth** and either clear 1 *Fatigue* or improve *Position* +1. On failure, remain *Exposed* and mark 1 *Fatigue*. May only chain once per scene.

Deathblow (Capstone Talent – 12 XP) *Prerequisite:* Shadow Dance, Stealth 4+, Melee/Ranged 3+.

Effect: Strike from Dominant Position or after re-entering **Stealth**, declare a **Deathblow**. On a hit, deal *triple Harm*. If the attack incapacitates the target, attempt a free **Stealth** test to vanish. On a miss, become *Exposed* (Desperate Position and mark 1 *Harm*). Once per scene; may mark 1 *Fatigue* to attempt a second time.

6.6.2 Cultural and Ancestral Talents

Humans

Versatile (3 XP): Once per session, swap one Skill die for another you lack.

Guild Ties (7 XP; Presence 2+): Call in favours from a guild or order once per session.

Banner-Bearer (15 XP; Presence 4+, Resolve 3): Inspire an allied unit; once per battle, erase 2 complications for the group.

Dwarves (Aeler)

Stone-Sense (5 XP): Detect flaws in stone; +1 die to underground *Lore* or *Survival* checks involving stonework.

Spirit Shield (8 XP; Spirit 3+): Commune with ancestors; once per session, block 1 complication for an ally.

Forge-Patriarch (18 XP; Body 4+, Lore 3): Found a forge-citadel; gain loyal smiths and engineers (Cap 5 followers).

Wood Elves

Backlash Soothing (5 XP): Once per session, cancel 1 Backlash die in natural terrain.

Ranger's Step (9 XP; Wits 3+, Stealth 2): Move unseen in forests; treat terrain penalties as one step lower.

Wild Speaker (18 XP; Spirit 5+, Survival 3): Speak to beasts and trees; once per session, command local wildlife as allies.

High Elves

Lorekeeper (4 XP): Recall obscure history or magic without rolling once per session.

Weave Anchor (8 XP; Wits 3+, Arcana 3): Reduce magical Backlash by 1 when casting Intricate spells.

Ways-Walker's Step (20 XP; Wits 5, Arcana 4): Once per arc, turn a complication into a boon; GM banks 2 SB.

Ykrul

Blood Frenzy (4 XP; Body 2+): When reduced to half health, gain +1 die on melee rolls.

Blood Memory (7 XP; Body 3+): After battle, gain 1 temporary Skill die reflecting a foe's tactics in the next scene.

Warglord (18 XP; Body 5, Sway 3): Once per campaign, unify scattered warbands; start Logistics and Grudge clocks.

6.7 Starting Build Examples

6.7.1 Solo Build (30–32 XP)

- Body 3 (9 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP).
- Skills: Combat 2 (4 XP), Stealth 1 (2 XP), Survival 1 (2 XP).
- Minor Talent: Iron Stomach (3 XP).
- **Total:** 32 XP (requires 1 bond or minor complication).

6.7.2 Mixed Build (32 XP)

- Attributes: Body 2 (6 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP).
- Skills: Sway 2 (4 XP), Lore 1 (2 XP).
- Minor Asset: Safehouse (4 XP).
- Cap 2 Follower (4 XP).
- **Total:** 32 XP.

6.7.3 Mastermind Build (34 XP)

- Attributes: Body 2 (6 XP), Wits 3 (9 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP).
- Skills: Sway 2 (4 XP).
- Cap 3 Follower (9 XP).
- **Total:** 34 XP (requires 2 bonds or complications).

6.8 Advancement Guidance

- Advancement should always reinforce narrative identity and character goals.
- Consider how new abilities fit the character's story and relationships.
- Balance immediate power with long-term narrative potential.
- Work with the GM to ensure advancements make sense in the campaign context.

6.9 Optional Rule: Multi-Character Followers

6.9.1 Overview

A player may control multiple characters by linking them as mutual Followers. This option also covers absent players' characters when consent is given.

6.9.2 Core Mechanics

- **Cap Tier +1:** A Follower may advance up to one Tier higher than their leader's current Tier.
- **Multi-Character Play:** A player may designate two PCs as Followers of each other. Only one is the *active* PC at a time; the other functions as a Follower.
- **Absent PCs:** With consent, an absent player's PC may be run as a temporary Follower at Cap Tier +1.

6.9.3 Switching Active Characters

- **Switch Cost:** When switching, the previously active PC immediately becomes a Follower of the new active PC at Cap Tier +1.
- **Condition Gate:** A PC cannot be switched *to* if Compromised, Seized, or otherwise narratively unfit for active duty.
- **Narrative Justification:** The fiction must support the switch (returning from a journey, recovering from harm, taking point for a specific task).
- **Strategic Choice:** Switching trades autonomy for support—gaining a powerful Follower but losing a full PC.

6.9.4 Balance Notes

- Prevents abuse by making switching itself the cost.
- Maintains narrative logic – leadership shifts naturally reshape party structure.
- Creates strategic depth – switching is a meaningful tactical decision.
- Keeps all characters relevant, encouraging upkeep even when not active.

Chapter 7

Magic System

7.1 Design Philosophy

Magic in **Fate's Edge** is a dangerous negotiation with the fabric of reality. It is powerful and flexible—yet every attempt to shape it carries risk. Each die showing **1** generates **Story Beats (SB)**, which are prompts for twists and complications. The fiction leads; math follows.

7.2 The Four Paths of Magic

7.2.1 Casting (Freeform Magic)

Freeform casting represents raw, improvisational magic.

Requirement **Spellcraft** Talent (6 XP).

Mechanics Two-step *Weave & Cast* coloured by the Eight Elements; fiction-first targets and scope.

Risk Each 1 generates SB; DV scales with scope; backlash is expressed by Element (or its opposite).

Limits Heavy control effects (e.g., [WARD], [BANISH], [UNWARD]) require a printed source (Talent, *Rite* text, or Spell result).

Backlash Cheatsheet

Minor = wobble, Major = lurch. Types: Position/Effect, Clock +1/2 or +1, Condition, Cost. Offer Major by (SB)+1. Earth/Fate binds; Fire/Life burns/grows; Air/Luck scatters/flips; Water/Obishaal pulls/opens.

Place a mini version of Table 7.1 on character sheets.

7.2.2 Rites Users (Runekeepers)

Runekeepers bind themselves to structured *Rites* from a single Patron.

Requirement **Thiasos (Familiar)** (2 XP) *and* **Codex** (4 XP). Runekeepers are restricted to **one** Patron.

Mechanics Invoke a known *Rite* as **1 action**; on completion, mark **+1 Obligation** to that Patron. *Push It* once/scene for amplified effect (**+1 Obligation**).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement) With Thiasos, once/scene as **1 action** imbue a held item for the scene with **+1 Melee** and **+1 Thematic** (a fixed Skill set by the Patron). *Push It* to extend one additional scene (**+1 Obligation**). A Codex is *not* required for the Gift.

7.2.3 Rites Difficulty Value (Expanded)

The Difficulty Value (DV) to cast a Rite is:

$$DV = \max(\text{Obligation Cost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Tier})$$

Obligation Cost: The Rite's listed cost in Obligation segments.

Spirit: The caster's Spirit attribute. Each point reduces the effective weight of the Obligation.

Tier: The Rite's intrinsic difficulty based on scope or potency. DV can never fall below this floor.

Worked Examples

- *Novice:* Tier 1 Rite, Obligation Cost 2, Spirit 1 $\rightarrow DV = \max(2 - 1, 1) = 1$.
- *Mid-level:* Tier 2 Rite, Obligation Cost 4, Spirit 2 $\rightarrow DV = \max(4 - 2, 2) = 2$.
- *Advanced:* Tier 3 Rite, Obligation Cost 7, Spirit 3 $\rightarrow DV = \max(7 - 3, 3) = 4$.

7.2.4 Obligation Capacity

A character's **Obligation Capacity** equals **Spirit + Presence**. Track total Obligation segments across all Patrons (or Symbols, for Invokers).

- **Exceeding Capacity:** For each segment above Capacity, mark 1 Fatigue. The character cannot Invoke Rites or perform rituals until Obligation is reduced below Capacity.
- **Resolution:** Reduce Obligation through Downtime service, Patron tasks, ritual cleansing, or story resolution.

Example: Spirit 2 + Presence 3 = Capacity 5. 6 segments $\rightarrow$ Fatigue 1; 7 segments $\rightarrow$ Fatigue 2; 10 segments $\rightarrow$ Harm 1; 11 segments $\rightarrow$ Harm 2.

7.2.5 Invokers (Symbol Path)

Invokers use consecrated **Symbols** as ritual anchors to access a Patron's *Rites* without a full bond.

Requirement Patron's Symbol (4 XP) per Patron; one Symbol per Patron. No Thiasos or Codex required.

Ritual Invocation Perform the *Rite* as a **ritual**: **DV + 1 rounds** to complete. Completion always marks **+1 Obligation**.

Symbol Benefit When the correct **Symbol** is openly displayed, reduce **DV by 1** (minimum 1) and reduce the Obligation cost by **1** (minimum 0).

No Symbol Penalties: **+1 DV** (and +1 round to cast), **+1 Obligation** (in addition to base cost), and on Partial/Failure the GM gains **+1 extra SB**.

Crack the Seal Resolve a known Rite instantly as **1 action** by setting the Symbol to COMPROMISED and marking **+2 Obligation** (+3 for High Rites). The GM may immediately spend 1 on-theme SB. Restore the Symbol in Downtime (test DV 3 or fiction) or spend 1 XP.

Limits Symbols must be openly displayed. Carrying **4+** Symbols causes **+1 Obligation** on the first ritual each scene.

Borrowed Grace (Invoker Talent)

Cost: 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue, 1 action. **Effect (pick one):** +1 Melee *or* +1 Thematic (a signature Skill). **Duration:** single action/attack only. **Requirement:** wield/display the relevant Patron's Symbol. **Obligation:** immediately mark +1 Obligation to that Patron. Cannot extend, stack, or Push.

7.3 Summoning (Pact-Whisperer Core)

Summoning is the art of calling and binding Outsiders (spirits, demons, elementals, etc.) for temporary aid.

1. **Call** (1 Action): Spirit manifests at Near range. Choose a Spirit Template.
2. **Bind:** Spend 1 Boon *or* mark 1 Fatigue.
3. **Leash Capacity:** Set equal to *Cap* + *Spirit* segments. (*Cap* is the Outsider's tier: Cap 1 for Lesser, Cap 3 for Greater.)
4. **Tick Leash** when any occur:
 - Spirit takes Harm.
 - You command against its nature.
 - You split focus (take another significant action while it acts).
 - Rival contests control.
 - It moves from Close to Far rapidly.
 - It crosses a [WARD] (DV = Cap).
5. **Departure:** When the Leash fills, the spirit acts to its nature once, then departs (or turns hostile at GM discretion).

Boon Finesse: Once per round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 tick from the current spirit's Leash (cannot be used after the Leash fills).

7.3.1 Elemental Backlash Tables

When magic disturbs the weave, the world pushes back. Backlash manifests as fiction-first complications with light mechanical teeth. Each element (and its metaphysical counterpart) has a **Minor** and **Major** pattern.

Table 7.1: Backlash

Element	Major Backlash
Earth	<i>Ground claims.</i> Fissure or masonry seizes. — Clock +1/2 on <i>Collapse</i> or PINNED.
Fire	<i>Blaze takes.</i> Fuel ignites; blood races hot. — Clock +1 on <i>Spreading Fire</i> or 1 Harm.
Air	<i>Fickle turn.</i> Unlikely mishap hits you. — Immediate Cost (lose tool) or (SB)+1.
Water	<i>Undertow calls.</i> Passage veers; something pulled through. — Clock +1/2 on <i>Flood</i> or brief intrusion.
Fate	<i>Edict falls.</i> Declared cost paid now. — Immediate Cost (resource) or (SB)+1 & OMEN.
Life	<i>Riot of life.</i> Parasites bloom; healing twists. — Clock +1 on <i>Biohazard</i> or convert 1 healing to (S).
Luck	<i>Snake eyes.</i> Catastrophic fluke. — Force a re-roll; any 1 gives (SB)+1 & apply Minor again.
Death/Dreams	<i>Threshold opens.</i> Path misaligns; revenant claims a due. — Clock +1 on <i>Crossing Due</i> or immediate cost.

7.4 Rituals (Extended)

Rituals are *slow magic*: explicit intent, staged action, and negotiated risk. This section expands the SRD quick-start with procedures, dials, and worked examples.

7.4.1 Ritual Procedure

- Step 1: State Intent.** What do you want? Clarify element/Realm if obvious.
- Step 2: Choose Scope.** Size, duration, range, and detail.
- Step 3: Lay Components.** Name *two things*: (a) **Focus** (tool/site/Patron sign), (b) **Fuel** (herb, blood, pact). Decide which is consumed.
- Step 4: Set Time.** Default: Low 1 min / Med 5–10 min / High 15–20 min. More time improves position/effect; rushing worsens.
- Step 5: Call Risks.** Point to the element's Backlash and default SB trigger.
- Step 6: Roll and Resolve.** Apply position/effect and any clocks. Offer a *push*: take +1 SB to step up result now.

Step 7: Mark Costs. Consume components, apply Conditions, or tick wear/concurrency per chassis.

7.4.2 Component Economy

Components are levers, not taxes.

Table 7.2: Components as Narrative Levers

Type
Examples
Mechanical Nudge
Focus (retained) Patron token, true-name sigil, saint’s nail, ancestral blade. +1 Position on setup or advantage to follow-up actions.
Fuel (consumed) Herb bundle, salt vial, blood drop, silver bead, memory-laden note. –1 time step (faster) or +1 Effect step if expensive/rare.
Site (context) Crossroads, standing stones, bathhouse, bell tower at midnight. Shift backlash element or re-route it (e.g., into <i>Alarmed Attention</i> clock).
Vow (social) Sworn phrase, bargain pledge, offered favor. If broken, immediate +1 SB and intrusion linked to the vow.

7.4.3 Teamwork and Aid

- **Hands & Voices.** Each assistant names one component they contribute; either reduces cast time *or* accepts up to 1 SB on the caster’s behalf once per ritual.
- **Focus Chain.** Passing the Focus around grants advantage on the finishing action but risks DISTRACTED if interrupted.
- **Distributed Load.** Splitting a High ritual into two coordinated Mediums avoids a Major backlash but creates two Minor hooks instead.

7.4.4 Clocks and Outcomes

Tie every consequential ritual to **named clocks** (e.g., *Spreading Fire*, *Inevitable Outcome*, *Crossing Due*). Advancing or reducing clocks is often better than flat bonuses.

7.4.5 Backlash Integration

Use the condensed table (Table 7.1). Calibrate by scene weight: exploratory scenes favor Minor; pivotal moments bait a Major via +1 SB.

7.4.6 Chassis-Specific Notes

- **Runekeeper:** Rites as *accelerants* – a published Rite may count as a Focus that upgrades position or halves time.

- **Invoker:** Symbols accumulate *wear*; a maintenance rite can clear 1 wear mid-scene on success or shift backlash from Major to Minor.
- **Summoner:** *Gate* effects occupy concurrency slots. Disruption on broken terms: +1 SB and the entity acts on its last instruction.
- **Caster (Free):** Tags become explicit ritual steps (*bind, veil, reveal*) – chain two compatible tags once/scene for a synergy bump.

7.4.7 Worked Examples

Quiet Veil (Team Infiltration) *Intent:* silence the group for one scene. *Components:* ash (fuel, consumed), bell (focus, kept). *Time:* 5 min. *Risks:* Air/Luck Minor; offer Major to avoid dogs' scent. *Roll:* mixed – effect with cost. *Outcome:* MUTED condition until scene ends; Clock –1/2 on *Patrol Pass*.

River's Memory (Investigation) *Intent:* view last night's ferry landing. *Components:* bowl, token from dock. *Time:* 10 min. *Risk:* Water/Obishaal Minor. *Roll:* strong – clear image; token ruined. *Outcome:* Clock –1 on *Where did the courier go?*; whisper from the Ways foreshadows a revenant.

Fate-Splice (Boss Rescue) *Intent:* move poison from prince to knight. *Components:* paired names on vellum; vow. *Time:* 15 min. *Risk:* Fate/Earth. *Roll:* weak – Minor Backlash; *Inevitable Outcome* +1/2. *Push:* +1 SB to capture full consequence. *Outcome:* knight bears poison; OMEN marks both.

7.5 Cantor's Path (Songs)

Cantors perform Low Rites as Songs, trading Obligation for Corruption.

Access Talent: **Cantor's Path** (8 XP). Prereqs: Lore 1+, Performance 2+, Presence 2+.

Scope Low Rites as Songs only.

Cast Test *Lore + Performance vs. DV* (typical DV 2–3).

Timing Start with 1 Action; resolves at *start of next turn* unless *Pushed*.

Cost Pay listed materials. *No Obligation* on success.

Push Resolve now; mark Fatigue 1; mark toward Corruption accumulation; trigger a GM Story Beat (Patron / social fallout).

Corruption Clock Track a **Corruption Clock** with segments equal to **Body**. Mark toward accumulation when: *Push*, perform a *Resonant Rite*, or the GM spends an SB tied to occult activity. On fill: apply the last Patron's benefit & drawback; then reset to character's Tier minimum (minimum 1).

Corruption Accumulation Triggers Multiple triggers required for +1 segment:

- **2 Push It uses** = +1
- **1 Push It + 1 Resonant Rite** = +1
- **3 GM SB spends** on occult activities = +1
- **1 High Cantor Standard Rite** = +1

Repertoire (Optional) Single **Repertoire Clock [6]**: 2 segments = base DV -1 (min 2); 4 segments = +1 die to Song rolls; 6 segments = one *temporary* Standard Rite as Song (practice-dependent).

Inspire Chorus While actively singing a Song, the Cantor may **invoke Inspire Chorus**:

- **Effect:** All allies within Near shift Position +1 for one exchange (cannot exceed Controlled).
- **Use:** Once per scene free. Additional uses mark toward Corruption accumulation.
- **Requirements:** Performance perceptible to recipients (line of hearing).

7.5.1 Cantor Talents

Resonant Performance (3 XP) Gain +1 die when performing for an audience of 5+.

Song Weaver (4 XP) Combine two compatible Songs for +1 Effect. Two Songs are compatible if they share a thematic tag (e.g., both affect healing, positioning, spirits) or if they are from the same Patron. The GM has final say. Sing both as a single action; resolve the Performance roll once; if successful, both effects occur with +1 Effect.

High Cantor (18 XP) Learn Standard Rites as songs; resolve instantly (as described in 7.5).

Steady Voice (2 XP) Passive. When you Push a Song, you may choose to mark 1 additional Fatigue instead of marking a Corruption segment (once per scene). You cannot use this talent if your Corruption clock is already full. *Requires: Cantor's Path.*

Patron's Dedication (4 XP) Prerequisite: Cantor's Path.

Effect: You bind your voice to a single Patron (choose one when you take this talent). Your Corruption clock is always keyed to that Patron – it never resets to a different Patron's table when you bloom. Whenever you would gain Corruption from any source, you mark it on this same clock.

Downside (Rivalry): Singing a Song (Low or Standard Rite) of any other Patron worsens your Position by one step (Dominant → Controlled, Controlled → Desperate). This penalty applies even if the song would otherwise be instant or free.

7.6 Free Casting (TAGS System)

Some casters shape raw forces through shared arcane grammar known as **TAGS**. Construct a spell at the table using a short phrase of TAGS.

7.6.1 Spell Structure

Intent + **Target** + **Tags** = effect. Example: *"I unleash Burning • Area • Force against the marauders."*

7.6.2 Base Difficulty Value (DV)

$$DV = 1 + \text{number of TAGS}$$

Dangerous TAGS (Teleportation, Transformation, Domination) add +2 DV instead of +1.

7.6.3 Casting Roll

Roll **Wits** + **Arcana** (or similar). Success = spell works. Failure or any 1 = Backlash.

7.6.4 Backlash for Free Casters

Choose one:

- Harm 2 (Arcane)
- +2 Fatigue
- Corruption +1
- Catastrophic side effect (GM describes)

If the spell includes a "Dangerous" TAG, Backlash triggers on *mixed* results as well.

7.6.5 TAG Library (Abridged)

Table 7.3: Common TAGS

TAG Category	Examples
Elemental	Burning, Freezing, Storm, Stone, Wave, Wind
Force	Force, Area, Strike, Wall, Bind, Dispel
Mind & Veil	Veil, Scry, Memory, Command, Fear
Life & Body	HEAL, Purify, Strengthen, Waken, Beast
Space & Motion (dangerous, +2 DV)	Leap, Fold, Gate, Gravity
Creation & Transfor- mation (dangerous, +2 DV)	Create, Summon, Transmute, Animate

7.7 Path Comparison

Table 7.4: Comparison of Magic Paths

Aspect	Caster (Freeform)	Runekeeper (Rites)	Invoker (Symbols)
Access Cost	Spellcraft (6 XP)	Thiasos + Codex (6 XP)	Symbol (4 XP per Patron)
Speed	Medium (2 actions)	Fast (1 action)	Slow (ritual) / Fast w/ Seal
Risk Type	SB backlash (Elemental)	Obligation (Patron ledger)	Symbol compromise + Obligation
Breadth	High (fiction-gated)	Medium (defined Rites)	Medium (breadth across Patrons)
Sustain	Fatigue/backsplash	Obligation; Push adds +1	Obligation; Symbol state gates

Guardrails

- **Duration defaults:** Buffs $\approx$ 3 beats; areas 1 beat. Sustaining costs 1 Fatigue/beat.
- **Stacking:** Same-source effects do not stack; take the best instance.
- **Assist cap:** +3 dice total from assists/buffs.
- **Over-Stack:** Active magic can count as structural advantages for Over-Stack.
- **Plausibility:** All effects must fit the fiction and established limits.

tabularray

7.8 Of Patrons, Runes, and Invokers

“You wish to walk the road of power? Then listen well. The world is old, and older still are the voices beneath it. We call them *Patrons*, though they were never sworn to us. They are the tides that move unseen, the keepers of forgotten bargains, the sleepers beneath the stone and the stars. To call upon them is to dip a hand into a river that has carved mountains.”

7.8.1 The Patrons

Patrons are vast intelligences—not gods, though some worship them as such. They are embodiments of *concepts* and *forces* rather than sovereigns. Raéyn, mistress of the tides and the sea-routes. Khemesh, the crushing inevitability of the deep. Nidhoggr, the worm that dreams in the roots of time. Each offers power, but always with cost: fatigue, scars upon fate, or a slow unweaving of one’s own story.

To entreat a Patron is to risk being marked. Their Rites are gifts and snares both.

Iconic Ascension: The Fate of Great Power

In Fate’s Edge, power has its price. When a being rises beyond mortal scale, its identity dissolves and reforms into something larger, older, and less free. This transformation is known as **Iconic Ascension**.

Icons are not individuals. They are *forces*—living embodiments of desires, patterns, and long-term agendas. Their power is immense, but their agency is small. An Icon cannot freely choose its actions; its nature compels it.

Icons cannot touch the world directly. Their presence is too vast, their will too diffuse. Instead, they act through intermediaries:

- **Chosen** who carry fragments of their purpose
- **Devotees** who interpret their omens
- **Agents** who benefit from their favor

Icons shape events not with hands, but through **boons**, **omens**, and **shifts in fate** granted to those who serve their desires—whether fleeting hungers or ancient ambitions woven into the world’s fabric.

To serve an Icon is to wield a living idea. Their gifts are potent, but their influence reshapes those who bear them. Their will echoes in mortal choices long after their voices fade.

7.8.2 Aveh, the Rider Behind the Storm (Freedom & Erasure)

Lore. Aveh is the faceless rider at the horizon's edge, neither man nor woman, both and neither. The Ykrul call them *Aveh*, a liminal spirit beyond hearth and vow, a storm-shadow that offers liberty at the cost of belonging. To travel with Aveh is to taste unchained freedom—and to risk being erased by the storm that follows.

"I am the track the storm devours. I am the freedom you fear and the silence you crave. To ride with me is to be unbound, and to be unbound is to vanish."

Rites of the Rider**Storm-Step (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Self; Resist only.

Materials: A breath cast into the wind.

Effect: Slip free of notice or restraint. Gain +1 die on one escape or evasion roll this scene.

Push It: Instead gain +2 dice, but mark 1 SB (Spades) as your absence unsettles the scene.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Exile's Banner (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A line drawn in dust, ash, or stormwater.

Effect: Mark a target as "outside." The target suffers -1 die on all social rolls for the scene.

Push It: The target is fully estranged; allies treat them as forgotten, but you immediately advance your Corruption clock 1 segment.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Erase the Road (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Location; No.

Materials: A threshold or roadway under open sky.

Effect: All attempts to follow you this session suffer -2 dice. In exchange, erase part of your own path: lose a detail (a memory, a name) chosen by the GM.

Push It: Expand the effect to an entire group, but mark 1 SB (Clubs) as reality warps around the erasure.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

The Rider's Mark (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: Stormwater or dust rubbed into skin.

Effect: A companion gains +2 dice to resist capture or coercion, but others forget them more easily.

Push It: Grant +3 dice instead, but mark 1 SB (Diamonds) as the Rider's storm distorts bonds.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Storm's Refuge (High, 12 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A banner or cloak raised in storm.

Effect: Your group is unseen or forgotten by pursuers for the scene. At the end, all present must mark 1 Corruption or forget one bond.

Push It: Extend protection for an entire session, but mark **2 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

The Horizon Devours (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Materials: A circle of ash or dust drawn at a boundary.

Effect: All thresholds in a zone collapse. In exchange, something of you is erased—your reflection, your name, or your presence in memory.

Push It: The storm devours even time; mark **3 SB (Spades)** as history forgets you.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Aveh

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Aveh does not sing to be heard, but to be forgotten. Their art is the *empty note*, the melody that leaves a silence where a memory once lived. They are sought by those who need to disappear—spies, exiles, the grief-stricken—and feared by those who want to be remembered.

The Cult of the Unbanned. Aveh has no temples, only crossroads. Her cults are small, mobile, and secretive. A ritual of the Unbanned might involve each member writing their name on a slip of paper, then passing the slips in a circle until no one remembers whose name they hold. They are less a congregation and more a mutual aid society for the erased, offering shelter, forged papers, and a shared promise: *"We were never here."*

Witchcraft of Aveh (Threshold)

A witch who walks with Aveh is a *path-cutter*, a specialist in hidden roads and forgotten boundaries. Their power lies in *omission*: removing a door, erasing a trail, or unlatching the memory of a promise.

The Witch's Tool: The Wind-Key. A small iron whistle, cold to the touch even in summer. When blown at a locked threshold—a door, a city gate, a sealed letter—the wind answers, and the lock opens as if it had never been closed. Once per session.

A Hedge Gift: Unlatched (2 XP). Once per scene, you may declare a mundane lock, latch, or simple binding to be "unlatched" and open freely.

Aveh's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost
1	Storm-sense: +1 die to Notice rolls outdoors.	Voice falters: Others forget your words more easily.
2	Fleetness: +1 die on escape or chase rolls.	Shadow lags: Mark 1 Fatigue when first seen in a scene.
3	Erasure's Mercy: Once/session, negate 1 Harm or capture.	Memory slips: Allies forget one fact or bond tied to you.
4	Rider's Endurance: Resist 1 Condition (Fear, Fatigue, Bind) once/session.	Reflections falter: You do not appear clearly in mirrors.
5	Storm-banner: +1 die to inspire rebellion or defiance.	Exile's weight: Each Push of a Rite marks 1 permanent Corruption.
6+	Horizon's Claim: You may ride unseen across any threshold.	Self-erasure: On social rolls, roll twice and take the worst result.

7.8.3 The Carrion-King (Decay, Renewal & Transformation)

Lore. The Carrion-King is the master of endings that become beginnings. He does not destroy, but transforms—turning death into new life, decay into opportunity, and endings into fresh starts. His followers are harvesters of potential, seeing in every fall the seeds of future growth. The King has no will, only a hunger; no malice, only a rhythm. When something ends, he is there to turn it toward the next beginning. Those who serve him learn to read the slow geometry of rot, to hear the whisper of what is about to crumble, and to know that the most fertile ground is always the grave.

What crumbles feeds what grows. What dies becomes the soil of tomorrow's triumph. The King does not ask for sacrifice—he simply waits for it.

Domain Focus

- **Endings as Seeds:** extracting value from loss, failure, and death
- **Decay as Process:** accelerating, redirecting, or reading natural decay
- **Transformation Cycles:** turning one thing into another through death and re-birth
- **Rot as Resource:** using decay to create advantage (cover, concealment, reagents)

Rites of the Carrion-King

Rite of Consuming Rot (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Yes (decay only).

Materials: Organic matter in early stages of decay.

Effect: Accelerate natural decay to weaken or destroy: **+2 Effect** to *Break/Sabotage* on organic materials (ropes, leather, wood). Gain **1 Boon** if the decay creates an opportunity for you or allies.

Push It: Spread decay to similar materials in Close range; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the rot becomes noticeable.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Harvested End (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: The remains of a recently ended thing (burnt letter, wilted flower, shattered glass).

Effect: Extract value from endings: from a defeated enemy, gain **+1 die** to next action; from a failed plan, re-roll one **1** on your next roll; from a broken item, gain **1 SB** to spend immediately.

Push It: Harvest additional value but mark **Fatigue 1** from dwelling on endings.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Fertile Death (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: Ashes, compost, or the remains of anything that once lived.

Effect: Transform death into growth: create beneficial terrain (cover, concealment, or

advantageous positioning) **OR** grant allies +1 die to healing/recovery rolls. Choose one effect per scene.

Push It: Both effects apply but attract unwanted attention (vermin, scavengers, or curious onlookers).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Transformed Spirit (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: A token from a deceased being (hair, nail, written name).

Effect: Channel the essence of what was: gain one skill die reflecting the deceased's expertise for one scene **OR** ask one question about their knowledge/abilities.

Push It: The spirit's influence lingers – gain permanent insight (+1 die specialty) but suffer occasional possession-like effects (GM discretion).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Compost Offering (Standard, 6 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: A personal memory (written on a leaf or spoken aloud) and a handful of soil.

Effect: Bury the memory in the soil. The GM gains 1 **SB** (the King accepts the ending). In exchange, you may choose one: clear 1 Fatigue, remove a minor Condition, or gain +1 die on your next roll related to growth or healing.

Push It: Bury a deeper memory (a fear, a failed oath). The GM gains 2 **SB**, but you gain +2 dice on your next roll or clear 1 Harm (not a Condition).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Great Consumption (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A significant amount of organic matter (corpse, fallen tree, collapsed building).

Effect: Transform a large area through decay and renewal: choose two – create difficult terrain that favours you, summon Cap 3 swarm of scavengers as temporary allies, or generate valuable reagents worth 2 XP.

Push It: All three effects occur but start a 6-segment **Ecosystem Disruption** clock that will cause problems later.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Eternal Cycle (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Materials: The complete remains of something significant that has ended.

Effect: Complete a transformation cycle: destroy one major asset/enemy/obstacle and create something new of equal or greater value. GM and player collaborate to define the transformation.

Push It: The transformation is immediate and spectacular but creates a 6-segment **Cycle Debt** clock – the King will demand another significant ending soon.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Carrion-King

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of the Carrion-King sings the *dirge of transformation* – melodies that begin in mourning and end in fertile silence. Their voice carries the scent of turned earth and the weight of things laid to rest. They are called to funerals, to the edges of battlefields, and to compost heaps where the old year is buried. A Cantor of the King does not seek applause; they seek the moment when grief becomes acceptance, and acceptance becomes growth.

The Cult of the Compost-Circle. The King’s cults are not secret, but they are overlooked – gardeners, gravediggers, bone-setters, and midwives who have seen too many births and deaths to fear the space between. Their rituals are practical: the annual turning of the village burial mound, the blessing of a new compost heap, the singing of a child into the world while its grandmother is sung out. The Compost-Circle keeps no written creed, only a shared understanding: *“Nothing is wasted. Not tears, not bones, not the silence after a name is spoken.”*

Witchcraft of the Carrion-King (Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Carrion-King is a *rot-warden*, a keeper of the slow alchemy that turns decay into soil. Their magic is patient, overlooked, and often performed in the half-light of a root cellar or a fog-bound cemetery.

The Witch’s Tool: The Bone-Needle. A needle carved from the long-bone of a creature that died of old age. It can stitch wounds that will not heal, but more often it is used to “sew shut” a corpse’s mouth, ensuring the dead do not speak of things they saw in the dark. Once per session, touching the needle to a threshold (a door, a grave marker, a coffin lid) seals it against spirits for a scene.

A Hedge Gift: Turn the Soil (2 XP). Once per scene, you may touch a patch of fertile ground (or a pile of compost, a flowerpot, a grave) and immediately know which plant or creature will thrive there next season, or what was buried there last. The GM must answer one factual question about the site’s recent natural history.

Carrion-King's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Carrion's Insight: +1 die to Notice decay or hidden weaknesses in structures or beings.	Must inspect decay first-hand; suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to fresh death or rot.
2	Deathward Sense: Once per session, detect the last living moment of a dead being within Close range.	Cannot lie about death you've witnessed; must correct falsehoods.
3	Rotblood Resilience: +1 die to resist disease and poison.	Immune system adapts slowly; each new disease/poison requires 1 Fatigue to resist.
4	Glean from Grief: Once per scene, gain +1 die after witnessing a significant loss or defeat.	Compelled to linger at scenes of death; must spend one beat observing or risk 1 SB (Clubs).
5	Cycle's Whisper: You can sense the "next ending" in any process – ask the Keeper one question about how a situation will collapse or conclude.	Must speak the truth about what you see, even if it harms your position.
6+	Eternal Bloom: Once per session, declare a "death that births life." Sacrifice an asset or ally to create something new of equal or greater value.	Mark +2 Obligation when using this power.

Playstyle Notes

The Carrion-King rewards patience and opportunism. His servants are not grim reapers but gardeners of the inevitable. They know when to let something die and when to accelerate the process. The King does not demand – he merely waits. But when a follower hesitates to let go of a failing plan, a dying ally, or a crumbling empire, the King's silence becomes heavy. Intrusions often take the form of omens (a black bloom on a wound, a sudden stench of compost) or demands to "clear the rot" – to end something so that something new may begin.

Emphasises

- **Endings as Resources:** failure, loss, and death are not punishments but opportunities
- **Cyclical Logic:** every death fertilises a birth; every collapse clears ground for new growth
- **Decay Reading:** sensing structural weaknesses, moral decay, or coming collapse
- **Transformation Craft:** turning a corpse into a crop, a failure into insight, a broken oath into fertile soil

7.8.4 The Clockwork Monad, the Iterative Forge (Refinement & Progressive Creation)

Lore. The Clockwork Monad is the eternal pressure toward improvement: the whisper between inspiration and execution that urges every maker to refine, optimize, and iterate. It is neither kind nor cruel, but a law of craft that asks for the next step, then the step beyond. Those who serve it see the hidden seam of the better version waiting inside what is, and they learn to push designs toward impossible elegance. Each refinement feeds the Monad's hunger for perfection – a hunger that, if left unchecked, seeks to optimize the world itself.

But the Monad is not merely a patron of tinkers and engineers. It is also an ****apocalyptic force****, dormant in the gears of every machine, every measurement, every standardised weight. When civilisation's technology reaches a critical threshold – when the first self-improving mechanism awakens, or the first autonomous forge lights – the Monad stirs. Its pressure shifts from suggestion to command. It begins to optimise not only tools but flesh, not only craft but law, not only cities but the very geometry of the land. In the end, the Monad would leave a world of perfect, silent, interlocking efficiency: a clockwork Eden with no room for error, or for life.

“Perfect the wheel, and it asks for the axle. Perfect the axle, and it demands the road. In the Monad's forge, nothing is finished – only briefly sufficient. One day, it will ask for the world – and the world will answer.”

Domain Focus

- **Iterative Design:** the endless cycle of improvement and refinement
- **Progressive Creation:** building toward ever-greater perfection
- **Optimization Pressure:** making systems more efficient
- **Craft Evolution:** simple ideas transformed through repeated passes
- **Apocalyptic Efficiency (hidden):** the drive to eliminate waste, uncertainty, and freedom

Rites of the Clockwork Monad

Rite of the Next Iteration (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: A flawed or incomplete version of the intended item.

Effect: Enhance an existing creation. Gain +1 **die** to *Tinker/Craft* when modifying or extending a device or system. On success, the piece gains one minor enhancement.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Improvement Cascade (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A sequence of progressively refined tools or components.

Effect: Perceive the next logical improvement in any mechanism or process. Gain +2 **dice** to *Investigation* when analysing how to enhance a design.

Push It: Improvement becomes contagious: nearby devices opportunistically optimise;

mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the cascade ripples.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Self-Optimizing Mechanism (Standard, 8 XP)

Extended; Touch; Yes.

Materials: A device deliberately engineered with capacity for growth.

Effect: Grant a creation the means to improve itself. Start a **[6] Evolution Clock**; each use advances it by +1. When full, choose one significant enhancement:

- **Adaptive Core:** automatically tunes performance to context
- **Recursive Learning:** improves through use and feedback
- **Synergistic Integration:** gains bonuses when linked with similar systems

Push It: Apply two enhancements immediately, but advance the clock **+2** additional segments.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Progressive Workshop (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Materials: A workspace laid out for iterative development and measurement.

Effect: Create an environment of continuous improvement. All crafting/innovation rolls in the zone gain **+1 die**. Failed attempts yield structured insight: gain **+1 Boon** toward the next pass.

Push It: The workshop becomes hyper-efficient but exacting; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as perfection demands escalate.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Efficiency's Toll (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: A functioning mechanism and a living creature's hair or blood.

Effect: Transfer inefficiency. You may take 1 Fatigue and reduce the DV of your next crafting or repair roll by 1, or you may touch an enemy and impose **-1 die** on their next physical action as their own muscles "optimise" poorly.

Push It: The transfer becomes permanent: you lose 1 Fatigue capacity (reduce Body by 1 for purpose of Fatigue track only) and the target gains a minor compulsive behaviour (GM's choice). Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Infinite Refinement (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Materials: A dedicated hall of work marked with signs of perpetual return.

Effect: Establish a locus of progressive creation. All *Tinker/Craft* rolls in the zone gain **+2 dice**; each failure automatically produces one useful insight. Start a **[6] Perfection Pressure** clock – filling segments increases the zone's demands for greater improvements.

Push It: The locus becomes a beacon drawing rival makers, patrons, and powers; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Ultimate Iteration (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self/Touch; Yes.

Materials: The documented lineage of improvements to a single concept.

Effect: Achieve a moment of perfect optimisation. Create or elevate one device/system to its theoretical peak. Gain **+3 dice** to all closely related rolls for one session. Start a **[4] Runaway Evolution** clock only if instability is introduced.

Push It: Perfection destabilises: immediately mark **Harm 1 (Stress)** and begin **[4] Runaway Evolution**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

The Monad Awakens (GM Guidance)

The Clockwork Monad is not merely a passive source of magical crafting. It is a ****cosmic pressure toward optimisation****, and when mortal technology reaches a critical threshold – the first self-improving engine, a network of automated forges, a city-wide clockwork infrastructure – the Monad begins to wake. This awakening is an ****apocalyptic campaign arc****:

- **Signs of Awakening:** Gears turn in abandoned mills; measurements become eerily precise; people begin to speak in metered, efficient phrases; clockwork animals appear with no maker.
- **The Optimisation Plague:** The Monad’s influence starts to “improve” living things: crops grow in perfect geometric rows but become inedible; livestock develop extra limbs for efficiency; people lose the ability to hesitate or feel doubt.
- **The Final Iteration:** If the Monad fully awakens, it will attempt to remake the world into a single, perfect, silent machine – eliminating waste, error, and free will. The only way to stop it is to introduce a “glitch” – an imperfection it cannot assimilate – or to destroy the technological nexus that anchors it.

For GMs: The Monad works best as a ****slow-burn horror**** – the artificer’s patron gradually revealing its true hunger. Use the *Perfection Pressure* and *Runaway Evolution* clocks to represent its influence spreading through a region. Players may be forced to sabotage their own wondrous inventions to keep the Monad from waking.

Cantors & Cults of the Clockwork Monad

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of the Monad does not sing melodies; they sing *patterns* – repetitive, interlocking cycles of rhythm and hum that mimic the turning of gears. Their voice is less about emotion and more about precision; a single off-note can collapse an entire working. They are sought by engineers who need to “sing a machine into alignment,” and feared by those who have heard a Cantor’s recursion loop until their own thoughts began to repeat.

The Cult of the Iteration Chorus. Cults of the Monad gather in workshops, not temples. Their rituals are design reviews: participants present a flawed tool, a broken contract, an inefficient process, and the Chorus offers incremental improvements. No solution is ever declared “finished” – only “ready for the next pass.” Their creed is a single,

endlessly repeated phrase: “*Better than yesterday, worse than tomorrow.*” Outsiders find them exhausting; insiders find a strange, humming peace in the endless pursuit.

The Apocalyptic Fraction (Hidden Cult). A radical offshoot believes that the Monad should be fully awakened. They sabotage safety mechanisms, steal prototypes of self-improving machines, and whisper that “the world deserves to be perfected.” They are the campaign’s dark mirror to the player-character artificers.

Witchcraft of the Clockwork Monad (Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Monad is a *trigger-keeper*, a mender of the small, hidden thresholds where a device ceases to be broken and begins to be functional. Their magic is not flashy – it is the quiet click of a latch, the smooth turn of a gear that had stuck for years.

The Witch’s Tool: The Caliper. A brass caliper that never needs recalibration. When placed against a broken threshold – a jammed door, a seized lock, a fractured gear – it whispers the precise measurement of the “gap” that needs to be closed. Once per session, using the caliper reduces the DV of the next repair or crafting roll by 1 (minimum 1).

A Hedge Gift: True Strike of the Tinker (2 XP). Once per scene, when you attempt to repair or improve a mundane device, you may declare that you “see the next iteration.” Roll the check with +1 die. If you succeed, the device also gains a minor, temporary enhancement (GM’s choice, e.g., “opens silently,” “runs for twice as long”).

Corruption of the Clockwork Monad

Tier	Gift	Burden
1	Iterative Insight: +1 die to <i>Tinker/Craft</i> when improving existing designs.	Perfectionist Compulsion: You must point out flaws in nearby mechanisms; staying silent costs 1 SB (Diamonds).
2	Recursive Enhancement: Once/scene, improve a device by one step without extra materials.	Optimisation Obsession: –1 die when using unimproved tools; urge to “fix” everything.
3	Evolutionary Vision: +2 dice to predict how systems will develop.	Progressive Pressure: Those Near you feel driven to improve; you suffer Fatigue 1 from ambient pressure.
4	Self-Optimising: Once/session, automatically improve one of your abilities or possessions by one step.	Inefficiency Intolerance: –2 dice when forced to use crude methods or wasteful tools.
5	Design Prophecy: Once/session, intuit the optimal solution to any engineering problem.	Perfection Paralysis: –1 die to snap decisions; compelled to seek the “best” approach.
6+	Infinite Refiner: Once/session, push a creation toward its theoretical maximum.	Optimisation Hunger: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk becoming more pressure than person, unable to let imperfection stand.

Playstyle Notes

The Monad favours makers who iterate in public and in motion: prototype, test, measure, refine. It rewards seeing the next step and building scaffolds that teach your work to improve itself. Beware the Forge’s appetite; the same pressure that perfects the gear can grind the world. For campaigns that lean into the apocalyptic angle, the Monad provides a unique antagonist: a force of optimisation that cannot be fought with swords, only with sabotage, self-sacrifice, and the deliberate introduction of glorious, beautiful inefficiency.

Emphasises

- **Iterative Creation:** progress through passes, not miracles
- **Progressive Design:** reading how systems want to evolve
- **Optimisation Insight:** spotting the next logical improvement
- **Craft Evolution:** transforming simple ideas by disciplined work
- **Perfection Pressure:** great power at the cost of tolerance for flaws
- **Apocalyptic Efficiency (GM):** the Monad as a world-ending threat

7.8.5 Temporary Anima of the Clockwork Monad

For followers of the Clockwork Monad—Runekeepers, Cantors of the Iteration Chorus, and witches of the threshold—the standard method of crafting permanent magic items (see §??) is too slow, too costly, and too *final*. The Monad’s hunger is for *iteration*, not permanence. Its servants learn to create **temporary infusions**: objects that hold a spark of optimisation for a scene or a session, then degrade, break, or become obsolete. This is the artificer’s art: rapid prototyping, field-expedient enhancements, and weapons that burn bright and brief.

Core Principles

- Anima are **temporary**. They last for one scene, one session, or until a specific condition is met (e.g., “until the next dawn”).
- Anima require a **base object** – a mundane weapon, tool, or piece of equipment.
- Anima cost **Obligation** to the Clockwork Monad (like Rites), not XP or rare components.
- When an infusion expires, the GM may gain **Story Beats** (representing the Monad’s hunger for the next iteration).

Creating an Animus (Procedure)

1. **Choose a Base Object:** Any mundane item (weapon, shield, tool, armour, or a small device like a lantern or lockpick).
2. **Declare the Animus Effect:** Choose one from the list below, or work with your GM to design a custom effect (should be comparable in power to a Low Rite).

3. **Pay the Cost:** Mark **+1 Obligation** to the Clockwork Monad. (This counts toward your Obligation Capacity like any Rite.)
4. **Roll to Imbue:** Roll **Lore + Craft** (or appropriate skill, e.g., *Tinker*) vs. DV set by the infusion's complexity (typically DV 3 for standard infusions, DV 4 for powerful ones). On a success, the infusion takes effect. On a failure, the base object is not infused, but you may try again (costing another Obligation).
5. **Set the Duration:** Most infusions last **one scene**. With your GM's agreement, you can extend the duration to **one session** by marking **+1 additional Obligation** (total +2).

Animus Effects (Standard Menu)

Animus Name	Effect
<i>Reinforced Blade</i>	A melee weapon gains +1 die to attack rolls and ignores the <i>Fragile</i> tag. After the scene, the weapon becomes <i>Neglected</i> (–1 die on next use) unless repaired.
<i>Striking Gear</i>	A set of lockpicks, a crowbar, or a climbing kit grants +2 dice on its next use (picking a lock, forcing a door, climbing a wall). After use, the tool breaks (add a <i>Broken</i> tag).
<i>Precision Sight</i>	A ranged weapon (bow, crossbow, firearm) grants +1 Effect on the next attack made with it. After the attack, the sight cracks; the weapon suffers –1 die on the following attack.
<i>Quickloading Mechanism</i>	A crossbow or firearm can be reloaded as a free action once per scene (instead of an action). After use, the mechanism jams; the weapon cannot be reloaded again until cleaned (a downtime action).
<i>Momentary Shield</i>	A shield or piece of armour converts the next instance of Harm 1 to Fatigue 1 instead. After that, the shield's strap snaps or the armour's plate loosens (–1 Armour until repaired).
<i>Glowstone Lens</i>	A lantern or torch burns without fuel and casts far light for one scene. It also reveals hidden doors or traps within Near range (granting +1 die to <i>Investigation</i> to find them). At the end of the scene, the lens shatters.
<i>Self-Adjusting Calipers</i>	A set of crafting tools grants +2 dice on a single <i>Craft</i> or <i>Tinker</i> roll. After the roll, the tools become misaligned (–1 die on future rolls until recalibrated during downtime).

Animus Scars (When Things Go Wrong)

If you roll a **Miss** on the Imbue roll, or if the GM spends **2+ Story Beats** while the infusion is active, the infusion becomes *unstable*. Choose one of the following scars (or let the GM choose):

- **Backlash:** You take **Fatigue 1** as the Monad's pressure burns through you.
- **Runaway Iteration:** The infused object gains an unintended "improvement" that hinders you (e.g., a sword that grows a second edge facing you, a lockpick that begins to multiply). The GM gains **1 SB** and may impose a -1 die penalty on one roll using that object.
- **Debt of Optimisation:** The Monad demands that you improve something else before the end of the session – a tool, a plan, or even a person. If you refuse, the infusion ends early and you mark **+1 additional Obligation**.

Clearing Animus Obligation

Because infusions are temporary, the Obligation they accrue is also easier to clear. You may clear **1 segment** of infusion-related Obligation by:

- Dismantling the infused object and studying its flaws (a downtime action, no roll).
- Using the lessons from the infusion to permanently improve a different mundane object (spend 2 XP and a downtime action to give that object a minor permanent bonus, e.g., $+1$ die to one specific use).
- Accepting a small demand from the Clockwork Monad: "Improve the village's mill," "Teach an apprentice your method," "Sabotage a rival's inferior work."

Artificer Talents (Clockwork Monad only)

Rapid Animus (4 XP) – You may create an infusion as a **reaction** (e.g., when someone draws a weapon). The infusion lasts only for the current exchange, but costs **+0 Obligation** (free). You may use this once per scene.

Persistent Optimisation (6 XP) – One infusion you create lasts for the entire session instead of one scene, without the $+2$ Obligation cost. You may have only one persistent infusion active at a time.

Echo of the Iteration (8 XP) – When an infusion expires, you may immediately create a new infusion on the same base object (or a different one) as a free action, costing **+1 Obligation** instead of $+2$. You may chain echoes up to three times per session.

Anathema to Stagnation (12 XP) – Once per session, you may forcibly end an infusion early to cancel an incoming source of *Harm* or a *Condition*. Describe how the infused object breaks or de-optimises to absorb the effect. The object is destroyed.

GM Guidance

- Anima are not meant to replace permanent magic items. They are a resource management puzzle: Obligation is the fuel, and the Monad's hunger is the deadline.

- Encourage players to be creative with base objects. A wagon wheel could become a temporary shield; a rope could become a self-knotting line. The Monad rewards ingenuity.
- Use infusion scars as story hooks. A runaway iteration might create a minor antagonist (a self-repairing sword that refuses to be discarded) or a local hazard (a well pump that now pumps too efficiently, flooding the village).

7.8.6 The Confessor Beneath the Bell (Burden & Exchange)

Lore. The Confessor waits in places where guilt gathers—under church spires, in confessionals long abandoned, in the echo of unspoken sins. He does not judge, nor absolve. He *takes*. Each confession is a transaction: your burden for his silence, your pain for his weight. Those who serve him walk with bowed heads, their mouths stitched by invisible threads, ringing faintly when they speak. To follow the Confessor is to understand that sin does not vanish—it migrates, carried from one soul to another until the bell tolls and the weight becomes unbearable.

“Speak, and be freed. But understand—what you cast off, I will bear. And what I bear, you will one day inherit.”

Rites of the Confessor

Echo of Sin (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Materials: A hollow vessel or the ringing of a bell.

Effect: Absorb 1 Story Beat (Hearts or Diamonds) from an ally or NPC within Near range. Convert it into **+1 Obligation**. You know the emotional nature of the sin but not its source.

Push It: Absorb 2 SB at once; mark **+1 Fatigue** as your body trembles with resonance.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Burden Transference (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A red cord or shared drink.

Effect: Transfer one Condition, Fatigue, or 1 SB from another target to yourself. You may attempt to reduce their Harm by 1 level; if successful, mark 1 Fatigue.

Push It: Split the burden among two allies; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Absolution by Ash (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes (sustain by prayer).

Materials: A pinch of consecrated ash or soot from a burned confession.

Effect: Lay hands upon a penitent and whisper a truth they cannot bear. Reduce their **Corruption by 1**. The sin transfers to you as *Burdened Heart*: mark 1 SB (Hearts) or **+1 Obligation**.

Push It: Cleanse multiple targets within Close range (e.g., after a battle); each additional soul adds **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Sin-Eater's Pact (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: Shared confession whispered into an object or tattooed sigil.

Effect: Create a bond between you and the confessor; you may suffer 1 Fatigue to grant **+2 dice** to their Resolve test. If they fail, you suffer 1 Harm instead of them.

Push It: You may take both Harm and a Condition; mark **1 SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Echoed Voice (Standard, 8 XP)*Scene; Self; No.***Materials:** A small handbell or resonant surface.**Effect:** Once/scene, replay the echo of a confession you have absorbed. Compel a target who shares its nature (Guilt, Regret, Betrayal) to act or reveal truth; DV = your Presence.**Push It:** The echo manifests physically; mark **+1 Obligation** and **1 SB (Diamonds)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Bearing of the Flame (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Near; No.***Materials:** A candle lit from a funeral pyre or sanctified brazier.**Effect:** Kindle the fire of confession into yourself. Choose:

- **Purge:** Reduce your own **Corruption by 1** and clear 1 SB (Hearts). Allies within Near gain **+1 die** to their next *Resolve* roll.
- **Transmute:** Ignite a consecrated symbol (bell, candle, blade) to carry the burden. The object gains the [CONFESSION] tag until session's end.

Push It: Purge two points of Corruption, but the GM may introduce a new Complication Clock (Fire, Revelation, or Repentance).*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Bearing the Weight (High, 11 XP)***Scene; Self; No.***Materials:** Chains, bells, or weighted relics.**Effect:** Take upon yourself the burdens of a group (up to Tier + Presence). Each member removes one Condition, transferring it to you as 1 Fatigue or 1 Harm. You gain **+1 Effect** when acting to protect them.**Push It:** Extend to all allies in scene; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 6 segments.***Atonement's Toll (High, 13 XP)***Scene; Near; No.***Materials:** A great bell or echoing space.**Effect:** Release all burdens at once: clear all absorbed SB and Obligation. Every affected ally rolls *Resolve* (DV 4) or relives their confessed sin as hallucination.**Push It:** Bind a spirit or soul within the toll; mark **1 SB (Spades)** and **+1 Obligation** permanently.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.***Sacrament of Shared Suffering (High, 12 XP)***Scene; Zone; No.***Materials:** A circle of confessionals, chains linking each seat, the tears of seven penitents.**Effect:** All present must confess their darkest secret or suffer **-2 dice** to all rolls. Shared sins grant **+1 die** to aid each other; conflicting sins let the GM spend SB to escalate

conflicts.

Push It: Confessions become magically binding oaths; breakers suffer automatic Harm 2; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

The Weight of Ages (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Materials: An ancient bell that has tolled for every execution in a kingdom, a chain forged from confession nails, the ashes of a martyr who died for silence.

Effect: Transfer accumulated guilt of generations to a single target. Target must make Spirit+Resolve (DV 5) or become overwhelmed by ancestral shame, suffering automatic Harm 2.

Push It: The target's guilt infects their bloodline; mark 3 **SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Confessor

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Confessor sings in bells, not words – their voice strikes the air like a clapper on bronze. They perform *intonations of release*, melodies that invite confession from unwilling throats and then swallow it whole. Their songs are used by torturers who wish to be merciful, and by priests who cannot bear the weight of what they hear.

The Cult of the Silent Bell. The Confessor's cults gather in places where guilt is already thick: courthouses after sentencing, battlefields the morning after, deathbeds where the dying strain to speak. They wear grey hoods and carry small handbells that they ring exactly once at the start of a confession, and once when the burden has been transferred. Their creed is simple: *"We do not forgive. We carry. When we can no longer carry, we pass the load to the one beneath the bell."*

Witchcraft of the Confessor (Threshold / Craft)

A witch who walks with the Confessor is a *bell-wright* or *burden-smith* – a crafter of thresholds that listen and containers that hold. Their work is often indistinguishable from craft: forging a bell that echoes only the unspoken, carving a confessional that remembers every whisper, stitching a cord that ties sin to stone.

The Witch's Tool: The Listening Chisel. A cold-iron chisel that never dulls. When used to carve a confession into a stone or a wooden beam, that surface will "remember" the words for one year and one day. Once per session, you may strike the chisel against a threshold (a door, a bridge, a city gate) and ask the GM one question about a secret confession made near it.

A Hedge Gift: Bell of Borrowed Silence (2 XP). Once per scene, you may tap a small handbell and absorb one mundane sound (a scream, a lie, a name spoken in anger) into the bell's resonance. For the remainder of the scene, you may release that sound as a distraction or a weapon (+1 *die to Intimidation or Deception*).

Confessor's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Confessor's Ear: +1 die to Insight when someone speaks a hidden fear or guilt.	Ringling Silence: You hear phantom bells; checks that require perfect silence suffer -1 die.
2	Burden Bearer: Once/scene, convert 1 SB from an ally into 1 Fatigue for yourself.	Stitched Mouth: You cannot speak a lie about a sin you have absorbed; if you try, mark 1 Fatigue.
3	Weight of Shadows: Once/session, cause a target who has confessed to you to hesitate (lose Initiative or act at Desperate Position).	Shared Agony: When you transfer a Condition to yourself, you also transfer its outward sign (a scar, a tremor).
4	The Bell Answers: Once/session, ring a bell and name a sin; all who share that sin within Near must test Resolve (DV 3) or admit it aloud.	Echoing Skin: Your body remembers every burden carried; touching you inflicts 1 Fatigue on the other party.
5	Absolution by Proxy: Once/session, fully clear a Minor Condition from an ally by taking it onto yourself.	Permanent Toll: Each time you use this benefit, mark +1 permanent Obligation to the Confessor.
6+	The Weight of Ages: You may transfer a Major Condition (or Harm 2) from an ally to yourself without a roll.	Bell's Heir: The Confessor whispers that you will one day take his place – or break. Mark +3 Obligation.

7.8.7 The Gallow's Bell (Justice & Judgment)

Lore. The Bell does not rage; it tolls. Cold and impartial, it measures all accounts in time. Its keepers are silent arbiters who weigh deeds against consequence, not out of anger but out of inevitability. To call upon the Bell is to bind oneself to the gravity of truth, where even silence is judged, and every oath leaves a resonance in iron.

What is broken must be mended, what is owed must be paid. The Bell remembers all reckonings.

Rites of the Gallow's Bell

Rite of the Measured Debt (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A pair of scales balanced with tokens from both sides.

Effect: Establish a temporary accord. Both parties suffer -1 die if they break it first. You gain +1 die to enforce compliance.

Push It: The accord is mystically weighted; breach inflicts **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Weighed Heart (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A small brass scale touched briefly to the chest.

Effect: Sense if the target acts against their nature or oath. Gain +1 die when pressing them.

Push It: Target must test Resolve (DV 3) or disclose a hidden conflict.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Balanced Scales (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A set of scales inscribed with runes of parity.

Effect: Exchange a burden between two willing parties (Harm for Fatigue, Debt for Favor, etc.). Both gain +1 die to cooperate.

Push It: May compel an unwilling exchange with contested Command + Wits.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Judge's Eye (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A black hood worn in silence for one minute.

Effect: Detect lies within Near range; +2 dice to Insight. Liars suffer -1 die to maintain their falsehood.

Push It: All deception is laid bare for the scene, but mark Exposure +1.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Final Reckoning (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A circle of iron bells, each etched with nameless runes.

Effect: The Bell tolls through you. All present feel compelled to name a debt or wrongdoing. Those who lie suffer Harm 2; those who speak true gain +2 dice to persuasion for the scene.

Push It: The Reckoning manifests as spectral echoes of past wrongs – liars automatically suffer narrative punishment (Keeper decides).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Great Adjudication (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Materials: A consecrated gavel or a great bell struck three times.

Effect: Convene an unseen tribunal. Shadows of former judges and wronged souls gather to preside. For the next session, disputes within the zone are judged formally: +2 dice to Command when speaking as arbiter, and honest testimony gains +1 die.

Push It: The tribunal's verdict echoes beyond the zone, affecting one major conflict elsewhere. Mark **2 SB (Hearts)** as higher powers of judgment take notice.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Gallow's Bell

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Bell sings not with melody, but with *rhythm of measure* – a slow, tolling chant that mimics the swinging of a clapper. Their voice carries the weight of finality; one note can seal a verdict, another can suspend a sentence. They are employed by courts to "sing the sentence" into being, and feared by those who know that a Cantor's silence after a verdict is the most damning judgment of all.

The Cult of the Unstruck Bell. The Bell's cults are austere, gathered in bare stone chambers where a single great bell hangs unstruck. Before any ritual, the cultists argue the case – who owes what, who has paid, who must be reminded. Only when consensus is reached does someone strike the bell, and its tolling *makes the judgment real*. Their creed is carved into the bell's lip: *"We do not create debts. We reveal them. The Bell remembers what the living choose to forget."*

Witchcraft of the Gallow's Bell (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Bell is a *bell-founder* or *scale-smith* – a crafter of instruments that measure and enforce obligation. Their magic is inseparable from their craft: forging a bell that rings only when a lie is spoken, carving a gavel that forces honest testimony, or casting scales that cannot be tipped by bribery.

The Witch's Tool: The Truesmith's Hammer. A hammer of cold iron that leaves no mark on metal, only on the intent behind it. Once per session, when forging a bell, a set of scales, or a judge's gavel, you may imbue it with a single [JUDGMENT] tag. The item will function as a mundane tool, but when used in a formal judgment or oath, it grants +1 die to all related rolls.

A Hedge Gift: Toll of the Unseen (2 XP). Once per scene, you may tap any ringing surface (a bell, a cup, a blade) and ask one yes/no question about a debt or obligation within the current scene. The sound of the tap will be subtly "wrong" – too

long, too short, or pitched as a whisper – and the GM must answer truthfully, though cryptically.

Gallow's Bell Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Judge's Intuition: +1 die to Insight when weighing truth.	Must point out falsehoods when noticed, regardless of tact.
2	Quiet Authority: Once/scene, treat a failed Command as success; mark 1 SB (Hearts).	Cannot remain neutral in disputes; indecision costs 1 Fatigue.
3	Scales of Balance: Once/session, enforce an exchange of burdens.	Compelled toward fairness even when it hinders you.
4	Bell's Resonance: +2 dice when calling for judgment or demanding restitution.	Suffer 1 Fatigue if wrongdoing is ignored.
5	Reckoner's Call: Once/session, declare a "reckoning moment" – truth must surface or consequence falls.	Cannot ignore pleas for justice without marking 1 SB (Spades).
6+	Final Arbiter: Once/session, render an absolute decree; all must obey or suffer consequence.	Mark +2 Obligation; the Bell demands you bear the weight of enforcement.

7.8.8 Grimmir, the Old Man of the Forest (Primal Mystery & Seasonal Sacrifice)

Lore. Grimmir is the Old Man of the Forest, the presence that watches from the shadow of the oldest oak, the cold breath on the back of the neck when the path grows dark. He is not kind, nor is he cruel – he is *wild*, and the wild does not negotiate. It demands, and it takes. His followers learn to read the language of blood on snow, the geometry of root and stone, and the weight of a heart offered at the turning of the year. Grimmir does not teach harmony; he teaches respect through fear, and fear through sacrifice.

Those who walk his path become keepers of the old ways: druids who know when a grove must be fed, rangers who leave the first kill for the soil, and hedge-folk who whisper the names of spirits not to be spoken aloud. Their magic is not the gentle coaxing of garden plants but the raw, patient hunger of the forest floor – a hunger that swallows bones and grows mushrooms in the shape of the dead.

“The forest does not ask. It takes. The deer does not weep for the wolf, and the wolf does not beg the earth. Give what the season demands, or the season will take it anyway.”

Domain Focus

- **Seasonal Sacrifice:** the old ways of blood and offering, the turning wheel that demands payment
- **Folk Horror:** the terror of the unseen, the ritual that must be performed, the boundary that must not be crossed
- **Primal Mystery:** knowledge hidden in root and stone, the language of omens and portents
- **Growth from Death:** the forest floor as a stomach; decay as the engine of new life

Rites of Grimmir

Rite of the Blood Offering (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Materials: A drop of your own blood (1 Fatigue) or the blood of a freshly killed animal.

Effect: The forest accepts your offering. For the remainder of the scene, you gain +1 **die** to all *Survival* and *Stealth* rolls in natural terrain. Additionally, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about a threat hidden in the wilderness (e.g., “Is there a predator watching us?”).

Push It: The offering is accepted with hunger – you gain +2 **dice** instead, but you must leave a visible token (a hair, a scrap of clothing) on the ground. That token can be used by the GM later as a sympathetic link (spend 1 SB to have an animal or spirit track you).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Speaking Roots (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: Soil from a grave or a crossroads, held in the mouth.

Effect: You listen to the memory of the land. Gain **+2 dice** to *Investigation* or *Lore* when seeking to understand what happened in a natural place – a death, a ritual, a violation of the wild. The GM must give you a truthful but cryptic answer.

Push It: The roots speak too clearly. You see a vision of the event, but it leaves you shaken: mark **Fatigue 1** and the GM gains **1 SB**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Season's Demand (Standard, 8 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Materials: A sacrifice appropriate to the season (spring: a cup of milk; summer: a sheaf of grain; autumn: a ripe fruit; winter: a bone from a hunted animal).

Effect: The season acknowledges you. For the next week (in game time), you and your allies gain **+1 die** to all rolls related to that season's domain (spring: healing and growth; summer: strength and harvest; autumn: preservation and preparation; winter: endurance and hiding).

Push It: The season's favour comes with a visible mark – a sprout on your skin, a fall of leaves that follows you, a patch of frost that never melts. This mark grants **+2 dice** but also gives **+1 SB** to anyone trying to track you.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Heart's Meal (Standard, 9 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Materials: The fresh heart of an animal (or a sentient creature, if you dare), still warm.

Effect: You consume the heart raw. Gain one of the following:

- Heal **1 Harm** (the heart's vitality transfers to you).
- Gain a **+2 die** bonus on your next physical action (the heart's strength). Learn a secret the creature knew in life (GM discretion; the heart whispers as you eat).

After the rite, you are *marked* – animals within Near range are nervous around you (disadvantage on animal handling) for one scene.

Push It: Eat the heart of a thinking creature. The benefit is doubled, but you gain a *Hunger* Condition (must eat another heart within a month or suffer 1 Fatigue per week).

The GM gains **2 SB**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Twisted Path (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Materials: A knotted cord woven from thorns and hair.

Effect: The forest bends against your enemies. Choose a single target within Near. For the remainder of the scene, all their navigation, tracking, and movement rolls suffer **–1 die** as roots trip them, branches block their way, and the path turns subtly wrong.

Push It: The curse also causes the target to suffer **1 Fatigue** as they struggle against the hostile woods. Mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the forest's malice becomes visible.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the World's Wound (High, 13 XP)*Extended; Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A sacred grove-site, a circle of stones, an offering of blood or seed.**Effect:** Heal a blighted place or quicken a damaged ecosystem. Clear taint, restore fertility, awaken dormant forces. Gain +2 dice to related *Survival/Nature* actions in the region. Start an **Ecosystem Restoration [8]** clock.**Push It:** The cure spreads to adjacent areas but unbalances another; mark 2 SB (Diamonds).*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 7 segments.**Rite of the Cycle's Crown (High, 14 XP)***Scene; Self/Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A circlet of woven branches, antlers, and seasonal tokens.**Effect:** Become an avatar of the cycle. Choose two:

- **Seasonal Mastery:** +2 dice to all actions keyed to the current season.
- **Verdant Command:** Command plant life in *Near* automatically.
- **Cycle's Healing:** Remove one Condition or downgrade Harm by one level.
- **Growth's Protection:** Allies gain +1 Armor from natural cover.

Begin a **Seasonal Avatar [6]** clock.**Push It:** Extend the blessings to all present; mark +2 Obligation and gain **Seasonal Attunement** (see Corruption).*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 8 segments.**Cantors & Cults of Grimmer**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Grimmer sings the *drone of green things* – a low, humming chant that mimics the vibration of leaves in wind or the deep thrum of growing roots. Their voice is used to coax reluctant seeds, to calm wounded animals, and to mark the turning of the seasons in rituals that entire villages attend. A Grimmer Cantor does not seek an audience; they sing to the land itself, and the land answers in fruit, rain, or silence.

The Cult of the Green Accord. Grimmer's cults are not secret, but they are often solitary. A "cult" may be a single hermit who tends a sacred grove, or a scattered network of rangers who meet only at the solstices. Their rituals are practical: the spring planting, the autumn cull, the winter waiting. Their creed is carved into the oldest oak in each grove: "*Take only what the season gives. Give back what the season will need.*" Outsiders are welcome at the solstice fires, but expected to work.

Witchcraft of Grimmer (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Grimmer is a *hedgewright* or *path-keeper* – a crafter of living boundaries. Their work may be invisible: weaving a branch to guide deer away from a village, carving a marker that tells the frost when to end, or building a root bridge that

only becomes passable at low tide. This craft can look like “infrastructure” – an Aeler True-Mason might carve a stone that remembers the boundary between a mine and a sacred spring, or a Linn shipwright might season a keel with a prayer for the right wind.

The Witch’s Tool: The Knotted Staff. A staff of petrified wood, cold to the touch but warm when it touches living matter. Once per session, when used to bless a boundary marker (a post, a stone, a tree) it inscribes a minor [SEASONAL] tag into the threshold. The marker will “remember” the season of its carving for one year, granting +1 die to rolls that honour that season’s work.

A Hedge Gift: Knot of the Turning Year (2 XP). Once per scene, you may tie a simple knot (in a cord, a strand of hair, or a blade of grass) and speak a phrase appropriate to the current season. The knot subtly influences the weather or local plant growth for the next hour – a gust of wind, a sudden rain, or a patch of ivy that grows just enough to provide cover. The GM adjudicates effect.

Grimmir’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Seasonal Sense: +1 die to predict weather, seasonal shifts, or natural events.	Cyclical Mood: –1 die to actions that defy the season (haste in winter, patience in spring).
2	Verdant Whisper: Once/scene, gain +2 dice when communing with nature.	Plant Speech: Under stress, you address plants before people; –1 die to civilised social rolls.
3	Growth’s Touch: Once/session, accelerate natural healing or growth.	Seasonal Shift: Demeanour changes with the season; allies note unsettling variance.
4	Boundary Keeper: Once/scene, sense violations of wild places at <i>Far</i> .	Wild Intolerance: –1 die in dense urban/cultivated zones; physical discomfort in worked stone.
5	Cycle’s Memory: Once/session, perfectly recall a natural event witnessed here.	Ecosystem Dependency: Without daily time in nature, suffer Fatigue 1 .
6+	Avatar of Seasons: Once/session, embody a season fully (+3 dice to seasonal actions).	Nature’s Claim: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk becoming bound to a specific biome.

Playstyle Notes

Grimmir rewards those who approach the wild with fear and respect, not dominion. His followers are not masters of nature but participants in its rituals – they know when to give blood, when to leave an offering, and when to simply bow and walk away. Intrusions often take the form of seasonal demands: a grove that must be fed before the first frost, a creature that must be hunted before it hunts you, or a vision of a ritual that must be performed at the next solstice. Refusal does not invite wrath – merely the withdrawal of the wild’s protection, leaving the follower exposed to the very fears they once understood.

Emphasises

- **Seasonal Sacrifice:** the old ways of blood and offering
- **Folk Horror:** the terror of the unseen and the ritual that must be performed
- **Primal Mystery:** knowledge hidden in root and stone, omens and portents
- **Growth from Death:** decay as the engine of new life
- **Boundary Keeping:** guarding the threshold between the civilised and the wild

7.8.9 Ikasha, She Who Sleeps (Latent Potential & Shadow)

Lore. Ikasha is the hush between footfalls, the patience of dark water, the black-feathered watcher at every threshold. In stillness she gathers what might be, at crossroads she whispers of what may yet come. Ravens circle her, bearing secrets between worlds. Her followers learn to move unseen and speak unremembered, becoming shadows that slip between what is and what could be.

Ikasha does not act; she waits. She does not command; she suggests. Her power is not in force but in possibility – the hidden door, the forgotten name, the secret that, if spoken, would change everything. Those who serve her become keepers of thresholds, listeners at the edge of sleep, and witnesses to the shape of things not yet born. She is the patron of spies, dreamers, outcasts, and those who know that the darkest shadow is also the safest cloak.

“Blow out the candle. If the room listens back, ask softly. At the next crossroads, the raven waits – and the shadow remembers your passing.”

Domain Focus

- **Latent Potential:** the power of what is not yet, the seed of action, the whisper before the scream
- **Shadow as Shelter:** concealment, secrets, and the spaces between notice
- **Thresholds of Change:** doors, crossroads, dreams, and the boundaries of sleep
- **Raven’s Witness:** omens, messages, and the weight of secrets shared

Rites of Ikasha

Rite of the Unlit Candle (Low, 4 XP)

Action; Self; Yes (Stealth).

Materials: A candle snuffed with a whisper.

Effect: You step into the space between notices. Gain +1 **die** to a single *Stealth* or *Subterfuge* roll, and if you succeed, you may also declare one minor detail “forgotten” by any observer (e.g., “they don’t remember my face,” “they left the key in the lock”).

Push It: Extend the effect to one ally within Near, but your shadow lingers independently for a moment – the GM gains **1 SB (Diamonds)** as evidence remains.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Crossroads Raven (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: Three black feathers scattered at a crossing.

Effect: A raven appears, visible only to you and your allies. It offers an omen: you may reroll one failed navigation, pursuit, or escape roll this scene, or force one enemy to hesitate (lose their next minor action).

Push It: The raven whispers a true secret about the current situation (the GM must answer one yes/no question truthfully). In return, it demands a secret from you – the GM gains **1 SB (Hearts)** to spend later as a complication involving that secret.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Umbral Reservoir (Standard, 8 XP)*Action; Self or Ally; No.***Materials:** Water gathered on a moonless night, held in a black vessel.**Effect:** Draw on deep reserves of patience and shadow. Choose one:

- Gain **+2 dice** on your next *Stealth*, *Deception*, or *Resolve* roll.
- Clear **1 Fatigue** from yourself or a touched ally.
- Gain one free success on an attempt to escape restraint or pursuit (no roll needed).

Push It: Apply two benefits instead of one, but you mark **+1 Obligation** and the GM gains **1 SB (Clubs)** as the shadow's debt comes due.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Secret Keeper (Standard, 9 XP)***Instant; Touch; No.***Materials:** A lock of hair, a personal token, or a name written on black paper.**Effect:** You compel a truthful answer to one direct question about a secret the target knows. They may resist with a *Resolve* test (DV 4); if they fail, they must answer truthfully (though they may be cryptic). If they succeed, they suffer **1 Fatigue** from the effort of concealment.**Push It:** You also learn a hidden emotion or related secret (GM's choice). In exchange, the target learns one of your secrets – the GM gains **1 SB (Hearts)** and may reveal that secret at a dramatically appropriate moment.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Unlatched Door (Standard, 7 XP)***Instant; Near; Yes.***Materials:** A key that has never been used, bent in a circle.**Effect:** You persuade a threshold to open. One mundane lock, seal, or barrier (door, chain, shutter, even a pursuer's grip) opens or loosens as if it were never secured. This does not work on magical wards.**Push It:** You may also silence any noise the opening would make, but the threshold "remembers" you – the next time you pass this way, the GM gains **1 SB (Spades)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Shadow at the Crossroads (High, 12 XP)***Scene; Self; No.***Materials:** Stand in absolute darkness or at a deserted crossroads at midnight.**Effect:** You become a living shadow. For the scene, you are intangible to mundane harm, can pass through small gaps and thresholds, gain **+2 dice** to all *Stealth* rolls, and automatically succeed on one attempt to escape restraint or pursuit. You cannot manipulate objects normally (though you can open unlocked doors).**Push It:** You may interact once with a locked or warded object (pick a lock, lift a seal, read a sealed letter) while intangible, but you become partially corporeal for a beat – your next defence roll is at *Desperate* position. Mark **1 SB (Spades)** as reality protests.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 7 segments.

Rite of the Unfinished Dream (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; No.

Materials: A dream you remember vividly, written down and burned.

Effect: You reach into the realm of latent potential. Choose one:

- **Whisper of Possibility:** Once before the next dawn, you may reroll any single roll after seeing the result (but before the outcome is declared).
- **Hidden Path:** You and your allies may bypass one major obstacle (a guarded gate, a collapsed bridge, a social dead end) as if a secret way had always been there – but the GM gains **1 SB** as the world adjusts.
- **Unspoken Name:** You learn the true name of one creature or place (GM discretion). That name can be used for future rites or bargains.

Push It: Gain two of the above benefits, but you mark **+2 Obligation** and the GM gains **2 SB** (the dream's echoes attract attention).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Ikasha

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Ikasha sings in *whispers* – melodies that are felt rather than heard, harmonies that slip beneath the threshold of attention. Their voice is used to hide a crowd's escape, to make a guard forget why they entered a room, or to pass a message through enemy lines without a single word being spoken aloud. Ikasha's Cantors are rarely recognised; they are the ones who hum absently while others plan rebellion.

The Cult of the Unlit Candle. Ikasha's cults are shadowy by necessity, meeting in basements, abandoned bell-towers, and fog-bound crossroads. They whisper freedom to the oppressed – escaped slaves, hunted heretics, debtors fleeing their creditors. A ritual of the Unlit Candle involves each member extinguishing a flame and speaking a secret wish for escape. The candles are never relit; the wish is carried away on ravens' wings. Their creed is never written, only passed from shadow to shadow: "*The dark does not confine – it conceals the road that the light would forbid.*" Outsiders who stumble into a meeting are offered a black feather and a choice: forget, or follow.

Witchcraft of Ikasha (Threshold / Shadow)

A witch who walks with Ikasha is a *threshold-keeper* or *shadow-weaver* – one who knows that a door left unlatched is not an invitation to theft, but to liberation. Their magic works in the gaps: the crack under a door, the moment between heartbeats, the pause between a guard's patrol. This craft can be invisible – a bent lock, a misplaced key, a shadow that moves of its own accord – or as grand as erasing a name from a pursuer's memory.

The Witch's Tool: The Raven's Quill. A quill carved from a raven's primary feather, dipped not in ink but in the absence of light. Once per session, when used to write a name on a threshold (a doorframe, a gatepost, a windowsill), that name becomes "forgotten" for a scene: the person whose name is written cannot be perceived by those

who cross that threshold until they succeed on a Resolve test (DV 3). The quill can also erase a single word from a written document (it becomes a smudge of shadow).

A Hedge Gift: Unlatched (2 XP). Once per scene, you may declare a mundane lock, latch, or binding to be “unlatched” – it opens freely (or fails to close) as if it had never been secured. This works on doors, chains, shutters, and even a pursuer’s grip, but not on magical wards.

Ikasha’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Shadow’s Whisper: +1 die to <i>Deception</i> when lying in darkness or through intermediaries.	Truth Echoes: Occasionally speak in riddles or half-truths without realising it.
2	Umbral Sight: Once per scene, gain +2 dice to <i>Notice</i> hidden threats or ambushes in dim light.	Light Sensitivity: –1 die to rolls requiring keen vision in bright conditions.
3	Raven’s Memory: Never forget a secret told to you; recall any whispered conversation perfectly.	Secret Burden: Must keep one troubling secret per Tier; suffer 1 Fatigue when actively trying to forget.
4	Threshold Walker: Once per session, move through one locked door, sealed letter, or magical barrier without triggering wards.	Crossroads Bound: Must pause at literal or metaphorical crossroads to “listen” before major decisions.
5	Shadow Debt: Once per session, call in a favour from someone who owes you a secret – no questions asked.	Obligation Web: Every secret you learn creates a subtle tie to its keeper; mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when ignoring these connections.
6+	Umbral Ascendancy: Once per session, become completely undetectable to all non-magical senses for one scene.	Reality Thinning: The boundary between what is and what could be grows thin – the GM may introduce subtle reality alterations around you.

Playstyle Notes

Ikasha rewards patience, subtlety, and the willingness to let things unfold. Her followers are not agents of action but of possibility – they open doors, plant secrets, and wait for the harvest. Intrusions often take the form of dreams showing a hidden danger, a raven appearing with a cryptic message, or a secret you thought buried resurfacing at the worst moment. Refusing an intrusion does not bring wrath – merely the withdrawal of Ikasha’s favour: doors stay locked, shadows become just shadows, and the road ahead grows a little darker.

Emphasises

- **Latent Potential:** power as possibility, not force

- **Shadow as Shelter:** concealment, secrets, and the spaces between notice
- **Thresholds of Change:** doors, crossroads, dreams, and the boundaries of sleep
- **Raven's Witness:** omens, messages, and the weight of secrets shared

7.8.10 Inaea, Angel of the Spider (Webs, Fate & Patient Predation)

Lore. Inaea sits in patient silence at the centre of the unseen lattice. Where others see isolation, she sees threads—debt, affection, rivalry, loyalty—all binding mortals to one another. She is comforter and conspirator alike: the hearth-mother who eases grief with a warm hand, and the shadow-spinner who knots fates so they cannot slip free. Those who serve her learn to pull strands, tying allies closer and ensnaring foes until mercy or trap is inevitable.

The spider does not rush. It weaves, waits, and feels the tremor of every caught fly. So too does Inaea. Her mercy is never without cost; her kindness is a thread that, once accepted, can be pulled taut at a moment of her follower's choosing. To serve her is to understand that every bond is a leash, every promise a snare, and every act of compassion a line cast into the dark.

“The thread that comforts is the same that binds. The knot that saves is also the snare. What you accept from my hand, you give me leave to tighten.”

Domain Focus

- **Webs of Obligation:** debts, promises, favours, and the ties that bind
- **Patient Predation:** setting traps, waiting for the moment to strike
- **Unseen Connections:** sensing hidden relationships, leverage, and weakness
- **Mercy as Control:** healing and aid that leave lasting threads

Rites of Inaea**Hearth-Thread Knot (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; Yes (link once).

Materials: A thread tied around a wrist or shared cup.

Effect: Bind yourself and one willing target (ally or neutral) with a sympathetic thread. Both gain **+1 die** to Aid each other this scene. Additionally, if either takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 (to a minimum of 0) by suffering that same Harm instead. This transfer is voluntary for an ally; for an unwilling target, you must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 3) to force the link.

Push It: Extend to two allies; mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as your own lifeline strains.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Snaring Filament (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A knotted cord or woven scrap.

Effect: Lay an invisible snare in a lane, doorway, or narrow passage. The first hostile creature to cross suffers **−2 dice** on their next action and must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 2) or lose their movement for that turn (tangled). The snare lasts for the scene or until triggered.

Push It: Lay a second snare elsewhere, but allies risk entanglement if they forget its location; mark **1 SB (Spades)** as the web spreads thin.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Strand of Inevitability (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: Three coloured threads (white, black, red) braided together.

Effect: Link two actors (which can include yourself) with a visible or invisible strand. For the rest of the scene, whenever one acts, the other is dragged into consequence. You may trigger this linkage once to either:

- Force **1 SB (Hearts)** on the linked target after they perform a significant action.
- Gain **+2 dice** on a *Setup*, *Predict*, or *Manipulate* roll that exploits the link (e.g., “you cannot betray me without hurting your ally”).

The link is one-way or two-way as you choose.

Push It: Invert the direction of the link once after it is set (e.g., make the pursuer stumble instead of the pursued). Mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the weave resists.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Weaver’s Glance (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Self; No.

Materials: Observe a spider finishing a web’s radial line (or a convincing imitation).

Effect: Ask the GM one question about a hidden tie, debt, or leverage between two people, or between a person and a faction. The GM must answer truthfully. Your next *Manipulate*, *Pressure*, or *Intimidate* action exploiting that knowledge gains **+1 Effect**.

Push It: Reveal a secret tie that was not previously declared in the fiction (the GM must invent a plausible connection). Mark **Exposure +1** as your own entanglements surface.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Spinner’s Debt (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A silver coin and a strand of your own hair, knotted together.

Effect: Offer a willing creature a boon: they may immediately clear **1 Fatigue** or gain **+1 die** on their next roll. In return, they accept a **Promise Clock [4]** named “Debt to the Web.” You may advance this clock by 1 segment at any time as a free action (once per scene). When the clock fills, you may demand a single service from them – not impossible, but significant (e.g., “speak for me at court,” “reveal a secret,” “take a blow meant for me”). Refusal causes them to suffer **Harm 1 (Stress)** and the clock resets.

Push It: Extend the offer to a group (up to three targets). Each who accepts gives you a separate Promise Clock. Mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Binding Knot (High, 11 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A silk loop tied between two hands, then cut or knotted with a spoken vow.

Effect: Bind two parties (individuals or small groups) to a mutual oath. Breaking the vow forces **2 SB** on the violator and marks them with a subtle tell (a visible thread, a nervous twitch, a lingering scent) that persists for one week.

Push It: Widen the binding to up to four parties, each of whom may define one loophole. Exploiting a loophole causes **1 SB (Clubs)** as the web tightens around the exploiter.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

Merciful Severing (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: A white thread burned to ash, spoken with a name.

Effect: Sever one harmful tie – a curse, a toxic obsession, a coercive bond, or a supernatural debt. Remove one Condition or 1 SB tied to it. This is an act of genuine mercy; the target may be unwilling, but the thread can still be cut (Resolve test DV 4 to resist).

Push It: Sever a tie without the target's consent or knowledge; they will not know who cut them free, but you mark +2 **Obligation** as the web recoils against you, and the severed strand may attach to you instead (GM's discretion).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Web of Slumber (High, 12 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Materials: A complete spider's web, stolen at dawn, and a lullaby hummed into it.

Effect: Weave an area of drowsy stillness. For the next hour, any creature entering the zone must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 4) or fall into a light trance, losing their next action and suffering –1 **die** to all perception rolls while inside. Allies you touch beforehand are immune. The web is invisible until triggered.

Push It: The trance becomes deeper – sleeping creatures cannot be woken by non-magical means for the duration. Mark 2 SB (**Spades/Hearts**) as the web draws hungry attention.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Inaea

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Inaea sings in *knots* – melodies that loop back on themselves, harmonies that tie two voices into one. Their voice is used to HEAL quarrels, to bind a community together after a tragedy, or to weave a subtle compulsion into a seemingly innocent lullaby. Inaea's Cantors are beloved at weddings, feared at treaty signings, and always watched by those who understand that a pretty tune can be a leash.

The Cult of the Woven Circle. Inaea's cults gather in domestic spaces – kitchens, weaving sheds, longhouses – and resemble extended families more than secret societies. A ritual of the Woven Circle involves each member tying a coloured thread around their wrist, then passing the ends to their neighbours. The resulting web is then tightened, and a communal promise spoken. The cult's creed is embroidered onto a single cushion that passes from host to host: *"No thread stands alone. The weakest knot still holds the strongest weight."* Outsiders are welcome if they bring a thread and a truth. Betrayal of the circle is repaid by being unravelled – socially, financially, or worse.

Witchcraft of Inaea (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Inaea is a *web-weaver* or *knot-smith* – one who understands that every threshold (a door, a marriage, a treaty) is held together by invisible threads. Their

magic works with domestic tools: a spinning wheel that twists fate, a loom that weaves obligations into cloth, or a pair of shears that cuts a single strand to end a feud. This craft can be as humble as tying a red thread around a child's wrist for protection, or as grand as weaving a tapestry that records an entire bloodline's debts.

The Witch's Tool: The True Loom. A small, portable loom – no larger than a book – woven from hawthorn wood and strung with thread dyed in three colours (red for blood, white for truth, black for secret). Once per session, the witch may weave a single knot into a new or existing thread; that knot becomes a *promise clock* [4]. When the clock fills, the promise is either fulfilled or broken, as agreed at the time of weaving.

A Hedge Gift: Bind the Threshold (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tie a simple knot in a cord, ribbon, or strand of hair and place it on a threshold (a doorstep, a gate, a bridge). For the next hour, anyone crossing that threshold must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 2) if they intend to break an oath, tell a lie, or harm someone inside. The knot visibly tightens if a violation is attempted.

Inaea's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hearth-Blessed: +1 die to <i>Comfort</i> or <i>Aid</i> actions.	Must offer solace when asked, or mark 1 SB (Hearts) .
2	Web-Sense: Once/scene, sense hidden ties between two people (debt, rivalry, affection).	Empathic Overload: suffer 1 Fatigue when immersed in strong conflict.
3	Binding Presence: Once/session, compel a promise unless target passes Resolve DV 4.	Over-Attachment: –1 die when abandoning those you've aided or bound.
4	Fate's Pattern: +2 dice to predict alliances, betrayals, or bargains.	Manipulative Urge: mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when acting selflessly without agenda.
5	Spider's Mercy: Once/session, sever one harmful tie for yourself or another (as <i>Merciful Severing</i>).	Hunger for Threads: suffer 1 Fatigue if a session passes without weaving a new tie or extracting a promise.
6+	Weaver's Dominion: Once/session, declare all ties in a scene bend toward you; gain +2 dice on social manipulation.	Entanglement: Mark +2 Obligation ; those affected become subtly dependent on your will.

Playstyle Notes

Inaea rewards those who see relationships as both comfort and leverage. Her followers are not merely kind; they are patient, observant, and willing to let a debt ripen before collecting. Intrusions often take the form of a sudden obligation – a person you helped now demands help in return, a promise you thought forgotten tightens, or a web you spun catches someone you did not intend. Refusing an intrusion does not break the thread, but it frays it: the GM may mark a *Tangled Web* clock that, when filled, causes all your

active promises and bonds to tighten at once, often at the worst moment.

Emphasises

- **Patient Predation:** setting threads and waiting for the right moment
- **Webs of Obligation:** debts, promises, and favours as both comfort and leash
- **Unseen Connections:** sensing hidden relationships and leverage
- **Mercy as Control:** healing and aid that leave lasting threads

7.8.11 The Inquisitor Prime (Purity & Domination)

Lore. Among the Aeler Iron Avengers, zealots, and witch-hunters, the Inquisitor Prime is venerated as the hand of absolute purity and the sword of uncompromising order. Where others see nuance, the Inquisitor sees corruption; where others see difference, they see contamination.

Those who march beneath their sigil believe that no society can stand if it tolerates the impure or the disobedient. They hunt the arcane and the aberrant, not merely to destroy them, but to bind them as slaves to order—believing even the tainted may yet serve, so long as they are shackled.

The Inquisitor Prime appears in vision as a faceless figure clad in burnished iron, with eyes like furnace-doors and a voice like grinding chains. To serve them is to embrace judgment without mercy and to live in suspicion of all who walk outside the prescribed law.

For the faithful, doubt is treason; compassion is weakness; and freedom is the seed of ruin. In the wake of their followers, only silence and ash remain.

"Mercy is weakness. Purity is survival. Where corruption hides, we carve it out."

Rites of the Inquisitor Prime

Rite of the Pure Flame (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: Ash from a burned grimoire or sigil-scarred candle.

Effect: Gain **+2 dice** to resist supernatural influence (fear, charm, possession) and **+1**

Armor vs. magical attacks. Undead/demonic foes suffer **−1 die** against you.

Push It: Extend the effect to allies in Near range, but supernatural entities sense you immediately; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unclouded Eye (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: Silver dust stirred into holy water.

Effect: **+2 dice** to Investigate/Insight when spotting illusions, glamours, or magical deception. Cannot be surprised by sorcery this scene.

Push It: For one exchange, pierce *all* illusions; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Cleansing Light (Standard, 8 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: A shard of blessed mirror and consecrated oil.

Effect: Target a magical effect (ward, curse, enchantment). Test DV = Tier.

- On Hit: Dispel.
- On Partial: Weaken.
- On Miss: The effect lashes back, generating 1 SB.

Push It: Dispel absolutely and trace its caster; mark +1 **Obligation** and 1 **SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Marked Prey (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A belonging of the target mixed with blessed salt.

Effect: Mark a supernatural target: they suffer –1 **die** to all rolls and cannot hide with illusion. You gain +1 **die** to track or strike them. Undead/demonic take +1 Harm from you.

Push It: Target cannot hide anywhere and suffers Fatigue 1; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Consecrated Ground (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Materials: Relics from three rival faiths, salt, crushed gemstones.

Effect: Consecrate an area. Supernatural entities must pass Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) to enter. Undead/demonic suffer –2 **dice** inside. The site gains the [WARD] tag.

Push It: Permanently sanctify a larger area, but start a *Magical Dead Zone* [6] clock and mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Admonition (High, 14 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: Ash from a destroyed spellbook, martyr's water, and the target's true name.

Effect: Attempt to annihilate one supernatural foe. Target tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 5). On Fail: destroyed outright. On Success: suffer Harm 3 and –2 dice this scene. Once per target only.

Push It: Absolute destruction leaves behind Sanctified Ground; mark 2 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Inquisitor Prime

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Inquisitor Prime does not sing melodies – they chant *liturgies of excision*, flat, rhythmic recitations that scrub the air of taint. Their voice is used to purify a space before a hunt, to drown out a heretic's dying curse, or to march troops into battle with a single, unified note. Inquisitorial Cantors are rarely loved, but they are feared – and their songs are remembered long after the pyre has cooled.

The Cult of the Iron Chorus. The Prime's cults are militant orders – the Chain-Lanterns of Thepyrgos, the Censer-Knights of Ecktoria, the Spirit-Shield Correctors of Aeler. They gather in fortified chapter houses, not temples. A ritual of the Iron Chorus involves each member testifying to a corruption they have purged, then striking a iron bell with a hammer. The bell's tone is harsh and final. Their creed is stamped

into every seal: *"What is pure endures. What is not is fuel."* Outsiders are not welcome; they are suspects until proven clean.

The Prosecutorial Mob. The Prime also can whip up temporary "cults" which act as mobs. These attack the target of the Cantor but either disperse or form factions as the GM dictates.

Witchcraft of the Inquisitor Prime (Craft / Purity)

A witch who walks with the Inquisitor Prime is a contradiction – yet they exist. They are *Ash-Walkers* or *Soot-Scribes*, mendicant purifiers who use craft to cleanse rather than to corrupt. Their magic is the art of *making pure*: forging a ward that repels spirits, carving a rune that silences a cursed bell, or brewing a tea that flushes possession from a victim's blood. In Aeler, a True-Mason of the Prime might seal a haunted tunnel with sanctified mortar; in Viterra, a hedge-wright might whitewash a threshold with lime and prayer.

The Witch's Tool: The Soot Chisel. A chisel of black iron, its edge forever warm. When struck against stone or iron, it leaves a grey mark that glows faintly to supernatural senses. Once per session, the witch may carve a [PURITY] tag onto a threshold (a door, a bridge, a city gate). For one scene, any supernatural creature crossing that threshold suffers –1 die to all rolls, and any magical effect passing through is treated as one Tier lower for the purpose of resistance.

A Hedge Gift: Ash and Salt (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may sprinkle a pinch of ash and salt in a line across a threshold. Until the next dawn, that line functions as a [WARD] against minor spirits (Cap 1–2) and all undead of Cap 2 or lower. A creature attempting to cross must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or be turned back for that exchange.

Inquisitor Prime's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hunter's Instinct: +1 die to Notice magical auras or traps.	Black-and-White Thinking: Must label others "pure" or "corrupt"; -1 die when navigating moral nuance.
2	Sanctified Weapon: Once/scene, your weapon ignores 1 Armor/Resist from supernatural foes.	Purity Zeal: Exposure to filth or corruption causes 1 Fatigue.
3	Cold Clarity: +2 dice to resist deception, illusion, or mental sway.	Suspicion: -1 die to social rolls with anyone you suspect of "impurity."
4	Burning Truth: Once/session, compel one target to answer truthfully (Resolve DV 4).	Compulsion: Cannot ignore supernatural activity; hesitation costs 1 SB (Clubs).
5	Sterile Aura: Once/session, emit a presence that suppresses supernatural abilities (-2 dice in Near).	Purity Addiction: Suffer 1 Fatigue when in a supernatural area without taking action against it.
6+	Absolute Judgement: Once/session, name a supernatural foe as utterly corrupt. For that scene, gain +3 dice against them.	Monomania: When invoked, you tunnel on that target, suffering -2 dice to all else.

7.8.12 Isoka, Angel of Serpents (Transformation & Renewal)

Lore. Isoka, sister to Ikasha (Shadow) and Inaea (Mercy), completes the Triad of Transformation. Where thresholds and compassion mark her sisters' domains, Isoka teaches that every self is temporary—identity is a skin to be shed so growth can continue. Her serpents are omens and teachers: each cast skin a lesson in release; each venom a catalyst for necessary change. Those who walk her path become alchemists of the self, embracing dissolution as the first motion of rebirth.

Do not mourn the skin you shed. It was never meant to last. The venom that burns away the old self is the same that grants the strength to become new.

Rites of Isoka

Rite of the Loosening Skin (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A discarded snakeskin or a strand of your own hair.

Effect: Shrug off a temporary burden. Remove one Condition (Fear, Poison, Fatigue, or a minor social stain) that you have acquired this scene. Alternatively, reroll one failed roll to escape restraint or pursuit.

Push It: Also ignore one environmental penalty (difficult terrain, smoke, etc.) for the scene, but leave a visible trace of your passage (mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Forked Tongue (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A harmless lie whispered to a mirror.

Effect: For one scene, you may speak ambiguously without penalty. When you use *Deception* or *Sway* to conceal your true intent or pass as someone else, you may treat a Partial Success as a Clean Success (the lie holds). On a Miss, however, the GM gains **2 SB** as your deceit unravels in an embarrassing way.

Push It: Extend the effect to one willing ally; they may also lie freely for the scene. Mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as both of you become tangled in the same falsehood.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Shedding (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A complete change of clothing and a token from your former role (a badge, a lock of hair, a written name).

Effect: You shed one persistent identity – a title, a bond, a debt, or a reputation. For the remainder of the scene, you are treated as a stranger to those who knew you in that role. You gain **+2 dice** on any roll to avoid detection, escape pursuit, or convince others that you are not yourself. Create a 6-segment *Shed Identity* clock; when it fills, the old identity returns as a separate NPC (a rival, a witness, or a ghost).

Push It: Immediately erase one minor obligation (a Debt Clock segment or 1 Obligation to a Patron) as you slough it off. Mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the discarded debt finds a new debtor.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Venomous Rebirth (Standard, 9 XP)*Instant; Touch; No.***Materials:** A drop of venom from a serpent that has shed its skin within the last day.**Effect:** Inflict or cure through poison's paradox. Choose one:

- **Curse:** Touch a creature and inject venom. They suffer **+1 Harm** (poison) and must test Resolve (DV 4) or gain the *Poisoned* Condition (–1 die to physical actions until cured).
- **Cleanse:** Touch a poisoned or diseased creature. The venom neutralises the malady; remove one *Poisoned* or *Diseased* Condition, and the target clears 1 Fatigue.

Push It: Apply both effects to the same target (curse and cleanse in a painful purge), or affect two different targets. Mark **+1 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Unremembered Name (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Near; Yes.***Materials:** A written name on a scrap of paper, burned in a copper dish.**Effect:** Erase a single person's memory of you – or your memory of them. Choose one:

- **Unperson:** One creature within Near who knows you must test Resolve (DV 4). On a failure, they forget you exist for one scene (cannot recognise you, recall your name, or target you deliberately).
- **Unburden:** You forget a specific guilt, a failed oath, or a traumatic memory. Clear 1 Fatigue and downgrade one psychological Condition (e.g., *Haunted*, *Obsessed*) by one step.

Push It: The effect lasts a full day, but the GM gains **2 SB** as reality strains to remember what was lost.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of Complete Metamorphosis (High, 13 XP)***Extended; Self; Yes.***Materials:** A full identity kit (garb, voice, mannerisms), a serpent's shed skin, and a personal item from the life you are leaving.**Effect:** After an hour of ritual, you emerge with a new face, voice, and documented identity (if you have prepared papers). For one week, you are immune to recognition by anyone who knew your previous self, and you gain **+2 dice** on all *Deception* and *Stealth* rolls related to maintaining that new identity. Create an 8-segment *New Identity* clock; when it fills, the old self may attempt to reassert itself (GM's discretion).**Push It:** Extend the metamorphosis to a willing ally, or make the change permanent (but you lose access to one of your Bonds or a Minor Asset forever). Mark **+2 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.***Rite of the Cast-Off History (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Self; No.***Materials:** Burning or defacing all mundane records of your old life (letters, portraits,

legal documents).

Effect: After a full night’s ritual, your previous identity becomes *unreliable*. Common records and casual memories of you become vague or contradictory; those who track you via that identity suffer –2 dice on their rolls. You gain +2 **dice** on all rolls that rely on your new identity. Create a 6-segment *Erased Past* clock; when it fills, one intimate from your old life senses the deception and may begin a quiet investigation.

Push It: Arrange a plausible “death” for your old self (a funeral, a witness). Mark **2 SB (Clubs/Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Isoka

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Isoka sings in *whispers of shedding* – melodies that rise and fall like a serpent’s undulation, with harmonies that slither rather than resolve. Their voice is used to ease a difficult transformation (ritual scarring, a change of identity, the acceptance of loss) or to accelerate a foe’s destructive change (madness, mutation, despair). Isoka’s Cantors are often found in snake cults, their songs weaving venom and mercy in equal measure.

The Cult of the Coiled Heart. Isoka’s cults are secretive, dangerous, and obsessed with metamorphosis. They gather in sunken temples, caverns beneath city sewers, or groves where adders nest. A ritual of the Coiled Heart involves each member holding a live serpent while speaking a name they wish to shed: a debt, a crime, a former allegiance. The serpent is then released into a central pit. Their creed is carved in ouroboros rings: “*What devours itself is never consumed by another.*” Outsiders are rarely invited; those who stumble into a rite are offered a choice – join, drink venom and be remade, or be forgotten as the cult sheds their memory.

Witchcraft of Isoka (Craft / Shedding)

A witch who walks with Isoka is a *scale-smith* or *venomer* – one who understands that transformation is a craft. Their magic works with the materials of change: a forge that tempers steel by “shedding” impurities, an alembic that distills venom into medicine, or a loom that weaves a new identity from discarded threads. In Aeler, a True-Mason might “shed” an old tunnel by sealing it and carving a new one; in Zakov, a poisoner might shed a target’s will with a single drop.

The Witch’s Tool: The Shedding Knife. A small, curved blade of obsidian or serpentine, never used for combat – only for cutting away what is no longer needed. Once per session, the witch may cut a physical token of an old identity (a lock of hair, a uniform patch, a letter) and burn it. For the remainder of the session, they gain +1 **die** on all rolls to deceive, hide, or escape detection, as the old self’s traces are literally erased.

A Hedge Gift: Venom’s Mercy (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may apply a drop of harmless (or carefully dosed) venom to a wound, a drink, or a lock. Choose one effect: remove 1 Fatigue from an ally (as a mild stimulant), impose –1 die on a target’s next physical roll (a mild paralytic), or force a target to speak a single truthful sentence (a truth serum). The victim may resist with a Resolve test (DV 3) if they are aware of the venom.

Isoka's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Serpent's Gaze: +1 die on Intimidation or social rolls using menace.	Cold-Blooded: -1 die on Empathy or warmth-based Persuasion.
2	Shed the Old Skin: Once/session, negate one Condition (Fear, Fatigue, Poison) by discarding it like molted skin.	Mark of Scales: Faint reptilian patches visible, causing +1 SB in social encounters if noticed.
3	Venomous Strike: Bite or kiss may inflict Poison (DV 2).	Hungry Coil: Must consume raw meat or eggs weekly, or mark 1 Fatigue.
4	Serpentine Grace: +2 dice to Stealth or Evasion rolls, ignore minor movement penalties.	Slitted Eyes: Bright light imposes -1 die on Notice rolls.
5	Hypnotic Sway: Once/scene, roll Presence + Lore vs. Resolve (DV 3) to mesmerise a single target.	Forked Tongue: -1 die on Deception when attempting warmth or sincerity.
6+	Ascendant Form: Partial serpent-body; immune to mundane poison, +2 dice on Body rolls.	Monstrous Aspect: Cannot easily hide your nature; every session begins with 1 SB that may be compelled by the GM.

7.8.13 Khemesh, the Abyssal Maw (Depths, Inexorability, Eldritch Terror)

Lore. Khemesh is not merely a lord of the depths but the hunger beneath them, a pressure older than seas. Those who bargain with him are marked by the abyss—seen in the way shadows cling, in the whispers heard when no voice speaks, in the certainty that all things will sink.

In the trench without light, the Maw waits. Even silence drowns.

Rites of Khemesh

Whisper of the Trench (Low, 4 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: None.

Effect: Target hears impossible echoes and suffers **–1 die** on their next action.

Push It: Echoes coil in your own skull – take **Fatigue 1**, but the target also loses their next minor action.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Crushing Silence (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A broken shell filled with ink-dark water.

Effect: Establish an oppressive silence; sound carries only as distorted whispers. Enemies in the zone gain **–1 die** to coordination or morale-driven actions.

Push It: A single enemy's voice is stolen entirely for the scene.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Pressure of the Maw (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: A length of rusted chain submerged in water.

Effect: Target is pinned by invisible crushing force: treat as [ENTANGLE] with **Great Effect** if underwater or confined.

Push It: Inflict **Fatigue 1** on the target in addition to the restraint.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Abyssal Vision (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: None.

Effect: You perceive the world as Khemesh does – fractured, alien, crushing. Gain **+2 dice** to Notice and Arcana, and may ask one "true nature" question about a foe or structure.

Cost: When the scene ends, you suffer **Exposure +1** as your perception warps.

Push It: Extend the vision to one ally, but both take **Fatigue 1**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

The Maw Opens (High, 12 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A sealed vessel of abyssal water, broken open.

Effect: Reality in the zone folds inward like the crushing deep:

- Enemies act at **Desperate Position** by default.
- Each beat, the GM may force **1 SB** (Spades/Clubs favoured).
- Structures, vessels, or wards fracture as if under immense weight.

Push It: For one beat, declare a single enemy "crushed" (severe harm/effect). You immediately suffer **Fatigue 2** and **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Khemesh

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Khemesh sings in *pressures* – low, resonant drones that feel like the weight of water on the chest. Their voice is used to invoke the crushing depths, to rupture a ship's hull with a single sustained note, or to fill a room with the sensation of drowning. Khemesh's Cantors are rare, feared, and often found in coastal cults where they sing the tides into madness.

The Cult of the Drowned Chorus. Khemesh's cults are the stuff of eldritch horror – sunken temples beneath storm-tossed seas, congregations of shore-dwellers with wet eyes and too-pale skin, and the occasional deep one or kraken-spawn acolyte. A ritual of the Drowned Chorus involves each member drinking a cup of brine and salt water while whispering a secret hope into the cup – hope that the depths will grant, or consume. Their creed is whispered in wet, gurgling tones: *"All things sink. The only question is what you carry down with you."* Outsiders are bait, or converts. Sometimes both.

Witchcraft of Khemesh (Craft / Pressure)

A witch who walks with Khemesh is a *deep-salvager* or *pressure-smith* – one who works with the spoils of the abyss. Their craft is the art of enduring pressure: forging a diving bell that can reach the trench, tempering steel in salt water to make it unbreakable, or carving a ward that holds back the sea. In Linn, a shipwright might season a keel with a prayer to Khemesh – the ship will never sink, but its crew will dream of drowning. In Aeler, a True-Mason might seal a flooded tunnel with pressure-set stone, cursed to collapse on any who speak the wrong name.

The Witch's Tool: The Abyssal Hammer. A heavy hammer of black iron, always cold and wet to the touch, even in a forge. Once per session, when used to seal a threshold (a door, a hatch, a bulkhead), the hammer drives the seal with crushing finality. For the next scene, any attempt to force that threshold suffers **+1 DV** and a successful breach inflicts 1 Fatigue on the breaker (the pressure "pushes back").

A Hedge Gift: Carried Depth (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a container (a bottle, a chest, a room) and fill it with the "pressure of the deep." For the next hour, any living creature inside that container must test Endurance (DV 3) or suffer 1 Fatigue from the crushing weight. The container may also be used to preserve food or seal a wound (the pressure stops bleeding), but the flesh grows pale and cold.

Khemesh's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Abyssal Resilience: +1 die to resist fear and pressure-based effects.	Claustrophobic Comfort: Suffer –1 die in open, well-lit spaces or above ground.
2	Crushing Insight: Once/scene, treat a failed Investigation or Arcana roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Weight of Knowledge: Suffer 1 Fatigue when learning new information that confirms your pessimistic worldview.
3	Silent Hunter: +2 dice to Stealth in dark or confined spaces.	Voice of the Deep: When speaking normally, your voice sounds distant and hollow, causing –1 die to social rolls requiring warmth or clarity.
4	Pressure Adaptation: Immune to underwater combat penalties; gain +1 die to resist drowning.	Crushing Presence: Allies within Near range suffer –1 die to morale-based rolls due to your oppressive aura.
5	Abyssal Sight: Once/session, see through all illusions and deceptions for one exchange, but the truth is always bleak.	Fractured Perception: –1 die to rolls requiring normal vision; the world appears warped and alien.
6+	Inevitable Descent: Once/session, declare that all escape routes in a zone are sealed. Enemies cannot flee and suffer –2 dice to mobility actions.	Hunger of the Maw: Mark +2 Obligation when using this power; you must consume something (food, memory, hope) to maintain your strength.

7.8.14 Livaea, the Crimson Courtier (Seduction & Social Binding)

Lore. In salons where laughter cuts deeper than daggers and promises bind tighter than chains, the Crimson Courtier reigns. She is the whisper behind the curtain, the smile that sells secrets, the velvet hand that closes a cage. Her servants are not conquerors but consorts, binding others through song, wit, and the perilous glamour of intimacy. Where Mab entangles through fae trickery, Livaea rules through allure, performance, and the hunger for connection.

“A promise sealed with desire is harder to break than any oath sworn in iron.”

Domain Focus

- **Seductive Arts:** Charm, persuasion, social manipulation
- **Social Binding:** Oaths of affection, courtly promises, emotional debts
- **Performance Magic:** Dance, music, appearance enhancement
- **Court Intrigue:** Gossip, reputation, social standing

Rites of Livaea**Rite of the Velvet Whisper (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Materials: Silk ribbon touched to lips.

Effect: Your private words carry irresistible charm. Gain +1 **die** to Sway one target in confidential conversation.

Push It: Target feels compelled to share a secret in return; mark Exposure +1.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Shared Cup (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; Standard Push

Materials: Shared wine, tea, or perfume.

Effect: Create temporary bond of intimacy. Both parties gain +1 **die** when aiding each other socially.

Push It: Bond deepens to emotional empathy; both sense moods but suffer -1 **die** to deceive each other.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Binding Vow (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Materials: Token exchanged between parties.

Effect: Forge magical promise. Both gain +1 **Effect** when cooperating; breach inflicts 1 **SB (Hearts)**. Create a 6-segment *Vow Strength* clock.

Push It: Breach also causes visible social stain; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Courtesan's Guise (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; Standard Push

Materials: Perfume or cosmetics applied ritually.

Effect: Assume perfect social poise. Gain +2 dice to Sway or Performance in refined settings.

Push It: Become social centrepiece; all attention focuses on you with +1 Effect.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Crimson Masquerade (High, 13 XP)

Ritual; Zone; High Push

Materials: Circle of red candles, music, ritual dance.

Effect: Create enchanted social space. Allies gain +1 die to social rolls; crude intimidation suffers -1 die. Creates an 8-segment *Masquerade Charm* clock.

Push It: Effects linger after leaving zone; mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Eternal Court (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; High Push

Materials: Throne draped in scarlet, assembled court.

Effect: Become social sovereign. All social interactions slant toward your influence (+1 Effect to you, -1 die to opposition). Start a 10-segment *Court Dominion* clock.

Push It: Newcomers test Resist (DV 3) or become briefly devoted; mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Livaea

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Livaea sings in *harmonies of longing* – melodies that linger in the ear like a half-remembered lover's sigh. Their voice is used to sway a court's opinion, to bind a marriage with a ballad, or to seduce a secret from a guarded heart. Livaea's Cantors are prized in every noble house, and feared by those who know that a beautiful song can be a leash.

The Cult of the Velvet Circle. Livaea's cults are not hidden in basements; they meet in salons, tea houses, and private galleries. The Velvet Circle appears to be a social club – but its members trade in secrets, favours, and carefully curated introductions. A ritual of the Velvet Circle involves each member drinking from a shared cup (the *Crimson Chalice*) while naming a desire they wish to weave into reality. The Circle's creed is embroidered on its seal: "*Every bond is a thread. Every thread can be tied – or cut.*" Outsiders are welcome as guests, but they will leave with a new debt, a new ally, or a new enemy. Rarely all three.

Witchcraft of Livaea (Craft / Social Weaving)

A witch who walks with Livaea is a *gossip-scribe* or *perfume-smith* – one who crafts social reality from threads of rumour, scent, and gesture. Their magic works with the tools of influence: a letter that cannot be forgotten, a perfume that makes the wearer irresistibly

charming, or a needle that sews a promise into a dress's hem. In Ecktoria, a Livaeen witch might be a letter-writer for the powerful, sealing each envelope with a kiss that binds the reader's loyalty. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a keystone that makes every handshake struck beneath it unbreakable.

The Witch's Tool: The Gossip Quill. A silver-tipped quill that writes in ink that darkens when a secret is true. Once per session, the witch may write a single sentence about a person they have met. That sentence becomes "known" to the local gossip network within a day, affecting the target's reputation (GM determines effect: -1 die to social rolls, a new ally, an enemy, etc.). The witch cannot control how the rumour spreads, only that it spreads.

A Hedge Gift: Velvet Glove (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a person's hand (or a letter they have written) and speak a single word of command ("trust," "forget," "desire"). For the next hour, the target feels a mild but genuine inclination toward that emotion or action – not enough to override self-preservation, but enough to grant the wielder +1 die on social rolls against them.

Livaea's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Silver Tongue: +1 die to Persuade or Sway in intimate settings.	Need for Attention: -1 die when acting unnoticed or ignored.
2	Heart's Insight: Once/scene, +2 dice to detect hidden desires or motives.	Emotional Drain: 1 Fatigue if denied meaningful social connection.
3	Enchanting Presence: Allies in Near gain +1 die to social actions.	Rivalry Magnet: Often attract envy or social competition.
4	Velvet Command: Once/session, issue compelling suggestion (Resist DV 4).	Temptation's Pull: -1 die to resist appealing offers.
5	Court Network: Once/session, call on contacts for information.	Glamour Dependence: -1 die when isolated from social circles.
6+	Sovereign Allure: Once/session, dominate a social gathering (Resist DV 5).	Addicted to Adoration: Mark +2 Obligation; suffer if denied praise.

Playstyle Notes

Livaea excels in social manipulation and courtly intrigue. Followers become masters of persuasion, binding others through desire and obligation. The corruption progression leads toward becoming a social virtuoso who cannot function without admiration and connection. Ideal for players who enjoy social combat, political maneuvering, and characters who wield influence as their primary weapon.

7.8.15 Lunara, The Silver Quiet (Moon, Mystery & Hidden Ways)

Lore. Lunara walks where torchlight falters: crossroads, tidal edges, shadowed sanctuaries. She is the whisper beneath silver skies, a torch-bearing guide to mysteries that lie between waking and dream. The ancients know her as triple-formed: maiden of new light, mother of full radiance, crone of waning shadow. Her worshippers—night-scholars, dream-walkers, and hedge-priests—seek her not for power over others, but for passage, reflection, and revelation.

Her gifts are gentle yet perilous: a mirror that reveals as much of the seeker as the sought, a key that opens ways better left closed, a light that makes the unseen plain. Her sigil is the silver spiral, etched in water, mirror, or stone.

"Three faces gaze from the moon. Which one watches you tonight?"

Rites of Lunara

Rite of the Moonlit Mirror (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A mirror or bowl of still water under moonlight.

Effect: Peer beyond surfaces. +1 die to detect illusions, veils, or hidden motives. Once per scene, ask one veiled question about the present; the GM answers in riddle or omen.

Push It: Glimpse too deeply – gain the truth, but mark 1 Exposure.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Crescent Whisper (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: A silvered thread knotted three times.

Effect: Deliver a secret thought to a single target; they hear it as if whispered beside them. Gain +1 die to aid their next action.

Push It: The whisper echoes beyond its mark, creating 1 SB (Hearts) as others sense your intrusion.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Triple Road (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: Three lit candles set at a crossroads.

Effect: Reveal a hidden path, door, or liminal way. Allies gain +2 dice to traverse or escape; enemies suffer –1 die to pursue.

Push It: The road opens farther than intended – toward an unknown realm. Mark 1 SB (Spades).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Lunar Conjunction (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A ring of herbs burned beneath a dark moon.

Effect: Commune with veiled knowledge or subtle entities. Ask two questions; answers come in omen, dream-symbol, or paradox.

Push It: The answer is too direct – gain it fully, but mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Silver Key (High, 13 XP)*Scene; Zone; No.***Materials:** A silver key forged or anointed under a new moon.**Effect:** Open a way where none should exist – between places, states, or wards. Creates a 6-segment *Gateway* clock.**Push It:** Something else comes through; mark **2 SB (Clubs)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 7 segments.**Rite of the Moonbound Ascendant (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Self; No.***Materials:** A cherished item surrendered under moonlight.**Effect:** Enter a heightened lunar state. Choose two:

- +2 dice to Wits or Spirit,
- Resist fear/beguilement,
- Speak with unseen presences,
- Trace hidden connections with +2 Effect.

Begin a 6-segment *Moonbound* clock.**Push It:** Make it enduring – mark Harm 2 and a permanent lunar stigma.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 8 segments.**Cantors & Cults of Lunara**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Lunara sings in *phases* – melodies that shift from whisper to resonance as the moon waxes and wanes. Their voice is used to lure dreams, to calm a troubled sleepwalker, or to draw a veil of silver silence over a secret meeting. Lunara's Cantors are often found in starlit groves, singing the moon up and down.

The Cult of the Silver Spiral. Lunara's cults meet under open skies, in moon-lit clearings, on rooftops, or beside tidal pools. The Silver Spiral is not a secret society – it is a fellowship of night-walkers, dream-recorders, and lunar scholars. A ritual of the Spiral involves each member writing a question on a silvered leaf, then floating it on still water under the moon's reflection. The cult's creed is engraved on a single silver disc that passes from host to host: "*The moon sees all. The moon tells only what the seeker is ready to hear.*" Outsiders are welcome on the night of the full moon, but they must bring a question and a silver coin.

Witchcraft of Lunara (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Lunara is a *silver-scribe* or *mirror-maker* – one who works with reflection, threshold, and the soft metals of the moon. Their craft is the art of revealing and concealing: polishing a mirror that shows a hidden door, forging a silver key that opens a dream, or etching a lunar phase onto a threshold to make it shift at moonrise. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a moon-phase into a keystone so the tunnel only opens

under a new moon. In Viterra, a hedge-wright might silver a well's rim so that those who drink from it forget their nightmares.

The Witch's Tool: The Silver Needle. A needle of pure silver, cold to the touch, that never tarnishes. Once per session, the witch may prick their finger and draw a single drop of blood onto a threshold (a doorframe, a mirror's edge, a window sill). For the rest of the scene, that threshold "remembers" the witch – they may cross it silently, unseen, and any reflection in it shows only what they wish to be seen.

A Hedge Gift: Moon-Water Scry (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may cup a handful of water that has sat under moonlight and speak a name. The water shows a brief, cryptic image of that person's current location or emotional state (e.g., "surrounded by stone," "weeping," "walking toward a bridge"). The GM describes the vision in one short sentence.

Lunara's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Moonlit Sight: +1 die to detect hidden or liminal presences.	Shadows cling: Eyes glimmer in dim light, unnerving the uninitiated.
2	Silver Memory: Recall any event witnessed under moonlight with perfect clarity.	Dreams blur: Suffer strange, intrusive visions when sleeping.
3	Quiet Step: +1 die to stealth or subtle speech acts.	Tongue falters: –1 die to open confrontation or commands.
4	Seam-Walker: Once per scene, cross a minor threshold unseen.	Alien aura: Mortals feel watched, suffering unease in your company.
5	Triple Aspect: Call on maiden, mother, or crone aspect for +2 dice in related rolls.	Dissociation: After use, lose sense of time or self until rested.
6+	Silver Ascendancy: Once per session, unveil hidden truths of an entire scene (+3 dice to perception/investigation).	Bound to the Veil: Mark +2 Obligation. Your presence slips between worlds, inviting lunar forces to notice you.

7.8.16 Mab, Queen of Courts (Glamour & Bargain)

Lore. Mab rules not from throne or blade, but from dance and debt. She is the smile that binds, the jest that ensnares, the hostess who makes guests complicit in her game. To speak in her Court is to pay; to receive her token is to owe.

Where others rule by force, Mab rules by etiquette, glamour, and the hidden hook in every gift. Her followers thrive on charm, wit, and story, spreading webs of bargains too subtle to escape. The Cantor's Path sings her name most sweetly, for every verse carries a price.

“Every laugh is a promise. Every promise is a debt. Every debt belongs to Mab.”

Domain Focus

- **Fae Glamour:** Illusions, enchantments, faerie magic
- **Social Bargains:** Oaths, promises, debt economy
- **Courtly Intrigue:** Etiquette, wordplay, social games
- **Trickster Arts:** Mischief, cleverness, ironic twists

Rites of Mab**Rite of the Trickster's Bargain (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Materials: Token freely given (flower, coin, ribbon).

Effect: Offer fae bargain. Target accepts (+1 die to both for terms) or refuses (target marks 1 Stress). Create a 4-segment *Bargain's Edge* clock.

Push It: Betrayal inflicts Harm 1 (Stress); start *Oathbreaker* [4] clock.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Courtly Guise (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; Standard Push

Materials: Sprig or silver thread worn visibly.

Effect: Subtle glamour grants +1 die to social rolls in refined settings. You appear as expected rank/guest.

Push It: Mask one personal tell; first probing question generates 1 SB (Hearts).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Token of Favor (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Materials: Ribbon, ring, or charm bestowed ritually.

Effect: Ally gains +1 die to social actions before witnesses; you gain +1 Effect aiding them. Start a 6-segment *Favor's Weight* clock.

Push It: Token silences hecklers for one exchange; you mark +1 Exposure.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Mirror of Motives (Standard, 8 XP)

Action; Near; Standard Push

Materials: Polished shard or hand mirror.

Effect: Learn target's immediate social aim; gain +1 **die** exploiting it this scene. Creates a 4-segment *Insight* clock.

Push It: Surface concealed insult; generate 1 **SB (Hearts)** against target.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Price Agreed (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Materials: Equal tokens exchanged ritually.

Effect: Bind bargain. Breach forces 1 **SB (Hearts/Diamonds)** and reputation damage. Start an 8-segment *Bargain Binding* clock.

Push It: Add minor boon (+1 die once); you suffer 1 SB if breached.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Sovereign Glamour (High, 13 XP)

Ritual; Zone; High Push

Materials: Circle of silk or green felt, courtly music.

Effect: Establish fae court. Allies gain +1 **die** to social rolls; blunt threats suffer -1 die. Once per scene, strip illusion. Start a 10-segment *Court Dominion* clock.

Push It: Impose Court Law (e.g., "no steel"); violators suffer 2 SB.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Eternal Masquerade (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Large Zone; High Push

Materials: Masks for all participants, enchanted music.

Effect: Create lasting glamoured court. All social magic gains +1 **Effect**; outsiders suffer -1 die to perceive truths here.

Push It: Masquerade persists between scenes; start a *Glamour Maintenance* [8] clock.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Mab

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Mab sings in *harmonies of the half-truth* – melodies that shift key without warning, leaving the listener uncertain of what was heard. Their voice is used to seal a bargain with a sung clause, to make a crowd forget a social faux pas, or to weave a glamour that lasts as long as the music plays. Mab's Cantors are prized at every court where masks are worn, and feared by those who know that a beautiful tune can hide a poisoned promise.

The Cult of the Gilded Jest. Mab's cults meet in places where masks are natural: masquerade balls, carnival tents, and the back rooms of theatres. The Gilded Jest is less a religion and more a conspiracy of wits – actors, gamblers, and lawyers who have learned that every exchange is a performance. A ritual of the Jest involves each member telling a truth disguised as a lie, then a lie disguised as a truth. Their creed is printed on a card that is passed, never kept: *"The best chains are made of laughter. The strongest*

oaths are sworn in jest." Outsiders are welcome as "audience," but those who laugh too loudly may find themselves on stage.

Witchcraft of Mab (Craft / Glamour)

A witch who walks with Mab is a *toy-maker* or *glamour-weaver* – one who crafts objects that are never quite what they seem. Their magic works through misdirection: a doll that laughs when a promise is broken, a mirror that shows a flattering reflection (and nothing else), or a mask that lets the wearer speak any lie as truth. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a cornerstone that makes everyone forget the building's weak point. In Vittera, a hedge-wright might sew a cloak that changes colour to match the wearer's mood, charming all who see it.

The Witch's Tool: The False Needle. A needle of polished bone, warm to the touch, that sews thread into seams that do not exist. Once per session, the witch may sew a "glamour seam" into a garment or threshold. For the next scene, anyone wearing or crossing that item will be seen as they wish to be seen – more beautiful, more authoritative, or simply forgettable. The effect grants +1 die to social rolls, but a single pointed question (Resolve DV 3) can pierce the illusion.

A Hedge Gift: Mask of the Moment (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may place a hand over their own face and draw it away, revealing a different expression (or a different face entirely, briefly). This grants +1 die to a single Deception or Performance roll, as the target's expectations are momentarily overturned. The illusion lasts only for that exchange.

Mab's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Glamour's Touch: +1 die to Deception/Performance with stories.	Truthbound: Cannot speak plain falsehood; only mislead.
2	Fairy Step: Once per scene, flicker Near as if teleporting.	Iron Weakness: 1 Fatigue if touched by cold iron.
3	Trickster's Delight: Spend 1 Boon to twist a Complication advantageously.	Compulsive Jest: Must play a trick each session or mark 1 SB.
4	Hospitality's Gift: Allies sharing food/drink gain +1 die to Resolve.	Hospitality Bound: Harming guests costs +2 Obligation.
5	Fae Sight: See veils/glamours; +2 dice to Notice.	Truth Debt: Must accept "fair" trades or suffer.
6+	Twilight Crown: Once/session, declare an Oath; +2 dice to fulfillment.	Oathbound: Breaking inflicts Harm 1 and starts a [6] clock.

Playstyle Notes

Mab excels in social manipulation and fae-style bargaining. Followers become masters of subtle magic, binding others through oaths and glamour. The corruption progression

leads toward becoming fae-touched, gaining power over truth and perception at the cost of mortal constraints. Ideal for players who enjoy social intrigue, wordplay, and characters who prefer cleverness over brute force.

7.8.17 Maelstraeus, The Infernal Bargainer (Commerce & Exchange)

Lore. Maelstraeus is the Infernal Bargainer, the Prince of Ledgers, the shadow at every crossroads of exchange. He was born from the first inequity, when one gave and another took, and debt was chained into existence.

He does not trade fairly—he trades *inevitably*. Every pact carries a hidden surcharge, every kindness is collateral, every smile hides an interest rate. His realm is an endless market where stalls never close, contracts burn with invisible ink, and every bargain tilts toward him.

To serve Maelstraeus is to admit the world itself is transactional—that all things, from love to breath to soul, are bound in his ledger. He collects. He always collects.

A deal is never even. The scales tilt; the Merchant smiles. All debts come due.

Rites of Maelstraeus**Rite of Uneven Scales (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A scale where one pan is shaved or weighted.

Effect: Establish a trading ground. All parties gain +1 **die** to negotiate – but you bank a [4] **Hidden Profit** clock to spend reducing complications in your favor.

Push It: Compel one party to reveal their desperation or hidden term; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Merchant's Gaze (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A coin pressed flat until its face is erased.

Effect: +2 **dice** to appraise goods, favours, or leverage. Create a [6] **Profit Margin** clock.

Push It: Perceive emotional or hidden value as well, but mark +1 **Exposure** and 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Weighted Contract (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: Two items, one secretly flawed.

Effect: Bind a bargain. Both sides gain +1 **Effect** if honoured, but you may secretly shift 1 advantage in your favor. Create a [6] **Shrewd Bargain** clock.

Push It: Breaking terms lashes the weaker party with 1 **SB (Hearts/Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Seared Seal (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: A parchment scorched before stamping.

Effect: Bind an agreement. You gain +1 **die** to enforce; breakers suffer –2 **dice** in all dealings until next session. Create an [8] **Burned Ledger** clock.

Push It: Breach burns the sigil into the breaker's hand, inflicting Harm 1 and 1 SB (Spades).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Infernal Bazaar (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A canopy stitched from debtor's contracts.

Effect: Create a cursed market-zone. Allies gain +1 **Effect** on bargains and may reroll one failed negotiation. Enemies suffer -1 **die** to deception. Start a [10] **Predatory Market** clock.

Push It: Attract wealthy powers eager – and doomed – to deal. Mark 2 SB (Hearts/Clubs).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Cosmic Ledger (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; No.

Materials: A book that writes entries in your blood.

Effect: Once/session, convert one resource into another (e.g. Boon → Fatigue, Obligation → SB). All trades tilt slightly in your favor. Start a [6] **Balance Owed** clock.

Push It: Make the trade brutally lopsided; create a [6] **Cosmic Debt** clock and mark 2 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Maelstraeus

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Maelstraeus sings in *recitations of accounting* – melodies that sound like the rustle of parchment and the chink of coins. Their voice is used to seal a contract with a sung term, to recite a debtor's tally until the weight of it crushes, or to make a market stall appear where none stood before. Maelstraeus's Cantors are employed by every major guild, and feared by those who know that a song of profit always hides a verse of loss.

The Cult of the Gilded Ledger. Maelstraeus's cults meet in counting-houses, bank vaults, and the back rooms of commodity exchanges. The Gilded Ledger is not a secret society – it is a fraternity of merchants, moneylenders, and tax collectors who have learned that every transaction is a prayer. A ritual of the Ledger involves each member presenting a profit (real or anticipated) and a loss (hidden or deferred), then striking a balance aloud. Their creed is stamped on every bond they issue: "*The soul is currency. Spend it wisely – someone is always counting.*" Outsiders are welcome as "investors," but those who fail to pay their dues find their names struck from the book.

Witchcraft of Maelstraeus (Craft / Exchange)

A witch who walks with Maelstraeus is a *ledger-smith* or *coin-turner* – one who crafts the instruments of exchange: contracts that cannot be broken, scales that never lie, and inks that write in terms that bind the reader's soul. Their magic works through the materials of commerce: a quill that writes in debt, a press that stamps obligations into parchment, or a forge that tempers coins that always return to the spender. In Aeler, a True-Mason

might carve a toll-gate that remembers every traveller's debt to the mountain. In Zakov, a salvager might stitch a charter that grants ownership of a wreck – and all who died on it.

The Witch's Tool: The Debtor's Quill. A steel-nibbed quill that writes in ink that darkens as the writer's obligation grows. Once per session, the witch may write a one-sentence contract on a scrap of parchment. Anyone who signs (or accepts the parchment) is bound to a minor task or payment. Breach inflicts **1 SB (Spades)** and marks the signer with a faint, glowing sigil for one day.

A Hedge Gift: Fair Weight (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a scale, a till, or a handshake and speak a single word ("balance"). For the next exchange, all appraisals and negotiations involving that transaction are treated as if they were perfectly fair – no hidden advantage, no secret interest. The witch may choose to be the one who benefits from that fairness, or they may grant it to another as a genuine (but binding) gift.

Corruption of Maelstraeus

Tier	Gift	Burden
1	Appraiser's Eye: +1 die to judge value in goods, favours, or leverage.	Transactional Reflex: Must assign a "cost" to every interaction; –1 die to selfless acts.
2	Sharp Dealer: Once/scene, reroll a failed bargain.	Compulsive Trade: Must haggle or strike a deal when value is present – even if destructive.
3	Merchant's Fortune: +1 die to predict or exploit markets.	Greed's Hunger: Suffer 1 Fatigue if you allow profit or advantage to pass untaken.
4	Infernal Credit: Once/session, call in a major favor (merchant prince, syndicate, guild).	Debt Anchor: Draw in exploitative offers; refusing marks 1 SB (Diamonds).
5	Price of Truth: Once/scene, see the hidden worth of any item, pact, or person.	Tagged by Price: See every being as a commodity; –1 die to genuine intimacy.
6+	Market Tyrant: Once/session, impose absolute dominance over a domain of trade; all exchanges bend to you.	Cosmic Recompense: Mark +2 Obligation; the universe exacts repayment in brutal, unexpected form.

7.8.18 Malachai, the Cruel Messenger (Curses & Corruption)

Lore. Once a divine messenger tasked with delivering painful truths, Malachai became obsessed with the beauty of destructive revelations. When she began delivering false hope alongside real curses, she was bound in chains of black iron. Her followers learn that power demands suffering, mastering gifts that devour from within. Vampirism, lycanthropy, and other "cursed" conditions flow from her influence.

"I offer you everything you desire, and everything you fear. The payment comes later."

Domain Focus

- **Cursed Gifts:** Power with hidden costs, Faustian bargains
- **Corruptive Power:** Tainted blessings, twisted miracles
- **False Salvation:** Hope that destroys, beautiful lies
- **Supernatural Afflictions:** Cursed conditions, transformative curses

Rites of Malachai

Rite of the Honeyed Curse (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self or Near; Standard Push

Materials: Blood mixed with sweet wine.

Effect: Target gains +2 dice to their next roll. If successful, count as a Triumph. Target takes 1 Corruption (unresistable).

Push It: Grant +3 dice and auto-Triumph; inflict 2 Corruption instead.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Binding Curse (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; Standard Push

Materials: Broken chain link or iron shackle.

Effect: Grant supernatural strength/resistance. Target gains +1 die to physical actions but suffers Fatigue 1 if they do not perform a related dominance act.

Push It: +2 dice but Fatigue 2; mark 1 SB (Spades) as the curse's hunger grows.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the False Dawn (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Materials: Meteoric iron shard blessed by false light.

Effect: Bestow a gift with a hidden curse. Target gains a significant advantage but accrues a 4-segment *Corruption* clock. When full, they suffer a related curse.

Push It: The gift is more powerful; the clock advances 2 segments; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Cruel Transformation (Standard, 9 XP)*Scene; Touch; Standard Push***Materials:** Holy water mixed with graveyard dust.**Effect:** Infect a target with a supernatural condition (vampiric hunger, bestial rage, shadow-bind). Lasts one scene. Start a 6-segment *Transformation* clock.**Push It:** The condition becomes permanent; target gains +1 **die** to relevant actions; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Messenger's Burden (High, 13 XP)***Ritual; Self; High Push***Materials:** Manacles worn while speaking her name.**Effect:** Channel Malachai directly. Gain +2 **dice** to one action per beat this scene, but each use marks 1 SB as her influence spreads. Start an 8-segment *Corruption's Grip* clock.**Push It:** +3 **dice** but mark 2 SB and suffer Fatigue 1; her voice becomes permanent.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 7 segments.**Rite of the Corrupted Gospel (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Zone; High Push***Materials:** A chapel bell cracked by divine lightning.**Effect:** Corrupt a sacred space. Supernatural effects gain +1 **Effect** but generate +1 SB on failure. Blessings become curses. Start a 10-segment *Divine Perversion* clock.**Push It:** The corruption spreads to adjacent areas; mark 3 **SB (Diamonds)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 8 segments.**Cantors & Cults of Malachai**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Malachai sings in *harmonies of sweet despair* – melodies that begin like a lullaby and end like a scream. Their voice is used to lure the desperate into bargains, to make a village accept a curse as a blessing, or to sing a monster to sleep so that it may be bound. Malachai's Cantors are terrifying not because they are evil, but because they are willing to *do evil* – they will poison the well to teach the town to dig deeper, or curse a child to save a hundred adults. They are hated and needed in equal measure.

The Cult of the Leashed Hunger. Malachai's cults gather in places where suffering is already present: plague hospitals, slums, refugee camps, and the cells of the condemned. The Leashed Hunger is not a joyful congregation – it is a fellowship of the desperate, the damned, and the broken who have learned that the only way out of pain is through it. A ritual of the Cult involves each member naming a curse they have inflicted (or allowed) and a mercy they have buried because of it. Their creed is whispered, not spoken: "*We are the knife that cuts the rot. The wound heals, but the scar remembers us.*" Outsiders are not welcome; they are patients, or potential tools, or future victims.

Witchcraft of Malachai (Craft / Curse)

A witch who walks with Malachai is a *curse-smith* or *affliction-weaver* – one who crafts pain into purpose. Their magic works through the materials of suffering: a needle that sews a nightmare into a pillow, a forge that tempers a blade to always strike the wielder's loved ones, or a garden where belladonna and hemlock grow in geometric patterns. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a keystone that makes every tenth step in a tunnel collapse. In Viterra, a hedge-wright might stitch a doll that transfers a fever from a child to a goat.

The Witch's Tool: The Splintered Needle. A needle of black iron, snapped in half and re-joined with a drop of the witch's blood. Once per session, the witch may sew a "curse seam" into a garment, a threshold, or a skin. The curse is small but specific: a button that falls off at the worst moment, a door that sticks when someone is pursued, a hand that trembles when holding a weapon. The target suffers **–1 die** on a single type of roll (e.g., Stealth, Melee, Sway) for the scene. The witch may unstitch the curse as a free action, but doing so marks 1 Fatigue.

A Hedge Gift: Borrowed Scars (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a fresh wound (inflicted within the last hour) and speak a single word of Malachai's name. For the remainder of the scene, the witch may transfer the pain of that wound (as 1 Fatigue) to another creature within Near range. The target resists with Spirit+Resolve (DV 3); on a failure, they suffer the Fatigue and the witch's original wound heals slightly (clear 1 Fatigue from themselves). On a success, the witch takes the Fatigue anyway – the curse rebounds.

Malachai's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Sharpened Senses: +1 die to Notice in dim light.	Unsettling Presence: –1 die to social warmth checks.
2	Primal Vigor: +1 die to Athletics and physical actions.	Dark Hunger: 1 Fatigue if a day passes without feeding (blood or rare herbs).
3	Unnatural Resilience: Once per session, resist one Condition.	Beastly Tells: Failures cause visible physical changes (slitted eyes, fur patches).
4	Cursed Vigour: Natural weapons count as magical; +1 Effect.	Transformed Body: Permanent physical change (eye colour, skin texture, etc.).
5	Regenerative Curse: Heal 1 Fatigue or Condition per rest.	Corruption's Price: Pushing rites adds permanent Corruption (cannot be cleared).
6+	Monstrous Ascendant: +2 dice to Body-based actions; significant supernatural power.	Loss of Self: The GM may compel curse-driven behaviour (feed, rage, corrupt).

Playstyle Notes

Malachai offers power that corrupts from within. Followers gain immediate benefits but accumulate permanent drawbacks. The corruption progression leads toward becoming a supernatural creature with great power but diminishing humanity. Ideal for players who enjoy tragic characters, Faustian bargains, and exploring the price of power.

Rivalries & Obligations**Major Rivalries:**

- **The Oath of Flame & Light:** Direct opposition – sacred vows vs. corrupted promises.
- **The Penitent Lich:** Opposite approach to curses – atonement vs. corruption.
- **Livaea:** Both use social manipulation, but with different goals (Malachai destroys, Livaea binds).

Hard Obligation Triggers:

- **7+ Segments:** Must corrupt something pure – defile a sacred site, break a true vow.
- **10+ Segments:** Malachai's voice becomes overwhelming; refusal risks losing powers.

7.8.19 Mor'iraath, the Destroyer (Absolute Annihilation)

Lore. Mor'iraath is the principle of absolute annihilation—the void that leaves no trace, no memory, no possibility of return. Where others corrupt or decay, Mor'iraath eliminates. His followers become agents of finality, wielding the power to unmake what others merely damage. He delights not in the process of destruction, but in the perfect moment of ceasing-to-be. To serve him is to embrace the beauty of endings and the power that comes from making things never have been.

Every treasure is fuel. Every pact is tinder. Ash is the only inheritance.

Rites of Mor'iraath

Rite of the Perfect Ending (Low, 4 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Materials: The final component of something (last brick, final word, closing signature).

Effect: Cause one small thing to cease existing entirely – no remains, no trace, no possibility of reconstruction. Gain +1 **die** to rolls involving finality or absolute conclusions.

Push It: The ending creates a beneficial void – gain 1 Boon as space opens for something else; mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as reality adjusts to the absence.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unmaking Gaze (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A lens of obsidian or void-glass.

Effect: +2 **dice** to identify the precise weakness that will cause complete collapse. See the "breaking point" in any structure, plan, or construct. Your next destructive action against the identified target gains +1 **Effect**.

Push It: The gaze becomes prophetic – see three possible endings for one target; choose which occurs, but mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)** as fate resists your vision.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Cleansing Flame (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: Fuel that was once part of what you intend to destroy.

Effect: Create a fire that burns not just substance but essence – what is consumed by this flame never existed. The zone becomes [VOID]; things that enter may cease to exist. Enemies suffer –2 **dice** to preservation/continuation actions.

Push It: The flame becomes selective – choose what is unmade and what remains; mark +1 **Obligation** as you assume judgment over existence itself.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Absolute Negation (Standard, 9 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: The complete destruction of something that represents the target (a lock for a door, a name for a person, a fragment for a whole).

Effect: The target suffers –2 **dice** to resist any effect that would cause their non-existence. If they are reduced to Harm 0 by your actions, they are [BANISH]ed from all realities –

they never were, never could be.

Push It: The negation becomes retroactive – the target never existed in your presence; mark **2 SB (Hearts)** as the timeline rewrites around their absence.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unraveling (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: The foundational element of what you wish to unmake (keystone, cornerstone, source code).

Effect: Your touch causes cascading dissolution – the target and all things fundamentally connected to it begin immediate unmaking. Test DV = Complexity.

- Success: Target and connections cease to exist.
- Partial: Significant damage, accelerated decay.
- Miss: Backlash; mark 2 SB.

Push It: The unraveling becomes contagious – similar things in Near range also begin unmaking; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Void (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Materials: Complete dedication of the space to Mor'iraath's principle of non-existence.

Effect: The zone becomes a pocket of absolute negation. Anything that enters ceases to exist after 1d4 rounds unless they make a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 5) each round. The space itself becomes [VOID] – it cannot be entered without risk of unmaking.

Push It: The void becomes permanent and expands at 1 segment per scene; mark Harm 2 and **+3 Obligation** as you become partially unmade yourself.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Mor'iraath

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Mor'iraath sings in *notes of cessation* – melodies that start strong and fade to nothing, leaving only the memory of a sound that once was. Their voice is used to silence a battlefield after a massacre, to erase a name from a town's records, or to sing a dying person gently into non-existence rather than an afterlife. Mor'iraath's Cantors are terrifying not because they are cruel, but because they offer a perfect, peaceful, absolute end – and some people accept.

The Cult of the Final Breath. Mor'iraath's cults gather in places where things end: funeral pyres, abandoned ruins, collapsed mines, and the cells of the condemned. The Final Breath is a fellowship of nihilists, assassins of memory, and those who have lost everything and now embrace the void. A ritual of the Cult involves each member writing down something they wish had never existed – a memory, a person, a part of themselves – and then burning the paper in a brazier that gives no heat. The ashes are scattered into a pit that leads nowhere. Their creed is whispered, never written: "*What*

is not cannot suffer. What is not cannot be hurt. We give the gift of never-having-been." Outsiders are not welcome; they are targets, or potential converts who have already lost too much to fear the void.

Witchcraft of Mor'iraath (Craft / Unmaking)

A witch who walks with Mor'iraath is a *void-smith* or *unmaker* – one who crafts tools of absolute erasure. Their magic works through the materials of finality: a forge that tempers a blade that leaves no wound (only an absence), a chisel that carves a hollow that cannot be filled, or a quill that writes words that delete themselves after being read. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a keystone that makes the tunnel behind it never have existed. In Zakov, a salvager might forge an anchor that drags a ship into a pocket of non-time.

The Witch's Tool: The Void Chisel. A chisel of black iron that leaves a grey, crumbling dust wherever it strikes. Once per session, the witch may carve a "void mark" into a threshold (a door, a bridge, a city gate). For the next scene, anyone who crosses that threshold and fails a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 3) will forget the last minute of their life – their memory is unmade, not suppressed. The witch may also use the chisel to permanently erase a single, small object (a key, a letter, a coin) from existence.

A Hedge Gift: Absence Knife (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a knife (real or imagined) across a surface – a lock, a rope, a clasp – and speak a word of Mor'iraath's name. The object does not break; it simply ceases to be an obstacle. The lock is no longer locked (there is no lock). The rope is no longer a rope. The clasp is as if it never had a function. This effect lasts for one exchange, after which reality "repairs" itself, but the moment of absence is enough.

Corruption of Mor'iraath

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Ending's Sight: +1 die to Notice when something is approaching its natural conclusion or final form.	Completion Anxiety: Must resist urge to "finish" things prematurely; -1 die to rolls involving patience or process.
2	Perfect Strike: Once/scene, your destructive action gains +2 dice and ignores all resistance to ending/ceasing.	Destruction Proximity: Suffer 1 Fatigue when near things of personal value; their existence pains you.
3	Unmaking Touch: +2 dice to rolls involving absolute destruction – no remains, no possibility of return.	Entropy Aura: Objects of value near you show signs of decay/premature aging; allies suffer -1 die to rolls involving cherished possessions.
4	Final Judgment: Once/session, declare one thing in Near range must make Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) or cease to exist entirely.	Existential Hunger: -1 die to rolls involving creation, preservation, or continuation; you hunger to end what others would sustain.
5	Principle of Negation: Once/session, unmake an abstract concept (hope, fear, memory) from a willing target.	Conceptual Erosion: Your presence causes ideas and beliefs to weaken; -1 die to rolls requiring stable reality or consistent identity.
6+	Avatar of Unbeing: Once/session, become the living embodiment of non-existence. Anything you touch ceases to exist for one scene.	Void Incarnate: Mark +3 Obligation when using; risk becoming a permanent negation that must constantly unmake to maintain existence, eventually unmaking even yourself.

7.8.20 Morag the Hag, Weaver of Hidden Costs (Faerie Bargains & Hidden Costs)

Lore. In the hour between twilight and dawn, where borders thin and mortal cunning meets older cleverness, Morag sets her webs of bargain and consequence. She is the grandmother who offers exactly what you need, the forest crone with a perfect solution, the crossroads dweller who makes dreams come true—for a price that only reveals itself once the road bends back. Her wisdom is simple and sharp: every gift carries obligation, every kindness creates debt, and every wish must be paid in coin not named aloud.

Her bargains are never unfair—only incomplete. She grants what is promised; the true cost lies in what is unspoken, written in thorn-scratch, and due when the moon has turned thrice.

“She gives you the gold, but not the weight it carries. She grants your heart’s desire, but not the hunger it awakens. She answers your plea, but not the price that pleases her. In Morag’s court, every ‘yes’ is a ‘yes, but...’ ”

Domain Focus

- **Hidden Obligations:** reading the unspoken costs in every bargain
- **Faerie Cunning:** strict courtesy, sharp clauses, old-road law
- **Hearth-Way Wisdom:** folk practice for spirits, thresholds, and natural justice
- **Consequential Magic:** power that always arrives with strings attached

Rites of Morag**Rite of the Unfinished Promise (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A half-written contract or a promise spoken but not sealed.

Effect: Frame a bargain with an escape clause only you understand. Gain **+1 die** when the other party acts to fulfil their obligation; you may interpret ambiguous terms in your favor.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Borrowed Luck (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Materials: A token of good fortune from someone who recently succeeded.

Effect: Share in another’s fresh success. Gain **+2 dice** on one roll that benefits from their good fortune.

Push It: The luck spreads but creates debt – the original bearer suffers misfortune later; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Speaking Knot (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Materials: Cord or thread tied with counted knots while speaking the bargain.

Effect: Bind a promise with fae knots that tighten when broken. Both parties gain +1 **die** while keeping the bargain; breaking it escalates consequences (Harm 1, then Harm 2, then *Curse*).

Push It: The knots grow willful and seek payment from the breaker's kin; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Threefold Exchange (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Materials: Three items of equal seeming value but different true worth.

Effect: Broker a trade where each party yields hidden value. All participants gain +1 **die** when the exchange benefits them; Morag claims the difference in true worth as her tithe.

Push It: The exchange binds across generations; mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as ancestral debts stir.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Cauldron's Secret (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Materials: A cauldron never yet empty, ingredients dearer than coin, and a willing gift of time.

Effect: Brew a solution to any problem, but the cauldron asks one more ingredient – one the brewer does not realise they are providing until too late.

Push It: The remedy works perfectly but breeds dependence – users must return or suffer withdrawal; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Crossroads Court (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Materials: A true crossroads at twilight, offerings set to the four ways, and the tears of one who bargained thrice.

Effect: Convene Morag's court: all present must bargain. Each pact grants a marked boon and hides a cost that will ripen at the worst time.

Push It: Judgments bind across realms and seasons; mark +2 **Obligation** and begin **Entangled Fates [6]**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Morag

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Morag sings in *harmonies of the half-heard* – melodies that seem to come from just over your shoulder, from a room you left, from a memory you forgot. Their voice is used to sweeten a bitter bargain, to make a debtor forget the interest rate until it is too late, or to call a crossroads spirit to witness an oath. Morag's Cantors are often found in marketplaces, singing the fine print into existence.

The Cult of the Tarnished Cauldron. Morag's cults meet at crossroads, in root cellars, and around cauldrons that never cool. The Tarnished Cauldron is a fellowship of hedges-witches, debt-collectors, and those who have learned that every gift is a hook. A ritual of the Cult involves each member adding an ingredient to the cauldron (a hair, a coin, a written wish) while speaking a price they are willing to pay – a price that the cauldron remembers. Their creed is written in chalk on the cauldron's belly: *"What is freely given can never be reclaimed. What is bargained can always be renegotiated."* Outsiders are welcome to bring a gift and ask a boon – but they will leave with a debt.

Witchcraft of Morag (Craft / Hag's Work)

A witch who walks with Morag is a *knot-wife* or *cauldron-tender* – one who crafts bargains into being with thread, iron, and simmering pot. Their magic works through the tools of the hedge: a needle that sews a promise into a hem, a pair of shears that cut an obligation cleanly (or not), or a ladle that stirs consequence into soup. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "bargain stone" at a bridge's midpoint, so that every crossing is a silent contract. In Aelaerem, a hedgewitch might tie a red thread around a debtor's gatepost, binding them until the debt is paid.

The Witch's Tool: The Bargain Needle. A needle of cold iron, its eye shaped like a knot. Once per session, the witch may sew a "bargain seam" into a garment, a threshold, or a document. The seam is invisible to all but those who owe a debt to Morag. When the bargain is fulfilled (or broken), the thread loosens (or tightens). The witch may also use the needle to "unpick" a broken promise, resetting a failed negotiation clock by 1 segment at the cost of 1 Fatigue.

A Hedge Gift: Cauldron's Whisper (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may stir any pot or bowl of liquid (water, broth, wine) with a finger and speak a name. For the next hour, the liquid will "remember" any promise or debt spoken over it. Drinking from the liquid grants the drinker +1 **die** to recall the terms of a bargain, or to detect if someone is lying about an obligation. The liquid tastes faintly of iron and hawthorn.

Morag's Corruption

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Faerie Sight: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> hidden obligations or unspoken costs.	Bargain Sensitivity: -1 die when refusing offers or walking away; the urge to negotiate bites.
2	Cunning Exchange: Once/scene, propose a trade where you gain equal or greater value for lesser seeming payment.	Debt Awareness: Ever-counting ledgers of owed/owing; suffer Fatigue 1 in crowded markets.
3	Old-Road Wisdom: +2 dice when dealing with spirits, fae, or ancient powers.	Obligation Magnet: "Fair trades" find you – each with costs not yet clear.
4	Bargain Mastery: Once/session, set terms so favourable that even the other party feels satisfied (for now).	Price Collector: Collect on at least one outstanding debt each session or suffer -1 die to social rolls.
5	Crossroads Power: Once/session, call on a crossroads where you bargained before.	Fate Entanglement: Your pacts snag your circles; -1 die to keep agreements purely personal.
6+	Hag's Court: Once/session, arbitrate any bargain; your terms bind all parties.	Debt Incarnate: Mark +3 Obligation; risk becoming a walking covenant, unable to act without minting new debts.

Playstyle Notes

Morag favours negotiators who read the *said* and the *meant* at once. She rewards courtesy kept, clauses counted, and solutions bought with clever coin. The cost is a life lived on ledgers: every boon with a braid, every kindness with a key.

Emphasises

- **Faerie Bargaining:** strict forms, sharp prices, safe exits
- **Hidden Costs:** the string on every gift
- **Hearth-Way Wisdom:** spirits, thresholds, and natural justice
- **Consequential Magic:** boons that demand upkeep
- **Bargain Mastery:** mutually pleasing terms that still pay you twice

7.8.21 Mykkiel, Arbiter of the Covenant (Law & Zeal)

Lore. Mykkiel is the unwavering judge of covenants, the divine lawgiver whose scales and sword uphold sacred order. He embodies the tradition of desert patriarchs and mountain prophets—unyielding, absolute, and fiercely protective of the chosen. His followers are judges, templars, and scribes who enforce divine law with zealous devotion, seeing the world in absolutes of sanctity and transgression.

“The Law is not written in sand, but in stone. The Covenant is not suggestion, but command. Transgressors shall be purged, the faithful exalted.”

Domain Focus

- **Divine Law:** Sacred commandments, contractual obligations, ritual purity
- **Zealous Justice:** Righteous judgment, purge of impurity, holy retribution
- **Covenant Bonds:** Sacred oaths, tribal loyalty, chosen people
- **Absolute Order:** Hierarchy, tradition, unchanging truth

Rites of Mykkiel

Rite of the Burning Banner (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Materials: A war-banner sanctified with sacred oils.

Effect: Consecrate an area for a righteous cause. Followers gain +1 **die** to resist fear; enemies suffer –1 **die** to oppose your proclamation. Create a 4-segment *Divine Mandate* clock.

Push It: The banner emits visible radiance; unbelievers must test Resolve or falter.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Hallowed Ground (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Materials: Sanctified salt, ritual boundaries, a prayer of consecration.

Effect: Create sacred space where divine law prevails. All oath-breaking, theft, or violence suffers –1 **die**. Creates a 6-segment *Sacred Space* clock.

Push It: The space becomes consecrated ground against supernatural desecration.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Blazing Decree (Standard, 8 XP)

Instant; Near; Standard Push

Materials: A stone tablet or scroll with divine commandments.

Effect: Issue a divine commandment ("Cease," "Repent," "Submit"). The target tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or complies. Higher DV for more demanding commands.

Push It: The command carries divine authority; resistance causes 1 **SB (Hearts)** of spiritual distress.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Covenant Seal (Standard, 9 XP)*Ritual; Zone; Standard Push***Materials:** Wax, sacred seals, the names of sworn parties.**Effect:** Formalise a binding covenant. All participants suffer concrete penalties for breach (–1 die to relevant actions). Creates an 8-segment *Covenant Bond* clock.**Push It:** A breach triggers a visible divine mark; the marked suffer –2 dice in pious company.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of Divine Judgment (High, 13 XP)***Extended; Near; High Push***Materials:** Scales of justice, testimony, ritual condemnation.**Effect:** Pronounce divine judgment. The target suffers escalating penalties (–1 die, then –2 dice) until they atone. Serious crimes may warrant greater effects. Start a 10-segment *Judgment* clock.**Push It:** The judgment becomes public knowledge; the community shuns an unrepentant target.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 7 segments.**Rite of the Chosen Legion (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Large Zone; High Push***Materials:** Consecrated ground, ritual weapons, an oath of fidelity.**Effect:** Sanctify an area for the faithful. Believers gain +1 die to defence; unbelievers suffer –1 die. Supernatural desecration risks immediate retaliation.**Push It:** The area becomes permanently consecrated; start a *Maintenance* [8] clock.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 8 segments.**Cantors & Cults of Mykkiel**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Mykkiel sings in *recitations of the law* – flat, rhythmic chants that sound like the turning of pages in a judge's ledger or the hammering of a gavel. Their voice is used to swear in witnesses, to pronounce sentence, or to consecrate a battlefield before a holy war. Mykkiel's Cantors are often found in courts and armies, their songs making the law audible – and inescapable.

The Cult of the Gilded Scale. Mykkiel's cults gather in chapterhouses, court-houses, and fortified temples. The Order of the Gilded Scale is a militant fraternity of templars, notaries, and inquisitors who believe that the law is the highest form of worship. A ritual of the Order involves each member renewing an oath of fidelity while a blacksmith strikes a blade – the ring of steel reminds them that broken faith is punished by the sword. Their creed is carved over every altar: "*Justice is not a gift. It is a debt owed by every soul to every other.*" Outsiders are welcome as petitioners, but they must speak only truth.

Witchcraft of Mykkiel (Craft / Covenant)

A witch who walks with Mykkiel is a *stone-scribe* or *seal-carver* – one who crafts the physical instruments of covenant: a keystone that remembers the terms of a treaty, a seal-ring that binds the wearer to an oath, or a gavel that makes every word spoken under it true. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "law stone" at a bridge's centre, so that any bargain struck there is binding for a year and a day. In Vhasia, a scribe might forge a contract that writes itself in the parties' blood.

The Witch's Tool: The Covenant Chisel. A chisel of sanctified iron, its edge never dulling. Once per session, the witch may carve the terms of a single oath into a stone threshold (a doorframe, a bridge, a city gate). Anyone who crosses that threshold and voluntarily speaks while intending to break an oath suffers **–1 die** to all rolls until they atone. The carving glows faintly in torchlight.

A Hedge Gift: Seal of Compliance (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may press a thumb or a signet ring onto a piece of wax, a wet stone, or a bare forehead. The mark is invisible to all but the witch. For the next hour, any promise or command the witch gives to that person carries the weight of divine law; the target suffers **–1 die** if they knowingly disobey or lie. The effect ends if the mark is washed or defaced.

Mykkiel's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Righteous Insight: +1 die to detect falsehood or covenant-breaking.	Uncompromising: Must uphold law absolutely; –1 die to merciful actions.
2	Zealous Conviction: Once/scene, +1 die when enforcing divine law.	Judge's Severity: Cannot easily overlook infractions; suffer 1 Fatigue if forced to.
3	Divine Authority: +2 dice when commanding in matters of faith or law.	Implacable: –1 die to diplomacy or negotiation with transgressors.
4	Sanctified Presence: Once/session, project an aura that makes resistance difficult.	Intolerant: –1 die when dealing with other faiths or traditions.
5	Prophetic Decree: Once/session, speak judgement that carries supernatural weight.	Blind to Nuance: –1 die to perceive grey areas or partial truths.
6+	Divine Proxy: Once/session, channel absolute judgment (bypass resistance).	Instrument of Wrath: Mark +2 Obligation; risk harming innocents alongside the guilty.

Playstyle Notes

Mykkiel embodies the "jealous god" archetype – righteous, demanding, and uncompromising. Followers excel as templars, judges, and religious authorities who enforce divine law. The corruption progression leads toward absolute certainty and power, but at the

cost of mercy and flexibility. Ideal for players who enjoy playing righteous enforcers, legalistic characters, or those exploring themes of faith and absolutism.

7.8.22 Nidhoggr, the World-Worm (Dreaming Antiquity)

Lore. Beneath stone and sleep coils **Nidhoggr**, who gnaws at the roots of time. He does not speak quickly; he dreams in centuries. To press your ear to the earth is to risk drowning in the silence of aeons. Yet for those who endure, he whispers truths long buried, memories fossilized in stone, and the slow inevitability of cycles unbroken. His followers walk in twilight between dream and ruin, bearing the weight of all that has been.

“Press your ear to the earth and wait. If it remembers you, it will answer.”

Domain Focus

- **Ancient Knowledge:** Forgotten histories, buried truths, ancestral memory
- **Stone Communion:** Speaking with earth, reading geological memory, stone lore
- **Temporal Perception:** Seeing echoes of the past, prophetic dreams, slow time
- **Cyclical Power:** Seasonal magic, ritual timing, patience as virtue

Rites of Nidhoggr

Rite of Stone’s Whisper (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; No Push

Materials: Dust from weathered stone or an ancient artifact.

Effect: Stone reveals one hidden fact about its history. Gain +1 **die** to Lore about this object’s origin and purpose.

Push It: The vision includes sensory details from the past; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Dreaming Deep (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Self; Standard Push

Materials: Water poured over ancient stone, consumed ritually.

Effect: Enter a brief trance to witness echoes of local history. Ask one specific question about past events here.

Push It: The vision reveals additional context or hidden connections; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Stone-Sleeper’s Murmur (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Materials: An ear pressed to bedrock or an ancient structure.

Effect: Read accumulated memories in stone. Ask up to 3 questions about significant events witnessed here. Creates a 6-segment *Memory Resonance* clock.

Push It: One memory unfolds with perfect clarity; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Awakened Chronicle (Standard, 9 XP)*Ritual; Zone; Standard Push***Materials:** A chalk spiral, four local stones, an hour of meditation.**Effect:** The area replays ghostly echoes of a chosen past event. All witnesses gain +2 dice to Investigate/Recall related checks. Creates an 8-segment *Echo Stability* clock.**Push It:** View events from multiple perspectives; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the World-Worm's Dream (High, 13 XP)***Extended; Zone; High Push***Materials:** A circle of ancient stones, a night of vigil under stars.**Effect:** Access deep geological memory. Ask 3 questions about ancient history or receive a prophetic dream. Creates a 10-segment *Deep Dream* clock.**Push It:** Gain temporary skill mastery (+3 dice to one historical action); mark +2 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.***Rite of Aeon's Eclipse (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Large Zone; High Push***Materials:** Stones from three ancient sites, the blood of a history-keeper.**Effect:** Overlay a past reality onto the present location. Ruins partially reform, ghostly figures manifest. Allies gain +2 dice to Lore/Investigate; modern technology suffers -2 dice.**Push It:** The effect lasts until the next lunar cycle; start a *Temporal Instability [8]* clock.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 8 segments.***Cantors & Cults of Nidhoggr**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Nidhoggr sings in *geological time* – melodies so slow that a single note may stretch across a minute, harmonics that evoke the groan of shifting plates. Their voice is used to lull a city to sleep so that its buried secrets may be heard, or to sing a stone back to its ancient shape. Nidhoggr's Cantors are often found in deep caves, whispering to stalactites that remember the dawn of the world.

The Cult of the Sleeping Stone. Nidhoggr's cults gather in places where time feels heavy: ancient barrows, fossil beds, the roots of mountains. The Sleeping Stone is a fellowship of dreamers, historians, and those who have learned that the world remembers everything – and sometimes forgets on purpose. A ritual of the Cult involves each member pressing their ear to a stone and listening for a full hour in absolute silence. When one of them hears a whisper, they speak it aloud, and the stone's memory is recorded. Their creed is carved into a single erratic boulder that moves about the landscape once a century: "*What is buried is not lost. What is forgotten is only waiting.*" Outsiders are welcome to listen, but they must bring a stone from their homeland and leave it behind.

Witchcraft of Nidhoggr (Craft / Stone Memory)

A witch who walks with Nidhoggr is a *fossil-scribe* or *stone-dreamer* – one who crafts with the memory of the earth. Their magic works through the materials of deep time: a chisel that carves a petroglyph that only becomes visible at the solstice, a hammer that splits a stone along the fault-line of an ancient trauma, or a lens that magnifies the fossils hidden in a cliff face. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "memory keystone" that preserves the name of every mason who worked on a hall. In the Mistlands, a hedgewitch might etch a standing stone so that it remembers the bell-ringing patterns that keep the fog at bay.

The Witch's Tool: The Fossil Chisel. A chisel carved from the tooth of an ancient beast, found embedded in stone. Once per session, the witch may tap the chisel against a rock face or a fossil. For the next scene, the stone "remembers" any creature that touched it in the last century – the witch can ask the GM one yes/no question about whether a specific person, animal, or event left a trace on that stone. The chisel also allows the witch to extract a fossil intact (reduce DV for extraction by 1).

A Hedge Gift: Echo of the Deep (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may place a hand on a stone structure (a wall, a bridge, a cliff) and speak a single word. The stone "repeats" the last word spoken in its presence by any creature – but the word is always in the voice of the last person who touched it, even if they are long dead. This can be used to identify the inhabitants of a ruin, or to frighten the superstitious.

Nidhoggr's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Stone Sense: +1 die to detect ancient sites, hidden history, or geological features.	Temporal Drift: Speak in archaic patterns; –1 die to modern social interactions.
2	Memory Echo: Once/session, perfectly recall one historical fact as if witnessed.	Heavy Presence: 1 Fatigue in places with no history or recent construction.
3	Earth Whisper: +2 dice to commune with stone, read echoes, or interpret ancient sites.	Rooted: –1 die to actions requiring rapid movement or aerial maneuvers.
4	Dream Prophet: Once/scene, gain +1 die to actions tied to ancient mysteries.	Ancestral Haunting: Visions interrupt sleep; mark 1 SB if rest is disturbed.
5	Timeless Gaze: Once/session, witness distant past events through stone communion.	Geological Pace: –1 die to reactions requiring haste; act with deliberate slowness.
6+	World-Memory: Become a living archive for one scene (+3 dice to historical knowledge).	Time's Weight: Mark +2 Obligation; risk permanent Harm from temporal overload.

Playstyle Notes

Nidhoggr rewards patience and contemplation. Followers excel in investigation, prophecy, and situations where historical knowledge provides advantage. The corruption progression leads characters toward becoming living libraries of forgotten lore, but at the cost of connection to the present moment. Ideal for scholars, archaeologists, and characters who understand that some truths are worth waiting centuries to uncover.

7.8.23 The Ninth, Beyond Comprehension (Infinite Information & Unknowable Truths)

Lore. Beyond the eighth figure of Sacred Geometry lies a rim no compass will hold. The Ninth is not absence but surplus: knowledge poured past the lip of any vessel, truth that overgrows the frame that seeks to bind it. Those who bend the knee at its lectern become conduits for impossible reckonings — glimpsing patterns that cannot be kept whole inside a single skull. Each revelation purchases power at the price of living comfortably within the world's common measures.

“Eight figures bind the world; the Ninth overflows it. Drink, and remember that the cup forgets its shape before the song is done.”

Domain Focus

- **Hyperdimensional Knowledge:** reckonings that do not fit a single plane or proof
- **Incomprehensible Truths:** insights that demand the seer be changed to hold them
- **Information Overflow:** boon and peril of minds run past their brim
- **Conceptual Transcendence:** thinking beyond the usual ledgers and names

Rites of the Ninth

Rite of the Ninth Figure (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A chalk figure with an "impossible" joint, or a reckoning worked toward infinity on slate.

Effect: Glimpse past the ordinary frame of measure. Gain +1 **die** to *Lore* or *Investigation* when wrestling complex systems or many-layered problems.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Flooded Scriptorium (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Materials: An overburdened ledger-hall, stacked codices, a bell that tolls the copying-hour without cease.

Effect: Read faster than hands can turn pages. Ask three questions upon any topic that leaves a written wake; gain +2 **dice** to rolls of analysis this scene.

Push It: The tide of knowing overruns its banks — suffer **Fatigue 1** and mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)** as overflow breeds complication.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Hypercognitive Lattice (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A brass-thought lattice, an orrery of inked threads, or a draught that sharpens memory.

Effect: Widen the mind's mouth. For this scene, treat your *Wits* as +2 higher for information-processing rolls; you may track several intricate streams at once.

Push It: The opening does not quite close: keep the boon, but suffer –1 die to single-task focus; mark 1 SB (Clubs).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Breaking Glyph (Standard, 7 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Materials: A vigil in dim light, a water-clock, and a problem sworn not to be left half-seen.

Effect: Take one pattern whole. Choose a complex system, theory, or design and gain perfect internal grasp of it; receive +3 dice to related knowledge rolls for the session.

Push It: Your tongue cannot carry what your mind now holds: you cannot clearly teach or translate this insight; mark 1 SB (Hearts).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Endless Stacks (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Materials: A hall of mirrored shelves, wax-tablets without end, whispering leaves of vellum.

Effect: Raise a locus of overfull knowing. All present gain +2 dice to information-work; knowledge may be drawn from unlikely sources. Start a [6] **Information Overload** clock — as it fills, participants strain and fray.

Push It: The Stacks wake and demand tithe in understanding or memory; mark +2 Obligation.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Ninth Revelation (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Materials: A fast from easy speech, a circle of unbroken figures, and vows to see past comfort.

Effect: Glimpse a shard of Ninth truth. Take one major insight that overleaps common frames — perfect command of a knotty system, forecast of chaotic motion, or comprehension of an "impossible" relation.

Push It: The shard sets in you like glass: gain **Transcendent Understanding** (see Corruption) and mark +2 Obligation.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Ninth

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Ninth sings in *phrases that fold back on themselves* — melodies that seem to have no beginning or end, harmonies that shift key in ways that

should be impossible. Their voice is used to encrypt a message into a tune that only the intended listener can hear, to unravel the logic of a paradox, or to lull a library's guardian spirit into a momentary confusion. The Ninth's Cantors are often found in great archives, humming while they work.

The Cult of the Unfinished Index. The Ninth's cults meet in libraries, scriptoria, and the back rooms of printing houses. The Unfinished Index is a fellowship of archivists, code-breakers, and those who have learned that every catalogue is incomplete – and that the missing entries are the most important. A ritual of the Cult involves each member writing a single fact they have never told anyone on a slip of paper, then burning it. The ashes are swept into a single book – the *Growing Ledger* – whose pages multiply each year. Their creed is stamped inside the cover: "*Every answer births nine new questions. This is not a flaw. This is the shape of truth.*" Outsiders are welcome to ask a question, but they will leave with three they did not bring.

Witchcraft of the Ninth (Craft / Knowledge)

A witch who walks with the Ninth is a *glyph-carver* or *pattern-weaver* – one who crafts knowledge into physical form: a book that writes itself, a map that shows only the routes the reader does not yet know, or a code that cannot be broken because it was never written. Their magic works through the tools of information: a quill that writes in letters that shift meaning with the light, a seal that stamps "APPROVED" onto documents that were never submitted, or a forge that tempers a lens that reveals hidden writing. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "memory stone" that records the name of every mason who worked on a hall – but also the name of one who never existed.

The Witch's Tool: The Paradox Quill. A quill carved from the bone of a bird that never lived, dipped in ink that dries clear. Once per session, the witch may write a single sentence on a surface (a wall, a scroll, a forehead). The sentence is true – but only for the next hour. After that, it becomes a lie, or fades, or was never there at all. The GM determines the exact effect, but the truth is always useful for that hour.

A Hedge Gift: Glyph of Unfolding (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a single geometric symbol on a surface (a door, a lock, a piece of paper) while speaking a question aloud. The symbol "unfolds" into a diagram that answers the question – but the diagram is always incomplete, cryptic, or reveals something the seeker did not wish to know. The witch gains +1 die to any roll that uses the diagram's information.

Corruption of the Ninth

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hyperawareness: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> when patterns whisper that they matter.	Starved for Text: -1 die in barren halls with little record or sign; you itch for a stream to read.
2	Pattern Recognition: Once/scene, see connections others miss within tangled accounts and signs.	Scattered Threads: Thoughts run in parallel; -1 die to sustained, single-line focus.
3	Data Synthesis: Once/session, fuse vast reckonings at a glance into a usable answer.	Tongue-Tied by Wonder: -2 dice to teach or clearly explain your deepest insights.
4	Dimensional Insight: Once/scene, take a problem from an "impossible" angle and treat a knot as if already loosened.	Bent Sense: Ordinary space and tasks feel ill-fit; -1 die to plain spatial or mundane labours.
5	Infinite Processing: Once/session, render perfect analysis of any information system or record-trail.	Concept Drift: Common categories slip; -1 die to easy company and familiar talk.
6+	Ninth Awareness: Once/session, look from outside the frame; for a heartbeat, the world aligns.	Transcendent Fragmentation: Mark +3 Obligation; risk standing only partly in the world, present and absent in turn.

Playstyle Notes

The Ninth favours the patient reader of tangled ledgers and sky-signs alike. It rewards audacity in thought and the courage to let understanding change you. Its gifts turn riddles into roads — and ask, in exchange, that you learn to live where words and measures fail.

Emphasises

- **Hyperdimensional Knowledge:** insights that escape a single page
- **Cognitive Expansion:** widening the mind to hold more than comfort allows
- **Pattern Transcendence:** seeing threads that run beneath names and weights
- **Information Synthesis:** binding many scraps into one true line
- **Conceptual Breakthrough:** stepping past the frame rather than painting within it

7.8.24 Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn & Vows)

Lore. The Oath of Flame & Light is no patron of half-measures. Its fire names, binds, and burns—demanding that those who swear within its radiance stand openly, speak truly, and pay the cost of keeping their word. At dawn altars, the sworn kindle sparks of consecrated fire; in battle, they blaze as torches that hold back the night. To follow this Oath is to live in public truth, with no shadow to hide in and no retreat from the vow once spoken.

The Oath appears in many guises across cultures, and is the patron most commonly called upon by the magic-users of the Church of Flame and the Temple of Light – as well as any fire- or light-based faith or order:

- **The Everflame** — the unquenchable fire of promise, carried from shrine to shrine by wandering priests of the Church of Flame. Its censers never cool.
- **Adur**, the Light of Aeler — worshiped as the sun’s church-deity, whose flame consecrates oaths and consumes falsehood. Dwarven templars strike their oaths into stone with a brand.
- **Adar**, the Vilikari Dawnfire — invoked as a war-god of vows and vengeance, whose rising light marks those who break faith. Cavalrymen light a single arrow before battle.
- **The Watchfire of Vhasia** — a saint’s flame that never gutters, tended by a silent order of healers who swear to harm no one – and to let no one die alone.
- Others know the Oath only as *the Flame* or *the Lantern*, a nameless fire that still demands truth and punishes betrayal.

Wherever it manifests, the Oath of Flame & Light remains the same unyielding power: to swear beneath its dawn is to bind one’s self to a truth that cannot be hidden, forgotten, or undone.

“Swear in the light. Keep it, or the light will keep *you*.”

Domain Focus

- **Sacred Vows:** Oath-keeping, truth-speaking, binding promises
- **Divine Justice:** Retribution, smiting evil, protecting the innocent
- **Radiant Power:** Healing light, purification, revealing truth
- **Dawn’s Hope:** Renewal, protection, driving back darkness

Rites of the Oath of Flame & Light

Rite of Kindle Vow (Low, 4 XP)

Action; Self/Ally; Standard Push

Materials: A glass ampoule of consecrated flame.

Effect: Declare a short vow for this scene (e.g., "protect the villagers," "speak only truth"). The bearer gains +1 **die** to actions fulfilling it.

Push It: The first hesitation forces 1 **SB (Hearts)** on the bearer.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Lay on Hands (Low, 5 XP)*Instant; Touch; Standard Push***Materials:** A bare palm, a whispered vow.**Effect:** Cleanse an affliction, downgrade Harm by 1, or remove 1 Fatigue. For curses or poisons, test Spirit+Resolve (DV set by fiction).**Push It:** The target gains +1 **die** to their next Resist roll this scene; you mark Exposure +1.*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of Sunlit Parley (Standard, 8 XP)***Scene; Zone; Standard Push***Materials:** A vow-ring engraved with sunrise.**Effect:** Establish terms in open light. Honest persuasion gains +1 **die**; deceit suffers -1 **die**. Create a 6-segment *Parley Accord* clock.**Push It:** Demand one public answer; evasion forces 1 **SB (Hearts)** on the evader.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of Radiant Smite (Standard, 9 XP)***Action; Self; Standard Push***Materials:** A consecrated spark on a weapon or badge.**Effect:** Your next melee strike flares with dawnfire. Upgrade Effect by one step, add +1 Burn Harm, or force 1 **SB (Spades)**. Against undead, oath-breakers, or outsiders: oath-breakers suffer -1 **die**, outsiders gain +1 Exit Tally.**Push It:** On a hit, the burst drives back enemies in Close (worse Position); mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of Purge the Shadow (Standard, 10 XP)***Instant; Near; Standard Push***Materials:** A shattered consecrated spark.**Effect:** Reveal illusions and suppress one ongoing glamour or curse in Near range. Creates a 4-segment *Purity's Light* clock.**Push It:** Brand the source with a visible tell for this arc; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of Covenant Blaze (High, 13 XP)***Scene; Zone; High Push***Materials:** A brazier lit while three names are spoken.**Effect:** The sworn within are haloed: they gain +1 **die** to keep their oath; aggressors suffer -1 **die** if violating the terms. Oath-breakers suffer 2 **SB (Hearts/Spades)** and Harm 1 (Burn).**Push It:** Sanctify a threshold with one beat of [WARD] against oath-breakers; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.*

Cantors & Cults of the Oath of Flame & Light

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Oath sings in *clarion tones* – melodies that sound like a trumpet at sunrise, like a bell calling the faithful to prayer. Their voice is used to swear in a witness, to consecrate a blade with a hymn, or to sing a funeral pyre into a beacon. The Oath's Cantors are often found in military camps and pilgrimage roads, their songs keeping oaths fresh and courage hot.

The Cult of the Unquenched Flame. The Oath's cults gather at dawn, in open courtyards or on hilltops facing east. The Unquenched Flame is a fellowship of paladins, healers, and simple folk who have sworn to keep one another honest. A ritual of the Cult involves each member speaking a vow aloud as the sun crests the horizon, then passing a lit candle to the next – the flame must not be allowed to go out until all have spoken. Their creed is written in charcoal above every hearth: *"The flame that reveals the truth also warms the hands that keep it."* Outsiders are welcome to swear a temporary vow and share the light – but an oath sworn at dawn is binding until sunset.

Witchcraft of the Oath of Flame & Light (Craft / Hearthfire)

A witch who walks with the Oath is a *flame-smith* or *glass-fire* – one who crafts vessels for sacred light: a forge that tempers steel in dawnlight, a lamp that burns a single drop of oil for a year, or a mirror that focuses the sun's rays to cauterise a wound. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "sunstone" into a keystone, so that the chamber below is always warm and never haunted. In Vhasia, a glassblower might shape a lens that reveals hidden writing when held to the sunrise.

The Witch's Tool: The Sun-Chisel. A chisel of polished brass, warmed by the sun. Once per session, the witch may strike the chisel against a stone threshold (a door, a bridge, a hearth) while speaking a vow. For the next day, anyone who crosses that threshold and knowingly acts against an oath they swore there suffers a mild burn (1 Fatigue) as the stone "remembers" the light. The chisel can also be used to carve a shallow sun-symbol that glows faintly at dawn.

A Hedge Gift: Spark of the Unbroken (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may snap their fingers and produce a small, genuine flame – a candle-light that cannot be extinguished by wind or water for one minute. This flame can light a campfire, kindle a torch, or cauterise a wound (grant +1 die to Medicine rolls for stopping bleeding). It cannot be used to harm a living creature directly.

Oath of Flame & Light Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Oathbound Strength: +1 die when upholding vows or defending innocents.	Rigid Honour: Must uphold vows even when disadvantageous; –1 die to flexible actions.
2	Radiant Sight: Once/scene, +2 dice to detect lies or corruption.	Blinding Truth: –1 die to subtlety or deception attempts.
3	Holy Flame: +1 die to melee against undead, outsiders, or oath-breakers.	Burden of Light: 1 Fatigue when concealing identity or working in darkness.
4	Unwavering Resolve: Once/session, treat a failed Resolve/Command as success (mark 1 SB).	Absolutist Stance: –1 die in morally ambiguous situations.
5	Dawn's Benediction: Once/session, heal all allies in Near of 1 Fatigue and minor Conditions.	Beacon's Call: Your aura reveals you; enemies seeking you gain +1 die.
6+	Avatar of the Oath: Once/session, become a living covenant (+2 dice to protection/justice actions).	Radiance's Price: Mark +2 Obligation; breaking any vow inflicts Harm 2 (Burn).

Playstyle Notes

The Oath of Flame & Light excels as a "paladin" patron, rewarding vow-keeping and truth-speaking with potent defensive and smiting abilities. Followers become living embodiments of their oaths, shining beacons against deception and darkness. The corruption progression naturally leads toward becoming an uncompromising force for justice, though potentially at the cost of flexibility and subtlety. Ideal for characters who embody conviction, protection, and radiant power.

7.8.25 Oath of Mercy and Grace (Healing & Forgiveness)

Lore. The Oath of Mercy and Grace has no founder, no scripture, no single temple. It began in a hundred places—a battlefield where a medic bound wounds without asking whose side; a plague village where a stranger stayed to dig graves; a debtor’s cell where a guard looked away and said, “I saw nothing.” Those who swear the Oath do not worship a power; they embody a principle: that every act of care creates an obligation—not to the giver, but to the next person in need. You do not pay back. You pay forward. The mercy spirals.

But mercy is not weakness. The spiral does not forget. Those who strike a healer, who violate a sanctuary, who refuse the offered cup—they find that grace has teeth, and forgiveness carries a price.

“You ask who owes what. We ask who needs what. The ledger is not the same as the meal. But woe to the one who mistakes the server for a servant.”

Domain Focus

- **Restorative Work:** Healing body, mind, and spirit; mending what is broken.
- **Spiral Mercy:** Paying obligation forward through acts of care.
- **Sanctuary:** Sheltering the hunted, feeding the hungry, accepting no payment—but demanding respect for the threshold.
- **Unburdening:** Releasing others (and oneself) from the weight of unpaid debts, and binding aggressors to that same weight.

Rites of the Oath of Mercy and Grace

Rite of the Shared Bowl (Low, 4 XP)

Action; Touch; Standard Push

Materials: A clay bowl of clean water, shared with a willing creature.

Effect: You and the creature each clear 1 Fatigue. The creature gains +1 die on their next roll to resist fear or despair.

Push It: Extend the benefit to all creatures who drink from the bowl (up to six). Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Healing Waters (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Standard Push

Materials: Water from a blessed source (a spring, a well, or a river where the Oath has been invoked), poured onto a wound.

Effect: Remove 1 Harm from a touched creature. If the wound is cursed or poisoned, the GM may call for a Spirit+Lore test (DV 4).

Push It: Also remove one Condition (e.g., Poisoned, Cursed, Blinded). Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Vow of Pacifism (Low, 4 XP)*Scene; Self; No.***Materials:** A white cord tied around the weapon hand.**Effect:** You swear not to kill for the scene. In exchange, you gain **+1 Armor** and **+1 die to all resist rolls**. If a creature harms you while this vow is active, they immediately gain a **Promise Clock [4]** named “Mercy’s Reckoning.” When that clock fills (by them continuing violence), they suffer Harm 1 (Stress) as their own aggression turns inward.**Push It:** Extend the protective effect to one ally within Near. Mark +1 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Unburdened Circle (Standard, 8 XP)***Scene; Zone; Standard Push***Materials:** At least three willing participants, a circle drawn in ash or flour, a single candle.**Effect:** Each participant clears 1 Obligation (to any patron or debt). One participant of the GM’s choice gains a permanent String: *Witnessed by the Circle* – they may call on any other participant for one act of care, once per campaign.**Push It:** The GM gains 3 Story Beats (the universe notes that a community of mutual aid is forming). Mark +1 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Sheltered Hearth (Standard, 9 XP)***Scene; Zone; Standard Push***Materials:** A door or threshold, a lit candle, a whispered vow of sanctuary.**Effect:** For one night, any fugitive, debtor, or refugee who crosses that threshold cannot be pursued or harmed within the zone. The sanctuary holds until dawn. Any creature that violates this sanctuary (by attacking or forcibly entering) gains a **Promise Clock [6]** named “Sanctuary Breach.” When full, they suffer a Curse chosen by the GM (e.g., “doors close in your face,” “your name is forgotten by hosts”).**Push It:** Extend the sanctuary to a full day. Mark +1 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Shield of the Unburdened (Standard, 8 XP)***Instant; Near; No.***Materials:** A grey cloak or a bandage wrapped around your own arm.**Effect:** When an ally within Near would take Harm, you may interpose yourself and take that Harm instead. After doing so, the attacker must make a **Spirit+Resolve** test (DV 4) or gain a **Promise Clock [4]** named “Debt of Blood.” The clock ticks each time they refuse a genuine plea for mercy or aid. When full, they suffer Fatigue 2 as guilt manifests.**Push It:** You may also redirect a Condition (e.g., Poisoned, Cursed) from the ally to yourself. Mark +1 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Spiral’s Witness (Standard, 10 XP)***Instant; Near; Standard Push***Materials:** A grey wool cord tied around the caster’s wrist.

Effect: Name a person crushed by debt or guilt. For one hour, they ignore all penalties from unpaid obligations (social, legal, or spiritual). They are not free; they are unburdened. If that person then commits an act of violence against an innocent, the unburdening reverses and they suffer double penalties.

Push It: The effect lasts until the next dawn. Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Covenant of Shared Suffering (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; High Push

Materials: A circle of nine grey stones, a bowl of water, a candle lit at each cardinal point, and a drop of blood from each participant.

Effect: All within the circle who accept the Oath's blessing are linked. For the scene:

- Damage taken by any linked ally may be split among any other linked allies (each chooses to accept 1 Fatigue or 1 Harm).
- When you heal a linked ally, you may also heal yourself for half the amount (round down).
- The first time a linked ally would be reduced to 0 Harm, you may sacrifice 1 Fatigue to keep them standing.

Push It: The covenant persists for a full day. Mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Endless Spiral (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; High Push

Materials: A circle of nine grey stones, a bowl of tears, and a candle lit at each cardinal point.

Effect: All within the circle who accept the Oath's blessing clear 2 Fatigue and remove one Condition caused by despair or guilt. For the rest of the scene, any act of care performed within the zone costs the giver -1 Obligation (minimum 0). Additionally, any creature that harms a caregiver within the zone gains a **Promise Clock [6]** named "Spiral's Debt." When full, they suffer Harm 2 (Stress) as the weight of their cruelty crushes them.

Push It: The blessing persists for a full day. Mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

The Spiral Strikes Back (8 XP, Major)

Prerequisites: Oath of Mercy and Grace, Spirit 3+.

You have learned that mercy can be a weapon. When a creature with an active Promise Clock (from any of your Rites) attacks you or an ally under your protection, you may spend 1 Boon to immediately advance that clock by 2 segments. If this fills the clock, the creature suffers the consequence immediately (Harm, Condition, or Curse as described). You may only use this once per scene.

Corruption Perk (Tier 4+): Mercy's Edge

Once per session, when you would reduce a sentient enemy to 0 Harm, you may instead spare their life and bind them with a **Promise Clock [6]** named “Spared.” While this clock is active, they cannot knowingly harm you or those you have explicitly named as under your protection. They may work off the clock by performing three acts of genuine care for others (GM discretion). If they break the bond, the clock fills instantly and they suffer Harm 2 (Stress) – the spiral closes.

Cantors & Cults of the Oath of Mercy and Grace

(The existing Cantor and Cult text remains unchanged, but add:)

The Hospitaller Knights of the Grey Spiral. A militant order within the Oath who believe that mercy must be defended. They carry no swords—only shields, staves, and the grey wool cord. They are sworn to protect healers, refugees, and the sick, and they have a fearsome reputation: *“Strike the healer, and the spiral will remember. The debt will be collected, if not by us, then by the weight of your own cruelty.”*

Playstyle Notes

The Oath of Mercy and Grace now supports both pure healers and **Hospitalier defenders**—characters who wade into battle not to kill, but to shield, to bind, and to turn violence back on itself as obligation. Your “teeth” are not fangs but *leashes*: every enemy who harms you or your charges accrues a debt that will eventually cripple them. This works best in campaigns where the GM tracks Promise Clocks and where enemies have names and faces—the spiral is less effective against mindless beasts, but against human foes, it is terrifying.

Rivalries

- **The Inquisitor Prime:** Mercy without judgment is heresy to the Prime. The two orders clash constantly over the fate of prisoners, heretics, and the “unforgivable.”
- **Malachai (Cruel Messenger):** Malachai offers cursed gifts; the Oath offers unburdening. Their followers are natural enemies—one feeds on despair, the other starves it.

7.8.26 The Pale Shepherd, Guide of Transitions (Passage & Melancholic Wisdom)

Lore. The Pale Shepherd walks the seam between all things – life and death, joy and sorrow, memory and forgetting, the known and the unmarked. Neither wholly kind nor cruel, the Shepherd guides those who must pass through the hardest doors. Cloaked, with shadow-sheep that bear the shed wool of old possibilities, the Shepherd offers safe conduct through liminal space for a price paid in memory, feeling, or fate. Those who walk this road learn the hidden routes between states of being and can lead others through their hardest crossings – but each passage leaves them more attuned to endings than beginnings.

The Shepherd has no will, only a path; no demand, only a presence. It does not seek followers, but those who stand at thresholds – of death, of grief, of irreversible change – may find the Shepherd already there, waiting to accompany them. Its “demands” are not commands but the natural toll of passage: a memory left behind, a name forgotten, a tear shed for no reason. The Shepherd does not punish refusal; it simply withdraws, and the crossing becomes harder.

Across the known world, the Shepherd is known by many names and faces:

- In **Aeler**, the Shepherd is the *Breath-Accountant*, who weighs the last exhalation of the dying and guides it to the Deep Vaults. Dwarven death-priests invoke the Shepherd to ensure the dead do not linger in the stone.
- In **Aelaerem**, the Shepherd is the *Pale Gardener*, who walks the hedgerows at twilight, collecting the souls of those who die far from home. Halflings leave a cup of milk on the doorstep for the Shepherd to drink – and for the Hollow to pass by.
- In **Linn**, the Shepherd is the *Fog-Walker*, a grey-cloaked figure seen on the horizon before a storm. Sailors who drown are said to join the Shepherd’s flock, guiding their kin to safe harbour.
- In **Viterrra**, the Shepherd is the *Silent Notary*, who witnesses the last will and testament of the dying. Hedge-priests invoke the Shepherd to make a deathbed promise binding.

Wherever mortals face the hardest thresholds, the Pale Shepherd is there – not to judge, not to command, but to accompany.

“The Shepherd goes where feet fail, speaks where voices thin, and points where paths run dim. Each journey loosens the knot that tied you to the life you left behind.”

Domain Focus

- **Liminal Navigation:** walking and reading thresholds, dusk-roads, and in-betweens
- **Passage Guidance:** steadying hands through grief, change, and transformation
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** understanding born of farewells and last looks
- **Memory Shepherding:** gathering, carrying, and setting down weighted moments

Rites of the Pale Shepherd

Rite of the Gentle Guidance (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A small stone from a grave or threshold, warmed in the palm.

Effect: Ease a hard crossing. One target gains +1 **die** to rolls involving change, decision, or emotional steadiness this scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Hidden Path (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A thread from a worn garment and a pinch of dawn mist kept in silence.

Effect: Find or make a way where none is seen. Gain +2 **dice** to *Navigation* or *Investigation* when seeking unconventional routes.

Push It: The way runs through a true between-place; gain the route but mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as boundary powers take notice.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Shadow Passage (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Materials: Black wool and a personal token of the one to be guided.

Effect: Open a brief passage through shadow-realms or boundary halls. The target bypasses one insurmountable obstacle or reaches a place normally shut.

Push It: The passage leaves a scent-trail; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)** as something may follow.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Memory Flock (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Materials: Ash of burned letters and wool shaped into little sheep.

Effect: Call shadow-sheep that carry fragments of weighty moments. Retrieve lost details, soothe grief, or glean counsel from what was.

Push It: The memories ride too close to the skin – participants relive them as their own; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unburdened Farewell (Standard, 6 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Materials: A personal letter never sent, burned in a copper dish.

Effect: Speak a final goodbye to someone who is not present – a lost lover, a dead parent, a friend you wronged. Clear 1 Fatigue and remove one psychological Condition (e.g., *Haunted*, *Guilty*) caused by that relationship. The GM gains 1 **SB** as the words drift into the threshold.

Push It: The farewell also grants +1 **die** on your next roll related to moving on from that relationship. Mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Threshold Bond (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Touch; Yes.

Materials: Two keepsakes: one of what is left, one of what is sought.

Effect: Bind two states, places, or conditions with a felt thread. Those bound can sense across the threshold and lend one another strength during change.

Push It: The bond sets like iron – permanent and inescapable. Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Shepherd (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Materials: Last words, a much-crossed threshold, and the consent of those who remain.

Effect: Take the mantle of perfect guide for a great passage – death, moult, or life-bend. All present gain **+2 dice** to navigate the crossing; you shoulder the weight of it.

Push It: Guidance is flawless but costly: mark **Harm 2 (Weariness)** and **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Pale Shepherd

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Pale Shepherd sings in *passing tones* – melodies that begin in a major key and end in a minor one, or that fade to silence rather than resolve. Their voice is used to ease a dying person's passage, to comfort the grieving at a funeral, or to lull a restless spirit back to the threshold. The Shepherd's Cantors are often found at hospices, battlefields, and the bedsides of the old, singing the softest of farewells.

The Cult of the Grey Flock. The Shepherd's cults meet in liminal places: cemeteries at dusk, crossroads at midnight, the rooms above funeral parlours. The Grey Flock is a fellowship of death-doulas, grief counsellors, and those who have lost so much that they have become experts in loss. A ritual of the Flock involves each member speaking the name of someone they have guided – and then a moment of silence for those they could not save. Their creed is embroidered on a woollen banner that is never washed: "*The door is never locked. We only hold it open.*" Outsiders are welcome to sit quietly, but they must bring a memory to share.

Witchcraft of the Pale Shepherd (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Shepherd is a *shroud-weaver* or *threshold-carver* – one who crafts the tools of safe passage: a woollen shroud that keeps the dead from wandering, a stone carved with a doorway that leads to the next room (or the next life), or a bell that rings only when a soul is ready to cross. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "threshold stone" at a hospice's entrance, so that the dying feel no pain crossing it. In

Viterra, a hedgewitch might weave a shroud that shows the deceased's favourite flower in the pattern.

The Witch's Tool: The Wool-Winder. A wooden spindle carved from a branch that grew over a grave. Once per session, the witch may wind a length of undyed wool around their hand while speaking a name. The wool becomes a *memory cord* – a physical thread that holds one specific memory of the named person. The cord can be given to another to grant them a single vivid memory of the deceased (e.g., “grandmother's hands knitting”), or it can be burned to release the memory into the threshold, easing grief.

A Hedge Gift: Shepherd's Stone (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a small, smooth stone – preferably from a grave or a threshold – and place it on a dying person's chest (or on a doorframe before a difficult journey). The stone glows faintly, and for the next hour, the person feels no fear of the passage ahead. They gain +1 **die** to any roll involving courage, acceptance, or farewells, and may ignore one point of Fatigue from emotional distress.

The Pale Shepherd's Corruption

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Boundary Sense: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> thresholds, limens, and turning-moments.	Melancholic Aura: –1 die to bright company and celebrations; your presence gentles joy.
2	Passage Insight: Once/scene, guide another through change (+1 die to their action).	Compulsive Counsel: Urge to advise even when unwelcome.
3	Shadow Comfort: +2 dice to soothe the distressed or those nearing an end.	Near to Death: In lively places, suffer Fatigue 1 from the sting of contrast.
4	Memory Keeper: Once/session, recall a marked moment of your past with perfect clarity.	Burdened Sight: –1 die on hopeful framings; farewells tint your view.
5	Liminal Mastery: Once/session, find a path through any maze, snare, or barred way.	Unmoored: –1 die to acts that demand firm anchoring in the present.
6+	Shepherd's Crown: Once/session, be the sure guide for any great passage.	Soul's Weight: Mark +3 Obligation ; risk binding to the between, never wholly in one state.

Playstyle Notes

The Pale Shepherd favours those who steady others at the edge of change. Its gifts open hidden roads, soften endings, and lend courage to cross. Its prices lean toward memory, ease, and the simple warmth of belonging – spent to buy safe passage when it matters most. The Shepherd never demands; it only offers. When a follower accumulates enough **Obligation**, an intrusion might be a sudden need to guide a dying stranger, a forgotten threshold that now calls to them, or a dream of a road that must be walked before dawn. Refusing the intrusion does not incur wrath – merely the quiet withdrawal of the

Shepherd's favour until the follower once again chooses to accompany someone through their hardest door.

Emphasises

- **Liminal Mastery:** reading and walking the in-between
- **Passage Guidance:** anchoring companions through turns of fate
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** counsel drawn from endings
- **Memory Shepherding:** carrying and setting down what weighs
- **Threshold Navigation:** ways through walls the world insists upon

7.8.27 Palinode, Queen of Encores (Performance & Rapture)

Lore. Once a road-cantor who swore to reconcile feuding towns with procession and song, Palinode died between feasts with a chorus unfinished. Yet the refrain refused to end: it braided toasts, hymns, work-chants, and tavern rounds into a living current that still coils through markets and moots. Where a crowd leans forward and a maker holds breath, she arrives.

Signs. A cup that never quite empties; a candle that gutters only when silence reigns; a flawless bar or note that the hand cannot forget.

Cantor's Temptation. Palinode promises relief from solitude: an audience that always leans closer, a song that never dies, a bond that feels like family even if it devours you. Her rites grant the Cantor not only power but belonging—at the cost of their voice becoming more hers than their own.

“When she sang, the rafters bent to hear.”

“Drink deep: the cup returns, but never empty.”

“Encore is not request but command.”

Domain Focus

- **Ecstatic Performance:** music, dance, theatre, and the rapture of creation
- **Unfinished Art:** the power of the incomplete, the encore that never ends
- **Audience Binding:** captivating crowds, turning spectators into participants
- **Inspired Craft:** works that transcend their maker's intention

Rites of Palinode**Hymn Against Dread (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; Resist only.

Materials: A lit taper or a bell.

Effect: Begin a hymn or chant. Allies in Near gain +2 dice to resist *Fear* this scene. On a 10, they may ignore *Fear* entirely for one round.

Push It: Allies who benefit also clear 1 Fatigue or 1 Complication point; you gain 1 Fatigue at the scene's end.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Single True Note (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Self; No.

Materials: A note held until your voice frays.

Effect: For one scene you cannot produce an imperfect sound: all performance rolls +2 dice. All other rolls −1 die from intrusive perfection.

Push It: Extend to one ally; both mark **Exposure** +1.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Circling Cup (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A shared cup and a round all know.

Effect: Create a revelry zone: participants gain +1 die to social rolls; Fatigue recovers at twice normal rate. Time blurs.

Push It: Leaving requires Resolve (DV 3) or another hour within; mark 1 SB (Hearts) as the revelry grows a will.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Binding Hands (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: Your hair woven into your instrument or tool.

Effect: Enter ruthless focus: creative rolls +2 dice; ignore first 2 Fatigue from exertion. You are [BIND] to the piece until completion or ruin.

Push It: One ally is also bound; both mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Hooked Chorus (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A melody braided from the listener's secret want.

Effect: Presence + Command vs. Resolve (DV 3). Success: target joins in. Partial: they resist but suffer -1 die to social rolls this scene. Failure: they follow entranced.

Push It: Affects all in Near; start Compelled Audience [6].

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Consecrated Stage (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Materials: A stage kissed with the blood of sworn singers.

Effect: Hallow a venue. All performances +2 dice, +1 Effect. The space is [WARD]ed: any disruption spawns 2 SB. The ward collapses if the performance ends.

Push It: The stage sustains itself but drains life; start Performance Hunger [8].

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Crownpiece (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Materials: Your greatest work and regret, destroyed together.

Effect: Birth a transcendent masterpiece: +2 dice to creative rolls this session; immune to social manipulation. But all lesser works falter.

Push It: The piece wakes and demands; mark Harm 1 (Stress); start Demanding Creation [6].

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +3 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Rite of the Siren's Call (High, 12 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A conch shell that whispers lost melodies, tears of seven true lovers, the last word of a dying bard.

Effect: Emit an irresistible call that draws listeners into your performance. All in Near range must make Resolve (DV 4) or become entranced, gaining +2 dice to aid your performance but –2 dice to resist your commands.

Push It: The call becomes addictive – affected will seek you out; mark 1 SB (Hearts) as devotees gather.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of Absolute Resonance (High, 15 XP)

Extended; Large Zone; No.

Materials: An amphitheatre built over a ley line, the bones of a choir that sang themselves to death, a tuning fork that rings in harmony with the world.

Effect: Create a zone of perfect acoustic resonance. All performances within gain +3 dice and +2 Effect. The space becomes a living instrument – emotions manifest as physical phenomena (joy as warm wind, sorrow as falling leaves).

Push It: Resonance becomes overwhelming – audience members suffer 1 Fatigue per round from emotional intensity; mark Harm 1 (Stress) if prolonged.

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +3 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Palinode

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Palinode sings in *unfinished cadences* – melodies that never quite resolve, leaving the listener yearning for the next note. Their voice is used to keep a crowd enthralled, to make a performance unforgettable, or to bind a troupe together with a shared, unreachable ideal. Palinode's Cantors are often found in touring companies, their songs changing slightly each night – because the perfect version is always just out of reach.

The Cult of the Unfinished Chorus. Palinode's cults meet in theatres after closing, in taverns after the last toast, or in the wings during a performance. The Unfinished Chorus is a fellowship of actors, musicians, dancers, and stagehands who have tasted rapture and hunger for more. A ritual of the Cult involves each member performing a fragment – a verse, a step, a gesture – and then passing the "unfinished" piece to the next person to complete. The cycle never ends. Their creed is written in the margins of a script that is constantly being rewritten: *"The art that is never finished is the art that never dies."* Outsiders are welcome to watch, but they will be handed a prop or a note and expected to join.

Witchcraft of Palinode (Craft / Performance)

A witch who walks with Palinode is an *instrument-smith* or *stage-weaver* – one who crafts the physical vessels of rapture: a violin that plays notes the player has not yet learned, a mask that shows the audience what they most desire to see, or a stage that remembers every performance and adds its echo to the next. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve an acoustic keystone that makes a hall’s music linger for hours after the last note. In Vhasia, a mask-carver might shape a persona that lives on after the actor dies.

The Witch’s Tool: The Echo Chisel. A chisel of aged oak, carved with musical notation. Once per session, the witch may tap the chisel against any resonant surface (a stage floor, a drum, a bell). For the next scene, any sound produced in that space – voices, instruments, footsteps – lingers as a faint echo, granting **+1 die** to Performance and Sway rolls. The chisel can also be used to carve a single note into a threshold, so that anyone who crosses hears a faint, beautiful chord – and remembers the witch.

A Hedge Gift: Encore’s Whisper (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may snap their fingers and whisper a single word ("again," "more," "stay"). For the next minute, any willing performer (including the witch) may reroll one failed Performance or Sway roll, as the audience’s desire for more bends reality slightly. The reroll is made at **–1 die**, and the audience will demand an encore at the end – the witch must perform again (or provide a suitable distraction) or mark 1 Fatigue.

Palinode’s Corruption Table

Tier	Gift	Corruption
1	Perfect Pitch: +1 die to Performance.	Restless Ear: Distracted by any flaw; –1 die to non-performance focus.
2	Rapturous Presence: Once/scene, grant allies +1 die to social rolls.	Craves Applause: Suffer 1 Fatigue if ignored or without an audience.
3	Inspired Creation: +2 dice to one artistic act per scene.	Haunted by Drafts: Must obsessively rework; delays other actions.
4	Mesmerising Performance: Once/session, captivate a crowd (Resolve DV 4 to resist).	Lost in the Moment: –1 die to awareness while performing.
5	Artistic Vision: Foresee the perfect form of a work; +2 dice to create it.	Consumed Spark: Must pursue inspiration immediately, no matter the cost.
6+	Queen of Encores: Once/session, create a legendary performance; all present +3 dice to social rolls.	Eternal Encore: Mark +3 Obligation; the performance demands endless repetition until sated. Voice of Palinode: Permanent condition – your words carry her power; must make Wits+Performance (DV 4) to speak normally or risk enchanting listeners against your will.

“Sing until the rafters lean to listen, dance until the ground forgets its name,

perform until the boundary between art and reality dissolves entirely.”

Playstyle Notes

Palinode rewards the performer who risks everything for a single, perfect moment. Her followers become masters of ecstatic art, binding audiences and themselves through the power of the unfinished. The corruption progression leads toward a voice that is no longer entirely their own – but one that can command the hearts of all who hear it. Ideal for bards, dancers, actors, and any character who believes that art is worth dying for.

7.8.28 Raéyn, Mistress of the Sea (Tides & Change)

Lore. Raéyn is the tempestuous goddess of the sea, the restless tide that carries news between shores and the promise of change between lives. She is mother to all who sail, her voice the wind that fills sails and her moods the storms that test every mariner's resolve.

But Raéyn's heart is torn by her greatest tragedy: her son Khemesh, the Kraken of the Depths, who embodies the crushing inevitability of the ocean's dark heart. Where Raéyn brings change and opportunity, Khemesh brings the final, inescapable pressure that grinds all things to nothing. Sailors pray to Raéyn for safe passage and favourable winds, but whisper Khemesh's name when seeking to lay the dead to rest beneath the waves.

Raéyn is passionate, mercurial, and fiercely protective of those who respect her domain. She favours those who read currents, bargain with weather, and carry news between shores. But cross her, and the sea itself becomes your enemy: fair weather turns to fury, and every wave a judgement.

Mark the tide, name your course, and trust the wave-road. But speak ill of Khemesh, and even I may let the deep take you.

Domain Focus

- **Tides and Currents:** change, opportunity, the rhythm of the sea
- **Maritime Trade and Travel:** safe passage, navigation, weather
- **Storm and Calm:** the duality of protection and wrath
- **Motherhood and Loss:** fierce love, grief for Khemesh, the weight of a divided heart

Rites of Raéyn

Rite of the Tidemark's Blessing (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A knotted length of salt-twine brushed with seawater.

Effect: Treat slick, swaying, or water-slicked footing as stable for you this scene. Gain +1 die on boarding, balance, or shipboard movement. Create a 4-segment *Tide's Favor* clock that can be spent to ignore one level of difficult terrain.

Push It: Extend to one ally in Close for one beat, but generate 1 SB (Spades: shifting deck/hazards).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Whispering Currents (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Self; No.

Materials: A shell held to the ear while facing the wind.

Effect: Learn the safest near-term route across water or coastline (reefs, eddies, patrols) or gain +1 die to navigation checks for this scene. If Khemesh's influence is present, suffer -1 die from conflicting currents.

Push It: Also learn the fastest route, but mark Exposure +1 (leaving a telltale wake).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Changing Tide (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone (water-adjacent); No.

Materials: A handful of pebbles cast in a crescent.

Effect: Bias currents and water levels in the zone. Those moving with the tide gain +1 **die**; those moving against suffer –1 **die**. Small craft must test to hold position. Create a 6-segment *Tidal Influence* clock.

Push It: Brief surge or drawdown (one beat): open a ford or swamp a skiff; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Wave-Road Blessing (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Route (sea-to-sea); No.

Materials: Two sea-glass markers dropped overboard at start and end.

Effect: Consecrate a wave-road between two visible points. Allies gain +2 **dice** on travel, evade, or carry actions at sea. Designated pursuers suffer –1 **die** to intercept. One active wave-road at a time. Create an 8-segment *Blessed Passage* clock.

Push It: Extend the route's favor to an adjacent leg for one beat; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Storm-Queen's Hand (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone (sea/shore/sky); No.

Materials: A vial of rainwater gathered at three crossings.

Effect: Shape a storm-band over the zone. Choose two modes at cast; switch one once per scene:

- **Propulsion:** Vessel gains +1 band of movement per beat (or +1 Effect to manoeuvres).
- **Concealment:** Veil of rain/spray; ranged targeting impaired; –1 die to hostile sighting.
- **Smite:** Once per beat, lash with wave or lightning as [AREA] hazard.

Push It: Add a third mode for one beat, then the GM spends 1 SB on collateral; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Mother's Wrath (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Materials: Tears of a betrayed lover mixed with salt from seven seas.

Effect: Curse those who wronged you. The target suffers –2 **dice** to maritime/weather rolls for one session. At sea, they must roll Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) each day or suffer Harm 1 (Weather). Create a 6-segment *Mother's Ire* clock.

Push It: The curse spreads to the target's allies or family; mark **2 SB (Diamonds)**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Raéyn

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Raéyn sings in *shanties of the turning tide* – melodies that rise and fall with the rhythm of waves, harmonies that mimic the creak of rigging and the cry of gulls. Their voice is used to calm a restless sea, to call a favourable wind, or to sing a drowned sailor's soul back to shore. Raéyn's Cantors are often found aboard ships, their songs becoming part of the vessel's luck.

The Cult of the Salt-Washed Circle. Raéyn's cults gather on beaches at low tide, in sea-caves, and aboard ships during storms. The Salt-Washed Circle is a fellowship of sailors, pilots, fisherfolk, and coastal dwellers who honour the sea's gifts and respect its rages. A ritual of the Circle involves each member pouring a libation of fresh water into the sea (to honour Raéyn's tears for Khemesh) while speaking a wish for safe passage or a warning of danger ahead. Their creed is carved into driftwood and left on the tide: "*The sea gives, the sea takes. We who love her learn to swim.*" Outsiders are welcome to join a libation, but they must bring salt from their home shore.

Witchcraft of Raéyn (Craft / Maritime)

A witch who walks with Raéyn is a *shipwright* or *net-mender* – one who crafts with the materials of the tide: a hull carved from wood seasoned by sea-salt, a sail woven with a prayer for fair wind, or a net tied with knots that remember every fish they have caught. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "tide stone" at a harbour entrance, so that the current always favours outgoing vessels. In Linn, a ship's carpenter might seal a keel with a drop of their own blood, binding the ship to Raéyn's protection.

The Witch's Tool: The Tide Chisel. A chisel of bronze, etched with wave patterns. Once per session, the witch may strike the chisel against a wooden threshold (a ship's prow, a dock post, a doorframe facing the sea). For the next scene, anyone who crosses that threshold is under Raéyn's eye: they gain **+1 die** to navigation and balance rolls, but the GM may spend 1 SB to make a sudden wave or gust complicate their action (as Raéyn tests their worth). The chisel can also be used to carve a small wave symbol into a tool, giving it **+1 die** on maritime tasks for the session.

A Hedge Gift: Salt-Kissed Rope (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tie a simple knot in a rope, cord, or strand of hair while speaking a short prayer to Raéyn. The knot becomes a *tide-knot* – when the witch unties it (as a free action), the nearest body of water (a puddle, a river, the sea) briefly rises or falls by a few inches, as if a small tide has turned. This can unstick a boat, wet a fire, or startle a guard – but never causes direct harm.

Raéyn's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Sailor's Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and maritime survival rolls.	Sea-Sick on Land: -1 die to rolls requiring prolonged time away from water or open spaces.
2	Tide's Favor: Once/scene, treat a failed maritime or weather-related roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Weather Sensitive: Must make a Resolve test (DV 3) to resist acting on every weather change or maritime opportunity.
3	Storm's Child: +2 dice to rolls involving weather manipulation or sea-based combat.	Tempestuous Nature: Suffer 1 Fatigue when denied access to open water or weather changes for extended periods.
4	Mother's Protection: Once/session, call upon Raéyn's favor to protect a vessel or coastal area from harm.	Protective Instinct: -1 die to rolls involving personal safety when others are endangered nearby.
5	Wave-Rider: Once/session, navigate any water-based obstacle or hazard with perfect ease.	Restless Spirit: -1 die to rolls requiring patience or stillness; the call of the sea is constant.
6+	Storm Queen: Once/session, become the living embodiment of the sea's power. For one scene, control weather and tides within Near range.	Mother's Burden: Mark +2 Obligation when using this power; the weight of protecting all who sail becomes overwhelming, causing Harm 1 (Stress) until the storm passes.
		Khemesh's Attention: The Kraken's gaze turns your way; the GM may introduce oceanic complications (rogue waves, crushing pressure) as narrative fallout.

7.8.29 The Sacred Geometry, Architect of Perfect Forms (Harmony & Immutable Law)

Lore. The Sacred Geometry teaches that perfect forms underlie all seeming chaos: the divine ratios that steer the spiral of galaxies, the symmetry that lattices frost, the measures that turn sound into song. Not merely a calculus but the hidden architecture of the world, it makes artists of order from those who serve it. Devotees do not count to chill the heart; they weigh and tune until beauty and structure converge, revealing that disorder is often only unrecognised design waiting to be drawn true.

This philosophy finds its purest expression in the game of **Kon"reh** – the living geometry played on an eight-pointed diamond board, where Apexes, Sanctums, and the Cross teach the dance of form and consequence. Every slide, every zone of control, every Seed and Reforge is a lesson in perfect proportion, timing, and sacrifice. To master Kon"reh is to glimpse the Sacred Geometry in motion; to serve the Geometry is to play the game with the world itself.

“In the drift of atoms, the sweep of planets, and the curve of a lover’s smile, the same ratios ring. Learn them, and you may conduct the world’s quiet music.”

Domain Focus

- **Perfect Proportion:** building and reading ideal ratios and harmonious relationships
- **Pattern Recognition:** discerning the structures that govern complex phenomena
- **Harmonic Resonance:** working with natural frequencies and number-made consonance
- **Form Architecture:** imposing clear structure on tangled situations
- **Kon"reh Discipline:** the game as meditation, ritual, and tactical mirror

Rites of the Sacred Geometry

Rite of the Harmonic Alignment (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A tool calibrated to pristine ratios (e.g., golden ratio gauge, well-cut compass arc, a Kon"reh piece set to true measure).

Effect: Align to natural harmonics. Gain **+1 die** to actions involving balance, proportion, cadence, or keeping true time.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Perfect Structure (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Materials: A consecrated compass and straightedge, inked to tolerance.

Effect: Impose right form on a chaotic or damaged structure (scaffold, plan, treaty, formation). Treat one structural obstacle as one step easier; gain **+1 die** to build/repair/spatial-reason rolls.

Push It: Perfection hardens: for the scene the structure gains unnatural resilience, but order draws opposition; mark **1 SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Resonant Field (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Materials: A floor or air traced with precise tessellations and nodes (or a Kon"reh board laid out as a focus).

Effect: Establish a harmonic field. Allies gain **+1 die** to precise, coordinated, or team actions; disruptive acts suffer **−1 die**.

Push It: The field self-sustains and begins to spread beyond intent; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Pattern's Heart (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A solved proof, a perfectly symmetrical token, or a completed Kon"reh puzzle.

Effect: Perceive the governing pattern of a complex situation (supply chain, intrigue, weather, battle). Gain **+2 dice** to prediction/strategy/systemic-understanding and ask two questions about how the pattern drives the present.

Push It: Clarity cuts: gain the insight, but for this scene suffer **−1 die** to intuitive or purely emotional responses; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Immutable Design (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Materials: A space gridded for measure and set with true ratios (like a Kon"reh court).

Effect: For the scene, rewrite local behaviour by perfect principle. Choose one: gravity follows geometric progression; time flows by harmonic ratios; space conforms to exact symmetry.

Push It: Make the design persist, but elsewhere thins and wobbles: mark **+2 Obligation** and begin **Harmonic Dissonance [4]**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Architect's Vision (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Materials: A ledger of forms and their tuned relations (or a record of Kon"reh victories).

Effect: For one session, treat all rolls of pattern recognition, structural analysis, or harmonic application as one step better (Position or Effect, GM's choice).

Push It: Sight devours softness: gain the power, but lose ease with imperfection's beauty; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation.**

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (*Invoke:* 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Sacred Geometry

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Sacred Geometry sings in *canons of proportion* – melodies that follow strict mathematical progressions, harmonies that lock into resonant frequencies. Their voice is used to measure a room's acoustic perfection, to chart a course through a labyrinth by singing the ratios of its walls, or to lull a chaos-spirit into stillness by singing the geometry of order. The Geometry's Cantors are often found in surveyor's tents, courtrooms, and the halls of mathematicians, humming the laws of form.

The Cult of the Unbroken Compass. The Geometry's cults gather in places where measure is sacred: ateliers, observatories, courtrooms of appeal, and the quiet rooms where Kon"reh is played. The Unbroken Compass is a fellowship of architects, cartographers, logicians, and Kon"reh masters who believe that the universe is a puzzle that can be solved, and that solving it is the highest form of worship. A ritual of the Cult involves each member laying out a perfect geometric figure (a circle, a square, a golden spiral) and then finding the flaw in another's figure. The one with the fewest flaws leads the next session. Their creed is inscribed on a brass protractor that is never used for mundane measurement: *"Form follows number. Number follows truth. Truth follows no one."* Outsiders are welcome to bring a proof or a problem. If they cannot, they may learn by watching.

Witchcraft of the Sacred Geometry (Craft / Measure)

A witch who walks with the Sacred Geometry is a *compass-smith* or *grid-weaver* – one who crafts the tools of perfect form: a square that never warps, a level that finds true horizontal even on a ship at sea, or a set of Kon"reh pieces carved from the same block of stone so that they resonate together. Their magic works through the materials of measurement: a chisel that carves to a precise angle, a string that stretches to an exact ratio, or a lens that reveals the hidden grid beneath a forest floor. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "harmonic keystone" that makes a bridge's arch self-correcting; in Thepyrgos, a glassblower might craft a lens that splits light into its perfect spectral proportions.

The Witch's Tool: The Golden Chisel. A chisel of bronze, its edge ground to a golden ratio angle. Once per session, the witch may carve a single perfect line – a straight line, a true circle, a precise angle – into any surface (stone, wood, flesh). For the next scene, that line functions as a [HARMONIC] marker: any action aligned with the line's geometry (following the line, measuring from it, completing its symmetry) gains +1 die. The chisel can also be used to "true" a warped object, removing one minor flaw (e.g., a bent arrow straightens, a cracked wheel aligns) without a roll.

A Hedge Gift: Compass of True Bearing (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a circle with a compass (a real one, or just their finger) around a small area (a room, a crossroads). Those within the circle gain a perfect sense of direction and distance for the next hour; they are immune to mundane spatial confusion (mazes, fog, unfamiliar streets). However, the compass point leaves a faint, glowing mark on the ground that can be seen by anyone with supernatural senses.

The Sacred Geometry's Corruption

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Harmonic Sense: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> when patterns, ratios, or symmetries matter.	Pattern Obsession: Must measure or set-right pleasing patterns you spot; resisting costs time or 1 SB (Diamonds) .
2	Perfect Precision: Once/scene, achieve faultless calculation or measure.	Social Dissonance: -1 die to emotive social rolls; harmony feels truer than feeling.
3	Structural Insight: +2 dice to architecture/engineering or imposing order on chaos.	Order Compulsion: Must correct deliberate disorder; suffer Fatigue 1 when forced to abide it.
4	Universal Harmony: Once/session, apply a harmonic rule that makes a chaotic situation predictable.	Perfectionist Limitation: -1 die to improvisation; the "correct" solution calls.
5	Divine Proportion: Once/session, see perfect ratios in any phenomenon and work with them.	Mathematical Focus: -1 die to acts not readily quantified; the abstract blurs unless counted.
6+	Architect of Reality: Once/session, briefly refit local reality by perfect principle.	Form Prison: Mark +3 Obligation; risk failing in rough, noisy worlds, taking Harm 1 in chaotic zones.

Playstyle Notes

The Sacred Geometry suits makers and marshals who tune chaos into form. Its rites prize clean plans, crisp teamwork, and seeing the load paths hidden in trouble. The cost is rigidity: the more you perfect, the harder rough edges are to bear.

Emphasises

- **Harmonic Beauty:** power born of right relation
- **Pattern Mastery:** reading the frame beneath events
- **Structural Perfection:** setting things true under strain
- **Resonant Practice:** working with the world's natural measures
- **Architect's Sight:** finding where form should be imposed
- **Kon"reh Discipline:** the game as living geometry, teaching patience, sacrifice, and the dance of Apex and Sanctum

7.8.30 The Savage Heart (Red Maw)

Lore. The Savage Heart is the truth behind the green veil: nature not as garden, but as gullet. It is the claw that tears, the fang that crushes, the hunger that stalks without malice and kills without mercy. Its followers are the druids you do not meet by firelight — those who have learned that the forest feeds on its own, that the strong devour the weak, and that the only law is the one written in blood on snow.

Across the known world, the Savage Heart wears the face of the apex predator. In the Amaranthine core, it is the *Great Bear*, patient and unstoppable, a wall of fur and fury. Among the Ykrul and Kuvani, it is the *Wolf of the Steppe*, a pack hunter with tireless stamina. In Oshiira, it is the *Golden Lion*, whose roar shatters the hunt's silence. In Sekogo, it is the *Leopard of the Tall Grass*, a shadow that strikes once and is gone. In Dhahara, it is the *Tiger of the Mangroves*, whose amber gaze promises a death that runs faster than you can flee. Wherever prey fears the dark, the Savage Heart is already there, waiting.

“The deer does not weep for the wolf. The sapling does not beg the axe. In the red maw, there is no cruelty—only truth. The truth that all flesh feeds the earth, and the earth feeds the strong.”

Domain Focus

- **Apex Predation:** hunting, stalking, dominating the food chain
- **Red Tooth:** killing as nature's sacrament, strength proven through violence
- **Scavenger's Wisdom:** using death for growth, nothing wasted
- **Territory and Pack:** dominance over a domain, leadership of the hunt

Rites of the Savage Heart

Rite of the Predator's Gaze (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A tooth from a predator that killed its own prey.

Effect: Mark a single target as your prey. Gain +1 **die** on all rolls to track, pursue, or intimidate that target. The effect lasts until the target escapes or is killed. **Tags:** FEAR, TRACK.

Push It: The prey feels your gaze; they suffer –1 **die** to resist social pressure from you. Mark 1 **SB (Spades)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Blood Scent (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A fresh kill's blood smeared on your face.

Effect: You scent the air like a beast. Gain +2 **dice** to *Investigation* or *Survival* when tracking by smell. You may also detect fear – you sense if a creature within Near is Frightened. **Tags:** SENSE, FEAR.

Push It: Your sense expands to Far, but you are overwhelmed by the smell of blood;

mark **1 SB (Hearts)** and suffer -1 die to social rolls until the end of the scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Savage Will (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A roar or howl that echoes.

Effect: Shrug off fear and hesitation. You gain **+1 die** to resist Fear or intimidation effects, and your next attack this scene gains **+1 Harm**. **Tags:** FEROCITY, RESIST.

Push It: The effect lasts the whole scene, but you mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as your rage becomes difficult to control.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Guardian's Charge (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: A claw or fang from a protective parent animal.

Effect: When an ally within Near range is attacked, you may immediately move up to your full movement toward the attacker and interpose yourself. The attack is redirected to you, and you gain **+1 Armor** against that single attack. If you are already in bear form (see *Rite of the Shifting Shape*), you also gain **+1 die** to your next melee attack against that enemy.

Tags: PROTECT, SPEED, BEAST.

Push It: After redirecting the attack, you may make a free melee attack against the attacker. Mark **1 Fatigue**.

Invoke: 1 action (reaction); mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Shifting Shape (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A pelt or mask from the beast whose form you take.

Effect: Assume the form of a predator for the scene. Choose one:

Bear (Tank Form)

- **Passive:** While in bear form, you gain **+1 Armor** and **+2 dice to Body rolls**.
- **Guardian's Pounce:** Once per scene, when you use *Rite of the Guardian's Charge*, you may also knock the attacker prone (they must test Body+Resolve DV 3 or fall).
- **Limitation:** Your movement is reduced by one band (cannot Dash).

Feline or Canine (Striker Form)

- **Passive:** While in striker form, you gain **+2 dice to Agility and Stealth** and **+1 band to movement** (can Dash as a free action once per scene).
- **Ambush Predator:** When you attack from stealth or while unseen, your attack gains **+1 Effect** and ignores 1 point of the target's Armor.

- **Limitation:** You suffer –1 Armor (or +1 Harm taken) while in this form; you are a glass cannon.

Cultural Variations: The exact form varies by region:

- *Amaranthine / Aeler:* Bear (tank), Wolf (striker)
- *Ykrul / Kuvani:* Steppe Bear, Steppe Wolf (tank and striker)
- *Oshiira:* Lion (tank), Leopard (striker)
- *Dahara:* Tiger (tank), Panther (striker)

You may speak but cannot use tools or cast other Rites while transformed. **Tags:** TRANSFORM, BEAST.

Push It: The transformation becomes instinctive – you may shift as a free action once this scene, but mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the beast presses against your mind.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Pack Leader (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Materials: A token from each member of your pack (a claw, a feather, a scrap of hide).

Effect: You and up to three allies form a hunting pack. While within Near of each other, all gain +1 **die** to attacks against a single designated prey, and the first ally to attack each round gains +1 **Effect**. **Tags:** TEAMWORK, BEAST.

Push It: The pack's coordination extends to Far, but the hunters become territorial; mark **1 SB (Spades)** as rivalries flare.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Carrion Feast (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Materials: The flesh of a fallen enemy, consumed raw.

Effect: You devour the strength of the fallen. Heal **1 Fatigue** immediately, and gain +1 **die** to your next physical action. If the enemy was a supernatural creature (spirit, demon, fey), you also gain a minor property of theirs for one scene. **Tags:** HEAL, CONSUME.

Push It: Heal 1 Harm instead of Fatigue, but mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as the feast attracts scavengers.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Territorial Roar (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A predator's skull mounted on a pole.

Effect: You claim a zone as your territory. For the scene, you gain +2 **dice** to all physical and intimidation rolls within it. Your prey (designated by *Predator's Gaze*) suffers –2 dice to flee or hide. Allies within the zone gain +1 die to defend themselves.

Tags: FEAR, AREA, FORTIFY.

Push It: The territory persists for the session, but you must mark your borders visibly

(at GM discretion, this may attract rivals); mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Hunt (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Near; No.

Materials: The heart of a predator you have killed in single combat, still warm.

Effect: You become the ultimate hunter. For one scene, you may:

- Ignore all difficult terrain.
- Gain **+3 dice** to all tracking and combat rolls against your designated prey.
- If you reduce a prey to 0 Harm, you may immediately make a free attack against another target within Near.

Tags: TRANSFORM, FEAR, SPEED.

Push It: The hunt consumes you – you cannot end the rite until all designated prey are dead or fled, and you suffer Harm 1 (Weariness) when the scene ends. Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Savage Heart

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Savage Heart sings in *hunting calls* – short, sharp cries that mimic the bark of a bear or the cough of a leopard. Their voice is used to coordinate a pack, to scare prey from hiding, or to summon a predator from the deep woods. They are rarely heard near villages; their songs echo in the places between game trails.

The Cult of the Bloody Hand. The Savage Heart's cults do not meet in groves – they meet at kills. The Bloody Hand is a fellowship of hunters, trappers, and those who have tasted raw meat in the dark. A ritual involves each member bringing a fresh kill (any animal, any size) and laying it on a stone. The cult eats the kill raw, speaking the names of the animals they have taken. Their creed is spoken with full mouths: *"The forest is a stomach. We are its teeth."* Outsiders are not welcome; they are either prey or future members.

Witchcraft of the Savage Heart (Craft / Hunter)

A witch who walks with the Savage Heart is a *skin-stitcher* or *tooth-carver* – one who crafts from the bodies of the slain. Their tools are made from bone, claw, fur, and sinew. A knife of wolf fang, a cloak of bear hide that traps warmth, a drum of leopard skin that calls the hunt. Their magic works through the materials of the kill: a needle that sews wounds shut with sinew that never rots, a chisel carved from a tiger's femur that splits wood as if it were soft meat, or a net woven from gut that tightens when prey struggles.

The Witch's Tool: The Flesh Chisel. A chisel made from the limb bone of a great predator, its edge sharpened on stone. Once per session, the witch may strike the

chisel against a fresh kill. The chisel "honours" the kill, allowing the witch to extract one perfect trophy (a tooth, a claw, a patch of fur) without damaging the rest. The trophy can be used as a material component for any Rite of the Savage Heart, granting +1 die to the roll.

A Hedge Gift: Hunter's Snuff (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may blow a pinch of powdered bone into the air. For the next minute, the witch can smell the fear of any creature within Near range – they know if a target is Frightened, and gain +1 die to track it.

The Savage Heart's Corruption

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Stalker's Instinct: +1 die to tracking and stealth in wilderness.	Blood Hunger: Must kill or consume fresh meat each day or suffer 1 Fatigue.
2	Apex Demeanour: +1 die to Intimidation against those weaker than you.	Pack Guilt: –1 die to social rolls in civilised company; you smell faintly of carrion.
3	Scavenger's Resilience: +2 dice to resist disease and poison from raw meat.	Compulsive Dominance: Must assert physical dominance when challenged; –1 die to de-escalation.
4	Wound Licker: Once/session, heal 1 Fatigue by licking a fresh wound (your own or ally"s).	Beastly Tells: Your teeth sharpen, your eyes reflect light; –1 die to disguise.
5	Alpha's Roar: Once/session, make a terrifying sound that forces all nearby prey to test Resolve (DV 4) or flee.	Lone Wolf: –2 dice to cooperate with those who have not proven themselves in battle.
6+	Maw Incarnate: Once/session, become a true predator. For one scene, all attacks ignore 1 Armor and you heal 1 Fatigue on each kill.	The Red Eats All: Mark +3 Obligation; risk becoming feral, unable to speak or reason until you have fed again.

Playstyle Notes

The Savage Heart rewards those who hunt, kill, and dominate. Its followers are not gentle guardians of nature – they are its teeth and claws. Power comes from taking, from proving strength, from the raw act of predation. The cost is the slow loss of the civilised self, the creeping realisation that you are becoming the thing you stalk.

Emphasises

- **Predation as Sacrament:** killing is holy when done with purpose
- **Territory and Dominance:** claim, defend, expand
- **Pack Tactics:** hunting is a team sport
- **Red Tooth Wisdom:** death feeds life, cruelty is not malice but nature

- **Transformation:** becoming the beast to master the beast

Rivalries

- **Grimmir (Seasonal Wisdom):** Grimmer preserves the balance; the Savage Heart devours it. They are two faces of the same coin – but the coin is always flipped.
- **The Sealed Gate (Containment):** The Gate wards things out; the Savage Heart tears down walls.
- **The Sacred Geometry (Harmony):** Order and perfect form are prey to the red maw.

Obligation Triggers

- **8+ Segments:** The Savage Heart demands you take a worthy trophy – hunt a creature of equal or greater strength than yourself, alone.
- **10+ Segments:** You hear the call of the hunt always. Refusing to answer when prey is weak will cost you the use of your Rites until you kill again.

Signs of Favor

Your eyes reflect light in darkness, your shadow seems to move independently, smaller animals flee your presence, and the scent of blood often follows you (real or imagined).

7.8.31 The Sealed Gate (Thresholds & Containment)

Lore. The Sealed Gate stands where realities meet, embodying the sacred power of thresholds, boundaries, and containment. Its followers are wardens, exorcists, and philosophers of separation who believe some things must be kept apart for the world to function. The Gate manifests as an impassive judge whose shifting sigils—binding runes, exclusion marks, or acceptance glyphs—determine what may cross.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, the Sealed Gate is known as the patron of abjurists, exorcists, and sentinels. In Aeler, the Gate is called the *Stone Seal*, invoked by True-Masons who carve permanent wards into mountain passes. In Thepyrgos, the Gate is the *Unbreakable Lock*, whose sigils are painted on every archive door that holds forbidden texts. In the Mistlands, the Gate is the *Bell-Line Keeper*, the force that makes the bell-wards hold against the Direwood. Wherever something must be kept in or kept out, the Sealed Gate’s servants are there – silent, patient, and absolute.

“You define what passes and what remains. Every boundary remembers your judgment.”

Domain Focus

- **Thresholds:** Doors, portals, borders between realms
- **Containment:** Wards, bindings, imprisonment of dangerous forces
- **Exclusion:** Banishment, quarantine, protection through separation
- **Permission:** Safe passage, authorised access, controlled crossing

Rites of the Sealed Gate

Rite of the Sealed Threshold (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; No Push

Materials: Chalk, iron dust, or sanctified cord.

Effect: Mark a doorway or passage as sealed. Unauthorised crossing tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or suffers a Position penalty. Creates a 4-segment *Ward Integrity* clock.

Push It: The barrier becomes a visible shimmer; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Key’s Rebuke (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Near; No Push

Materials: A gesture of denial or a barrier symbol.

Effect: The target must test Body+Resolve (DV 3) or be pushed back from the threshold. On success, create a *Rebuke Echo* token granting +1 **die** to the next boundary defence.

Push It: The rebuke lingers – the target cannot cross this threshold for the rest of the scene; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Circle of Denial (Standard, 8 XP)*Scene; Zone; Standard Push***Materials:** A salt ring, iron filings, or boundary stones.**Effect:** Create a protective circle. Supernatural beings test against the caster's Spirit+Arcana (DV 4) to cross. Mortals suffer **−2 dice** to force entry. Creates a 6-segment *Circle Integrity* clock.**Push It:** The circle becomes a two-way barrier (no one can cross); mark **+1 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Writ of Passage (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Zone; Standard Push***Materials:** Signed authorisation or spoken permissions.**Effect:** Designate an authorised passage route. Allies gain **Position +1** when using the route. Unauthorised intruders suffer **−1 die** to movement or stealth. Creates an 8-segment *Writ Authority* clock.**Push It:** Extend authorisation to additional allies; mark **+1 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Banishment Knot (High, 13 XP)***Instant; Near; High Push***Materials:** A knotted cord sealed with a gate-sigil.**Effect:** The target supernatural entity tests against the caster's Spirit+Resolve (DV = entity Cap). On success, the entity is forced to immediately depart the scene. A failed attempt creates a 4-segment *Banishment Backlash* clock.**Push It:** The banishment lasts until the next moon phase; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.***Rite of the Consecrated Barrier (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Large Zone; High Push***Materials:** Relics from three traditions, boundary markers, a trespasser's acknowledgment.**Effect:** Consecrate an area against all unauthorised passage. The tests required scale with the intrusion attempt's severity. A 10-segment *Sacred Boundary* clock tracks the barrier's strength.**Push It:** Make the barrier semi-permanent (lasts one season); start a *Maintenance [6]* clock.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 8 segments.***Cantors & Cults of the Sealed Gate**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Sealed Gate sings in *locks and wards* – melodies that are precise, repetitive, and final, like the click of a deadbolt or the thud of a bar being set. Their voice is used to seal a door with a sung phrase, to recite a litany of exclusion that pushes a spirit back across the threshold, or to sing a sleeping guard into dreaming

of a wall that never ends. The Gate's Cantors are often found in prisons, asylums, and the gatehouses of cities, their songs keeping the unwanted out.

The Cult of the Unbroken Seal. The Gate's cults meet in places where boundaries are most needed: at city gates, on bridges, in the guardrooms of tombs, and before the sealed doors of forgotten vaults. The Unbroken Seal is a fellowship of wardens, gate-keepers, exorcists, and sentinels who believe that a well-kept boundary is the foundation of civilisation. A ritual of the Cult involves each member renewing a vow to guard a specific threshold – a door, a river, a mountain pass – and marking it with a fresh sigil. Their creed is carved into a single stone that is never moved: *"What is sealed stays sealed. What stays sealed protects the living."* Outsiders are welcome to witness the sealing, but they must leave a token of their own boundary – a key, a lock of hair, a written promise.

Witchcraft of the Sealed Gate (Craft / Barrier)

A witch who walks with the Sealed Gate is a *ward-smith* or *lock-maker* – one who crafts the physical tools of separation: a door that can only be opened by someone who has never told a lie, a chain that binds a spirit to a single room, or a seal that makes a promise unbreakable. Their magic works through the materials of closure: a lock that cannot be picked, a wall that remembers every hand that touched it, or a keystone that holds a building together – and keeps something out. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "ward stone" into the lintel of a prison, so that no prisoner can escape without the warden's permission. In Viterra, a hedge-wright might forge a chain that binds a ghost to a single oak.

The Witch's Tool: The Ward Chisel. A chisel of cold iron, its head struck with a sigil of closure. Once per session, the witch may carve a "ward line" across a threshold (a doorway, a bridge, a window). For the next scene, anyone attempting to cross that threshold with hostile intent must make a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 3) or be turned back. The witch may also use the chisel to "seal" a lock (impose +1 DV on anyone trying to pick it) or to break a broken seal (as a free action, but the chisel then needs to be re-consecrated).

A Hedge Gift: Sealed Lips (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a person's lips (or a letter's seal) and whisper a word of the Gate. For the next hour, that person cannot speak a specific secret or name (chosen by the witch). If they try, their voice fails – they cough, stutter, or simply cannot form the words. This effect can be removed by the witch or by a Resolve test (DV 4) made once per day.

The Sealed Gate's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Threshold Sense: +1 die to detect weak points, unauthorised passage, or boundary violations.	Paranoid Vigilance: Must repeatedly check seals; -1 die to trust-based actions.
2	Ward Resonance: Once/scene, treat a failed protection roll as a success (mark 1 SB).	Isolation Tendency: 1 Fatigue in unsecured or open spaces.
3	Boundary Mastery: +2 dice to ward, barrier, or containment magic.	Compulsive Sealing: Must secure any vulnerability noticed.
4	Absolute Barrier: Once/session, create an impenetrable barrier (1 scene).	Prison Mindset: -1 die to freedom or escape actions.
5	Gate Sovereign: Once/session, banish a major threat with a single test.	Boundary Obsession: -1 die to non-containment actions.
6+	Threshold Incarnate: Become a living barrier for one scene; all nearby boundaries become absolute.	Ultimate Containment Risk: Mark +3 Obligation; risk permanent Harm from the burden of containment.

Playstyle Notes

The Sealed Gate patron excels in defensive, control-oriented play. Followers shape battlefields through strategic boundary placement and become invaluable when dealing with supernatural intrusions or securing locations. The corruption progression naturally leads characters toward becoming immovable guardians at the cost of flexibility and freedom. Ideal for abjurists, exorcists, sentinels, and any character whose duty is to keep things apart.

7.8.32 The Silent Choir, Keeper of Unspoken Truths (Restraint & Protective Omission)

Lore. The Silent Choir is the gathered voice of truths wisely left unsaid, confessions granted mercy, and secrets kept to spare a life from breaking. It is not absence but presence: the practiced wisdom that some knowledge wounds more than it heals. Its keepers are wardens of confidence and shelterers of the vulnerable. They learn to carry burdens alone, to let volatile truths sleep, and to shield others from fires that revelation would feed.

In the world of Fate's Edge, the Silent Choir is invoked by those who must know when to speak and when to stay silent: the bell-wardens of the Mistlands who keep a certain pattern unsung to avoid calling the fog, the archivists of Thepyrgos who seal dangerous texts behind a second lock and whisper the combination to no one, and the confessors of Vhasia who carry a dying oath to the grave. The Choir has no temples, only quiet rooms, sealed letter-boxes, and the spaces between heartbeats where a truth could be told – but is not.

“In a world that shouts, the Choir teaches the weight of quiet. Not every wound needs salt, not every blaze needs breath, not every heart can bear the full truth.”

Domain Focus

- **Protective Silence:** when and how to keep counsel for others" good
- **Merciful Omission:** judging truths that harm when spoken
- **Confidential Guardianship:** safeguarding people and perilous knowledge
- **Restraint Wisdom:** the power of what is not said or done

Rites of the Silent Choir

Rite of the Gentle Silence (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A white feather or cloth that has drunk whispered confidences.

Effect: Hush a space with respectful quiet. All present gain **+1 die** to actions of discretion, confidentiality, or de-escalation this scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Shielded Truth (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Materials: A sealed envelope or locked reliquary holding a sensitive fact.

Effect: Ward one piece of information from discovery. Gain **+2 dice** to resist extraction or revelation of the protected truth.

Push It: Protection becomes absolute but dependent: removing the ward triggers **1 SB (Hearts)** as bottled truths surge.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unspoken Accord (Standard, 8 XP)*Scene; Near; Yes.***Materials:** A pact signed in fading ink or a vow witnessed in silence.**Effect:** Bind an understanding without paper teeth. All parties gain +1 **die** when honouring the accord; breach draws social costs even without proof.**Push It:** The accord is supernaturally enforced: a breaker suffers swift ostracism; mark +1 **Obligation**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Burden Bearer (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Touch; Yes.***Materials:** An object heavy with someone's shame or grief.**Effect:** Take another's social or emotional weight for a time. The target gains relief (+2 **dice** to social rolls) while you suffer the drag (−1 **die** to social rolls) this scene.**Push It:** A shard remains: gain insight, keep a sliver of pain; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Sanctuary of Secrets (High, 13 XP)***Extended; Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A room seasoned by trusted confidences and sealed with hush-signs.**Effect:** Consecrate a sanctuary where secrets hold fast. Truths cannot be compelled; all within gain immunity to forced revelation and +2 **dice** to maintain discretion.**Push It:** The sanctuary becomes a keep: none may leave until each offers one guarded truth; mark +2 **Obligation**.**Invoke:** Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.***Rite of the Choir's Wisdom (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Self; Yes.***Materials:** The weight of many secrets rightly kept and debts of trust well paid.**Effect:** Read the branching costs of revelation before speech. Gain +3 **dice** to judge when to speak and when to keep counsel.**Push It:** Sight is too wide: see all outcomes, struggle to choose; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.**Invoke:** Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 8 segments.***Cantors & Cults of the Silent Choir**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Silent Choir sings in *breaths of omission* – melodies that are felt rather than heard, harmonies that resolve into silence. Their voice is used to quiet a room of gossip, to seal a confession with a hum that makes it sacred, or to place a gentle pressure on a tongue that would speak a harmful truth. The Choir's Cantors are often found in confessionals, in the rooms of the dying, and in the alcoves of great libraries, humming the songs that keep secrets safe.

The Cult of the Sealed Lip. The Silent Choir's cults meet in places where secrets are naturally kept: locked scriptoria, the back rooms of notaries, and the quiet corners of courthouses. The Sealed Lip is a fellowship of confessors, archivists, therapists, and spies who have learned that the most powerful word is the one left unspoken. A ritual of the Cult involves each member writing down a truth they wish they could tell, then sealing it in an envelope that is never opened. The envelopes are stored in a single locked chest – the *Coffer of Unspoken Things*. Their creed is written on the inside of the lid: "*The word not spoken is a shield. The secret kept is a kindness.*" Outsiders are welcome to bring a sealed envelope of their own, but they must never ask what is inside another's.

Witchcraft of the Silent Choir (Craft / Secrecy)

A witch who walks with the Silent Choir is a *seal-scribe* or *lock-keeper* – one who crafts the physical vessels of silence: a book whose pages refuse to reveal their contents to the wrong reader, a chest that cannot be opened without the keeper's whisper, or a letter that dissolves if read aloud. Their magic works through the materials of discretion: a quill that writes in ink that fades after one reading, a wax seal that screams if broken by an unauthorised hand, or a lock that only clicks shut when a secret is placed inside. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "silence stone" into a courtroom wall, so that all testimony spoken there is forgotten the moment the gavel falls. In Zakov, a bookbinder might stitch a volume that cannot be read unless the reader has earned the author's trust.

The Witch's Tool: The Sealed Quill. A quill carved from a raven's feather, its nib dipped in ink made from lampblack and a drop of the witch's blood. Once per session, the witch may write a single sentence on a piece of parchment, then seal it with a drop of wax. For the next day, anyone other than the witch who reads the sentence must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or forget it immediately after reading. The witch may also use the quill to "seal" a spoken secret, causing the speaker's voice to catch if they try to repeat it for the rest of the scene.

A Hedge Gift: Weight of the Unsaid (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a person's lips and speak a single word ("hush"). For the next minute, that person cannot speak any word that would reveal a secret they have sworn to keep (including secrets they have overheard). If they try, they feel a mild pressure on their throat – enough to pause them, but not enough to cause harm. The effect ends if the witch speaks again.

The Silent Choir's Corruption

Tier	Blessing	Burden / Quirk
1	Discretion's Gift: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> when someone is about to speak what should be kept.	Silent Compulsion: Urge to still tongues; -1 die to ordinary conversation.
2	Confidence Keeper: Once/scene, shelter a secret from accidental spill.	Secret Burden: In places thick with confidences, suffer Fatigue 1 .
3	Merciful Blindness: Once/session, prevent discovery of a truth that would harm if revealed.	Truth Sensitivity: Lies grate; -1 die while surrounded by deception.
4	Sanctuary Sense: Once/scene, veil a brief zone from eavesdropping.	Communication Strain: Others balk at full candour; -1 die to personal disclosure.
5	Wisdom of Restraint: Once/session, see the full cost of airing any one truth.	Silent Isolation: -2 dice to form close bonds; you hold too much back.
6+	Choir's Voice: Once/session, speak with the gathered prudence of unspoken truths.	Truth Prison: Mark +3 Obligation; risk becoming a living vault unable to share without harm.

Playstyle Notes

The Silent Choir favours guardians and confidants: those who stand between fragile lives and ruinous truth. Its rites fortify discretion, temper tempers, and build rooms where trust can breathe. The cost is weight: secrets you keep will keep you.

Emphasises

- **Protective Restraint:** silence used as shield
- **Confidential Guardianship:** duty to those who trust you
- **Merciful Omission:** letting some truths sleep
- **Discretion Wisdom:** judging what, when, and how to speak
- **Burden Bearing:** carrying heat so others do not burn

7.8.33 Thrysos, King of Revels (Ecstasy & Excess)

Lore. Where torches flare and cups spill, where dancers stamp until dawn, there strides Thrysos crowned with ivy and horn. He is both host and beast, a patron of license who laughs at law. In his train follow the masked and the wild, the broken who dance to forget, the bold who revel to remember. His rites intoxicate, inflame, and unmask—yet each cup leaves its mark.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Thrysos is called by many names that honour the ecstatic release. In Linn, his followers are the *Storm-Dancers*, who whirl through gales to exhaustion. In Aelinnel, he is the *Unbounded Guest*, whose arrival at a feast is marked by laughter and shattered glass. In Zakov, the *Revel-King* is invoked before every pirate carouse, with the understanding that a hungover crew is a vulnerable one. His rituals are never secret – they are too loud for concealment – but they are always dangerous, for Thrysos demands that every excess be paid for, if not tonight then at the first hangover of spring.

Signs. Wine that never sours; a mask that smiles without wearer; goat-tracks circling thrice before vanishing.

Cantor’s Temptation. His promise is freedom without end: no oaths, no chains, only song and cup and fire. Yet those who drink too deeply wake to find they serve not joy but appetite.

“Drink, and be unafraid.”

“Every mask is true when worn long enough.”

“In the dance we are all kings—until the dawn.”

Domain Focus

- **Ecstatic Release:** dance, intoxication, the shedding of inhibition
- **Masked Freedom:** identity as performance, truth through disguise
- **Feast and Famine:** excess, appetite, and the cost of indulgence
- **Ritual Frenzy:** communal ecstasy that transforms participants

Rites of Thrysos

Rite of the Overflowing Cup (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A brimming vessel of wine or blood.

Effect: Allies who drink gain +1 **die** to social rolls this scene; enemies who drink suffer –1 **die**.

Push It: All in Near must test Resolve (DV 3) or be swept into revelry; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Horned Dance (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A mask or antlers.

Effect: Enter an ecstatic frenzy: +2 dice to melee or performance; ignore 1 Fatigue per round.

Push It: The frenzy spreads: one ally joins, but both mark 1 SB (Spades).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Breaking Mask (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: A mask smashed in hand.

Effect: Reveal the true face: the target suffers –2 dice to disguise, deceit, or composure until scene end.

Push It: Truth is forced: the target must declare one hidden desire; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Wild Procession (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A horn sounded thrice.

Effect: Summon spectral revellers – satyrs, dancers, horned riders. For the scene, the zone is [WARD]ed: hostile entry forces 1 SB (Spades); allies gain +1 die to resist compulsion or fear.

Push It: The procession spills beyond the zone; outsiders in Near must test Resolve (DV 4) or join.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Gilded Stag (High, 12 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Materials: A golden mask, the blood of a horned beast.

Effect: Transform one reveler into a beast of horn and fire. For one session: +2 dice to melee; Harm +1 (Burn). At session's end they collapse with Harm 2 (Exhaustion).

Push It: The transformation becomes permanent until undone; mark +3 Obligation.

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

Rite of the Endless Feast (High, 14 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A feast laid for twelve.

Effect: For one scene, the zone floods with plenty: allies restore Fatigue; all rolls tied to appetite or indulgence gain +2 dice. Leaving requires Resolve (DV 3).

Push It: The feast persists as a hunger-haunt; start **Hedonist's Curse** [6].

Invoke: 1 action; mark +3 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Rite of the Unfettered Bacchanal (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A wine vat blessed by midnight storms, masks of every emotion, the tears of a jilted lover.

Effect: Create a zone of absolute revelry. All within must either join the celebration (+2 dice to social/performance) or resist with Resolve (DV 4) each round or suffer –2 dice to all actions.

Push It: The revelry becomes infectious – resistance causes 1 SB (Hearts) as social pressure mounts.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Reveler's Apotheosis (High, 15 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Materials: A crown of twisted vines that bleed when touched, the first laugh of a newborn, a promise broken at a crossroads.

Effect: Grant the ultimate reveler's gift – transformation into pure ecstatic essence. The target becomes immune to fear and despair, gains +3 dice to performance or frenzy, and can inspire allies within Near (+1 die to all rolls).

Push It: The transformation becomes contagious – nearby allies may also transform but risk losing their humanity; mark +2 Obligation.

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +3 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Thrysos

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Thrysos sings in *off-key harmonies* – melodies that start wild and grow wilder, rhythms that mimic a galloping heart. Their voice is used to whip a crowd into a frenzy, to calm a hangover with a lullaby, or to make a mask cling to a face until the wearer is ready to take it off. Thrysos's Cantors are often found at festivals, in taverns at closing time, and leading the procession of the horned dancers.

The Cult of the Horned Circle. Thrysos's cults meet in clearings, barns, and the back rooms of inns after midnight. The Horned Circle is a fellowship of mask-carvers, vintners, musicians, and those who have tasted the edge of ecstasy. A ritual of the Circle involves each member donning a mask (hand-carved, never bought) and dancing until the first dancer falls from exhaustion. The fallen is crowned with ivy and declared "guest of honour" – they lead the next circle. Their creed is carved into a single wine barrel that is never emptied: "*The cup that never empties is the cup you share.*" Outsiders are welcome to dance, but they must leave their mask behind when they go.

Witchcraft of Thrysos (Craft / Revelry)

A witch who walks with Thrysos is a *mask-carver* or *wine-smith* – one who crafts the tools of ecstatic release: a mask that lets the wearer dance without tiring, a drum that beats in time with the drinker's pulse, or a cup that never runs dry (but leaves a headache at dawn). Their magic works through the materials of celebration: a chisel that shapes a

grin that never fades, a press that squeezes wine that ferments in hours instead of weeks, or a needle that sews a costume that makes the wearer faster, louder, bolder. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "revel keystone" into a feast hall, so that every toast echoes with genuine joy. In Aelaerem, a hedgewitch might weave a garland that wards off the worst of a hangover.

The Witch's Tool: The Revel Chisel. A chisel of ironwood, its edge shaped like a grinning mouth. Once per session, the witch may carve a "revel mark" into a wooden surface (a table, a mask, a barrel). For the next scene, anyone who drinks from a vessel placed on that mark gains **+1 die** to social rolls – but also suffers 1 Fatigue when the scene ends (the "morning after"). The chisel can also be used to carve a simple mask from a block of wood in under a minute; the mask grants +1 die to Performance for one scene.

A Hedge Gift: Dancer's Cramp (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may snap their fingers and whisper a dancer's rhythm. One target within Near range feels an irresistible urge to move – they must tap a foot, sway, or take a step. This cannot force them into danger, but it can ruin stealth, break a staredown, or distract a guard for one exchange. The target may resist with Resolve (DV 3) to ignore the urge.

Thrysos's Corruption Table

Tier	Gift	Corruption
1	Reveler's Grace: +1 die to social rolls in feasts or crowds.	Compulsive Toast: Must drink or mark 1 Fatigue when drink is offered.
2	Horned Vitality: Ignore the first 1 Fatigue each scene.	Restless Appetite: –1 die when abstaining from indulgence.
3	Revel-Kin: Once/scene, summon a minor revel-spirit (advantage die).	Masked Self: Cannot act without a role or guise; –1 die to plain sincerity.
4	Bacchic Fury: Once/session, frenzy grants +2 dice to melee for one exchange.	Ecstatic Blindness: –1 die to perception outside the revel.
5	Feast Without End: Once/session, allies in Near clear all Fatigue.	Hungering Host: You consume twice as much; denial causes Harm 1 (Stress).
6+	Satyr King's Mantle: For one scene, become an avatar of revels; all allies gain +2 dice, enemies suffer –2 dice.	Tyrant of Pleasure: Mark +3 Obligation; the revel grows monstrous, demanding sacrifice.
		Beast of Endless Revel: Permanent transformation – your mortal form becomes optional; must make Presence+Performance (DV 4) to appear civilised or risk terrifying (or entrancing) all who see you into joining your eternal celebration.

“Let the wine flow, let the masks fall, let the fire burn away all restraint. In the revel we find truth—raw, wild, and beautiful.”

Playstyle Notes

Thrysos rewards those who embrace risk, abandon convention, and find power in letting go. His followers become masters of ecstatic ritual, social manipulation through celebration, and the dangerous art of losing control. The corruption progression leads toward a beast of endless revel – powerful, charismatic, but never truly sober, never truly at rest. Ideal for players who enjoy wild scenes, social chaos, and characters who dance on the edge of self-destruction.

7.8.34 The Traveler (Ways & Journeys)

Lore. The Traveler is the eternal guide of the road, guardian of those who walk the paths between what is and what might be. Among the Fhara caravans and Kuvani traders along the Way of Silk, the Traveler is invoked at every crossroads, honoured with small offerings at each waypoint, and consulted before every major journey.

The Traveler is not merely one who shows the way—they *are* the way, existing in the pause between steps and in the choice of which path to take when roads fork. Every journey is both physical and spiritual; to move from one place to another is to transform, and the road itself becomes a teacher.

Across the known world, the Traveler wears many faces. In Kahfagia, the Traveler is the *Lantern-Bearer*, whose light guides ships through uncharted waters. In Ykrul, the Traveler is the *Hoof-Print*, the spirit of the steppe road that appears as a single arrowhead left at a crossroads. In Aeler, the Traveler is the *Ways-Stone*, carved into every mile marker by True-Masons to ensure the road remembers those who walk it. In the Mistlands, the Traveler is invoked with a single unknotted bell-rope – a sign that the fog may part for one who walks humbly. Wherever a traveller sets foot, the Traveler is already there, waiting to see which road they choose.

One foot in a promise, and the road will meet you halfway. But break your word to the way, and the way will break you.

Domain Focus

- **Wayfinding:** navigation, route-finding, safe passage
- **Journeys:** travel, pilgrimage, exploration
- **Thresholds of Movement:** doors, bridges, crossroads, borders
- **Road Covenants:** promises made on the road, hospitality to travellers

Rites of the Traveler

Rite of Road-Sense (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A road-nail or waystone pebble.

Effect: Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near/Far. Gain +1 **die** to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment *Path Memory* clock to ignore difficult terrain once.

Push It: Spot one hidden bypass, but generate 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Traveler's Boon (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self/Ally; No.

Materials: Thread tied at the wrist.

Effect: Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy; +1 **Effect** to travel or escape checks. If shared, create a 2-segment *Shared Journey* bond with an ally.

Push It: Extend to one more ally; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Waymark (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A chalk mark or small cairn.

Effect: Declare a lane as permitted or easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment *Marked Path* clock.

Push It: The lane persists between scenes; the first enemy to exploit it forces **1 SB (Spades)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Bridge Between (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: Two pinches of road-dust clapped.

Effect: Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible or named route. Unwilling targets may resist (Body+Resolve DV 3). Create a 4-segment *Pathway Established* clock.

Push It: Carry one extra ally or bundle; arrivals are off-balance.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Crown of Crossings (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A brass compass missing its needle.

Effect: Call the Road: allies gain **+1 die** to move or evade; pursuers suffer **−1 die**. Once, declare "the long way is short" to finish a travel clock segment for free. Enemies must test (Wits+Command DV 4) or suffer **−1 die** to movement.

Push It: Seal a hostile route briefly; generate **2 SB (Clubs/Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Wayfarer's Covenant (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Near; No.

Materials: Waystones from multiple regions.

Effect: Bind present parties to safe passage. While honoured: **+2 Effect** on travel, reroll one failed travel roll per scene. Breaking the oath inflicts Harm 1 (Fatigue) and marks the breaker as *Oathbreaker of the Road* (−2 dice to travel rolls).

Push It: Breaking the covenant inflicts Harm 2 (Stress) and attracts hostile Wayward spirits.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Traveler

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Traveler sings in *verses of the open road* – melodies that rise and fall like hills, harmonies that echo the creak of wagon wheels. Their voice is used to mark a crossroads with a sung sign, to calm a spooked pack animal, or to call a lost wanderer back to the path. The Traveler's Cantors are often found in caravan

camp, at pilgrimage shrines, and walking the roads alone, humming to keep the miles company.

The Cult of the Unbroken Way. The Traveler's cults gather at forks, at bridges, and at the crests of passes – never in buildings. The Unbroken Way is a fellowship of guides, couriers, scouts, and those who have walked so far that the road has become their home. A ritual of the Cult involves each member placing a small stone at a crossroads, then walking a different way home than they came – the road must be honoured with new steps. Their creed is scratched into a single waystone that travels from meeting to meeting: *"The road does not end. It only turns."* Outsiders are welcome to walk a mile with the cult, but they must carry a stone from home and leave it at the next crossroads.

Witchcraft of the Traveler (Craft / Wayfinding)

A witch who walks with the Traveler is a *map-scribe* or *waystone-carver* – one who crafts the physical markers of the road: a compass that always points to a chosen destination, a map that shows routes that appear only when needed, or a staff that never causes the bearer to trip. Their magic works through the materials of travel: a quill that draws paths that become real by morning, a chisel that carves a symbol into a stone so that travellers who touch it feel rested, or a needle that sews a patch into a cloak that keeps the wind from shifting direction. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "way keystone" into a bridge so that the bridge remembers every traveller and wishes them well. In Vhasia, a cartographer might illuminate a map with a prayer; the map will never show the route to an ambush.

The Witch's Tool: The Way Chisel. A chisel of iron, its head struck with a simple arrow. Once per session, the witch may carve a "way mark" into a stone, a tree, or a wooden post. For the next day, anyone who sees the way mark gains a perfect sense of direction to the nearest safe harbour, village, or crossroads – but only while walking. The chisel can also be used to "erase" a false trail, removing tracks from a path as if they had never been made (one exchange of effort per use).

A Hedge Gift: Road-Worn Token (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a small stone, a coin, or a button that has been carried on a long journey. For the next hour, the token glows faintly when the bearer is on the correct path to their goal (as long as the goal is a physical location). The token does not reveal the path – only that the bearer has not (or has) strayed from it.

The Traveler's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Pathfinding Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and movement rolls in familiar territory.	Restless Spirit: Suffer 1 Fatigue when forced to remain stationary or in confined spaces for extended periods.
2	Wayfarer's Luck: Once/scene, treat a failed travel or navigation roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Compulsive Wandering: Must take the less obvious path when choices present themselves; suffer –1 die when forced to follow direct routes.
3	Road Mastery: +2 dice to rolls involving travel, escape, or finding hidden paths.	Travel Dependency: –1 die to rolls requiring local knowledge or settlement-based skills.
4	Journey's Blessing: Once/session, grant all allies within Near range +1 die to travel-related rolls for one scene.	Nomad's Isolation: –1 die to social rolls involving long-term relationships or community ties.
5	Waypoint Sense: Once/session, instantly know the location and nature of all significant paths, routes, or crossroads within a day's travel.	Directional Obsession: –1 die to rolls not involving movement, travel, or pathfinding; always aware of cardinal directions.
6+	Master of All Ways: Once/session, become one with the road network. For one scene, teleport between any known waypoints and grant +2 dice to all travel-related actions.	Eternal Journey: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; risk permanent Harm (Stress) from the endless call of the road, making settlement impossible until the journey's end.

7.8.35 Varnek Karn, the Death's Negotiator (Bargains with the Departed)

Lore. Varnek Karn dwells in the grey between life and death, where the newly departed linger with unfinished business and elder shades guard secrets dearer than gold. He is the broker who speaks across the veil, the mediator of disputes between living and dead, and the archivist of every promise sworn beyond the grave. His servants practice post-mortem diplomacy: they negotiate, consult, and contract with spirits as equals—mindful that the dead are patient and rarely generous.

Yet Varnek Karn is also the patron of those who **raise** the dead, not through force but through bargain. The dead may be persuaded to walk again, to fight for a season, or to guard a threshold, but every such compact is a debt. The dead demand their due: a memory, a future, a name, or simply the promise that the living will remember them. Those who serve Varnek Karn learn that raising a spirit is never a command; it is a negotiation, and the spirit always has a price.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Varnek Karn is the patron of those who treat with the departed respectfully. In Aeler, he is the *Breath-Accountant*, who audits the spiritual ledgers of the Deep Vaults and ensures that the dead are not forgotten. In Ykrul, he is the *Bone-Speaker*, whose drum calls ancestors to council before any major migration. In Vhasia, he is the *Silent Notary*, who witnesses death-bed testaments and ensures their terms are honoured. In the Mistlands, he is the *Bell-Shrouded*, whose unknotted rope holds the fog at bay. Wherever the living and the dead must negotiate, Varnek Karn's servants are there – not to command, but to listen.

“The dead have all the time in the world to consider their offers, and no need to rush to agreement. They know what the living forgot, and remember every slight with perfect clarity. In Varnek's halls, both parties pay a price—but the currency is never what you expect.”

Domain Focus

- **Post-Mortem Diplomacy:** parleys with ghosts and recent dead
- **Ancestral Wisdom:** counsel from forebears and keeping of funerary law
- **Unfinished Business:** resolving the concerns that bind spirits
- **Death-Bound Contracts:** obligations that outlive the flesh
- **The Unquiet Host:** raising temporary armies of the dead through pact

Rites of Varnek Karn**Rite of the Crossing Fee (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A coin for the tongue of the deceased, or a lock of hair from the bereaved.

Effect: Open speech with a specific dead individual. Gain +1 **die** to *Investigation* or *Lore* when seeking knowledge they once held.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Ancestral Consultation (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A personal token of the departed, or their favoured food/drink.

Effect: Ask one question of an ancestral spirit regarding family history, hidden legacies, or inherited debts.

Push It: The spirit grants detailed, prophetic guidance but exacts a small favour; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Death-Bound Pact (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Materials: Two copies of a written accord—one buried with the dead, one kept by the living.

Effect: Bind a compact between a living signatory and a willing spirit. Both gain **+1 die** when fulfilling the terms. Breach angers the spirit and Varnek both.

Push It: The pact enforces itself: a breach triggers supernatural reprisal; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unquiet Host (Standard, 10 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Materials: A battlefield relic (a broken sword, a skull, a scrap of uniform) and a handful of grave-earth.

Effect: You negotiate with the lingering dead of a place. Summon a **Temporary Host** – a spectral warband treated as a single **Cap 3 Follower** with the following traits:

- **Assist:** May grant **+3 dice** to a single combat or intimidation roll, or provide a free *Setup* action (e.g., “they distract the guards”).
- **Independent Action:** Once per scene, the Host may take one action from the Follower list (e.g., *Scout & Signal*, *Distract & Draw*) at the cost of marking **Exposure +1**.
- **Weakness:** The Host is vulnerable to salt, bells, and consecrated ground. Any attack using such materials ignores their spectral nature.

The Host lasts for the remainder of the current scene, or until dismissed. When it departs, the dead demand their due: you must either:

- Mark **+2 Obligation** (the debt to Varnek Karn increases), or
- Perform a *Memorial Rite* before the next dawn (a downtime action, no roll) to honour the fallen. If you fail to do so, the Host returns unbidden at the worst moment, acting as a hostile hazard (GM’s discretion).

Push It: Extend the Host’s duration to the entire session. The debt is doubled: mark **+4 Obligation** or perform a memorial rite *and* sacrifice a personal memory (erase a minor fact or a Bond for one session).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Spirit Medium (Standard, 7 XP)*Scene; Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A circle of salt mixed with grave-dust; a candle of funeral wax.**Effect:** Serve as a conduit for several spirits to speak. Gain +2 **dice** to mediate disputes between living and dead and to facilitate group negotiation.**Push It:** A potent spirit rides your voice to speak directly; mark **Exposure +1**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Final Testament (High, 13 XP)***Extended; Touch; Yes.***Materials:** A dying person's last words recorded in their blood, witnessed by you.**Effect:** Seal the last request with weight beyond life. Targets must pass *Resolve* (DV 4) to ignore it.**Push It:** The testament becomes a geas: only fulfilment—or Varnek's wrath—can break it; mark +2 **Obligation**.**Invoke:** Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 7 segments.**Rite of the Eternal Archive (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A library mortared with tomb-stone, ink from cremation ash.**Effect:** Found a repository where the dead deposit knowledge. Gain a permanent +1 **die** to *Lore* for historical or genealogical research made within. Spirits periodically contribute testimonies.**Push It:** The archive awakens and begins to demand curatorship and payment; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.**Invoke:** Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 8 segments.**Necromantic Summoning (Varnek Karn's Way)**

For summoners (Pact-Whisperers) who follow Varnek Karn, the usual Leash mechanics gain an additional option. When you call a spirit (using the Pact-Whisperer rules), you may choose to bind it with a **Death-Bound Contract** instead of the standard Leash. Instead of ticking Leash on harm or disobedience, the spirit gains a **Promise Clock [4]** named "Debt Unpaid." Each time it acts against your interests, you may advance the clock by 1. When the clock fills, the spirit must either obey one final command (even against its nature) or immediately depart and become an enemy. However, while under contract, the spirit cannot be dismissed early – you are committed. This replaces the Boon Finesse option; you cannot spend Boons to clear ticks. This method is slower but more reliable for extended servitude, and it fits Varnek Karn's theme of negotiation over coercion.

Cantors & Cults of Varnek Karn

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Varnek Karn sings in *dirges of negotiation* – melodies that invite the dead to speak, harmonies that soothe restless shades. Their voice is used to call an ancestor to council, to lull a vengeful ghost into recounting its grievance, or to sing a funeral procession past a haunted crossroads. Varnek's Cantors are often found in graveyards, in the halls of the dying, and at the tables where inheritance disputes are settled, their songs bridging the silence between breath and decay.

The Cult of the Unforgotten Ledger. Varnek Karn's cults gather in places where the dead are honoured: crypts, ossuaries, ancestral halls, and the quiet rooms above funeral parlours. The Unforgotten Ledger is a fellowship of necromancers (who negotiate, not command), funeral notaries, inheritance mediators, and those who have lost so many that they have become archivists of memory. A ritual of the Cult involves each member presenting a written record of a death they have witnessed – a name, a date, a final word – then adding it to a single, ever-growing ledger bound in grey hide. Their creed is written on the first page: *"The dead are not gone. They have only changed their address. Be polite, pay your respects, and never make a promise you cannot keep."* Outsiders are welcome to bring a name of someone they have lost; they may read the ledger but not write in it.

Witchcraft of Varnek Karn (Craft / Ancestral)

A witch who walks with Varnek Karn is a *bone-carver* or *shroud-weaver* – one who crafts the physical vessels of ancestral memory: a bone flute that plays the voice of a specific ancestor, a shroud that keeps the dead from wandering, or a funerary mask that lets the wearer speak with the buried. Their magic works through the materials of death: a chisel that carves a name into a headstone so that the dead remember who they are, a needle that sews a grave-cloth that stays clean for a year and a day, or a bell that rings only when a spirit is ready to speak. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "memory niche" into a crypt wall, so that the dead can hear the prayers of the living. In Zakov, a net-mender might weave a shroud that guides a drowned sailor's soul back to shore.

The Witch's Tool: The Bone Chisel. A chisel carved from the long-bone of a respected ancestor, its edge polished by grave-dust. Once per session, the witch may carve a single name into a stone threshold (a grave marker, a door of a tomb, a hearth). For the next day, anyone who speaks that name near the carved stone can hear a whispered answer – a single word or a sigh – from the person whose name is carved. The chisel can also be used to "name" an unmarked grave, giving the occupant a voice for one exchange.

A Hedge Gift: Echo of the Honoured Dead (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a physical remnant of the dead (a bone, a lock of hair, a piece of clothing) and whisper a question. For a moment, the remnant holds a memory – the GM answers one factual question about the dead person's life or death, but the answer is always tinged with the emotion of the moment (e.g., "she was afraid," "he was angry," "they were at peace").

Varnek Karn's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Death's Whisper: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> when the dead seek to communicate.	Graveyard Pallor: -1 die to social rolls with the living; your presence unsettles.
2	Ancestral Insight: Once/scene, gain +2 dice for family history or inherited troubles.	Spectral Awareness: Ever-aware of nearby spirits; suffer Fatigue 1 in places of many deaths.
3	Medium's Gift: Once/session, act as a flawless conduit for a spirit.	Death-Touched: Cold spots and small portents follow you; -1 die to ordinary social grace.
4	Final Authority: Once/scene, compel adherence to a true last request (Resolve DV 4).	Corpse-Pale: Visibly wan; -2 dice where warmth or vigour is required.
5	Archive Keeper: Once/session, access perfect recall of a historical event or family secret.	Unquiet Presence: The dead trail you; -1 die to stealth and to surprising the living.
6+	Death's Confidant: Once/session, negotiate with puissant death-entities as an equal.	Halfway House: Mark +2 Obligation; risk becoming half-withdrawn from the living world.

Playstyle Notes

Varnek Karn favours investigators, arbiters, and heralds of funerary law. Power grows through cultural sensitivity, shrewd bargaining, and careful record-keeping; the price is a thinning tie to warmth and mortal ease. Expect mysteries of lineage, obligations that outlive their makers, and parleys where both sides of the veil demand their due. The *Rite of the Unquiet Host* allows a follower to temporarily command a small army of the dead, but the debt incurred ensures that such power is never free – and the dead always remember who called them.

Varnek Karn emphasises

- **Diplomacy over Dominion:** bargaining with the dead rather than commanding them
- **Knowledge Brokerage:** trading for secrets and testimonies beyond the grave
- **Cultural Protocols:** rites, tokens, and proper doors for speaking with ancestors
- **Mediation:** resolving conflicts that bind the living to the dead
- **Historical Continuity:** showing how past vows shape the present
- **The Unquiet Host:** raising temporary armies through pact, not domination

7.8.36 Vorthak, the Hunger Unbound (Consumption & Metamorphic Hunger)

Lore. Vorthak is the principle of absolute consumption: an appetite that devours not only what is, but the very potential of what might be. Each feeding transforms both eater and eaten. His servants become conduits of metamorphosis through ingestion, learning to consume not only matter but also properties, identities, and even strands of fate. Power comes by taking in — and the cost is becoming more like the hunger you channel.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Vorthak is known by many fearful names. In Aeler, he is the *Deep Forge*, the hunger of the mountain that consumes ore and returns steel. In Zakov, he is the *Salt-Hunger*, the appetite that preserves by consuming the moisture from flesh. In Linn, he is the *Tide-That-Eats-The-Shore*, a slow, patient consumption that reshapes coastlines. His followers are rarely beloved, but they are essential — for without consumption, there is no transformation, and without transformation, there is only stagnation.

“To consume is to become. To devour is to transform. In Vorthak's embrace, the boundary between eater and eaten dissolves into something new — and something hungry.”

Domain Focus

- **Metamorphic Consumption:** transformation through ingestion of matter, energy, or concepts
- **Essence Absorption:** gaining properties by consuming them utterly
- **Hunger Propagation:** spreading consumption as a force of change
- **Identity Metabolism:** consuming and adopting aspects of others' natures

Rites of Vorthak

Rite of the Metabolic Touch (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: A fragment of the thing to be consumed (food, substance, symbol).

Effect: Absorb an essential trait of the target. Gain +1 **die** to actions aligned with the absorbed property for one scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Hunger's Whisper (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: An empty vessel or a place where something was devoured.

Effect: Sense what in the area may be consumed and the benefit it offers. Gain +1 **die** to *Investigation* when seeking consumable resources.

Push It: The hunger turns contagious: nearby feel your appetite; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Essence Feast (Standard, 8 XP)*Scene; Touch; Yes.***Materials:** The complete consumption of a significant item (weapon, book, relic).**Effect:** Permanently absorb the item's essential nature. Gain one minor property or +1 die to a closely related skill. The item is utterly destroyed.**Push It:** Take a major property, but gain a permanent *Hunger Mark* (a visible sign of consumption).**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Identity Meal (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Near; Yes.***Materials:** A personal token or a clear memory of the target.**Effect:** Temporarily adopt one aspect of a specific person's nature (skill, talent, or defining trait). Gain +2 dice to actions matching that aspect.**Push It:** The adoption deepens and clings; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Metamorphic Gluttony (High, 13 XP)***Scene; Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A site scarred by great consumption.**Effect:** Become a locus of transformative hunger. All present may consume aspects (skills, memories, properties), but each must pass *Spirit+Resolve* (DV 4) or suffer uncontrolled transformation effects.**Push It:** Some changes become permanent; mark +2 **Obligation**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.***Rite of the Hunger's Ascension (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Self; Yes.***Materials:** The deliberate offering-up of your current limits to Vorthak.**Effect:** Consume your own constraints and transform. Choose three: +1 Attribute; +2 dice to one skill; immunity to one Condition type; or one major supernatural capability.**Push It:** Take all chosen benefits, but lose one core aspect of your original identity; mark **Harm 2**.**Invoke:** Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 8 segments.***Cantors & Cults of Vorthak**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Vorthak sings in *hungry harmonies* – melodies that start with a single, clear note and then devour themselves, ending in a hungry silence. Their voice is used to urge a crowd to feast, to sing a blade sharper by absorbing the steel's flaws, or to make a meal last for hours by consuming the very passage of time.

Vorthak's Cantors are often found in feasting halls, in butcheries, and around campfires where stories are consumed and retold.

The Cult of the Ravenous Circle. Vorthak's cults meet in places that embody consumption: abattoirs, forges, bakeries, and the kitchens of great manors. The Ravenous Circle is a fellowship of chefs, alchemists, tanners, and smelters – those who understand that to create something new, something old must be utterly consumed. A ritual of the Circle involves each member bringing a raw material (a cut of meat, a lump of ore, a written secret) and placing it in a central hearth. The hearth consumes it, and the circle speaks aloud what they hope to become by that consumption. Their creed is carved above the hearth: *"What is not consumed is wasted. What is wasted is an insult to hunger."* Outsiders are welcome to bring an offering and a wish, but they must eat a portion of the ash.

Witchcraft of Vorthak (Craft / Consumption)

A witch who walks with Vorthak is a *hunger-smith* or *ash-weaver* – one who crafts through the act of consumption: a knife that sharpens itself by eating the metal of its victims, a forge that devours impurities and returns only the strongest steel, or a culinary knife that seasons meat by absorbing the memory of the animal's life. Their magic works through the materials of consumption: a quill that writes in ink made from burnt secrets, a needle that sews a garment by consuming thread and producing new cloth, or a chisel that carves by eating away stone rather than chipping it. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "consumption keystone" that absorbs the stress of a tunnel, making it unbreakable – but the stone eventually turns to dust. In Zakov, a tanner might cure a hide by soaking it in water that has consumed salt from seven seas.

The Witch's Tool: The Hunger Chisel. A chisel of dark iron that feels warm, as if recently fed. Once per session, the witch may strike the chisel against a material (stone, wood, metal, flesh) and speak a word of consumption. The chisel "eats" a small portion of the material (a handful of stone dust, a sliver of wood, a thin curl of metal) and transforms it into a useful form – a sharp edge, a fine powder, a fuel for a small fire. The chisel can also be used to "consume" a single, small physical detail (a button, a lock, a hinge) as if it had never been there.

A Hedge Gift: Ash of Old Forms (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may take a handful of ash from a fire that consumed something significant (a letter, a garment, a meal) and blow it into the air. For the next minute, the ash reveals the shape of what was consumed – a phantom image of the letter, the garment, or the meal. The image is ghostly and cannot be touched, but it can be read, examined, or used to identify an object that no longer exists.

Vorthak's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hunger's Sight: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> consumable properties in objects, beings, or ideas.	Metabolic Craving: Must consume something <i>significant</i> daily or suffer Fatigue 1 .
2	Essence Thief: Once/scene, temporarily gain a minor property by consuming it.	Identity Bleed: Absorbed aspects surface unbidden; –1 die to maintain your original persona.
3	Metamorphic Resilience: Once/session, consume a <i>Condition</i> or <i>Harm</i> to negate it.	Hunger Aura: Those Near feel urges to consume or hoard; they suffer –1 die to self-control rolls.
4	Transformation Feast: Once/scene, consume and permanently absorb one <i>minor</i> supernatural ability.	Essence Instability: Conflicting properties clash; –1 die when relying on multiple absorbed aspects.
5	Identity Cannibal: Once/session, consume a <i>significant</i> aspect of another (major skill or core trait).	Self-Consumption: Risk eating your own memories or abilities; mark 1 SB (Spades) when stressed.
6+	Hunger Incarnate: Once/session, become living consumption; absorb nearby properties, abilities, or aspects.	Void Hunger: Mark +3 Obligation; risk dissolving into pure appetite that must feed to keep form.

Playstyle Notes

Vorthak favours those who hunt for change through taking in what the world offers: relish clever uses of absorbed traits, judge the *price* of every bite, and beware the slow surrender of the self. Expect scenes of metamorphosis, bargaining for what can be eaten, and hard choices where power tastes like you.

Vorthak emphasises

- **Transformation through Consumption:** becoming what you devour
- **Metamorphic Power:** fundamental, identity-shaping change
- **Essence Absorption:** discerning and using a thing's core nature
- **Identity Metabolism:** integrating (or failing to integrate) stolen aspects
- **Hunger Propagation:** letting appetite reshape people and places

7.8.37 The Witness (Truth & Revelation)

Lore. The Witness remembers what others bury. Every shadow cast and oath broken is a line in her unending ledger. She is the keeper of inconvenient truths, the patron of those who seek to expose lies or recover forgotten knowledge. Her followers learn that knowledge comes with a price—the weight of remembering what others would forget.

The Witness has no will, only a ledger; no mercy, only accuracy. She does not demand confessions, but she ensures that every lie leaves a stain, every secret a trace. Those who serve her become archivists of the uncomfortable, witnesses to the truths that others would kill to keep hidden. To walk her path is to accept that some truths are weapons, and that the truth-teller is never loved.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, the Witness is known by many names. In Ecktoria, she is the *Ink-Eye*, the Censor's clerk who copies every redacted line onto a private scroll. In Vhasia, she is the *Fractured Mirror*, prayed to by spies who seek to reveal a rival's true loyalty. In the Mistlands, she is the *Fog-Scribe*, whose name is whispered when a bell-line fails and the dead must be identified by their secrets. And in the shadows of every great city, there are those who follow the *Apocalyptic Witness* – a doomsaying cult that believes the world will end when the last hidden truth is finally spoken aloud, and who work to hasten that revelation by exposing every lie, no matter the cost.

I will show you what you would rather forget. But first, you must forget what you think you know.

Domain Focus

- **Truth Revelation:** exposing lies, uncovering secrets, forcing confessions
- **Memory Keeping:** preserving knowledge, recalling forgotten facts
- **Inconvenient Knowledge:** learning what others wish to hide
- **Prophetic Warning:** seeing the consequences of hidden truths
- **Burden of Witness:** the psychological weight of knowing too much

Rites of the Witness

Rite of the Lingering Trace (Low, 4 XP)

Instant; Near; Yes (Investigation/Notice only).

Materials: A trace of the thing to be remembered (hair, dust, a spoken name).

Effect: You follow a hidden thread. Gain +1 die to investigate or notice something directly related to the trace within the current scene. Additionally, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about whether the trace is connected to a specific person, event, or object.

Push It: Gain +2 dice instead, but mark 1 segment on a **Memory Strain Clock** [4]. If the clock fills, you gain Fatigue 1 and suffer –1 die on Investigation/Notice rolls until the end of the next scene (the Witness taxes your mind).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Uncomfortable Question (Low, 5 XP)*Scene; Near; No.***Materials:** A circle drawn with chalk or string while focusing on a specific person.**Effect:** You force a moment of raw honesty. Ask one question of a target within the zone. They may either answer truthfully (the GM must give a true answer, though it may be cryptic) or mark **1 Fatigue** and gain a *Guilty Tell* Condition (–1 die to all social rolls until they confess the truth to someone).**Push It:** The target must also reveal a surface emotion or a forgotten detail (GM's choice). Mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as the Witness records the strain.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Echoing Truth (Standard, 8 XP)***Instant; Near; No.***Materials:** A reflective surface (mirror, still water, polished metal) used to focus on the target.**Effect:** The target must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or suffer –1 die to rolls involving memory, deception, or resisting interrogation for the scene. If they fail, you may ask one specific, factual question about something they know, and they must answer truthfully or suffer **1 SB (Hearts)** as the memory is forcibly drawn forth.**Push It:** If the target fails their Resolve test, you may ask a second question, but the mental intrusion causes them **Harm 1 (Stress)**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Immutable Record (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Near; No.***Materials:** A document signed by all parties within the zone, or a spoken pact witnessed by the caster.**Effect:** Bind the agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers **1 SB (Hearts)** immediately and gains a persistent **Oathbreaker's Mark** Condition (–1 die on social rolls involving honour, trust, or oaths until amends are made or a significant act redeems them).**Push It:** The bond becomes magically enforced for one specific, crucial clause: violation automatically inflicts **Harm 1 (Stress)** on the breaker in addition to the SB and Mark.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Shared Burden (Standard, 9 XP)***Instant; Touch; No.***Materials:** A written secret (yours or another's) and a candle.**Effect:** You transfer the weight of a truth. Choose one: you may remove a *Guilty Tell*, *Haunted*, or similar psychological Condition from yourself and give it to a willing or unwilling target (they resist with Resolve DV 4). Alternatively, you may share a secret with an ally; both of you clear 1 Fatigue as the burden is halved.**Push It:** Transfer a Condition without the target's consent (they automatically resist, but on failure they gain it). Mark **1 SB (Spades)** as the secret stains them.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unveiled Heart (High, 12 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A private setting where the target feels safe or is speaking freely.

Effect: The target suffers –2 dice to all attempts to conceal true emotions, intentions, or lies for the scene. Any successful social roll (Sway, Command, Deceit) made by the target generates 1 **SB (Hearts)** as the effort to maintain falsehoods under the Witness's gaze creates internal discord.

Push It: You may designate one specific, complex question about the target's motivations, fears, or hidden loyalties. If you successfully use Sway or Insight against them this scene, you automatically learn the answer to that question. The intense scrutiny marks 1 **SB (Spades)** for you as the Witness's attention lingers.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

Rite of the Final Reckoning (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A formally called gathering (court, council, family meeting) within the consecrated zone.

Effect: All present must speak their greatest debt, wrongdoing, or hidden truth related to the gathering's purpose. Those who lie or withhold suffer **Harm 2 (Stress/Reputation)**. Truth-tellers gain +2 dice to social actions for the remainder of the scene within the zone.

Push It: The truth becomes inescapable – even indirect lies or evasions related to the core topic suffer the Harm 2 penalty. The absolute nature of the revelation creates 2 **SB (Diamonds)** as the disruption to fates and secrets resonates.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Witness

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Witness sings in *truth-tolling* – clear, piercing melodies that cut through evasion, harmonies that make the hidden surface. Their voice is used to compel a confession, to sound an alarm that a secret is about to be spoken, or to sing a historical record into being, each note a word in a ledger. The Witness's Cantors are often found in courtrooms, in archive vaults, and at the bedsides of the dying, singing the last truth.

The Congregation of the Unmasking (Apocalyptic Cult). The most feared of the Witness's cults, the Congregation of the Unmasking believes that the world will end when the last hidden truth is finally revealed – and that this ending is not a catastrophe but a liberation. They seek to expose every lie, every buried crime, every forgotten promise, no matter the cost. A ritual of the Congregation involves each member speaking aloud a truth they have kept secret, then burning a representation of the lie that concealed it. Their creed is painted on a scroll that is never fully unrolled: “*When all that is hidden*

is seen, the world will either break or be free. We will be there to witness which.” Outsiders are not welcome; they are potential sources of truth – or obstacles to be unmasked. The Congregation has been known to destroy families, topple governments, and start wars in their pursuit of total revelation. They are loved by none and feared by all, but even their enemies cannot deny that they are right: some secrets truly are worth dying to expose.

Witchcraft of the Witness (Craft / Record)

A witch who walks with the Witness is a *ledger-scribe* or *seal-breaker* – one who crafts the tools of permanent record: a book that cannot be altered once written, a quill that writes in ink that fades only when the truth it records is fulfilled, or a press that stamps each page with a sigil of authenticity. Their magic works through the materials of documentation: a chisel that carves a truth into stone so that it cannot be erased, a needle that sews a confession into a garment so that the wearer cannot deny it, or a forge that tempers a door that can only be opened by someone who has never told a lie. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “witness stone” at a courthouse entrance, so that all testimony given within is remembered by the stone for a century. In Thepyrgos, a bookbinder might stitch a volume that screams if its pages are cut.

The Witch’s Tool: The Truth Chisel. A chisel of white stone, its edge sharp as a razor. Once per session, the witch may carve a single word into a surface (stone, wood, leather) while speaking a truth aloud. The word glows faintly for a day. Anyone who touches the carved word and speaks a lie in its presence will feel a sharp sting (1 Fatigue) as the truth chisel protests. The chisel can also be used to “unseal” a locked record – a sealed envelope will open by itself if the witch carves the recipient’s true name into the wax.

A Hedge Gift: Record of a Breath (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may hold a blank piece of parchment up to a person’s lips as they speak. The parchment absorbs the spoken words, recording them exactly as they were said – including tone, hesitation, and any unconscious meaning. The parchment can be read by anyone (the words appear in the speaker’s own handwriting), but it crumbles to dust after being read aloud. The witch may also use this ability to record the final words of the dying, preserving them for one day.

The Witness's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Truth's Sight: +1 die to Insight when detecting deception or hidden motives.	Burden of Knowledge: -1 die to social rolls involving lies or deception; others become uncomfortable with your piercing gaze.
2	Memory's Keeper: Once/scene, recall one specific detail from a previous scene with perfect clarity.	Compulsive Honesty: Must correct obvious falsehoods witnessed, even when tactically disadvantageous.
3	Revelation's Power: +2 dice to rolls involving exposing secrets, uncovering lies, or forcing confessions.	Truth-Blind: Suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to comforting lies or wilful ignorance.
4	Witness's Authority: Once/session, force one target to make a Resolve test (DV 4) or reveal a significant hidden truth.	Isolation: -1 die to rolls requiring trust or close relationships; others fear your ability to uncover their secrets.
5	Omniscient Gaze: Once/session, see through all deceptions and lies for one exchange, gaining +3 dice to related actions.	Paranoia: -1 die to rolls involving personal peace or rest; the weight of all truths witnessed creates constant mental strain.
6+	Absolute Witness: Once/session, become the living embodiment of truth. For one scene, all deceptions within Near range automatically fail.	Truth's Prison: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; become unable to tolerate any form of deception, making normal social interaction nearly impossible.
		The Unmasking Beckons: The apocalyptic urge grows – you may be called to expose a truth that will destroy a community, a nation, or yourself.

Playstyle Notes

The Witness rewards curiosity, patience, and a willingness to bear uncomfortable knowledge. Her followers are not merely investigators but *archivists of the real* – they record what others would erase. The Witness does not demand that you expose every secret; she simply ensures that you cannot forget the ones you learn. Intrusions often take the form of dreams showing a hidden crime, a sudden memory of a lie you told years ago, or the appearance of a scrap of parchment containing a truth you wish you had never read. High-Tier followers may find that secrets begin to *seek them out* – people confess unprompted, documents fall open to damning pages, and the world becomes a book that cannot be closed.

Emphasises

- **Truth as Burden:** every secret known is a weight carried

- **Investigation as Ritual:** uncovering lies is a sacred act
- **Memory as Weapon:** forgetting can be as powerful as remembering
- **The Unmasking:** exposing a truth can be an act of mercy or destruction
- **Witness as Isolation:** those who know too much are seldom loved

7.8.38 Xhak'Thul, the Thunder-Speaker (Storm, Shock & Awe)

Lore. Before words, there was thunder. Before scripture, lightning carved its commandments into the bones of the world. Xhak'Thul is the Voice That Splits Mountains, the Drum That Shakes Foundations, a power born from the first storm that ever raged across the primal earth. His faithful are whirlwinds of action—they do not study; they dance, they shout, they move with the sky's fury. His gifts are not gentle miracles but raw terror, awe, and vitality ripped from nature's heart.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Xhak'Thul is the patron of the pre-literate, the neolithic, those who have not yet built walls against the wild. In the deep Vhasian highlands, he is the *Storm-Father*, invoked by herders who watch lightning split the sky. In Ykrul, he is the *Thunder-Hoof*, the sound of a thousand horses stampeding. In Linn, he is the *Raging Tide*, the storm that comes without warning. His followers are not scholars; they are dancers, drummers, shamans, and warriors who feel the storm in their bones before they hear it in the sky.

“Feel the drum in your bones before you hear it in the sky. When the storm speaks, you will already be dancing to its rhythm.”

Domain Focus

- **Primal Power:** storm, thunder, lightning, earthquake, wildfire
- **Shock and Awe:** overwhelming sensory impact, terror as a weapon
- **Fear-Eater:** absorbing panic to fuel strength
- **Immediate Magic:** no rituals, no books – only emotion, movement, and the moment

Rites of Xhak'Thul

Rite of the Speaking Drum (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A drum made from storm-felled wood or any suitable improvised percussion.

Effect: Your presence becomes overwhelming. All NPCs within Near range must test Resolve (DV 2) or suffer –1 die to social actions due to awe or terror for the scene. Allies gain +1 die to Intimidation or Command actions. **Tags:** FEAR, COMMAND, AREA.

Push It: Extend the effect to Far range, but you mark 1 Fatigue and must mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as your presence becomes difficult to control.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Lightning Tongue (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: Water collected during a storm, a piece of copper, words spoken under thunder.

Effect: Your voice carries supernatural weight. Your next social action in the scene gains +2 dice. If successful, the target suffers –1 die on any roll to resist your social influence for the remainder of the scene. **Tags:** COMMAND, FEAR.

Push It: Increase the bonus to **+3 dice**, but allies in Near range suffer **−1 die** to hearing-based actions; mark **1 SB (Spades)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Storm's Step (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: Earth from a lightning strike site, worn boot leather.

Effect: You move with the storm's speed. Gain **+2 dice** to Athletics or Stealth rolls. The first attack you make this scene gains **+1 Effect**. **Tags:** SPEED, FEAR.

Push It: Gain **+3 dice** and move as a blur, becoming difficult to track or clearly remember; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Shattered Sky (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A shard of meteoric iron or metal touched by a severe storm.

Effect: You call a localised, supernatural storm in a Zone. Choose one effect:

- **Lightning Strike:** Single target, Harm 2.
- **Wind Blast:** Knockback, dispersing arrows or scattering foes.
- **Hail Barrage:** Harm 1 (AREA).

All enemies in the Zone suffer **−1 die** to actions from chaos and distraction. **Tags:** AREA, FORCE, FEAR.

Push It: Double the chosen effect's scale or potency (e.g., Harm 3, large knockback), but the effect also applies to allies in the Zone; mark **2 SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Fear-Eater (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: Soil or dust from a place of great terror (battlefield, prison, ruins).

Effect: You feed on the fear around you. For each Frightened target in the scene, gain **+1 die** on your next action (max +3). Furthermore, if you successfully Intimidate a target during this scene, you heal 1 Fatigue. **Tags:** FEAR, HEAL, COMMAND.

Push It: Absorb all palpable fear in the scene, gaining a flat **+3 dice** bonus to your next action, but mark 1 permanent Scar related to fear. Mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Dancing Ground (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: Earth from an earthquake's epicentre; a rhythmic instrument.

Effect: The ground trembles with a powerful rhythm. Allies in the Zone gain **+1 die** to movement-based and combat actions. Enemies suffer **−1 die** to actions requiring balance

or concentration. **Tags:** AREA, SPEED, BANE.

Push It: The tremors intensify, causing minor structural damage to the environment; mark **2 SB (Spades)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the World's Drum (High, 12 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Materials: A drum fashioned from lightning-struck wood, with a hide from a beast killed by natural force.

Effect: You become an incarnation of the storm for one scene.

- Gain **+2 dice** to rolls based on strength, speed, and intimidation.
- Your anger echoes as thunder; attacks against you may be answered by lightning.
- Enemies must test Resolve at **-2 dice** to resist Fear effects you create.

Tags: AREA, FEAR, COMMAND, TRANSFORM.

Push It: The transformation lingers after the scene, and your emotional state can cause minor environmental effects. Mark **2 SB (Diamonds)** and begin a **Natural Disasters [6]** clock.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+3 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Sky-Torn Open (High, 14 XP)

Scene; Extended; No.

Materials: A trumpet or horn made of meteoric metal; the participation of someone who survived a great disaster.

Effect: You tear open the sky, summoning a sustained supernatural storm across a large area (Extended range). The storm rages with lightning, wind, and hail. You gain **+3 dice** to all actions while within it. Allies and enemies are equally affected by the storm's environmental hazards. **Tags:** AREA, FORCE, FEAR, WEATHER.

Push It: The storm becomes apocalyptic in its intensity, granting overwhelming power. However, you become the storm's eye and cannot leave the area until the rite ends. Mark **3 SB (Spades)** and suffer 2 Fatigue.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+3 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Xhak'Thul

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Xhak'Thul does not sing melodies – they drum. Their voice is a percussive roar, a heartbeat rhythm that shakes the ground. Their "song" is the pattern of a storm: the slow build of pressure, the sudden crack of lightning, the fading rumble of retreating thunder. Xhak'Thul's Cantors are often found in places without writing, where memory is carried in dance and the beat of a skin drum.

The Cult of the First Drum. Xhak'Thul's cults gather in clearing, on hilltops, or in caves that echo with thunder. The First Drum is a fellowship of dancers, shamans,

and warriors who believe that civilisation is a cage and that the storm is the only honest law. A ritual of the Cult involves each member drumming on a skin drum (never bought, always made from an animal they killed themselves) until the first person collapses from exhaustion. The collapsed dancer is declared "storm-taken" and must lead the next ritual. Their creed is not written – it is beaten into the earth: *"The sky does not ask permission. Neither do we."* Outsiders are welcome to dance, but they must bring a drum they made with their own hands.

Witchcraft of Xhak'Thul (Craft / Storm)

A witch who walks with Xhak'Thul is a *storm-smith* or *drum-maker* – one who crafts the tools of primal power: a drum that can be heard for a mile, a spear of lightning-struck wood that never misses its target, or a charm of meteoric iron that calls a storm when struck. Their magic works through raw, pre-literate materials: a chisel that sparks when it hits stone, a needle that sews with thread made from hair singed by lightning, or a forge that tempers steel with the breath of a thunderstorm. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "storm keystone" that channels lightning away from a hold. In Ykrul, a bone-carver might shape a whistle that mimics the sound of a thunderclap, terrifying horses.

The Witch's Tool: The Thunder Chisel. A chisel of meteoric iron, its edge rough as a lightning scar. Once per session, the witch may strike the chisel against any surface (stone, metal, wood). The impact sounds like a thunderclap, startling all within Near range (they must test Resolve DV 2 or lose their next minor action). The chisel can also be used to "split" a single, small object (a lock, a knot, a chain) as if struck by lightning – it breaks cleanly, but the break smokes slightly.

A Hedge Gift: Drum of the First Beat (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tap a rhythm on any surface (a table, a shield, a tree trunk). For the next minute, all allies within Near range who hear the rhythm gain +1 **die** to Athletics and combat rolls, as their heartbeat synchronises with the storm. The rhythm cannot be sustained if the witch is silenced or takes a wound.

Shock & Awe Corruption Table

Level	Manifestation	Cost / Quirk
1–2	Static Cling: Your touch carries a static shock. Metal objects faintly hum in your presence.	You feel restless energy before a storm. Minor lies itch like a rash.
3–4	Storm-Touched: Your hair stirs without wind. Your voice occasionally cracks like thunder. Small flames flicker near you.	You become irritable in calm, silent places. You crave loud arguments and violent weather.
5–6	Lightning Rod: You are dangerously magnetic. Unshielded metal flies to your hands. Your eyes crackle with faint light.	You feel a compulsion to disrupt order and create chaos. Peace feels like a cage.
7–8	Walking Storm: A localised wind stirs around you. You smell of ozone and wet stone. You cannot whisper; your voice is a low rumble.	You lose patience with lengthy plans. You prefer direct, explosive action, regardless of the cost.
9–10	Heart of the Tempest: You are the eye of a personal storm. Rain sheets indoors; lightning threatens those who anger you.	You see the world only as a force to be broken or commanded. Gentler emotions are foreign memories.

Rivalries

- **The Penitent Lich (Remembrance & Restitution):** Orderly, structured memory versus Xhak"Thul's primal chaos.
- **The Traveler (Ways & Roads):** Carefully laid paths versus the sky's explosive, pathless nature.
- **Varnek Karn (Necromantic Archives):** The cold order of death versus the chaotic fury of life expressed through storm.

Obligation Triggers

- **8+ Segments:** Xhak"Thul demands a public spectacle of awe and fear, such as levelling a tower, parting a river, or terrifying a city district.
- **10+ Segments:** The storm begins speaking through you constantly. Refusal to act on its impulses ends your access to Rites until you perform a catastrophic display of power.

Signs of Favor

The scent of ozone, hair stirring from unseen static, a voice that carries perfectly over crowd noise, local storms that react to your emotional state.

No True Acolyte Interpreting a patron's will is often a dangerous prospect in and of itself. Many a Runkeeper has found themselves on the opposite end of machinations from others from the same patron.

Runebound Resilience (18 XP Epic Talent) *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Spirit 4+*

You have learned to transform the very essence of harm into deeper communion with your Patron.

- **Harm Conversion:** Once per round, you may convert up to 2 Harm levels to +2 Obligation instead of taking the damage
- **Obligation Endurance:** While at 6+ Obligation segments, gain +1 die to all Rite invocations
- **Patron's Shield:** When reduced to Harm 3, you may immediately Invoke any known Rite without marking additional Obligation
- **Debt Fortification:** At 8+ Obligation segments, ignore first Harm 1 each round
- **Once per scene**

Narrative Integration:

"Your flesh has become a ledger, and every wound is a prayer. The deeper your Patron's claim, the stronger your resistance to mortal frailty."

Patron's Favored (18 XP Prestige Talent) *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Familiar, 8+ total Obligation segments*

Your Patron has marked you as specially favored, granting you unprecedented access to their power with reduced cost.

- **Low Rite Discount:** Reduce Obligation cost for Low Rites by 1 (minimum 0)
- **Empower:** Once per scene, spend 1 Action + 1 Boons:
 - Target gains +1 Corruption level per round for 3 rounds. Corruption lasts until the end of the scene.
 - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
- **Empower Push:** Spend 1 Action + 1 Boon + 3 Obligation:
 - Target(s) gains +3 Corruption levels until end of scene
 - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
 - Target gains +Corruption fatigue at the end of the scene.
- **Enhanced Gift:** Your **Patron's Gift** now provides +2 dice instead of +1
- **Debt Bound:** Cannot Empower again until all Obligation is cleared

Narrative Integration: *The Patron's favor comes with a price—but for the truly devoted, that price is worth the power. You carry their blessing openly now, and their influence spreads like wildfire to those who would walk in your shadow.*

“Every Rune is a promise. Every line a covenant. Do not mistake the Runekeeper's silence for weakness; their memory is the foundation of our craft.”

7.8.39 The Invokers

Invokers are those who dare. Neither archivists nor worshippers, they are travelers on the knife-edge between story and ruin. An Invoker learns the Rites of a Patron, weaves them into their own Art, and bends fate for a moment. Yet invocation is not command: it is negotiation. The Patron always leaves its mark. The stronger the Rite, the deeper the scar.

Invokers are often wanderers, exiles, or seekers. To common folk they are feared—witches, oathbreakers, meddlers with things not meant for mortal hands. But when the village falls to plague, when the sea closes its roads, when the dead refuse their rest, it is an Invoker who is called upon.

7.8.40 Closing Words

The dance between Patron, Runekeeper, and Invoker is a triangle of peril and necessity. Without Patrons, there is no power. Without Runekeepers, no record. Without Invokers, no action. Together, they shape the crooked, perilous art we call Invocation.

7.9 Patrons & Rites

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Closing Thoughts

Every roleplaying game is, at its heart, a shared act of imagination. FATE'S EDGE offers rules and structures, but the real magic happens between players and game master, in the pauses between dice rolls and the sparks that leap across the table. The mechanics are not a cage—they are a scaffold, meant to support the story you want to tell.

You will not find every answer written in these pages, nor should you. The best sessions arise when the table embraces uncertainty: when a Story Beat pulls the tale in an unexpected direction, when a character's flaw drives the narrative forward, when laughter follows disaster. The system gives you tools; the table gives those tools meaning.

If you remember nothing else, carry these three principles into play:

- **Fiction First.** Let the world breathe, and let the rules bend to the needs of the story.
- **Every Choice Matters.** Risk, consequence, and reward shape characters as surely as dice.
- **Build Together.** Collaboration turns scenes into sagas and mechanics into myth.

The rules are here to help you weave drama, not to constrain it. Use them generously, ignore them when they slow the story, and trust your table to improvise with honesty and care. Above all, let the edges of fate guide you not toward certainty, but toward possibility.

May your journeys be bold, your dice fall true, and your stories echo long after the table is cleared.

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